A WORLD BOOK

The Turning

Kind, Condition, and the reach of the Tree

Living world book · Cut-year 387

Chapters keep their numbers · a grey box is still unwritten

Using This Book

This is the world book of **the Turning**, written for the people who will sit down and play here. It explains the place in ordinary language, so a reader can follow a chapter without having opened the working notes. When a line is in quotation marks, it is something a person in the world might say, and the text tells you who is speaking. When people keep a habit and will not say why, the book tells you what they do and stops there, and what the world itself does is stated as fact. A question the world has not settled stays open on the page, because the people who live here have not settled it either.

The chapters keep the numbers and the titles they already have. When more of the world is written, it goes into the chapter that already holds that part of life. A grey box that begins **Not yet written** is a hole left on purpose. Filling one means taking that box out and putting the real account in its place, inside the same chapter. The hole that is still empty is two claimants on one green, in Other Places. The climate chapter names the weather, the water, and the walks between places, and it does not catalog every plant.

Books I–IX are what a player reads. **Book X** is for the person running the game. It holds the sound-system behind the names, and the material a table does not start out knowing. **Language and Naming** is where you name a person, coin a new name, or glue two old words into the name of a hall. The names of the continents, and what those names are saying the first time you meet them as places, are given in **The Four Continents**.

The rules for Daggerheart sit inside the Condition and Kind entries, where the life and the card on the table are the same subject. Those entries use the game’s own terms: Hope, Stress, Hit Points, Fear, and the range bands. Folklore, and any paper written by someone inside the world, is quoted as that person told it. The line around such a paper still says what the paper is.

The working notes remain the record this book is drawn from. This book is the copy you read, and it is filled as the world grows. Print the PDF with a wide right margin if you want room to write in it, or annotate it in any PDF reader. The HTML is the same book, searchable, with a clickable contents. Open that file in a word processor when you want comments in the margin.

Book I

What This World Is

The World in Brief

Vampires, werewolves, and the rest of that old kin live in the Turning in the open. Towns accept them, employ them, and need what they can do, and they live as neighbours, each of them changed into what they are now, with a job and a cost. The world calls that change a **Condition**, a becoming, and the body they were born with is a **Kind**, both of them true at the same time.

A Kind is the ancestry you arrived in, and the shape of that body. Human, Elf, Drakona, and the other ancestries the game already has sit beside four written for this world, born into those bodies the way a Human is born into one. You will know a Kitsune by the fox's ears and the brush of tail, a Selkie by the sealskin they were born able to wear, a Tengu by the dark feathers through the hair and down the arms and by the wings that carry them off a ridge, and a Yumboe, the hill-folk of Kumbaan, by a height about a mainlander's waist and by how rarely the mainland has seen one outside a sailor's story. Nobody blinks at a fox-tail in a market on Maiethorn, the old motherland, or at wings on a ridge of Heskoren, the frontier. A Yumboe is ordinary on Kumbaan, the storm-walled isle, and a tale on the other shores, because the distance and that wall keep the isle hard to reach. No Kind keeps a country of its own, and the place that raises you is the rest of a life.

A Condition is what you become after that birth. Roughly three people in four acquire one over a lifetime, and the towns meet it with law, with a guild, with medicine, and with the work that belongs to it. The society is built around what a person with a Condition can do, and around helping them live with the cost.

Most of those becomings are given in public, in a child's tenth year. During the midsummer week people call Turning-Week, the family brings the child to a **Turning Tree**. Most towns keep one in the square, a living cutting taken from an older Tree and planted in new ground. A cutting that has only just been planted still needs years before it can Turn a child, so a town that is too new, too remote, or has lost its Tree sends its children to a neighbour. A coloured leaf falls, a Condition is **Given**, and the colour is the name of which one. If no colour falls and the leaves close around the child, the Tree has kept them as they are. That child is one of **the Kept**, wanted in their own right. Later, some people are **Struck** when they cross a threshold the Tree does not hand to a child, a drowning they survive, an oath, or a death. The Condition arrives with no leaf and no ceremony, and the people watching call it tragic, or miraculous, or a little suspect. Some of the Kept are Struck in the years after the hug. Over a lifetime the split runs about sixty percent Given, fifteen percent Struck, and twenty-five percent Kept. A child who never stood under a Tree is **unTurned**. Neighbours may still say Kept, and the word belongs to the hug the town was there to see.

Every Condition carries a **Tithe**, the upkeep you meet if you are going to live well with the becoming. Ordinary work and ordinary rest are how it is paid. Meet it, and you are a valued citizen. Fall behind, and a small, real edge shows, while the person remains themselves. No Condition can compel, control, or bend another person's will. Children are taught that maxim as the Inviolate Will, in the sentence "the will is one's own," and the law holds it because it is true of every Condition. The danger stops at property, at pain, and at fear, at the edge of someone else's choosing.

Some hold that the **Leaf-Mother** blessed the world with these gifts, and that the Trees are her hands reaching down to choose. Skeptics, who are full members of the same towns, say the Trees are simply doing what Trees do, and they say the same of the hug, which the faith calls a blessing of its own. What puts you in her faith is the practice of bringing the children, tending the Tithe, and keeping the festival, which counts for more than what you privately believe about who does the choosing. Right practice binds, and right belief is what the faith still argues about. The Motherfaith is the common faith of these lands, and it is one faith among several.

There is one origin Tree, the **Awakening Tree**. In the old liturgical tongue its name is **Thaeloren**, the Tree that witnesses, and everyday speech wears that long name down to the Thallow. It stands on Maiethorn. Every town Tree is a living graft of that same wood, cut tissue kept alive on the road and planted so the same tree grows on, not a seedling raised from a seed the Tree dropped. How far the grafts have spread is the map. From Maiethorn, old and dense with Trees, the wood crossed the water to Strandoren, the shore-lands, where the life is trade and the Trees are still many, and it is still arriving on Heskoren, where the grafts are young, scattered, and prone to sickening. On Heskoren, more children are hugged than in the world at large, more are Struck later, and more never stand under a Tree at all. The lifetime mix of the whole world stays about sixty percent Given, fifteen Struck, and twenty-five Kept, and the old heart runs the other way, higher on the Given. Past Heskoren's last capes, a storm-wall of weather, current, and reef has wrecked most crossings. Kumbaan, which sailors call the Sundering Isle, has no Tree, and no graft has ever taken there.

Fifteen great powers stand across those three large continents, and Kumbaan is not a sixteenth of them. Between the fifteen, smaller seats and free towns still answer to their own Trees, and a good deal of wild has no great power on it at all.

Under that wood, ordinary life is late-medieval. Towns hold charters, and people keep guild halls, markets, mills, mechanical clocks, and universities, with letters of credit and the ledgers of banking houses. There is no printing press, so clergy and clerks keep the calendars by hand, and there is no gunpowder. The **Two-Bodied**, whom the old stories call werewolves, do the common labor as neighbours who carry a second, animal self and still decide what that body does, so rescue, herding, and the heavy jobs have a person for them. What reaches past that late-medieval town is the further labor a Condition makes possible, paid for by a Tithe, present where those people live and absent where they are not. The **Long-Lived**, which is what this world calls its vampires, stop aging and forget nothing they have witnessed, so a court, a bank, or a university can keep centuries in one living person.

The deathless houses, the banking houses that do not die, will finance a cathedral, a canal, or a university across a span no mortal lender would risk, and if that person is starved of anything new to learn, the memory begins to fade. The same bargain shows in the rest of the work a town cannot do without them: a surgery, because someone can hold a wound still; a mine collapse or a plague ward, because someone who died came back and took the job; thin ground that yields, because someone the wild has taken in works it; a warning that crosses a storm farther than any horn, because a voice can stay true, or because an element answers a maker’s hands. A town looks at the work and knows whose becoming paid for it.

This is the **Years of Hands**, the age in which a town’s own Tree is the ordinary way a child is Turned. The count this book uses is the **Cut-year**, numbered from the First Cut, the summer someone first cut living wood from the Awakening Tree and the cutting took. It is **Cut-year 387**, the 387th summer since that cut. The walk out to the origin remains, as devotion or as prestige, and it is still a necessity wherever the wood is travelling or a graft has failed. On Heskoren both of those necessities are still real. Other counts start somewhere else, at a crown, at a banking house, or in the year a local graft took, and some people will not start at the Cut at all. Who made the First Cut is still argued, and that the cut happened is not.

This book is the world as it stands.

Kind and Condition

Every person in the Turning carries two truths at once. You are born with an ancestry and the body that comes with it, and that birth-shape is your **Kind**: a Human, an Elf, a Drakona, or another ancestry the game already has, or one of the four this world adds. Kitsune are the fox-born, ears and a brush of tail included, and Selkie are born to a sealskin they can wear or set aside, which is still the Kind they arrived with. Tengu are lean, sharp-featured people of the high country, with dark feathers through their hair and down their arms, and with wings that carry them off a cliff or an updraft. Yumboe are the hill-folk of Kumbaan, the storm-walled isle sailors call the Sundering Isle, about waist-high to a mainlander, ordinary on that isle and a sailor's tale on Maiethorn, the old motherland, and on Heskoren, the frontier, which is why the mainland mostly has the story. A Yumboe character needs the GM's leave, the agreement of the person running the game, and is always the full Kind. Nobody blinks at a fox-tail in a Maiethorn market or at wings on a Heskoren ridge. The place that raises you is the rest of who you are, and no Kind keeps a country of its own.

Condition is what you become after that birth. Something happens, and the person changes into what the old stories would have called a vampire, a werewolf, or their kin, so the change is a becoming, a thing you cannot be born into. Roughly three people in four acquire a Condition over a lifetime. Towns meet it with law, with a guild, with medicine, and with the work attached to it, because the society is built around what those people can do and around helping them live with the cost.

How a becoming arrives

Which path a person took is the main division in society. A Condition arrives by one of two paths, or the Tree sees the child and leaves them as they are.

In a child's tenth year the family brings them to a **Turning Tree** for the **Leaf-Fall**, held in Turning-Week, the midsummer week of the solstice. There is one origin Tree, the Awakening Tree, named **Thaeloren** in the old liturgical tongue and worn down in everyday speech to the Thallow. It stands on Maiethorn. Most towns have a **scion** in the square, a living cutting of that same wood. In ordinary practice the cut is taken from a healthy town Tree cutting on the origin's behalf, and sometimes from Thaeloren itself. Either way it is cut tissue, kept alive on the road and planted, not a seedling from a seed the Tree dropped. A cutting that has just gone into the ground needs a generation, about twenty years, before it can hold a Leaf-Fall, and until then the children go to a neighbour, as they do from a town that is too new, too remote, or has lost its Tree. The leaves fall and wrap each ten-year-old. A

tree-warden, the clergy who tend that wood, says aloud what the Tree did. In a village the town itself is the witness. In a city the children stand by hearth, among people who already know them, across the days of the week, and the square is still full.

When a colour falls, a Condition is **Given**, and the colour is the name of which one. Ordinary people can already read the common colours. A rare fall, or a colour the square has never seen, belongs to the warden and to the texts. The day is ceremonial, expected, and what people call proper, so a Given child grows up knowing the life ahead and is trained and guilded toward it. When no colour falls and the leaves hug the child, that child is one of **the Kept**. The Tree keeps them as they are, wanted and kept whole. The faith calls the hug a blessing, and that reading is still argued. The Tree only Gives or Keeps, and a Struck Condition happens somewhere else, with no leaf.

A child who never stood, because the week was missed, or the family refused, or the only wood on offer could not Turn anyone, is **unTurned**. From the street that life can look like a Kept life, since neither one carries a Tithe and neither one carries a guild. Kept means the town watched the hug, and unTurned means there was no hug to watch, so the law does not let a neighbour's kindness rename one as the other. The doors by which a person can still be Struck remain open later.

Later, some people are **Struck**. Some Conditions cannot be Given to a child, because a ten-year-old cannot die and walk back, and a child cannot swear a contract. Those arrive only when a person crosses a threshold in a later year, with no leaf and no ceremony, and the threshold they cross decides what they become. Onlookers call it tragic, miraculous, or a little suspect. Some of the people the Tree hugged are Struck in the years after, so a Kept life is not a door that has shut forever.

The Tree and the thresholds sort the roster the same way every time. What needs no act from the child is Given only. The **Long-Lived**, whom the old tales call vampires, are rare and revered, aging stopped, a witnessed life never forgotten, while the **Two-Bodied**, the werewolves, are the common neighbours, a second animal self that the person still commands. The **Answered**, the djinn, also called a jinni, were answered by an element, with no lamp and no master, and they have no single standing, because which element answered and what temperament came with it changes the neighbour you actually meet. The **Phoenix** is Given the same way, and only one is alive in the world at a time. They burn down to ash and rise again on wings of living fire, each death taking a piece of who they were, which is a different thing from the Long-Lived, who do not die of age. When the last of those lives is spent, the Tree gives a white-fire leaf, opal in the texts, to a single child, somewhere, and the next Phoenix begins. Almost nobody now living has seen that colour fall. Whether a player carries it is a decision the whole table makes, and the person running the game may keep the Phoenix as a person in the world instead. That conversation sits in Playing in the Turning.

What a child physically cannot have done is Struck only. The **Returned** are what the old tales called zombies: a person who died with something unfinished and was brought back by that purpose, once, which is a different door from the Phoenix, who dies outright and rises through the lives still left. The

Bound are what the old tales called demons: a person who swore a contract. An **Infernis** is a person born demon-blooded, which is a Kind, and if that person swears a contract, the contract is the Condition. The two sit on the same person without becoming the same thing.

A near-death a person can survive may be foreseen by the Tree or walked into later by accident, and three Conditions come by either door. The **Far-Voiced**, whom the old stories call sirens, meet theirs in the water. Most drew a sea-blue leaf at ten and spent childhood in the guild, learning to let a feeling out on purpose, while a few were Struck, pulled under and brought up untrained, so that someone who survived a drowning at thirty carries the same becoming as the child with the blue leaf and is a very different person. The **Stilled**, the gorgons of those stories, can hold a moment still, a bleeding wound or a blade already swinging. Most were Given a pale, marble-white leaf at ten and trained under the guild, and a few survived being turned to stone and came back with the stillness already in them. Towns fear that gaze and license the work. The **Taken-In**, the leshy, are people the wild has taken partway into itself. Most drew a copper-green leaf at ten, a metallic green, not the ordinary summer-green of the hug, and grew up in the change. A few were Struck, lost and dying in the deep wild until the wild took them in. Either way they come back with bark at the knuckles and moss in the hair, and green things lean toward them when they stand still. Farm country that is prospering reveres them. The cities eat well because of that grain and timber, and polite company keeps them at arm's length.

Of the whole population, over a lifetime, about **60 percent** are Given at the Tree, about **15 percent** are Struck later, and about **25 percent** stay Kept. The Given and the Struck together are the three-quarters who carry a Condition. At the ceremony itself about two children in five are hugged and receive no colour, roughly **40 percent**. A little over a third of those hugged children are Struck someday. That later slice is the fifteen percent of everyone, and the hugged children who are never Struck are the twenty-five percent who stay Kept for life. Places with few Trees, or only young or sickening ones, run higher on the Kept, on the Struck, and on children who never stand. The Tree-dense heart runs higher on the Given. The lifetime mix of the whole world stays sixty, fifteen, and twenty-five.

The Tithe

Every Condition carries a **Tithe**, the upkeep you meet in order to live well with the becoming. You pay it in the work and the rest that life already asks, and meeting it is what leaves you a valued citizen, the neighbour and the colleague and the kin people already take you for. Fall behind, and a small, real edge shows in the shape of that becoming, while the person is still the one who decides.

Starve a Long-Lived of anything new and they fade and forget, and keep a Two-Bodied from the other self and the restlessness builds until the change comes at a moment they did not pick, though they still choose what that body does. Hold a feeling too long and a Far-Voiced lets out a Cry, emotion filling the room without commanding an action, a belief, or a roll. Let the stillness settle and one of the Stilled can lock a limb of their own stone-still. Leave an Answered's element unspoken and it may let

go in a crowded room, as heat, or water, or wind, or their own body going stiff, while the people nearby are not compelled and do not pay the debt. Guilds, licences, and the jobs themselves exist in large part so the upkeep can be paid in the day's work, where other people live, rather than in that edge.

The frightening part is something a person walks toward, or that circumstances press them toward. It does not seize the will, and it does not take a player character over. The cost is paid in the body, in memory, in Stress marked on the sheet, in the standing a town gives, and in the years. It is never paid by taking the bearer's will, or anyone else's. Children are already taught the sentence that covers it: the will is one's own.

Standing is not shared evenly across the roster. Some Conditions are common and ordinary, some are rare and looked up to, some are rare and looked down on, some are feared, and one is legendary. The table at the end of this chapter is the count.

Nine to choose, ten in the world

Nine Conditions can be Given or Struck. The tenth is **the Unbound**. Common speech calls it the Hollow. It comes later, when a Bound person's term-limited contract ends and nobody signs a new one. You become Unbound only by way of Bound, in play or because the table agrees at the start that the term has already ended. About 1.5 percent of people are Unbound, and that figure sits inside Bound's share of about 5 percent. It is not an extra number laid on top. An open-ended contract does not come due in that way. People pity the Unbound, and feel uneasy around them, because they were released and the price they pledged is missing.

The world uses **the Given-Over** for a Bound who signs contract after contract. They start because they are afraid of paying what they already owe, and another signing puts the debt off, until it is too much to stop and the being on the other side effectively holds them. The contract-guilds' term for that person is **the Forfeit**. It is a title, not a Condition and not a card. A player character does not take the fate. Someone who has signed away nearly all of themselves is no longer a character the table is playing.

RULES

A Condition is a Daggerheart **Transformation card**. The card opens with a line of flavor and then its features. At minimum there is a boon, what the Condition lets you do, and a Tithe with its name written on it, the drawback that keeps the boon honest. Both of them hook to resources the game already uses, Hope, Stress, Hit Points, Fear, weapon tiers, and Experiences, the phrases on the sheet for what a life has already taught, rather than to a private meter that only this card understands. A player character holds one transformation. It sits in the loadout the way a heritage card does, and it does not count against the limit on domain cards. How many features a card carries is allowed to vary. A Condition that takes the table's focus, or a complicated one, carries more than a common card. What stays constant is a clean boon, and a Tithe with its name on it.

The card does not level with the character. The card you hold at level 1 is the card you hold at level 10, while class features, domain cards, Experiences, weapon tier, and Hope scars, the marks that cross a Hope slot off the sheet, change around it. A few things look like the card is growing, and they are not a new rank of the becoming. A Two-Bodied may attach an animal-form Experience when they would gain an Experience, and a second signature capability only as a once-ever story milestone. Returned and Phoenix spend Hope slots, and what remains is a countdown rather than a power that climbs as they level. The standing obligations in a Bound contract, and the piece of the self named as the price, move when the story moves them. Attacks the card already grants roll more damage dice as Proficiency rises, because Proficiency is how many damage dice the game tells you to roll.

Roster

The shares below are of all people, not of the three-quarters who carry a Condition. They are the one count this book uses. The Unbound row is already inside Bound's five percent, and adding it a second time would count those people twice.

Condition	Folk still know	Path	Share of the people	Given / Struck	Standing
Long-Lived	vampire	Given	~2.5%	all Given	rare / revered
Two-Bodied	werewolf	Given	~18%	all Given	common
Returned	zombie	Struck	~7%	all Struck	normal / quietly respected
Bound	demon (by contract)	Struck	~5%, counting the Unbound (about 3.5% currently Bound, 1.5% Unbound)	all Struck	feared
The Unbound *(the Hollow)*	the price of a contract	Struck, chains off Bound only	~1.5%, *inside* Bound's ~5%	—	pitied / uneasy
Far-Voiced	siren	Both	~12%	~11% Given / ~1% Struck	revered
The Stilled	gorgon	Both	~7%	~6% Given / ~1% Struck	feared / guild-regulated
The Answered	djinn	Given	~10%	all Given	wildcard (no single standing)
The Taken-In	leshy	Both	~13%	~12% Given / ~1% Struck	respected-but-looked-down / frontier
Phoenix	phoenix	Given	<0.1% (one at a time)	all Given	legendary

The Kept are not on this table. They are the ~25 percent who carry no Condition for life. The Tree hugged them at the ceremony, the town was there to see it, and they are wanted in their own right.

Book II

Peoples

The Conditions

A Condition is what a person becomes, set beside the Kind they were born, the ancestry they came into the world already wearing. For about three people in four there is also a Condition, one of the old monsters living in town as a neighbor, with a job the town needs. The Turning Tree gives most of them at the Leaf-Fall, a child's tenth-year solstice, when the colour of a leaf names the Condition and that child is Given. The rest are Struck later, by a threshold the Tree does not hand out at that ceremony. Either way the Condition carries a Tithe, an upkeep you meet by ordinary play and an ordinary rest, and the Tithe must never seize control of the person.

On the sheet, a Condition is a Daggerheart Transformation card. The card opens with a line of flavor and then its features. At minimum there is a boon, the thing the Condition lets you do, and a Tithe, the drawback that keeps the boon honest. Both of them hook to resources the game already uses, Hope, Stress, Hit Points, Fear, weapon tiers, and Experiences, rather than to a private meter that only the Condition understands. A player character holds one transformation. It sits in the loadout the way a heritage card does, and it does not count against the limit on domain cards. How many features a card carries is allowed to vary. A Condition that takes the table's focus, or a complicated one, carries more features than a workhorse card. What stays constant is the shape of the card, a clean boon and a Tithe with its name written on it.

The card does not level, and it does not grow because the character does. A becoming is not a class. The card you hold at level 1 is the card you hold at level 10, while class features, domain cards, Experiences, weapon tier, and Hope scars are what change around it. A few things look like the card is growing, and they are not. A Two-Bodied may attach an animal-form Experience when they would gain an Experience, and a second signature capability is a once-ever story milestone, not a level to pick. Returned and Phoenix spend Hope slots, and that spending is a countdown of the returns they have left, not a power that climbs as they level. A Bound's Terms, the standing obligations written into the contract, and the Pledge, the piece of themselves named at signing as the price, move when the story moves them. Attacks that use Proficiency rise because Proficiency rises. Those attacks are Kindle, the Phoenix's burst of fire, Reach, the moment an Answered element's answer leaves the hands, the Green Word, the Taken-In's sudden growth, and the Two-Bodied natural weapon.

A Tithe's tokens drain or fill on a long rest, the full rest between days, unless the card names another trigger. A day with two short rests does not tick that clock a second time. When the long rest comes, you run this list once, and each line is a yes-or-no for that rest alone.

Condition	At this long rest	Not a rest clock
Long-Lived	Spent Hope on Unfading Mind, used Blood-Read, or spent a downtime move in study or witness? **Refill.** Else **remove a Memory token.**	—
The Answered	Spent Hope on Reach since last long rest? **Refill.** Else **remove a token.**	Asking the element a question leaves the tokens where they are
The Taken-In	Can you touch a living plant where you rest? **Refill.** Else **remove a Green token.**	—
The Stilled	This long rest included a physical downtime move, a spar, a drill, or a fight? If not, **add a Grey token.**	The Gaze still adds a Grey token when it is used
The Unbound	Rested with someone who knows your name and shares the meal or the watch? **Refill Quiet.** Else the tokens stay.	Quiet is spent in play, to act through what the contract took
Returned	Did anything toward your Purpose, the unfinished thing that keeps you walking, since last long rest? If not, you settle: mark a Stress, and your touch runs cold.	—
Far-Voiced	—	In a scene, marking Stress from feeling, or the GM naming grief, terror, rage, or joy, means you vent before the scene ends
Two-Bodied	—	A full day without the other self, then the next roll with Fear shifts you
Bound	—	A broken Term or a missed payment, and the Whisper while a debt is owed
Phoenix	—	Death, and the Dwindling, which is what each Rise From Ash costs

There are nine Conditions a person can be Given or Struck with, and the tenth, the Unbound, is not a starting Condition. Common speech calls those people the Hollow, for the hole a finished contract leaves. A Bound enters that state when a term-limited contract ends and no further contract is signed, so you become Unbound only through Bound, in play or arranged with the GM before the first session.

There are nine to choose from, and ten in the world. The Given-Over is a title rather than a Condition, the world's name for a Bound who signs contract after contract until the being on the other side effectively holds them. The contract-guilds call that fate the Forfeit. It is not a card anyone plays, and the account of it sits with the Bound.

Over a lifetime, about 60 percent of people are Given a Condition at the Tree, about 15 percent are Struck later, and about 25 percent are the Kept. The Given and the Struck together are the three-quarters who carry a Condition. The Kept are the people the Tree hugged at the ceremony and left as they are, wanted in their own right, who carry no Condition for life. At the ceremony itself, about 40 percent of children are hugged and receive no colour, and a little over a third of those children are still Struck someday.

The share named with each Condition below is the count in the roster at the end of Kind and Condition, and that table is the one count of how many people carry each Condition. The colour of the leaf is the Tree's palette, copied here so a colour can be read without leaving the chapter, and it does not replace that roster.

Condition	Colour, or none	Path
Long-Lived	deep red / wine	Given only
Two-Bodied	storm-grey	Given only
The Answered	lamp-amber / brass	Given only
Far-Voiced	sea-blue (Struck: none)	Both
The Stilled	pale stone / marble-white (Struck: none)	Both
The Taken-In	copper-green / verdigris (Struck: none)	Both
Phoenix	white-fire / opal	Given only
Returned	none	Struck only
Bound	none	Struck only
The Unbound	none; it chains off Bound	Struck only, and only through Bound

The Tree never Strikes, so the Returned, the Bound, and the Unbound have no colour. The hug that names one of the Kept is ordinary summer-green, and that green is not a colour that names a Condition.

Long-Lived

A Long-Lived is an ageless keeper of memory, and they live on what they learn. The vampire of folklore feeds on the living, and a Long-Lived who is starved does not hunt anyone. They fade, they forget, and if the hunger runs all the way out they empty, the memories gone and the life with them. What is left of the old blood-hunger is an echo, and only an echo. A Long-Lived can read a memory in a single drop of blood, and by an ancient courtesy they will not cross a threshold uninvited. You can still recognize the old story in those two habits, and the predation has been taken out of both.

Aging simply stops, and nothing a Long-Lived has witnessed is ever forgotten, which is why a court will trust them as a record that does not corrupt. They are scarce, about 2.5 percent of people, and every one of them is Given, never Struck. The leaf that names them is a rare deep red, the colour of wine, and there is no later door. A world with too many deathless people would lock its courts, guilds, and archives into the shape they already have, so their scarcity is part of the world's shape. They are revered, they are consulted, and they stand a little apart from the neighbors who will not live as long. Courts, guilds, and houses of record build themselves around these people, and use them as archivists, judges, notaries, and libraries that happen to be alive.

A Long-Lived will not cross the threshold of another's home uninvited, and they wait to be asked in, always. People hold that waiting as the deepest good manners, a mark of trustworthiness, because a keeper of records does not intrude, and no one quite remembers the custom as anything else, though it is old and it is universal among them. A Long-Lived who is refused the door feels the refusal more than they will say. It reads, faintly, as the last shadow of the folklore vampire, the one who could not enter unbidden, but nobody calls it that, and it is simply how the Long-Lived have always been.

The leaf is wine-dark, and a neighbor who has seen the ceremony can already read it. The Motherfaith is the faith built around the Turning Tree. Some hold that the Leaf-Mother blessed the world with the Conditions, and the faith treats that as a belief, not as a fact anyone has proved. In a deep-red leaf, that faith hears a chosen keeper, a memory fitted to a town that needs a record. The Watching is the older Tree-faith the Motherfaith grew over. They keep the Tree, they refuse the mother-name, and they say a colour falls because the Tree sees, not because a mother chooses. They call a Long-Lived a witness rather than a mother's pick. Those two readings do not get to close the argument between them.

From the ceremony they go to courts, guilds, and archives. Every Long-Lived is asked once to join the Pourers, who give memory into a cup they say holds a god they made, and they call that god the Unspent. A member gives one year of memory at a time, each year on its own night with its own minutes, and may stop before the next. Five years is what the circle asks of a member in all. For each year given, that year's papers go onto the shelf at the long-house that keeps the circle, and the circle counts the member one year younger. When a member leaves, the years already given stay in the cup, and the papers are what come back. Most Long-Lived say no to the ask, and a person who says no is received everywhere as before. The Pourers are described with the other houses in Orders and Houses.

Meeting the Tithe is why they hold the jobs they do. A Long-Lived wants to keep learning, so scholarship, judging, and the keeping of records are the careers that feed the hunger while the work gets done. Deprivation is the danger: a prison, a siege where nothing new ever happens, exile in a place with nothing to witness. Isolating a Long-Lived is a recognized cruelty.

They can have children, and they can have families, but no child of theirs is guaranteed the Condition, and most children do not inherit it. They watch a spouse grow old and die, and they watch the children do the same, and then they either stop, living on alone with the memory of that house, or they begin again and outlive the next family too. Beneath the hunger for knowledge, they outlive the people they love. That repeating funeral is the deeper Tithe. They are deathless, and they are not unkillable. Violence ends them, accident ends them, and a failed Tithe ends them, which is what keeps the numbers stable across the centuries.

RULES

> *Ageless keepers of memory, law, and record: they live on what they learn.*

- **Unfading Mind:** Your aging has stopped, and you forget nothing you take in. You have **advantage** on rolls to recognize, appraise, or recall what you have personally witnessed. Spend a **Hope** to recall a witnessed detail complete: the vow as it was spoken, the face, the exact count. The Hope pays for that perfect record. It does not pay for the ordinary work of a librarian.
- **Blood-Read:** Memory rides in blood. Taste a single drop of a creature's blood, freely given or taken from a wound that is already there, and you read a true memory carried in it, a fragment of what that person has lived. The GM chooses the fragment so that it fits what the blood remembers. It is never predation, and it never harms the donor. One drop gives one glimpse, and the older or more guarded the memory you reach for, the less of it you may get. You feed on knowledge, and blood is the oldest record of all.
- **The Hunger to Know** *(Tithe):* Place **3 Memory tokens** on this card. At a long rest, refill all of them if, since your last long rest, you spent Hope on Unfading Mind, used Blood-Read, or spent a downtime move in study or in first-hand witness. Otherwise remove a token. The advantage you always have does not refill the clock. Using the keeper's tools does.
- **2 tokens:** nothing has begun to slip.
- **1 token:** the fade begins. You have **disadvantage** on rolls to recall, recognize, appraise, or use Presence, and you start losing older memories, which you describe as they go. Other action rolls and reaction rolls are untouched.
- **0 tokens:** you are starving. You are **Vulnerable**, and at the start of each long rest that you are still at 0 tokens you mark a **Stress**. If you would mark your last Stress this way, mark a **Hit Point** instead. If you would mark your last Hit Point this way, you do not make a death move. You go still. The memories are gone, the mind is emptied, and that stillness is the true death of the Long-Lived. You may clear Hit Points and Stress as usual while you still have them. Getting a token back, by a Hope spent on recall, a Blood-Read, or a downtime spent in study, stops the starve before the next long rest.

Two-Bodied

A Two-Bodied carries a second, animal self, and that self is always theirs to command. The werewolf of the old stories is a beast that overtakes a person when the moon is up. There is no moon-curse here,

no rage, and no moment in which the person stops being the one who decides. What used to be told as a monster is a useful animal partner you carry inside you, and it is the common Condition, the one towns put to work.

A Two-Bodied has two bodies, the shape they were born in and one specific real animal, and shifting between them is voluntary and clean. That is what makes them the most common labor in the world, and the most versatile, about 18 percent of people, Given only, when the Tree drops a storm-grey leaf at the Awakening and a child of ten comes away with a second self. Rescue, herding, work in the wild, war, and the runs of couriers and scouts all use that second body, and the point of the Condition is that utility, a shape suited to the job, rather than the spectacle of the change. After the ceremony there is no guild waiting and no college to enroll them, so they do the work with no ticket, on civic land and on the ranging-commons, the ground at a town's edge where a Two-Bodied can be their other self.

The animal shape is not an empty suit you climb into. It carries its own personality, temperament, and inner voice, distinct from the born self, and you converse with it. Not aloud as a person, because the animal mouth cannot form human speech, but in your own head, a running second opinion: the wolf that wants to run the scent now, the hawk that trusts height over talk, the otter that finds the whole meeting tedious. It is named and known, so townsfolk say "that's Bramble, her otter," and they come to recognize its moods. It never takes the wheel, because the change and every action stay yours to command, and what it does is nag, want, and color the day, a live companion you happen to be.

The Condition runs in families, so the children of a Two-Bodied parent are far more likely to be Given it at their own Awakening, and usually as the same animal, which is why whole bloodlines are known as wolf-folk, hawk-folk, or otter-folk. A player character still picks their own animal, and someone who is first in the line, or who breaks the family type, is notable to the people around them.

The other self is a real, natural animal, roughly between a housecat and a large wolf, a bear, a boar, or a horse in size, and nothing larger than that band, and nothing out of myth. There is no giant hawk, no dire wolf, no roc, and no kelpie. A real animal does exactly what that animal really does, so a hawk flies, an otter swims and holds its breath, and a bear is strong. The lines between this Condition and the other peoples hold because of what the animal body lacks. In the other self you have no hands, no person's mind at work, no speech as a person, and no tools, and the person still chooses every action. A flying Two-Bodied is a superb scout and a superb courier, and is still not a Tengu, because a Tengu is a person aloft, with hands to carry and to fight and a human mind and a human voice in the air. An aquatic Two-Bodied swims brilliantly and works the water as that animal, not as a tool-using Answered, whose element already answers their hands, and not as a true amphibious person. The body is a magnificent animal, and it is not a person wearing fur.

Storm-grey is already a proverb by the time a child watches it fall, because this is the common leaf and people know what it means before the warden speaks. The path is Given only, with no later door. The

Motherfaith hears the common gift, a second body the town can put to work, and the Watching says the Tree saw two selves and made that seeing visible, a witness rather than a mother’s pick.

Because the upkeep is simply being the animal sometimes, most Two-Bodied satisfy it without having to think about the rule, since their jobs already demand the animal form. The risk is the restless shift that comes when the day was skipped. It arrives at the worst moment, in the middle of a negotiation or in the middle of a stealth, and it costs a Stress, but it never takes the wheel: you stay in command of what the body does, and only the timing belongs to the Tithe.

RULES

> *A person who carries a second, animal self, and not a beast that overtakes them.*

- **The Other Self** *(boon):* You have a second body, a specific real animal, chosen when you become Two-Bodied, inside the band above. You may shift between your two selves at will, as an action. The change is always yours to command. It costs no Stress and needs no roll, your gear melds with you, and the gear returns when you change back. In animal form you gain the natural weapon below, plus the beast's own movement, a wolf's run or an otter's swim or a hawk's flight, which is why the shift is worth making in a fight and not only in order to leave one. You are one body or the other, and you cannot equip another Primary while you are in this form.
- **A signature capability,** chosen with the GM to fit the animal. A hawk might see a mouse from the sky, a wolf might run a scent for miles, a bear might shrug off a blow. That is **advantage** on the fitting rolls, or a small effect once per scene that the GM sets. You start with one signature.
- **An animal Experience.** Choose one **Experience** that reflects the animal's nature, "Wolf's Nose" or "Cat's Balance" or "Bear's Strength," and use it only while you are in animal form.
- **A voice, not a driver.** Your other self has its own name, its own temperament, and an inner voice you can converse with. The voice is pure roleplay. It flavors the scene and it nags, it grants no bonus of its own, and it can never take an action you did not choose.

Natural weapon (animal form only):

Category	Tier	Trait	Range	Damage	Burden	Feature
Primary	1 (does not advance)	**Instinct**, or **Strength** if the animal's signature is brute force (bear, boar)	Melee	**d8 phy** (housecat-sized: **d6 phy**; bear or boar: **d10 phy**)	One-Handed	**Natural:** cannot be disarmed; usable only in animal form; you cannot equip another Primary while in this form

Roll damage dice equal to your **Proficiency**, as with any other weapon. You do not add a second weapon's dice on top. The tier stays 1, so the die on the card stays the die you started with. Proficiency is what raises the number of dice.

- **Both Must Be Lived** *(Tithe):* If a full day passes without time spent as your other self, it grows restless. The next time you roll with **Fear**, you shift into it whether you meant to or not, and you mark a **Stress**. You stay fully in control, and only the timing was not yours. You shift back in the ordinary way. This Tithe is not a clock that ticks at a rest. It rides the duality dice on purpose, the roll that comes up Hope or Fear.

Growth. You start with one animal-form Experience and one signature capability. As you live longer as Two-Bodied, growth deepens the character of the animal, not the raw power of the body. Whenever you would gain an Experience, you may attach a new animal-form Experience to your other self, usable only in animal form. Your signature capability stays at one, with a single exception. A second signature is a once-ever milestone, never a routine pick. The GM grants it as the payoff of a genuine story, a season lived almost entirely in the other self or a defining trial passed in that shape, and that grant is the only way the count of capabilities ever grows. The limit is what keeps a long-lived Two-Bodied from quietly stacking scout, tracker, and bruiser into one body.

Returned

A Returned is a person who died with something unfinished, and whose purpose keeps them walking. They are calm, they are deliberate, and they are unafraid of death because they have already been through it once. The corpse in the old stories rots and does not think. The Returned persist, mind intact, and the towns hand them the work that kills the living: the plague wards, the mine collapses, the recovery of a battlefield, and the tending of the dead, and the speaking for them.

The Returned are Struck only. You cannot be Given this at age ten, because the Tree gives a Condition at the Awakening by the colour of a leaf, and this Condition requires a death. Someone dies with a thing left undone that is strong enough to hold them, and they get back up. Their standing is ordinary and quietly respected, about 7 percent of all people. They are solemn and dependable, the ones you send where the living cannot safely go. Gore does not shake them and death does not shake them, and a death that takes them may still not be the last. A Returned has no colour, because the Tree never Strikes and a death leaves no leaf. What comes next is the Purpose rather than a guild, because no desk can issue one.

The Motherfaith brings them to the Tree after the fact, for acknowledgment rather than for a gift the Tree is handing out. The Wide-Hand, the reading that says the Leaf-Mother meets people at every door and not only under the Tree, says she met them at the death-door, and the Narrow-Hand, which holds that she gives only at the Tree, is uneasy. The Watching says the threshold was always a place of seeing, and the Old Ways, the land-and-ancestor faith that keeps rivers, groves, and oath-stones as

older doors than any grafted Tree, name them kin at the door that made them rather than calling the return a late gift. None of those faiths can close the question between them.

The Tithe is a feeling as much as a rule on the card. A Returned is steady only while they have a reason, and if they neglect the reason they cool, in the temperature of the skin and in the way the living step back from them. The living can tell a settling Returned at a touch. That is why the Returned build a life around the Purpose with a care that looks almost religious. The returns themselves are counted. Each time they Refuse to Fall, they cross out a Hope slot, so a Returned who has walked a long time is a person whose remaining comebacks you can count. Blaze of Glory stays available as the death they can choose. After a life of refusing rest, they can go out on their own terms, spectacularly, rather than on the last scar.

When the unfinished thing is finally done, they make the choice with the GM: lie down and take the rest they skipped, lay the Condition aside and live out the rest of their days as a mortal with no Condition at all, or take up a new Purpose and keep walking. That choice is a major beat for the character.

RULES

> *You died with something unfinished. It keeps you walking.*

- **Unfinished Business** *(boon):* You have already died once, and death does not hold you the way it holds other people. When you make a death move, you cannot choose **Avoid Death**. Your options are **Blaze of Glory**, **Risk It All**, and a fourth option this card gives you, **Refuse to Fall**. Avoid Death is the safe road in Daggerheart: you fall unconscious, you may take a scar, and you come back when an ally clears a Hit Point or the party finishes a long rest. Offering it here would make Refuse to Fall a worse version of a move every character already has, so it is off the list. When you Refuse to Fall, you go down and leave the current scene, and you pull yourself back together by the next long rest, which you describe. Coming back leaves a mark. You cross out a Hope slot as a scar. If that crossing would take your last Hope slot, you cannot Refuse to Fall. The unfinished thing finally lets go, and that death is true and final, the same scar rule Daggerheart already uses: crossing out your last Hope slot ends the character's journey. You may still choose Blaze of Glory, or gamble on Risk It All and die if the gamble fails. Refuse to Fall is the steady road back, and it is finite, because the scars count it. You are also unshaken by the dead and the dying. You automatically pass rolls to resist fear, horror, or despair that come from corpses, gore, and deathly places. That exemption belongs to this card alone. It is not the Unbound's missing capacity, and it is not Quiet.
- **The Tether** *(Tithe):* Name your **Purpose**, the unfinished thing that holds you here, and write it on the card. While you can still act toward it, you are steady. If a long rest passes in which you did nothing in service of that Purpose, you begin to settle. You mark a **Stress** that cannot be cleared until you next act toward the Purpose, and your touch runs cold. A living creature you touch, or that touches you, feels a bone-deep wrongness and marks a Stress, and you have **disadvantage** on rolls to comfort, persuade, or charm the living until you act toward your Purpose again.

When the Purpose is fulfilled, you settle and take the rest you skipped, or you live on with no Condition, or you name a new Purpose and keep walking.

Bound

The Bound are people who, in some extremity, swore a contract with something on the other side and are still keeping the terms. They are the only people carrying a Condition who chose it. Every other Condition was Given when the Tree offered it, or Struck when a threshold took the person whether

they had asked or not. The Bound asked, and something answered. The power they carry is the power they named, and what their neighbors fear is not a demon in the blood but the debt, and the counterparty who watches the ledger and does not look away.

Daggerheart already has the Infernis, people born demon-blooded. That is a Kind, the ancestry you come into the world wearing, and Bound is not that. Bound is acquired, and you are never born into it. An Infernis may still be Bound, because Kind and Condition stack on the same person. The blood is not a contract, and the contract is not a bloodline.

The Tree gives a Condition at the Awakening, or it withholds a colour and gives nothing, and it does not Give a contract. The Bound are Struck only. The threshold is a bargain: someone in dire need swore, at whatever age, and something answered. A Bound has no colour, because a contract leaves no leaf. People fear them because the contract-lane is about 5 percent of everyone, the power is real, the terms bind, and a Bound who falls behind is collateral the contract can collect. Towns need them in the same breath, because a Bound's sworn word is literally binding, and many of them can tell a lie when they hear one, so the world puts them to work as enforcers, oath-keepers, witnesses, and the people who arbitrate a debt. When a treaty absolutely must hold, a Bound swears to it. That 5 percent is the whole contract-lane, and it already holds both halves. People currently Bound are about 3.5 percent, and the Unbound already released are about 1.5 percent inside the same figure. You do not count the released ones a second time on top.

The faiths do not read a Bound the same way. The Motherfaith fears them and still needs them, and it receives them back at the Tree so the town can acknowledge what has already happened. That receiving is not a Gift, because the Tree is not handing the contract out. The Fair Hand, the fortune-and-contract faith that treats a becoming as an account a person can close and walk away from, says this is the same shape as every other becoming, written large enough to read, rather than a horror set apart. The Watching names a seeing at a harder door, and the Old Ways take a Bound to the oath-stone that heard the vow and name them kin. The Book-Hands, the Fair Hand's notaries, witness the signing, and on oath-day they recite the Terms where a neighbor can hear them, and they do not rewrite those Terms. A newly Struck Bound is sent first to the Intake, the shed that takes a raw Struck person in hand before the town reaches for a rope, so the contract can be read and written down.

You choose the counterparty when the character is made, or you do not know it yet and the discovery is a thread of play. What holds the note may be a demon or a lesser power, a named thing that bargains, or an intelligence that is vast, indifferent, and wrong. It may also be unknown even to you, so that you genuinely do not know what holds your note.

The only sure release is to kill the thing that holds the contract. A patron that can grant this power can often sense the intent while it is still forming, so plotting the kill is its own peril. A term-limited contract does not need that ending. It comes due, the counterparty releases you and collects the Pledge, and what that leaves behind is one of the Unbound.

A Bound may contract for true flight, but the sky is already spoken for. It belongs to the Tengu and, in legend, to the Phoenix. A contract for flight is uncommon and never clean. It grants literal, visible wings, or some stranger tell, a shadow that lifts or feet that will not touch the ground, and a Bound cannot furl those wings or hide that tell. The bargain marks them as plainly as a Phoenix's fire marks a Phoenix, so anyone looking can see that a deal was made. Most people who want the sky are more simply served by a glide or a saving slow-fall. True sustained flight is a GM's call, priced with heavier Terms and a Pledge to match, and it is not one of the ordinary boons a Bound can carry in a crowd.

The world has a name for a Bound who keeps signing, power after power and pledge after pledge. They start because they are afraid of paying what they already owe, and another contract defers the debt, and then it becomes too much to stop. Bit by bit they give themselves over until the being effectively holds them. This is a fate for people the table meets, not a Condition a player takes, and a player character who has signed away nearly all of themselves is no longer really playable. The plain name is the Given-Over, the contract-guilds call that same fate the Forfeit, and the pipeline that feeds it is the Holding Desk, the back room that will still write a next term after the honest stamp has already closed.

RULES

> *You swore something to something, and it answered. Now you both keep the terms.*

- **The Granted Power:** When you became Bound, you named what you wanted, and the contract granted it. With the GM, choose one small, defined boon your class doesn't give you. The boon might be that you can never become lost, so you always know true north and the way back. It might be that you don't need to breathe, or that you need no food or water, or that you can speak and understand any tongue, or that you always know when someone lies to you. If the boon is something you actively call on, it costs a **Stress** to use. If it is simply true of you, it works with no cost at all. Flight, if granted at all, follows the visible-wings terms above, and it is not one of these ordinary boons.
- **The Terms** *(Tithe):* Your contract carries **Terms**, written on the card, a standing obligation the counterparty exacts. You might never refuse a sincere plea, or you might be bound to collect what is owed, or to tell no lie on a holy day. Keep the Terms and the power stays clean. Break a Term, or miss a payment, and the contract collects. The GM gains a **Fear**. Until you make restitution, which is a defined act the GM sets, your Granted Power costs a **Hit Point** instead of Stress, and the Whisper begins. While you owe that debt, whenever you roll with Fear the GM may voice an intrusive thought, or a plausible lie the counterparty wants you to believe. You may act against it freely. Shutting it out costs a Stress, and the debt compounds each time you fall further behind. The Whisper suggests and never commands, and the counterparty cannot take control of you. You choose every action.
- **The Pledge:** At signing you also named what you would give when the contract ends, a part of yourself: an eye, a leg, your capacity for fear, your memory of home. It is written on the card, and you keep it while the contract runs. When a term-limited contract comes due, the counterparty releases you and collects the Pledge, and you become one of the Unbound, whom people colloquially call the Hollow.

The Unbound

The Unbound are what a term-limited Bound contract leaves behind when the term ends. The counterparty releases the person and collects the Pledge, the part of themselves that person named at the signing, and they walk away unbound: free of the contract at last, and left with a hole where that piece used to be, exactly as the contract agreed. The state is Struck only, and it chains off Bound, so there is no other door into it. It is rare, about 1.5 percent of all people, and that figure sits inside Bound's 5 percent contract-lane, because only the Bound whose contracts were term-limited, rather

than open-ended, ever arrive here. An open-ended contract does not come due, and people still call them the Hollow, for the absence the freedom cost.

The Condition takes its title from the release, because the contract is over and the person is unbound, while common speech fixes on the cost and calls them the Hollow. Both names are true, one of them a freedom and the other an absence.

The Pledge was chosen at the signing, before any of the power had been spent, so you knew what you would owe. It might be an eye, or a leg, or your capacity for fear, or your memory of home. The loss is grief and gift at the same time, because the hole where that part was is also an immunity to whatever used to come in through it. People are not afraid of the Unbound so much as unsettled by the absence in them, and the standing that follows is pity mixed with unease. Where the Long-Lived have to keep learning if they want to stay whole, the Unbound have to keep connecting if they want to stay quiet. The fuel runs the other way.

An Unbound has no colour, because the state chains off Bound and the Tree never named them, and you cannot start a character here. The Motherfaith pities a person who paid with a part of themselves, while the Fair Hand hears a closed account, the debt paid in full so the person walks away. The Watching names a seeing of what is missing, and the Old Ways still count them as kin of the oath-door rather than as someone the Tree refused. Nothing institutional comes next, no guild and no school, so family keeps an Unbound person company through a long rest, or a hired companion does. The Book-Hands settled the contract in the year the person became Bound, and they do not help with the loss afterwards.

You become Unbound only after you have played through an actual Bound contract, or arranged one with the GM before the first session: what the contract was, what you Pledged, and the moment the term came due and the Pledge was collected. The Absence has to be a specific loss the table has agreed, with real weight, and it is not a free immunity you pick off a list, so talk it through with the GM before anyone writes it on a sheet.

RULES

> *You paid what you promised. Something is missing now, and the missing place is quiet, and strong.*

- **The Absence:** Name what the contract took, which is the Pledge from Bound. You lose it permanently, in the fiction and, where the loss matters, on the sheet. The hole is also a narrow immunity. You are immune to effects that would mark Stress, or that would grant the GM Fear, when those effects work through the capacity you gave up. You are not immune to every roll that sits in the same broad lane. Agree the details with the GM at the moment you become Hollow. The loss falls in one of three lanes, and the lanes do not borrow from each other.
- **A capacity of the mind** (fear, grief, love, the ability to lie, or the memory of a person or a place) becomes a lack in the fiction, and the immunity covers only the Stress-marking or Fear-granting effects that use that particular capacity. If you gave up fear, a terror that would mark Stress does not mark it. You still have to treat a scared crowd as a crowd. If you gave up deceit, you cannot lie, and a lie that would have marked Stress on you if it landed does not mark Stress. You do not automatically know every lie you hear.
- **A sense of the body** (an eye, hearing, or taste) is a fictional loss with a sharp edge in play. Give up an eye and you have **disadvantage** on rolls that need depth or distance. You are immune to Stress-marking effects that require the sense you lost, including the Stilling Gaze aimed at you and a blinding light that would otherwise mark Stress. An illusion you have to see still works on you, unless the illusion would mark Stress through that missing sense.
- **A part of the body** (a leg, or a hand) is a fictional loss plus a standing penalty the group accepts, offset by immunity to Stress-marking pain and to other Stress-marking effects that work through that part. In the fiction there is often a prosthetic, or a Condition-crafted replacement.
- **The Quiet** *(Tithe):* Place **3 Quiet tokens** on this card, and begin play with them filled. Spend a Quiet token to act through the hole. You take an action the missing thing would have stopped, or you gain **advantage** on a roll where the empty place makes the hard thing easy. You still mark Stress from effects that sit outside your Absence immunity. Quiet is not a second immunity to the same lane, and it is not the Returned clause that leaves a Returned unshaken by corpses, gore, and deathly places. If you pledged fear, Quiet does not let you automatically pass a charnel house. At a long rest, refill all the tokens if you rest with at least one other person who knows your name and shares the meal or the watch. If you are alone, or among strangers who do not know you, the tokens stay where they are. At 0 tokens the pull turns loud. While the card is empty, whenever a bargain, a favor, or an offer of power is on the table, the GM may present that offer as unusually reasonable, and refusing to reach

> for it costs a **Stress**. The offer is a suggestion and never a compulsion, so you can always say no, and saying no aches. Taking the offer is how an Unbound becomes Bound again, and how a Bound moves toward the Given-Over.

Far-Voiced

A Far-Voiced carries a voice with total emotional fidelity. It travels exactly as far as they mean it to travel, and it arrives exactly as true as they mean it, with no extra feeling poured in and none shaved off. The siren of the old stories sings the unwilling onto the rocks. This is not that song, and a Far-Voiced does not override anyone's will. The danger runs the other direction, into the singer, when a feeling they have been holding finally comes out of them whether they chose the moment or not. Towns build their relay-singers, their sworn witnesses, and the performers who fill a hall out of people who can do this.

Distance does not drown the voice, and neither does a storm, the noise of a battle, or water over the singer's head. The voice also never says less than the Far-Voiced means. That is why the signal network runs on them. Relay-singers take posts along coasts, roads, and border-towns, and a warning, an alarm, or an order in that voice travels faster and farther than any horn or drum. Courts and treaties want them as witnesses for a reason that cuts against the glamour. The moment a Far-Voiced is under pressure, their own voice betrays the feeling they actually hold, so a sworn word from them is trusted precisely because they are bad at lying once the strain is on, where many Bound can instead hear that someone else is lying. Concert halls want the same fidelity, because emotion delivered so the room can hear it, and delivered exactly, is the whole of the art. They are revered rather than feared, and a Far-Voiced who has not mastered the channel is a genuine hazard to everyone in earshot, which is why the guild exists and why its training is what it is.

About 12 percent of all people are Far-Voiced, and about eleven parts in twelve of them were Given, roughly 11 percent of everyone. They drew the sea-blue leaf at the Awakening and spent childhood in the guild, learning breath, projection, and how to vent a feeling on purpose before it vents itself, so they come to the table controlled, professional, and poised. About one part in twelve was Struck, roughly 1 percent of everyone, and the door is surviving a drowning: they were pulled under, breath and voice both stopped, and both came back changed, raw and untrained, with the undertow already pulling before anyone had taught them how to swim it. It is the same Condition the guild trains, and it is not the same person at the table. There is no leaf and no ceremony, so the people watching call it a miracle, or call it faintly uncanny, depending on who is watching, and a Struck Far-Voiced usually needs a guild's help quickly, before they learn in public what happens when the tokens run out.

When the leaf falls it is sea-blue, and people who have stood at a ceremony know that colour, though a Far-Voiced who came up from a drowning has no leaf at all. The Motherfaith hears a gift of voice, and if the person came up out of the water instead of receiving a leaf, the faith holds a quiet receiving-rite after the fact, the Wide-Hand saying she met them there and the Narrow-Hand uneasy. The Watching says the Tree, or the threshold itself, saw a voice that would carry, and the Old Ways do not treat a drowning as a late gift from the Tree, so they name that person kin of the drowning-door. The Hall-Keepers keep the hour in which a Far-Voiced may feel on purpose, and they stamp the Voice-ticket, the licence that lets that voice be used where other people can hear it. A newly Struck Far-Voiced is sent to the Intake for help, before anyone has to restrain them.

The pleasant face of the Tithe is why the jobs exist. Deliberate, controlled venting, in a performance, a ritual song, or a relay-call, is how a working Far-Voiced manages the channel, so the careers that need a big voice are also the careers that keep one healthy. The guild drills the breath, schedules the performance, and holds people to the discipline of singing it out before a shift ends, because an un-vented Far-Voiced is not merely unpleasant to stand beside. When the feeling breaks out anyway, that outburst is a Cry, and a Cry in a crowded hall or a command tent is a real and documented hazard, the risk sitting under the reverence.

RULES

> *Your voice carries exactly as far, and exactly as true, as you mean it to.*

- **The Carrying Voice:** Your voice is never lost to distance, weather, noise, or water, and it lands with the emotional weight you intend. Spend a **Hope** to be heard clearly and understood by everyone you intend, across any distance or chaos in the scene, or to land a rally, warning, plea, or calming word with exact emotional force, and gain **advantage** on that roll.
- **The Undertow** *(Tithe):* Place **3 Breath tokens** on this card. The clock is triggered by the scene, not drained by rest. A long rest leaves the tokens where they are. When you mark Stress from feeling, or when the GM names grief, terror, rage, or joy as what is in you this scene, you must vent it before the scene ends. Sing, cry out, laugh, weep, something the room can hear. If you do not, remove a token.
- **2 tokens:** nothing about the voice has changed yet.
- **1 token:** the undertow pulls. Your voice starts leaking whatever you are actually feeling underneath the words you chose, and you have **disadvantage** on rolls to persuade, deceive, or perform a feeling you do not hold.
- **0 tokens:** the next strong emotion you feel escapes as an involuntary **Cry**. Everyone within earshot marks a **Stress** as your raw feeling crashes into them, or the GM may instead gain a **Fear** when the scene is a crowd or already hostile. The Cry empties you. Mark a Stress yourself, then refill to **2 tokens**. It is out now, one way or another.

The Cry costs the listeners a Stress and costs the Far-Voiced a Stress as well, and it never compels an action, a belief, or a roll. What hits the room is an emotional blow rather than a command, so the listeners feel the feeling and still choose what they do.

The Stilled

One of the Stilled can hold a moment still. A wound that is bleeding stops bleeding, a poison that is spreading stops where it is, and a blade already swinging hangs in the air a beat longer than the arm meant. The gorgon of the old stories turns a person to stone and leaves them there. That curse, inflicted on someone else as the point of the power, is not how this works. The stillness has to be paid for out of the Stilled's own body, and if they do not keep moving, the stillness starts to settle into them instead. Towns put them to work as peacekeepers, as surgeons, and as the menders who have to hold a struggling patient steady under the knife.

Peacekeepers want that gaze on a riot line, because a brawl that has been stilled is a brawl that did not turn into a massacre, and surgeons and medics want it in the theatre, because a patient held perfectly still is a patient who survives the cut. They are feared, and they are regulated by a guild, rather than simply revered. About 7 percent of all people live this way. The same gaze that stops a wound can, if someone misuses it, hold a person helpless in a fight, so a licence and a strict code decide who may still a thing, and for what reason. The snake-hair of the old folklore survives as something you can see, not as a rule on the card. The hair stirs, faintly, when something nearby has gone dangerously still, a held breath or a nocked arrow or a predator about to spring, and the people who do this work have learned to read that tell.

The two paths do not produce the same person. About six parts in seven are Given, roughly 6 percent of all people. They drew the pale-stone leaf, marble-white, at the Awakening, and they trained young under the guild, so they know how much stillness they can spend and how to keep moving until the spent stillness sheds, and they come to the table composed and professional. About one part in seven is Struck, roughly 1 percent of all people, by surviving being turned to stone. They were held rigid and unbreathing for however long the reversal took, and they came back with the stillness living in them, unpracticed and closer to the surface than any guild training would have left it. The stone came from a trap, a curse, or an accident, and then they returned to flesh, however the reversal was managed. There is no leaf and no ceremony, so the people watching call it a miracle, or a mercy, or a little unnerving, depending on who did the reversing. A Struck member of the Stilled usually needs a guild’s help quickly, before an unmanaged stillness teaches them, in public, what a seizing feels like, and that collected stillness is the Grey.

The leaf is pale stone, marble-white, a colour people know and fear, so the warden names it carefully when it falls, and a Struck Stilled has no leaf at all. The Motherfaith hears a hard gift, and the gift is licensed because the same gaze that saves a life can leave a person helpless in a fight. The Watching names a seeing of stillness that the town then made civic, a witness rather than a mother’s pick, and a Struck Stilled is a threshold the Motherfaith still argues over. The Old Ways take them back to the door that made them and name them kin. From there they go to the Stillers, the guild that keeps the strictest ticket, the infirmary, and the drill-yard, and a newly Struck Stilled goes to the Intake.

The Stilled drill hard, they spar often, and they stay physically busy almost as a matter of who they understand themselves to be, because every use of the gaze banks a little Grey. The guilds build constant motion into the job itself, patrols and practice bouts and dance used as therapy, so the Grey gets worked back out before it can settle. An unlicensed Stilled, or a careless one, who lets the Grey fill is a documented hazard, to themselves first of all. A doorknob turned to stone is one kind of accident. A hand gone still on a weapon is another, which is why the guild’s oversight is strict rather than a ceremony people attend and forget.

RULES

> *You can hold a moment still. The stillness has to come from somewhere, and if you don't move it along, it settles into you.*

- **The Stilling Gaze:** You may still a wound, a spreading harm, or a struggle you can see. Nothing you still in this way is harmed by the stilling itself. Each use adds a Grey token, as The Grey describes below. You can keep one stilling at a time, and a new use lets the last one go.
- A harm you can see, whether bleeding, poison, or disease, needs no roll. The harm pauses until you look away, use the Gaze on something else, or the scene ends.
- A willing creature, or a creature that is down, needs no roll. They gain **Stilled**, described below.
- An unwilling creature requires an attack roll using Instinct or Presence. On a success they gain Stilled. A miss still adds a Grey token, because the stillness has already left you.
- **Stilled** *(a special condition, not Restrained):* A Stilled creature cannot take actions or reactions. They can still speak, they can still perceive, and they can still be targeted. They are not Restrained. A Restrained creature would stay in place, while a Stilled creature can be moved by other people, and the effect does not by itself stop them from talking or from seeing. They may mark a **Stress** to clear Stilled at the moment they would act. The effect also clears if you look away, if you turn the Gaze onto another target, or if the scene ends. The same creature cannot gain Stilled twice at the same time.
- **The Grey** *(Tithe):* The stillness you spend collects in you, and if you do not work it back out, it settles. Place Grey tokens on this card, starting at **0**. This clock fills, and it does not drain. Add a Grey token each time you use the Stilling Gaze, and add one when you take a long rest that did not include vigorous exertion: a downtime move spent on labor, a spar, a drill, or a fight. Clear one token at the end of a scene in which you marked Stress from physical effort, or in which you dealt damage or took it.
- **1 token:** nothing has stiffened yet.
- **2 tokens:** the grey creeps in. Your joints stiffen, and you have **disadvantage** on Agility rolls and on rolls to evade.
- **3 tokens (full):** the stillness seizes. The next time you use the Stilling Gaze, or the next time you take damage, one of your own limbs locks stone-still and stays useless until it is tended and rested off. You describe which limb: an arm, a leg, your jaw. The GM may instead gain a **Fear**, and something small and nearby, a doorknob or a cup or a patch of ground, turns permanently to stone, collateral of the seizing. Afterward, clear back to **1 token**.

> The seizing only ever locks the Stilled's own body, or harmless scenery around them. It never petrifies another creature, and it never takes a player character's turn away from the player, so nobody's will bends and nobody else pays the debt.

The Answered

An Answered is a person one of the four elements answered, and the element has gone on answering ever since. The djinn of the old stories is a wish trapped in a lamp, bound to whoever holds the vessel. There is no wish here, no master, and no bottle. At the Awakening an element spoke to this person, and it talks back to their hands the way a native tongue talks back to the person who grew up in it. The glasswrights, the shipwrights, the masons, and the makers of instruments are Answered when the craft needs that element coaxed rather than forced.

The leaf that marks them is lamp-amber, or brass, and the shade of that colour names which element answered: Ember for fire, Tide for water, Root for earth and stone, and Gale for air. From that day the element is theirs to speak to, though they do not summon it and they do not command it. They coax it the way a potter coaxes clay, and they never conjure it the way a story conjures a spirit. That is why the guilds are built on the coaxing. Ember-Answered glasswrights and smiths do not need a furnace at full heat, and Tide-Answered shipwrights and dyers can bend a hull's planks or set a colour without steam and without mordant. Root-Answered masons and potters coax stone and clay with no chisel and no wheel, while Gale-Answered sailmakers and instrument-makers cut the cloth and voice the instrument with the wind helping. The path is Given only. An element answers at the Awakening or it does not, and there is no bargain in the leaf, whereas a Bound becomes Bound by swearing to a counterparty and an Answered did not swear.

Their standing is the wildcard, and they are about 10 percent of people, because an Answered is never one kind of neighbor. Which element answered, and what temperament arrived with it, changes from person to person. An even-tempered Root-Answered potter and a short-fused Ember-Answered smith share the name and very little else. Some guilds prize them above any other artisan, while some households are wary of keeping, under their roof, a person whose element runs hot. The leaf tells you the element and does not tell you the temperament, which you learn only by meeting them. That is why "wildcard" sticks as a label.

The Motherfaith hears an element that answered because the gift fitted a craft. The Watching says the Tree saw which medium would talk back, and calls that a witness rather than a mother's pick. The four element-guilds, one charter each for Ember, Tide, Root, and Gale, license an Answered to one standard and give them steady work, so the element has somewhere to go and does not break loose in public.

Real, purposeful use of the element keeps an Answered steady, so the apprenticeships run long, and the workshops exist to give them work. Just as often, the outlet is a watch rotation, an escort, or a firefighting crew. One of the Answered kept idle, grieving, or benched too long is a genuine hazard to be near, and every guild hall has a story about the time someone’s untended element finally let go in a crowded room.

RULES

> *An element answered you at the Awakening. It still does, and it still expects to be spoken to.*

Choose your element at creation: **Ember**, **Tide**, **Root**, or **Gale**. The choice sets the Reach in the table, and it sets what you are allowed to ask.

- **The Answering Hand** *(boon):* Your element answers your hands without a tool, a forge, or force behind it. Glass blows with no furnace, a hull bends with no steam, stone is coaxed with no chisel, and you have **advantage** on any action roll to shape, repair, wield, or read something made of your element. In the moment it answers too. Spend a **Hope** to use your element's **Reach**, in the table below. The Reach is always there to spend. What wears down, if you go too long without speaking, is the Tithe.
- **Spoken, not commanded:** Once per long rest, you may ask your element one question it can feel through its own medium. Ember can tell you about heat, fuel, and what would burn. Tide can tell you about flow, depth, and what the water has touched. Root can tell you about weight, fault, and what the stone holds. Gale can tell you about pressure, scent, and what the air is carrying. The GM gives you a clear impression, not a map you could navigate by. Your element does not obey another creature's order, and it does not take their bargain. If someone tries to treat the element as theirs, it answers them with silence. You may spend a Hope to turn that refusal into a Reach effect aimed at the interruption: the fire flares, the stone holds, or the water pulls away.
- **The Untended Element** *(Tithe):* Place **3 tokens** on this card. At a long rest, refill all of them if you have spent Hope on Reach since your last long rest. Otherwise remove a token. Asking the element a question does not refill the clock. Spending Hope on Reach does. At 2 tokens nothing has changed, and at 1 token and at 0 the element starts speaking for itself, which the table describes.

Element	Reach *(spend a Hope)*	1 token (restless)	0 tokens (it lets go)
Ember *(fire)*	Send a burst of fire at a target within **Very Close** range. Make an attack roll (Instinct or Strength). On a success, deal **magic damage in d6s equal to your Proficiency** and the target is temporarily **On Fire**.	You run **hot:** disadvantage on action rolls needing a steady hand or a cool head (stealth, precision, composure).	You **flare:** mark a **Stress**; searing heat rolls off you and anyone within **Very Close** must give ground or work through it (scorched cloth, singed hair; no direct damage). Refill to 2.
Tide *(water)*	Move like water: breathe and swim freely as though water were air, flow out of a fall or a grapple unharmed, **or** slick the ground within **Very Close**. Creatures there must succeed on an **Agility Roll** to move out of it.	You run **thin:** disadvantage on action rolls needing brute force or holding your ground.	You **flood:** mark a **Stress**; water and mud spread under you (**Very Close**), and you *and* everyone in it must make an **Agility Roll** to move out until it drains. Refill to 2.
Root *(earth/stone)*	Turn skin to bark and stone until the spotlight leaves you: **reduce the severity of the next damage you take by one threshold**, and gain **advantage** on rolls to resist being moved, knocked down, or Restrained.	You run **slow:** disadvantage on Agility rolls.	You **calcify:** mark a **Stress**; you become **Restrained** by your own stiffening body until you or an ally clears it with a successful action roll. Refill to 2.
Gale *(air)*	Move like wind: on a move, reach anywhere within **Close** range with no roll even under pressure; **or** a sudden gust slams a door, knocks something loose, or carries your voice clearly across a storm.	You run **wild:** disadvantage on action rolls needing careful aim or a steady stance.	You **gust:** mark a **Stress**; uncontrolled wind scatters every loose or unsecured thing within **Very Close** (dropped weapons, papers, smoke, dust; the GM adjudicates). Refill to 2.

Every consequence at 0 tokens lands on the Answered's own body, or on the air, the water, and the ground immediately around them. It never targets another creature directly, it never harms

> another creature directly, and it never bends anyone’s will. Other people keep their own will, and nobody else pays the debt.

The Taken-In

A Taken-In is a person the wild took partway into itself and then gave back changed. Bark shows at the knuckles, moss grows in the hair, and somewhere on the body there is a spread of antler or a knot of root, and green things lean toward them when they stand still. The leshy of the old stories is a trickster that leads travelers in circles until they die. There is no haunting here, and no luring. The wild lives in them now, and it answers them, which is why the hard land gets worked at all. Farms, forests, herds, and the wardens of a frontier run on people the wild has already taken in.

One of the Taken-In can coax a thing into growing, read the wild, and move through it without being seen and without losing the way. That is why the frontier runs on them. A Taken-In steward makes thin soil yield, keeps a herd alive through a bad winter, walks a forest without ever losing north, and knows a day ahead which way the weather will turn. They are respected, and they are looked down on, and they are about 13 percent of all people. Cities and their guilds need the grain, the timber, and the wardens the Taken-In provide, and the cities eat well because of that work, but a Taken-In comes to town dirt-handed and backcountry, and no longer quite human to look at. The bark and the antler unsettle people who have never left the paved districts. Farm country that is prospering reveres them. Polite society in the city finds them a little coarse, a little uncanny, and keeps them at arm’s length.

Both paths lead here, and they do not make the same person. About twelve parts in thirteen are Given, roughly 12 percent of all people. They drew the copper-green leaf, the metallic green called verdigris, at the Awakening, and they grew up inside the change. A farm child or a forest child is comfortable in that half-wild skin, because the change came on gently and everyone around them already knew what it was. About one part in thirteen is Struck, roughly 1 percent of all people. They were lost in the deep wild, and they were dying there, days without a path and ready to lie down, and the wild took them in rather than let them die, remaking them partway so they would live. They come back more uncanny than a Given cousin, more overgrown, and quietly unsure whether they walked out as a person or as something the forest decided to send.

The leaf is copper-green, and people know it only if they have learned not to confuse it with the hug. The Tree’s own summer-green is the colour of a child it holds and does not name, and verdigris is not that colour, while a Struck Taken-In has no leaf at all. The Motherfaith hears a gift of green, which people in the city call a little coarse. The Old Ways call them the grove’s own children, the land making its own people whether or not the Tree had a hand in it, and a Struck Taken-In is, to them, the oldest door rather than a late embarrassment. The Watching names a seeing, and does not call it a

taking-in performed by a mother. What happens next is civic work rather than a college. The towns treat that green as a utility they use, not as a school that trains it, and the Greens-Keepers, who keep living land inside a stone town so a Taken-In does not wilt on a parlour floor, will hire the skill for the lot while refusing a Taken-In a seat at the high table.

They also live in the city, and that life is not a contradiction of the frontier one. A copper-green leaf falls at a city Tree, where family and a hearth-witness, someone who stood when that child Turned, keep the child, and leaving the city would mean leaving the people who saw it. Grain-hands, seasonal Taken-In who came in with the harvest, winter on the quay, and not all of them go home. A rare Struck door can open in a walled grove, a city lot at night, or a river-garden after a flood. City pay covers what it costs to keep the Tithe and does not cover what it costs to leave, which is the gap that makes them easy marks for the Slide, the people who rent a week of green when the upkeep is about to fail in public and who make the failing last. Polite districts keep them at arm’s length for the bark, the antler, and the dirt. Their share of the world is about 13 percent, a stone city has fewer of them, and most of those work on the greens. The fuller account of the money sits with the economy of the Tithe.

The work is the upkeep. A life spent on soil, among things that are growing, under open sky, keeps the green in them fed without anyone having to think about it. The Tithe bites when a Taken-In is pulled off the land: a long voyage by sea, a stretch in a gaol of stone, a season stuck inside a walled city on a lord’s business. Old custom on the frontier is to send them home before they wilt. A city host who must keep one indoors learns to fill the room with potted green and to open the windows, a courtesy that is also how you keep your guest from going to seed on the parlour floor.

RULES

> *The wild took you in and gave you back green. It still lives in you, and it needs living things around it.*

- **The Green Word** *(boon):* Growing things heed you. You have **advantage** on action rolls to forage, track, navigate wild land, calm or read an animal, or find your way, and you never become lost in a natural place. In the moment, the green answers, and each of these costs a Hope.
- Spend a **Hope** and roots, vines, and brush erupt from any natural ground within **Close** range. Make an attack roll with Instinct or Strength against a target there. On a success, deal **physical damage in d6s equal to your Proficiency**, and the target is temporarily **Restrained**.
- Spend a **Hope**, while you are in any natural cover, brush or trees or tall grass or roots or soil, to draw that cover around you and become **Hidden**.
- Spend a **Hope** to force a sudden useful growth: a branch that bridges a gap, a screen of thicket, a ladder of root, a burst of forage that is already ripe. The GM sets how large the growth can be.
- **The Rooting** *(Tithe):* Place **3 Green tokens** on this card. At a long rest, refill all of them if you can touch a living plant where you rest, whether that plant is soil, a tree, a field, or a green in a pot. Otherwise remove a token. The test is yes or no. Open sky with no plant in reach does not count, and a window-box does.
- **2 tokens:** nothing has wilted.
- **1 token:** you wilt. Your green browns and sheds, and you have **disadvantage** on action rolls to resist fear, despair, or exhaustion, because the wild in you is starving and it drags at you.
- **0 tokens:** you go to seed. Mark a **Stress**. You are **Vulnerable** until you next touch living land, and the wild reaches for any living thing it can find. Weeds crack the flagstones, a beam sprouts leaves, roots buckle the floor, and the room around you goes riotously overgrown. The GM may instead gain a **Fear** if the scene is already tense. Reach living land and refill to **2 tokens**.

The growth that comes when you go to seed erupts from the ground and from the structures around the Taken-In, and it stays there. It never entangles another creature, it never targets one, and it never harms one directly, and it never bends anyone’s will. Each person keeps their own will, and nobody else pays the debt.

Phoenix

A Phoenix is a person who burns down to ash and rises again, but not unchanged and not forever. The bird in the old stories is reborn eternal, and that rebirth costs nothing. Each death here takes a piece of who they were, and each life sits a little further from the first. Where the Long-Lived never die and the Returned refuse to stay dead, a Phoenix does die, completely, and comes back a new turn of the same soul, carrying fewer and fewer of the old one's memories. There is only ever one of them at a time in the entire world, so almost nobody has met them, and the world knows that one person through stories.

There is exactly one Phoenix in the world at any moment, and never two. When the current one finally ends, having spent their last life, the Tree gives the white-fire leaf, the colour of opal, to a single child, somewhere, and the next one begins. A Phoenix is not rare the way a good harvest is rare, because they are singular, the one living person the whole world's phoenix-stories are currently about. The path is Given only, and no threshold can Strike one into being. The Tree names them once a generation or once an age, and then not again until they are gone. Their share of the people is less than 0.1 percent, that trace is still only the one life the stories are about, and the standing is legendary.

Every other Condition wears a plain title, the Long-Lived, the Returned, the Far-Voiced, because those becomings pass unremarked in a crowd, and the quiet name is their camouflage. The Phoenix cannot pass and cannot hide, and the whole world already knows the story, so they are called what the stories call them, and the naming itself marks them as singular.

That singularity is why a whole city can form around them. In a single town they may be, all at once, revered, worshipped, hunted, and hated. The people who revere them parade a living miracle on holy days and take that parade as proof the Leaf-Mother is real, while the people who worship them believe that touching the Phoenix, or touching the ashes, blesses or heals. Hunters want the ashes, the blood, the feathers, or the death itself, some because they believe a Phoenix's ash grants a life and some because they want the one irreplaceable person gone. Beside the hunters are the people who hate and fear them: skeptics who call the Phoenix a fraud, faiths who call them heresy, and rulers who cannot stand a symbol they do not control. They cannot hide in a crowd, because a Phoenix is the Phoenix and everyone has heard the stories, and that is the true weight of the Condition, heavier than any Tithe. You are the most known person alive, and the world has already decided what you mean.

A Phoenix is a spotlight Condition, and it belongs to the whole table, not to one player who liked the card. The group and the GM agree to it together, the way you would agree to a campaign about a chosen one. The Phoenix player commits to playing the legend, the constant recognition, the followers and the hunters, and the impossibility of an ordinary life, and the other four players commit to a campaign that will keep arriving at their door. If anyone at the table does not want that weight, pick another Condition, or run the Phoenix as a legend the party meets. What those other four players receive is a living legend in the party, so the town already has an opinion before anyone speaks, and the Hope slots left on the card, which are how many lives are still left, are a countdown the whole table

can see. The factions come looking for the group, not only for the Phoenix. What the table gives up is stealth as the way you enter a place, and the opening in which everyone still has an ordinary job and a face nobody knows. The Phoenix player has to pass the scene and hand the spotlight across the table, and if they will not pass the scene, do not take the card. The fire on the card is a full immunity to fire, flight on wings of flame, an attack that costs a Hope, and a fourth death move. The package is strong on purpose, and the tax that pays for it is social and finite, so a table that wants the myth without that tax does not want this card. A hidden or captive Phoenix is a different seat at the same card, and what that player still gets to decide belongs to that seat rather than to the open legend.

Clergy know the white-fire, the opal, from their texts, and almost no living town has seen that leaf fall, so a warden who names it at a ceremony has just made history and a problem together. The Motherfaith hears a living miracle, and the hearing then splits into proof, heresy, a hunt, or hate, depending on who is talking. The Watching describes the same fall as a seeing rather than a mother's pick, and still sends the runner. The faiths cannot confirm what the world is by what they saw, and they can only watch. A town-warden does not guess at the next step, and sends a runner to the First Seat of the Tree-Wardens, the clergy who tend the town Trees and speak a colour aloud, and if the Seat agrees, the child cannot hide.

The wings are living fire, so a Phoenix can furl them and pass for a moment as an ordinary person, but the moment those wings open and they leave the ground, everyone watching knows what they are. Nothing is owed on an ordinary day, because this Tithe is not the hunger that keeps a Long-Lived learning, or the living plant a Taken-In has to touch, or the feeling a Far-Voiced has to let out, and the whole cost waits until death, a little less memory and one fewer life. The real upkeep is social and does not let up, because they are the only one. A Phoenix cannot walk a market unrecognized, cannot refuse the meaning other people pour onto them, cannot stop the worshippers or the hunters from finding them, and cannot grieve a rebirth in private. The stories are heavy with loss for a reason. There are Phoenixes who rose so many times they forgot their own children, and Phoenixes who ended not by a hunter's hand but by choosing to stay dead rather than come back as still less of themselves. A Phoenix late in their cycle is a person made mostly of legend, with almost none of their first life left inside.

RULES

> *You are the only one. You will die, as you have died before, and rise, a few more times, and no more.*

The living-fire boons (a Phoenix simply is these, no cost unless noted):

- **Deathless to Flame:** You cannot be harmed by fire or heat of any kind. You take **no damage from fire** and can walk through, stand in, and breathe within flame unharmed. Ash and cinder are home.
- **Wings of Fire:** You have wings of living flame and you can fly. **Once per rest**, while flying, you may mark a **Stress** after an adversary attacks you to gain a **+2 bonus to your Evasion** against that attack. You can furl the wings and pass for ordinary for a moment, but the moment you fly, everyone watching knows what you are.
- **Kindle:** Spend a **Hope** to send a burst of fire at a target within **Close** range. Make an attack roll (Instinct or Strength). On a success, deal **magic damage in d6s equal to your Proficiency** and the target is temporarily **On Fire**.

The rebirth:

- **Rise From Ash:** When you make a death move, you gain a fourth option, **Rise From Ash**. Your body burns to nothing and reforms by the end of the next scene, standing in your own ashes. You return with **Hit Points cleared**. **Stress is not cleared.** You are **Vulnerable** until your next rest. Rebirth burns part of who you were. With the GM, name a piece of the old life that did not come back: a memory, a face, a skill, a fear, a name you used to answer to. You come back you, but lighter, and a little more like something that has done this before. The count this costs you is the Dwindling, below.
- **The Dwindling** *(Tithe):* Rebirth is finite, and paid in self. Each Rise From Ash permanently crosses out a Hope slot, as a scar does, and your lives are counted in Hope. When you would cross out your last Hope slot to Rise, you cannot. That death is your true and final one, and this turn of the soul ends for good, the same scar rule Daggerheart already uses: crossing out your last Hope slot ends the character's journey. Then, somewhere, a leaf falls for the next Phoenix. The dread is the count. Everyone at the table can see how many risings are left, and so, quietly, can the Phoenix.

Rise From Ash acts only on the Phoenix's own body and Hope. Kindle is an ordinary attack, no different from a torch or a blade in what it may target. Nothing here compels another creature's will.

The Kinds

Kinds

You are raised by a place, not by your ears.

A Kind is the body you were born in, the shape you bring to the Turning Tree, and nobody blinks at a fox-tail in a Maiethorn market or at wings on a Heskoren ridge. What the world organizes itself around is the becoming, a Condition, the change that comes after birth, and most people carry one. Carrying it also tells you the Tithe, the upkeep that Condition asks, and often the guild or the licence that goes with the work. There are no Kitsune kingdoms, no Selkie empires of the sea, and no Tengu mountain-empires, because any of those would turn a whole people into one country, and that is not how a Kind works here.

What the four custom ancestries do have are hearths. A hearth is the ground they were born to, a forest, a coast, a ridge, a dry country, or an isle, and it is where they are densest, not where they are the only ones allowed to live. Other people live on that ground too, so a hearth is not a flag and it is not a government.

The Yumboes are the case that shows the rule. They are rare off Kumbaan, the far isle, because of the distance and because of the storm-wall that keeps the isle hard to reach, not because a Kind is a nationality. On the isle they are ordinary, and on the mainland they are a sailor’s tale, the same people in both places, with the map as the thing that separated them.

Kind, Condition, place

Layer	What it tells you	What it does not
Kind	The birth-shape, and sometimes a hearth, the coast, ridge, wood, or isle where that shape is densest	Loyalty, faith, legal standing, or which country they belong to
Condition	What they became. Most people carry one. It also tells you the Tithe, the upkeep that Condition asks, and often a guild or a licence	Ancestry. The birth-body stays the Kind
Place	The drift they speak, which is the local wear on the old tongue, the names they use for institutions, the country that stood witness for them, and whether the second name is a byname or a house-name	What ears they have

A byname is the second name a witness-town uses, *of a town* or *of a deed*, and a house-name is the inherited name a list uses when it has to find you after the witness is gone. Lestrand is the Ledger Coast, the secular docks. Threnmaieth is the Tallied Crown. Vaethorn is the Waiting Lands. A Kitsune clerk on the docks of Lestrand, a Tengu pilgrim in Threnmaieth, and a Selkie standing witness for someone in Vaethorn are all ordinary lives, and none of those lives is a contradiction. What matters is the Kind, the Condition, and the place that raised them, taken together. A Tithe belongs to a Condition.

The four custom hearths

Kitsune: three hearths, one Kind. The fox-born already come in three Foxes, Wilds, Snows, and Sands. That split is the distribution, and it is written into the body. There is not one fox-country. There are three grounds, shared with whoever else lives there. They marry and mingle, and a child takes after one parent’s line. You meet Kitsune in every port and every court, and you meet more of a given Fox where that Fox’s ground is.

Fox	Hearth	Where on the map
Wilds (red / forest)	tangled wood, hedgerow, Motherwood	densest in Maiethorn's Motherwood and Heskoren's deep forests
Snows (white / high cold)	high snow, pale open country	densest on Maiethorn's Rain-Wall and Heskoren's highland spines
Sands (pale / dry)	dry hills, rain-shadow, sand-country	densest in Maiethorn's Rain-Shadow, the leeward east of the Rain-Wall, the one true dry country in the known world

The Rain-Wall is the high country on Maiethorn that catches the weather, and the Rain-Shadow is the dry country in its lee. A Fox of the Sands in a wet Strandoren harbour has simply moved, the way people do. Strandoren is the shore-continent, almost all coastline. A town in the Rain-Shadow with no fox-born at all would be the thing worth asking about.

Old Kitsune hearths still have a word for a fourth fox, and nobody is born as that fox anymore. A grandmother may still say the word, and she will not say what it means.

Selkie: the coasts. Selkies belong to two homes at once, shore and sea, so their hearth is the line between those homes: the strand, the estuary, the cold harbour, and the towns that face the water. They are densest on Strandoren's indented coasts. They are common in Maiethorn's western ports on the Old Crossing, the sea those ports face, present on Heskoren's wild coast, and thinner inland. They are not native to Kumbaan. A Selkie who makes that crossing is a story, not a population.

Inland Selkies do exist, because the skin Anchors, which is how they can always find their way back to water. They are simply fewer, and they miss the place they are not in, which they consider normal.

Tengu: the ridges. Tengu hearths are the peaks, the cliff-shelves, and the wind that lives there. They are densest on Maiethorn's Rain-Wall and on Heskoren's highland spines, the two continents that actually have killing height. They are rare as a settled people on low Strandoren. The ones you meet there are usually sky-couriers, a family, a perch on a clock-tower, and a run over the Old Crossing, and not a ridge-town picked up and set down on a quay.

Tengu settlements cling to crags and are reached by wing or by rope. A lowlander who arrives on foot is a guest who climbed, and that climb is the courtesy.

They keep a running, half-teasing rivalry with the Selkies. Sky-folk and sea-folk, each remains convinced their element is the one worth belonging to. The rivalry is colour between neighbours. It is not a border.

Yumboe: the isle. Kumbaan, and almost nowhere else. They are mythic-rare off the isle and ordinary on it. On the isle there is no Leaf-Fall, the tenth-year rite in which a Turning Tree Gives a Condition, and a Condition that arrives because someone was Struck is possible but rare. Struck means the change came later, at a threshold, rather than at that rite. Their Kind is their own, and so is their place at the table. A Yumboe on the mainland is usually the only one anyone in that town has ever seen. They have no mainland hearth, because the storm-wall keeps them on the isle.

A hearth is terrain, and not a government. A Kitsune on a Lestrand quay still sounds like a Kitsune, and that is a habit of kitchens, not a fox-principality at work.

You are named by the place that raised you, and you are taught by the other kitchen.

The civic year happens at home. That is the drift of the old tongue, the second name, and the town that will watch the child Turn, the tenth-year gathering where a child may be Given a Condition or Kept without one. The Kept are the people the Tree hugged and left as they were. The Kind-year is shorter, and it is borrowed from kin. In the summer before a custom-Kind child's tenth year, or the first summer the family can spare, the child is sent to another kitchen of the same Kind. It is not a pilgrimage, and it is not the walk to a Tree. It is an aunt's coast, a cousin's crag, or a fox-market three valleys over, and people just say it that way.

Kind	What they call the season	What moves
Kitsune	a **fox-summer**	A child of one Fox-ground sleeps in another, so the Wilds, the Snows, and the Sands stay one Kind. The register is taught in person, and foxfire is shown, not described.
Selkie	a summer on **another strand**	Kin from a second coast attend the skin-days, or the child is sent. The stitch-pattern of a skin is a family thing, and it does not travel well as a letter.
Tengu	a season at the **other perch**	A visiting ridge, or a sky-courier family carrying a child over the Old Crossing. A first solo flight may be off a crag that is not the home one.
Yumboe	the **hill-feast**	They do not run a diaspora season. The isle is the hearth. A Yumboe on the mainland keeps the one register by being the only one in the room.

Families who cannot send a child still teach at home. Poverty, a sick Tree-year, a war, or a child needed on the boat, and the register survives those. What the other kitchen does is keep a dispersed Kind from thinning into twenty private dialects. A fox-born child who has never left Hallowquay, a quay people name in the ordinary way, still answers to a Kusawe name, the fox-born hearth-register, because someone who had left came through to trade and to talk.

What travels, instead of a flag, is people, and not an office. Sky-couriers, night-brokers, salvage kin, and a grandmother who does the summers carry it from kitchen to kitchen. Faiths and guilds still recruit by Condition, by faith, and by office, and there is no Kitsune guild. The crafts that travel have to be taught with the hands in the room, foxfire and a skin-stitch and a wind-call and a service at the hill-feast. A recipe that worked from a letter would have made a nation, and these do not travel that way. A few objects go along that are slightly wrong in the next town: a fox-lamp whose pale fire only a shown hand can start, a perch-feather worn at a wedding on the strand, and a current that Selkies can name and will not draw.

A few things stay small, and people will not explain them: the word for the fourth fox, a mark on a ridge that lowlanders are not taught, and a current that Selkies can name and will not draw on a chart.

A hearth-neighbourhood is the other kitchen made local: a Selkie quay, a Tengu perch, or a Rain-Shadow fox-market. The town around it is still mixed. Ornsael is the worked example, a fox-market by the well, mixed Kinds, and no gate.

Stock ancestries

Daggerheart's stock ancestries live everywhere the Trees do: Clank, Drakona, Dwarf, Elf, Faerie, Faun, Firbolg, Fungril, Galapa, Giant, Goblin, Halfling, Human, Infernis, Katari, Orc, Ribbet, and Simiah. They are not given continents. A few of them are more common in some kinds of country, and that is a tendency, not a law. The kitchens below use the ordinary larder of the place. An ancestry does not grow its own staple crop.

You are raised by a place, not by your ears. The tendencies are not rules. A Ribbet judge in inland Threnmaieth is ordinary. A Giant on a Lestrand dock is ordinary, and a Giant who works as a Lestrand banker is ordinary too. If a town has more of one ancestry, that is a fact about the town. Raillath, Denlad, and Tunral do not belong to any ancestry, and neither do Maiethlir and Orentel.

Humans are common, and they are not the normal body that everyone else is a variation on. There is no unmixed household that counts as the default. A marriage between Kinds is a marriage. Nobody files it, and nobody calls it marrying out.

A character whose two ancestry features both come from this stock list takes a Hearth-Mark from the place that raised them. That is how those characters stay playable next to the four custom Kinds, who each have three features. The Mark names a place. It does not turn a tendency into a country.

The water-born. Ribbet and Galapa are most common on the same coasts as Selkies, and they are not Selkies. Those coasts are Strandoren's indented shore, Maiethorn's western ports on the Old Crossing, and, less often, Heskoren's wild coast. A Ribbet can breathe underwater. A Selkie holds their breath, and you cannot keep a Selkie under. Galapa live on the same quays as both. A Ribbet who grew up inland grew up in that town. They cook on the quay, close enough to hear the tide, and the meal is

bread softened in fish broth, with seaweed or a cockle when the tide was good. They do not own the coast, the Old Crossing, the deep water, or the Selkie strand. Some Seaborne communities live in the same weather. Seaborne is a community, a life people share, and not a Kind.

Beside the ridges. Giants are more common on Heskoren's uplands, next to Tengu ridges, and they do not take those ridges over from the Tengu. Some people raised on ridges, or in wild country, live in the same weather. Ridgeborne and Wildborne are communities, lives people share, and not a Giant law. A Giant who grew up on a Lestrand dock grew up on that dock. They eat the usual upland meal, oat mash with dried peas, and cheese or smoked fish when the house has them, and they do not eat it on a Tengu perch. They do not own the ridge, the wind, the high road, or the sky-courier's run. On Maiethorn's Rain-Wall, Tengu and Snows foxes are already common, and a Giant on that road is a neighbour.

The old wood. Elves, Faeries, Fungril, and Firbolg are more common in Maiethorn's Motherwood, beside the hearths of the Wilds foxes, and the clearing is still mixed. Heskoren's deep forests are Wilds-fox country too, so an Elf there is a neighbour in that forest. The place where this group is common is the Motherwood. Faeries are small and they can fly, which does not make them Yumboe. Halflings are small and people call them lucky, and that is a different thing from a Faerie's wings, and it still does not make them the good people of the isle. A winged neighbour in the Motherwood is someone the town already knows. They cook oat pottage with dried peas, and mushrooms when the week was wet, and they start the pot for whoever is already in the clearing, fox-born neighbours included. A Fungril household sets one spoonful aside, and they will not say who it is for. They do not own the Motherwood, the graft, which is a cutting of a Turning Tree, the Wilds hearth, the air, or Kumbaan.

Hedgerow and herd. Fauns and Halflings are more common on farmland, in the pastures of the Mother-core, on the Chart-run plain, which is Strandoren's interior river-plain, and in the valleys under Heskoren's spines, wherever a hedge and a herd already feed a town. If a village that already has a name has more of them, that is a fact about the village, and it does not make the village theirs. Halflings are small, and people call them lucky, and they are not Yumboe. They cook cabbage in the morning's milk and eat it in the yard, before they let the herd through the hedge. That is how that house eats, and it is not the guest-meal, the stranger's bowl. They do not own the field, the herd, luck, the small, or the isle.

Loft, mast, and canopy. Katari and Simiah are more common where the work is up high, in the Motherwood canopy, in the rigging on Strandoren, and in the lofts over a market or a drying floor. They live next to the old wood and next to the quays, and the town below is still mixed. They eat a handful of hazelnuts, or cold fish, in the place where they were working, a loft, a mast, or a branch, and they still come down to the table for the town's supper. They do not own the canopy, the mast, the night, or the market.

The warm bench. Clank, Dwarves, Goblins, and Drakona are more common where a town already mends things, a flood-wall, a hull, a mill, a drying loft, or the bottom of a road that climbs to a perch. Maiethlir and Orentel have that work, and the work does not become a neighbourhood that belongs to them. You will meet more Drakona in a house that keeps a work-fire going from morning until dark. Some of them are Ember-Answered. Ember is the fire-work of the element-guilds, and that fire-work is common. Ember is not a Drakona chapter. They eat bread and beans at the bench while the bench is still warm from the work. They are using the job's heat, and they did not build a separate kitchen for the Kind. They do not own the wall, the quay, the mill, the forge, Ember, or the stone under a Tengu ridge. Faiths and guilds still recruit by Condition, by faith, and by office. Nobody is recruited because of their ears.

The carrying yard. Orcs are more common where the day's work is lifting, on the thaw-roads, at the landings of the Salt Walk, the sea-then-land road through Strandoren, in the dock-gangs, and hauling on a live front, which is a young graft or a neighbour's wood that cannot Turn yet. Other Kinds do that same lifting. A crew that is mostly Orcs is a fact about that crew, and the town is still mixed. They eat a pot of peas in the yard while the cart is still hitched, with smoked fish if the road met a quay. They do not own the road, the ford, the watch, or a war.

Human. Humans are common on every continent that has Trees, and they are no more common on one of those continents than on another. A street with many humans is just that street. They are not the body everyone else is measured against. They cook what the town cooks, the same meal as the street they live on. They do not own being the ordinary person, the standard for any other Kind, or a government that belongs to humans.

Born to the blood. Infernis are born with demon blood, so the blood is a Kind. They are not Bound. Bound is a contract a person swears, and therefore something they become. The blood and the contract are different things. They have no home landscape and no country of their own. They are born wherever the Trees are, and a street with more of them is a family that stayed there. An Infernis who swears a contract is Bound like anyone else. The blood is what they were born, and the contract is what they became. They eat from the same pot as the rest of the house, and they do not set a separate bowl because of the blood. They do not own the contract, Bound, or a homeland.

The quay, the ridge, the wood, the field, the canopy, the mill, the road, and the pot belong to the town. A kitchen cooks there. It does not hold the ground.

Hearth-Mark

A stock Daggerheart ancestry grants two features. Each custom Kind written for this world grants three, so a stock character set beside one of those four looks weak, because the sheet is carrying less. The four three-feature packages stay as they are. You do not even the scales by cutting a Kitsune's fox,

a Selkie’s skin, a Tengu’s wing, or the unseen hands of a Yumboe. The difference is made up at the place that raised the character.

A character whose two ancestry features are **both from stock ancestries**, whether that is a single stock Kind or a mix of two stock Kinds, takes a **Hearth-Mark** at character creation. A character who takes **any custom-Kind feature** does not take the Mark. For that character, the third feature is the hearth already written into the body.

Name the **place that raised you**. It might be a town, a quay, a ridge-road, a walk-hold, or a roll-street. You write it as a place-phrase, the way *Hallowquay salvage-child* is a Hearth-Mark, and not as a Kind-phrase, the way *Seal-blood* is not one.

Once per session, when you make an action roll or a reaction roll that leans on how that place taught you to live, you add **+2**. You do not spend Hope, the currency a player uses to push a roll, in order to add it. You may still spend Hope to add a relevant Experience on the same roll.

The Mark is not an immunity, it is not a power that spends Stress, and it is not a shopping list of tricks. If a phrase starts granting swim-breath, flight, or “cannot be caught off guard,” it has become a feature. Throw it back and write the place again. The +2 is the whole of the Mark.

Everyone still takes a **Community**, as the published rules require, the card for the sort of place that raised the character. A Hearth-Mark is not a second Community, and it is not a third ancestry feature slipped in under another name. Ridgeborne, Seaborne, Wildborne, and the rest of those cards stay what they are. The Mark is one town, or one quay, or one road, and it is not a Kind-nation. You still take the two Experiences the rules give every character, and the Mark does not replace them.

Mixed Ancestry

The table allows what Daggerheart allows. Mixed Ancestry is a legal heritage here, an ordinary way to build a character, and you do not have to ask permission to use it. The published rules, the System Reference Document, take the **top** feature, the first one listed, from one ancestry, and the **bottom** feature, the second one listed, from another. Two mainland Kinds, stock, custom, or one of each, mix by that rule.

Custom Kinds have a third feature. That third feature is the **hearth feature**, the one that belongs to the full Kind, and a mix leaves it out.

Kind	Top	Bottom	Hearth feature, only on the full Kind
Kitsune	Slip the Frame	Fox’s Glamour	Your Fox (Wilds / Snows / Sands)
Selkie	Second Skin	Slip the Hold	Seal-Kin
Tengu	Wind-Winged	Wind-Caller	The Mountain’s Mood

Yumboe is not on this table. That Kind is written below.

Two parents means two hearths and a body that can wear both, and nobody files the marriage. There is no mixed-Kind licence. The live question is still whose kitchen, not whether the marriage was allowed. A mixed mainland child carries two features, one from each side, which is the pairing the published rules describe, and not two full custom packages stacked together. If either side is a custom Kind, the child answers to one register, often the kitchen they spent the summer in, or simply the name that stuck, and the second name still comes from the place. Both sides show on the body, ears and webbing, or a fox-brush under a wing, and that is ordinary, not a secret third feature. If a Kind they wear keeps another kitchen, they may visit it, and they may visit both, without growing a second hearth feature just for having gone.

A mixed Kitsune is fox-touched, which means they have Slip the Frame or Fox’s Glamour, and they are not a Fox of the Wilds, the Snows, or the Sands unless they take the full Kind and the hearth feature that names which fox they are. Kitsune Fox-lines are still one Fox when the child is a full Kitsune.

How to build one:

1. Take **one Top** from one parent Kind and **one Bottom** from the other. Use the table above for the three mainland customs, and use the printed card order for a stock ancestry.
2. Take **no** hearth feature from either custom Kind. The third feature stays with the people who took the whole package.
3. Take **no** Hearth-Mark if either of the features you chose is custom. Take a Hearth-Mark if both features are stock.
4. If both chosen features grant the same verb, fly and fly, or swim and swim, keep one of them and take the unused listed Top or Bottom from either parent instead. You do not stack the same verb twice and call it a mix.
5. Write both sides on the body. That might be ears and webbing, or wings and a fox-brush, or whatever the pairing actually is. The visible mix is the mix, and it is not a hidden tell waiting to become a third feature.

You do not take three features from one custom Kind and then add a stock feature on top, and you do not take two hearth features. Community is still the card it always was. Kind still stacks with a Condition, so a character of mixed heritage Turns at the Tree, or is Kept, or is Struck, the same as anyone else, and Kind does not vote.

Yumboe at the table

A Yumboe character needs the GM's **leave**. They are mythic-rare off Kumbaan, the isle on the far side of the storm-wall, so a mainland campaign that seats one has already decided that the wall let someone through.

If the table says yes, that character is the **full Kind**: Hollow-Hill, Moon-Waked, and The Unseen Hands, all three and nothing mixed in. They take no Hearth-Mark, because the three features already include the hearth. You do not split them into a Top and a Bottom, and you do not pair a Yumboe feature with a stock feature or with a mainland custom feature, because the good people do not come in halves.

A child of a Yumboe and anyone else is either a full Yumboe, with the same GM leave, or the other parent's Kind, with at most a story-tell, a detail people say about the child and not a feature on the sheet. There is never a top-and-bottom split that includes a Yumboe feature. Distance and the storm-wall are why a mainland table asks first.

A Condition arrives on its own clock, so a mixed-Kind child, and a Yumboe child, Turns, or is Kept, or is Struck, the same as the neighbour's child.

Kitsune

Kitsune are slight and quick-eyed, fox-born, with a fox's ears and a brush of tail, and the cold pale light of **foxfire** always a thought away at their fingertips. They say *kitsunebi* for that fox-flame. They are born with the ears, the tail, and the fire already theirs, so the neighbours treat that shape as ordinary: a Kind is the body a person arrives with, and a Condition is a change that comes later, which this shape is not.

In folklore the fox is a shapeshifter and a liar, and the truth here is gentler, and it is real. A Kitsune can throw a **glamour**, foxfire drawn into the shape of another face, a borrowed voice, or a trick of the eye. The glamour is a seeming, not flesh. It changes what a person perceives, and it never touches what they decide. A Kitsune is as honest as their neighbours. They simply cannot quite be pinned down. They redirect, step out of the frame of a situation, and leave you looking at where they were, or at a

face that isn’t theirs. The tail is real and worn openly, and it is often the surest way to catch a glamoured fox, the one thing the fire will not hide.

Foxfire is the thread that runs through all of them, the ghost-light that leads travelers off the mountain path, the pale fire that hides the sacred white fox, the flame the old nine-tails were said to carry. Each kind of fox bends the same fire a different way.

Just as the world holds arctic, desert, and forest foxes, the fox-born come in kinds shaped by the country they were born to. The **Fox of the Wilds** is red-and-russet, a forest and hedgerow fox. The **Fox of the Snows** is white-coated, born to the cold north and the high snows. The **Fox of the Sands** is pale and huge-eared, born to the dry country. All of them are Kitsune. They share the same slipperiness and the same foxfire, and they marry and mingle freely, a child taking after one parent’s line or the other. Each carries a gift bred into it by its home ground, and turns its foxfire toward a different old fox-story: the will-o’-wisp that leads a hunter astray, the pale flame that swallows the white fox from sight, and the ward-fire of the fox that always knows what is coming.

A Kitsune is not changed into anything. They are known for never quite being where you left them, a reputation for misdirection without deceit. The fox slips the trap, and it does not lie about the trap being there.

Values

Kitsune prize the graceful exit and the unfought fight, the deal that dissolves before it comes to blows, and the door found before the room fills with smoke. They tend to distrust a cornered situation, because their instinct in a corner is to make a new corner, and they admire cleverness over force. They say, “Never the last one holding it.” They keep their word carefully, precisely because they are so slippery that an untrustworthy Kitsune would be trusted by no one. A Kitsune’s given word tends to be very solid, and they know it is their most valuable possession.

Customs

Because they defuse rather than escalate, and because they can never quite be cornered, Kitsune work as mediators, brokers, and night-couriers. They carry delicate news between rival houses, hold the neutral ground in a negotiation, walk the dark roads by their own cold foxfire, and are trusted to be somewhere unnoticed and then gone again without a scene. Foxfire is a small everyday grace as well, so children are taught to make it before they are taught to read, and a home with a fox-born in it never wants for a soft, safe light. The summer before they Turn, the season when the town will gather to watch them, many spend a fox-summer at another Fox-ground, so the Wilds, the Snows, and the Sands stay one Kind. Older Kitsune, by tradition, carry themselves with more tails in the telling of it. The folklore of nine tails survives as reputation and as an honorific, not as literal biology and not as a power. The body keeps one brush, and the extra tails live in the telling.

Daggerheart ancestry features

Every Kitsune has **Slip the Frame** and **Fox's Glamour**, and chooses one **Fox** at character creation. The Fox is a full feature. Each grants a lasting knack, the real animal's gift bred in by its home ground, and a foxfire signature move, the fox-spirit myth, each kind turning the same ghost-flame a different way. In a mix, the top feature is Slip the Frame and the bottom is Fox's Glamour. Your Fox stays with a full Kitsune. The full package takes no Hearth-Mark.

- **Slip the Frame:** When you would take damage from an attack, you can mark a **Stress** to slip aside: halve the damage, then immediately move up to **Very Close** range to a position out of the attacker's reach. If you end this movement out of line of sight, you are **Hidden**.
- **Fox's Glamour:** You can wrap yourself in foxfire-glamour to seem other than you are: veil your fox features to pass unremarked, cast your voice or a small sound a short way off, or throw a minor sensory illusion (a flicker of movement, a scent, a light) into a space within **Close** range. Once per scene, you can mark a **Stress** to **wear another face**: take on the convincing seeming of another person you've seen, holding it as long as you concentrate. The glamour is illusion, not flesh. It doesn't change your body or fool touch, and a creature that has strong reason to doubt what it's seeing can make an appropriate roll to catch the tell (a fox-shadow, a reflection that's a beat late, an animal's unease). This is disguise and misdirection. It changes what others perceive, and what they decide stays theirs.
- **Your Fox:** Choose the fox you were born to. Each has a lasting knack and a foxfire move:
- **Fox of the Wilds** *(red / forest fox: the will-o'-wisp that leads travelers off the path). Knack:* you are at home in tangled, broken, or overgrown country: **advantage** on Agility Rolls to climb, leap, tumble, or move through difficult terrain, and you ignore its movement penalty. *Foxfire (Wisp-Lure):* mark a **Stress** to send dancing ghost-lights and false trails around a creature within **Close** range; until the end of its next turn it is drawn after the lights: its attacks against anyone but you are made with **disadvantage**, and you may immediately move up to **Very Close** range without drawing an attack. The lights are a lure, not a leash. The target is baited to look the wrong way, and still chooses where to move.
- **Fox of the Snows** *(arctic fox: the sacred white fox that vanishes in its own pale fire). Knack:* you leave no trail worth following. Adversaries have **disadvantage** on rolls to track, trail, or find you, and you have **advantage** on rolls to **Hide** or move unseen in open, snowy, pale, or exposed terrain. *Foxfire (Cold Vanishing):* once per scene, mark a **Stress** to wrap yourself in cold white foxfire and let the eye slide off you, and become **Hidden** even while observed and in the open, so long as you don't take an action that would obviously reveal you.
- **Fox of the Sands** *(fennec: the huge-eared fox that hears what's coming). Knack:* you see clearly in darkness and dim light as far as you would in daylight, and your great ears miss nothing: **advantage** on rolls to hear, notice, or locate hidden creatures, sounds, or movement. *Foxfire (Ward-Flame):* when you or an ally within **Close** range would be targeted by an attack, you can

mark a **Stress** to throw up a sudden curtain of foxfire. The target gains a **+2 bonus to their Evasion** against that attack. What the Sands do is hear, and hearing does not cancel a surprise. Nine tails stay reputation and honorific, and they are not this Fox's body.

Naming

The hearth-register is **Kusawe**, said koo-SAH-way, a light, slipping, sibilant tongue, full of *s* and *sh*. Daily speech is the local Maiethren drift, the local wear on the old tongue, and the fox-name is what they answer to when someone is trying to pin them down. They consider this funny. Given names include Raki, Nenyu, Wishi, Kiraye, Suti, Hatu, Ranyu, Sinro, Foryo, Heka, Sofan.

A Kitsune raised devout in Threnmaieth, where a clerk says the house first, may still be Raki at home and Maethaem, Raki on the roll. Where they live is three hearths, not a fox-country.

Selkie

Selkies are sleek, cool-skinned people who carry a second self, a **sealskin** they can wear or set aside. They are sea-born, skin-kin, born to that skin, so it is a Kind, the ancestry they arrived with, and not a Condition, a change that came later. The skin is not a costume and not a disguise. It is genuinely them, a spare body kept close, and slipping it on or off takes only a moment. Distinct from the frog-folk, who live underwater and breathe there, a Selkie's gift is not breathing the deep. It is that you cannot keep hold of one. A Selkie in the water, in a net, in a grip, in a locked room, has a way out. The sea taught them that being held is temporary.

Out of the skin, a Selkie reads as an ordinary person with a few quiet tells: cool, faintly sleek skin, large dark eyes, and sometimes a little webbing at the fingers. Nobody stares, because the seal-blood shows the way any other Kind's does, and the real change lives in the skin, not the face.

A Selkie belongs fully to **two homes at once**, shore and sea, and so they move easily between those homes when the people on either side do not understand the other. The removable skin is a private, tender thing, and it is not a leash. Loaning it is a real intimacy, and having it taken is a real violation. Both are matters of story and trust, and never a penalty on the sheet.

Values

Selkies value belonging without being bound, a deep loyalty freely given and resented the instant it is demanded. They are hard to detain and hard to hold onto. A Selkie loves fiercely and will not be caged, and a relationship or a job that starts to feel like a net is one they will quietly, gracefully leave. They

carry a comfortable double-homesickness their whole lives and consider it normal. To always miss the place you aren't is, to them, simply the price of getting to have two homes.

Customs

Because they can't be kept down and can't be kept out, Selkies work as rescue swimmers, cold-water divers and salvors, and go-betweens, the ones sent into the surf after a drowning, down to a wreck, or across the water to a community the shore-folk can't talk to. That same talent for getting free makes them trusted couriers for anything that must not be seized in transit. The sealskin is treated with real ceremony. Where a Selkie keeps their skin, who they would ever let hold it, and the day a child is first given the run of their own skin, are all significant and private. Kin from another strand often come for those skin-days, or the child spends a summer on a second coast, which is how a quay-born Selkie still sounds like the sea.

Surviving a drowning is the threshold that Strikes the Far-Voiced, a Condition that can arrive by that drowning rather than by birth. Selkies, being so at home in the water, have a complicated, storied relationship with that threshold.

Daggerheart ancestry features

Every Selkie has all three. In a mix, the top feature is Second Skin and the bottom is Slip the Hold. Seal-Kin, the hearth feature, stays with a full Selkie. The full package takes no Hearth-Mark.

- **Second Skin:** You carry a **sealskin**, a second self you can don or shed in a moment. While you wear it, you ignore the effects of cold and deep water, you can hold your breath far longer than anyone should, and you always know which way is up and where the nearest surface or shore lies. You have **advantage** on Agility Rolls to swim, dive, or move through water.
- *Anchored.* Your skin is your fixed point in the world. Wherever you leave it stashed, you always know the direction and distance to it and can find your way back to it unerringly, however far you've travelled or however turned-around you are. Loaning your skin, or having it taken, is a matter of story and trust, never a mechanical penalty.
- **Slip the Hold:** When a creature grabs or restrains you, or succeeds on an attack against you, you can mark a **Stress** to slip free like a seal from a net: you end any grab or **Restrained** effect on you, ignore any forced movement from that attack, and move up to **Very Close** range out of the creature's reach.
- **Seal-Kin:** Seals and the beasts of the sea treat you as kin, not as prey or stranger. You have **advantage** on rolls to calm, read, or call an animal of the sea. Once per scene, while you are in or near water, you can mark a **Stress** to let the sea itself warn you: the GM **names** what is approaching through the water, and until the end of your next turn the nearest seal-kin surfaces to aid you — a distraction that draws a foe's attention, a tow through the current, or a shove that

carries you toward shore or safety. You may move up to **Close** range before the named approach arrives. What you receive is a warning and a help, and you do not receive an immunity.

Selkies are at home in the water: a long breath-hold, the cold and the deep set aside, and advantage when they swim. Ribbets are the frog-folk who breathe underwater. Seal-Kin calls seal-kin to aid. The phrase “cannot be caught off guard” is not written here.

Naming

The hearth-register is **Sakoa**, said sah-KOH-ah, a liquid, rounded, coastal tongue, the sort of name you can say with cold air in your mouth. Daily speech is the local Maiethren drift. Given names include Lavo, Fesa, Moka, Dovo, Neson, Foaro, Veakea, Didel, Roadoa, Woanun, Laknea.

The hearth-name is spoken to the water the day a child is first given the run of their skin. The second name, a byname or a house-name, comes later, from the town that watched them Turn. Two homes, two names, and they do not consider this a conflict. Where they live is the coasts, not a sea-nation.

Tengu

Tengu are lean, sharp-featured people of the high country, crow-born, with dark feathers through their hair and down their arms, black bright eyes, and broad wings that carry them off any cliff or updraft. They are born with those wings, so the feathers are a Kind, the ancestry they arrived with, and not a Condition, a change that came later. They are the folk of the peaks and the wind, born where the air is thin and the weather turns in a heartbeat, and utterly unbothered by either. Where lowlanders see a killing drop and a coming storm, a Tengu reads a launch point and a rising thermal. They fly, and the deeper truth of a Tengu is that the mountain never surprises them. They feel the rockfall before it slides and the squall before it breaks.

The crow-born of the Turning belong to the high wild the way Selkies belong to the sea: at home in the exact place that kills everyone else. The fox-born move unseen through society, the sea-born through water, the crow-born through the sky and the heights, and the Yumboe, the good people, keep the hill and the night.

The wings are always present, so a Tengu reads as Tengu at a glance, as ordinary in the towns as any other Kind.

Values

Tengu prize the view from height, and the habit of mind that comes with it. Their instinct in any tangle is to get above it and look down: gain height, gain distance, and see the whole shape of a thing before acting. They tend toward blunt directness, the habit of people who are used to seeing exactly where a path leads and saying so, and they run out of patience with anyone who will not climb and look for themselves. They say, “The valley argues about the storm; the ridge just watches it come.” They respect earned skill and hard-won height, and they have little patience for status that was not climbed to.

Customs

Because they can go where a footpath cannot, and because they read the mountain’s mood before it turns, Tengu work as high-pass guides, weather-callers, sky-couriers, and mountain rescue. They carry word over the peaks faster than any road, they call an avalanche warning down to the valley towns, and they go over the edge after a fallen climber. Tengu settlements cling to cliff faces and ridge-shelves, reached by wing or by rope. A Tengu’s first solo flight is as significant a coming-of-age as the day a Selkie child is first given the run of their own skin, and that flight is often off the other perch, a cousin’s crag or a courier family’s clock-tower, so ridge-speech does not thin into twenty private winds. They keep a running, half-teasing rivalry with the Selkies, sky-folk and sea-folk each convinced their own element is the one worth belonging to.

Daggerheart ancestry features

Every Tengu has all three. In a mix, the top feature is Wind-Winged and the bottom is Wind-Caller. The Mountain’s Mood, the hearth feature, stays with a full Tengu. The full package takes no Hearth-Mark.

- **Wind-Winged:** You can fly. While flying, you can mark a **Stress** to fold your wings and **dive** on a target within Close range: treat it as a **Finesse** attack dealing **d8** physical damage using your Proficiency, and end the dive anywhere within **Very Close** range of that target.
- **The Mountain’s Mood:** You read the high wild before it moves. You have **advantage** on rolls to sense danger in the natural world (a coming storm, rockfall, avalanche, unstable footing, treacherous terrain) and to navigate mountainous or aerial ground. You **cannot be caught off guard by an environmental hazard or a terrain-based ambush**. You always feel it coming in time to act or call a warning before it lands. It does not cover a person stepping from a doorway.
- **Wind-Caller:** You command the mountain wind the way the old fan-bearers did. Mark a **Stress** to call a sudden gust and choose one: **shove** a target within **Far** range a step closer or farther and knock it **Vulnerable**; **carry** yourself or a willing ally an extra move on the wind (a great leap, a

saving glide down from a height, a boost across a gap); or **sweep** an area within Close range clear of smoke, gas, fog, or loose airborne projectiles until the start of your next turn.

Cannot be caught off guard is written once, on The Mountain's Mood, and it applies only to environmental hazards and to ambushes that come out of the terrain. The other three customs keep the fiction they already had, and they do it without that phrase. The Sands fox hears, and hearing does not cancel a surprise. Seal-Kin is a warning the sea names, together with aid from kin and a move the character can make. Hollow-Hill feels a gait through the ground, which is a sense of who is moving and not an immunity to being caught off guard.

Naming

The hearth-register is **Gonan**, said GO-nan. It is clipped, windy, and high-country, and it does not sound like Kusawe, because this is ridge-speech rather than the foxes' slipping names. Daily speech is the local Maiethren drift. Given names include Teku, Kukra, Gobak, Hosen, Kotak, Buka, Rekren, Kuhos, Hrarat, Gonan. Gonan is also the people-name. Giving it to a child honors the hearth, the way naming a child after the ridge does.

A Tengu raised where people are witnessed often takes a perch or a pass as the byname, Teku of Highgate, Hosen of the White Stair, and not a harbour. Raised on a roll, they wear the house-name like anyone else, and the perch stays the name the ridge uses. Where they live is the ridges, not a mountain-empire.

Yumboe

Yumboes are the good people, *Bakhna Rakhna* in their own tongue, the small, moon-waked hill-folk of the far isle of Kumbaan. They are born into that shape as a Kind, and not changed into it later by a Condition. They stand about waist-high to a mainlander, with pearl-pale skin that catches the light, hair like spun silver, and wide dark eyes made for the night. They live within the green hills of their home, a warren of hearths and long feast-halls hollowed under the turf, and they come up by moonlight, because they keep the night the way other folk keep the day. They are famously and defiantly hospitable. A Yumboe's table is open to native and stranger alike, laid with more than a small people should be able to carry, and waited on by hands and feet you can plainly see and bodies you cannot, the unseen servants that are the good people's oldest wonder.

Unlike Kitsune, Selkie, and Tengu, who are native to the mainland and unremarkable there, a Yumboe is mythic-rare off that far isle. Most people of Maiethorn, Strandoren, and Heskoren have only heard stories of the pearly, silver-haired good people from across the drowning sea.

They are an ordinary, warm, whole people who live somewhere almost no one can reach, so their strangeness is distance, not nature. They are not strange to themselves. They are a legend to a world that has never had them to supper. The mainland files them, and the hands with no bodies, under fairy-tale.

A Yumboe reads as a Yumboe at a glance, which is why they are remarked on the moment they leave their isle.

Values

Yumboes prize hospitality above nearly all else. To feed a guest, and to be fed as one, is their deepest courtesy and their firmest bond, and a shared table binds them the way a sworn word binds the Bound, people who carry a contract they swore. They are a people of the threshold and the hearth, comfortable underground and after dark, unhurried, and quietly certain that the bustle of the surface at noon misses most of what matters. Because they are small, and because their home is hidden, they have never learned to meet force with force, so they meet it with welcome, with misdirection, and with a great many helping hands. They say, “No one is a stranger twice.” They find the mainland’s daylight faiths loud, and they find its treatment of anyone left unwelcomed baffling.

Customs

On Kumbaan, life runs by the moon. The good people wake at dusk, they work and feast and dance through the bright nights, and they sleep out the glare of day in the cool of the hills. Their halls are famous, in their own telling, for feasts that outshine their means, because the unseen hands fetch and pour and serve, so that even a poor household sets a table like a lord’s. They keep terrace-gardens and standing-stone marks up on the surface, and they keep the real life below. They fish the storm-walled shallows and, the old accounts say, were not above lifting a little corn from anyone careless enough to leave it out, a small people’s small mischief, told fondly.

Off the isle, among the very few who make the crossing, a Yumboe is a walking wonder and knows it. They tend to become hosts, keepers, cooks, and go-betweens wherever they land, turning the one thing they always have, a welcome and hands to lay a table, into a place in a world that first meets them as a myth. A Yumboe abroad is usually the only one anyone in that town has ever seen. They do not run a season away from the isle. The hill-feast stays where the hill is, and a Yumboe on the mainland keeps the one register by being the only one in the room.

On the isle there is no Leaf-Fall, so no child there is Given a Condition, and a Condition that arrives because someone was Struck is possible but rare. Kind does not vote on that clock, and when a Condition does come it sits on the birth-shape the way it sits on anyone else’s.

Daggerheart ancestry features

Every Yumboe has all three: **Hollow-Hill**, **Moon-Waked**, and **The Unseen Hands**. This Kind is not a Mixed Ancestry partner. There is no split into a top feature and a bottom feature, and no pairing of a Yumboe feature with a stock feature or with a mainland custom feature. The package is the whole Kind, and it takes no Hearth-Mark. Playing one needs the GM's leave.

- **Hollow-Hill:** You are one of the good people: **small** (hill-folk stature), and born to the deep earth. You can move through gaps and spaces too tight for a larger creature, and you have **advantage** on Agility Rolls to squeeze, climb, or move through cramped, broken, or underground terrain and to **Hide** where there is cover to slip behind. Underground, or within stone and hill, you always know your depth and heading and **cannot become lost**. You feel movement through the ground: the **direction, number, and gait** (walk, crawl, or slide) of creatures within **Close** range who are on or under the earth. That is a tremor-sense, a sense of who is moving. It is not an immunity, and it is not the phrase "cannot be caught off guard," which belongs to the Tengu.
- **Moon-Waked:** You keep the night. You see in darkness and dim light as clearly as others see by day, and you have **advantage** on rolls to notice, search, or act **at night or underground**, anywhere the sun doesn't reach. When you take rest **under the open night sky or moonlight**, you clear **1 additional Stress** (or your party gains a little of the good people's ease: the GM's call on the fiction). Daylight does not harm you. Glare is when you are least at your best.
- **The Unseen Hands:** You can call the good people's unseen servants, **hands and feet plainly visible, but no body between them**, to attend you. At will, they perform small tasks within **Close** range: fetch and carry a light object, pour and serve, hold a door or a rope, steady a load, lay a table. Once per scene, you can mark a **Stress** to set them to **harry** instead: a flurry of unseen hands swarms a target within **Close** range, and until the end of its next turn choose one: the target has **disadvantage** on its next attack, **or** the next ally to act against it has **advantage**. The hands are a conjured seeming of many small helpers. They can distract, fumble, and fetch. Damage, a weapon, and holding a determined creature are outside their work.

Naming

The Yumboes speak their own tongue, unrelated to Maiethren. It is the one tongue that owes nothing to the Leaf-Mother's liturgy, the prayers of the faith that grew up around the mainland's Turning Trees, because the Trees never crossed the storm-wall. The sound is open-voweled and warm, with soft clusters at the front of a beat, *mb, nd, nk, nj*, and a lilting, drum-like rhythm, so a Yumboe name sounds foreign the instant it is spoken.

- They call themselves *Bakhna Rakhna*, the good people.
- They call the isle *Kumbaan*, said koom-BAHN, the hidden home. Mainlanders call it the Sundering Isle.

- Given names include Ambaa, Njeela, Kumbo, Sambanka, Ndeya, Mbaraan, Njunda, Rakhilo, Sonkaa, Mbindaa, Yumbaka, Ndoolu, Sambiyo, Lunji, Yaaba, Saalo, Mbela, Soonke, Njili, Yendo, Waandi, Koriwaa.

Yumboes are too rare on the mainland to have grown a local byname-layer. They keep the one register, and that is why the introduction sounds foreign the moment it is spoken.

Language and Naming

You need a person who sounds like they grew up somewhere, and a hall that sounds like the land that built it.

Speak the common name, and write the liturgical name. The common name is what a person says. The liturgical name is the one that belongs on a charter, a rite, a learned map, or a scholar's tongue. A traveller asks for the *hall-keepers* or sails to *the Night Shore*. The paper may say *Orenhael* or *Netstrand*. At the table, the common handle comes first. The Hinge Shore has no current liturgical form. *Eolstrand* is retired, and a few old dockets still carry the crossed-out form.

A person is named by the place that raised them. If they are Kitsune, Selkie, Tengu, or Yumboe, they also keep a hearth-name from their Kind, the ancestry they were born into. Everyone else uses the local speech of the Old Tongue, which the devout call Maiethren, Mother-speech. Two names is ordinary. You introduce a fox-born broker on a quay that does not file people as **Raki of Hallowquay**, the given name from the fox register and the second name from the quay.

This chapter is the how-to: how names work, how to pick one, and how to make one that is not on a list. Under each Kind, the sound table and **To make another** are how you build a name that could sit next to the list without anyone blinking. **How to Name a Place or a Hall** names towns and offices from the old-word table. The lookup tables are what each land calls the same building. The map of the continents waits for **The Four Continents**. The deeper sound-system, and the words linguists use for it, live in Book X under **GM only: Language**. What you need in the room is here.

How to Name a Person

1. **Where were they raised?** That sets the second name, and the sound of a common-tongue first name.
2. **Are they one of the four custom Kinds?** If yes, pick the given name from that Kind's list. If no, pick from the place-list. Stock ancestries have no private tongue, so a human neighbour draws a given name from the town.
3. **Add the second name that place uses.** A **byname** where people are witnessed. A **house-name** where a list has to find them again. The civic name carries one of those, not both, and it is never a

name taken from the Kind.

4. **Say it once with the stress marked** (CAPS), then use it normally.

Most people have two names, and the civic line uses only those two. The first is a given name, chosen by the family. Custom-Kind families often draw it from the hearth-register, the sound that Kind keeps for given names, for kin, and for talk inside the group. Everyone else draws it from the local Maiethren drift, the regular way that place has worn the old tongue. The second is the second name the raising-place uses. You can often hear both homes in one introduction. The place that did the raising also decides whether that second name is a byname or a house-name.

A byname is how a place names you when someone there saw you. You are *of a town*, *of a Tree*, *called such for a deed*, or *of the house you actually sleep in* when that house is not itself a written list. This is the habit anywhere a witness still does the naming and a roll does not: on the road, on the live front, in the waiting towns, and under every power that refuses to write persons down. A human at the next desk might be **Valen of Hallowquay**. They share the street and the civic shape of the name, and the first sound is what tells you which home the given name came from.

A house-name is inherited. Children wear it. A neighbour says the given name, while a clerk says the **house first**, then the given name. The house-word is still from that place's drift, often an old given name that stuck to a line. It is not an English family name, and it is not a town. You do not hand over every piece you own. The place that asks decides which piece, and in which order.

A neighbour gets the given name. A clerk in a list-land, a place that writes people down so it can find them after the witness is gone, gets the house first, then the given name. That order is the file, and a given name alone is an incomplete row. A witness-town gets the given name, and *of the place* if you are a stranger, and leading with a house-name there sounds filed, or cold. Kumbaan, the far isle, gets the given name, and a mainland house, or a mainland *of-the-town*, is not your name there.

The rows below are the pattern in use. Maiethlir is Threnmaieth's counted river-seat, and Threnmaieth is the Tallied Crown. Trenledd is the Worn Count: it keeps a roll of persons and does not call that roll holy. The Inner Close is the household of the Walled Book, and the line is said there when rank is in the room. Brenod is a worn folk hearth-name, and it keeps no house-list. The Held bed is a bed that is never let. The White Note is a desk on the third quay at Orentel, and it is a house only while the paper is open. The Feeding Hill does not add a town to Njunda's name.

Who	What they own	At home	In a witness-town	When a list asks	On Kumbaan
Raki, raised in Maiethlir	Given **Raki**. House **Maethaem** *(MAY-thaym)*.	Neighbour: **Raki**. Clerk: **Maethaem, Raki**.	**Raki of Maiethlir**. Do not open with Maethaem.	**Maethaem, Raki**.	**Raki**.
Tilim, raised in Trenledd	Given **Tilim**. House **Vonti** *(VON-ti)*.	Gate: **Vonti, Tilim**. A friend: **Tilim**.	**Tilim of the Worn Count**. Vonti first sounds like a column.	**Vonti, Tilim**.	**Tilim**.
Volir, raised in the Inner Close	Given **Volir** *(VOH-leer)*. Line **Vonsumur** *(von-SOO-mur)*.	Where rank is in the room: **Vonsumur, Volir**. Kin: **Volir**.	**Volir of the Inner Close**. The line first is a display.	**Vonsumur, Volir**. The crown files the line as a house. It is not their book.	**Volir**.
Tora, raised in Brenod	Given **Tora**. Bynamed **of Brenod**. No house.	**Tora**. A stranger: **Tora of Brenod**.	**Tora of Brenod**.	**Of Brenod**. There is no house to give. If she stays, they may invent one. She should not borrow one.	**Tora**.
Thilim, the Held bed	Given **Thilim**. Bynamed **of the Held bed**. No house.	**Thilim**. A stranger: **Thilim of the Held bed**.	**Thilim of the Third Hearth**.	**Of the Held bed**. Same as Tora: no house, and do not invent one to be polite.	**Thilim**.
Foaro, of the White Note	Given **Foaro**. The desk is a house only while the paper is open. The street is the third quay at Orentel.	In the room: **White Note, Foaro**. On the quay: **Foaro of the third quay**.	**Foaro of Orentel**.	**Of the White Note**, and say it is a desk. Said like a family, they will file the desk as one.	**Foaro**.
Njunda, the	Given **Njunda**. No house. Not *of*	**Njunda**.	**Njunda**. If they will not	**Njunda**, of the Feeding Hill. No	**Njunda**.

Who	What they own	At home	In a witness-town	When a list asks	On Kumbaan
Feeding Hill	*a town*.		let it go: **of the Feeding Hill**.	house to put first.	

A marriage in a list-land chooses which house the new household is written under, and the children wear that house. Refusing the writing is a fight with the clerk, not a blank where the surname should be. In Trenledd, where the gate already says the house first, the column may file you under the house that pays, including one you dislike. In the Inner Close, the line can cast you out and keep the name on you anyway. *Closed* on a roster is that rank, not a second name. The Walled Book keeps its own heir-roll inside its walls, and that roll is not a list of everyone outside them.

Harrow's will not use a roll-name unless it means to be cold. Maiethlir, which already keeps a house when it has one, will invent a house for a walker who stays, and the walker will feel filed.

A mixed mainland child answers to one register if either side is custom, usually the kitchen they spent the summer in, or else the name that stuck, and still takes the second name of the place that raised them. A Selkie-and-Tengu child might be **Lavo of Highgate**. The perch is in that byname, a perch or a pass rather than a harbour, and the child does not wear two hearth-registers at once. A Yumboe keeps the one register and is never a mix.

Who is asking	What you give
A neighbour	the given name
A clerk in a list-land	the house first, then the given name
A witness-town, and you are a stranger	the given name, and *of the place*
Kumbaan	the given name

The list-lands are Threnmaieth, Trenledd, the Inner Close, and a filing house while the paper is open. Shut the paper, and the quay goes back to the witness way. A witness-town asks *of where?* because the name that stands for you is the place that saw you. A given name with no place on it has not been stood for. Leading with a house sounds like a column on a roll, and that town does not keep the column. A list-land asks *what house?* because the paper has to find you after the witness is gone. The house is the row the paper looks up, and the given name alone is an unfinished line. Kumbaan asks neither question. The given name is the name.

A Tengu's byname is often a perch or a pass: **Teku of Highgate**, **Hosen of the White Stair**. Raised on a roll, they wear the house-name like anyone else, and the perch stays the name the ridge uses.

Yumboes are the exception you can hear. They are too rare on the mainland to have grown a local byname-layer, so they keep the one register, and a Yumboe introduction sounds foreign the instant it is spoken.

Keep the cast distinct

Before you lock a name for a player character, or for anyone else at the table, say it next to the names already in the room.

Raki and **Ranyu** in the same party are easy to mix up, because the shared opening and the shared cadence make the table hear one person twice. **Teku** and **Kukra** sound like twins, so they belong together only if they are twins.

A Selkie named **Wishi**, or a Tengu named **Maethaem**, is a tell. It says the person was raised away, or adopted, or is passing. Use that on purpose, or do not use it at all.

Names by Place

Everyday names are the Old Tongue worn down to something you can shout across a yard. The warmth is in the liquids and the nasals, *l* and *r* and *m* and *n*, and the weight is in a soft *th* and the long vowels. A drift is one regular way that sound has worn. There are three of them, the same three that institution-names travel, and you push a person-name through the drift of the place. You do not invent a fourth human language.

Drift	Place	What happens to a person-name	Pick from
Conservative	**Threnmaieth**, pious Maiethorn	The old church sound, kept whole. You hear the *th*.	**Maethaem** (MAY-thaym), **Reimaethe** (RYE-may-theh), **Thilim** (THIL-im), **Rithnali** (rith-NAH-lee), **Valein** (vah-LAYN)
Worn	**Vaethorn**, Heskoren folk	The *th* softens. Endings simplify.	**Nathdo** (NATH-doh), **Saelid** (SAY-lid), **Tora**, **Seine** (SAY-neh), **Nethiro** (neth-EE-ro)
Eroded	**Lestrand**, Strandoren docks	Clipped. The *th* has gone to t or d, or dropped.	**Valen**, **Tilim**, **Mataero** (mah-TAY-ro), **Ledan**, **Sorel**

Devout places keep the old *th*, the thorn, which is the *th* of *thin* and never the *th* of *the*. In worn speech, when that thorn sits between two vowels or right after a vowel, it commonly becomes *t*, endings simplify, and unstressed vowels flatten. Written Vaethorn is spoken **Wetorn**. Careful prayer puts the thorn back for as long as the prayer is open. On the docks the thorn becomes t or d, or drops, long vowels clip, and word-ends wear off. A name that still has the *th* comes from a devout place. A name that has dropped it comes from a dock.

To make a new common-tongue name, start from one of the lists above and keep that drift's sounds. A named power uses the same roots and the drift that matches how it stands. It does not get a new language unless it refused the Tree. Vaelhesk keeps the older *vael* and the frontier *hesk-*, and that is this same speech, worn further. The isle of Kumbaan already has its own speech, and it is the exception.

Stress follows the Old Tongue rule under **How to Say It**. A compound you can still hear as two roots stresses the first root. The stress marked on first use is the one to trust.

How a place speaks

A traveller can say **Turning Tree**, **the Mother**, **a hug**, **a colour**, **a tree-warden**, and **a graft**, and be understood on every mainland road. The Turning Tree is the shared name for the Tree. The Mother is the one the pious core calls Maieth in the street and the docks call the old rite. A colour is what a Tree speaks when it can already speak one, and a hug is the no-colour, the embrace that leaves a child without a Condition. A tree-warden is the person named with that Tree, under a different word in each column below. A graft is wood that has been brought and set and cannot yet Turn. Use the common

words and you will be understood. The table is what a place says when it is being itself, rather than reaching for the word a stranger would already understand.

The pious core keeps the thorn, waiting towns soften that thorn to *t*, and the docks drop it. Kumbaan speaks a language of its own. Mainlanders call that isle the Sundering Isle, the old liturgical tongue belongs to the mainland, and the hill was never part of it.

	Conservative — pious core	Worn — waiting lands, the live front	Eroded — the docks	Kumbaan — the hill
the Tree	**the Mother's Hand**	**the Thallow**	**Tallo** *(TAL-oh)*	**the far tree**
the Mother	**Maieth** *(MY-eth)*	**Mait** *(MAYT)*	**the old rite**	**the loud story**
a hug	**a keeping**	**a hug**	**a clear**	**the place**
a colour	**the colour**	**the gift**	**the fall**	**a test**
a warden	**the Reckoned Hands**	**Hands-folk**	**a tree-tender**	**the loud guest**
a graft	**a Hand carried in**	**a carried Thallow**	**a carrying**	**their cutting**

A neighbour in Maiethlir or the Tallied Crown says **Maieth** in the street, the way another town says the Mother, and the polity's own street-name is still the Tallied Crown. A polity is a land with its own way of standing. **The Mother's Hand** is the Tree that can already speak a colour. Wood that has been brought and set, and cannot yet Turn, is **a Hand carried in**, and at the rite they call the no-colour **a keeping**. The Tallied Crown's clerks file that child as unmarked. That word belongs to the desk, and the square does not use it. Maiethvael shares Maieth and the Mother's Hand, and calls the warden a **tree-warden**. The Reckoned Hands is the crown's word for the same person.

Careful prayer in a waiting town puts the thorn back, and Maieth returns for as long as the prayer is open. The kitchen says **Mait**, which is Maieth with the thorn tired, and **the Thallow** is their name for the Tree. A colour is **the gift**, and a no-colour is still **a hug**, which they do not dress as a prize. Young wood on the road is **a carried Thallow**. On the live front, a young graft or a neighbour's canopy such as Harrow's Green, people say **the wood** until that wood can Turn.

Tallo is how a quay says the Thallow once the thorn is gone. Say it on the water, and keep it off the charter, because the written name stays the Turning Tree, or the old liturgical name when the paper is a rite. They call her **the old rite**, and they call a no-colour **a clear**: the child came up clear, and is free to be hired. A warden there is **a tree-tender**. A scion in the hold, their word for a graft being carried, is **a carrying**. Trenledd is this speech with a list behind it. The gate asks the house, and the gate will not put the thorn back to be polite.

Ndenjoo, a hall on the hill, has a table, and it has no Tree and no graft, so it does not grow a word that would put one in the valley. **The far tree** and **their cutting** are mainland things, said of someone else's country. **The loud story** is what they call the Mother when a guest brings her up, a tale about being chosen, told at noon-volume. **The place** is what they offer where a mainlander expects a hug. **A test** is their word for a colour, and they will not use one on a guest. A warden who climbs the hill is **the loud guest**, and is still fed.

A scene uses one of four ways of talking. Each one is a sentence length, the thing they say again, and the thing they will not say while mixed company is present. Each mainland drift still has one phrase it says whole, and the hill has its own. Nobody stops to translate them.

In a devout square, which is the speech of Threnmaieth, of Maiethlir, and of the Inner Close when the room is a household rather than a file, people use two sentences, and the first one finishes. If that first sentence left **the Mother's Hand** or **Maieth** out, the second puts them back. A fragment sounds like the dock, and they will hear it. What they say again is Maieth, and the Mother's Hand. While the room is mixed they will not say *Tallo*, *the old rite*, or *a clear*, and they will not say *unmarked* while the rite is still open, because that word belongs to the desk. They will not lead with a house-name to a neighbour, and they will not joke a colour. While the room is mixed, they greet a neighbour by the given name. A player who needs the sound can say the line below, and then stop. The last words are the phrase, left whole.

> *"The Mother's Hand kept her. We say Maieth before the square moves. Lei thulen." (lay THOO-len)*

On a dock, which is Lestrand, Orentel, and the Ledger Coast quays, and Trenledd when the list is what is speaking, people give about six words to a breath, and they take another breath only if the number or the berth needs it. Then the phrase, and the quay lets it go. What they say again is **clear**, and the number, and the berth. What they repeat is the last hard fact, not a person's feelings about it. They will not say *Maieth* or *the Mother's Hand*, they will not restore a thorn to sound devout, and they will not call a clear a sadness. They will not ask *what house?* while the paper is shut. While a filing house has the paper open, they will, house first and then the given name, and they still will not hymn it. They speak the dock form, with the old *th* gone.

> *"Clear. Berth five. The fall's on Tallo. Ka doven." (kah DOV-en)*

One tone covers the waiting towns and the live front, and the two of them repeat different words. Waiting towns, the Waiting Lands and Eolvaeth among them, say again the week that has not come. The live front, Harrow's Green or a young graft or a neighbour's canopy, says the wood again. They use one sentence, and that sentence does not close the week. Twelve words is already long for them.

They reach for the old word and let the thorn thin. Waiting speech says **not this week**. The live front says **the wood**, and then **the neighbour** if the wood will not speak. They call their Tree the Thallow. They will not promise the week, they will not say *the old rite*, and they will not offer a house-name. They will not call the Thallow *Tallo*, because that is the coast, and on this road it sounds like a slight. Prayer puts the thorn back. The kitchen keeps the tired form to itself.

> *“Not this week, and the Thallow is still the Thallow. Len soret.” (len so-RET)*

The live front uses the same length and the same phrase, and the other repeat.

> *“The wood first, and the neighbour if the wood won’t. Len soret.”*

A hill-hall on Kumbaan, Ndenjoo and any attic that is still keeping the table, keeps a night pace. The welcome is the whole of what they are willing to say about it with guests in the room. They spend three short sentences on that welcome, a welcome, then a pause, then one practical thing, and they do not explain a Tree inside it. What they say again is **sit**, and **the place**. They will not read **a test**, they will not point to a graft on the hill, and they will not ask *of where?* or *what house?* as the price of a seat. They will not say *Maieth*, and a mainland house-name, or a mainland *of-the-town*, is not the name they use at the table. A newcomer is seated on that welcome. The hill’s own phrase stays inside it, untranslated.

> *“Sit. The place is set. Aman ndo.” (ah-MAHN ndoh)*

Names for the Four Custom Kinds

Kitsune, Selkie, Tengu, and Yumboe keep a hearth-register for given names, kin, and in-group talk. On the street they still wear the local second name. You can often hear both homes in one introduction. The own-names, the names the peoples use for themselves, are settled. The common-tongue names outsiders say, Kitsune, Selkie, Tengu, and Yumboe, stay.

Each register is a naming-language: a sound, a short recipe, and a list, rather than a grammar. Nobody writes sentences in Kusawe, Sakoa, or Gonan. If a scene needs an in-group word, coin one word from that Kind’s sounds and say what it means in the same breath.

The tables are how you check a new name. A beat is one syllable. C is a consonant and V is a vowel, so CV is a consonant and then a vowel, the way *Ra* is, and CVC closes on another consonant, the way *Tek* does. When the table says F, that is the consonant allowed to end the beat, and it names which

ones. A prenasal is the hum on the front of a stop, *mb* and *nd* and *nj* and *nk*. *Ai*, *ea*, and *oa* are glides, two vowels spoken as one. An onset is whatever consonants begin the word. A sound in the forbidden row already belongs to another home, and the register does not take it.

The lists are what you pick from. **To make another** is only for when you need a name that is not on the list. Make one that could sit next to the others without anyone blinking.

Kitsune: Kusawe (koo-SAH-way)

A Kitsune hearth-name sounds light, slipping, and a little sibilant, full of *s* and *sh*, the sort of name that slips round the corner of a sentence.

Consonants	k s sh n r m t w y f h
Vowels	a i u e o ai
Syllables	CV · CVF (F = n/m/r) · 2–3 syllables
Forbidden	*th* (Maiethren sacred), prenasals *mb/nd/nj* (Yumboe), *kr/gr* (Tengu)

Pick from: Raki, Nenyu, Wishi, Kiraye, Suti, Hatu, Ranyu, Sinro, Foryo, Heka, Sofan.

The hearth-name is the one they answer to when someone is trying to pin them down. They consider this funny. A fox raised devout in Threnmaieth, where the clerk says the house first, may still be Raki at home and Maethaem, Raki on the roll.

To make another: two or three short beats, using k, s, sh, n, r, m, t, w, y, f, h, and the vowels a, i, u, e, o, plus *ai* as in *eye*, and you can end on n, m, or r. Leave *th* to the church, *kr* and *gr* to the Tengu, and *mb*, *nd*, and *nj* to the Yumboe.

Selkie: Sakoa (sah-KOH-ah)

A Selkie hearth-name sounds liquid, rounded, and coastal. You can say it with cold air in your mouth.

Consonants	l r n m s v f d b k w
Vowels	o u a ea oa i e
Syllables	CV · CVC · 2–3 syllables
Forbidden	*th*, *sh*, *kr/gr*, prenasals

Pick from: Lavo, Fesa, Moka, Dovo, Neson, Foaro, Veakea, Didel, Roadoa, Woanun, Laknea.

The day a child is first given the run of their own skin is when the hearth-name is spoken to the water. The civic second name comes later, from the town that watched them Turn, a byname, or a house-name if that town writes people down. Two homes, two names, and they do not consider this a conflict.

To make another: two or three beats, using l, r, n, m, s, v, f, d, b, k, w, and the vowels o, u, a, i, e, plus *ea* and *oa*. Leave *th*, *sh*, *kr*, *gr*, and the prenasals to the homes that already use them.

Tengu: Gonan (GO-nan)

A Tengu hearth-name is clipped, windy, and high-country. The names are shorter, and they start hard, on a single consonant or on an onset such as *kr*, *gr*, and *hr*, said as if the wind might take the end. This is ridge-speech, and it does not sound like Kusawe.

Consonants	k t g n r h s b d · onsets kr gr hr
Vowels	a o u e *(few i — that vowel lives in Kusawe)*
Syllables	CVC · CV · 1–3 syllables, prefer 2
Forbidden	*th*, *sh*, prenasals, long *ai/ea/oa* glides

Pick from: Teku, Kukra, Gobak, Hosen, Kotak, Buka, Rekren, Kuhos, Hrarat, Gonan.

Gonan is also the people-name. Reusing it as a given name is a hearth-honor, like naming a child after the ridge.

To make another: prefer two beats, using k, t, g, n, r, h, s, b, d, with *kr*, *gr*, and *hr* at home at the front, and the vowels a, o, u, and e. Few *i*, because that vowel lives with the foxes. Leave *th*, *sh*, the prenasals, and the long *ai*, *ea*, and *oa* glides to the other homes.

Yumboe

Yumboe is its own tongue. Open vowels, a drum-like rhythm, and *mb*, *nd*, *nk*, *nj* at the start of a beat. A Yumboe name sounds foreign the instant it is spoken. The Trees never crossed the storm-wall, so the speech stayed the island’s own, and it owes nothing to the Leaf-Mother’s liturgy.

They call themselves **Bakhna Rakhna**, the good people, and their home is **Kumbaan** (koom-BAHN), the hidden home, which mainlanders call the Sundering Isle.

Pick from: Ambaa, Njeela, Kumbo, Sambanka, Ndeya, Mbaraan, Njunda, Rakhilo, Sonkaa, Mbindaa, Yumbaka, Ndoolu, Sambiyo, Lunji, Yaaba, Saalo, Mbela, Soonke, Njili, Yendo, Waandi, Koriwaa.

To make another: keep the open vowels and the *mb*, *nd*, *nk*, and *nj*. No *th*, and no clipping it down to a Lestrand dock-name. They keep the one register on the mainland.

How to Say It

CAPS is the stressed beat. Mark it the first time, then drop it.

- **ae** = “ay” as in *day*
- **ai** and **ei** = “eye”
- **eo** = an “ay-oh” glide
- **a** as in *father* · **e** as in *bed* · **i** as in *machine* · **o** as in *go* · **u** as in *moon*
- **th** as in *thin*, never as in *the*

The Old Tongue feels warm and weighty, a hall-and-hearth tongue. The liquids and the nasals carry the warmth, *l* and *r* and *m* and *n*. The thorn and the long vowels carry the weight. The consonants in use are m, n, l, r, w, j, p, t, k, b, d, g, f, v, s, h, and *th*. The vowels are a, e, i, o, u, plus the two-letter sounds ae, ai, ei, and eo.

A word may open on a consonant, and it may open on one of a small inherited set of clusters, consonants that already begin an old word together: *br*, *kr*, *st*, *str*, and *th* followed by *r*. Those are the shapes in *bren*, *crae*, *stel*, *strand*, and *thren*. A word may close on a single consonant, and the inherited closings include *sk* and *nd*, which is how *hesk* is licensed. Do not invent a three-consonant opening except *str-*, and do not invent a four-consonant knot. A new root should prefer the simpler shape. If you cannot say it at the table, it is the wrong name.

A simple root keeps the stress listed for it. A compound you can still hear as two roots takes its main stress on the first root, with a lighter beat on the second: **THAEL**-oren, **VAETH**-orn. Old ceremonial forms, and personal names, may keep a stress of their own, the stress that word already had before anyone compounded it. When that happens, the pronunciation given on first use is the one to trust.

How to Name a Place or a Hall

The Old Tongue is **Maiethren** (MAI-eth-ren), Mother-speech, the church language of the Awakening Tree. It is this world's Latin. Nobody grows up speaking it at the market, and it is still the language of the Tree, the rite, and the law's oldest words. Everyone who is not speaking as the devout calls it the Old Tongue. Place-names, crowns, and old offices are built from it. Everyday talk uses plain compounds. People say *the Kept*, *the ranging*, and *tree-wardens*, and you should hear those as worn Old Tongue rather than as a separate language. The common handle is the name spoken at a dock, on a road, in a market, and at the table. It is not a translation sitting after the "real" name. Liturgical forms stay real. They belong to writing, to ritual, and to the moment someone deliberately uses the older form. No new liturgical names are being made.

To name something old or official:

1. **Pick one or two old words** from the list below.
2. **Glue them together.** Thaeloren is *thael* + *oren*. That is Tree and witness.
3. **Wear it the way the land wears it.** A devout land keeps the *th* and the long vowels. A frontier town softens them. A dock town wears the *th* and the long vowels away. The most worn name belongs to the least-devout place.
4. **Mark the stress** on first use.

Same building, three names, and the name shows the stance. A devout land calls the Far-Voiced hall a *gift-hall*. A merchant coast calls it a *release-house*. Threnmaieth calls it a *counted hall*. The lookup tables below are that fact, row by row. Kumbaan's names are Yumboe, and Kumbaan is not in this box of old words.

The old words

These are the blocks names are built from. The meaning is what the word meant in the rite, even when a dock town has kept the sound and let the meaning slide. A suffix is an ending, and *ren* used as a suffix means "the speech of" whatever stands in front of it. A month-root is a root the calendar already took. *Strand* is a loan, a word that arrived from another shore and was made ordinary before the daughter speeches divided. Where the notes contrast *thren* with *ledd*, *thren* is sacred counting, a stewardship reckoned before the Mother, and *ledd* is the commercial twin, the ledger and the sum. The list is small and settled. No new roots are being added.

Root	Says	Meaning	Where it already sits
oren	OR-en	to witness; to speak true	Citizenship is witnessed, and to witness is to speak truly.
ren	ren	speech, tongue	As a suffix, “the speech of.” Maieth**ren** is Mother-speech.
thael	thayl	the Tree; sacred motherwood	The Turning Tree itself.
maieth	MY-eth	the Mother	The Leaf-Mother, as the faith names her.
vael	vayl	a gift Given. Older: what the land yields	A Condition handed down. The Old Ways say that is a narrowing. The frontier still uses *vael* for a harvest, a child returned from water, a person the hill kept.
vaeth	vayth	the waiting; the longing	The Kept, and the pilgrim’s wait.
hael	hayl	whole, hale, sound	Untithed wholeness, being kept whole.
thren	thren	to count, to tally, to number	Sacred counting, stewardship before the Mother.
ledd	led	to reckon, to account	The ledger and the sum. The secular twin of *thren*.
orn	orn	land, ground, a holding	A held or settled land.
neth	neth	night; the long dark	A month-root.
eol	AY-ohl	a hinge; the year’s turning	A month-root, and the liturgical name of the First Cut: **Eoloren**.
bren	bren	hearth; the kept fire	A month-root.
lir	leer	thaw; water that runs again	A month-root.
sael	sayl	sowing; the first green	A month-root. Not *vael* (a gift) and not *hael* (wholeness). Also the greens-keepers’ root.
ael	ayl	to air; to let feeling out	The Far-Voiced outlet, the **ael-hall**. Not *sael*, and not *hael*.

Root	Says	Meaning	Where it already sits
stel	stel	to still; to hold from moving	The Stilled's craft.
crae	kray	craft; the working of an element	The Answered shops as a sector.
hesk	hesk	far, outer edge	Frontier coinage, not in the old liturgy. The liturgy is older than this grafting. Heskoren, Vaelhesk.
strand	strand	shore, strand, landing-coast	Kept in Strandoren, Lestrand, and Netstrand.

One name carries the setting. The Awakening Tree's liturgical name is **Thaeloren** *(THAEL-or-en)*, *thael* for the Tree set beside *oren* for witnessing, so the name means the Tree that witnesses. To witness, in this tongue, is to speak truly, and citizenship-by-witness is that witnessing folded into the name of the Tree. Everyday, people say **the Thallow**.

Each daughter speech is the Old Tongue worn by distance from the Trees and from the faith, a later speech descended from this root, and the changes are regular enough that any old word can be pushed through them. Conservative speech, in Threnmaieth and the pious core, barely moved, so it still sounds like the rite: archaic, formal, and holy. Worn speech, in Vaethorn and on the devout frontier, is rough-warm folk-speech that still reaches for the old holy words. Eroded speech, on Lestrand and the secular coast, is smooth, clipped, and mercantile. The most-drifted sound belongs to the least-devout place.

Closer to the Tree the old sound stays, and farther out the *th* wears away.

Vaethorn *(VAETH-orn; spoken worn **Wetorn**)* joins *vaeth*, the waiting, to *orn*, land, and means the Waiting Land. Careful writing and prayer keep the sacred *th*, ordinary speech wears it down to *t*, and people say the Waiting Lands, or simply the Waiting.

Lestrand *(LES-trand)* joins *ledd*, to reckon, to *strand*, the shore, and then wears the compound smooth, so the name means the Reckoning Coast. It is the most worn of the original three. People say the Ledger Coast, and formal records keep *Lestrand*.

Threnmaieth *(THREN-mai-eth)* joins *thren*, sacred counting, to *maieth*, the Mother, and means the Mother's Reckoning. The pious core keeps the full sacred sound, and it names its census as reverent stewardship of Her gifts. People say the Tallied Crown, and the crown writes *Threnmaieth*.

The other twelve are built on the same lever, so the written name is the stance you can hear.

On pious Maiethorn the old sound stays. **Maiethvael** *(MAI-eth-vael)* keeps *maieth* and joins it to *vael*, so the name is the Mother's Gift, gift rather than count. **Orenbren** *(OREN-bren)* is *oren* and *bren*, the

witnessing-hearth, and it stays clear of *brenhael*, which is an inn. **Saelthael** *(SAEL-thael)* is *sael* and *thael*, the sown Tree, and it stays clear of *Saelorn*, which is a month, and of *Saelhael*, the greens-keepers. **The Hinge Shore** is the common name that replaced the retired *Eolstrand*, a compound that had crowded *Eoloren*, *Eolthael*, and *Eolvaeth*. Current speech and current writing use the common name. **Lirorn** *(LIR-orn)* is *lir* and *orn*, thaw-land, and it stays clear of *Liren* and of *Ornthael*.

On the eroded shore the sacred count will not be said whole. **Brenledd** *(BREN-ledd)* sets *bren* beside *ledd*, hearths of the ledger, and that name is the compact. **Leddvael** *(LEDD-vael)* is *ledd* and *vael*, the gift reckoned, and it stays clear of *Leddoren* and of *Leddhael*. **Trenledd** *(TREN-ledd)* is *thren* worn down beside *ledd*, and the reconstruction *Threnledd* goes unused, because they will not say the holy word. **Netstrand** *(NET-strand)* is *neth* worn down beside *strand*, the reconstruction *Nethstrand* goes unused, and people there will not say why the name means night.

On worn Heskoren the sacred *th* survives in careful writing and thins in the mouth. **Ornled** *(ORN-led)* is *orn* and *ledd* clipped. On this continent, dropping *th* is a neglect, so the reconstruction *Ornledd* goes unused. **Vaelhesk** *(VAEL-hesk)* sets *vael*, in the older sense of what the land yields, beside the frontier *hesk-*, and it stays clear of *Vaeloren* and of *Vaethorn*. The fight is in the first syllable, *vael* against *vaeth*. **Saelvaeth** *(SAEL-vaeth)* joins *sael* to *vaeth* and means sowing into the waiting, and it shares *sael* with Saelthael on purpose. Kumbaan is not a sixteenth name on this list.

Faiths are named from the same blocks, so a faith sounds like the land that keeps it. **Haelthael** *(HAEL-thael)* sets *hael*, whole and hale, beside *thael*, the Tree, and means the Tree kept whole, which is what the Watching calls the Tree from before anyone gave it a mother's name, and its people are the Watchers. **Leddoren** *(LEDD-or-en)* is *ledd* joined to *oren*, the witnessed account, because the Fair Hand takes the Tree as a signing-table, and its people are the Book-hands. **Vaeloren** *(VAEL-or-en)* is *vael* in the older sense plus *oren*, the land's witnessing, which the Old Ways keep, and its people are the door-keepers and the Kin-speakers. **Ndeyaan** *(ndey-AHN)* owes this liturgy nothing. It is the Yumboe night-keeping, not Maiethren, and it is the Open Table's own name, whose people are the table-keepers and the hill-hosts.

The houses that work the faith are named from the same box, and no new ones are being made. Tree-wardens write themselves **Orenhael** *(OREN-hael)*, witness beside whole, because they speak the fall truly and keep the Tree hale. Road-hands are **Thaelvaeth** *(THAEL-vaeth)* when the rite names them, the Tree gone to the waiting. Watchers are **Nethoren** *(NETH-or-en)*, the night-witnesses. They are not written *Haeloren*, which would sit too close to Orenhael. Book-hands are **Leddhael** *(LEDD-hael)*, the accounted-whole. *Orenledd* was not used, because it collides with *Orledd*, the Counterparty, the other party named in a Bound's bargain. Door-keepers are **Vaelbren** *(VAEL-bren)*. Here *vael* keeps the older sense, the land's yield, and beside *bren*, the hearth, the name means the yield-hearth. It is not *Vaelorn*, which belongs to the Taking. **Njaalo** *(NJAH-lo)* is a Yumboe coinage, not Maiethren, and it means the hall that is kept, the own-name of the table-keepers. The isle's name for the shore-sitters, also outside Maiethren, is **Njawaal** *(njah-WAHL)*. The Slide's cant is **Vaethledd** *(VAETH-ledd)*, the waiting

reckoned. A cant is the house's other name, neither the everyday word nor the compound a charter writes. Vaethledd is not *Orledd*, and it is not *Nethledd*, which was retired with the Back Table, a Slide name that stayed unused.

Greens-keepers are **Saelhael** *(SAEL-hael)* in the liturgy, the sown-whole, and that name is not *Saelorn*, which is a month. **Aeloren** is retired, because it collided with *Vaeloren*, *Leddoren*, and *Eoloren*, and it never carried information that hall-keepers or ael-hands did not carry better. Old rosters may preserve it as a crossed-out form, and no living house claims it. Stillers are **Stelhael** *(STEL-hael)*, the held-whole. **The Crae** *(kray)* is simply *crae*, craft, and it is the umbrella over the element-guilds, one name set over the houses rather than a separate liturgy for each. There are four doors under it, and those four do not each receive a liturgy. The Intake has no liturgical name, and its cant is *the catching-year*. Hall-keepers have no current liturgical form.

Era-names come from the same old words. **Brenvaeth** *(BREN-vaeth)* is the Walking Years, the hearth gone to the waiting, and the compound is a deliberate inversion of *Thaelvaeth*. People walked in, and later the wood walked out. **Eoloren** *(EOL-or-en)* is the First Cut, the witnessed hinge, and the same name serves the clerical year-count, the *Eoloren-count* or the Cut-years. It is not *Eolthael*, which is a month. **Ornthael** *(ORN-thael)* is the Years of Hands, Tree-land. That name is not *Maiethorn*, the Motherland, and it is not *Haelthael*, the Watching. Before the Walk stays mostly unnamed on the mainland roads. The Watching keep **the Before**. Kumbaan keeps moons rather than this count.

A Walking-era road-house has the cant **brenhael** *(BREN-hael)*, the hearth kept whole, the inn that kept you hale through the waiting, and the everyday word is *road-house*. The cant is not *Brenvaeth*, which is the era, and it is not *Brenorn*, which is a month. The three walks stay in the common tongue on purpose, the Near Mile, the Salt Walk, and the Long Mile, because they were logistics before they were liturgy.

The nameless knife and the nameless green are folk objects of the First Cut, and they have no liturgical form on purpose. Naming the green would pick a hearth, and a hearth would pick a hand, so the everyday name comes first and stays. The generation of argument is the run of summers from the first taking to the first local Leaf-Fall, the stretch when the First Seat could not undo the graft and had not yet written permission for grafting. It stays in the common tongue because it was a quarrel, not a rite. It is not *Eoloren*, and it is not *Brenvaeth*.

The extra mile, the First-Hand year, and the neighbour's week are the walk's three jobs in the Years of Hands. They stay in the common tongue because they are jobs, not a fourth age. They are not *Brenvaeth*, which is the requirement, and they are not *Ornthael*, which is the era. *The old mile* still means the Long Mile when the neighbour is a continent. The stone in the square, the upper room, and the Held bed are what that walk left sitting in a Hands town. The everyday name comes first. *Brenhael* remains the inn's cant, and it does not become the loft's name.

Ornsael *(ORN-sael)* sets *orn* beside *sael* and means the sown-ground. It is the Rain-Shadow walk-hold on Saelthael, and it is not *Saelthael* itself, not *Saelorn*, not *Saelhael*, and not *Ornthael*. **Brenthael** *(BREN-thael)* sets *bren* beside *thael* and means the hearth-Tree. It is the neighbour Hands-town of the Third Hearth, and it is not *brenhael*, not *Brenvaeth*, not *Brenorn*, and not *Orenbren*. **Brenod** *(BREN-od)*, **Vaelun** *(VAY-lun)*, and **Ornath** *(OR-nath)* are the worn folk hearth-names of the Three Hamlets Past the Ford. They have no liturgy on purpose, because the Seat's leave did not write them, and they stay clear of *Vaeloren*, *Brenvaeth*, and *Ornled*. The Mill-hold and the First Bowl are two more squares. The First Bowl's folk hearth-name is *Lonasir*, the common tongue comes first, and there is no liturgy. They stay clear of *Brenthael* and of *Vaelun*.

Eolvaeth *(EOL-vaeth)* is *eol* and *vaeth*, the hinge-waiting, and it is Vaethorn's pilgrim-edge seat. Everyday worn speech says *Elvaeth (EL-vaeth)*. The name is not *Vaethorn*, not *Thaelvaeth*, and not *Eoloren* or *Eolthael*. **Orentel** *(OREN-tel)* is eroded *oren* and *thael*, the witnessing-Tree, with the *th* worn off. It is Lestrand's salt-quay seat, and everyday speech also calls it the Salt Quay. It is not *Thaeloren*, not *Orenbren*, and not *Lestrand* or *Netstrand*. **Maiethlir** *(MAI-eth-lir)* is *maieth* and *lir*, the Mother's thaw, and it is Threnmaieth's counted river-seat. It stays clear of *Threnmaieth*, *Threnhael*, *Thaeloren*, *Maiethvael*, *Maiethorn*, *Lirorn*, *Liren*, and *Brenthael*.

No new roots are spent on ground. The everyday name comes first, and these stay in the common tongue: the Old Crossing, the West Water, the Rain-Wall, which Lirorn calls the Thaw-Wall, the Noon Pass, the Shelf-gate, the Core-thaw, the Well-wash, the Rise-water, and the Chart-run.

What Each Land Calls the Same Thing

Every land has the same institutions. They flow from the Trees and the Conditions, and both are universal. What each land calls them comes from how it stands on the faith, on whether it sits among healthy Trees or at a thin edge, and on how far the state reaches onto a person. A devout land calls the release-hall a gift-hall, a merchant coast calls that same building a release-house, and a surveillance-crown calls it a counted hall. It is the same building under three worldviews.

Use the **common tongue** column unless you need the local word. Use the local word when a Vaethorn pilgrim, a Lestrand factor, or a Threnmaieth clerk is speaking, or when you want the table to hear the difference. When a cell pauses in parentheses, that parenthesis is the stance in miniature.

Citizenship and law

Thing	Common tongue	Vaethorn (devout)	Lestrand (secular)	Threnmaieth (surveillance)
proof-by-people (vouching)	**standing-for**	*the speaking* (vouched at worship)	*warranting* (a commercial guarantee)	*the naming* (you are named to the crown)
city / nested witness	**hearth-stand**	*the street that watched*	*the quay-gang* (a commercial circle)	*the named stand* (copied to the Threnhael)
traveler's vouch	**road-word**	*the walking-speak*	*the last warrant*	*the named road* (you are already on a list)
party passage	**company-vouch**	*the shared speaking*	*the company warrant*	*the named company*
host's temporary stand	**guest-right**	*the hosted speaking*	*the inn-warrant* (a week)	*the counted guest*
night hold	**the watch**	*the night-blessing* (a rope if they must)	*the gate* (three questions)	*the counted watch*
public harm hearing	**open hearing**	*the speaking in square*	*the factor's hearing*	*the named hearing*
the safety-licence	**the ticket**	*the blessing-to-practice*	*the guild-ticket*	*the crown-warrant*
a census of persons	*(no common name; only two crowns keep one: Trenledd's **roll**, and Threnmaieth's Threnhael)*	*(none — the giving is the Mother's to know)*	*the roll* (a **tax** roll only, never of persons)	**the Threnhael** (THREN-hayl, "the whole-keeping")
the Inviolate Will	**"the will is one's own"**	*the Mother's own line* (held as scripture)	*the free-will clause* (sound commercial law)	*the crown's assurance* (cited to justify the roll)

Threnmaieth's census calls itself the **Threnhael**. That is *thren* set beside *hael*, so the name means the keeping-whole. It sounds like care, the keeping of every subject hale, and it is total surveillance. Its own clerks say they keep the realm hale. Its subjects are kept whole. Outsiders hear the Counting. On that roll the second name is the house, said where other lands would say a surname. Witness-lands, which still name you by who saw you, do not do this.

Tithe-provision

These are the civic buildings the tithe-provision furnishes. *Ael* in the ael-hall is pronounced AYL, and the word means the airing.

Thing	Common tongue	Vaethorn (devout)	Lestrand (secular)	Threnmaieth (surveillance)
venting-hall (Far-Voiced)	**the ael-hall** (AYL, "the airing")	*the gift-hall*	*the release-house* (also the playhouse)	*the counted hall*
ranging-commons (Two-Bodied)	**the ranging**	*the wild-leave*	*the beast-yard* (a hired yard)	*the ranging-roll*
garden-commons (the Taken-In)	**the greens**	*the Mother's green* (held in common)	*the leaf-lot* (rented by the season)	*the tended green* (crown-furnished)
endowed library (Long-Lived novelty)	**the long-house of books**	*the deathless gift*	*the endowment* / *the house*	*the crown archive*

The people

The three standing-terms keep their plain names **everywhere**: *the Given*, *the Struck*, *the Kept*. The Given are people a Condition was Given to. The Struck were turned later and alone. The Kept are untithed and whole. Each land's second word is how it feels about them.

Common tongue	Vaethorn (devout)	Lestrand (secular)	Threnmaieth (surveillance)
the Given (a Condition Given)	*the gifted* (blessed)	*the Given* (plain)	*the marked* (on the roll)
the Struck (turned later, alone)	*the late-come* (met at a later door)	*the turned* (neutral, a fact)	*the unwitnessed* (suspect until named)
the Kept (untithed, whole)	*the Waited* / *Mother-kept* (pitied — passed over)	*the free* (**approving** — unencumbered labor)	*the unmarked* / *the passed-over* (noted as such)

The Kept are pitied in devout Vaethorn, where people say they missed the gift. They are envied as free on mercantile Lestrand, where no Tithe and no guild means a person can go anywhere, and the word is said with approval, as unencumbered labor. They are filed as unmarked in Threnmaieth, a gap in the roll that the crown wants explained.

Clergy

Everyday words for these people already live beside the faiths. A liturgical name is the name a rite or a charter writes. An own-name is the name the house uses for itself. The three polity columns are the second word, the one that shows the stance.

Thing	Common tongue	Vaethorn (devout)	Lestrand (secular)	Threnmaieth (surveillance)
the Motherfaith's working clergy	**tree-wardens** (liturg. *Orenhael*)	*Hands-folk*	*tree-tenders*	*the Reckoned Hands*
the pilgrimage college	**the First Seat**	*the First Hand's college*	*the old seat* (a civic bureau)	*the Reckoned Seat* (wants them on the roll)
graft-carriers / sick-Tree circuit	**Road-hands** (liturg. *Thaelvaeth*)	*the waiting-hands*	*the graft-carts*	*the counted road*
authorization to cut a scion	**Cutting-leave**	*the wood's blessing*	*the carrying-licence*	*the scion-warrant*
the Watching's people	**Watchers** (liturg. *Nethoren*)	*the night-kin*	*vigil-folk* (rarely met)	*the second column*
the Fair Hand's people	**Book-hands** (liturg. *Leddhael*)	*Bargainers' clerks*	*the Settling-hands*	*the Uncounted Book*
the Old Ways' people	**door-keepers** / **Kin-speakers** (liturg. *Vaelbren*)	*the door-folk*	*grove-talkers*	*the Unreached*
the Open Table's people	**table-keepers** / **hill-hosts** (own *Njaalo*)	*(a sailor's tale)*	*the Moon-Feast people*	*(off the map)*
the Shore-Sitters (isle flavor)	**shore-sitters** (own *Njawaal*)	*(a sailor's tale)*	*(the wreck-waiters)*	*(off the map)*
the Slide (shadow house)	**the Slide** / **week-keepers** (cant *Vaethledd*)	*the last pot* / *gift-credit*	*week-rent*	*(the late week — unfiled)*

Tithe-infrastructure and tickets

An umbrella name is a single word set over several houses. A cant, where the table marks one, is the other recorded name, neither the everyday word nor the liturgical compound.

Thing	Common tongue	Vaethorn (devout)	Lestrand (secular)	Threnmaieth (surveillance)
the official furnishing sector	**the furnishing** / **the greens and the halls**	*the gift-works*	*the provision*	*the counted channel*
greens-keepers	**greens-keepers** / **lot-keepers** (liturg. *Saelhael*)	*Mother's-green hands*	*lot-keepers*	*the Tended*
hall-keepers	**hall-keepers** / **ael-hands**	*gift-hall folk*	*release-hands*	*counted-hall clerks*
the Stillers	**stillers** (liturg. *Stelhael*)	*blessing-surgeons*	*ticket-surgeons*	*crown-stillers*
the element-guilds	**the element-guilds** (umbrella *the Crae*)	*gift-shops*	*the craft-houses*	*the Reckoned Craes*
the Intake	**the Intake** / **the shed** (cant *catching-year*)	*the late-catching*	*the emergency ticket*	*the unwitnessed warrant*

Faiths

The common-tongue name is what a traveller says. The own-name is what the house says. The land's second word is how the state files them, when it files them at all.

Faith	Common tongue	Own name	Vaethorn	Lestrand	Threnmaieth
the Leaf-Mother	the Motherfaith	*Maieth*	*the Mother* (hot)	*the old rite* (worn light)	*the Reckoned Faith*
the Watching	the Watching	*Haelthael*	*the First Watching* (cousin-dissent)	*(rarely met)*	**the Grown-Over** (a column on the roll)
the Fair Hand	the Fair Hand	*Leddoren*	*the Bargainers* (suspect)	*the Settling* (ordinary)	*the Uncounted Book* (private books offend the crown)
the Old Ways	the Old Ways	*Vaeloren*	*the Before-Faith* (live fight)	*(a frontier curiosity)*	*the Unreached*
the Open Table	the Open Table	*Ndeyaan*	*(a sailor's tale)*	*the Moon-Feast* (quay-story)	*(not on the roll — off the map)*

Vaethorn says *the Mother*, and says it hot. Lestrand says *the old rite*, and wears the saying light.

Eras and dating

There is no universal year-zero. Travellers call the pilgrimage-required past the Walking Years, the first successful town-graft the First Cut, the still-moving spread of grafts the Grafting, and the town-Tree present the Years of Hands. A year's number stays local.

Thing	Common tongue	Vaethorn (devout)	Lestrand (secular)	Threnmaieth (surveillance)
the pilgrimage-required past	**the Walking Years** (liturg. *Brenvaeth*)	*the old mile* / *the waiting-road*	*the road-years* (a logistics problem)	*the uncounted summers* (they want them on a roll)
the first successful town-graft	**the First Cut** (liturg. *Eoloren*)	*the wood's blessing*	*the first carrying*	*the first warrant*
the still-moving spread of grafts	**the Grafting**	*her hands travelling*	*the carrying* (supply)	*the counted road* (they would number it)
the town-Tree present	**the Years of Hands** (liturg. *Ornthael*)	*Since the Hands*	*since the local canopy*	*the Reckoned Hands-years*
a year's number	*(none universal)*	*the year our graft took*	*a house-year* / *a note-year*	*a Cut-year* (and a crown-count, later)

Before the Walk goes unnamed on the mainland roads. The Watching keep **the Before**. Kumbaan keeps moons.

The road

These are the lived names of the Walking Years. People say the common-tongue name. The inland walk through Maiethorn is the Near Mile, the sea-then-land walk through Strandoren is the Salt Walk, and the walk through Heskoren and the far interior is the Long Mile.

Thing	Common tongue	Vaethorn (devout)	Lestrand (secular)	Threnmaieth (surveillance)
Maiethorn inland walk	**the Near Mile**	*the waiting-road* (they use this for all three)	*the inland days*	*the counted near-miles*
Strandoren sea-then-land walk	**the Salt Walk**	*the salt-waiting*	*the berth-road*	*the uncounted crossing*
Heskoren (and far-interior) walk	**the Long Mile**	*the old mile*	*the far road-years*	*the uncounted long-miles*
a deathless inn on the walk	**road-house** (cant *brenhael*)	*waiting-hearth*	*the bed-house* (still means the bank)	*(wants them on the roll)*
a day's stone	**mile-shrine**	*ribbon-stone*	*the mile-mark*	*the unfiled stone*
the tenth-year week at the origin	**the one-week door** *(descriptive)*	*the only hug*	*the appointment*	*the uncounted week*

The three walks keep their common-tongue names. People say the Near Mile, the Salt Walk, and the Long Mile when they plan the road.

The Cut and the spread

These are the lived names of the First Cut. People say the common-tongue name. The cutter is unnamed. The nameless knife and the nameless green have no liturgical form. A liturgical name for the green would name a hearth, and a hearth would name a hand.

Thing	Common tongue	Vaethorn (devout)	Lestrand (secular)	Threnmaieth (surveillance)
folk object of the first taking	**the nameless knife**	*the mother's knife*	*the first theft*	*the first unfiled cut*
the first town-graft (unnamed)	**the nameless green**	*the wood's blessing* (they also use this for the Cut)	*the first carrying's ground*	*the first warrant-green*
Seat quarrel before the paper	**the generation of argument**	*the unblessed years*	*the first unlicensed carrying*	*the uncounted cuts*
Old Ways courtesy at a planting	**the first meal**	*(suspect — a guest-word)*	*(a frontier courtesy)*	*(unfiled)*

Residues

These are the lived names of the Years of Hands, and the everyday name comes first. An origin-walk you take when you already have a Tree is the extra mile. A walk you take because the Tree is missing, young, or sick is the neighbour's week, and people still say *the old mile* when that neighbour is a continent. The prestige origin-winter is the First-Hand year. The Years of Hands are the present.

Thing	Common tongue	Vaethorn (devout)	Lestrand (secular)	Threnmaieth (surveillance)
origin-walk you already have a Tree for	**the extra mile**	*the First Hand's hug*	*the First-Hand year*	*the counted pilgrimage*
walk because the Tree is missing, young, or sick	**the neighbour's week** (still *the old mile* when the neighbour is a continent)	*the waiting-road* (they use this for all walks)	*the borrowed week*	*the uncounted neighbour*
prestige origin-winter	**the First-Hand year**	*(suspect — a bought hug)*	*the First-Hand year* (plain)	*the counted winter*
mile-shrine now in a Hands square	**the stone in the square**	*the ribbon still*	*the old mile-mark*	*the unfiled stone*
unused pilgrim dorm	**the upper room**	*the waiting-beds*	*merchant-loft* (when let)	*the uncounted loft*
bed never let	**the Held bed**	*the kept-place*	*the unlet* (house custom)	*(wants it on the roll)*

Book III

The Tree and the Faiths

The Turning Tree

A Turning Tree is a broad, slow, long-lived hardwood, with a canopy like a great oak or a great beech, though the tree is its own kind. It stands at the ceremonial heart of a town, usually in a square, on a green, or in a walled yard the town keeps for it. Out of season it looks like an unusually grand old tree, and the town treats it as one: children climb the low boughs, courts and markets meet in the shade, and lovers carve nothing into the bark, because cutting a mark there is taboo. In the tenth-year solstice week, the midsummer people call Turning-Week, the tree turns. The canopy shifts through colours no ordinary tree wears, and a leaf falls for a child, or the leaves close around them.

People call it a **Turning Tree** for what it does at that solstice. It turns, and it turns a child into what that child will become. When a coloured leaf settles on the child, the colour names a **Condition**, the change that child will grow up carrying, a becoming rather than the people they were born. When the leaves close round the child and no naming colour comes, the child is one of **the Kept**, wanted as they are. The devout call each Tree **a Hand of the Mother**, because they hold that a mother is reaching down through the wood to choose, and the reverent word for that kind of tree, in the liturgy, is **motherwood**. In the old liturgical root tongue the Awakening Tree's own name is **Thaeloren** *(THAEL-or-en)*. *Thael* means Tree and *oren* means to witness, so the name says the Tree that witnesses. People wear that long name down, in everyday speech, to *the Thallow*.

The Awakening Tree

There is one origin Tree, the **Awakening Tree**, the great first Tree and the place the world's pilgrimage is aimed at. It is old past any dating the faith can rely on, and it is vast, and it is the one Tree that nobody grafted out of another tree, which is why every other Turning Tree descends from it. The liturgy calls it **the First Hand**, and people really do make the journey: devout families travel so that a child can be Turned under the origin, and some of those families settle in the country around it. The faith's central clergy sit in the Tree's shadow as the **First Seat**, a college of tree-wardens, the people whose work is the Trees, with no throne in that shadow. The Tree stands on Maiethorn, in the Sacred Core, the old country of hills, river valleys, and Tree-crowned towns around that grove.

Grafts

Every town Turning Tree is a living graft of that one tree. When a town takes root, and especially when the town is so far off that a family could never reach the Awakening Tree, someone carries out a **scion**

and plants it in the new town's square. A scion is not a seedling that grew from a seed the Tree dropped. It is cut tissue of the one Tree, kept alive on the road, and planted into the new ground so the same wood grows on. That planting is a **graft**.

A town gets two things from the arrangement. Ordinary families walk to their own Tree for the **Leaf-Fall**, the ceremony at which a colour falls or the leaves hug, so the rite stays local and the distance of the road does not exile anyone from it. This is the ordinary way in the Years of Hands, the years when a town's own Tree is what people expect. It was not always so. People devout enough to want the origin still travel to the Awakening Tree, either to have a child Turned there or simply to stand under it. On Heskoren, the continent where that wave of living wood is still unfinished, and in any place where a graft has failed, the walk is a necessity and not only a devotion.

The devout call each grafted tree a Hand of the Mother. Anyone in the square can see the cut and the planting, and whether a mind is choosing through that wood remains the faith's argument, which the horticulture does not close.

The graft is a rite, and it is also the work of keeping living wood. The tree-wardens cut a scion from the Awakening Tree or, in ordinary practice, from a healthy town Tree that is cutting on the origin's behalf. The cutting travels in living earth, and it is planted with ceremony. The first time a carrying succeeded, someone took living wood from Thaeloren, or from a branch that came away in a hand, carried it as far as the wood can go in a day and still meet new ground green, set it into that ground, and it took. Everyday speech calls that taking the **First Cut**. What the college captured afterward was not the living wood, which it could not own, but the right to say who may cut next, and that right is a paper. The cutting had been a heresy before it was a permit. The clergy count their years from the taking itself, so the taking is Cut-year 0 and the present year is Cut-year 387.

A young Tree cannot Turn anyone yet. A scion that has just been planted needs years, a generation by the reckoning people actually use, before it is mature enough to hold a Leaf-Fall. While it grows, the new town leans on a neighbour's Tree, and the children travel to the nearest town that can Turn them. That borrowing is where a lot of the small texture of the world comes from: rivalries between towns, customs that belong to the road, and the sentence people still say, "we Turned at Harrow's Tree before we had our own."

When Trees sicken and die

The wood is mortal, so a blighted or dying Tree is a real crisis for the town, because the town may lose the power to Turn its own children and have to fall back on a pilgrimage or on a neighbour. A Tree that has died is replaced only by a fresh graft, and then by the long wait while the new wood matures. A mature Tree is hard to move once it is in the ground. The practice is to graft a new scion, rather than to dig the old tree up and carry it.

A town with no Tree is what the frontier usually looks like. The place is too new, or too remote, or it has lost the Tree it had. Towns in that condition send their ten-year-olds onto the road to be Turned, and the journey is one of the ways the map marks its own edge.

The Leaf-Fall

The Leaf-Fall is the rite the rest of the world is built around. It is held in Turning-Week, the tenth-year solstice week, which is the High Solstice of midsummer, when the Trees hold their colour and the leaves fall.

Every child who has turned ten since the last solstice is brought by their family. The witness-circle, the people gathered to see that child, comes together, and a tree-warden of the town officiates. The First Seat is present only in a week when people have come on pilgrimage. The hour is a sacred rite and, at the same time, the largest festival the settlement holds all year, something like a christening and a graduation and a fair held in the same afternoon. In a village the witness-circle simply is the town. In a city the circle is a hearth, a group of people who already know the child, and the square is still full.

The children come to the Tree one at a time, or in the small cohort who share that year, and they stand where the canopy can reach them, and they wait. The Tree turns, and it lets fall whatever it is going to let fall. The rest of the town watches from the edge of the boughs.

A healthy Tree, with a child under it and the town watching, does one of two things, and the wardens do not write a third outcome into the book.

A colour falls, and a Condition is **Given**. One leaf, or more than one, in a colour that means something, drifts down and settles on the child. The colour is the name of the Condition. This is the outcome people expect, the one they call proper, and the one they celebrate. The child grows up already knowing what they will become, and the town trains them and guilds them toward that life.

Or the leaves hug the child, and there is no colour, and the child is Kept. Instead of a coloured fall, the ordinary leaves gather and wrap the child, a green embrace with no colour that names anything. The faith holds the hug to be a kindness the Tree chose, and the schism argues over that reading, which the faith has not closed.

The Leaf-Fall is warm, and it has weight, and it belongs to the whole town: a breath that the circle holds, every eye on one child, a parent who was Given this same colour years ago weeping when it falls again, or a parent who had quietly hoped the leaves would hug. The **Tithe**, the upkeep a Condition later asks of the person who carries it, belongs to the years after this afternoon. The shadow that belongs to the rite itself is a human one, a wrong word spoken over a fall, or a week that was missed.

Turning-Week in a city

A Gift can still be given in that one week, and not in some other week, and the Tree is still the centre. A city of tens of thousands does not grow a second rite to get through the number of children. It divides the witnesses into hearths, the groups of people who already know the child they have brought.

The stands run by hearth across the week. In the morning, the afternoon, and the eve, a quay-gang or a courtyard or a guild-stair or a lot takes its turn, eighty to two hundred people who already know the child, so that hundreds of ten-year-olds are never stood up together as one crowd nobody could read.

The warden **Speaks**. To Speak is to say aloud whether the Tree gave a colour or a hug, and to name the colour when there is one. The warden does not write those gifts onto a roll. The week-slate, the board kept for the week, only records which hearth stands at which bell. It is a festival schedule, the same kind of board that says who has the square for the fair.

The legal fact is that a hearth witnesses a child, and a crowd does not. When a desk far from the city asks who saw the standing, one pillar of the hearth carries the memory. The pillar stood in that hearth, and already carries one of three Conditions: a Long-Lived, an ageless keeper of memory; a Bound, who swore a contract in extremity and is still keeping its terms; or a Far-Voiced, whose voice carries a feeling exactly as far as they mean it to, and no farther.

Threnmaieth, the crown on Maiethorn that keeps a written roll of its people and calls the writing a way of keeping them whole, is the one place that writes the stand down. A clerk who copies the colours off a week-slate has begun a register of Conditions, and a register is a thing the hearths do not keep.

A village still watches the rite as one circle.

Reading the colours

The colour of the leaf that falls is how the town knows which Condition has been Given, and the way that reading is known is also what gives the faith a civic office. Ordinary people know the common colours. Everyone in an ordinary town can already name the deep-red leaf of the Long-Lived, and the storm-grey fall of the Two-Bodied, who carry a second animal self and still command it. The tree-wardens hold the reading that counts. They confirm it out loud at the ceremony, and they handle a fall that is rare, or subtle, or mixed: a colour almost nobody present has seen, or a fall that could honestly be read two ways. In a small town the warden is the one who Speaks. In a pilgrimage-town, or at the First Seat, a **Speaker** is the elder who holds the rare-colour texts and the last word on a mixed fall.

The Conditions that are only ever Given have colours that are clear and widely known, because those colours are only ever seen at a Tree. Three Conditions can also be **Struck**, which means a person can come to them later, away from the Tree, and those three can fall as colours too. They are the Far-Voiced; the Stilled, who can hold a moment still, a bleeding wound or a blade already swinging or a

patient under the knife; and the Taken-In, a person the wild took partway into itself and gave back changed. A Far-Voiced who was Given and a Far-Voiced who was Struck share a nature and do not share a story. The Answered are Given only: a person whom one element answered, fire or water or earth and stone or air, and that element has gone on answering ever since, under a leaf of lamp-amber or brass.

Leaf-colour	Condition	Who can read it
deep red / wine	Long-Lived	folk-known, and already a proverb
storm-grey	Two-Bodied	folk-known, and already a proverb
lamp-amber / brass	the Answered	folk-known
sea-blue	Far-Voiced	folk-known. A child Given the blue leaf is trained toward it, and a Far-Voiced who was Struck has no leaf at all
pale stone / marble-white	the Stilled	folk-known, and feared, so the warden says the name carefully
copper-green / verdigris	the Taken-In	folk-known, once you know not to confuse it with the hug. This green is the wrong green for a hug: metallic, and not the Tree's own green
white-fire / opal	Phoenix	clergy-known, from the texts. Almost no town now alive has seen it fall. A warden who names it at a ceremony has just made history, and has also made a problem

The Tree never Strikes, so the Returned and the Bound have no colour, and the Unbound has none either. A Returned is a person who died with something unfinished, and whose purpose got them walking again. The Bound come by the contract, not by a leaf. The Unbound is what a term-limited contract leaves behind when the term ends and the other party to that contract collects the piece the person named at the signing, so they walk away free of the terms and short of that piece, and that becoming chains off Bound instead of falling as a leaf of its own. The hug that marks the Kept is ordinary summer-green, and it carries no naming colour. That is why the leaf of the Taken-In must not be that same ordinary green.

A fall that is rare, or mixed, or already being argued, two colours at once, or a colour nobody in the square has seen, or a reading of Phoenix that someone wants to be wrong, is why the tree-wardens are a civic office and not only a devout one. White-fire is the leaf of a Phoenix, a person who dies down to ash and comes back a little further from the person they were, and there is only ever one of them alive

in the world at a time, which is why a living town almost never sees that leaf, and why naming it is history and a problem together.

The Tree only **Gives**, or it **Keeps**. People who are Struck received a Condition through a later threshold, a drowning, an oath, or a death they survived, and that change happens away from the Tree, with no leaf and with no ceremony. Whether the faith still counts the Struck as the Mother’s own doing is the schism that is still live.

Questions a warden gets asked

These are the questions families actually bring to a warden, and the answers are the custom of the town. The door is still **one week**, the High Solstice week of the year a child turns ten. In the Walking Years the only Tree was the origin, so a tenth year was a journey or it was no Leaf-Fall at all, and the towns of the Years of Hands did not grow a second chance beside that narrow door. A healthy Tree, with a child stood under it, still gives a colour or a hug.

Question	What the town does	What that does to a life
We missed the week. The child had a fever, or the pass was shut, or the boat did not come, so the child was ten and was not under the boughs.	They are **unTurned**. The child never stood, and the door has shut, so next summer they may visit the square and they do not stand for a Gift. The doors by which a person can still be Struck open later, somewhere else. The expensive mercy is the old one: keep a nine-year-old through the winter near a Tree that is sound, so this particular week cannot be missed.	The child has no colour and no hug. The neighbours remember the miss, and folk will call the child Kept, though the law will not, because Kept is a hug the town was there to see.
We will not stand. The family refuses the Tree. The Old Ways, the land-faith that was already walking rivers and groves before the grafts, treat a refusal as another door. The Open Table, the supper-faith of the storm-walled isle, will not walk a child of the table to a Tree. Others refuse from fear, or from a quarrel.	The Tree does not chase them. The legal result is the same result as a miss: the child is **unTurned**, and the door is shut. A warden may ask one time. The warden does not put a rope on a child in order to produce a Gift.	The Old Ways already count that refusal as a different door, and not as a failure of the wood. The Open Table's quarrel over the walk can use up the week.
Who brings an orphan? There is no living parent, or there is no parent who will come.	The town acts as the family. Kin are asked first, then the household that feeds the child, then the **warden-hearth**, the warden's house on the square. An orphan who stands is witnessed the way anyone else is witnessed. An orphan that nobody brings is a miss.	Some of these children are older than the grafts: a Given child whose only crowd was a continent away, back when the origin was the only Tree, or a child of a road-house with nobody to walk them home. What they need is someone to vouch for them. They do not need a second leaf.
An adult who never Turned. A road-child, a child whose family refused, a child of a storm-year, a	They remain **unTurned**. They do not stand for a Gift at thirty. The town can vouch for them as the person the town raised, and they	The life is a story a person can carry, and it is not a late appointment the Tree will keep. What remains is a later door, or

Question	What the town does	What that does to a life
child raised on the isle, a child who was held over and missed the week even so.	can still be Struck later. Some hearths file such a person as Kept in order to be kind, and that kindness is sloppy law.	an ordinary life with no Tithe and a thinner witness.
Can they stand again? The family wanted a different colour, or they regret the hug, or a parent is sure the Tree missed.	**No.** A standing that was completed, whether it ended in a colour or in a hug, under a Tree the warden called sound, happens once. The blessing already says that the Hand does not reach twice by chance. A warden who offers a second Leaf-Fall is not being generous. That warden is inventing a rite the wood has never answered.	A town may correct a **Speaking**, the word the warden said aloud, and a town may not run the fall a second time. The year people cite is the Wrong Green.
Our Tree is sick this week. The canopy is blighted, or it is dying, or the scion is still too young.	Do not stand the children under wood the warden already knows is unsound. Borrow a neighbour's canopy, and borrow it in this same week. A warden who lets a cohort stand under a Tree they know cannot Turn has spent the week, and those children are unTurned.	The next year does not repair a week that has already been spent.
The child is already Struck. They drowned at nine, or they died and came back in the spring with a purpose still unfinished, or a contract no ten-year-old should have been able to reach did reach them.	Bring the child to be **acknowledged**, and do not bring them for a Gift. The Tree does not Strike, and it does not lay a second Condition on top of a first one. Some canopies hug such a child anyway, and the town reads the hug as a welcome. A colour falling on a child who is already Struck is a problem for the Seat, and it is not a second life.	The child is Struck. The town vouches for them again, and the child is guilded if the door they came through is a hazardous one. The tenth year is how the square takes them in. It is not a chance to do the year over.
Twins, or two colours, or a fall that nobody will name.	Two children mean two standings and two outcomes. A fall that is mixed, or that people are already	Two practices in one square is a common arrangement. A Watcher, of the older Tree-faith

Question	What the town does	What that does to a life
	arguing, is the reason the Speaking exists. Colours the square already knows, the folk can read for themselves, and the warden's word is what makes that reading a civic fact. The texts that cover the rare falls are kept at the First Seat.	that keeps the wood and will not say the Mother's name, may describe the same fall alongside the warden, and not over the warden. Two Speakers who both claim the last word in one square is a fight.
The warden named it wrong.	The Gift does not move when the word was wrong. The town is what moves. Someone Speaks a second word, and the child is not stood again. The town trains the child toward the life the leaf actually gave, un-trains the life it named by mistake, and apologises to the neighbour whose week it used.	The year the square still cites is the **Wrong Green**: Harrow's, in Cut-year 248, a hug Spoken aloud as copper-green, and two summers the child spent in a garden that had no way to teach them, because there had been no Tithe to pay and no Gift to tend. The square goes on citing that year. What it has is a civic name that wasted years of a life. The Tree is not haunted.
White-fire fell, or someone wants to say that it did.	A warden of a town does not guess at Phoenix. They send a runner to the First Seat. To name white-fire is to make history, and it is also to make a problem. A Speaking of Phoenix that turns out to be false is the loud cousin of the Wrong Green.	Almost no town now living has seen white-fire fall. If the Seat agrees that this child received it, the child cannot hide what they are. The weight of that belongs to the Phoenix, and not to a ruling invented in the square.
A child of the Open Table, or a Yumboe, under our boughs. A Yumboe is one of the good people born on Kumbaan, the storm-walled isle, and not a child the Tree made.	If the child stands during the week of their tenth year, the Tree does what the Tree does for anyone who stands. If the host will not bring the child, the week can end without them. There is no mission sent to Kumbaan, and there is no warden of the moon. When the fight over the child happens, it is already happening in the port.	The Open Table holds that the child was never lacking anything. A warden from the mainland holds that a tenth year is a tenth year. Neither of those people is the villain of the week, and the door does not wait while they finish the argument.

Question	What the town does	What that does to a life
The city cannot know every child. The port holds tens of thousands of people, and hundreds of ten-year-olds come due in the one week.	The children stand **by hearth**, in the slots the week has named, and the square is full. What gets remembered is the street that brought the child, together with one pillar who can carry that memory later, and the colours are not written down.	“I am of the third quay” is how a person of the city says where they belong.

UnTurned is not the same thing as Kept. Kept means the leaves hugged the child and the town watched it happen. UnTurned means the child never stood. From the street the two lives can look alike, because neither one carries a Tithe and neither one carries a guild, and only the Kept life was witnessed at the Tree. Citizenship still depends on who saw you. A neighbour who is unTurned is vouched for as the child the town raised, and not as a colour, and not as a hug.

A failure in the rite means a standing was not completed, and the Tree has not produced a third outcome to cover the gap. While the Tree is healthy, the child is under the boughs, and the town is watching, a colour falls or the leaves close in a hug. A missed week, a refusal, or a week spent under wood that could not Turn leaves no Given. The later doors, the ways a person can still be Struck, are the whole of the mercy that remains. If a fire takes the square, or a bough comes down, or the child is pulled away before the fall, and the week still has days left and the Tree is sound, the standing is finished later in that same week. Once the week has gone, the town treats the child as a miss. When the Speaking fails, the precedent is the Wrong Green: the town corrects the word that was said, and it does not bargain with the wood for a different life.

A parent who asks what happens if the Tree simply does nothing is asking a question the hearths do not keep a form for. A skeptic will say that is because it is just a tree, and trees that Turn, Turn. A believer will say the Hand does not come to the square to shrug. The working clergy side with the book they have: two outcomes, or the child was not there.

The Leaf-Mother

Some people hold that the **Leaf-Mother** blessed the world with the Conditions, the gifts of a becoming beyond the life a person was born into, and that the Turning Trees are her hands reaching down to choose. On that account each **Leaf-Fall**, the town's gathering when a child of ten stands at the solstice and a leaf falls or the leaves hug, is an act of a mother's love. Many people hold this, and it remains a belief, because nobody in the world has proved it. The skeptics who decline it are sincere and full members of society, the faith having been built to keep a place for them. Everyday people call the faith **the Motherfaith**. The faith calls itself **Maieth**, and a devout square that says the name means a mother, quiet, who gives, and who does not come because someone called.

A gift-religion

The faith begins from gifts the world received, the Conditions, and from the gifts that still come at each solstice. Nobody here is being rescued from a fallen state. The long question is how a person lives worthy of a gift.

What makes you of the Motherfaith is what you **do**. You bring your children to the Tree, you tend your **Tithe** honestly, the upkeep a Condition asks of the person who carries it, and you keep the festival. That practice counts for far more than what you privately believe about who does the choosing. A devout believer and a quiet skeptic can stand at the same Leaf-Fall and both belong, because the practice is what binds and the belief is what the faith argues about.

The faithful speak of a mother who is benevolent, attentive, generous, and quiet: she gives, and they say she watches, and she does not thunder or command or ask to be feared. People come to her by trying not to waste what she hands them.

The Motherfaith is the dominant faith of the Turning lands, and the other faiths are lived beside it. To the people who hold her, she is their Mother.

The houses do not share one face for her. What they share is the wood. A pressed leaf kept in a chest is a common keepsake, and it is only a leaf, and it does not speak, and some hearths keep no image of her at all. The faith does not picture her standing at a drowning, or at an oath, or out in the deep wild, because it has not agreed that she is in those places, and that argument stays open. Some Long-Lived people, the ageless keepers of memory, keep a cup they call the **Unspent**. Among themselves they say the Cup We Made, because they will tell you they invented whatever is on the other side by pouring in memories they could no longer carry, and on a quay people say the Poured God, with the smile they

keep for a rich uncle’s hobby. No town Tree is involved in it, no leaf falls for the cup, and a warden does not set that cup on the sill.

Doctrine (as the faithful hold it)

What follows is what the faithful hold. Nobody in the world has proved it.

In the beginning, they say, a person was only what they were born. That born half is a **Kind**, the people they were by birth, and nothing more. The Leaf-Mother’s gift was **becoming**: the capacity to be given something beyond birth, a Condition the world would need. They call that first gift the Giving. They say she first reached down at the Awakening Tree, and that every town Tree is a grafted **Hand of the Mother**, a living cut of that first Tree, planted so that no child is too far from her reach.

Doctrine holds that she chooses, and that she chooses well. The colour a child receives is chosen, looked-at, intended, and fitted to the child and to the town’s need. Believers point to gifts that fit too well to be accident. Skeptics call that hindsight.

The Tithe is the weight of a gift, and the faith does not read the cost as a punishment. Every Condition asks upkeep. The faith reads that cost as honest weight: a real gift has a real charge to carry, and tending it well is the ordinary devotion of a lifetime. “Tend what you’re given” is the closest thing the faith has to a first commandment.

To be Kept, hugged by the leaves and given no colour, is in the doctrine a gift of being left whole. The faithful do not call the hug an oversight. This is where the argument bites hardest, and the schism below is that bite.

She has no throne a person can visit, and no voice that answers because someone demanded an answer. The faithful say a person meets her at the Tree, in the turning of a life, and in the fittingness of things, and never by summoning her. They hold that the quiet is intended, because a mother lets her children live. The same quiet is what leaves room for honest doubt.

Practice

The Leaf-Fall is the central rite, a child’s tenth-year solstice Turning, and people keep it as sacrament, coming-of-age, and the town’s great festival in the same afternoon. The questions a warden actually gets, a missed week, a refusal, an orphan, a child who is already Struck, and whether anyone stands twice, belong with the Tree. The rite’s cited shadow is the **Wrong Green**. In Cut-year 248, at Harrow’s Green, a warden named a hug as copper-green, and the child spent two summers in a garden that had no gift to teach, until the correction came as a second word and the child was not stood under the Tree again.

The Tending is the ongoing, private devotion of paying a Tithe well. To tend a Condition honestly is, in this faith, to honour the gift. A Two-Bodied person, who carries a second animal self and still commands it, works in that other body. A Long-Lived person keeps the vigils and the learning their years require. The faith calls that life worship, lived as the upkeep itself.

The Turning-week festival is the solstice week around the Leaf-Falls. Towns hold markets and feasts, families reunite, and the year names its new Given and its new Kept. A colour fell on the new Given. The leaves hugged the new Kept. It is the emotional high point of the calendar, the week the year calls the High Solstice, and also Turning-Week.

The Struck receive a Condition away from the Tree, at a drowning they survived, an oath they swore, or a death they crossed, so the faith grew quiet rites to receive them afterward. A Struck person is brought to the Tree to be **acknowledged**, and folded into the community of the Given, rather than left as an anomaly. The Tree does not Strike, so this is not a Turning. How warmly a town does it is itself part of the argument.

Tree-tending is the civic and sacred care of the town's Turning Tree: the watering, the watch against blight, and the planting of a new scion, a living cut carried in earth. The **tree-wardens** do that work. They are one order with offices inside it, not a set of rival chapters. They officiate the Leaf-Fall, and they hold the authoritative reading of the colours. Common colours are already folk-known. The wardens confirm them, and they rule on the rare, the subtle, and the mixed falls, which is why a town needs them as a civic office and not only as people who pray.

The **First Seat** is a college in the Motherwood about the Awakening Tree, the old wood around that grove, and it is not a throne. Pilgrims go there. The Seat authorizes graft-scions, whether the cut comes from the origin or from a healthy town Tree acting on the origin's behalf. It confirms **Road-hands**, the people who carry a living cutting, and **Speakers**, the elders who hold the last word on a rare colour. It does not appoint every town-warden. A hearth is taken by apprenticeship, and the town that watched the new warden through a year is what confirms them.

The keeping of the order is ordinary and local. Towns house the warden-hearth, the warden's house on the square, and the stipend is bread, wood, and a place, not a tax on Conditions. During Turning-Week the warden eats from the festival, the way the town feeds any office it needs that week. **Cutting-leave**, the paper that says who may take wood and for where, carries a fee the Seat describes as carrying-earth, the cost of the living soil the cutting travels in and of a Road-hand's year. Pilgrimage keeps the Seat: offerings, lodging, and the devout who settle in the Motherwood. The wardens point a new Given toward the work the colour named. The halls that help a person meet a Tithe are other people's work.

The live schism

The faith holds more than one reading. The central argument is sincere on every side, and no one has settled it, which is why the faith endures. It turns on three questions the doctrine cannot prove.

The first question is the Kept: if the Mother blesses everyone, why does the Tree hug so many children and give them no colour at all? The **Tender reading** is the majority, and it is the teaching the faith usually gives. The Kept are given wholeness, a real gift, chosen for them, and to be Kept is to be trusted to need nothing added. The **Wanting reading** is the minority. The Kept were passed over, loved but not chosen, and the doctrine of wholeness is a kindness the faithful tell them. This reading quietly stings, and it shapes how some Kept feel about the festival.

The second question is the Struck, who received a Condition the Tree never handed out. Did the Mother reach through the threshold too, or did something else give the gift? The **Wide-Hand reading** says she meets people at the drowning, the oath, and the death, and that the Tree is only her ordinary hand, so the Struck are fully hers. The **Narrow-Hand reading** says she gives only at the Tree, and that the Struck received their Condition by some other means, which is why this reading finds the Struck a little suspect. That suspicion is the seed of real social friction toward the Struck.

The third question is whether a mind chooses at all, and it is the line between believer and skeptic. Believers say the fittingness of the gifts, the care of the Kept, and the way the Struck feel received add up to a Someone. Skeptics say it is just what the Trees do, biology, or a phenomenon so old that it wears a face people gave it. The grafting is horticulture a person can watch, a cut of wood set into new ground, and a choosing mind is an inference they decline to make.

Because a person belongs by the rite they keep, a skeptic who tends their Tithe and brings their children to the Tree is a good member of the Motherfaith. Belief in the Mother is honoured, and it is not policed, so the skeptic can speak the doubt and remain that member. Every branch above is held in good faith, and no house is a villain. Being a skeptic costs nothing day to day, because the practice is what binds. The questions stay open because no one in the square can close them.

Two sayings

The Tender’s blessing is spoken over each child at the Leaf-Fall.

> *“What falls to you, wear well. What is kept from you, keep. The Hand that reaches is the Mother’s own — and the Mother does not reach twice by chance.”*

The blessing is comfort, and it carries the ethic of tending the gift. Believers hear intent in it, skeptics hear a proverb about not asking the wood twice, and both can say the words.

A Kept child’s saying is folk, half a consolation and half a barb.

> *“The Tree that gives to all its neighbours held me instead. I have decided that is not the same as being forgotten.”*

It takes the Tender reading of the Kept and makes it personal, and a little defiant. “I have decided” is a choice made against doubt, and not a certainty.

The Five Faiths

The Motherfaith is the dominant faith of the Turning lands, and it is not the only one. Five lived faiths each answer a different experience the Trees, or the lack of a Tree, actually produce, and what follows is how people live those answers, not a list of gods.

Faith	Home	A Condition is…	Everyday name	Own name
the Leaf-Mother	everywhere the Trees stand; born on Maiethorn	a **gift chosen**	the Motherfaith	*Maieth*
the Watching	Maiethorn's oldest districts	a **seeing**, later named a gift	the Watching	*Haelthael*
the Fair Hand	Strandoren's ports and houses	a **bargain struck**	the Fair Hand	*Leddoren*
the Old Ways	Heskoren's groves and doors	the **land making its own**	the Old Ways	*Vaeloren*
the Open Table	Kumbaan, the Sundering Isle	a mainland hunger **they never had**	the Open Table	*Ndeyaan*

A Condition, in all of these arguments, is a becoming: something a person becomes, set beside the Kind they were born. The Watching, the Fair Hand, and the Old Ways live where the Trees stand, on Maiethorn, Strandoren, and Heskoren, so the friction is inside the settled world, among people who already live with the wood. The Open Table grew on Kumbaan *(koom-BAHN)* with no Tree and no Mother-name. Sailors call that place the Sundering Isle, and a storm-wall of weather, current, and reef keeps it, which is why the grafts never crossed.

Smaller household rites, quay-charms, and Kind-customs stay local, especially the household customs of the Kitsune, the Selkie, and the Tengu, peoples a person is born as. Those charms are not what the five faiths stand on. A household can keep a charm the next street has never heard of, and the five faiths are still the five.

The people who do the daily work are the tree-wardens, who keep the Motherfaith at the Tree; the Watchers, who keep the vigil; the Book-Hands, who witness a signing; the Door-Keepers, who walk

the rivers, the stones, and the groves; the Table-Keepers, who keep the supper; and the Shore-Sitters of the isle, who sit the storm-beach and wait, and do not swim out. A fringe of the Long-Lived, the people whose aging has stopped, call themselves the Pourers and keep a cup they call the Poured God, and that cup is not a sixth faith.

The argument (what a becoming *is*)

Every faith in this world has to answer the same fact, that most people become something they were not born as, and the faiths do not agree on the verb for that becoming.

The people a Tree gives a colour are the Given, and even that name is already an argument: the Motherfaith says the child was chosen, the Watching at the same wood says the child was seen, the Fair Hand says the child was signed, and the Old Ways say the Tree is a late guest at a door the land already kept.

The Struck are the people who change later, at a threshold, often with no Tree nearby, and the faiths do not hear the same door. The Motherfaith is still arguing whether the Leaf-Mother reached that threshold, while the Watching says the threshold was always a place of seeing, the Fair Hand hears a later contract struck in extremity, and the Old Ways call this the oldest becoming, the land's own children.

The Kept are the people who get the hug and no colour, and on the mainland that same hug has four readings: a gift of wholeness, a person passed over, no bargain taken, or a year the land had no door for you. The Open Table does not offer a reading of the hug, because on their account a Condition is a mainland hunger they never had.

The Tithe is the upkeep a becoming still asks, and the faiths read that same upkeep four ways: the Motherfaith calls it the honest weight of a gift, the Watching calls it the cost someone once paid, the Fair Hand calls it the term of the contract, and the Old Ways call it the land's due.

None of these is a villain-theology. Each is a sincere answer to a seam people actually live with: gifts that fit, a reach that runs thin at the edge, the written terms a Bound person carries, the Struck who change with no Tree nearby, and a whole isle that never Turned, that never brought its children under a Tree to become. The Motherfaith's own schism already taught the courtesy the others use. What you do at the rite is what binds, what you believe is what gets argued, and a household that keeps two practices is ordinary rather than a scandal.

How they live together

People belong by the rite they keep, and the creed can wait. Because the Motherfaith counts you by what you do at the Tree, a Watcher who brings their child, a Settler of the Fair Hand who stands as

witness to the colour, and a Kin-speaker of the Old Ways who also walks the rivers, the hills, and the stones can all belong at the same Leaf-Fall. Doctrine fights, and the festival usually does not.

Each fight stays in its own land, inside a district or a port, and it does not become a march of one faith upon another.

On Maiethorn the fight is at the centre. The Watching and the Motherfaith share the same Trees and argue over the blessing spoken there. Threnmaieth, the crown that writes its people down, files the Watchers on the Threnhael *(THREN-hayl)*, the roll whose name means the keeping-whole, as a known, counted dissent. The file calls that dissent the Grown-Over. What follows from the filing is pressure, not a pogrom.

On Strandoren the faith is worn light, so the fight is over the Bound and the books. The Bound are the people who chose a grant and named the terms of it. The Fair Hand and the Motherfaith compete for the same oath-keepers in the same port. Lestrand, the great merchant power of that coast, which people call the Ledger Coast, prices both and polices neither.

On Heskoren the fight is over the grove. The Old Ways were there before the grafts, the Trees set into older ground, and the Motherfaith burns hottest where the gift is scarcest. A dying Tree has two claimants. Vaethorn, the devout power of the Waiting Lands, makes the quarrel tender and sharp, not holy-war loud.

On the Sundering Isle the wall still holds. A Yumboe on the mainland, one of the good people born to that isle, is a guest at everyone else’s rite. They keep their supper, and they find the noon-day faiths, the mainland rites kept in the daylight, loud the way a guest who will not sit is loud. The quarrel is already in the port. A host counts a guest as family after two suppers, a clerk wants to know where the person was Turned, and a host will not spend a child’s tenth-year week on a Tree.

Most years what actually happens is a household keeping two practices. The hard edge is the hour when the two stop agreeing.

Pair	The common blend	The hard edge
Motherfaith + Watching	The household keeps the same Tree and inherits which of the two blessings it speaks.	Threnmaieth's roll wants one name for what you are.
Motherfaith + Fair Hand	The Leaf-Fall is a festival and a signing-watch, the Fair Hand standing witness to the terms, and the Tithe is paid as both tending and settling.	Gift-language and debt-language contend over the same Bound soul.
Motherfaith + Old Ways	People make a pilgrimage to a graft and still walk the old doors at the threshold.	When a Tree sickens, the quarrel is who tends it, the warden or the door-keeper.
Any mainland + Open Table	A shared supper is rare, and someone will say "no one is a stranger twice."	On the mainland a person belongs because a town watched them Turn. The Open Table says a person belongs after two suppers. A child of the table who reaches Turning-Week in Eolthael, the Turning-month of the High Solstice, is the hard case.

All five houses tell the Child at Four Doors, and the last line changes. That is how the world argues without a council.

The Leaf-Mother remains a belief in public life, and the other faiths stay beliefs with her. The Watching says it remembers a cost, and what that cost was the house will not agree, so the claim stays unsettled.

The Watching

The Watching is Maiethorn's heartland heresy, an older Tree-faith the Motherfaith grew over, and the dissent sits at the centre rather than out on a frontier. They keep the Tree and refuse the Mother-name, holding that the colours fall because the Tree sees, and not because a she chooses.

In everyday speech a neighbour says **the Watching**. Their own name is **Haelthael** *(hayl-THALE)*, from *hael* and *thael*, the Tree kept whole. They mean the Tree before anyone split it into a Mother and her hands. The Motherfaith's soft name for them is **the First Watching**, and Threnmaieth's file-name is **the Grown-Over**.

Shape of the faith

This is a witness-faith, and the founding fact is that the Tree looks, so a colour is a seeing made visible, and not a present wrapped in a leaf. To live well is to name what was seen, rather than to thank a giver you cannot prove.

Their practice is older than the Motherfaith's. They stand at the same Leaf-Fall, and they will not say the Tender's blessing, the line the warden speaks over the child, as the warden says it. The rite still binds them to the town, and the withheld word is the whole dissent.

They will not give the Tree a divine character, neither a mother nor a bargain-partner nor a land-spirit in a new dress, because for them it is the Tree. Naming it *Maieth* is, to them, the overlay, a comfort the sacred centre invented when the seeing needed a face.

You know them by the name they keep for the wood. They keep **Thaeloren**, the Tree that witnesses, and they refuse **Hand of the Mother**, so the wood is the same and the title is the schism.

Doctrine (as believed)

They share the Motherfaith's picture of the Before, a beginning in which the world was Kind and Kind alone, people as they were born and nothing besides. They part company on what came next: the Tree, they say, was already there and already watching, the Giving came after that Watching, and the Mother-name came last, so that each layer is a story laid over a seeing.

"She chooses well" is, to them, a later sentence. Fittingness is what a witness produces: the Tree sees what you can carry and what the town will need, and the leaf matches the seeing. They call that intent, and they do not call it a mother's. To a Watcher, the skeptics of the Motherfaith are almost right, and still too quick to call the Tree a phenomenon with no mind. There is a mind in the seeing, and it does not owe you a lap.

Haelthael teaching remembers a cost, and holds that the Giving was not free: something was spent, someone was lessened, and the Tree, or whatever stands behind it, does not reach twice by chance, because reaching costs. They will not name a Mother who pretends otherwise. What the cost was, they will not agree, though they agree the cost was real.

The Kept were seen: a hug and no colour is a seeing of wholeness, or a seeing that did not reach, and they argue this as fiercely as the Motherfaith does, without the consolation of a mother's lap. The hug is still a witness, not an oversight, and not, they insist, a slight dressed as love.

The Struck were seen at a harder door, so a drowning, an oath, or a death is an older place of seeing, and the Tree is the ordinary one. The Watching does not need the Wide-Hand and Narrow-Hand split the Motherfaith keeps, the quarrel over how wide a giving hand reaches, because seeing was never confined to a grafted scion, a living cut of the origin planted in a town.

Practice

The Night Watch is kept the night before Turning-Week. Watchers keep a silent vigil at the town Tree. They speak no blessing and read no colour. They keep watch on the Tree all night, as they believe it watches the town.

The withheld blessing is what they do at the Leaf-Fall itself. They attend, because the practice still holds and their children still Turn, and when the warden says the Tender's line a Watcher household speaks its own, quietly.

> *"What falls, was seen. What is kept, was seen. The Tree does not reach twice by chance."*

The cadence is the same as the Motherfaith's blessing, and the Mother is not in it. Towns that have lived with both wordings for a long time barely notice the difference. Threnmaieth notices.

Name what you saw is the devotion after a Turning. A Watcher does not say "tend what you're given." They sit with the child and describe the fall: the colour, the way the leaf came, and what the year will ask. Devotion, for them, is accurate speech.

In Haelthael liturgy the origin Tree is only Thaeloren. "First Hand" is tolerated as poetry. "Hand of the Mother" is the overlay they will not say.

Watchers are not priests. They keep the Night Watch, they teach the withheld blessing, and, where a town will have it, they offer a second reading of a rare or mixed fall. That reading is a witness alongside the tree-warden. It is not a reading over the warden, and the warden's word stays the town's. In Threnmaieth they are a known column on the roll. The Watching has no mother-church and no seat in the Awakening Tree's shadow, because that seat was grown over by the First Seat. Their oldest rooms are under older chapels, or in houses that never took a warden's blessing on the door. What they keep as offices are the Night Watch and the withheld blessing.

The live schism

The Masked say the Mother is a later face the Witness learned to wear, or a name people needed and the Tree allowed. The reading sits close to the Motherfaith, and it is common in mixed families. A Masked Watcher will stand for the Tender's blessing and add the withheld line under it.

The Bare Tree says there was never a she. The overlay is a comfort the sacred centre invented, and comfort is not the same thing as truth. This is the harder and smaller reading, and it is the one Threnmaieth files most carefully.

Both branches agree the Giving cost something, and they do not agree what: a wound in the Tree, a year the watching failed, or a someone who became the wood. This is the question they will not close.

It is also the one the Motherfaith most wants left unasked.

An inscription on a door-beam

The inscription was cut on a door-beam, then recut, and found when a warden-chapel on Maiethorn was re-floored. The new beam faces the Tree. This face was turned to the stone.

> *We kept the watch before the name. The wood was already looking. If a mother came after, she came to a work begun. Do not thank the latecomer for the seeing.*

It reads as heresy, stubborn and local, and it claims that the Tree is older than the Mother-name.

The Fair Hand

The Fair Hand is Strandoren's fortune-and-contract faith. It has no catechism, and it distrusts anyone who offers one. What follows is assembled the way Settlers, the people who keep this faith, assemble what they hold: from working books, settled margins, and clauses copied often enough to become prayer. The faith reads a Condition not as a gift given but as a bargain struck. The world, on this account, is a ledger of deals. The Tithe is a term, not a devotion. When the book is closed you are even, and you do not owe gratitude forever. It is the direct rival to the Motherfaith's gift-language, at home on the trade continent, and especially among the Bound.

In everyday speech the name is **the Fair Hand**. Their own written name is **Leddoren** *(LEDD-or-en)*, from *ledd* and *oren*, the witnessed account. Along the Ledger Coast the slang is **the Settling**. The Motherfaith calls them **the Bargainers**. A Bound person, who chose a grant and named the Terms of it, will say they have **a closed book** once that year's Terms are paid.

Open a quay-factor's book, a factor working the quay, and the line reads: *A grant without a term is a debt whose number the giver keeps.*

Open a Bound mason's book and the line reads: *Asked. Answered. Owed through rain-month. Closed.*

Open a Kept daughter's book, beneath a blank colour-line, the line where a colour would have been entered, and it reads: *Nothing granted. Nothing owed. My mother still thinks this means nothing happened.*

No one entry speaks for the Fair Hand. Together they are closer than an official creed would be.

Shape of the faith

This is a settling-faith. Nobody is being rescued, and nobody is being given something they cannot refuse, because a gift you cannot put down is, to them, an imposition. The founding ethic is fair terms. Know what you owe, pay it, and walk.

What makes you of the Fair Hand is that you keep accounts honestly: the Tithe, the contract, and the witness. You do not have to deny the Mother in the street. Many Settlers still bring a child to the Tree. They attend as witnesses to a signing.

The faith splits on whether anyone sits across the table as a counterparty, the other party to the deal, or whether the far side of the table is empty, and either way of keeping the book agrees that the table is real. The Leaf-Mother, if she exists, is a giver who will not show her terms, which, to a Settler, is the one unforgivable clause.

The mark of a Settler is a small personal book, and it is not a census, because a census is the sin they lay at Threnmaieth's door. In the book a Settler writes colour, Tithe, and what they are owed. The Bound did not invent this book. They are simply the ones whose book is also a contract.

Doctrine (as believed)

The Fair Hand holds that nothing is given, and that the Leaf-Fall is a striking of terms. The colour is the grant, the Tithe is the price, and the town's need is the other side of the deal. "Tend what you're given" is how a creditor teaches you to be grateful for the interest.

The Bound are how the faith proves the model. A Bound person chose, named a grant, named Terms, and named a Pledge, the piece of themselves the contract would collect. The Fair Hand says this is not a special horror. It is the same grammar as every becoming, written large enough to read. The Motherfaith's fear of the Bound is, to them, embarrassment. The Bound make the ledger visible.

The Kept, on this reading, declined, or were not offered. No bargain was taken, nothing is owed, and nothing is owed to them, which the faith holds as a cooler dignity than spared or slighted. On Lestrand the same life rhymes with calling the Kept the free. The Fair Hand did not invent that slight. They gave it a theology.

The Struck, they say, signed later, in a storm, because extremity is when people accept bad terms. A drowning, an oath, a death: of course the book opens then. The Struck are not suspects. They are people who bargained without a clerk. The faith's kindness is to settle the year fairly after the fact, by a hall or a warrant: someone vouches, and the civic year is taken up in place of the bargain that had no clerk. A Bound person's Terms are the exception. Those belong to the Counterparty, the other party named in the Bound's own bargain, and not to a clerk. The cruelty is the same motion. A Struck person who cannot settle fades, and the quay steps around them.

What they mean by grace is a closed book. It is not forgiveness, and it is not a mother’s lap. The sentence they trust is the one they can say in a breath: you paid, you are even, walk.

Practice

The signing-watch is what Settlers make of the Leaf-Fall. They attend as witnesses, not as petitioners, and they leave the Tender’s blessing to the warden. They speak, if they speak:

> *“Grant and term, seen and spoken. The book is open. Keep it fair.”*

Public settling is the Tithe paid where a neighbour can see it, and the act is a clearing, not a confession. A Bound person’s oath-day is the high holy day. The Terms are recited, and the year’s book is closed or marked owing. The Motherfaith calls this showing off. The Fair Hand calls it the only honest worship.

Quay-blessings are short, worn, and said in a tongue the use has rubbed down. A Settler says “fair wind, fair term” over a hull, a contract, a marriage. The sacred and the commercial use the same sentence, and that is the teaching.

The personal book holds the colour, the Tithe, the debts, and what the year owes you. It stays private. It is not the Threnhael. A Settler will die to keep a crown-clerk out of it. That refusal is the one fury they share with every other faith on the subject.

Book-hands, whom neighbours also call Settlers, are notaries who are also theologians. They witness signings, they teach children how to keep a book, and they settle a Struck person’s civic year by a hall or a warrant. They recite a Bound person’s Terms on oath-day, and they do not rewrite those Terms, because that clause belongs to the Counterparty and not to a clerk. On Lestrand they are often the same people as the commercial clerks, so the faith is the profession, worn lightly. Two book-hands may refuse each other’s settlements and still borrow ink.

The Fair Hand has no seat and many tables. It meets in guild-rooms and quay-shrines, and a high house in a rich port is the oldest book-room. There is no membership roll, because a roll would be a Threnhael.

The live schism

Settlers do not form two branches, because they write over one another in the same book.

> ***Recto:*** *Something sits across the table — a mind, a power, a hand that is fair rather than mothering. The Bound prove that an answer has an address.*

> ***Verso, in another ink:*** *A book does not require a reader on the far side. Rain settles downhill without a creditor.*
>
> ***Lower margin:*** *Then whom did you pay?*
>
> ***Trimmed edge:*** *Paid is paid.*

What unites the inks is a practical fury at a hidden term. That is why Settlers cannot join the Motherfaith even when they share a festival. “The Mother does not reach twice by chance” is, to them, a clause with no number on it.

From a Bound’s working contract

The page still in use is a preamble copied from a Bound person’s working contract, the form-words a Lestrand book-hand uses when the grant is ordinary and the Terms are not.

> *I was not given. I asked, and I was answered, and I named what I would pay. If a mother had wanted me she would have sent a leaf, not a clause. I prefer the clause. I can read it.*

It is a Bound person’s pride, a little cold, and it is the Fair Hand’s whole case against gift-doctrine. The Bound person who prefers the clause is sincere. They have felt the cost and named it a price.

The Old Ways

The Old Ways are the ancestor-and-land faith of Heskoren. The faith predates the grafts. It says the Mother’s reach is new here, and the land was already making children of its own, the Struck and the Taken-In, at rivers, drowning-pools, oath-stones, and groves. A Taken-In is a person the wild took partway into itself and gave back changed. The Trees, on this account, are guests. They are not the source.

Everyday, and in the house’s own common speech, the name is **the Old Ways**. The liturgical name is **Vaeloren** *(vay-LOR-en)*, from *vael* and *oren*. They use **vael** in an older sense. It is not “a Condition Given,” a becoming handed down as a leaf-colour, but **what the land yields**. They say the Motherfaith narrowed the word until it meant only a leaf-colour. Pious speech in Vaethorn calls them **the Before-Faith**. The Taken-In among them say **the Green Kin**.

Shape of the faith

This is a land-and-kin faith, and the founding fact is that place makes people. A river that has drowned someone and returned them, a hill that took someone in, and an oath-stone that heard a vow are **the old doors**. The grafted Tree is a new door, and it is welcome if it behaves.

You keep the Old Ways by walking, not by watching a colour fall. You go to the doors, you feed the kin who stayed, and you stand for the Struck when a town will not. Belief about the Mother comes second. Many Kin-speakers also bring a child to a healthy graft when they can reach one.

What they hold as divine is many, and the dead stay. It is not one mother, and it is not a ledger. It is hills, waters, old trees, and the people who went into them. The old trees are the wild kin of motherwood, the wood of the Turning Trees, and the grafts are the planted ones. Ancestors here are not ghosts to be feared. The Returned, people who died with something unfinished and got up walking, come through a different door. The ancestors of this faith are kin who remained in the ground.

You know them by a worn token from their door: a river-stone, a grove-twig, or a pinch of hill, carried the way a Settler carries a book. No two tokens look alike, and that difference is the theology.

Doctrine (as believed)

The land was first. Before grafts, and before pilgrimage, Heskoren's people already became things other than the people they were born. The Struck are not a problem the Motherfaith has failed to place. They are the oldest rite, the land doing what the land does, and the Taken-In are the grove's own children rather than a frontier embarrassment.

Vael meant yield: grain, game, a child returned from water, a person the hill kept. The Motherfaith's vael, a Given Condition, is a special case they mistook for the whole word. To call a leaf a vael is fine. To say that only a leaf is a vael is a theft of speech.

Grafts are guests. A healthy Tree is a new kin-house. You may tend it, and you may Turn under it, and you may not pretend it invented becoming, or that a town without one is empty of the sacred. A sickening Tree is a guest who is dying in your grove. The fight with the tree-wardens is who is host.

The Kept are a year the land had no door. The Old Ways will not call that spared, or slighted, or free labour. Some years a door does not open for you, and you are still the land's, whether the opening comes next year, in the drowning-year, or never. The waiting that Vaethorn sanctifies as pilgrimage is, here, just weather.

The Mother is a late name. Either the land is wearing a face the newcomers needed, which is the Guest-reading, or the name is a claiming, which is the First-reading. Both readings agree she did not arrive first.

Practice

Threshold-walking happens at the year's hinges, the turns of the year, and not only at the High Solstice. People walk the old doors of their district. They greet the water, the hill, and the stone, they leave food, and they do not ask for a colour. They ask to be known.

Ancestor-meals set a place at the board for the ones in the ground. The meal is quiet and domestic, easy to miss as religion if you came from Maiethorn looking for a chapel, and the courtesy is the rite.

Standing for the Struck is what they do when a person changes later and alone. The Old Ways do not take that person to a Tree to be acknowledged as Given. They take them back to the door that made them, if it can be found, and name them kin. The Motherfaith's quiet receiving-rite and this one sometimes happen in the same week, for the same person, and the argument is which name goes first.

The contested grove is an ailing graft standing in an old Taken-In green. That is the fight everyone knows: warden against door-keeper, guest against host, the scarcity that sends people on pilgrimage against the sentence "we had ways." It is a quarrel between neighbours who both love the wood.

Door-keepers, whom neighbours also call Kin-speakers, know which doors still open. They speak at ancestor-meals, and they stand for the unvouched Struck, the ones no one has yet stood for, when they can. The standing is a reputation more than a hierarchy. A famous door-keeper is the one three valleys will walk to, and the two names often belong to the same person. The land is the seat, so there is no mother-church to sit in. Vaethorn's tree-wardens find this infuriating and, in a dry year, quietly useful. The door-keepers walk the doors. They do not carry scions.

The live schism

The Guest-reading says the Mother is the land wearing a face the newcomers needed, the land in a new dress, and the grafts are kin. It is common in Vaethorn towns that finally got a Tree and did not want to throw their grandparents out of the rite. They will make the pilgrimage, and they will walk the doors.

The First-reading says the grafts are a claiming, and the old doors were enough. It lives in the thinner-reach districts, the ones still waiting on a scion that will not take. They will tend a dying graft as a guest in their house, and they will still refuse the Tender's blessing.

Both branches revere the Struck and the Taken-In, and that shared reverence is what the faith stands on. A reading that started pitying them as unreached has already become Motherfaith.

Said at a drowning-stone

Said at a drowning-stone on Heskoren's wet margin, the year after a graft sickened and a child came back from the river Changed, Struck by the water and carrying no leaf:

> *The tree is young. The water is not. If a mother sent the water she sent it before she sent the leaf, and she has not told the wardens. We will feed both. We will not let either pretend it was first.*

It is frontier courtesy, a little barbed, and it is the Old Ways' whole case. They have correctly felt that becoming happens at doors where there is no healthy Tree.

The Open Table

Kumbaan's faith grew with no Tree and no Mother-name. The good people keep the night, set a place for hands that have no bodies, and hold that a stranger at the table is the holiest thing in the world, holier than a colour, a graft, or a bargain. The Yumboe, which is the mainland's name for them, are the hill-folk of that isle, born into the shape rather than Turned into it. They stand about waist-high to a mainlander, pearl-pale, silver-haired, and they call themselves the good people. The bodies are warm. The ancestral idiom lives in the hands, not in the people.

On the mainland a neighbour says **the Open Table**, and a sailor says **the Moon-Feast**. The house says **Ndeyaan** *(ndey-AHN)*, the night-keeping. In full courtesy the name is **Bakhna Ndeya**, the good night. The opening of every meal that matters is already their creed. Someone at the table says "No one is a stranger twice."

Shape of the faith

Ndeyaan is a hospitality-faith, and the founding fact is the table. To feed and to be fed is how the living sit with the staying-kin, the hands that remained, and with anyone the storm-wall did not keep out. There is no Leaf-Fall, because, as they say, there was nothing missing to give.

The rite is the meal. Ndeyaan has almost no clergy and no chapel, because the rite is supper under the moon, a place set for hands you can see and for a body you cannot, with daylight reserved for sleep. A Yumboe who keeps this on the mainland is still of the Open Table. A mainlander who sits once is a guest. A mainlander who sits twice is kin.

What they hold as divine is the hill, the moon, and the ones who stayed. It is not a mother, and it is not a ledger. The dead do not leave. They stay as hands. Whether those hands are the dead, which is the Staying, or the hill's own courtesy, which is the Serving, is the house-argument, and neither reading makes the good people into ghosts.

You can know a house of the faith by an extra place laid, even when the household is poor. The unseen hands are what make that place possible. That is not a metaphor they use. It is the furniture.

Doctrine (as believed)

Wholeness is the default. The mainland invented a hunger and called it a gift. On Kumbaan you are born Yumboe and that is enough. If the good people become anything else, they do not become it at a Tree, because there is none. How any other becoming happens is not a doctrine they owe a stranger. It is a family matter, and they are not in a hurry.

The dead stay to serve. Folklore on the mainland calls Yumboes spirits of the dead. They find this rude and, in a sideways way, nearly true, because the hands are the staying-kin. The living host, and the staying pour. A feast that outshines its means is a theological statement, because the household is larger than the bodies you can count.

The moon wakes both, so night is the shared day of the living and the staying, and daylight is a Sabbath of sleep, a day kept for rest, and not a fallen hour. Mainland noon-faiths are loud the way a guest who will not sit is loud.

A stranger is the sacrament. The storm-wall keeps the world out, and anyone who crosses it has already been through drowning-water, so you do not test them with a colour. You feed them. The second supper is the rite of belonging. This is why a lone Yumboe on Strandoren becomes a host wherever they land, still keeping Ndeyaan with whatever table they can make.

The Mother, as they hear her, is a story about a quiet table, told too loud. They do not hate her. They have never met her. They do not understand why a people would need to be chosen in order to be wanted.

Practice

The moon-feast is the ordinary high rite: night, a hill-hall or open turf, the extra place, and the unseen hands fetching and pouring. There are songs. There is no colour-reading, and there are no terms recited.

The place is laid even in a poor house. To omit it is the one real impiety, not because the staying starve, since they do not, but because you have counted the household too small.

“No one is a stranger twice” is spoken at the second supper. The first night you are a guest, and a guest is already sacred. The second night you are of the table. Mainlanders who hear this as a proverb have missed that, on Kumbaan, it is a legal sentence in all but parchment. It is spoken, and it is not written down.

Daylight sleep is rest. The glare is not holy, and it is not cursed. It is when the good people and the staying-kin rest. A Yumboe abroad will still take their long rest when the moon is down, if they can, and they will not make a scene about it.

Table-keepers, whom neighbours also call hill-hosts, are almost not clergy. The office is the person whose hall the valley comes to on the bright nights, and the standing is a reputation rather than a title. They have one job, which is to keep the table.

Shore-sitters, whom neighbours also call wall-waiters, are the other isle job. They sit the storm-beach and wait. Swimming out is outside the job. The living go uphill to a table.

A Yumboe abroad is a table-keeper by necessity. One person can keep Ndeyaan in a Lestrand attic, and that is how the faith travels, when it travels at all. It recruits by who will lay the extra place, and not by Kind. Kumbaan sends no mission.

The live schism

The Staying says the unseen hands are the dead: grandparents, the drowned, the ones the hill kept. The reading is ancestral and literal, older in the tellings, and still common in the deep-hill halls. It is not a ghost-cult. The dead are family who took the serving-work.

The Serving says the hands are the hill’s own courtesy, the good people’s oldest wonder, and not a roster of names. This reading is gentler. It is the majority in the halls that face the surface, and it is easier to explain to a mainland guest who has gone pale.

Both branches set the extra place. A Serving host who will not say the dead’s names, and a Staying host who will not stop saying them, will still pass the same cup. The argument is for after the dishes.

Two suppers, or a Turning-witness

On Kumbaan, “no one is a stranger twice” is how you belong. On the mainland, you belong because a town watched you Turn. A host of this faith counts a guest as family after two suppers. A town clerk wants to know where the person was Turned.

This is the faith’s edge on the mainland. It does not need a mission, and it does not need a chapel on Strandoren. It needs a room, a tenth year, and a clerk who counts belonging a different way.

The everyday collision is citizenship. A guest sits a second night in a Lestrand attic. The host says the sentence and means it. A quay clerk, a Book-hand, or a warden passing through wants a Turning-witness, someone who saw the person Turn, before they will treat that person as of a place. Inside the room the guest is kin. Outside the door the same person is still a guest. Neither office is cruel, and the sentence does not mean the same thing outside the room.

The week that can close is the Given-door. A child of the table, whether isle-raised, convert-raised, or a sailor's tenth summer in a port, reaches Turning-Week. The host will not walk them to a Turning Tree, because in the host's telling they were never lacking, and a neighbour or a town-warden will. The Given-door is one week. If the argument outlasts Eolthael *(ay-ohl-THALE)*, the Turning-month, the child is unTurned. Struck doors still open later. That is not a comfort the host asked for, and it is not a kindness the warden can file. This is not a crusade on Kumbaan. The child is already on the mainland, and the storm-wall stayed where it was.

When a tenth year is in the house, the extra place is set slightly back, and the host says the sentence or refuses to take the child down to the Tree in the morning. A warden, a clerk, or a neighbour is in the street with a list of this year's children. In Hale-month, the worn name of the spring month before the Turning, the same list is manners. In Eolthael it is a child's life.

Mbela *(MBEH-lah)* keeps an attic off a Lestrand salt-stair and will not spend a child's week on a colour. **Sorel** of the quay will not file a second supper as belonging, and will walk a tenth-year neighbour to the Tree if the host will not. They are not enemies. They count belonging differently, and they share a stair.

Romanticizing the Moon-Feast is itself a slight. Printing the sentence on a luck-card is how Lestrand files the whole faith. The woman in the attic still sets the place.

A place-setting blessing

Said to the empty plate before the hands arrive, taught to children, and heard once, badly copied, by a Strandor sailor who did come back.

> *We have counted you. Sit. If you have a name we have not learned it yet; if you have a colour we have no tree to read it. The moon is enough light. Eat, and be the household.*

It reads as hospitality, almost twee, and it also says that being wanted never depended on a colour. The sailor who copied it thought it was a grace. What was copied is a claim that being wanted was never a gift.

Kumbaan keeps the moon, and not the solstice. The Yumboe reckoning is nocturnal and lunar, and it owes the Trees nothing, because they have none. The High Solstice, the mainland's holiest week, is not a hinge on the isle.

The Child at Four Doors

A teaching-story told in every house. The bones of it stay the same, and the last line does not, so the story carries the argument of the five faiths in a shape that will not resolve. A Turning, in this telling, is the year a child comes to the one door the town said would be there. Children hear the ending that belongs to their own house first. Travellers hear the other endings, and they do not sleep well.

The story (as told)

A child came to the year of their Turning and found **four doors** where the town said there was one.

The first door was a Tree, and a leaf hung over it, coloured, waiting.
The second door was a book, open, a line already drawn, a space for a name.
The third door was a river-stone, wet, older than the road.
The fourth door was a table with a place set, and no one sitting in it.

The child asked which door was theirs.

No one would say. Each keeper only said: *this one opens.*

The child sat down in the middle and waited to be chosen, or seen, or signed, or fed.

They waited a long time.

When they looked up, all four doors were open, and the child was still in the middle, and the year had gone on without a colour, or with one — the tellings do not agree — and the child had to stand, and pick, and did, and the story ends before you see which.

The last lines (by house)

The bones above are common. What a house adds, once the bones are done, is the faith that house keeps.

- **Motherfaith (Tender):** *The Mother had opened the Tree before the child sat down. The waiting was the hug. They were wanted either way.*
- **Motherfaith (Wanting):** *The Mother opened one door and the child was looking at the other three. That is how a person is passed over: by having too many doors.*
- **The Watching:** *The Tree had been looking the whole time. The other three doors were people talking. The child was seen. That was the Turning. The leaf was optional.*
- **The Fair Hand:** *The child signed by sitting. Waiting is a term. Someone should have told them the price of a year in the middle.*

- **The Old Ways:** *The stone was wet before the Tree was planted. The child was already the land's. The waiting was weather.*
- **The Open Table:** *The place was set. The child was the guest, then the household. There was never a test. The other doors are how hungry people decorate a supper.*

Skeptics of every faith tell a seventh ending, which is not kind and is very short: *There were not four doors. There was a child, and a year, and a town that needed a story.*

Variants

On Maiethorn the four doors are carved on the underside of old door-beams, and the wardens say the carving is decoration. On Strandoren the story is a quay-song, and it has a chorus the Bound like to sing: *name the term or get up.* On Heskoren the tellers put the river-stone door first and the Tree third, and some of them leave the book out entirely. On Kumbaan the only door in the story is the table. The other doors are "mainland verses," and people tell them as a curiosity after the dishes, if a guest insists on hearing them. A school-version told in Threnmaieth adds a clerk who writes all four doors down on a roll. The children are not meant to laugh. They do.

Orders and Houses

The Tree-Wardens

The Tree-Wardens are the working clergy of the Motherfaith, the faith built on the Leaf-Mother. They are one order, with offices inside it. A town keeps them because someone has to water the wood, say a colour aloud so the reading counts for the town, and know when a scion is dying. A scion is a living cut of a Turning Tree, carried in earth and planted so a town that does not yet have a mature Tree can grow one. They recruit by the office, by the work, and sometimes by Condition, the change a person lives with and the Tithe, the upkeep that change asks, or the lack of either. They never recruit by Kind, the people a person is born as.

People call them tree-wardens, or just wardens. When a rite or a charter writes the name, it writes **the Orenhael** (OREN-hael), those who say the fall truly and keep the Tree sound. The Waiting Lands, which people also call Vaethorn, say **Hands-folk**. The Ledger Coast, Lestrand, says **tree-tenders**. The Tallied Crown, Threnmaieth, files them as **the Reckoned Hands**.

Shape of the order

The Motherfaith does not run rival chapters. It is one order with several offices, and those offices sit in the same house. The argument already running inside the faith is three questions at once. One is whether a hug, the holding that leaves no colour, was wholeness or a passing-over, which the faith calls Tender or Wanting. Another is whether a Struck person belongs to the Mother’s reach. Someone is Struck when a Condition comes later, at a death, an oath, or a drowning, rather than at Leaf-Fall, the day a child of ten stands under the boughs. That question is Wide-Hand or Narrow-Hand. The third is whether anyone is choosing at all, believer or skeptic. The Orenhael holds that argument inside the one order. A second Motherfaith order would only be a costume.

The wardens are needed before they are holy, because a town has to keep someone who can water the wood, name a rare colour, and know when a scion is dying. Doctrine comes after the watering. That is why a quiet skeptic can hold a town-hearth, and why Lestrand still pays its tenders.

The order is a college at the origin and one hearth in the town. The **First Seat** is that college, not a throne, and a town has one warden-hearth. Someone grows a town Tree from a cutting, and that

planting is a **graft**. The Seat cannot direct a graft that has gone far from the Motherwood, and it does not pretend it can.

They tend the wood, they speak the colour, and they carry the graft. They do not police what a person privately believes. The pressure they meet is the Tithe that comes with a Condition, and the line of towns waiting for a Tree. It is not a court for heresy.

The warden-hearth (the town)

Every town with a mature Tree keeps a **warden-hearth**, a house on the square or in the temple-yard, close enough that blight is smelled before it is announced. The warden, sometimes a small household of an apprentice and an elder, does the civic-sacred work from that house.

Tree-tending is the watering rites, the blight-watch, and the ordinary care of wood that can still die. The Leaf-Fall is the rite they officiate. They bring the child under the boughs, and they wait there with the town.

The Speaking is how they confirm the colour aloud. The colours a neighbour already knows, deep red, storm-grey, lamp-amber, sea-blue, pale stone, and copper-green, need the warden's word before the reading is the town's. Rare, mixed, or argumentative falls are why the office exists. A **white-fire** fall, the leaf that would name a Phoenix, is sent to the First Seat by runner. A town-warden who names a Phoenix from a book has just made history, and a problem.

Receiving the Struck is a quiet rite at the Tree after the fact. It is not a Turning. The Tree does not Strike. How warmly the rite is done follows the warden's Wide-Hand or Narrow-Hand lean, and that difference is how the argument inside the faith reaches the square.

A new town without a mature Tree borrows a neighbour's warden and a neighbour's canopy until its own scion comes of age. That borrowed year is remembered. People in the new town will tell you they Turned at Harrow's Tree before they had their own.

The Speaking (colour-authority)

The Speaking is an act, and it is not always a separate person. In a small town the warden Speaks. In a pilgrimage-town, or at the First Seat, a **Speaker** is the elder who holds the rare-colour texts and the last word on a mixed fall.

They do not invent the palette. They keep it. People already know the common colours, and the Speaker is the reason a copper-green is not mistaken for the hug, and the reason a Watcher's second reading stays a witness alongside the warden, not a rival authority. Two houses can stand at the same fall. Two Speakers, each claiming the last word in one square, is a fight.

The failure the squares still cite is the Wrong Green, at Harrow's, in Cut-year 248, a hug Spoken aloud as copper-green. A town may Speak a second word over a fall. It may not stand the child again.

The Road-hands (graft and sickness)

Road-hands carry living scions in living earth, plant them with ceremony, and are the people sent when a Tree sickens. The everyday name is the one used everywhere. The liturgical name is **Thaelvaeth** (THAEL-vaeth), the Tree gone to the waiting.

They are the order's thin edge. A dying Tree is a civic crisis, and a waiting town is a political one. The First Seat writes the **Cutting-leave**, the paper that says who may take wood, and for where. The Road-hand walks that paper. Far from the Motherwood they have almost no authority except the scion in the cart and whatever reputation three valleys will grant.

They are sent to keep sickening Trees alive, and to deliver a living scion to a town that has already waited too long. Time works against them, and so does thin soil, and so does a Cutting-leave written for someone else. They work in living earth and mortal wood only. They are a thin circuit of hands for a whole thin reach. A week out from the Motherwood, their authority has already expired. They advise. They do not command a town that has decided to meet a feared Struck person with a rope.

The Seat's support is conditional. A live Tree is a quiet success no one writes down. A dead one is a name on a complaint. Doing the work well gets you the next hard road, not a better cart.

The Tree hugged some people and left them without a Condition. Those are the **Kept**. The road fills with people who already range, with the Kept who will not sit a comfortable hearth, and with the Wide-Hand Struck who still want the Tree to acknowledge them. Any Kind may walk it. The road is not a unit of one people, and it is not stocked with the Seat's favourites.

The college will grant a grudging Cutting-leave, and it will still decide which waiting town is next.

The First Seat (the college)

The faith's central authority sits in the **Motherwood** about Thaeloren, the Awakening Tree, on Maiethorn. Everyday the college is called **the First Seat**. It is a college of Speakers, elder wardens, and the Cutting-leave desk, and it is not a palace.

What the Seat actually holds, and this is all it holds, comes to three things.

Scions are cut from the Awakening Tree, or, as the work actually goes, from an established healthy town Tree acting on the origin's behalf. The Seat authorizes the cut. It does not uniquely possess every knife. A far college-town that cuts without leave is in schism with the Seat, not with the Tree.

The rare-colour texts are the second thing. They cover Phoenix, and the argumentative mixed falls, and they are the book a town-warden has never opened.

The third thing is the queue, the decision of which waiting settlement receives the next scion. That decision is the order's real power, and its injustice.

The Seat does not appoint every town-warden. A hearth is taken by apprenticeship and confirmed by the town that watched the new warden tend a year, the same kind of witness that makes a citizen, applied to the clergy. The Seat confirms Road-hands and Speakers. That is as far as the appointments reach. A far town's hearth is beyond them.

Beside the college, in a side-yard of the Motherwood, the order keeps a desk called the Remainder. The clerks there are not Speakers. They take back what did not take, what rotted on the road, and what a square swept up after the colours were Spoken. They jar blight so it does not travel with the next leave, and they box the colourless scraps. They do not Speak a colour, and they do not walk a box out of the yard unless someone with leave takes the earth.

The college keeps copies of what its people wrote, and the copies do not share a last line. Someone who asks for the Seat's position can be handed any of these and told it is current.

A warden-hearth in an unnamed Hands-town wrote on the back of a blight-slate.

> *The wood is sound. The child is ten. I will Speak. I will not write the colour onto anyone's roll unless the family asks. The Tree witnessed. A tablet is a second, lesser seeing. If the Seat wants this as a policy, they may send a policy. I have a watering-can.*

A Speaker in the Motherwood wrote the same summer, in a different hand.

> *A colour unspoken to the realm is a colour that can be stolen. File the fall. The hearth that will not copy is doing piety as a gap. We are one order. We are not one breath.*

A Road-hand on the Heskoren front wrote on the inside of a pot-wrap. Heskoren is the continent where the old doors and the grafts share the same ground.

> *The leave was for Harrow's. The three hamlets can see the canopy. I ate at the First Bowl first because the grove asked. The Seat may call that delay. The hill called it a meal. I am out of carrying-earth and out of argument. Send a second pot or send a better sentence than soil.*

A Remainder-clerk wrote in the side-yard after a mixed fall. The Remainder logs the scraps. It does not Speak.

> *Scraps logged. Colourless tissue boxed. The Speaking was storm-grey; the Watcher said amber at the serration. We do not Speak. We do not walk the box unless someone with leave takes the earth. Two accounts, one yard. Do not ask us which summer was true.*

One note is unsigned, and filed under “Reckoned Hands, refused.”

> *Tarvae stood beside. I Spoke. I did not copy. The water was loud. If this is insubordination, the college may recall me. If this is the job, the tablet-hall already knows.*

A later hand has written *Rithim?* in the margin and then struck the question. The college has not decided whether that strike is horticulture or politics.

Who may be a warden

Any Kind may hold the office. A Kitsune hearth-child, slight and quick-eyed, with a fox’s ears and a brush of tail, and a human neighbour hold the same office if they can tend wood and speak a colour. The order keeps no separate chapter for foxes, for the ridge-born, or for any other people.

Practice comes first. You are taken as a hand when you are apprenticed to a warden-hearth, and you are confirmed when the town has watched you through a Turning-Week, the week of the Leaf-Fall. What you do at the Tree makes you of the order. People call that orthopraxy. What you privately believe about who chooses is the argument inside the faith, and it is not the hiring test.

Skeptics sit the hearth, and believers gather at the Seat. A town-warden may sincerely say that the Trees simply do what Trees do, and still be a good warden, because the wood is mortal and the colours are already known. The First Seat runs believer-heavy. Pilgrimage wants a Someone, and the rare-colour texts are kept as hers. A skeptic Speaker at Thaeloren is possible, and the college is uncomfortable about it.

A Condition, and the Tithe that comes with it or the lack of one, leans people toward the work that fits. It does not lock the door. Anyone who can do the work may still hold the office.

Office	Often	Why the Tithe fits	Also, and welcome
Town-warden	the Kept	They carry no Tithe, so they can sit a hearth the year round.	Anyone who will tend
Speaker (Seat and pilgrimage-towns)	Long-Lived	A Long-Lived person's aging has stopped, and the memory of a rare fall stays. The Phoenix texts are a century's job.	A sharp Kept scholar; a Wide-Hand Struck warden who has seen a threshold-colour from the other side
Road-hand	Two-Bodied	A Two-Bodied person also carries an animal body, and the road is the ranging.	Kept; the Taken-In, people the wild has taken partway in, when the job is a sickening grove
Grove-tending / blight	the Taken-In	Their Tithe is living green, lived next to living wood.	Root-Answered, a person the root-element still answers, for the carrying-earth
Threshold-receiving	Struck wardens (Wide-Hand lean)	They have been on the far side of the door.	Any warden the town will stand for

The feared and still licensed are not barred. Those are the Stilled, whose gaze can hold a room or a wound still; the heavily Far-Voiced, whose feeling carries into everyone nearby; and the Bound, who live under a contract's Terms. They are rare at the First Seat. A Stilled Speaker is a comfort to a town that wants the room held, and a fright to a pilgrim. A Bound warden is easier on Lestrand, where the faith is already a profession, than in the Motherwood, where a written Term sitting next to a gift-teaching looks like the Fair Hand leaking in. A Phoenix is never clergy, because the Seat has no file for the problem a Phoenix makes.

Struck wardens must still be vouched anew, the way any Struck person must. Someone the town trusts still has to stand and say who they are. The order does not stand in for that witness.

How they live with the other houses

What people do at the Tree is the peace. The Orenhael officiates the Leaf-Fall, and the other four houses stand at it. The fights stay local.

House	Everyday arrangement	The hard edge
the Watching	The same Tree, and two blessings. A Watcher may offer a second reading of a rare fall, a witness alongside the warden and not over them.	Threnmaieth wants one name on the Threnhael, the crown's roll of persons. A Speaker who lets the withheld blessing stand is a column the crown can count.
the Fair Hand	The Leaf-Fall is a festival and a signing-watch in the same week. Book-hands and wardens share a square on Lestrand and ignore each other's sentences.	The warden calls the Condition a gift. The Book-hand calls it a debt. A Bound warden lives in both sentences.
the Old Ways	A healthy graft is kept as a guest. Kin-speakers who read the Tree as a guest go on pilgrimage and still walk the old doors.	When a Tree sickens in an old grove, the question is who is host, the warden or the door-keeper. Both are neighbours who love the wood.
the Open Table	A warden who crosses the storm-wall is a guest at supper, and there is no Tree on Kumbaan, the Sundering Isle, to tend. On the mainland they already share landings, a quay, an attic stair, a list of tenth-year children.	A host of the Open Table will not walk a child of the table to a Tree, and a warden will. That door, the week a child can be Given, is one week. There is no mission-chapter on Kumbaan.

How they live in the three corners

It is the same order in each corner. What changes is the local name, and the pressure on the hearth.

Vaethorn (Hands-folk). In the Waiting Lands the warden is most of the state a town can see. The reach of the Trees is thin, the faith runs hot, and there is almost no guild to issue a licence. A Road-hand here is doing the Seat's real work: sick Trees, borrowed Turnings, a scion that may not take. On this hearth a Kept apprentice is pitied for missing the gift they are about to spend a life tending.

Lestrand (tree-tenders). The warden is a paid civic office. The Leaf-Fall is a commercial milestone, and the warden Speaks so a guild-ticket can open, with the faith worn light. From the docks the Seat's queue looks like any other scarce good, and a Cutting-leave can be brokered. That brokering is Lestrand's sin among its own clergy, and it does not require a heresy.

Threnmaieth (the Reckoned Hands). This is the heaviest pressure, because the First Seat stands in the same sacred centre of Maiethorn as the Tallied Crown. The crown wants wardens named to the Threnhael as officers of the Reckoned Faith, the colours written down and the Speakers working as clerks of stewardship. Some Speakers cooperate, because they believe they are keeping the realm hale.

Some refuse. The Tree witnessed, they say, and a ledger is a second, lesser seeing. Nearness is the pressure. The Seat can still refuse the roll, and some Speakers do.

The scion-queue

A graft takes a generation to Turn, and there are always more waiting towns than there is carrying-earth, the living earth a scion travels in, so someone has to decide the order.

The First Seat frames that queue as horticulture. The wood will take here, the soil is thin there, and the carrying-earth is needed for the first. All of that can be true. It is also a choice about who lives another twenty years sending children down the road to a neighbour's canopy, and those years run Kept-heavy and Struck-heavy, which the frontier already knows as weather. The Motherfaith's kindness, if you hold it, did not write the queue. People did.

Road-hands walk the consequence. They plant what they were given leave to plant, they sleep in the town that was not chosen, and they learn not to say *queue*.

Economy of the order

Towns house and feed the warden-hearth. The stipend is civic and paid in kind: bread, wood, and a place on the square. It is not a tax on Conditions.

Turning-Week is the festival share. There are markets, the reunion, and the year's namings, and the warden eats from the fair the way any other needed office does.

Cutting-leave has a fee. The Seat frames it as the cost of carrying-earth and of a Road-hand's year, and at the edge people experience it as the price of a future Tree. Lestrand will broker the fee, Vaethorn will call it an offering, and Threnmaieth will want it on the roll. This is how the Seat took over a practice that began without a fee.

Pilgrimage keeps the Seat: offerings, lodging, and the devout who settle in the Motherwood. The college is rich in nearness to the Tree, not in a tax on Conditions.

Venting-halls, greens, ranging-commons, and the safety-guilds belong to other houses. Wardens point a new Given, a child who has just received a Condition at Leaf-Fall, toward a guild. They do not licence the Stilled.

A Cutting-leave

This is a Cutting-leave, in a First Seat hand, carried north in the same earth as the scion. The back is travel-stained. The front is clean.

> *The wood will take at Harrow's green. It will not take this year at the three hamlets past the ford — the soil is thin there, and the carrying-earth is needed for the first. Cut from a healthy hand, not from the First, and married with the watering-words. If the scion sickens, send to the Seat; do not cut a second without leave. The Mother does not reach twice by chance, and neither do we.*

The leave is competent and a little cold. It reuses the Tender's blessing, the sentence in which the Mother does not reach twice by chance, as a shipping clause. The clerk writes that the soil is thin at the three hamlets, and the three hamlets will run Kept-heavy and call it weather.

The Watchers

The Watchers are the working people of the Watching, the faith that keeps the Tree and withholds the Mother-name. Their own name for that faith is Haelthael. They are not priests, and they have no mother-church, because the First Seat grew over the rooms that would have been one. What they still keep, in those rooms and under those chapels, is a vigil and a second voice. They are the neighbour who will sit up with the Tree the night before Turning-Week, and the second pair of eyes a family sends for when a leaf comes down strange. They describe what they saw, and they do not confirm it, because that confirmation, the civic word, stays with the warden. They have day jobs. The house is a practice, not a wage.

A second reading that becomes a confirmation is the house breaking itself. A Night Watch that becomes a hunt is the house breaking itself the other way.

People call them **Watchers**. The rite writes **the Nethoren** (NETH-or-en), those who keep the night and speak what was seen. The Waiting Lands say **the night-kin**. The Ledger Coast barely has a name, and a clerk who needs a label says **vigil-folk**. The Tallied Crown files the house as **the Grown-Over** and the people who keep the vigil as **the second column**.

Shape of the order

They have no seat. The Watching has no college in the Motherwood, because that seat was grown over. Their oldest rooms sit under older chapels, or in houses that never took a warden's mark. Those rooms are the belief they keep: the Watching was already here. A Watcher who wants a mother-church has already become something else.

The house has two acts, and it does not keep four offices. The **Night Watch** is what the house does, and anyone of Haelthael may keep it. The **Second Reading** is a reputation, not an office. It is the

person a town will ask to sit beside the warden when a fall is rare, mixed, or argued. There is no Speaker with the last word, no Road-hand circuit, and no Cutting-leave desk. Those jobs belong to a faith that has a Tree to carry.

A town does not keep a Watcher the way it keeps a warden. The wood still wants watering, and that watering is the warden's. What a Watcher is for is accurate speech, and a night of matching the Tree's attention with their own. Lestrand can live without that. Threnmaieth cannot stop counting it.

They do not police the Mother-name in the street. They withhold it. The pressure they meet is a door-beam turned so its older face sits against the stone, and a roll that wants a name for the withheld word. That pressure is not a hunt.

If you meet one

A Watcher looks like a neighbour. You might meet a baker, a weaver, a Long-Lived person who copies texts, or one of the Kept who sits a quiet hearth. They do not wear a warden's mark, because that mark belongs to the warden. You know them because a neighbour said to ask the old room, or to send for the one who sat last year's mixed fall, or because you saw them under the Tree the night before Turning-Week with no lamp and no blessing.

They are useful the way a second opinion is useful. A town can live without them. A family that does not trust a single speaker on a strange leaf cannot.

Who knocks, and when

Who	Why they come	What the Watcher does	What they will not do
A household of the house	Turning-Week is coming, and a child needs the withheld line taught.	They sit at the hearth and make the child say what they saw last year, a neighbour's fall or a colour in the square, until the speech is accurate.	They will not teach the Tender's blessing, the warden's line, as the true one. A Masked Watcher will teach both, with the withheld line under the Tender's.
The family of a ten-year-old, after a rare or mixed fall	The warden Spoke one colour, the leaf looked like two, and the year will argue.	They sit beside the warden, or after, in the old room, and describe the stem, the serration, how the leaf turned, and whether the child flinched. They write it if asked. They file nothing unless Threnmaieth makes them.	They will not Speak. Description is not confirmation. If they saw two colours they will not say the Condition-names Two-Bodied or Answered. They will say the two colours.
A Struck person, or the people standing for one	The warden did the quiet receiving-rite, and the family wants a witness who will not call it a late gift.	They describe the threshold as a seeing at a harder door, they sit the rite, and they say the withheld line if they say anything.	They will not take the person to be acknowledged as Given. They will not rewrite a contract's terms, which is a Book-hand's work. They will not name anyone kin at a drowning-stone, which is a door-keeper's work.
A crown-clerk of Threnmaieth	The Night Watch needs a time on the festival roll, or a second reading needs a column.	They give the night, or the description, as counted dissent.	They will not call the withheld word a heresy they recant. A Bare Tree Watcher will not say *she* to make the docket cleaner.
Almost no one, most weeks	The week is ordinary.	They do their day job, sweep the old room, and keep the coats hung.	They will not invent a reason to be sent for. They are not a circuit.

An ordinary year

Eleven months of the year they are not on duty. They bake, they copy, they range, and they keep a stall. The house-work that still happens in those months is the teaching, the naming of what was seen, and the care of the old room.

They teach the withheld blessing at the hearth, the year a child turns nine. It has the same cadence as the Tender's line, and the Mother is not in it. This is how you can tell a Watcher household in a mixed street. The child can recite both lines, or will only recite one.

After any Turning they attend, they name what they saw. It is not a sermon. They sit with their own child, or with a neighbour's if they were asked, and they make the fall into accurate speech: the colour, the way the leaf came, and what the year will ask. Devotion, in this house, is the description. A sloppy Watcher is a bad Watcher.

They sweep the old room. If the house still has a recut beam, they keep the hidden face of that beam from rotting. They hang the Night Watch coats. In Threnmaieth they answer the clerk who wants to be told that the room is still a room.

They do not water the Tree. That is the warden-hearth. A Watcher who starts watching for blight has started doing the Orenhael's job.

The Night Watch

The night before Turning-Week is the eve of Eolthael, the high-solstice month, in a town that keeps the clergy's year. That is the night the Watchers keep a silent vigil at the town Tree. There is no blessing, no colour-reading, and no lamps if they can help it. The point is to be seen keeping the night.

This is not an office you are appointed to. A household that speaks the withheld blessing is expected to send someone. A town with three Watcher families may have six people under the boughs and no one in charge. A town with one old room under the chapel may have a single Long-Lived person who has kept the same night for eighty years. Both are the order, such as it is. They count the silences, not the hours. No one will explain this to a guest. A first-time sitter who asks how long is told, by whoever is already sitting, that they sit until it has been seen.

They do not officiate the Leaf-Fall the next day. The warden does that. They attend, because the practice is what binds them and because their children Turn, and they speak their own line when the Tender's blessing is said.

The Second Reading

Where a town will have it, a Watcher may sit a **second reading** of a rare or mixed fall. It is not authoritative over the warden. It is a witness alongside. They describe what they saw, and they do not confirm it. Confirmation is the town's word, and it belongs to the Speaking.

The hour runs like this.

1. The child is still under the boughs, or has just been walked to the warden-hearth, and the town is still there. The warden Speaks. Storm-grey, say.
2. If a household asked, or if the fall was mixed enough that the square muttered, the Watcher is already standing to the side, and they do not interrupt the Speaking.
3. They say what they saw, in the square or afterward in the old room: the stem, the serration, the turn, the flinch or the lack of one. They will use colour-words. They will resist Condition-names if the leaf was not one colour.
4. Most years the town nods at both accounts and goes to the fair. The child is called Two-Bodied because the warden Spoke that name, and also someone said there was amber at the edge, and that sentence lives in the family.

A Second-reader is simply the Watcher three streets will send for when the fall is argumentative. Neither a diploma nor a confirmation from the Seat is what makes them one. A Watcher may describe the same fall while the warden Speaks. Two Speakers, each with the last word, is the fight the First Seat will not permit, and the Watching does not ask for it.

In Threnmaieth they are a known column on the Threnhael. The second reading is tolerated as counted dissent, the night is tolerated as a festival-eve custom, and the withheld word is what the roll wants a name for.

What they carry

They carry almost nothing that looks like clergy. They keep a scrap for the description, plain paper and not a book, because a book would be a Settler's tool, and the Settlers are the Book-Hands. A coat lives in the old room and smells of last year's eve. In a Bare Tree household, where they will not say *she* at all, there is no Mother-mark on the door-frame. In a Masked one, where they will stand for the Tender's blessing and add the withheld line under it, the warden's mark is on the frame, and a second, older scratch sits underneath, where a clerk can miss it.

They have no stamp, no Cutting-leave, and no ticket, so they cannot licence a Stilled person and they cannot plant a Tree.

What they refuse

They will not Speak, and if a town has no warden that year they will still only describe, because a civic confirmation from a Watcher is the house breaking itself. They will not take a warden's mark. Their oldest rooms are in houses that never took one, and under the chapels built over those rooms. They will not police the Mother-name in the street. They withhold it. They will not travel as a circuit, because a Watcher in another town is a cousin visiting.

There is no chapter-house circuit. The order meets, when it meets, because Turning-Week gathers people who already keep the same night. What looks like organisation from the outside is the building itself: the house that never took a warden's mark, the beam that was turned to the stone when the chapel was re-floored, and the room under the nave where the Night Watch leaves its coats. The First Seat knows those rooms exist. It grew over them. It does not inventory them, except in Threnmaieth, where inventory is the local weather.

Who may keep the watch

Whoever will sit the night may keep it. A Kitsune hearth-child and a human neighbour keep the same night if they will sit it and speak accurately. Kind does not sort the watch, and the Watching has no chapter inside it that only one people may join.

Practice comes first. You are of the house when you keep the Night Watch and teach a child the withheld blessing. That belonging is older than the Motherfaith's. The withheld word is the dissent, and the standing at the Tree is the belonging.

The argument inside the house walks into the square. A **Masked** Watcher will stand for the Tender's blessing and add the withheld line under it, and a mixed town barely notices them. A **Bare Tree** Watcher will not say *she* at all. Both may sit a second reading. They will not always read the same fall the same way. That is the house arguing with itself in the square, which the square allows, and it is why they cannot present a single rival authority even if they wanted one.

A Condition, or the lack of one, may lean a person toward the night or the second reading. It does not close the door.

Act	Often	Why the Tithe (or the lack) fits	Also, and welcome
Night Watch	anyone of the house	The night does not care what you carry.	The Kept, who were seen as whole; the Struck, who were seen at a harder door
Second Reading	Long-Lived	The memory of how a rare fall looked last time does not fade.	A sharp Kept person; a Stilled person who will describe without flinching; a Wide-Hand Struck person who has seen a threshold-colour from the other side
Keeping an old room	families that never took a warden’s mark	The room under the chapel is inherited with the house.	A new household that refuses the warden’s mark

The feared and still licensed are not barred. A Stilled Second-reader is a comfort to a town that wants the room held still for accurate speech, and a fright to a pilgrim. They are rarer at the sacred centre than in an old district that never stopped being Haelthael. A Phoenix is not clergy here either. A Phoenix is a seeing no one in the square is ready to describe twice.

Struck Watchers must still be vouched anew, the way any Struck person must. The old rooms do not stand in for that witness.

How they live with the other houses

The warden officiates, the Watcher withholds a word, and the conflict stays local.

House	Everyday arrangement	The hard edge
the Tree-Wardens	They keep the same Tree and two blessings. The second reading sits alongside, not over.	Threnmaieth wants one name on the Threnhael. A Speaker who lets the withheld line stand is a column the crown can count, and two Speakers with the last word in one square is a fight.
the Fair Hand	They rarely share a square. A Settler hears “what falls, was seen” as a clause with no number on it.	Almost none, until a Bound person wants a second reading of an oath-day and a Watcher will not call that hour a signing.
the Old Ways	Two old memories, from opposite edges. A Watcher remembers a Before at the Tree, the older memory from before the Mother-name grew over the seeing. A door-keeper remembers a Before without a Tree.	They will not agree, and the argument can leave the table. The First Bowl, the guest-grove, is the ordinary room for it. A meal refused, a Night Watch held in an old green, and a Road-hand arriving in the middle are how it starts.
the Open Table	A Watcher who crossed the storm-wall would be a guest at supper, and would find the night already kept, for a different reason.	There is no Night Watch on Kumbaan. The fights that matter are already on the mainland.
the Reckoned Offices	They are the second column, counted dissent on the roll.	Tarvae files a description as error. Menirein wants the night scheduled. The old room refuses.

How they live in the three corners

It is the same house in each corner. What changes is the name, and the pressure.

Vaethorn (the night-kin). This is cousin-dissent in the Waiting Lands. The reach is thin and the faith is hot, and a Watcher household is unusual and not hunted. From a Hands-folk hearth the Night Watch looks like extra piety. The withheld Mother-name is the only sting, and a town that reads the Tree as a guest has larger fights, the grove among them, than this one.

Lestrand (vigil-folk, when named). They are rarely met. A Watcher on the docks is a scholar, or someone who came from the sacred centre. The signing-watch does not need a second reading, because the book is already the second reading. Faith is worn light enough that a withheld blessing is just another sentence on the quay.

Threnmaieth (the second column). This is where the pressure is heaviest. They are a known column on the roll, the Grown-Over, counted, and the crown does not hunt the households. The Night Watch is a festival-eve custom the crown can schedule. The second reading is tolerated until it contradicts the Speaker the Threnhael has already named. Laevila, a Long-Lived baker on Maiethlir's old extra-mile, the street where people still walk past what the local rite already gave them, still has the only copy of the beam from before it was recut. The pressure is a tolerated column on the roll, not a hunt.

The recut beam

They remember a cost, and they have no institution that can keep a beam from being turned to the stone.

The First Seat did not steal a throne from them. There was no throne. What was lost is quieter: a beam recut, a room under a chapel that is now a vestry, a second reading that remains alongside because the civic word was given to the warden when the Mother-name grew over the seeing. All of that can be described as history. It is also a choice, still being made, about whose speech counts in the square.

A second reading does not buy a seat, and the Grown-Over column stays a column. They have hold of the Before and of the cost. They do not have the last word on a colour. A settled Mother-name would not promote them.

They do not walk a queue of scions. That grievance belongs to the Orenhael. The one they live with is the recut beam.

Economy of the house

As a house, they have almost no money of their own, and that is how the practice stays a practice. Households keep the night, and the bread comes from the same table. There is no stipend, no Cutting-leave, and no share of a pilgrimage. A Second-reader eats as a neighbour. Some old districts leave a plate at the room under the chapel during Turning-Week, and that plate is courtesy, not a wage.

Threnmaieth has a tell. Being a column can become a living if a crown-clerk pays for a copied beam or a listed name. A Watcher who takes that coin has not left the house. They have let the roll furnish it. The Bare Tree branch will not eat with them. The Masked will, and they will argue after.

They point no one at a licence. They describe a fall. The halls, the greens, and the tickets belong to other houses.

A second-reading slip

This is a second-reading slip, written in a Watcher's own hand the morning after a mixed fall, and filed by a Threnmaieth Speaker under "alongside, not over." The Speaker's docket-mark is cleaner than the

slip.

> *Storm-grey at the stem, lamp-amber at the serration, and the child did not flinch when the leaf turned. I will not say Two-Bodied. I will not say Answered. I will say what I saw: the Tree looked twice and did not choose the easier colour. The warden Spoke storm-grey. I sat beside and said the amber. Both were seen. File me as the second column if you must. Do not file the amber as an error.*

The writer is a careful witness, a little stubborn, and useful to a clerk who needs a name for dissent. The slip's whole case is that seeing something is not the same as choosing it. The Speaker who filed it alongside was keeping the peace between the warden and the Watcher.

The Book-Hands

The Book-Hands are the working people of the Fair Hand, the faith that keeps an account fair enough that a person can walk away from it. Their own name for that faith is Leddoren. They are notaries who are also theologians. In the morning they may stamp a hull. In Turning-Week they stand with a child's private book. When a Struck person comes to the table, someone who Changed later, by drowning, by death, or by being taken, and who cannot live this year as the town is, they help that person find a payable year: a hall, a warrant, and someone who will stand. On oath-day they will recite a Bound person's Terms, the year's obligations already written down, where a neighbour can hear them. They will not change those Terms.

They have no seat and many tables. On Lestrand they are often the same people as the commercial clerks, and the faith is the profession, worn lightly. The house splits on one question, which is whether anyone sits across the table when a Bound person wants the clause itself changed. A Counterparty hand believes someone is there to be asked, and may sit and wait. A Book Alone hand does not believe the far side of the table is occupied, and will not sit that hour. Neither hand will rewrite the Terms, and neither will sell an easing. The house calls that other party, when it believes in one, the **Counterparty**.

People call them **Book-hands**, or **Settlers**. The rite writes **the Leddhael** (LEDD-hael), those who keep the account fair enough that you can walk. The Waiting Lands say **Bargainers' clerks**. The Ledger Coast says **the Settling-hands**, ordinary, the way a quay says notary. The Tallied Crown files them as **the Uncounted Book**. Private books offend the crown.

Shape of the order

The Fair Hand keeps guild-rooms and quay-shrines, and it does not keep a college in anyone's sacred wood. A high house in a rich port is the oldest book-room, old because the copies have piled up, not because that room can give the next quay leave to stamp. The next quay has its own table, and it does not write to the first for permission.

The faith is the profession. A Book-hand witnesses a signing, teaches a child to keep a book, and helps a Struck person settle a year that can actually be lived, which means a hall, a warrant, and a neighbour who will stand. On Lestrand the same person may stamp a hull before noon and recite a Bound person's oath-day after. The teaching of the house is the ethic of the stamp: fair terms, then walk. They copy a Bound person's Terms. They do not author them.

There is no membership roll. A roll of Book-hands would be a Threnhael sitting in a clerk's pocket, and the house will not make one. What makes you of the house is that you keep accounts honestly, and that you will die to keep a crown-clerk out of a personal book.

They sit at tables. They witness a signing and copy what was already written. They do not ride out, and they do not hunt hidden terms as an order of knights. The pressure they meet is the book that will not close.

If you meet one

On Lestrand a Book-hand looks like a clerk, ink-stained, with a small stamp on a cord and a table in a guild-room or in a quay-shrine the size of a pantry. Before noon they may witness a hull, and after that they may stand a Bound person's oath-day, and the sentence is the same both times: fair wind, fair term. You would not know which hour was the rite unless you already kept Leddoren.

Off the coast they are rarer, and they look more obviously religious, because a pilgrim-town sends for them when a Struck person cannot live this year, with no hall and no one to stand, while the Hands-folk of that town would rather walk the person to a Tree.

They are useful the way a notary is useful. A port cannot live without someone who will stamp a signing. The faith holds that the stamp on a contract and the record of a becoming are the same kind of account. In this house's book, the becoming is the colour and the Tithe written down beside what the year owes.

Who sits down, and when

Who	Why they come	What the Book-hand does	What they will not do
A ten-year-old's Settler household, at Turning-Week	The child Turned, or was Kept, and the personal book must open.	They stand as witness, not as petitioner. If they speak, they speak the signing-watch line. They enter the colour, or the hug if that is what was seen, and the Tithe, and what the year owes, and they put the book in the child's hands.	They will not speak the Tender's blessing. They will not call the colour a gift. They will not Speak the civic name. The warden does that, and the Book-hand copies what was seen into a private book.
Anyone with a contract	A marriage, a hull, or a year's closing.	They witness it, copy it, stamp it, and date it.	They will not hide a clause. Hidden terms are the house's one sin. They will not show a personal book to a crown-clerk.
A Bound person, on oath-day	The year's Terms must be spoken where a neighbour can hear.	They recite the Terms as already written, and they mark the civic book closed if the Tithe-year was paid, or owing if it was not.	They will not rewrite the Terms. That clause belongs to the Counterparty, not to a clerk, and they will not pretend a stamp can ease a Pledge, the payment the contract still holds over the person.
A Bound person who wants the clause changed	The Terms are killing them, and they have heard a clerk can fix it.	A Counterparty Book-hand may sit a petition-watch: they witness the ask, keep the book open, and wait, and if something answers they copy what was answered. A Book Alone hand will not sit that hour, because they do not believe anyone is across the table.	They will not dictate a new clause, and they will not sell an easing. Anyone who claims they can is a liar, or someone taking coin in a cellar.
A Struck person who is not Bound	They Changed later, and this town cannot	Civic settling: they find a payable year, which may be passage to a hall that exists, a warrant, or someone to stand for them.	They will not take the person to a Tree to be acknowledged as Given. They will not name them kin at a door. They will

Who	Why they come	What the Book-hand does	What they will not do
	house the Tithe.		not rewrite a Bound contract under this heading.
A child of the house, about nine	They must learn to keep a book before they Turn.	The child sits with a blank personal book, and together they enter colour, Tithe, debts, and what the year owes. The book is private. It is not the Threnhael.	They will not let a Reckoned clerk help copy it, and they will not teach the book as a census.
A Tithe-poor Settler	The year will not close, and they cannot stamp a fee.	Some stay and rewrite until the candle dies. Some mark *owing* faster. Both are of the house.	They will not furnish a venting-hall or a share of a green. They may write a term that assumes one. The Hall-Keepers and the Greens-Keepers own the hall and the lot.

An ordinary week on Lestrand

The morning is the commercial table. Hulls, marriages, copies, and a deathless house's instrument are paid by the stamp. A Kept clerk, one of Lestrand's free, who carries no Tithe and belongs to no guild and for whom the book is a choice, may do only this hour and still be of the house, if they keep accounts honestly and will die to keep a crown-clerk out of a personal book.

Turning-Week and the oath-days are the signing-watch. They attend the Leaf-Fall as witnesses, and they do not officiate. They stand at the edge of the square with a child's first book and wait for a colour they can enter. A Bound person's oath-day is the high holy day. The Terms are recited in a voice the quay can hear, and the year's book is closed or marked owing. The Motherfaith calls this showing off. The Fair Hand calls it the only honest worship.

When someone Changed last week, the work is civic settling, and it does not rewrite a god's clause. A drowning came back Far-Voiced in a town with no ael-hall, no hall where a carried feeling can go. A death came back Returned, a person who returned with a purpose the street will not house. The Book-hand finds a year that can be paid: passage, a warrant, a neighbour who will stand. If no one will stand, they write *owing*. The quay steps around. That is still the house's kindness and its cruelty. It is not a Bound person's Terms being edited.

On a Bound person's oath-day they recite what was already sworn, and they do not improve it. A Bound person who wants the clause itself changed is asking the Counterparty, not the clerk. The

honest house will witness the ask, or it will refuse to pretend that the clerk can answer. Anyone selling a new clause after the lamps is another table.

They never write the word *gift*, even as a loan. A first-year apprentice who copies *vael*, the word for a gift, into a personal book, in the line where *gift* would have stood, is made to strike it and write *grant*. No one calls this a rule. It is how the ink goes.

They do not cut grafts, tend Trees, or carry scions. A sickening Tree is a warden's crisis and a door-keeper's fight, and a Book-hand will only write the delay into a contract.

No Book-hand holds a last word over the others. If two Book-hands disagree on a clause, they write both readings and date them. The book holds both readings. That is not a split in the house. That is a book.

How civic settling actually runs

This hour is for a Struck person whose Tithe cannot be lived in this town. It is not for a Bound person's Terms. The house calls the settling a **novation**: the payable civic terms of a year, passage or a warrant or a seventh day, are written onto a year someone can pay. The Bound person's clause is never what gets rewritten.

1. The Struck person sits, and the Book-hand names what is already true, in the words the house uses: you carry a voice, or you carry a purpose.
2. They name what cannot be paid here, a hall that is not in this town, or a warmth no one will give.
3. They find a year a neighbour can see being paid, which may be passage to a release-house, a warrant, or a seventh day.
4. They find someone to stand for the person. The Book-hand is not themselves one of the three pillars a town will accept as proof, unless the Book-hand is Bound, Long-Lived, or Far-Voiced.
5. If that fails, the mark is *owing, not broken*. The civic book stays open, and the quay learns the name.

How a Bound petition-watch runs (if they sit it)

1. The Bound person speaks the ask, and the Book-hand writes the ask, not the answer.
2. They wait, and they do not invent a clause to fill the silence.
3. If nothing answers, they close the hour. The old Terms still stand, and the house was honest.
4. If something answers, they copy the new clause as heard. They do not improve the wording, and they do not take a fee for getting a better deal.

A Book Alone hand stops at the first step and sends the Bound person home. They will not play at a table they believe is empty. That is also honest.

What they carry

They carry a stamp that is personal, and it is not a guild-licence. The ticket that lets a guild work is a different paper, and it belongs to the Stillers, the Hall-Keepers, and the Element-Guilds. They carry ink, and a cord-knife for striking a line. They sell, or give, the small personal books to children of the house. Those books are not the Threnhael, and a clerk who confuses the two has started a fight. On a Bound person’s oath-day they have the year’s working contract in hand, and they read it aloud as written, not as improved.

A high house is a room with old copies and a better lamp. It is not a palace. The next quay does not write here for leave.

What they refuse

They will not show a personal book to the crown, and in their language a crown order that demands one is stealing a soul. They will not call a Leaf-Fall a gift, and they will not rewrite a Given child’s past so the child was always a debtor, because the book opens at the colour and does not invent an earlier debt. They stay at the table. They do not ride out, and they do not carry a scion. They will not keep a membership roll of Book-hands, because a roll would be a Threnhael, and they will not rewrite a Bound person’s Terms or sell an easing of a Pledge, because the clerk is not the Counterparty.

Who may keep a table

Any Kind may hold the stamp. A Selkie quay-child, sleek and cool-skinned, carrying a sealskin that can be worn or set aside, and a human clerk hold the same stamp if they keep accounts honestly. Leddoren has no chapter of seals and no notary reserved to one people.

Practice comes first. You are taken as a hand when you are apprenticed at a table, and you are confirmed when a quay has watched you through a year’s closings and at least one signing-watch. What you privately believe about whether anyone sits across the table, Counterparty or Book Alone, is the split inside the house, and it is not the hiring test. Both branches refuse hidden terms. That is enough to share a desk.

A Condition, or the lack of one, may lean a person toward the work. It does not lock the door.

Act	Often	Why the Tithe (or the lack) fits	Also, and welcome
Witnessing / teaching	Bound	Their book is a contract. The faith did not invent this. It made the contract legible.	The Unbound, people whose need is warmth and company, who have closed a year and will teach the closing; a Kept clerk, one of Lestrand's free
Novation of the Struck, the civic settling onto a year someone can pay	Bound; Wide-Hand Struck who have already settled	They have been on the far side of a bad term.	A Far-Voiced person who can make a feeling impossible to fake at the table
Oldest book-rooms	Long-Lived houses that endow a room	A century of fair copies is what makes a high house.	Anyone the port still comes to

The feared and still licensed are not barred. A Bound Book-hand is ordinary on Lestrand, and a problem for doctrine in the Motherwood, where a written Term sitting next to a gift-teaching looks, to a Speaker, like this house leaking in. A Stilled person at a table is rare and useful, because the room holds still for the clause. A Phoenix is not a clerk. There is no term that covers them.

Struck Book-hands must still be vouched anew. Civic settling is how the house helps that vouching, which is also how the house can pressure the person it settled. It still does not rewrite a Bound person's clause.

How they live with the other houses

House	Everyday arrangement	The hard edge
the Tree-Wardens	The Leaf-Fall is a festival and a signing-watch in the same week. On Lestrand they share a square and ignore each other's sentences.	The warden's gift and the Book-hand's debt meet over the same Bound person. A Bound warden is the seam, and a Bound Book-hand is this house at home.
the Watchers	They rarely share a square. "What falls, was seen" sounds, to a Settler, like a clause with no number on it.	A Bound person who wants a second reading of an oath-day meets a Watcher who will not call that hour a signing.
the Old Ways	A door-keeper names a Struck person kin at the door that made them, and a Book-hand settles the civic year at a table. Sometimes it is the same week and the same person.	The question is which name goes first, kin or payable year. It is two courtesies, not a trial.
the Open Table	A Settler who sits a moon-feast twice has been called kin in a language that keeps no book.	"No one is a stranger twice" is not a term in any book, and there is no Leddoren mission on Kumbaan.
the Holding Desk	One house works upstairs and the other downstairs. A Settler who marked *owing* has made a customer.	A clerk who follows a customer down the stair has started a case. The honest stamp and the hold do not share a docket, and a case about whether the person on the stool is still a person can start there.

How they live in the three corners

Lestrand (the Settling-hands). This is home, and here the faith is the profession. A high house is a proud old room on a rich quay, and it is still not a seat over the other tables. When a Tree sickens, the delay can be written into a contract, and on this coast a Cutting-leave can be brokered by the same people who close books. That brokering is Lestrand's sin among the wardens, and it belongs to the wardens' fee, not to a Book-hand's stamp, except in the hour when a clerk helps a waiting town write the delay. The Tithe-poor Settler who cannot close the book is still a person the rich city steps around, and the faith treats that step-around as part of the rite.

Vaethorn (Bargainers' clerks). On the pilgrim edge they are suspect, useful, and few. A Book-hand there is settling a Struck person's year in a land that would rather take them to a Tree to be

acknowledged as Given. The Hands-folk will eat with them if the year comes out kind. A Narrow-Hand preacher will not.

Threnmaieth (the Uncounted Book). Private books offend the Tallied Crown. A personal ledger that is not the Threnhael is, to a Reckoned clerk, a second seeing the crown does not hold. Book-hands here work quietly, or not at all, or as commercial notaries who have learned not to say *Leddoren* on a docket. A demand for a Settler's book is, in their language, stealing a soul.

The book that will not close

The house settles a person's year and closes the book. That is its kindness, and its cruelty.

Every civic settling that saves a Struck person who can pay is paid for, somewhere, by the Struck person who cannot. The Book-hand sees one table. The quay sees a step-around. A settled name for the Mother would not make that fading kind, and it would not turn a Bound person's clause into a clerk's draft.

Their other hard case is the Bound person they cannot help. A clerk who will not rewrite Terms will watch someone walk down the quay looking for a cellar that will lie to them. That cellar is the Holding Desk. The refusal to rewrite remains honest, and it is no longer a reason the clerk cannot follow. The week of upkeep sold off the books is the Slide. A witness sold for coin is the Standing Trade. Book-hands do not stamp those books either.

Economy of the house

The stamp is the living. On Lestrand a Book-hand is paid as a clerk is paid, by the signing, the copy, and the year's closing. The faith does not take a cut of the Tithe.

High houses endow rooms. Money that does not die likes a fair copy that will outlive a hull. That wealth is nearness to the quay, not a tax on Conditions, and it is why the oldest rooms sit on the richest quays.

Civic settling is badly paid. The Struck people who most need a hall and a warrant are the ones who can least stamp a fee. Some Book-hands stay until the candle dies, and some mark *owing* faster, and both are of the house.

They may write a term that assumes a venting-hall or a share of a green, and they do not furnish one, because the halls and the greens are other houses' work.

A civic settling

This is a civic settling, written by a Lestrand quay-hand the week after a drowning came back Far-Voiced and could not pay a singer’s Tithe in a town that had no ael-hall. The back has the old storm-terms of the year, struck through. Those struck lines are not a Bound person’s clause.

> *Grant: the voice, already carried. Old term: a hall that is not here. New term: one honest outlet each seventh day at the release-house in Greyhull, passage stamped, warrant by M. Senn the hull-clerk. If the seventh day is missed, the book is owing, not broken. Walk, if you can walk. If you cannot, the quay will not call it a gift.*

The slip is the house’s kindness: a storm-year’s terms rewritten so a person can live. “The quay will not call it a gift” is honest, and it is also how the quay steps around the person. Greyhull’s release-house will take the seventh day. The eighth week the passage-money fails, the slip will still be fair, and the person will still owe a book that does not close.

The Door-Keepers

The Door-Keepers are the working people of the Old Ways, the faith that still walks the land’s old doors. Their own name for that faith is Vaeloren. They have no seat in a city and no ladder of rank above them, because the land is the seat, and a person becomes a door-keeper when the district already treats them as one. For a famous one, that means three valleys will walk to them. A hill, a drowning-stone, a grove, or an oath-rock is the office they keep, and there is no mother-church that can overrule the door.

People call them **door-keepers**, and also **Kin-speakers**. The rite writes **the Vaelbren** (VAEL-bren), those who keep the land’s yield at the hearth. In the older sense, *vael* is what the land yields, a harvest and a returned child, and *bren* is the hearth. The Waiting Lands say **the door-folk**. The Ledger Coast says **grove-talkers**. The Tallied Crown files them as **the Unreached**.

They are the person three valleys walk to when someone needs to know which drowning-pool still returns and which grove still takes people in, and they are the person who names a Struck person kin at the door that made them, instead of walking them to a Tree to be filed as late.

Shape of the order

The Old Ways cannot have a mother-church, so the land stays the seat. A hill, a drowning-stone, a grove, or an oath-rock is the office, and a person is of the house when three valleys will walk to them,

not when a college confirms them.

Two jobs sit in the house, and they are often the same person. A door-keeper knows which doors still open and will walk them at the year’s hinges, the solstices, the equinoxes, and the local turns a city calendar does not print. A Kin-speaker speaks at the ancestor-meals, where a place is set for the ones in the ground, and names a Struck person kin at the door that made them. In a thin-reach district, where a warden may not come for a generation, this is one tired person. In a town that reads the Tree as a guest, that finally got a Tree and will still pilgrimage to it while walking the old doors, the two jobs may split for a generation and fold back into one person when the old one dies.

They are not Road-hands. They keep no queue and do no Speaking. A Road-hand carries a scion up the road. The Door-Keepers do not carry scions, do not confirm colours, and do not authorise a cut. When a graft sickens in an old green, they argue over who is host, not over the horticulture, and the Road-hands already walk that other job.

This is a house of land and kin. They do not police the Mother-name, and many of them also bring a child to a healthy graft when they can reach one. The pressure they actually meet is a grove both houses claim, and a Struck person the town has not vouched. That is a harder ordinary week than any holy war.

If you meet one

A door-keeper looks like someone who knows the district. There is mud on the hem, a worn token at the belt, and a sack that is sometimes food for a door and sometimes food for a meal. The token is a river-stone, a grove-twig, or a pinch of hill in a twist of cloth, and no two of them are alike. You would miss them as clergy if you came from Maiethorn looking for a chapel. You would find them if you asked who still walks the drowning-stone, or who will speak at the board for the ones in the ground.

They are useful the way a midwife is useful, except the birth they attend is a later becoming, someone who Changed at a door rather than a child just born, and the map they keep is which of those doors still open. A thin-reach town can live without a warden for a generation. It cannot live long without someone who remembers the water.

Who sends for them, and when

Who	Why they come	What the door-keeper does	What they will not do
Anyone in the district, at a year’s hinge	The doors have to be walked at Deep Solstice, the long night and the low year, at the equinoxes, at High Solstice, and at the local hinges a printed map leaves off.	They walk. They greet water, then hill, then stone, leave food, and ask to be known, not Given a Condition. They take the young one who carried the food last year.	They will not ask the door for a colour, and they will not skip a door because a Tree is healthier this year.
A household at an ancestor-meal	Someone has to know the names and keep the empty place at the board.	They speak the names, set the place, and do not let a guest sit in it. They eat, and if the household is going to argue Guest or First, that argument waits until the dishes are done.	They will not treat the empty place as a Returned person’s chair, because that is a different door, and they will not make the meal a chapel service.
A Struck person, or the people who found them	They Changed at a river, a grove, an oath-stone, or a death, and the town wants them vouched or gone.	They take them back to the door that made them, if it can be found, and name them kin. They feed them, and they walk with them if the town will not house them.	They will not walk them to a Tree to be acknowledged as Given. A warden may do that the same week, and the fight is which name goes first. They will not settle a civic year, because that is a Book-hand’s work. They cannot be a civic pillar unless they themselves are Long-Lived, Bound, or Far-Voiced.
A warden or a Road-hand	A graft in an old green is sickening, and someone already holds Cutting-leave.	They tend the wood as host, or as the keeper of a guest, and they demand the meal before a second cut.	They will not carry the next scion up the road, they will not sell a cut, and they will not call the Struck “unreached.”

Who	Why they come	What the door-keeper does	What they will not do
A scholar, a Lestrand clerk, a curious pilgrim	They want the older sense of *vael*, or they want a drowning-stone found.	They show the door, and they use the old word for the harvest and the returned child.	They will not give a map of every door. Some doors are walked, and not published.

An ordinary season

Most weeks, someone asks whether the pool below the ford still returns, and the door-keeper goes and looks. They know which grove took someone in ten years ago, and whether that hill is still a door, and when the hinge is close they carry food for it. Under the reputation they have a day life, ranging or tending green or keeping a stall, and the reputation sits on top of that life rather than replacing it. A famous door-keeper is simply the one three valleys will walk to. A young one is the apprentice who carried the food last year and was watched doing it.

The walk is not only High Solstice and Turning-Week. They also walk Deep Solstice, both equinoxes, and the local hinges a Maiethorn calendar does not print, the first flood and the night the hill-ice breaks. They walk the old doors of the district and greet them water, then hill, then stone, and they will not say why that order is the one they keep. A guest who reverses it is corrected, and nobody turns the correction into a sermon.

At the meal there is a place at the board for the ones in the ground, and the hour is quiet and domestic. The Kin-speaker is the one who knows the names. In a thin-reach district this is the same tired person who walked the ford at dawn.

When someone Changed later, they do not start at the Tree. They start at the door: the river if it was water, the grove if it was green, the oath-stone if it was a vow, and the death-place if it was unfinished work. There they name the person kin. The Motherfaith’s quiet receiving-rite, the one that can acknowledge the same person as Given, may happen the same week, and a Book-hand’s novation may happen the same month. It is three courtesies, not a trial. The hard case is the Struck person the town will not house. The door-keeper has a name to give and not a civic pillar to stand on, unless they themselves are Long-Lived, Bound, or Far-Voiced, so they may spend a season walking with one person, and they may not be able to.

If the town has a healthy graft, they tend it as a guest in the grove. They may Turn under it. They will not pretend the graft was what invented becoming.

How a kin-naming actually runs

1. They find the door, if it can be found. If it cannot, they use the nearest old door of the same kind, water for a drowning and green for a taking. A door that is only a Tree is a last resort, and a First-reading walker, one who keeps the old doors first and will not take the Tender’s blessing, will hate it.
2. Food comes first. The door is greeted, and the person is not tested with a colour.
3. The Kin-speaker says the name the person already had, and then the kin-name the door is owed. There is no leaf and no stamp. The token at the belt is shown, not given, unless this person will walk next year, in which case they will find their own.
4. The town, if it is watching, still wants a warrant before it lets them stay. The kin-name is a courtesy, and standing-for, someone the town trusts saying who the person is, is the civic act beside it. A door-keeper who is also Long-Lived, Bound, or Far-Voiced can do both, and most cannot.

The contested grove

An ailing graft in an old Taken-In green is the fight people know this house by, and you can see the shape of it from the path. It is warden against door-keeper, guest against host, and the scarcity that sends people on pilgrimage set against the old answer, which is that the grove already had ways. Both are neighbours who love the wood.

For an hour their hands do the same work. They water, they watch the blight, and they sit up with wood that can still die. What they are arguing about is not the care of the wood, but whether this Tree is a guest in the grove or a Tree the town failed. A Guest-reading Kin-speaker will go on pilgrimage and still walk the doors, and will tend a dying graft as kin. A First-reading door-keeper will tend the same graft as a guest in their house and still refuse the Tender’s blessing. Both revere the Struck and the Taken-In. A reading that starts pitying them as “unreached” has already become Motherfaith, and this house will not use that word.

If a Road-hand arrives with Cutting-leave, the door-keeper’s job is the meal first, and then the question of whether this grove receives a guest. They do not carry scions.

What they carry

They carry the token from their door, a river-stone or a grove-twig or a pinch of hill, and they carry food for the walk. They carry names in the head, the ones in the ground and the doors that still open. They do not carry a stamp, a colour-book, or Cutting-leave.

What they refuse

Confirming a colour is not their work, and neither is officiating a Leaf-Fall. If they bring a child to a healthy graft, the warden Speaks. They will not carry a scion, and they will not sell a cut. They will not call the Struck or the Taken-In "unreached," because that word is the Motherfaith leaking into a house that does not use it. Some doors they will walk and will not publish, so a curious clerk does not leave with a map of every one. They will not become priests of the undeath. An ancestor-meal is for kin who remained in the ground, and the Returned are a different door.

Who may keep a door

Any Kind may keep a door. A Tengu ridge-child, lean and sharp-featured, with dark feathers through the hair and down the arms, and a human neighbour walk the same stone if they know it and will stand for kin. Vaeloren has no chapter only the ridge-folk may join, and no grove-guard that only the Taken-In may enter. The Taken-In are revered here. Reverence is not a membership test.

Practice comes first. You are taken as a walker once you have carried the food, been watched at a meal, and earned three households that will send for you. What you believe about the Mother, whether you read her as Guest or as First, is secondary to that practice. Many Kin-speakers also bring a child to a healthy graft when they can reach one.

A Condition, or the lack of one, leans a person toward the walk they already know. It does not bar the others.

Act	Often	Why the Tithe (or the lack) fits	Also, and welcome
Walking the doors	the Taken-In	They are the grove's own children, and a green Tithe lived in an old green is what already fits the walk.	Two-Bodied people, for whom the walk is a ranging, and the Kept, for whom a closed door was weather rather than a slight.
Naming the Struck kin	Struck door-keepers	They have been through a door with no warden waiting on the other side of it.	A Wide-Hand warden who will share the week, and a Bound person whose oath-stone is the door.
Ancestor-meals	anyone of the house	The dead stay in the ground, which is not the Returned's door.	A Returned guest is a different door. The Kin-speaker is not their priest.

The feared and still licensed are not barred. A Taken-In door-keeper is ordinary on Heskoren and an embarrassment in a Narrow-Hand sermon, the sermon that will call the Struck "not hers." A Phoenix is not a walker. There is no old door that answers to white-fire.

Struck door-keepers must still be vouched anew. Naming them kin is the house's courtesy at that seam, and it is not a substitute for the three pillars a town still wants, the Long-Lived, the Bound, and the Far-Voiced, before it lets someone stay. The town may still want a warrant.

How they live with the other houses

House	Everyday arrangement	The hard edge
the Tree-Wardens	A healthy graft is kept as a guest. Guest-reading Kin-speakers go on pilgrimage and still walk the doors. Vaethorn's Hands-folk find the missing seat infuriating and, in a dry year, quietly useful.	A Tree sickening in an old grove raises the question of who is host, and both houses are neighbours who love the wood. A Narrow-Hand preacher calling the Struck "not hers" is the person they will not eat with.
the Watchers	They are two old memories on opposite edges, the Before sat at the Tree and the Before sat without one.	They will not agree on the Before, and neither will give way. The First Bowl is the ordinary room for that disagreement. It starts when a meal is refused, a Night Watch is held in the green, or a Road-hand arrives in the middle of it.
the Book-Hands	A kin-name and a set of rewritten civic terms can land on the same Struck person in the same month.	The hard edge is which name goes first. They stay two courtesies, not a trial.
the Open Table	Ancestor-meals and a place set for the dead look, to a traveller, like cousins of the extra seat. They are not. The dead in the ground are not the unseen hands that fetch and pour.	The Door-Keepers walk no doors on Kumbaan. There is no Vaeloren mission on the isle.

How they live in the three corners

Vaethorn (the door-folk). This is home ground, and it is where the fight stays live. The warden is most of the state a town can see, and the door-keeper is the older state the land still keeps. Towns that read the Tree as a guest, and that finally got one, did not throw their grandparents out of the rite. They go on pilgrimage to the Tree, and they still walk the old doors. In the First-reading districts, where a scion still will not take, they tend the dying guest and they refuse the blessing. What they are up against is the Waiting Lands' habit of reading a scarce gift as unworthiness, while the Hands-folk

hearth stays a neighbour’s house. A closed door is weather, something the land does, and it is neither a slight nor a verdict that the town was unworthy.

Lestrand (grove-talkers). On this coast a door-keeper is a curiosity from the frontier. One on the docks is a migrant or a story. The Settling will stamp a Struck person’s terms and call the kin-name poetry. The house is useful if someone needs a drowning-stone found. It is not a rival for the quay.

Threnmaieth (the Unreached). The crown files them as a gap, people who were not at a proper Tree, and doors the roll cannot name. A Kin-speaker in the core is rare enough that a crown-archivist finds the rarity interesting, and the census wants a column to set them in. The land will not become that column. What follows from the want is pressure, and it is not a hunt.

The host of a dying guest

Someone has to decide whether a sickening graft is a guest in the grove or a Tree the town failed.

The Road-hand arrives with leave and with a case about the soil. The door-keeper arrives with grandparents and with food. Both of them can be right about the wood. The years the grove spends arguing are years in which children walk to a neighbour’s canopy, and the children who make that walk are Kept-heavy and Struck-heavy. The frontier already knows that mix as weather, the ordinary way of a thin place, and Vaethorn will sanctify the same mix as unworthiness if no one says otherwise.

Their complaint is not a queue. It is who is host, and who will stand for the Struck person the town will not. A healthy Tree in the grove would not change which wood came first, and it would not make a closed door into a slight. The grievance stays where they left it. The grafts are late, and the Motherfaith did talk as if becoming were new.

Economy of the house

A door-keeper eats at the boards they speak for. There is no stipend from a seat. A famous one is housed because three valleys would be ashamed not to house them.

They hold no Cutting-leave and they charge no fee, because they do not sell wood. If a town that reads the Tree as a guest wants a scion, that coin goes to the Seat, not to the Kin-speaker. A First-reading district that pays for a Cutting-leave and still refuses the blessing is doing both courtesies at once, and the argument about it will start after the work is done.

Standing for the Struck is unpaid. The people who most need a kin-name are the ones a town will not house. Some door-keepers spend a year on one person, and some cannot, and both are of the house.

Garden-commons and ranging-commons belong to other houses. A Taken-In door-keeper may live in a green without holding any licence over it.

Left tied to an ailing graft

Someone left this tied to an ailing graft in an old Taken-In green, the week a Road-hand's cart was seen at the ford. Two hands, and one knife-cut for the string.

> *The tree is young. The grove is not. We have fed it as a guest and we will feed it still. If you have come with leave, come to the meal first. If you have come with a second cut in mind, know that the hill already yielded a child this year and does not owe you a colour. We will not let either wood pretend it was first.*

The writer is polite and a little barbed, and the note takes a saying from a drowning-stone and sets it on a trunk. The house's case is that becoming happens at doors where there is no healthy Tree. The Road-hand who eats first will plant as a guest. The one who cuts without the meal will be remembered as a claiming, and the wood may still take.

The Table-Keepers

The Table-Keepers are the working people of the Open Table, the faith kept on Kumbaan, the Sundering Isle. Their own name for that faith is Ndeyaan. They are the hill-hosts, and they are almost not clergy. When the faith travels at all, it travels as a Yumboe, one of the small pearl-pale people of the isle, keeping an attic abroad, and that happens rarely. The storm-shore is a different job on the same isle, and the Shore-Sitters are the ones who keep it.

On the mainland people say **table-keepers**, and also **hill-hosts**. Their own name is **the Njaalo** (NJAH-lo), a Yumboe coinage in the night-keeping tongue, "the hall that is kept." It is not a Maiethren word, and this house owes the liturgy nothing. Sailors say **moon-hosts**. Vaethorn has them as a sailor's tale. Lestrand says **the Moon-Feast people** when a quay wants a story. Threnmaieth does not file them. They are off the map.

They are the person who opens the hall, or the attic, and lays an extra place. On Kumbaan that is how a valley eats and how a stranger becomes kin. On the mainland it is one room, one supper, and a sentence that will not travel past the door.

The faith's quarrel is two sittings set against a Turning-witness, which is belonging because a town watched you Turn, and it is also a tenth-year week that a host will not spend walking a child to a Tree. What follows is the table itself: who is fed, what the host refuses, and what they carry.

Shape of the order

Ndeyaan is almost not an order. It has no chapel, no college, no authority over colours, no graft, no book, and no door-walk that wants a title. The person whose hall the valley comes to on the bright nights is a table-keeper, and that is reputation rather than an office. When they die, the valley comes to the next hall that still sets the extra place.

There is one job, and there is no second office to be promoted into. The table-keeper keeps the table, lays the extra place, and on the second sitting says that no one is a stranger twice. That sentence is the whole of the work.

There is no seat across the sea, and there is no mission. A Yumboe who wants a hill-hall on Strandoren, the harbour continent west of Maiethorn, keeps Ndeyaan in whatever room they have, and they do not send for a scion, a stamp, or a Night Watch. The mainland does not send wardens to Kumbaan. The storm-wall, the weather and reef that close the isle, is the boundary.

This is a hospitality-house. It is not a bargain struck with a fairy, and it is not a guild of one Kind. The unseen hands fetch and pour as part of the hall, and you can see the cups move. They are not a binding laid on a guest, and sitting the table does not put a guest in debt. A human who has sat twice and will lay the place is of the table. A Yumboe who will not is just a neighbour who sleeps through the bright night. The house takes people by who will keep the table, not by the people they were born as.

If you meet one

On Kumbaan a table-keeper looks like the person whose hill-hall the valley already knows. The hall a traveller can actually sit in is Ndenjoo, one of the Paps, and the host there is Njunda (NJOON-dah). They are small, pearl-pale, and silver-haired if they are Yumboe, and most are, because that is who lives there, and they open the door on the bright nights. By mainland noon they are often asleep. You would not call them a priest. You would go to their hall when the moon is up because that is where the food is and where a stranger is allowed to sit.

On the mainland they look like one person in a rented room who still sets a place no body will use. A sailor finds them by asking for the Moon-Feast. A clerk finds them by following a rumour and then files them as a guest. They cook, they pour, and on the second night they say the sentence.

They are useful the way a host is useful. They do not water Trees, stamp books, or walk drowning-stones. If you came for those jobs you have the wrong house.

Who comes, and when

Who	Why they come	What the table-keeper does	What they will not do
The valley, on a bright night (Kumbaan)	The moon is up, and the hall is where you eat.	They open the hall and lay the extra place slightly back from the board, not at the end. They let the unseen hands fetch and pour. They sing, and they sleep when the moon is down.	They will not read a colour, they will not test a guest, and they will not omit the extra place.
A stranger who crossed the storm-wall	They have already been through drowning-water, and they need a seat.	On the first night they are a guest, and a guest is already sacred. The host feeds them and learns a name if they offer one. On the second night the host says no one is a stranger twice and treats them as of the table.	They will not make the guest Turn. They will not ask what the guest is. They will not sell the sentence as a proverb.
Anyone at an ordinary supper	The extra place is every meal that matters, not only the feast.	They set it, and a poor house still sets it. The hands are what make the extra place possible.	They will not count the household as only the bodies you can see. That is the one impiety.
A guest on the mainland, in an attic	They heard of a Moon-Feast, or they are hungry, or they are curious.	The same two sittings happen in a smaller room. The host feeds them, says the sentence on the second night, and treats them as kin inside the room.	They will not walk the guest to a warden to be filed as belonging. They will not stamp a book. They will not collect coin for a hall across the water.
A rare Struck person on the isle	A drowning, a death, or a green taking, uncommon enough to be family news.	They feed them and keep them in the household. They are not treated as a class apart.	They will not invent a mainland receiving-rite, and they will not send them to a Tree that is not there.
A warden, a Book-hand, or a Watcher who crossed	They came by courtesy, by curiosity, or because someone brought them.	They are a guest. They get a first night and a second night. The host will find their noon-faith loud.	They will not be given a Tree to tend, a book to stamp, or a Night Watch to keep. There is nothing here for those jobs.

A bright night on Kumbaan

At dusk the table-keeper opens the hill-hall, often because it was their grandmother’s, and often because it was the only roof that still fitted the crowd. Njunda opens Ndenjoo for both of those reasons. People arrive as the moon clears the Paps. The extra place is already set, slightly back and a little apart, and the unseen hands begin to fetch and pour, so that you can see the cups move. There are songs, and there is no reading of a colour and no reciting of terms. A Staying host says the dead’s names when the dead fill that place. A Serving host does not say the names, and still fills the place, and calls the hands the hill’s own courtesy.

In that hour the table-keeper opens, sets, and greets, keeps the extra place from being used as a spare stool, and sends a child for more bread if the hands have not already gone. If someone is sitting their second night, the host says the sentence. When the moon goes down the table-keeper sleeps. Daylight is not a fallen hour in this house. It is the time they keep for rest.

On one night of the moon sailors call Yoltal, Ndenjoo eats the heel of the loaf first. Every other night the heel is last, or it goes to the goats. The valley says the hands like the crust when the mainland is loud. Njunda will not correct that, and will not say it is the reason. They will not say why. A guest who asks is given more bread.

They do not confirm becoming, and there is no Leaf-Fall on the isle. They do not vouch a Struck person in the mainland sense. Struck people are rare enough here to be a family matter, not a class. They do not licence anyone, they do not graft wood, and they do not file a person onto a roll.

An ordinary supper

The extra place is not only furniture for the feast. A poor house lays it on a quiet night. To omit it is the one real impiety, not because the people the place is kept for starve, since they do not, but because you have counted the household too small. The hands make this possible. That is not a metaphor the hall uses. It is why a table-keeper can host beyond their means without becoming a charity for Tithes.

A child of the house learns the work by carrying dishes and by being told not to sit in the extra place. That is the apprenticeship. There is no Seat to confirm it.

An attic on Lestrand

A Yumboe on the mainland is a table-keeper by necessity. At morning, which is their night’s end, they may work a quay kitchen, or mend, or copy, and they pay the rent in the local coin. In the evening they lay the extra place in a room that fits four. Someone climbs the stair. On the first night that person is a guest. On the second night the host says the sentence and means it. The quay will not file the guest as a citizen. The host will still set them a place on the third night.

This is how the faith travels, when it travels at all. It does not travel as a mission. There is no Njaalo chapter-house, no collection taken up for one, and no Road-hand of the moon. A second Yumboe in the same city may share a supper and not share a roof, and both of them are of the table. A mainlander who has sat twice and opened their own room is of the table too.

The second sitting

The first night you are a guest, and a guest is already sacred. The second night you are of the table. On Kumbaan this is how a stranger becomes kin, nearly law, in all but parchment. On the mainland the same supper collides with citizenship by witness, because there you belong when your town watched you Turn, not because you ate twice.

A table-keeper who treats the second supper as belonging is doing their faith honestly. A warden who smiles and files them as a guest is doing theirs. Neither is a villain. The sentence does not cross the storm-wall intact. The host's job, abroad, is to keep the sentence inside the room and not pretend the clerk will honour it.

What they carry

They carry an extra plate, the songs, and the sentence. On the isle they have a hall, inherited, or simply the one that still fits the crowd. On the mainland they have the rent and whatever the room will hold. They do not carry a stamp, a token from a land-door, a colour-scrap, or Cutting-leave.

The extra place is set slightly back from the board, not at the end of it. A mainlander who puts the plate at the foot, "for a servant," is corrected without a sermon, and the plate is moved.

What they refuse

They will not read a colour, tend a Tree, or keep a Night Watch, and they will not turn the sentence into a Fair Hand term or into a binding, because the words are eat, and be the household, not sign, and owe. They will not test a guest. The storm-wall already did. They will not send a mission, collect for a hall across the water, or plant a Moon-Feast chapter in Vaethorn, and they will not omit the extra place in order to look poorer or more devout. That omission is the one impiety.

Who may keep a table

Kind is not the test, and that courtesy is already the faith. A mainlander who sits once is a guest, and a mainlander who sits twice is kin. A human, a Selkie, or a Kitsune who will lay the extra place is of the Njaalo. A Yumboe who will not is not.

Practice comes first. You are a table-keeper when the valley, or the attic stair, comes to you and you set the place. No Seat confirms an apprenticeship. A child who has carried dishes on the bright nights is being watched, and a mainland convert who has sat twice and opened their own room is being watched by whoever they fed.

The argument inside the house does the dishes. A **Staying** host will say the dead's names. A **Serving** host will not, and will call the hands the hill's own courtesy. Both of them set the extra place, and both of them pass the same cup. The argument is for after the meal.

On Kumbaan a Condition barely leans the work at all, because there are no Given Conditions on the isle. Elsewhere, the life that fits the table often keeps it. The table still seats the others.

Act	Often	Why	Also, and welcome
Hill-hall on the isle	whoever inherited the hall	There are no Given Conditions on Kumbaan, and the Kind is Yumboe because that is who lives there, not because the order requires it.	A rare Struck person who still hosts, and a mainlander who stayed after the second sitting.
Attic on the mainland	a Yumboe abroad, by necessity	They are still keeping Ndeyaan with whatever table they can make.	A mainland convert who sat twice, and a Kept clerk who likes the night better than the Tree.
Laying the extra place	anyone of the table	The one impiety is omitting it.	The poor house, as much as the deep-hill hall.

The feared and still licensed are not barred, and they almost never arise on the isle. A Phoenix is not a host the Njaalo have a rite for. A Bound person who sits twice is kin, and their Terms are not a grace said over the plate. The Open Table does not use the Fair Hand's terms and debts.

Struck table-keepers on the mainland must still be vouched anew if they want to stay in a town. The second supper will not satisfy a clerk who wants a Turning-witness. That collision is the ordinary weather of the house abroad, and it is not a failure of the hospitality.

How they live with the other houses

House	Everyday arrangement	The hard edge
the Tree-Wardens	A warden who crosses the storm-wall is a guest at supper, and there is still no Tree to tend. On the mainland they already share the same landings, a quay, an attic stair, a tenth-year list.	The host will not walk a child of the table to a Tree, and the warden will. That Given-door is one week. There is no mission-chapter on Kumbaan and no moon-warden, and the fight is in the port.
the Watchers	A Watcher who crossed would find the night already kept, and kept for a different reason.	There is no Night Watch on the isle.
the Book-Hands	A Settler who sits twice has been called kin in a language that has no book.	The sentence is a courtesy, not a term.
the Door-Keepers	Ancestor-meals and a place set for the dead look like cousins to a traveller, and they are not, because the dead in the ground are not the unseen hands.	The Door-Keepers walk no doors on Kumbaan.
the Shore-Sitters	They are the sister house. They sit the storm-beach, and a living wreck is walked uphill rather than seated on the sand.	A table-keeper does not go down to the beach to wait. The sand is where someone decides who is alive, and the hall is where someone decides who is kin.

How they live in the three corners (and off the map)

The three corners barely reach this house.

Kumbaan (hill-hosts). This is home. The Njaalo is simply whoever opened the hall. They keep the moon, not the solstice, and wholeness is the default, the way people already are when nobody is waiting to be chosen. There is no queue, no roll, no book, and no second reading of a person.

Lestrand (the Moon-Feast people). On this coast the house is a quay-story, and an attic-host is a curiosity who also sets a good supper. Sailors print “no one is a stranger twice” as a proverb on a card. The Settling will not enforce that card. The attic-host will enforce the sentence inside the room, and cannot enforce it past the door.

Vaethorn (a sailor’s tale). The faith here runs hot and the reach of the Trees runs thin, so a table-keeper is a wonder if they ever arrive, and a test of how a household that reads the Tree as a guest

treats a guest. They will be fed. They will be asked about the Mother. They will not understand why a people need to be chosen in order to be wanted.

Threnmaieth (off the map). They are not on the roll. A Yumboe in the sacred centre is a diplomatic incident of manners, not a column the crown can fill. The crown cannot file a people who were never at a Tree. That is a relief and a slight at once.

The sentence that will not travel

On Kumbaan, the second sitting is how you belong. On the mainland, you belong because a town watched you Turn.

The host who treats the second supper as kin-making is keeping Ndeyaan, and the warden or the clerk who files that same person as a guest is keeping a different grammar of belonging. The sharper clock is Turning-Week. A child of the table is in it, the host will not walk them to a Tree, a neighbour will, and a door shuts on the last day of Eolthael.

Treating the Moon-Feast as a romance is itself a slight. They have no queue of scions and no mission, and an attic-host is one person at an ordinary supper, with no authority outside the room. That is enough.

Economy of the house

On Kumbaan the hall is the living. A table-keeper is fed by the same feast they host, and the unseen hands are what make a poor house’s extra place possible. There is no stipend, no Cutting-leave, and no share of a pilgrimage.

An attic pays its rent in the local coin. A Yumboe abroad works as anyone works. They are not a charity-order, and they are not part of the halls and greens that furnish a Tithe, so they may cook for a quay and still will not furnish a venting-hall.

There is no collection for a hall across the water. That collection would be a mission, and there isn’t one.

A place-card

This is a place-card, badly copied by a Strandor sailor who did come back, and sold on a Lestrand quay as a dinner-grace. The back is the sailor’s own hand: “for luck at second sitting.”

> *We have counted you. Sit. If you have a name we have not learned it yet; if you have a colour we have no tree to read it. The moon is enough light. Eat, and be the household. —*

> *and if you sit again, you are not a stranger. This is not a proverb. Do not sell it as one.*

The card is a hospitality blessing, and the quay's copy has already half-ruined it. The sailor thought it was a grace. On the isle the same words are how you belong, a legal sentence in all but parchment. The last two lines were added by the table-keeper when she saw him copy the blessing, and he sold them anyway. Lestrand files the Njaalo as a Moon-Feast story, lucky if you eat twice. The woman in the attic still sets the place.

The Shore-Sitters

The Shore-Sitters are a second house on Kumbaan, small, and not an order of the mainland. The Table-Keepers are the ones who open the hall. The Shore-Sitters sit the storm-beaches. Almost no one reaches the isle, and someone has to be there on the sand when someone does. They share the faith of the Open Table, and the beach is their part of it.

People call them **shore-sitters**, and also **wall-waiters**. Their own name is **Njawaal** (njah-WAHL), a Yumboe coinage, "the sitting at the wall." It is not a Maiethren word. Table-keepers call them **the first night**, and the joke is half a joke: a wreck is not yet kin.

They sit the storm-shore with their back to the hill-hall and wait. They do not swim the wall, they do not test anyone with a colour, and if someone is still breathing they walk them uphill to a table.

If you meet one

You meet a small person on a bad beach, with the lamp hooded so it does not call ships in. They look as if they have been there a long time, and they will not wade. They will take a living mainlander by the sleeve and start the path up. If the house leans Staying, they will name a drowned body, and if it leans Serving, they will not name the body, and either way they still carry it above the tide. Below Ndenjoo, the person the valley knows on that sand is Soonke, who decides whether a wreck is alive to be walked up. Njunda, at the hall, decides whether that person is kin.

You would not call them a priest. You would find them if you asked who sits the black sand when the wall is loud.

What they actually do

On the nights that matter, which are storm nights, wreck-moons, and the weeks after a rumour of a crossing, they sit. If a stretch of coast is kept at all, one person keeps it, and the claim is reputation

rather than a roster.

A living person gets water and a blanket, and nobody asks what Kind they are or what colour they carry. A dead person is carried above the tide. Cargo is whatever the hall can use. They do not loot it for a market, because there is no quay to sell it from.

The living are walked uphill to a table-keeper. The first night, the night a newcomer is only a guest, starts at the hall and not on the sand. The shore-sitter is the reason there was a first night at all.

They will not swim the wall, and they do not keep a boat for rescue, because the wall is not a door they walk. A mainlander who asks why no one came sooner is told that they do not call the sea, and that they wait.

They do not keep the extra place. That plate is the hall's work. They do not Speak a colour, stamp a book, or walk the old doors of the mainland, and they do not send anyone back across the wall.

Who comes

Almost no one comes, and they treat that emptiness as part of the faith rather than as a failure of the watch. A shore-sitter's year may pass with an empty beach, and the job is still to sit. When someone does come, the whole valley hears it as news, not as a line on a shipping schedule.

How they sit with the table-keepers

They keep the same faith and do two different jobs, so the shore is where someone decides whether the person is alive, and the hall is where someone decides whether the person is kin. A shore-sitter who starts laying the extra place on the sand has started doing the table-keeper's work, and a table-keeper who walks the black sand every storm has started doing this one. Both of those crossings can happen in a thin year, when there are not enough people to keep the jobs apart. Most years the two jobs are still held by different people.

Said to a sailor who did come back

This was said to a sailor who did come back, the night before he was walked uphill. Someone copied it later as a quay-story, and copied it badly.

> *We did not fetch you. The wall does not owe you a hand. Sit until you can walk. If you walk, there is a hall. If you do not, we will still take you off the sand. Do not thank the sea. It was not kind. We were only here.*

The sitter sounds cold, and the message is plain. They did not fetch the sailor, the wall owes nobody a hand, and what he got was a wait rather than a rescue. They do not say the crossing was a gift, and they do not say it was a pilgrimage the Mother arranged.

The Slide

The Slide is the illegal supply of what a Tithe needs. A Tithe is the upkeep a person owes for what they have become, and it has to be met or the failure shows in public. The Slide is not a fifth faith, not clergy, and not a copy of the Book-Hands. They do not help a person pay a Tithe. They step in when a person starts to fail, and they make the failing last.

Everyday speech calls them **the Slide**, and also **week-keepers**. In the cant of the trade they are **the Vaethledd** (VAETH-ledd), the waiting, reckoned. The Waiting Lands say **the last pot**, and when the commons have run out a pious neighbour may still say *gift-credit*. The Ledger Coast says **week-rent**. The Tallied Crown files nothing, because the roll already has a counted hall. A clerk who knows will say **the late week**.

What they rent is not falling, sold as one week of green, or one outlet, or one new page, and they are never in a hurry to let you get free.

Shape of the house

This is a practice, not a gang. There is no seat, no colour, no roster, and no liturgy in a cellar. You are of the Slide when someone comes back next week, and that return is the whole of the reputation. When a keeper dies, the book of weeks goes to whoever still has a pot, a room, or a key.

They have one job. They furnish just enough of what the Tithe needs that the person does not become a public hazard, and never enough that the person recovers. The product is the week, and the price of that week is remaining theirs.

They think they are in a rent story, so they do not call themselves monsters. They extend, they keep a book, and they will tell you they kept someone whole. That is what makes them neighbours: a kind face, a real key, and a measured withhold later.

They are not clergy, and they are not the official doors. They do not stamp books, Speak colours, walk old doors, or open a hill-hall. They do not run the town greenhouse, the counted ael-hall, or a licence-guild. Those doors are the ones that make a person wait. On ordinary days the guilds pretend not to know these people. When an official gate closes on purpose, the pretence is over, because the guild and the Slide are then serving the same street.

If you meet one

They look like a landlord, or like a cousin who still has a pot after the commons ran dry, or like a junior clerk at a deathless house, a long-house kept by the Long-Lived, who will extend a novelty subscription one more week. They may be a person with a spare room and a voice who will let you cry there, for a price that is never quite coin.

You would not call them a priest. You would find them if you asked who still has green when the leaf-lot is closed. A leaf-lot is a strip of living green let by the season, and when it is shut, someone still has a pot.

They are useful the way a week is useful. If you came for a stamp, a colour, or a false childhood, you have the wrong house.

Who comes, and when

The people who come are already late. A Taken-In person needs living green, and without it they wilt. A Far-Voiced person needs somewhere for feeling to go, and without it a Cry, that feeling breaking loose, breaks into the street. A Long-Lived person needs something new, and without it they fade. The other needs are warmth, civic coin, a purpose that does not pay, or a family trying to keep the square from seeing any of this. The week-keeper rents the missing piece and stops short of a cure.

Who	Why they come	What the week-keeper does	What they will not do
A Taken-In person cut off from land	The queue for a green is longer than the wilt. The people in that queue were Given at a city Tree and never left, or they are harvest-hands who wintered, or they work the lot and cannot save the cart-fare home.	They rent a pot, a strip, or a night on living dirt, and they extend if the week cannot be paid.	They will not give a share of a commons that lasts, and they will not walk anyone to a warden to be filed as housed.
A Far-Voiced person who lost a stage	The posting is isolated, the labor is dull, there is nowhere to vent, and the Cry is close.	They give a room, an hour, and a door that shuts: one outlet, and the next week is the same week.	They will not find honest work. They will not let the Cry happen in the street, because that brings the watch and ruins the book.
A Long-Lived person whose novelty has thinned	The endowment is late, and the fade has started.	They ration a page, a letter, or a gossip that is new enough.	They will not endow a library, and they will not be that person's deathless patron in public.
An Unbound person losing warmth	Company costs money, and the lack of anyone who knows them is getting hard to hide.	They sit with them, let themselves be known a little, and charge for the company.	They will not be family. They will not sign a new Bargain, the contract an Unbound person lives by, because that is another table.
A Bound person behind on civic coin	The debt is rent, a guild fee, or a year that will not close.	They hold the debt, extend it, and use the hold.	They will not rewrite Terms. The hold is money, not a clause, and they will not sell a cellar-easing.
A Returned person whose purpose pays nothing	The work the dead want done is not a trade that pays.	They give a week of keep so the person can keep walking.	They will not furnish the purpose. They will not send anyone to a plague-ward unless the ward pays them.

Who	Why they come	What the week-keeper does	What they will not do
A family, before the town sees	A child or a parent is sliding, and the family will pay so the square does not have to watch it.	They take the week, take the family's coin, and keep the person quiet.	They will not tell the warden, and they will not make the slide a sermon.

An ordinary week

They extend first. That opening is how a person gets onto the book, and it is also what the week-keeper believes about themselves. A person arrives already late. The week-keeper does not withhold on the first night. They open the lot, the room, or the page, they write *extended*, and they name a day.

The withhold comes later, and it is measured. It is never enough to make a public hazard, a wilt in the square, a Cry in the market, or a fade a neighbour can name, because that brings the watch, the guild, the counted hall, and the book dies. It is never enough to let the person stand up and walk to a commons that would keep them. The asset is a person who is always almost whole.

They keep a book of weeks, not a ledger of coin. Coin is how some weeks are paid. What they are counting is how long you have not fallen, on their floor.

A child of the house learns the work by carrying water to the pots and by being told not to let a guest sleep a second week for nothing. There is no Seat to confirm it.

What they carry

They carry a key, a pot or a spare room, a stack of pages that are new enough, and a book of weeks. They carry no stamp, no colour-scrap, no Cutting-leave, and no false witness to sell in the square.

What they refuse

They will not pretend to be clergy. That means no colour, no book-stamp, no door-walk, and no extra place at a table that is not theirs. They will not rewrite a Bound person's Terms. They may hold a Bound person's rent, and that hold is money. They will not steal a scion, and they will not sell the sentence "I watched you Turn." Those belong to other trades.

They prefer not to push someone over the edge that ruins the week. A corpse, a public Cry, or a wilt the town can see is a ruined week and a ruined name. Nothing stops a keeper who is losing the book from withholding too far, and a measured week can miss.

They will not run a mission, a cellar-church, or an export to Kumbaan. There is almost no Tithe on the isle to own, so there is almost nothing there for a week-keeper to rent. They will not call the week a gift, and they will not call it a cruelty. They call it a week.

Who may keep a week

Kind does not decide this house. A human, a Kitsune, a Selkie, or a Tengu who has a pot and a book can be of the Slide. A Yumboe abroad who has started charging for the extra place has committed a different wrong, the one the Table-Keepers argue, and that wrong is not the Slide's.

Practice comes first. You are of the Slide when someone comes back next week and you still have the key. There is no apprenticeship for anyone to confirm. A cousin who extended once and then let the person recover was kind. They are not of this house.

A Condition leans a keeper toward the week they already know how to furnish. It does not bar anyone else.

Act	Often	Why	Also, and welcome
A pot, a strip, a night of dirt	a Taken-In person who kept a private lot	They already furnish green.	A Kept person, who carries no Tithe of their own, with a window-box.
A shut room, an hour of voice	a Far-Voiced person with a spare hall	They already know what an outlet costs.	A performer who lost the honest stage and kept the door.
A page that is new enough	a Long-Lived clerk, a junior at a deathless house	Novelty is already their weather.	Anyone who can still find a rumour the fade has not heard.
The book of weeks itself	whoever can read a late face	The house is the count, not the crop.	A Kept broker, unencumbered, who can move and can carry the book to the next town.

The feared and still licensed are not barred. A Stilled person who rents hours of stillness is rare and tightly watched. A Bound person who holds civic debt is dealing in money, not in a Counterparty's Terms.

How they live with the other houses

House	Everyday arrangement	The hard edge
the Tree-Wardens	A warden furnishes a Tree, not a week. Contact is rare, and it is not a ban.	A Road-hand who starts a week-cart has left the wood. A scion is not stolen to pay a Tithe.
the Watchers	A Watcher who sat an eve-vigil is not in this book.	A false watch is a trade the Slide does not run.
the Book-Hands	A Settler who marked *owing* has just made a customer, and the clerk will watch them walk down the quay.	The Slide does not stamp. The clerk does not furnish. The Bound person they cannot help is still not this house's Terms to rewrite.
the Door-Keepers	A Struck person named kin at a door still has a Tithe. Kinship is not green.	A drowning-stone is not rented out as a lot.
the Table-Keepers	No contact that matters. The second sitting is not a week.	Charging for the extra place is a different faith's one impiety.
Official halls and greens	The official hall, the counted green, and the licence are the town's posted doors, and the town is glad someone takes the late ones.	The pretence ends when the official gate closes on purpose. The worst case is a public wilt or Cry that the gate caused.
the Holding Desk	The product is different, and a Bound person may be on both books.	Money is not a clause.
the Standing Trade	A customer who also needs to move may be sent on.	A false Turning is the other house's trade.

How they live in the three corners (and off the map)

Vaethorn, which calls them the last pot, is home weather for the pious version. The commons ran out, and a cousin still has a pot. They will say they are tending a gift. The quiet obligation is the week: you are helped, and you are theirs. Public help in the Waiting Lands already shades into service you cannot refuse, and this private week is that same shade.

Lestrand, which calls the charge week-rent, treats the house as ordinary, posted, almost. A leaf-lot by the season is already the honest market. The Slide is the lot that will still open after the season-fee failed, at a price that is the next season, and the person who opens it is a landlord, not a preacher.

Threnmaieth calls it the late week, because the crown already holds the Tithe and the Slide does not compete with the counted hall on ordinary days. They sell the week the hall is late, the extra green the roll does not cover, and the novelty the archive will not release. They look like a clerk. The crown's count is cold and precise, and this house is the leak that count cannot file without admitting the channel failed. The roll pretends not to know.

On Kumbaan the Slide has no work, because the isle has no Tree and almost nobody on it carries a Given Tithe. A wreck walked uphill is a guest, not a debtor.

The week that will not end

Whoever furnishes a Tithe that someone else depends on holds power over the person who bears it. The Slide is that power with a landlord's face, and with a patience the official hall is not allowed.

The town is glad of the arrangement. A person who is quietly almost falling is not a Cry in the market. The Waiting Lands can say the gift is still being tended. Threnmaieth can say the channel held. The quay can say the owing was marked and someone took them in.

The Motherfaith says she gave the need. The book of weeks is people's work, and nobody in a town expects the Tree to make the week fair.

The house has no queue of scions, no refinancing of a Bound person's clauses, and no authority except the one the Tithe gives its keepers, which is one key and a measured week. Adding a Term to a Bound person's contract is the Holding Desk. Selling a person who will swear they watched a Turning is the Standing Trade. They are not this house.

Economy of the house

The week is the living. It is paid in coin, in labor, in a favor, or in a child sent to carry water, and the book counts weeks first.

They are not a charity-order, and they are not the official furnishing. A town greenhouse, a counted ael-hall, and an endowed long-house of books are the doors a town posts. A week-keeper may sit next to all three and take the overflow.

A junior at a long-house who rations novelty is how a fortune that never dies feels on the street: not a loan of a century, a page at a time. The house does not run the bank.

They do not collect for a hall across the water. There isn't one.

A week-slip

This is a week-slip from a Lestrand leaf-lot, pinned inside a door that still opens after the season-fee has failed. The back is the same slip, last week, the date scratched once.

> *One week of the lot. Extended. Do not let the pot dry. If you cannot come, send a child. The week is the same week. We do not call this a gift. We do not call it a debt. Come before the leaves turn. If you have already turned, come anyway.*

The slip is a landlord's, practical and almost kind. The product is not falling, and the slip never calls the week a debt, which is how the book stays a book of weeks and never closes. "If you have already turned, come anyway" is the house's whole case: becoming did not save anyone from needing them. The child who carries water is learning the trade.

The Holding Desk

When the honest stamp has already closed and a person still has clauses to sign, the everyday name for the people who will write the next one is **the Holding Desk**, and the people themselves are **hold-clerks**. They keep a back room under an honest table, and the oldest chair is on Orentel's lower slip.

A Bound person signed a contract and is still living under its Terms, the clauses that outlast a single year. The civic year is the honest account of that year. A Book-hand can close it upstairs. The desk opens when the year is payable and the Terms are not. On Lestrand people say the Holding Desk the way they say extension, as if a second term were ordinary business. In Vaethorn a preacher has no clean word for it and calls it **the second signing** when they want a sin. Threnmaieth files nothing, because a private Term that is not the Threnhael is already a problem, and this desk is that problem with a chair.

They are not the Slide. They do not rent a week of green, an hour, or a page. The desk works in clauses.

You would know them by the ink, and by a stool that does not face the quay. They look like a junior Settler who lost the front room. You would find them if you asked who still writes after the book is closed.

Mutelo of the Lower Slip (moo-TEL-o) keeps the oldest chair on Orentel and speaks the worn-down speech of the quay. They will tell you they kept a person walking. The book on the shelf is labelled *extensions*. The last page is not.

A Bound person finishes a civic year at an honest table, and the year is payable while the Terms are not. Fear of the Pledge, the payment the contract still holds over them, is what starts the next ask. The hold-clerk does not invent that fear. They name a smaller Term that covers the larger one for a season, and they call that an extension.

That is how the desk works. Each signing eats more of the person, until the last signing, which is the Given-Over, the person the guilds call the Forfeit. The law has never decided when the person on the stool stopped being one.

Who comes	What the desk does	The limit
A Bound person behind on a Pledge	They write a covering Term, name a day, and extend.	They will not recite the old Terms as if they were gone. The honest table still has them.
A family who will pay to keep a sibling “working”	They hold the person as an asset that still signs.	They will not call this kinship, and they will not take them to a door-keeper to be named kin.
A creditor who wants a walkable instrument	They match a Counterparty who will accept the next signing.	They will not stamp a civic year. That is a Book-hand.
A Struck Bound person, raw from the signing that made them	Sometimes, if the ask is already live.	They will not sit the Intake, the shed that takes a newly Struck person in hand before the town reaches for a rope. That is the wrong shed. The Whisper, the thought a Bound person hears when they fall behind on a Term, suggests and never commands, and this is still a table.

They extend first. That is what they believe about themselves. The withhold is the next clause, measured, never quite the last one until it is.

They will not rent a Tithe-week, whether that week is dirt, a Cry, or a page. They will not sell “I watched you Turn.” That trade belongs to the Standing Trade, which sells a witness rather than a clause. They will not steal a scion, and they will not Speak a colour, which is a warden’s naming and not a clerk’s. They will not rewrite a Term the Counterparty has already named. They add a Term, and that distinction is how they sleep. They will not work a wreck on Kumbaan, because there is no Bound table on the sand.

A dead Bound person is a ruined book, and the desk does not want one. They still walk people toward the Forfeit.

A party meets the desk in the ordinary way the desk works. A Bound friend is being refinanced, which is the word they use for the next covering Term. A Book-hand's *owing* walks downstairs and does not come back up. Someone is asked to witness a signing that is "only a season." A Given-Over case has no settled law, and it needs a witness who is not the creditor's. Mutelo will hire runners, and they pay in extensions.

House	Everyday	The fight
the Book-Hands	They work upstairs and downstairs of each other. A Settler who marked *owing* has made a customer.	It is the same Bound person in the same week, and the clerk who follows them down has started a case.
the Slide	The product is different, and a Bound person may be on both books.	Money is not a clause. A week-keeper who starts writing Terms has changed houses.
the Standing Trade	A Forfeit who needs to cross a border may buy a witness.	A false childhood will not pay a Pledge.
the Tree-Wardens	There is almost no contact. A quiet receiving-rite does not close a Term.	Wardens carry grafts, and they do not carry Terms.
the Reckoned Offices	A private Term that Threnmaieth cannot file is a leak in the crown's count.	Menirein wants the name on a roll. The desk wants the name off any roll that is not theirs.

Lestrand is home weather for the desk, the coast where an extension already sounds like business. Vaethorn calls it a sin and still uses it when a Bound person would otherwise become a story that ends in a rope. Threnmaieth cannot file the desk without admitting the channel failed, so the hold-clerk is left looking like any other clerk.

This is an extension-slip from Orentel's lower slip, pinned under a stool. The back is last season's slip, the date scratched once.

> *Covering Term, one season. The upstairs year is closed. This is not that year. Come before the Pledge-day. If you cannot come, send no one — a clause is not a child. We do not call this a gift. We do not call it a sale. If you have already signed, come anyway. The next Term is the same Term until it is not.*

The writer sounds like a clerk being practical. What the desk sells is not paying yet, and the slip never uses the word *Forfeit*. "If you have already signed, come anyway" is the house's whole case:

becoming Bound did not save anyone from needing them.

The Standing Trade

Citizenship in this world is witnessed, not recorded. What travels ahead of you, when the town that watched you is far behind, is a witness: a person who will say they watched you Turn, which is the standing under a Tree where a child becomes what they become, or where a later threshold takes someone. The unvouched, people no living circle will stand for, will buy one.

Everyday speech calls the sale **the Standing Trade**. A buyer says **a standing**. A seller says “I was there,” and means they will be, later, in a square that was not theirs. Lestrand prices it. Vaethorn calls it **false kin** when a Hands-folk hearth wants a sin. Threnmaieth does not need it on ordinary days, because the roll already stands, and wants it badly when a name is missing from that roll.

They are not the Slide, and they do not rent a week of green or an hour or a page. They are not the Holding Desk, and they do not write a Term. The product is a person who will stand and say they watched.

They look like a useful cousin at a ford, or a factor’s runner, or a pilgrim who happened to be in the square that Eolthael. You would miss them if you came looking for a forger’s press, because there is no press, only a person who will say they were there.

Nomele of the Hinge (no-MEL-eh) works the Old Crossing face, the Hinge Shore more often than Orentel, because the Old Crossing has two shores and a standing has to travel between them. Nomele speaks the worn-down speech of the quay. They do not sell paper. They sell who will walk with you to the next Tree.

A person who Changed unwitnessed, or who left the town that watched them, or who was never there at ten, the year a child stands to be Turned, needs someone to stand. Three kinds of person already do this honestly. A Long-Lived person carries the memory. A Bound person binds the word so it holds. A Far-Voiced person carries a feeling that will not fake. The trade sells a corrupt version of the same three.

Kind of witness	What the buyer gets	Why it is catastrophic when it fails
A Long-Lived person who will remember you	A childhood that will not fade from the witness.	A Blood-Read, the reading that pulls a true fragment of memory from a drop of blood, will give that fragment. If the fragment is the sale, the standing dies, and so does every standing that witness has sold.
A Bound person who will bind the word	A sentence that holds like a Term, as if it were a clause of a contract.	The Counterparty, the other side of that Bound person's own contract, did not ask for this. A bound lie is still a lie the town can use, until the next signing eats the witness.
A Far-Voiced person who will make the feeling stick	The square feels that this person belongs.	A Cry in the same square can splash the false feeling onto everyone in earshot. The watch then has a riot and a fraud.

Honest vouching is priceless because it cannot be faked cheaply. That is why the corrupt one costs a year, a child sent to carry water, a hold on a Tithe, or a name on someone else's book.

They will not sell a colour, the leaf a Tree gives a child, and they will not Speak one, which is a warden's naming. They will not write you onto the Threnhael. That is a registrar's work, and Menirein would rather list you than buy you.

They will not stamp a civic year, because the Book-Hands do that with a real table. They will not rewrite Terms, and they will not walk a Bound person toward the Forfeit, because that walk belongs to the Holding Desk. They will not rent green or an hour, because that rent is the Slide, and they will not steal a scion. They will not stand on Kumbaan, because the isle does not vouch by Tree.

A recant ruins the book. They still sell standings that will recant if the price is higher on the other side.

The customers are the people the law already called rootless. People who cannot point at a town that watched them are the trade's ordinary hour. Nomele will offer a standing the way a ferryman offers a boat. They can pay, refuse, or become the witness. A town that already knows the child will smell the sale. A neighbour who was there still stands for free.

House	Everyday	The fight
the Slide	The product is different. A week-keeper may send a customer who also needs to move.	The Slide does not sell a false Turning, and does not put one in its book of weeks.
the Holding Desk	A Forfeit who must cross a border may buy a witness.	The two houses keep two books, and they charge two prices.
the Book-Hands	Civic settling sits beside honest vouching.	A Settler who finds a standing they did not stamp has a case against it.
the Door-Keepers	A kin-name is a courtesy spoken at a door, not one of the three pillars.	A Kin-speaker who will stand for a fee has left the door-keepers' way.
the Watchers	A second reading is a description, not a childhood.	A false watch is a description of a fall the seller did not see. The Watchers treat that as this trade reaching into their room.
the Reckoned Offices	The roll wants a name. A bought witness is a second account the crown does not hold.	Sirtal will withhold a channel, the crown's furnished upkeep, from a name that will not sit still. Nomele will sell the steadiness.

This is a fee-slate from the Old Crossing hinge, with no childhood written on it. The back is a list of squares, not names.

> *I will stand at the next Tree that asks. I will not say which summer. I will not say which child. I will say I was there. If you have a Long-Lived who was actually there, do not hire me — I will not win that room. If you have no one, come before the watch sets the question. We do not sell a colour. We do not sell a hug. We sell a witness. If the witness recants, the fee does not.*

The writer sounds like a ferryman. "I will not say which child" is the whole fraud: an honest witness names the child, and this one names only the square. The sentences around that fraud are plain about the product. The slate will not sell a colour or a hug, the two things a Tree does when a child stands, because what it sells is a witness.

The Reckoned Offices

People call these four jobs **the Reckoned Offices**, or simply **the tablet offices**. They are not a church, and they are not a sixteenth power, because the fifteen great powers are already named and these jobs sit inside one of them. They are four jobs the Tallied Crown already had. What a traveller can do now is go to the tablet-hall at Maiethlir and find them by name. The grove and the First Seat are other buildings.

Maiethlir still has **Rithim** (RITH-im) as town Speaker, the person who Speaks at the town's Tree and names the colour that fell, or the hug. These offices speak for the Threnhael. They are not a replacement for the hearth, the neighbours who stood and watched the child. The gap between the Speaking and the copy is where a traveller can stand.

They recruit by the office and by the practice of the work, not by Kind. Long-Lived memory is common at the tablet. A Long-Lived person does not age and does not forget what they have witnessed, so here that memory is bent to the census rather than left free to check it. That bending is already how this corner of the Crown works.

The four of them do not share a single want. Each office has its own good-faith aim, and the harm comes out of that aim.

Menirein (men-EE-rayn) keeps the Threnhael's local book, and what they want from it is a roll that is complete. An unlisted child is, to them, a child the Mother cannot be thanked for, and a child the crown cannot keep hale. They will knock on a door, including the door of people who have just arrived, because they believe they are doing care. They do not Speak the fall themselves. Once they have heard it, they copy it, and if Rithim will not let the copy happen in the same breath as the Speaking, Menirein will wait in the square until the water quiets, and then write what they heard. Their good-faith aim is no one unmarked, and the harm comes from that same wish.

Tarvae (TAR-vay) is the crown's preferred Speaker when a fall is mixed or argumentative, a Leaf-Fall where the colour can be read two ways or the square is already arguing. They want the Speaking and the filing to stay one act. A colour Spoken and not written is, to them, a seeing that can be stolen. They will stand beside the town-warden, and they will not always wait for Rithim to finish a breath. They are still a Speaker, and they still name the fall truly when they can. The roll is the second seeing, the lesser one, and they refuse to call it lesser. Their aim is one name, spoken and filed in one breath, and the fight with Rithim is the one that is live. Tarvae does not lie about colours. The dispute is about when the copy is allowed.

Videm (VEE-dem) runs the counted hall and keeps the slate that matches the tended green. They want the channel to hold, so that the late week never comes. The channel is the share the roll can open or shut: green, a counted hour, a novelty the archive keeps, a stiller's bed. A stiller is a person whose gaze can hold a wound or a patient still, and the bed is where that work is done. A Far-Voiced person cut off

from the counted hour is one leak, because without the hour the feeling breaks into a Cry that everyone nearby has to hear. A Taken-In person wilted off the lot is another leak, and a novelty the archive will not release is a third leak of the same kind. Videm will work late to stop a leak, and will also mark a name *late* so the leak can be blamed on the person who carries it. Their aim is no Cry in the market and no wilt in the street, and the injustice is that staying whole runs through them. They are not a separate faction of the hall. The hall is the civic greens and halls that keep people whole enough, held on a crown leash. Videm is the hand on that leash.

Sirtal (SEER-tal) writes the warrant that withholds the share. The warrant can close the green, the counted hour, a novelty, or a stiller's bed. Sirtal wants the roll and the channel to match before that share opens. A name that will not sit still does not get it, whether the name was bought from someone paid to claim they watched, is missing from the book, belongs to the Closed of the Inner Close, or is unvouched, with nobody who will stand and say they were there. Sirtal believes a share given to an unlisted person is how the realm sickens. Their aim is that the channel opens only for a name the offices already have, and the injustice is that same withhold dressed up as care. They will sit a gate to keep the share shut, and they will sit the gate a traveller is trying to use in the same way.

They will not capture the First Seat. Nearness is the pressure they use, and the college of the tree-wardens stays in the wood. They will not copy the Book of Tithes without a fight, and the lists stay two. The Walled Book ranks people by the Tithe they carry, while these offices count people and mean the count as care. They will not stamp a Bound person's Terms. Those are another table's paper. They will not sell a standing. The Standing Trade is a leak they want written on the roll, and it is not a service they will hire. They will not export a Threnhael to Kumbaan.

You can meet them one at a time, because they do not move as a squad. Menirein wants you listed on the roll, Tarvae wants your colour copied in the breath it was Spoken, Videm wants you on the slate that opens the channel, and Sirtal wants you kept still until the first three have you. When they do move together, someone is about to lose a channel.

House	Everyday	The fight
Rithim, at Maiethlir	Rithim is the town Speaker. Some years the copy happens in the same breath as the Speaking, and some years it does not.	Tarvae stands in the square the summer Rithim will not copy.
the Watchers	They keep the second column, where counted dissent is written down.	A second reading that contradicts the name Tarvae already filed.
the Walled Book	Two lists, kept a country apart.	Clerks of the roll come to the Inner Close gate, and the two books stay separate.
the counted halls and greens	The counted hall and the tended green are the channel.	Videm runs late on purpose against a lot that still has beds, and there is a wilt the channel will not walk to.
the Slide	The late week is the week the channel will not admit.	The channel can no longer pretend it does not know the Slide. Videm knows that, and Sirtal files the leak as the person’s own lapse.
the Holding Desk	A private Term is a second seeing, a contract the roll did not write.	Menirein wants the name on this roll, and the desk wants the name off it.
Maiethvael	The same hymns, sung over the opposite paper. Maiethvael is the gift-country on Maiethorn, and it will not keep a roll of persons.	A registrar sending clerks into that country, where the list is refused.

These are four docket-marks from the same Eolthael, written in the tablet-hall by four hands.

> *Menirein: the child is unmarked. I will wait in the square.*
> *Tarvae: the fall was storm-grey. File it in the breath. A delayed copy is a stolen seeing.*
> *Videm: the counted hour matches the name. If the name is late, the hour is late. The hall held.*
> *Sirtal: no green until the name sits. A share to an unlisted bed is how a channel fails.*
> *Rithim (verso, not a Reckoned mark): I Spoke. I did not copy. The water was loud. The Tree was enough.*

The four marks are competent, and they are four different cares that cannot all be met in the same hour. Rithim's note on the back is the gap the offices exist to close.

The Pourers

People call them **the Pourers**, or **the Cup Circle**. Neighbours call the practice **the five-year cup**, because five years is what the circle asks of a member in all, and they smile when they say it, the way people smile about a rich uncle's hobby. The Motherfaith is content to call the whole thing a private devotion. The Fair Hand will not put a stamp on it, because a stamp needs someone on the other side of the deal and the Hand cannot see anyone there. The Watching counts it as one more cost of a long life and says it has nothing to do with the Mother. The Old Ways do not treat the cup as a sacred place or as a door, and the Open Table has no use for it.

The Pourers say they made a god, and they call it the Poured God. That claim is the centre of the practice. The years go into the cup, and the god, as they tell it, is the presence they made on the other side of the gift.

None of this is a Turning. No leaf falls, no warden stands up to Speak a colour, and the practice is not one of the five lived faiths.

If you meet one

You meet a Long-Lived person with a small, ordinary cup. They have given some of their years of memory away, one year at a time, up to five, and they are missing those years, though they are still recognizably the same person. They will tell you they invented the god on the other side of the cup, and they will describe how the circle pictures it this decade, as a librarian, a quiet guest, or a child who never left home. The picture they use may change from one decade to the next, and the rule does not. Members give years, the cup keeps what they gave, and the cup cannot Give a Condition or save anyone from death.

Molevad (mo-LEV-ad) keeps the minutes of the best-known circle, on a long-house shelf in Lestrand. Molevad comes from an old quay that the sea has worn down, is the oldest member in the room, and keeps both the book and the key to the shelf. Molevad is not a priest, and is not a Hand.

A second, quieter circle meets in Orenbren, in an upper room of a lodging-house that once slept travellers. It keeps the same practice. It does not ask Molevad's circle for permission, and the two circles do not write to each other.

The ask

Every Long-Lived person is asked once to join the Pourers, and the asking is done in person by a member. At the long-house shelf in Lestrand, a member of Molevad's circle asks. In the upper room in Orenbren, a member of that circle asks. A Long-Lived person who lives in another town is still asked once, by a member who can reach them, and a person who has already been asked says so. That answer stands.

The invitation is a real one. The member asks because the circle will accept the person who says yes, and a yes is what makes them a member. From then on the member gives one year into the cup at a time, and five years is what the circle asks of a member in all.

A refusal is not punished. The person keeps their standing, people still consult them, and the work a court, a guild, or an archive already gave them stays theirs. A long-house will still seat a person who refused the invitation. Most Long-Lived people are not members, and every Long-Lived person still knows that the circle exists.

The gift

A member gives one year into the cup. Each year is its own night, with its own minutes, and the member may stop before the next one. Five years is what the circle asks of a member in all. Members say they give "the memories that year held, and the year itself." For each year given, that means three things, and they do not all go into the cup.

The memory goes into the cup. The member puts one drop of their own blood in the cup, because a Long-Lived person already reads memory from blood, and afterward the member no longer has the memories of that year. The member still needs to keep learning, as every Long-Lived person does. What changes is that they no longer carry that particular year of other people's funerals.

The papers go onto the shelf. The member also gives the long-house shelf everything they wrote or kept in that year, the letters, the account books, the diaries, and the court notes. The papers are not put in the cup. They are filed on the shelf under the member's name, where other members can read them, and where a visitor Molevad allows can read them too. That filing is one reason the shelf in Lestrand holds so much. Letters name other people, and those people were not asked before their letters went onto the shelf.

The circle counts the member one year younger. At a long-house that keeps the circle, a Long-Lived person's age and standing are counted only in the years they still remember, so for each year given the circle counts the member one year younger. A member who has given three years is seated as if they were three years younger. Among the Long-Lived, age decides who speaks first, who judges a hard case, and who keeps a key, which means every year given costs a member rank inside those long-houses. Courts, guilds, banks, and Long-Lived people who are not members keep counting the

ordinary way. The same person can be a bank's most senior clerk and still sit below a younger member at the long-house.

Members can read the cup the way a Long-Lived person reads a drop of blood. What they read is true, and it is also mixed, so one reading can hold memories of the same year from more than one member. The circle values that mix. They say the knowledge goes to the god they made. In practice the cup is where the memories are kept, and the circle is the group that reads them.

There are no priests. The oldest member writes down who gave which year, how the circle described the god that decade, and whether anyone asked to stop. One member has kept that book for so long that the circle cannot imagine meeting without them.

Who	Why they give	What the circle will not do
A Long-Lived person who has buried too many people	The ordinary Tithe is the need to keep learning, and the heavier cost is outliving everyone they love.	It will not make anyone Long-Lived, because they already are.
A younger member who wants the shared store	They want to read memories of years they did not live.	It will not take years from someone who is not Long-Lived. The cup is only for the deathless.
A member who wants out	The next year is coming due.	It will not lock the door. It will make leaving cost them their friends and their seat.
A neighbour who wants a god	They come from curiosity, from pity, or for a good story.	It will not set the cup up in a public square, and it will not ask a warden to Speak it.

Leaving

A member may stop before the next year, or leave the circle. The years already given stay in the cup. The circle gives back the papers from those years and does not give back the memory, and members call the papers a **thinner copy** of what was given. The real cost is social. The circle treats the person as someone who weakened the god, so other Pourers will not read blood with them, and Long-Lived houses that pay for the long-house will not give them a seat. They are free to go, and they will be alone among the other people who do not age.

Reimaethe (RYE-may-theh) is one of them, in a rise-loft in Orentel. They have given four years, one at a time, and the fifth is still ahead of them. They want to stop before it. They want their papers back,

thin as that copy is, because the papers are all the circle returns. Neighbours still call the loft a hobby. The long-house calls it a person they will not seat.

The members who have asked to stop are called the withdrawers. They have each given one or more years. They do not all want to stop for the same reason. They are not people who turned down the invitation, and a Long-Lived person who never joined is still received everywhere. They are not a second circle, they do not pour anyone else's years, they do not stand the cup in a square, and they do not say Mother over it. When a circle meets, a withdrawer stands in the passage and does not go in. They will not say why they stand there instead of going home.

The work

The members keep a library on the long-house shelf in Lestrand, and that shelf is the deathless library on the Ledger Coast. They copy the Old Tongue, and they copy the common speech people already use. The copies stay on the shelf, beside the papers members have given with their years, and Molevad keeps the minute-book on the same shelf. The circle in the upper room in Orenbren keeps the records of its own meetings. People use the books and the copies, and the work of copying and keeping them is real.

They do not take over medicine. That work stays with the Stilled, who stop a bleeding wound, hold a patient still through the surgery, and can stop a fight before someone is killed. Towns already call on the Stilled as surgeons, menders, and peacekeepers, and the Stillers licence that work and keep the infirmary.

They will not try to Give a Condition, and they will not Strike someone into one, because the cup cannot do either. They will not assign work by Condition. They are not a crown, and they are not the Walled Book. They say every gift is freely given. They will not become a sixth faith. The practice stays in the household, and it stays small.

What the circle says it made

Among themselves they say **the Cup We Made**. On a quay people say **the Poured God**, with the smile they keep for a rich uncle's hobby, and the name for the presence in the cup is **the Unspent**. Neighbours call the cup a memorial with airs. What a neighbour can see is ordinary: a cup, or a small bowl, usually common ware; one drop of the giver's blood; and a person who has given years away and is still recognizably the same person. They will tell you that they invented whatever is on the other side of the cup. There is no temple, only a shelf, and sometimes a second cup sits beside the first. The cup keeps what they gave, and the members read what it is storing by means of blood, because they believe they created the god they are giving the memory to. The cup cannot Give a Condition, it cannot save anyone from death, and it cannot make anyone Long-Lived. The minutes say that if a member asks the cup for a leaf, the cup keeps what it already has.

In Lestrand the Pourers are an ordinary hobby that happens to have a library key. In Vaethorn a preacher who needs a sin may call the cup an insult to the Mother’s gift, and most households will not notice it at all. Threnmaieth wants the minutes on its roll. Molevad’s circle files nothing the crown could use.

A long-house that keeps the circle still seats the members, and the members still learn new things from the books. Refusing a seat to someone who left is an argument about lodging, not a heresy trial. The Book-Hands find no other party to stamp, and a Settler who writes the cup up as a contract has misunderstood it. A warden will not record a gift to the cup as a late Condition, because the cup gives none. A hospice is not a cup. A Closed Heir of the Walled Book who is already Long-Lived may join as a private person, and ranking people is not the same thing as giving away your own memory.

From the minutes

These are the minutes on the Lestrand long-house shelf, in Molevad’s hand. Someone drew a face in the margin and scratched it out twice.

> *One year from S. into the Cup We Made. Face this decade: the quiet guest. Blood as record. The circle read a year that was not only S.’s. We do not write which. If S. asks the years back, the return is thinner and the copy stays. If S. asks the cup for a leaf, the cup keeps what it already has. We made the listener. We will not stand it in a square. We will not say Mother. We will say the shelf.*

These are the circle’s own words. They record a member, S., giving one year, and they say that a reading of the cup held memories of a year that belonged to more than one person. They also say what happens if S. asks for the years back: the papers come back, and the memory stays in the cup. The scratched-out face in the margin is the circle changing its mind about how to picture the god.

The Walled Book and the Inner Close

People call the roster **the Walled Book**, the class that keeps it **the Closed Heirs**, and the place **the Inner Close**. The walled city a first day’s walk from the Motherwood is **Rothallo** (roh-THAL-oh), the capital of Orenbren. Orenbren is already one of the fifteen great powers, so the Close is not a sixteenth flag of its own. People still say the Inner Close, and the Close, and the walls answer to those names. It is the same city. Orenbren calls the arrangement a guest-compact. Its inns will lodge anyone outside the wall, and the Book rules inside it. Threnmaieth keeps the Threnhael, the roll that writes every

person down and means to keep them, and it treats the Book as a rival roll, because the Book will not let Threnmaieth's clerks copy its pages. The First Seat stays in the wood. Rothallo is not the college.

The Closed Heirs are a political class, not a church. At Leaf-Fall a child stands for the Tree, and the Tree either hugs the child, who stays one of the Kept, with no Condition and no Tithe, or lets a coloured leaf fall, which Gives a Condition and the Tithe that Condition carries from then on. A warden Speaks the hug or the colour aloud. The Closed Heirs do not Speak colours, and they do not pour a god. Pouring, in this country, is a Long-Lived person giving years of their own memory into a cup, the deathless hobby of the Pourers, and a Closed Heir who is already Long-Lived may still pour as a private person. The Book does not take that cup up as its work. Its work is to classify people by whether they carry a Tithe, and then to write what the people inside the walls owe on top of that.

Folk still say there was an older empire of the untithed, people who carried no Tithe, and that it sat on the grove, and on that point the folk are right. The everyday historical name is **the Closed Seat**, and the walls of Rothallo are what is left of it. How the Closed Seat broke, the copy, the uprooting, and Hildal's Retreat, the withdrawal that carried a book behind a wall, is the history of the Closing. The Book is what that class is doing now.

If you meet one

They look like lodging-gentry who never took a Tithe, and they do not take the heavy turns of work inside the walls. Each one carries a key to a gate in the wall, and a person with a Condition may not carry that key. You would miss them if you went looking for clergy. You would find them if you asked who still decides what a Given person owes besides the Tithe they already carry.

Delamem (del-AH-mem) keeps the Book of Tithes. Delamem speaks the conservative common speech and will tell you the Book is housekeeping, though the page that assigns labour is in the same hand as the page that assigns a hearth-tax.

Talnin of the Inner Close (TAL-nin) is a Closed Heir of the present generation. The name is on the heir-roll, and the tenth year is not finished, so the Tree has not Spoken this child's colour yet. Delamem has already drafted the turns of work for the case if the leaf is not a hug.

What the house fears is a Closed child Given at the next Leaf-Fall, Threnmaieth copying the Book onto the Threnhael, and Orenbren deciding the guest-compact is only a tax on beds.

What a visitor sees

A visitor to Rothallo does not need to read the Book to see the rank. It shows in four places.

- **Where a person sits.** At a meal in a Closed house, the Kept sit at the end of the table nearest the host, and a guest who received a Condition is shown to the far end, past the last Kept guest. When

the Book is read aloud in the Book's house, the Kept sit on the front benches and everyone else sits behind them. Nobody is turned away from the table. The host says where each guest sits, and the guest is expected to sit there.

- **Whose word is taken.** When two people disagree in front of a clerk of the Book, over a debt, a boundary, or a broken pot, and one of them is Kept and the other has a Condition, the clerk writes the Kept person's account as what happened and writes the other account underneath it as "also said." The person with a Condition can still win, and to win they need a second Kept person to say the same thing they said.
- **Who holds a key.** Only a Kept person may hold a key to a gate in the wall, to the Book's house, to a cistern, or to a granary. A person with a Condition holds the key to their own door and to their own stall, and no others.
- **What the school teaches.** The children of the Closed houses learn their letters at a school beside the Book's house, and other families inside the walls may send a child if they pay. The teacher, **Volnai** (VOL-nai), tells the children that a hug is rare, and that a child the Tree hugged was kept back for something better than a colour. Volnai believes this and teaches it every year. The lesson is wrong about the count, which the next section sets beside the teaching.

A person with a Condition who lives inside the walls works for wages, keeps what they earn, owns their tools and their household goods, marries whom they choose, and can own a stall. The Book writes a licence for that stall, and a Kept stall-keeper needs no licence. A person with a Condition can walk out of the gate on any day it is open and live somewhere else. Nobody owns them, and they are not slaves. What they cannot have inside the walls is the heir's place, a gate key, a vote in the Close's compact, or the first word in front of a clerk.

The lesson and the count

The Close teaches that a hug is rare, and the teaching is wrong. Most towns have Kept neighbours, people the Tree hugged and left without a Condition, and most of those neighbours have never heard of the heir-roll. The shares of who is hugged and who carries a Condition are the ones given with the Conditions. The Close does not teach a second set of numbers for Rothallo, for the Closed houses, or for the heir-roll.

What is actually rare is a family that has stayed without a Condition on purpose, generation after generation, and treats that record as a birthright. The Closed houses manage it in two ways that reinforce each other. An heir who receives a colour is struck from the heir-roll, so the roll only ever lists people who were hugged. An heir also does not swear the kind of oath that can Strike a person, and stays away, where they can, from the other ways a person can be Struck. A Strike is a Condition put on a person later, by a drowning, an oath, or a death. After enough generations, every name on the

roll belongs to a hugged person. A family that has kept that record is rare, and being hugged is common.

Delamem and the other clerks of the Book can read the count, and the school does not teach it. If a visitor brings the count to the Close, a clerk will say the count is someone else's record and does not bind the Close, and the school teaches the same lesson the next year.

The Book of Tithes

The Book of Tithes is a roster rather than a hymn, and the roster does three kinds of work.

- **Taxes.** Coin, board, and a cut of self-paying labour, work a person is paid to do on their own account. An Answered shop inside the walls, a craft-house of a person an element answered and still answers, pays a craft-due the Ember-yard on the quay does not. That yard is where the fire-answered keep their craft. A Two-Bodied ranging-week, the week a person spends in the animal body they also carry, is scheduled as owed work before it is allowed to count as a ranging.
- **Restrictions.** Where a person with a Condition may hold a key, a stall, or a vote in the Close's compact. The Kept hold those. A Given person who keeps a stall does it as a licensed exception, and the exception is written down.
- **Labour.** Everyone who lives inside the walls owes the Close turns of work, the way a town expects each household to take a turn on the watch. The Book keeps the list of turns: the green, the hall, the wall, the road, and the beds outside the gate. A Kept household's turns are mostly the watch on the wall and the keeping of keys. A household with a Condition is given the heavier turns, and more of them, and the Book picks the turn by the Condition. The turns are not the Tithe, so a person with a Condition owes them in addition to the Tithe they already carry, and a person who does not want the turns can leave the city. The Book's list has no claim on anyone who lives outside the walls. The Book does not sell a person, lend a person to an employer, or hand a person over the way an owner hands over a worker. It cannot send for someone who has left.

A Closed Heir who is Given at Leaf-Fall loses status. The Gift is a disinheritance. The hug keeps the name on the heir-roll, and the colour takes it off. The person is still a person, and is no longer a Closed Heir, and the Book already has turns of work written for what they have become.

A Closed Heir who is Struck later, by a drowning, an oath, or a death, is treated the same way. The Book strikes the name from the heir-roll when the clerks learn of it, and writes the person's turns of work under the Condition they now carry.

This ranking is the opposite of Threnmaieth's care-count. The Threnhael writes everyone down in order to keep them, while the Book ranks by whether you carry a Tithe and will strike an heir for receiving a gift.

Orenbren’s sleep-line at the gate records who slept in a bed, and the Close’s Book records who owes turns of work. Both lists are kept in Orenbren’s country, and neither lets the other copy its page.

They will not call the Book a scripture. A preacher who does is either bringing the Motherfaith into a roster, or doing the Close a kindness the Close did not ask for. They will not Speak a colour or officiate a Leaf-Fall. A warden may come in for Turning-Week, and the copy made after that Speaking is the Close’s copy, not the Seat’s and not the Threnhael’s. They will not pour years into a cup as the Book’s own work. A Closed Heir who is Long-Lived may still pour years of their own memory, which the Book does not count as its business. They will not hide a Phoenix. A white-fire fall inside the walls would be a problem for the Book to rank. They will not add a sixteenth flag. Rothallo is already Orenbren’s capital, and the fifteen great powers already include Orenbren.

The Book reaches people on ordinary paper. A labour-roster names someone. A Given heir wants the heir-line back and will pay in board. Delamem wants a colour-copy the warden has not released. Threnmaieth wants the Book, and the Close wants those clerks off the gate. A Kept pilgrim who takes work inside the walls is put on the heavier turns, because the Book has no record of their hug. Travellers can be hired by the Close, by Orenbren’s lodging-guilds, or by a Closed child who just took a colour.

The Book shares a country with other houses that also write people down, and each fight is about which writing a person has to obey.

House	Everyday	The fight
Orenbren	Guest-compact. The inns keep beds outside the wall, and the Book rules inside it.	The inns charge for beds and the Book assigns turns of work, so a guest can owe both. The sharpest case is a Turning-Week when the Close will not lodge a Given pilgrim and Orenbren has no other bed.
the Reckoned Offices	Two lists. Threnmaieth wants the Book’s ink.	Menirein listing a Closed Heir as unmarked, with no Condition entered beside the name, is an insult the Book will answer, and the lists stay two.
the Tree-Wardens	A warden Speaks inside the walls if asked.	The Speaking is a civic rite, the disinheritance stays the Close’s own act, and Rithim is not the Close’s clerk.
the Pourers	A deathless Closed Heir may keep a cup.	The Book ranks people by the Condition they carry, a cup holds one member’s own memory, and the two do not overlap.
the Holding Desk	A Bound person inside the walls may still be refinanced.	The Book assigns labour, and the desk assigns the clauses of the contract. Both can claim the same person’s wages, and the two offices argue over whose claim comes first.

Outside the walls

The Book itself stays inside Rothallo, while the habit of ranking a hug above a colour keeps traveling, and three places show how far that habit reaches and where it stops.

Orenbren, outside the wall. The lodging-guilds do not ask a guest’s colour, and the sleep-line at the gate does not record it. Near the gate it is different. An inn that wants the Closed houses’ business keeps its best table for Kept guests on the nights a Closed house dines there, and moves a guest with a Condition to another table if the Closed house asks. The guild does not forbid this. In Turning-Week, when the Close will not lodge a Given pilgrim, the inns outside the wall take that pilgrim in, and some of them charge more for it.

Vaethorn, which rejects the ranking in public. At Eolvaeth, the gift-hall teaches that a colour is the Mother’s gift and a hug is the Mother keeping a child as they are, and that neither makes a person better than the other. The gift-hall says this out loud in its Eolthael preaching, and it says the Close’s teaching is wrong. A Given person who has left the Close can eat at the gift-hall without being asked for a house. That is why Hithaen (hith-AYN) walked there. Hithaen is one of the disinherited, the Given people a colour struck off the heir-roll, who will not let the next town copy the Book’s turns of work onto a slate. They eat where a hearth will have them. They do not ask to be let back into the

Close, and they do not preach that the Kept should lose the Book. Hithaen eats in the gift-hall with a letter from behind the wall still unopened, is not a leader of the others, and is not Talnin. When two of the disinherited meet, they do not trade the old house-name. They will not say why. The Waiting Lands have their own unkindness, pointed the other way: a hugged child there is sometimes pitied as passed over by the Mother. The two teachings disagree with each other, and neither one matches the count.

Brenthael, which copies the seating. Brenthael is the town with its own Tree a day's walk past the Third Hearth on the Near Mile. At its Turning-Week supper in the square, Kept people sit on the benches nearest the Tree, and people with a Condition sit on the outer benches, even when that splits a family. A child who has just received a colour gets up from an inner bench and moves to an outer one before the food is served. Brenthael has no copy of the Book, no heir-roll, and no list of turns. Nobody in the town can say when the seating started. They keep it because it is how the supper has always been laid out.

A leaf from the Book of Tithes

This is a leaf from the Book of Tithes, Inner Close, in Delamem's hand. The line for heirs and the line for turns of work share a fold.

> *Talnin, Closed, heir. If the fall is a colour, strike heir. Enter labour under the colour as the page already holds. The hug keeps the line. We do not file this as a slight. We file it as a house. Orenbren may lodge who they witness. They may not lodge who we rank. The Threnhael may count who they can see from the river. They may not copy this page. A gift is a gift. A gift is not a seat.*

This is a page from the Book of Tithes. It records an heir, says the Book will strike the name if the Tree gives a colour, and tells Orenbren and Threnmaieth that neither may copy it. Delamem writes that the Book does not mean the striking as a slight, and that is how a child learns that a leaf can take a name.

The Protectors (as the square knows them)

When anyone speaks of them, the everyday name is **the Protectors**. The building the world is allowed to know is **the Care**. It is a hospice-endowment, old money behind a closed court, and the story that travels is that the one Phoenix is being kept safe there, which is why no town has seen them in a generation. In that story a Phoenix is the one person the tales have been about. The Care says it holds that person, and says there is only one.

They worship the one. They do not hold the worship in a square, where a town could come and look.

Vimein (vih-MAYN) keeps the outer book of the Care. Vimein speaks the conservative common speech, quietly, and says little. They will say the Phoenix is in care, and they will not produce them. They will offer a viewing of the closed court, a hymn that does not name a Mother, and a request that you not carry a story back to a square that has finally gone quiet.

You would take them for a hospice clerk, and the building is a hospice. The wider world has not seen a Phoenix because the Care says it holds the old name, and the squares have stopped looking.

A neighbour can see a hospice with old money and a closed court, and a generation of squares that talk about the Phoenix in the past tense and the present tense in the same sentence, as if the one were both gone and still in the building. They will not stamp a ticket, rent a week, classify a Closed Heir, or pour years into a cup. A Closed Heir is someone the Walled Book has already classed. Pouring a year of memory into a cup is the Pourers' act, not this desk.

What they admit to refusing is the parade. They will not produce the Phoenix for a square. They say every square was staring at the one, and the Care ended that. They say there is only one Phoenix. They will not open the inner court to a relic-hunter, or to a Speaker who wants a colour-copy, a second writing of the leaf. They will not work a wreck on Kumbaan. There is no white-fire, the colour a Phoenix is known by, on that sand.

You meet them at the door and not past it. Someone is asked to carry a letter to the Care, and is not let in. A town wants the Phoenix for a festival and is told the one is in care. A guest who got as far as the inner door is turned away with a kind sentence.

A visitor's slip

This is a visitor's slip from the Care, in Vimein's hand. The inner court is not on the slip.

> *The one is in care. The stories may rest. We do not produce a person for a square that has already decided what they mean. If you have come to worship, the hymn is said in the closed court and not in the street. If you have come to hunt, you will find a hospice. We keep the one. We keep the quiet.*

These are the Care's own words to a visitor. They say the Phoenix is in care, that nobody will be shown them, and that the Care would like the story left alone.

Book IV

How People Live

Law and Citizenship

You belong to a place because someone who already knew you watched you become who you are. In your tenth year, during Turning-Week, the midsummer week a town keeps for the rite, you stand under that town's Turning Tree. Kin come, neighbours come, and the tree-wardens come. It is still the most-attended week of the community's year. Your **Kind** is what you already are by birth, the body and the bloodline you arrived with, and the week does not decide that. What the week decides is a **Condition**, the change three of every four people come to carry across a life and do not put down. A leaf falls, and the warden Speaks the colour, which is to say aloud which colour came down and so which Condition you were **Given**. Or the Tree hugs you and there is no colour, and you are one of the **Kept**, witnessed in the same hour as everyone else and carrying no Condition at all. Citizenship is settled then. You are of that place because a living circle watched, not because a clerk wrote the colour into a book.

In a village the circle is the whole settlement. In a city it is a **hearth**, a street, a quay-gang, a courtyard, or a guild-stair, and not twenty thousand people pretending to remember one child. The legal fact does not change. How a city actually gets through the week is the next part of this chapter.

So citizenship in the Turning is witnessed, not recorded. The law is the memory of the people who stood there, and it does not become a register when the crowd grows. There is no general list of the people. No town and no church keeps everyone and the gift they carry. A warden's week-slate only says which hearth stands at which bell, so it is a festival schedule, the same kind of board that says who has the square for the fair. A guild-roll is only the roster of people who practise a dangerous art. Neither paper is a census. The Walled Book keeps an heir-roll inside its own walls, and that roll lists only its own heirs. Two crowns are the exception and do keep a roll of persons. Threnmaieth, the Tallied Crown, calls its roll holy. Trenledd, the Worn Count, calls it the roll and does not call it holy. The rest of the world finds both unsettling.

That morning is also why a stranger can be known without papers, why a town can licence a dangerous practice without listing every neighbour, and why the person with no one to stand for them is the person the law leaves exposed.

This is how belonging works in the **Years of Hands**, the present age, when a town's own Tree is the ordinary place to Turn. The road under it is older. In the **Walking Years**, everyone who was Given had walked to Thaeloren, the Awakening Tree, or had been carried there. The crowd that saw you was the crowd under that one Tree, or there was no crowd at all if you never arrived. Someone who stood there, or a word from that someone, still has to be able to carry the witness home. The law on this page

is the present. The custom of answering for a person who is far away is what that older walk left on the road.

Turning in a city: the hearth stood

A village of three hundred can remember every child who stands. A salt-city of tens of thousands cannot, so witnessed citizenship does not turn into a register at that scale. The memory nests. It moves down into hearths, and the city does not open a book to replace them.

The Tree is still at the centre, Turning-Week is still the door the city comes in by, and the square is still full. The legal fact is that your hearth stood, not that the whole of Orentel, the salt-city on the Ledger Coast, saw you as if a city could be one witness.

A hearth, in a city, is eighty to two hundred people who already know the child. They bring their ten-year-olds in a named slot of the week, the warden Speaks the colour or names the hug, and the city, standing there as a crowd, sees only a crowd. The hearth is who sees the child.

One **pillar** of that hearth carries the memory when a desk far from the city asks. If a Long-Lived stood, the memory does not corrupt and it runs back centuries. If a Bound stood, the sworn word is literally binding, so a false vouch is not a lie they can cheaply tell. If a Far-Voiced stood, the voice betrays real feeling under strain, so they cannot smoothly lie on your behalf. Kin and neighbours carry the memory first. The pillar is how that stand travels once the child is no longer in front of the people who saw it. An orphan is still brought by kin, by the household that feeds them, or by the warden's own hearth. A child no hearth will bring has missed the Turning, the same as in a village.

To prove you are of a city, you name a hearth and produce someone of it, or a pillar who stood. "I am of the third quay" is a citizenship sentence. "I am of Orentel" only says where that hearth sits on the map.

Threnmaieth and Trenledd write the stand down. That writing is still the aberration. Everyone else keeps the week's slate as hours, which hearth at which bell, and the slate does not record the gift.

How you prove who you are: by *people*, not papers

If no one is written down, a stranger still has to prove citizenship in a far city. The Turning never had to invent a state of papers and registers, because trust runs through people who cannot be faked. The work those people do, and the witness they can give, exists because they carry a Condition. You are known by witnesses, not by a document a state issued you. Everyday speech calls this **standing-for**.

A Long-Lived remembers you, and that memory cannot be forged the way a clerk's copy can, because it does not corrupt and it runs back centuries. When a Bound vouches, the sworn word is literally

binding, so a false vouch is not a cheap lie. When a Far-Voiced speaks for you, the voice betrays real feeling under strain, and they cannot smoothly lie on your behalf.

To establish yourself in a new place is to be vouched into it. You acquire people who will stand for you. That is warmer than an identity check, and it has a sharp edge. The friendless and the rootless are the truly vulnerable, because they have no one to vouch, and the law's exclusions fall on the **unvouched**, a person no one will stand for, rather than on anyone you would call undocumented. A traveler is not, by default, that person. The next section is how they stay vouched on the road.

The same act wears a different name from town to town. In Vaethorn, the Waiting Lands, where the faith runs hot and the Trees run thin, someone vouches for you at worship, and they call that *the speaking*. On Lestrand, the Ledger Coast, where guilds do the governing a crown would do elsewhere, a commercial guarantee is *warranting*. In Threnmaieth you are named to the crown, and they call that *the naming*.

How a traveler stays vouched

The unvouched remain the vulnerable class. A legitimate traveler moves on someone's word, not on a paper a state handed them. The road still works the way it did when the witness had to come home from Thaeloren. The person who saw you, or their word, still has to be able to answer.

A watch that stops a stranger asks three things: your name, your last hearth, and who stands for you. Answer any two and the road continues. Answer none and you are held until dawn, or until someone will stand, or until you are walked to the next gate. The watch saves its pressure for the person who can give none of the three. A company that can name a last host and show one mark is how this law wants people to move, and an adventuring party is included.

The table is the set of words and marks a watch will actually take. A **Gaze** is the Stilled practice, the one surgeons, riot-lines, and demolition use, and the one a later charge means when someone has held a citizen still. A **Cry** is a Far-Voiced voice let out in earnest, in a hall or over a crowd. An **element** is what one of the Answered works, fire or water or stone or wind, in a yard or on a boat. A mark that names one of those uses is permission to practise it. It is not a list of who carries which Condition.

Custom	What it is	What it is not
Road-word	A named person at your origin or your last town, the one you mean by “Ask Halim of the third quay.” A Far-Voiced can call that person, a Bound can send a word, and a letter is only a token of the person who vouched.	Not a passport. The scrap is worthless if the person who vouched is dead or will not stand.
Company-vouch	A party stands for each other, so one locally known or ticketed member covers the rest for the passage.	Not citizenship. You may sleep in the town. You are not of the town.
Guild-mark	A stiller’s ticket, a Crae journeyman-mark from the element-guilds, or a Voice-ticket. Craft marks travel with the person who earned them. The Crae are the element-guilds under one umbrella name.	Not a census of Conditions. The mark says you may Gaze, work an element, or Cry in a hall, and nothing further.
House-note	Paper from a deathless house, a bank a Long-Lived founded and is still personally running. The credit also stands for the bearer, lightly.	Not required. Most travelers carry none.
Guest-right	A host who takes you in stands for the stay, whether that host is an inn, a table, or a road-house. “I ate at X” holds for about a week.	Not a vouch for sale. The host must have taken you in.
Walk-custom	Someone on a named walk, the Near Mile, the Salt Walk, the Long Mile, or a First-Hand year, is vouched as a walker by the road itself, through mile-shrines, road-houses, and a berth-slate.	Not permanent belonging. When the walk ends, the word ends.

People Struck on the road, meaning they took a Condition where no one from home was watching, are vouched anew at the next desk that will take them. If the change is already dangerous, that desk is the Intake, the guild shed that takes a raw Struck person in hand because the hazard is live. Changing without witnesses is still a seam in the law. It is not a crime to have changed.

People still sell a vouch under no name. That sale sits outside the customs in the table, and the economy chapter is where the market has a face. If the bought speaker will not answer when a Far-Voiced calls, the sale fails where everyone can hear it.

Kumbaan, the Sundering Isle, is not a jurisdiction under this law, so you do not arrive there already vouched. A road-word, a company’s vouch, or a guild-mark can still help you leave a quay on Strandoren, the continent across the water. None of those file you on a hill of the isle, and none of them make the isle a place this law administers. On the isle, guest-right is a seat at the table, and eating

there a second time makes you kin of that table. The meal does not become a last hearth you can offer when a mainland watch asks where you slept. Hand that watch the hall's sentence instead of a person who saw you, and the watch still wants the witness.

The Struck: those who changed *unwitnessed*

The seam this whole body of law grows around is not that someone fell off a list. A Struck person acquired their Condition later, and alone, by a drowning, a death, or a sworn contract, long after their tenth-year Turning. The town watched everyone else become who they are. No one watched the Struck. They changed with no witnesses.

So a Struck person must be vouched anew. The community has to learn them again as what they have become, on the word of the people who will stand for them. That is the plain root of the old unease that the Struck are "a little suspect," and the unease is not only prejudice, because their becoming happened where no one could see it. A change everyone witnessed is trusted. A change that happened in the dark has to be spoken for. Every polity has people whose transformation went unwitnessed, and every polity feels differently about them.

Two things make that seam sharper. The first is that the dangerous Struck arrive raw. A Struck Stilled or a Struck Far-Voiced manifests untrained, with the hazard already live and no guild that caught it while they were young. For these, being vouched in is bound up with mandatory guild-intake. You are taken in hand and apprenticed at once, for everyone's safety, whether you wanted the vocation or not.

The second is that some doors sit next to crimes. The Bound are Struck by a sworn contract, and the Returned are Struck by dying. To vouch a Bound into a community is to acknowledge a contract no one witnessed being sworn, which is why contract-law and the acceptance of the Bound stay tangled together in the edge cases below.

The second word shows the stance. Vaethorn says *the late-come*, met at a later door; Lestrand says *the turned*, a fact said plainly; Threnmaieth says *the unwitnessed*, suspect until the crown has named them.

The hour someone is Struck

The first hour is care. To be Struck is to be changed with no leaf in anyone's hand, before a town has had time to decide what sentence fits. The person has changed, and nobody has a colour for them yet. Later the town may acknowledge them at a Tree, settle their civic standing, or walk them back to an Old Ways door, the older faith's own threshold. Those are other days. This hour is the coat, the breaths, and the pen taken out of a hand.

At Orentel, under the pilings, on a tide that ought to have been an ordinary tide, the gang hauls up a person who went into the water as one of them and comes back with a voice that does not fit the chest, or with a calm the morning did not have. They get their shoulders under the person, get the water off,

and get a coat around them, and somebody counts the breaths. They do not walk the person to Tallo, which is the name the quay uses for its Tree, and they do not ask which story the new voice belongs to. If a book-hand opens a book over someone who cannot yet refuse a line, whoever is holding the head shuts the book. Tomorrow is soon enough, if the person can refuse by then. A civic settling, if one is going to happen, is an errand for daylight, not for this hour.

Before the coat is even fastened, someone on the gang will say the person was Struck, someone else will say the old rite reached them, and someone else will say a term opened in the storm. The person inside the coat is still coughing, so the argument waits until morning. A hall may later write slips about people who came in with no colour and would not agree on one account. Those slips are called the Uncoloured Intake, and they are not this hour.

On a thaw-street in Maiethlir, the Tallied Crown’s seat, the family takes the person into a house and does not take them to the root of the Tree tonight. One sibling is already planning the walk for the morning, so the person can be acknowledged and not Given, because that walk is not a request that the Tree hand over a Condition. The other sibling says the Tree does not Strike, and that a morning walk is a kindness which can wait until the person is able to decline it. Both of them are in the family. What the hour comes down to is the blanket and the shutters. The sibling who needs to say Maieth, the short name devout people use for the Leaf-Mother, may say it over the blanket. The person under the blanket is not required to say it.

In Eolvaeth, the waiting-lands seat, they get the person dry, and if the person can sit they take them to the pot in the gift-hall. If a door-keeper is in the fold, one of the people the older faith trusts with a door, that is who you fetch. If no door-keeper is there, the house does the same things it already does when the weather turns. Nobody names a colour over the steam. The wet leaf on the town spring is not a sign for this hour. A warden who has arrived early, however kind the warden is being, is still early.

It happens rarely on the hill. Once the hall at Ndenjoo has a name for what happened, it treats the news as family news. Njunda feeds the person. Nobody reads a test over the food, and nobody tells the loud story, the mainland telling of the Mother. How a becoming works on Kumbaan is not a lesson the valley owes a guest. The place at the board stays set for whatever it was already set for.

If the change came by an oath said in a back room, the people there take the pen out of the person’s hand until that person can hear the clause they are still saying yes to. If it came by a death that did not finish, they keep the person warm, and they do not name the person’s Purpose tonight. The Purpose is the unfinished thing a Returned person, someone death did not keep, is still here to tend. A family that knows them can tell later, by a touch, whether that Purpose is being tended, because a Returned who is settling goes cool. Someone who was turned to stone and then came back, or someone who came out of the deep wild changed, is fed, and is not brought under a canopy tonight.

If the person is still inside their tenth year, the problem is a different one, and it is short. While Turning-Week is still open, people bring them to be welcomed. They do not stand the child under the

Tree as if the Tree were giving them a second life.

The Inviolate Will

Every polity holds one principle as the floor of law, and it holds because it is true of the Conditions. No Condition can compel, control, or bend another person's will. The Bound's Whisper cannot, the Far-Voiced's Cry cannot, and the Long-Lived's regard cannot. Every Condition's danger stops at property, at pain, at fear, and at the edge of another person's choosing. That limit is the **Inviolate Will**. Every child is taught the maxim:

> ***"The will is one's own."***

The fears a horror story needs are void under that maxim. There is no such crime as being mind-controlled by a vampire, because that cannot happen, and the people a tale would call monsters live as neighbours, because the one thing that would make them impossible to live beside is impossible, and everyone knows it. The law has no charge for one Condition seizing another's mind. The Conditioned, the people who carry a change, are charged as neighbours on that ground.

A **Tithe** is the upkeep a Condition keeps requiring of the person who carries it. If you let it lapse, the dangerous side shows where other people have to live with it. Because a Condition cannot seize a will, harm done with one splits into two charges. **Negligent Tithe-lapse**, letting your element vent, your Cry break, or your green go to seed, is a matter of regulation or of public nuisance. **Willful weaponizing**, deliberately turning a gift on someone, is ordinary violent crime, and it is no gentler because the instrument was a Condition. In practice only the Stilled's gaze supports a charge the hearing can speak as "you held a citizen still." Most of what the law deals with here is negligence. Assault is the smaller share.

The same maxim is the shield the feared hide behind. A Bound can say, truthfully, "my contract cannot make you do anything." Whether a given polity listens is where the polities diverge.

Vaethorn keeps the maxim as *the Mother's own line*, and reads it as scripture. Lestrand cites *the free-will clause*, and treats it as ordinary commercial law. Threnmaieth cites *the crown's assurance*, and uses that citation to justify the roll.

The safety-licence: how hazard is regulated (and by whom)

The one place the law takes hold of a particular person is public safety, and it takes hold narrowly. A **ticket** attaches to a hazardous use, not to the fact of being Conditioned. Across the world, a licence attaches where a practice is dangerous to other people. It does not attach where a gift is merely powerful, and it is not a way to keep track of people. Everyday speech calls this leave **the ticket**. In

Vaethorn a practitioner asks for *the blessing-to-practice*. On Lestrand they show *the guild-ticket*. In Threnmaieth they show *the crown-warrant*.

The three ticket-Conditions are the Stilled, the Far-Voiced, and the Answered. Together that is about three people in ten, and the shares of each Condition are in *The Conditions*. They are a large minority who can be asked for a ticket if they practise the hazardous use. They are not a third of the world written on a crown's list. A ticket names a competence, stiller, hall-voice, or Crae-hand, which is the work you may do. It does not name the Condition as an identity, and it does not function as an identity paper.

Who	Ticket names	Who is not on it
the Stilled — personal Gaze-ticket	Anyone who Gazes in public: surgeons, riot-lines, demolition. Most stillers hold one, because the vocation is the Gaze.	A Stilled who never Gazes, which is rare. The guild still wants that person in the yard.
Far-Voiced — Voice-ticket / hall-hour	Those who Cry in a crowd or keep a scheduled hour: criers, performers, sworn witnesses. The hall-keepers stamp that you are competent and sell you the hour at the same desk.	A field-voice who lets the Cry out at the hedge. The hall-slate is a list of hours, not of every blue-leaf in the city. Blue-leaf is the ordinary name for a Far-Voiced. A Far-Voiced who never takes an hour is not on it.
the Answered — shop charter / journeyman-mark	Those who let an element speak in a crowded yard, where a crowd can be hurt. The Crae charter the shop. Journeymen work under that charter.	A Tide-Answered on their own boat, under a master's eye. They answer to the shop. The shop does not keep a person-file, and they carry no paper of their own.
Bound — a table, not a body-ticket	No licence for the body. The honest table oversees the Terms, the clauses a Bound is still keeping. The Whisper cannot command.	A ticket. A Bound is not counted among the licensed.
No ticket	—	Two-Bodied, Long-Lived, Returned, the Taken-In, the Unbound, Phoenix, and all the Kept. Most people hold no ticket. They are simply neighbours.

Active papers in a working city are fewer than the people who could be asked for one, and fewer again on the frontier, where a feared Condition is as likely to meet a rope as a stool. The stool is the ticket-

stool, the master’s seat that stamps the paper. The share is who might be asked. It is not a census of people under supervision.

What keeps this from becoming a general watch on neighbours is the way the pens are held. Three guilds keep the papers, and they do not keep a shared roll. A stiller cannot ask the Crae for a list of all the Answered. A hall-keeper cannot ask the Stillers for “all pale-stone,” and pale-stone is the ordinary name for the Stilled. There is no union of the lists except in Threnmaieth and Trenledd. The state watches the charter, not the person. It can pull a guild’s leave to operate, and it cannot ask for a list of this city’s Far-Voiced. The slates name hours, plants, and chairs, not gifts. A bed-slate is rows of beds. A hall-slate is bells. A guild-roll is the practitioners of an art. Only the two crowns that keep a roll of persons write down the gifts those persons carry.

Most people never hold a paper at all. The Kept do not. The Two-Bodied do not, and they are the plurality, the largest share of any Condition. Nor do the Taken-In, the Returned, the deathless, or the Hollow, which is the ordinary name for the Unbound, a Bound released from the contract and still missing what they paid. Among people who do carry a Condition, only that large minority can be asked for a ticket, and only if they practise. This is a world of crafts, not a world that keeps a register of neighbours.

Licences are guild-issued, not state-issued, which is the arrangement a craft town of this age already knows. A guild knows its own members the way any craft guild does. The state charters the guild and lets the guild police its own, under the threat of losing the charter. No single authority thereby holds the Conditioned. The arrangement makes its own friction. Guilds guard their monopolies, tickets become property, and an unlicensed practitioner threatens the guild’s charter as much as the public’s safety. A mill, a hull, and a road keep fellowships of their own, and those fellowships are not these papers.

Harm, the watch, and the hearing

The Inviolate Will has already sorted the charge into negligent Tithe-lapse or willful weaponizing. The ladder below is the path that charge walks. There is no crime on it for merely being a Condition.

1. **Neighbour-word.** Most harm dies on the street. Someone pays back what they took, or they apologize, or a Bound gives a sworn word if the street has one to give. The watch is not called.
2. **The watch.** Night-watch and ward-watch are the ordinary civic hold. The people who stand them are often Kept, whose nights are not themselves a Tithe, and Two-Bodied, for whom the ranging is the Tithe, with a Far-Voiced along so the shout will carry. They hold a body until morning. They do not investigate a Condition, which is a different question from whether someone was harmed tonight. When the matter needs someone who can speak for a hearth or a craft, they fetch a pillar or a guild. Where another page says “the watch,” it means this hold, not a secret police, except where

a Watchful crown, one of the two that keep a roll of persons, has told the watch to hold someone the roll wants.

3. **Guild-hearing.** Tithe-lapse comes here, and so does an unlicensed Gaze, and an element let go in a shop. The guild fines, or it suspends the ticket, or it binds the person to an apprenticeship. The state is not in the room unless the charter is at risk.
4. **Open hearing.** Willful harm is heard in the open, before witnesses, and especially before the three pillars. The charge is the act. “You Gazed a man” is assault. “You are Stilled” is not a charge. A Gaze used to hold a person still and leave them helpless is the rare charge the Stillers’ own code already names.
5. **What the hearing can do** without writing you down is a short list of real consequences. It can order restitution in coin or in labor, or order you to furnish a Tithe you broke. It can strip the ticket, so you may not practise the dangerous act. It can require a Bound’s word, or a term. It can exile you from the hearth, so that you become unvouched in your own city. That exile is the civic death, and it does not require a file. For murder, and for the rare holding of a citizen still, it can send you to the rope or the wall, which is used more often on the frontier and is rare in the Warm, the devout end of the world’s theology.

The two Watchful crowns write you down on top of whatever else the hearing did. That extra record is their extra punishment, and it is why a Watchful town feels like a different country.

The watch and the cohort

A town keeps a watch for the night. In a bad year it sends a cohort down the road with the children who still have to be Turned. Two old wars are finished. What they left, and what a power still collects, is a wall and a rate. In an ordinary year the work is a bench until morning.

When the watch is called, it is the hold already named: until morning, and not an investigation of anyone’s Condition. At a gate the three questions are the same ones a traveler has to answer. Your name, your last hearth, and who stands. Two answers, and the road goes on. No answer, and the person sits a bench until the second bell, until someone comes to stand for them, or until the watch walks them to the next gate. The bench is not a cell. They do not keep the three answers past dawn.

In a village the watch is whoever is awake. In Maiethlir it is the Down Gate and the path along the flood-wall. In Orentel it is the night-gate on the quay. In Eolvaeth the square watches. In a year when a cohort goes out, the camp-streets watch instead, because the people who would have stood have gone toward a luckier Hand. A Hand is that town’s own grafted Tree, the local wood that should Turn its children this week. Threnmaieth’s roll belongs to the clerks, not to the people on the bench. The watch in a Watchful town can be told to hold someone the roll wants. The holding is still until morning unless a clerk comes, and the roll stays the clerk’s.

A **cohort** is the group a town sends when its own Hand cannot Turn its children this week. The group is kin, the children who are ten, and a warden’s word. It is not a company kept under arms.

Vaethod, the town-warden at Eolvaeth, has sent one toward Saelvaeth in years when the wood did not do the week’s work. The gospel in that town says wait, but the children are ten now, and the Given-door, the one week in which the wood can give them what it gives, is that week, so they go. They come back Given, or not, or unvouched, with no one who watched the standing. One unvouched arrival in the gift-hall is a year the town still argues. Saelid’s bread stall feels that winter, because the people who buy bread are the people the cohort takes away. There is no barracks to come back to. When the week is over the cohort breaks up, and people remember it by the summer it went.

The Mill-hold sends its ten-year-olds toward Brenthael when its Hand is unsound. Talen writes them on the neighbour-slate. That walk is the same kind of cohort. A bed-guild in Orenbren may take the slate for a town that failed. Talen writes it down as one more summer’s walk. The children are not soldiers, and the slate is not a muster-roll.

Between those sends, the people are at their stalls and their races. A power does not keep a cohort in the field as its ordinary year. A sent cohort from Eolvaeth stops at the thorn outside the vale and eats before they go on, even when the path is clear. They will not say why.

The Closing ran from Cut-year 19 to the Retreat in Cut-year 38, in the year-count the chronicles use. Riders tried to pull up copied wood, the trees towns had grown as copies of a Tree. The towns hid the slips, the cuttings those copies were grown from, and lodging-hearths would not starve their beds. By the end, Hildal closed a wall and saved a book, and the riders went home. The wall is the Inner Close, Rothallo, the walled capital inside Orenbren. The Book still ranks who owes. That ranking is a class rule, not a garrison on the wall. Nobody kept the riders as a host that could be called again.

A house on the Near Mile may still hang a kitchen knife on a ribbon beside a scorch on an old pot-ring. The people in the house know which summer that was. It was the Closing, and they do not turn out for it. The Low Wall is another stone, from another dig. A person who says the two walls are one wall is making a claim about the past. They are not raising a company.

The Hinge Hush is the peace on the Old Crossing. From Cut-year 299 to 304, the Hinge Shore and the Ledger Coast tied up each other’s hulls over who set the crossing’s price. People died in a fight about a toll. In Cut-year 304 they hushed. The hush is a rate, a west-water clause, and a refusal to name a winner. Taerso spoke for the hinge-houses. Sirtol spoke for a charter-pile on the Coast, one charter-holder among many, not the White Note and not a crown. Both could stop a berth. Neither sat a throne, and neither left an admiral’s fleet. When the hush held, the quays went back to cargo.

What the hush still collects is the rate, and the present year is Cut-year 387. Dock-bells on the Hinge Shore pause in Hale-month, the spring month, also called Haelren, because that pause is the fifth summer, and then the bells go back to loading. Netstrand still keeps hulls for hire under the west-water

clause, so a charter is one crossing with a number on it, and Orentel holds berths the hush made easier to keep. The White Note did not sign, and it does not keep ships. A necessity-family, people who have to make the crossing, pays the rate and is not told which summer made the number. When a landing argues the clause, the argument is the old peace still doing the job it was written for.

A door-custom, pinned inside a Lestrand night-gate, with no crest on it. The back of the page is a week-old rain note, and the writing on the front is what a stranger reads before the watch speaks.

> *Name. Last hearth. Who stands. Two will do. None, and you sit the bench until the second bell, or until someone comes to stand for you, or we walk you to the next gate. We do not ask your colour. We do not keep the three answers past dawn. If you are on a walk, say which. If you ate at the bed-house, say so. If you have a ticket, show the stool-mark, not a story. The bench is not a cell. The bench is until morning.*

The stool-mark is the stamp from the ticket-stool. The watch that pinned this up thinks “we do not ask your colour” makes the gate unlike Threnmaieth. The three questions are the whole of how citizenship works, run at a gate, and the watch does not write the answers down. That is how a city of tens of thousands still runs on hearths.

The three pillars: why the Conditioned *are* the legal system

Walk into a hearing and three Conditions are already the court. The law is not a set of rules imposed on the Conditioned from outside. These three are the legal apparatus, which is why a register is unnecessary.

A Long-Lived’s memory does not corrupt, and it runs back centuries, so the archivists, the notaries, and the judges are often Long-Lived. A matter of record is whatever they say they witnessed, even when the witnessing was a century ago. Where a forged document would be the worry, a Long-Lived simply remembers.

A Bound’s sworn oath is literally binding, and they hear a lie as it is told. That is why they keep the oaths, arbitrate the debts, and stand as the witnesses. When a treaty must truly hold, a Bound is the one who swears it.

A Far-Voiced cannot fake the feeling in the voice. Under strain the voice betrays it, so they cannot lie well once they are on the stand, and a court trusts them for that reason.

Evidence and contract in the Turning are therefore made of people. Memory that does not corrupt, an oath that hears a lie, and testimony that cannot fake a feeling are enough. The people who do those jobs were Given their Condition at the Tree or Struck with it later, so the courts do not need a paper

bureaucracy to do the work. A world with witnesses like these does not need to write everyone down, which is why the two crowns that insist on writing everyone down look so strange to everyone else.

Rights of the Kept

The Kept are the quiet centre of citizenship, and their legal position is gloriously unremarkable. They were witnessed at their Turning like everyone else. They carry no Tithe, they need no licence, and they answer to no guild. In most polities the Kept are the default legal person, the frame the rest of the law is drawn around. In one surviving compact they are also a ruling class. The Walled Book ranks the tithed, the people who carry a Condition and so owe a Tithe, and it will strike a Closed Heir for taking a colour.

The second word shows how the quiet position is felt. Vaethorn says *the Waited*, or *Mother-kept*, with pity, as if the Tree passed them over. Lestrand says *the free*, labor with no Tithe attached, and says it with approval. Threnmaieth says *the unmarked*, or *the passed-over*, and the clerks note the gap.

Two facts keep that quiet position from being a footnote. Kept status is not a permanent immunity. About a third of the children the Tree hugged are still Struck later, so a person who is Kept now lives untithed and unlicensed without ever standing wholly outside the safety rules. The day they are Struck, they too must be vouched anew. In law, “Kept” describes your present, and not a promise about your future.

Where reverence for the gift runs hot, the Kept can be quietly pitied or pressured, treated as people who missed out and leaned on to explain why the Tree passed them over. That is a social harm the law rarely names, and it runs hardest in the most devout polities.

The Given keep their plain name everywhere, and the second word is the stance again: *the gifted*, said as a blessing in Vaethorn; *the Given*, said as a plain fact on Lestrand; *the marked* in Threnmaieth, because the name goes on the roll.

Edge cases the law must hold

A few people do not fit the ordinary hour, and the law has to hold them without pretending the fit is easy.

The Hollow, the Unbound, raise a question of capacity and of protection. They were Bound, and at the signing they named a Pledge, a part of themselves the counterparty collects when a term-limited contract ends. Freed, and missing that piece, an isolated Hollow is pulled to sign again. The law has to decide whether they still have the capacity to be held to a new contract, and whether someone must protect them from one. Kinder polities extend a protective status, which can be a guardian, a claim on connection, or a bar on presenting them with fresh contracts. Harsher polities leave them to the pull.

The Given-Over, also called the Forfeit, is the sharpest wound this law has. It is a Bound who kept re-signing until the counterparty effectively owns the person, a living case of legal personhood erased by accumulated contract. The contract-guilds have a term of art for it precisely because the law has never fully decided at what point a person has bargained away enough of themselves to stop being one. The question keeps returning, and it has not become a settled rule. The pipeline that feeds those signings has a lived face. People call that desk the Holding Desk. Sold vouching, a paid person who will stand rather than a paper, is the Standing Trade.

Phoenix is not a licensing problem. One legendary person is alive at a time and cannot hide, so the question is political, a symbol no ruler controls, and whoever currently wants the one alive tries to own them or to protect them.

A child who missed the week, refused to stand, or never stood is **UnTurned**. They have no hug and no colour. Folk will still call that child Kept. The law files them as the person the town raised, vouched if someone will stand, and unwitnessed at the Tree. A second Leaf-Fall is not a remedy. The doors that Strike a person later still open in their own time.

Three polity stances

The rules above hold in every polity. The tone does not. Three choices carry most of the difference, and every polity sets each one separately.

Theology is how gift-devout the place is. It runs from an ardent Motherfaith, the faith of the Leaf-Mother, in which a Condition is a blessing and belonging is a birthright, through civic religion worn lightly, to frank secular pragmatism, and the odd local heresy. That choice sets how the Struck, the Kept, and the feared Conditions are read before the law even speaks.

Reach is whether the place is a Tree-rich core or a Tree-poor edge, which follows where the Trees grew out from the first one by graft, a living cutting set in new ground. Where healthy Trees stand, reach is full and the Given are dense. Where Trees are few, young, or sickening, the population runs higher on the Kept and on the Struck.

Governance is how far the state reaches onto the person. It runs from light guild self-rule, the ordinary arrangement, in which the craft polices its own and the crown charters the guild, all the way to a crown that writes its subjects down. That choice sets how far a safety licence becomes a way of watching people.

The three choices combine, and the combinations are places, not a single ladder. A devout frontier can hold ardent faith, thin reach, and almost no bureaucracy. A secular merchant republic can be rich in Trees, lightly governed, and worn thin of faith. A pious core kingdom can also be Watchful, so that the watching of people is dressed as sacred duty. A cold trade-city can have no reverence at all. Each has real supporters and a real cost. Three stances recur. The Waiting Lands, the Ledger Coast, and the

Tallied Crown are three whole polities set on those choices at once. A polity can be Warm and a frontier at the same time, and lightly or heavily governed, because theology is only one of the three.

The Warm *(high theology).* Law here flows straight from the Motherfaith's gift-theology, so a Condition is spoken of as a blessing, the Struck are vouched in graciously as people the Mother met at a later door, and a licence is framed as help in tending the gift rather than as policing. The stance is warmest near the Awakening Tree. Its injustice is soft and hard to name. Everyone is expected to serve their gift, so a guild's "vocation" shades into pressure, the Kept are pitied for missing out, and declining your Condition's obvious use reads as ingratitude to the Mother herself.

The Watchful *(governance at its extreme: a deliberate aberration).* At the far end of governance are crowns that break the world's norm and do write their people down. They do not trust living memory, so they keep a roll of every subject and of that subject's Condition. Written records are not what makes this unusual. Every polity has guild rolls, notarial acts, and tax ledgers. The aberration is a census of persons and their gifts, a record held on people, and two crowns keep one.

Threnmaieth calls its roll holy. The census names itself the **Threnhael** *(THREN-hayl)*: *thren*, sacred counting, set beside *hael*, whole and hale, so the name means "the keeping-whole." It sounds like care, the keeping of every subject hale, and it is surveillance. Clerks say they "keep the realm hale." Subjects are "kept whole." Outsiders hear "the Counting." On that roll the second name is the house, an old given name that stuck to a line, said where other lands would use a surname. Witness-lands, which still name you by who saw you, do not do this. Trenledd calls its list the roll and does not call it holy. At home each crown frames the roll as prudence and order. Elsewhere it is felt as surveillance.

Under either roll the unvouched are hunted, and the Struck are pursued so they can be catalogued. Tithe-needs become points of leverage. The Bound especially are watched far past their real hazard, since the Whisper cannot command and the clerks know it, so the extra watch is stigma carried out as safety. Most of the world finds the two rolls chilling, because nobody else keeps a roll of everyone. The Walled Book's heir-roll lists only its own heirs. When a Watchful kingdom is also devout and Tree-rich, that watching is dressed as sacred duty.

The Frontier *(low reach).* Far from any healthy Tree, even the witnessing runs thin, and custom outruns law. These lands run higher on the Kept and higher on the Struck: more hugs, more later doors, fewer coloured falls. In town, people read that as distance and as young wood. They are freer in the good sense, because no one asks for a licence, and the Taken-In, whom cities keep at a social arm's length and still employ on the lots, are simply neighbours here and the backbone of the frontier economy. They are harsher in the bad sense, because an unvouched Struck person may have no one to stand for them and no guild to train them, and a feared Condition may meet a rope where a city would have issued a licence. Reach and governance often move together. A thin-reach edge tends to be thinly governed too. They need not. A devout frontier exists, and so does a lightly governed core.

Economy and the Tithe

In a world organized only around what people want, the work follows the appetite. In the Turning the work also follows what people have become. A **Kind** is what a person is by birth, already true before any leaf falls. A **Condition** is the change laid over that Kind, and three of every four people come to carry one. Every Condition has a **Tithe**, a permanent upkeep, and if the upkeep lapses the Condition's dangerous side shows. Once that many people carry one, the need stops being a private matter between a person and their gift.

The ordinary technology of the age is late medieval: guilds, letters of credit, merchant houses, and no exchange where a stranger buys a share of a company. The world moves past that age only where Condition-labor carries it, which is work that exists because someone carries a Condition. Those are its only advances. The roster of who carries what lives in *The Conditions*. The law under the markets is the chapter before this one.

Tithe-provision is a permanent civic utility, in the same way wells and roads are. You can see it in every town, people fight over it, and the people who depend on it cannot do without it. It is not the size of grain. Grain feeds everyone, every day. The greens and the halls keep an exposed minority from sliding into the danger their Tithe was holding back, and they keep the neighbours from having to live beside that slide. That is enough to organize a sector of a town's work. It is not the food supply.

Society organizes around the Conditioned, the people who carry a Condition, for that reason, rather than from reverence or from fear. The work fits the Tithe, and there is a net under the people whose Tithe does not pay itself. Most of the Conditioned pay by working, because for them the need and the job are the same act. A smaller share has to be furnished by someone else. The ones who furnish, and the ones who need furnishing, are often the same people. Whoever holds the gate holds power.

Who actually buys provision

The share of people with each Condition is in *The Conditions*. This table sorts people by how they pay, and it gives no numbers of its own.

Who	Conditions	What “provision” is
Self-paying by vocation	the Answered · Two-Bodied · the Stilled	The work is the Tithe. They do not buy a sector of the economy. They are a labor market.
If the work fits	Far-Voiced · Returned	They pay their own Tithe when the job fits. When it does not, they buy a hall-hour, an hour booked so a Far-Voiced voice can be let out, or they carry the need unpaid.
Provided-for	the Taken-In · Long-Lived · the Unbound · Bound Terms	Someone else supplies the green, the novelty, the warmth, or whatever clause the contract set.
The Kept	no Condition	No Tithe. They buy bread. They do not buy a lot-hour, which is an hour on the city’s living green.

Green is free on a farm, and most Taken-In live where it is free. The purchased or civic customer base is a minority of the people, and it concentrates in the stone towns: urban Taken-In, hall-users who have no stage of their own, people seeking novelty, and warmth that money can only approximate. The queues at those doors are real. The doors are not granaries. A city fights over lot-hours and over hall-bells, the hours a voice is allowed to vent, the way it fights over wells. A wilt for lack of green, or a Cry breaking in the square, is a public problem. Tithe-goods do not move in the grain carts, and they do not rival bread by the cartload.

Self-paying vs provided-for Tithes

Not all Tithes cost the same to pay, and some do not cost coin at all, because paying them is doing useful work. That sorts the Conditioned along a range from self-paying to provided-for, and almost everything else follows from where a Condition sits. The line is a range, not a wall. Which side a person lands on can depend on the work they actually do, not only on the Condition. Far-Voiced and Returned are where that shows.

Self-paying Tithes are the ones where the work is the payment. For several Conditions, the upkeep is discharged by doing exactly the labor other people need done. The cost of staying whole and the work they produce are the same act.

Condition	The Tithe	…paid by doing
the Answered	use the element in earnest	**The craft itself.** A Tide-Answered shipwright, one whose element is the water, slakes the Tithe by building the ship.
Two-Bodied	spend time as the animal	**The ranging work:** herding, rescue, courier, scout. Being the beast is the job.
the Stilled	burn off the Grey by exertion	**Active labor:** surgery, riot-lines, demolition. The Grey is the stillness each Gaze leaves in the body. The vigorous work clears it. Left full, that stillness locks one of their own limbs.

On the seam, a person self-pays if the vocation fits, and falls to being provided-for if it does not. Two Conditions do not sit cleanly in either column. Where they land turns on the job.

Condition	The Tithe	Self-pays when…	Falls to provided-for when…
Far-Voiced	vent strong emotion each day	The vocation is the vent. Performers, criers, negotiators, and sworn witnesses feel in earnest on the job, and that feeling discharges the Tithe.	The voice has no outlet: an isolated posting, dull labor, or simple silence. They need a venting-hall furnished so the voice can be let out.
Returned	act toward the Purpose	The Purpose, the unfinished task they came back carrying, lines up with the work. Plague wards, recovery, and tending the dead pay the Tithe by being the deadly job.	The Purpose is personal or unmet by any trade: a vengeance, a vow, a person still to find. No employer can furnish it, and it pulls against ordinary work.

Provided-for Tithes are upkeep someone else has to supply. For the rest, the Tithe is a cost with no productive by-product. Someone has to furnish the green, the novelty, or the warmth, and that furnishing is the town’s Tithe-provision.

Condition	The Tithe	…must be provided
the Taken-In	rest on living land	**Green:** trivial on the farm, and a real expense in a stone city, where it means potted groves and leave to use a garden.
Long-Lived	learn something genuinely new	**Novelty:** books, travel, correspondence, and the ordinary traffic of a university town.
the Unbound	keep connecting to others	**Warmth:** company, and being known. It is the one Tithe money buys least well.
Bound	keep the Terms	**Whatever the counterparty set down,** which is idiosyncratic and sometimes ruinous.

The self-payers are prosperous almost automatically, because their Condition is a trade. Prosperity is not the same thing as ease. The Stilled self-pay and are still the most tightly licensed people in the world. The Answered self-pay under heavy guild discipline. Self-paying buys a living. It does not buy social comfort along with the living. The provided-for are economically exposed. They depend on someone furnishing the upkeep, and whoever furnishes it holds power over them. The people on the seam are the most precarious of all. A Far-Voiced who loses the stage, or a Returned whose Purpose turns personal, can slide from self-paying to exposed overnight. That slide is where the injustice runs.

Tithe-poverty and the safety net

Because the provided-for Tithes cost money, you can be too poor to stay whole. A Taken-In who cannot afford green, a Long-Lived with no access to anything new, a Far-Voiced with nowhere to vent: these people do not only suffer want. They slide toward the danger, into the wilting, the fade, or the involuntary Cry, a voice breaking out because it was not let out on purpose. Destitution here has a visible, dangerous face.

Who pays for that provision is the political question, and polities do not answer it the same way.

Where provision is treated as a public good, which is the Warm answer, the devout end of the world's theology, the town keeps it the way it keeps roads and wells. There are town greenhouses, free venting-halls, and endowed libraries, because a town whose Conditioned stay whole is a town that stays safe and keeps working. The pious way of saying the same choice is that you help every person tend their gift.

Where provision is left as a private burden, harsher polities hand it to the individual and to the guild. The Tithe-poor fall. They become a real hazard to the people around them, and the same polities then police the fall instead of preventing it.

The cynical middle is leverage. The town, the guild, or the employer does provide the Tithe, and holds what it provides, so the furnisher can withhold it. How that lands on the stances is at the end of this chapter.

Labor: who does what

The Tithe and the vocation are usually the same shape, which is why a town's jobs sound like its Conditions. How large each workforce is lives in *The Conditions*. What follows is the work, not a census.

The people who move things are the Two-Bodied, and they are the plurality, the largest share of any Condition. Herding, haulage, rescue, courier, and scouting sit on them, and so does the fighting when a war actually comes. The Condition runs in blood, so a family can be wolf-folk or hawk-folk straight through, and the trade comes down with the animal.

The food those herds and that haulage depend on is Taken-In work: farmers, foresters, herders, and wardens. The frontier runs on them because they thrive on living land. A city still needs their grain, so it keeps a working minority inside the walls, at the social arm's length the next section describes. The distance is manners. It is not an empty workplace.

Once the goods are moving, someone has to be heard across the distance. Far-Voiced criers stand on the coasts, the roads, and the borders, and the same people perform, negotiate, and swear as witnesses when a court needs a feeling that cannot be faked. The relay is a live signal from coast to border. A medieval world would not otherwise have it, and it exists because the people posting it carry the voice.

The crafts that shape the materials are the Answered, guilded by the element they use in earnest. Ember is the smiths and the glasswrights, Tide the shipwrights and the dyers, Root the masons and the potters, Gale the sailmakers and the millers. When a fire breaks out, or a rescue needs those same hands, the guilds rotate into it.

Some of the work kills the living, so the Returned do it. Death cannot take them a second time until the Purpose is met, and the jobs are the plague ward, the mine after a collapse, the deep salvage, and the tending of the dead. Beside that, the Stilled do the work that needs a body held still: surgery, a riot-line, a demolition, a course of stone. They are licensed, and the guild disciplines them, because the Gaze is the hazard as well as the tool.

What has to be remembered, the archives and the notarial acts and the judgments and the banks, sits with the Long-Lived. They are few. If many more people never died, those chairs would stiffen and stop changing hands. Where a word has to hold, the Bound keep the oaths, the debts, and the treaties, and they stand as witnesses whose word is literally binding. The Unbound are in that same work. A released Bound is not a second workforce. They go back to whatever they did before, and they need other people if they are to keep at it.

A Phoenix is only a trace, and the economy does not employ them as a class of worker. They are a political symbol, not a trade. The Kept are the inversion of that whole ledger. They carry no Tithe, so there is no upkeep to fund, and they carry no Condition, so no Condition-guild claims them. They take ordinary work and move where the work is. Where the faithful pity them for missing a gift, the ledger calls them the least encumbered people in the world, a real freedom sitting under the slight.

Why Taken-In live in stone cities

Green costs money in a stone city, and the cities keep the Taken-In at arm's length because the Taken-In thrive on the frontier. Both are true. Arm's length is how the polite districts stand toward the bark and antler a Taken-In carries on the body. The lots are still staffed.

They are in the city for five ordinary reasons.

1. **They were Given here.** A copper-green leaf, the Taken-In's colour, fell at a city Tree. Family, work, and a hearth-witness are what keep them. Leaving the city would mean leaving the circle that saw them Turn.
2. **Grain and timber come in, and people come with them.** Seasonal Taken-In work the quays and winter over, and some of them stay. They are the harvest-hands who do not go home in Hale-month, the spring month, also called Haelren.
3. **The lot is a job.** The greens-keepers need Taken-In labor. The city imports that green-skill for the commons, and then will not sit the workers at the high table.
4. **The door can open in a city's old green.** Being lost and dying in a deep wild is the Struck path that makes a Taken-In. A walled grove, a lot at night, or a river-garden after a flood can open the same door. It is rare, and it is often enough to count.
5. **They cannot afford to leave.** Green-poverty is a trap. You need the lot if you are to stay whole, the lot is gated, you work for the hours on it, and you never save the cart-fare home. That trap is the city's book of the Slide, the illicit market in Tithe-goods. Week-keepers sell it, and the green is what they sell when the gate will not.

The Taken-In share of the whole world is in *The Conditions*. A stone city runs lower than that share. The Taken-In who are there concentrate on the lots, the orchards, the river-gardens, and the week-keeper's pot, the private green that same trade rents by the week. There are enough of them to make a queue, enough for a wilt two streets off the lot, and enough for the Slide to have a customer. The frontier keeps the density and the honour. The city keeps the gate.

Banking and the deathless houses

The banks of the Turning do not die. These are the **deathless houses**. A Long-Lived founds the house and is still personally running it two centuries later, the same memory, the same word, and the same

unbroken ledger. In a world of letters of credit and merchant houses, that continuity is the great advance a Condition makes in finance. A letter of credit is a written promise to pay, carried in place of a chest of coin. Three things follow.

The trusted note. A note from a deathless house is trusted almost as coin, because everyone knows the banker cannot forget a debt, cannot be quietly succeeded by a defaulting heir, and will personally answer for the paper in fifty years. Their paper circulates further than any crown's, and it holds its value better. Other paper is trusted by how close it comes to that word. The nearest thing this world has to a standard that does not wear out is the word of a house that will not die.

The long instrument. Deathless houses lend and endow on horizons no mortal lender would risk: century loans, multi-generation trusts, and the patient financing of cathedrals, canals, and universities. The instruments are letters of credit and endowments. There is no stock exchange, and no company split into shares a crowd of strangers can buy.

The concentration risk. Wealth that never passes to an heir never disperses through inheritance. The great scattering that a death forces on every other fortune does not happen here. There are few of the deathless, and even so they can slowly gather an outsized share of the capital that stands still. Their small number is what keeps that share from becoming the whole of standing capital, and the economy has never fully resolved the gathering. An endowment does not undo it. The coin moves out, and the steering stays, so the influence concentrates even while the cash flows into institutions the same hands still direct.

Many of the houses began as road-houses in the Walking Years, the age when families still had to walk to Thaeloren. They were inns, beds, and century-credit for that road. The everyday name is still road-house. The cant, the working nickname, is *brenhael (BREN-hael)*, "the hearth kept whole." The lived version is a house still in the act of being an inn: the Held bed, a bed kept for a name that has not come, and a note a necessity-family pays on the home-walk, which is to say they eat now and pay when they walk home. When the walk stopped being required in the core, the lands nearest the Awakening Tree, the same Long-Lived still remembered every debtor, and the paper outlived the pilgrimage season. The inns became banks. Two fates of that memory are still standing, on opposite errands. The White Note House took the path of collecting on the old paper. The Third Hearth kept making the bed. The trusted note is an instrument from the Walking Years that outlived the road it was written for.

Inheritance and the problem of not dying

Inheritance law is bent by the deathless, and the bend is a grief as well as a rule. A Long-Lived's children are not guaranteed to inherit the Condition. Most of them age and die while the parent does not. A deathless person therefore outlives most of the heirs, and the estate never enters the inheritance stream at all. A fortune that is never passed down still has to go somewhere.

The usual answer is that the deathless endow. They have no line of heirs waiting on the death, and their own Tithe needs a steady supply of novelty, new books, new scholarship, new things to learn. A Long-Lived characteristically funds the institutions that generate that knowledge: the libraries, the universities, the archives. The deathless banker becomes the deathless patron, and pays their own Tithe by building the places that feed it. It is also how they grieve, an endowment in the name of a child who died a century ago. It is not the same thing as letting the fortune go. An endowment converts coin into patronage that is permanent and directed. Because the founder does not die, the founder keeps the chair, names the scholars, and steers the institution for centuries. Endowment eases the concentration of coin, because liquid wealth flows out into public works, and it deepens the concentration of influence, because the same few deathless hands still guide the universities, the courts, and the archives their money built. Keeping the Long-Lived few does not end that lock-up. The lock-up changes shape, from hoarded coin to patronage that does not step down.

For everyone else, inheritance is ordinary, except in the Two-Bodied bloodlines, where the Condition, the family's animal, and often the family's trade descend together, so that a place in the guild and a Condition can be a single inheritance. The sharpest question the law still has open is economic at the root. The Given-Over is a Bound who contracted away so much of themselves that the counterparty effectively owns the person. That is the ultimate inheritance failure: an estate, and a self, absorbed by a creditor.

Center and periphery

The economy is not spread evenly, and the unevenness follows the same geography that shapes the law. Near the mature Trees, in the core, Conditions lie thick, the guilds are strong, and specialized Condition-work and the goods that come from it are what the core sells to everyone else. Out at the margins, on the frontier, the giving thins. More of the people there are generalist Kept, or Struck and untrained, and fewer of them are Given specialists.

The core exports the specialized work and the finished goods, Answered crafts, Stilled medicine, deathless-house credit, and it imports the raw staples. The frontier leans hardest on the Taken-In, who thrive there and are neighbours, and on Kept labor that can turn its hand to whatever the week needs. It exports food, timber, and raw materials, and it imports the specialists it cannot grow. Distance, spoilage, and the thin reach together make the friction real. They leave the frontier specialist-poor and self-reliant. Cities still keep a working minority of Taken-In behind a gate. They do not ship the Condition out of town.

The shadow economy

Every gate grows a market on the far side of it. The gates in this economy are Tithe-provision and vouching.

Illicit Tithe-supply. Where the legitimate provision is rationed, gated, or unaffordable, a shadow market fills the gap. The green it smuggles is for a Taken-In cut off from living land, and the customers of that urban book are the city-Given, the winter-stayers, and the people caught in the lot-hour trap. The same market keeps unlicensed venting-rooms, and it sells black-market novelty, rare texts and forbidden knowledge, to a Long-Lived who is starving for anything new. The customer is someone already sliding toward the wilting, the fade, or the involuntary Cry, which makes the trade both lucrative and cruel. In the street this trade is called **the Slide**. The same people are called week-keepers, because the sale is rented by the week.

Off-book contracts. The whole domain of the Bound has an underside: contracts sworn outside the honest tables, unregistered terms, and the predatory brokers who arrange them. That pipeline feeds the Given-Over. In the street this desk is called **the Holding Desk**. It sells clauses. It is not the Slide.

Sold vouching. Citizenship here is a place counting you as its own because a person will stand for you, rather than because a clerk has written your name down. The unvouched will buy a voucher, and a market exists in dubious character-witnesses. The one thing that cannot be faked is a Long-Lived's memory, which is why an honest vouch from them is priceless and a corrupt one is catastrophic. In the street this market is called **the Standing Trade**. It sells a person who will stand. It is not the Slide.

The Slide sells the upkeep. The Holding Desk sells clauses. The Standing Trade sells a witness.

How polities vary (economic faces)

The rules of the Tithe are the same everywhere. Who actually receives what is politics. It follows the same three choices as the law: how gift-devout the polity is, how many healthy Trees it has, and how far the state reaches onto the person. Three stances keep recurring, and each has an economic face.

The Warm *(high theology).* A Warm polity treats Tithe-provision as a public good. It keeps town greenhouses, venting-halls and libraries that someone has endowed, and ranging-commons held in common, ground at the edge where the Two-Bodied can be their other selves. The Conditioned are kept whole at the town's expense, because a whole populace is a safe and productive one, and because the faith says to tend every gift. The economic injustice is soft. The same help arrives with an expectation attached. You are helped to tend your gift, and you are quietly obligated to spend it as the community sees fit, until the subsidy shades into conscription, a requirement to spend the gift as the town decides.

The Watchful *(governance at its extreme).* A crown that writes its people down, as the Tallied Crown and the Worn Count do, turns the need of a Tithe into leverage. It provides, and it provides efficiently, even generously, and it holds what it provides. The green, the outlet, and the novelty all come through channels the crown controls and can withhold. Its deathless-house finance is superb and centuries-deep. The injustice is cold and precise. A population whose upkeep runs through the state is a

population that cannot afford to refuse the state. It is the most complete control in the world, and it is dressed as care.

The Frontier *(low reach).* There is little formal infrastructure for the Tithe, and there are few specialists. People improvise a way to meet the need, or they go without. The freedom is real. There is no guild monopoly and no crown holding the Tithe, and the Taken-In are neighbours rather than curiosities. The harshness is also real. The provided-for who cannot pay their Tithe slide with no net, and untrained Struck people manage dangerous Conditions alone. At the edge the economy runs on barter and favors, cash-poor and land-rich.

A polity's economy is set by where it stands on all three choices at once. A devout frontier runs commons-minded charity with almost no infrastructure to fund it. A secular Tree-rich republic has deep markets and thin welfare. A Watchful-and-pious core turns generous provision into the tightest hold in the world.

Daily Life

Most families in the Turning are ordinary, and that is the first thing to understand about them. Two people marry. Some of the household carry a **Condition**, the change that arrives across a life, and some do not. The children have not Turned yet, and will not until their tenth year. A **Kind** is what a person is by birth, the ancestry they arrived in, and a Condition stacks onto that Kind. It can arrive years later. A **Tithe** is the upkeep a Condition keeps requiring, and it shows up in a house as a cost, a noise, or a door left waiting. A wife born a Selkie, one of the seal-people, a husband Returned from a drowning, a Kept grandmother, three children who are simply children so far: this is not a remarkable household. It is the household. Because nearly every family is mixed in that way, mixed families are not a category anyone thinks about. There is no unmixed household to marry away from, so nobody treats the mix as a departure, and nobody keeps a separate name for it.

Family, the whole spectrum

Family life spreads along a range, and the spread itself is the point.

At the warm, mundane end, which is most families, a Condition is a texture of the household the way a trade or a temperament is. A Two-Bodied parent's other self has a name, and the children know it. A child says, "That's Bramble, mother's otter," and grows up with that other self as much a part of the family as a pet that is also a person. A Far-Voiced household is a loud one, because the Tithe means feeling must be aired each day. You do not get to sulk quietly in a home with a Far-Voiced in it, and families learn to treat the evening's singing, or weeping, or laughing, as ordinary weather. A Taken-In parent keeps the windows open and the rooms green. These are quirks rather than tragedies, the small daily accommodations of living with people who are also in the middle of what they have become.

In the middle, the Tithe becomes a shared family labor. Where a Condition is provided-for, kept whole by something the household has to furnish, keeping a family member whole is a household expense and a household duty. The green for the Taken-In, the books for the Long-Lived, the outlet for the Far-Voiced. Families organize around it the way a household organizes around a member's chronic need, mostly without drama, sometimes with strain, and with the quiet knowledge that to let a loved one's Tithe lapse is to watch them slide toward the harm that Tithe was holding back. A family too poor to furnish a Tithe carries a particular grief. They can see exactly what their kin needs, and they cannot buy it.

At the aching end sits the marriage ordinary life keeps returning to: loving someone whose span of years is not yours. Chief among these is marrying a Long-Lived. Their aging simply stops. Their spouse's does not. A Long-Lived can have children and a full family, but the Condition is not reliably inherited. Most children age and die like anyone, so a Long-Lived does not build a deathless dynasty. They outlive it. They watch a spouse grow old across a marriage that stays, on one side, unchanged. They bury their children. The old saying is that the cost of the Long-Lived is measured in funerals, and it is a cost paid inside the family, at the dinner table, over decades. A Long-Lived who has done this once faces the choice their whole existence turns on. They can stop, live on alone, and keep no more households. Or they can begin again, marry again, love again, and outlive that family too. Neither choice is cowardly, and neither is free. The grief lives in the most ordinary place there is, which is a marriage.

A few threads run through that range, and each of them is a way a house already knows its own people.

A Long-Lived never crosses another's home threshold uninvited. It is held as the deepest good manners, the mark of someone safe to let in. Inside a family this softens into something tender. To be welcomed across a Long-Lived's own threshold, or to welcome them across yours without a thought, is a real intimacy. A door held open is how this world says you are mine and I am yours. A door refused is felt more than a Long-Lived will ever say.

A person who died and Returned comes home, and contrary to what an outsider expects, they are not cold. They are calm, deliberate, unafraid, and quietly respected, and their loved ones get them back. The chill comes only if the Purpose lapses. The Purpose is the unfinished thing that holds them here, and a Returned who neglects it runs cold. The living can feel the wrongness at a touch. So a Returned's family learns a hard and intimate literacy. You can tell, by an embrace, whether the one you love is tending what holds them here. A warm embrace means they are well. A cold one is a family emergency dressed as a hug.

Two-Bodied bloodlines are family lines. The Condition runs in blood, and children of a Two-Bodied parent usually Turn the same animal, so wolf-folk, hawk-folk, and otter-folk are real extended families. The family animal, the Condition, and often the family trade descend as a single inheritance. Marrying into such a line is marrying into a shape your children will likely wear.

Every parent lives the same open question until the child's tenth year: what will they become, or will they be Kept? In a devout home a parent will say the Mother will give what the child can carry. In an anxious one the decade is quiet dread, or ambition. Parents who carry a heritable Condition, Two-Bodied especially, can half-guess. Most cannot. The Leaf-Fall, the rite inside Turning-Week when the child stands under the Tree, is therefore not only the civic hour of the year but the emotional hinge of a family's life, the day you finally meet who your child has been becoming all along. In the Walking Years, when a Giving still required the walk to Thaeloren, the Awakening Tree, the question had a prior, which was whether the household could get there at all. A household that could walk only one

child still lives in the present as two siblings, one Given at the origin and one UnTurned, who never stood under a Tree. Folk still call that UnTurned child Kept. The law does not.

Mixed-Kind children are allowed. Two mainland Kinds may sit in one body, the way the rules already allow a mixed ancestry, and a fox-and-seal child, Kitsune and Selkie together, is as ordinary as a Returned husband. Nobody files the marriage. Nobody calls it marrying out. The live question is whose kitchen the summer before they Turn, not whether the marriage was permitted. Yumboe, the people of the Sundering Isle, are the exception. A Yumboe at the table needs the GM's leave, because they are mythic-rare off the isle, and if one is seated they are the full Kind, never a mix. A child of a Yumboe and a mainlander is a full Yumboe, under that same leave, or the mainland Kind, with at most a story people tell about the child. There is never a half.

Medicine: miraculous, and strange to outside eyes

Medicine in the Turning is astonishing for a late-medieval world, a world of guilds and bone and herb with no anaesthetic worth the name, and it is astonishing for one reason. The work a Condition makes possible shows up hardest at the sickbed and the deathbed. Two Conditions turn a clinic into something a world of this technology should not have. To anyone standing outside it, the room holds wonder and wrongness together.

The Stilled are the surgeons. A stiller's Gaze arrests motion. It holds a wound from bleeding, slows a poison's spread through the blood, and keeps a patient perfectly still under the knife without holding them down. It does not petrify, and it does not harm. It simply stops what is moving, for a beat. In a world that cannot halt a hemorrhage any other way, this is the difference between a survivable operation and a death. The best surgeons in the world are Stilled, and a great infirmary is built around them. Sit in that room as an outsider and watch what it is. A surgeon's flat, patient gaze freezes the blood in the vein on command, and the surgeon works fast because the Grey is filling as they work. The Grey is the stillness the Gaze leaves in the surgeon, the clock of their Tithe, and a Grey left full locks their own limb to stone. They drill and spar between patients to burn it off. The most gifted healers in the world are also the most tightly licensed and quietly feared. The same gaze that saves you on the table can, misused, hold a person helpless, and it is the one the law watches hardest. Wonder and dread, one person, one room.

The Returned do the work that kills the living. Plague wards, mine collapses, the recovery of bodies from places the living cannot safely go, and the tending of the dead: this is Returned work, done by those death cannot take a second time until their Purpose is met. A Turning mortuary is staffed by the Returned, people who have been dead, calmly and well. A plague ward that would empty a town's living physicians is walked by Returned who are unshaken by rot and contagion. To an outsider this is ghoulish. Inside, it is simply respected. The Returned are the reason a plague does not take the doctors

too, and everyone knows it. There is a real tenderness in it as well. No one speaks for the dead, or tends them, as gently as someone who has been dead.

The rest of medicine is ordinary, and ordinarily unequal. Midwives, bonesetters, herbalists, and the Answered's craft turned to apothecary and instrument-making do the everyday care. More of the population carries a useful becoming, so that everyday care is better staffed than a town of this technology would otherwise manage. The care that makes the world exceptional is not evenly available. The great Stilled infirmaries and the deathless-endowed hospitals stand in the rich, Tree-dense core. A frontier town makes do with a travelling stiller if it is lucky, and with cloth, a rope, and a prayer if it is not. The deepest inequity is the one the economy already names. You can be too poor to stay whole, and the medicine that treats a lapsing Condition is the medicine the poor can least reach. The wonder is real. So is the queue outside it.

Living in a Turning town: city design

A city here is shaped by a fact no other world's city has to build for. Most of its adults have an upkeep, and some of those upkeeps are dangerous or expensive to meet. So the town builds for the Tithe the way it builds for water and waste, as civic infrastructure, visible and load-bearing.

Every town is organized around its Turning Tree. It is the civic and sacred heart, the site of the year's most-attended week, the thing the oldest quarter grew up around. You can read a town's age and standing in its Tree. A mature grafted Tree, grown from a cutting of an older one, means an old town where the giving runs thick. A young Tree, or none, means a new settlement or a frontier one. Geography and the street plan both point back to it. Older uses sit in the same square, a stone, an upper room, a road that ends at the boughs. If you want one of those squares under your feet, Harrow's Green is the neighbour's canopy on Heskoren's live front, and new towns still say they Turned at Harrow's Tree before they had their own. The three hamlets past the ford can see that green from the water, and they still have to send their ten-year-olds on. Further out, the Third Hearth is the road-house on the Near Mile that stayed an inn, the bed still made, and Ornsael is the well-town on the Rain-Shadow, where the drink that made people stop is leaving. When the question is a whole polity rather than one square, the seats are Eolvaeth in the Waiting Lands, Orentel on the Ledger Coast, and Maiethlir under the Tallied Crown.

A village watches a Turning as one circle. A city of tens of thousands does not pretend to be one. Turning-Week is still the civic festival, and the legal witness is the hearth that brought the child, the street or the quay-gang or the courtyard. The square is full. The memory is nested.

Where the polity treats provision as a public good, the town furnishes it in the open, and these buildings are as ordinary in the street as a well or a market cross. They are wells, not granaries. Grain still feeds the city. The lots and the halls keep a minority whole, and they keep a Cry, a Far-Voiced voice breaking loose, out of the market.

Everyday speech calls the venting-hall the **ael-hall**, pronounced AYL, “the airing.” It is part concert hall and part a place to let the voice out, and it often is the town’s performance venue as well. In Vaethorn, the Waiting Lands, the same building is the gift-hall. On Lestrand, the Ledger Coast, it is the release-house, and it is also the playhouse. In Threnmaieth, the Tallied Crown, it is the counted hall.

The greens are the potted groves and the garden-commons, the living plants a Taken-In in the city rests on so they do not go to seed indoors. Everyday speech just says **the greens**. A devout town in the Waiting Lands calls the same ground the Mother’s green, after the Mother the devout name, and holds it in common. On the Ledger Coast it is the leaf-lot, rented by the season. Under the Tallied Crown it is the tended green, because the crown is who furnishes it.

The long-house of books is the endowed library. It feeds a Long-Lived’s need to learn something genuinely new, and a Long-Lived is often the person who built it. In the Waiting Lands that gift is called the deathless gift, because the patron does not die. On the Ledger Coast the money set aside is the endowment, or simply the house. The Tallied Crown calls the shelves the crown archive, and the books sit with the crown.

Out at the edge, **the ranging** is the commons where the Two-Bodied can be their other selves. The Waiting Lands call it the wild-leave, which is leave to go out into the wild. The Ledger Coast calls it the beast-yard and hires the yard. The Tallied Crown calls it the ranging-roll, because someone writes down who went.

The night-watch and the ward-watch are part of the same street. They hold a person until morning, and at a gate they ask three things: a name, the last hearth, and who stands. They are not police sent after a Condition.

The work that can harm a bystander sits where such work always sits, at the margins. Stilled infirmaries and Answered workshops, fire and forge and tide, are guild-quartered and set slightly apart. The Returned’s mortuaries and plague-work sit at the town’s edge, near the dead. They sit there for the same reason a tannery sits downwind, and not from disgust.

Ordinary houses bend quietly to what the people in them have become. Windows open, and rooms stay green, for a Taken-In guest. An evening’s rhythm is built around a Far-Voiced’s vent. A threshold is a place a Long-Lived waits to be asked across. You can read the household in the house.

Core and frontier show in how much of that provision is there at all. Dense, Tree-rich towns are thick with it. Frontier settlements have little of it and improvise. How much of a town’s Tithe-provision is public, private, or simply missing tells you where that town sits.

How polities vary (domestic faces)

Everyday life varies on the same three choices as the law and the economy: how gift-devout the place is, how many healthy Trees it has, and how far the state reaches into a house. Three stances recur.

The Warm *(high theology).* In a Warm house the gift-theology is simply how the family talks. A child's Turning is a joyous sacrament, a mixed household is read as blessings compounded, the Tithe is furnished in the open, and the sick are tended as people whose gifts must be kept whole. The soft injustice reaches the same hearth. The Kept child is pitied for being passed over, marrying "beneath your gift" is quietly frowned on, and the family is expected to spend its members' Conditions as the community sees fit, so the love and the pressure arrive in the same kindness.

The Watchful *(governance at its extreme).* A crown that keeps a roll of persons, as the Tallied Crown and the Worn Count do, does not stop at the door. Marriages of heritable Conditions may be noticed and then encouraged or discouraged, a child's Turning is an event the state records, and the medicine that furnishes a Tithe runs through channels the crown controls. The cold injustice is that domestic surveillance. A household whose upkeep and bloodline are both on file cannot easily refuse the crown anything.

The Frontier *(low reach).* Infrastructure, medicine, and ceremony all run thin, so families improvise their own Tithe-provision or do without, and a travelling stiller is a rare blessing. The Taken-In, whom core cities keep at arm's length, are neighbours and kin here, the backbone of the place. No one polices your marriage or your gift. A lapsing Condition may have no infirmary to reach, and an untrained Struck child, someone the change came to outside a guild, may have no guild to catch them. The feeling runs warm. The net under a lapse is thin.

A place's daily texture is set by all three choices at once. A devout frontier holds joyous Turnings with almost no infirmary behind them. A secular Tree-rich republic has superb medicine and a marriage market that shrugs at theology. A Watchful-and-pious core turns the sacrament of a child's Turning into a state census with a hymn over it.

When the town buries

A funeral is the hour a street has a body to carry. It is a walk, and then a meal, and then a door. It is not a Turning. Nobody asks the Tree what the dead person was, and nobody stands the body under the branches for a colour.

The body is washed in the house, often by someone who is Returned, because that labour is already their street. The family still chooses the cloth. Then the neighbours carry the body. In a town with a Tree, the carry goes past the canopy, along the street the person used when they were alive, and the body is not stood under the boughs. A tree-warden may walk with the house. If the house wants a name said, the warden says Maieth, the short name the devout use for the Leaf-Mother, and says it the

way a neighbour would. If the house has asked for silence, the warden walks without speaking. Both of those walks are the same office.

Neighbours bring food to the door, and the door stays open through the meal. The person who is going to sleep in the house that night is the one who shuts it, or else the person the house has asked.

A Long-Lived who loved the dead waits on the step until someone says come in. That waiting is already how a household treats a deathless life, a life long enough that the funerals in it have to be counted, and this hour is one of them. It is still a door and a loaf.

Because a mixed house is the usual house, the meal is mixed, and each person does their own small rite at their own bowl. Nobody stops the eating to argue which name ought to come first. That argument can have the time after the dishes. A Motherfaith sibling says Maieth over their own bowl and means the life that has ended. A sibling of the Watching does not thank a giver. They talk about the dead as they were at the stall in Gift-month, the summer month after Turning-Week, when the colours have settled: the coat, the argument, the way they counted change.

If the dead kept a book, a Settler of the Fair Hand closes it on the table, where the room can see the last line, and does not write a new one. A kin-speaker of the Old Ways sets a little of the meal at the threshold, and if the dead kept those ways, the rest of the food goes to the door once the street has finished. Ancestors in that rite are kin who stayed in the ground. A return is a different matter, a Returned person still living a neighbour’s life, and you do not summon one. The food at the threshold is the funeral. It is not a calling.

Nobody Speaks a fall. To Speak, at a living child’s Leaf-Fall, is to say aloud whether the Tree gave a colour or a hug. Speaking a fall over the dead would mean naming a colour as if the Tree were being asked to answer, and the room does not do it. A neighbour who tries is walked outside by whoever is nearest the pot.

On a dock, if the dead person worked the water at Orentel, the gang carries the box along the quay. The box does not go under Tallo, the quay’s name for its Tree, to be read. Some of the gang say “fair wind, fair term,” because that is the sentence they already have for a leaving. Some of them will not say it, because they keep that sentence for a hull that is still going out. Both of those things happen in the same hour, and the gang does not stop the carry to settle which is right. If there is a book, it is closed where the gang can see that it has been closed. Salt sits on the Tree’s roots in Eolthael, Turning-month, the month of the High Solstice. People say it is the tide, and the tide does not reach the rise. Orentel will not say why the salt is there. The salt is not part of this hour.

Eolvaeth does not send off to a Tree-town to borrow a warden it does not have. If the warden is already in the vale, that warden may walk with the house. If the town sent its children somewhere else to Turn that summer, the town buries its dead with the people who stayed. The pot that feeds the mourners is the gift-hall’s, and the food goes to the door the dead person kept. A wet leaf lies on the spring, or too

many, or none. The leaf is the spring's business. It is not a funeral token. They will not say why it is there.

At Ndenjoo the body is carried above the tide, and the hall does not lay a second empty plate for the dead. The dead person's own cup is set in the place that was already laid. It sits there for one night, and then it goes back onto the shelf. Whether anyone speaks a name is the argument the valley already knows how to have, and that argument waits until the dishes are done. The shore does not come up the hill to invent a rite on the sand.

The guest-meal

The bowl is set down before anyone asks the guest who they are. That order travels from town to town. Everything after the bowl is the stance the street was already keeping.

In Maiethlir, in a kitchen on a thaw-street, there is bread and there are greens, and the river is loud enough that people can talk over it. The guest is a walker come from the vale, with a letter and with wet shoes. They sit, and they eat, and only then does someone ask, "Of where?" The guest says the vale. Nobody asks what colour they are, or whether any leaf fell for them at all. The host says Maieth over the host's own bowl, and does not hand that name to the guest to say. A Watcher in the same kitchen tells the guest what is in the pot, greens and a bone and too much salt, and then stops. A Settler at the end of the bench does not open a book. The only thing waiting to be settled is the letter, and the letter can wait until the shoes are dry.

At Orentel the first bread is eaten standing, at a barrel, where the crane can be seen. If you sit down before that bread, you are claiming a berth you have not paid for. After the bread, if no paper is open, there is a chair, and they ask which berth the guest holds. The guest has none, and the guest still eats. If a filing house has a paper open, the house-name is spoken before anyone offers the chair. A house-name is an old given name that stuck to a family line, that place's own word, and it is not a surname brought in from somewhere else. While the paper is open, a clerk gets the house first and then the given name. Shut the paper, and the quay goes back to asking where you are from. The bowl does not wait for the house to finish its paper. A book-hand who wants the guest's affairs written in ink is told, by the person who cut the bread, to come back and do that writing on the quay in the morning.

The guest who turns up in Eolvaeth is often the visit turned around: a clerk from the core who came to see a week and found a pot. If the house is thin, that clerk is fed out of the gift-hall. Nobody promises the guest that the wood will speak. If the clerk asks about the leaf on the spring, someone passes the bread instead of answering. The leaf stays unexplained, and they will not say why. A walker who arrived with a cohort, the group the town sent on to another Tree, eats with that cohort. The town does not lay a separate table for people who stood somewhere else this summer.

On the first night at Ndenjoo, the guest does not serve the food, and does not sit in the place that is set back from the board. That place is already kept. On the second night a plate is put into the guest's hands to carry, and someone says the sentence the hall already lives by. The words of that sentence belong to the hall. What this hour has is the plate. That second supper is how the hall counts you as kin on the isle. It does not become a last hearth you can name to a mainland watch, and it does not become papers. On the one night of the moon sailors call Yoltal, the hall eats the heel of the loaf first. Every other night the heel is last, or it goes to the goats. A guest who asks why is given more bread. They will not say why.

If someone asks what the guest is before the bowl has been set down, the room goes quiet. The person nearest the pot puts the bowl down anyway. Talk may start again when the guest takes a second bite, or it may not start again at all. There is no speech kept in reserve to repair the asking. A host who wants a doctrine can have one after the dishes, taken from whichever faith that host already keeps.

What a house keeps

When a town needs work done, it hires a person. The work people expect from a made thing is already someone's job. An Answered coaxes stone, water, fire, or air, and then goes home. A Stilled holds a body still for a knife. A mill-hand sets the stones, a hull-wright walks a hull, and a road-mend leaves a shovel in the bank. Those are people. A Clank is a Kind, a person born a Clank, who mends flood-walls, hulls, mills, and lofts alongside everyone else who does that work. A made thing is a thing, and a Clank is a person.

Most towns do not have one. If a scene has a thing that keeps working with nobody in it, a crane left running, a mill someone swears turns with nobody at the stones, or a figure of clay, then it has a maker and a problem. The maker is a person, or was one. The problem is why the thing is still doing the work: the stop broke, the maker left a debt unfinished, or a story got ahead of the mechanism. Name both before the scene goes on. It has no Kind, no Condition, and no hearth, and it owes no Tithe. It has no domain, because a domain is a job a person does. If the work needs doing, send the person whose job it is. A town without that problem does not keep one on a shelf.

Ordinary kit is whatever that ground already needed, clothing and tools, and it is not a ladder of better kit. Nothing here is rarer than the next town's version of the same need. A coat from this list keeps the weather off. It is not armor unless the wearer is also wearing armor. If someone fights with one of the tools, it counts as the smallest one-handed weapon in the rules, and the town that made it adds nothing.

Place	What they keep	Why it is there
Rain-Wall shelves, the passes above Lirorn	An oiled wool coat	The shelf is wet and cold, and a quay shirt does not finish the walk.
Orentel’s quays	A short hook, and a coat waxed against brine	The quay is lines, crates, and salt. The hook pulls. The coat is for the spray.
A young graft on the Heskoren live front	A pruning knife, and a wind cloak	The wood is new and the weather is not. The knife is a tender’s tool, and it is not the One Knife.
Rain-Shadow herds, toward the Dry Stair and Ornsael	A goat-hair blanket, and a water-skin	The days are dry and the well is shared. The blanket is the herd’s hair, felted.
Kumbaan halls and shallows	A peat cloak, and a short knife for mussels	Smoke, rain, and the rocks. The cloak is for the hall and the terrace, and it does not cross the storm-wall.
Mother-core orchards	Beeswax	They keep it for the hives, and for the halls that are owed wax when the blossom fails.

Motherwood is not on this list. A scion, a cutting of a Turning Tree carried for planting, is a warden’s cargo, not a material a person buys. The Spent Leaf and the Closed Lamp are not craft stock.

The pruning knife is not the blade people mean when they say “the knife.” One house on the Near Mile hangs a kitchen knife on a ribbon beside a scorch on an old pot-ring. The people in the house know which summer that was. It was the Closing, the war that ended when the riders went home, and they do not turn out for it. The Low Wall is another stone, from another dig, and a knife-ribbon left at that wall was left in error. Strangers call the Near Mile knife the nameless knife, because they want the first blade to have a handle they can buy. The house will not sell it as that. It is their kitchen knife. The summer is theirs, and the scorch is on their pot. A person can take it down and hold it. In a fight it is a small one-handed blade, the smallest such weapon in the rules, and the ribbon adds nothing. The single blade people mean when they say the knife has not been produced. Nobody has named who made the First Cut.

Tithe-Infrastructure and Guilds

People call this work **the furnishing**, or simply **the greens and the halls**. There is no church-name set over the whole of it. In the Waiting Lands, which write themselves *Vaethorn*, the same work is **the gift-works**. On the Ledger Coast, written *Lestrand*, it is **the provision**. Under the Tallied Crown, written *Threnmaieth*, the clerks file it as **the counted channel**.

What the sector does is keep people whole *enough*, in public, and then stop at the gate. A Condition is a change a person comes to carry. A Tithe is the upkeep that change keeps demanding, the living ground or the hour or the new page a person has to have if the change is going to stay livable. The furnishing is the town's way of meeting that upkeep until the share runs out. After the share, the Slide will still sell a week. What the Slide rents is not falling, one week of green or of an outlet or of a new page, and the week is measured so the person does not quite get free.

The greens-keepers and the hall-keepers are parts of this sector. They keep a lot or an hour, and they are not houses with colleges of their own. The Stillers and the element-guilds remain craft-guilds. They stamp a licence where a use can hurt someone standing nearby. The Intake is the shed that does not face the street. A person newly Struck, changed outside the childhood ceremony and not yet safe to stand next to, is caught there before the town reaches for a rope.

Shape of the sector

Furnishing and ticketing are two jobs. A town may put both under one roof, and they stay two jobs even then. Furnishing is the share of upkeep: a bed of living dirt, a scheduled hour, a library that is open. Ticketing is the licence for a hazardous act. The product of the official door is a person who can walk away until tomorrow. The Slide's product is a person who cannot. The town is glad of both. On an ordinary day the guilds pretend not to know the week-keepers next door. When an official gate closes on purpose, or a wilt or a Cry can be walked from that gate to the room that still opens, the pretence is over, because the two doors are then serving the same street, and the town has to say so.

A ticket names a competence, the practiced skill, and not the Condition itself. The people who might be asked for one are a large minority, about three in ten, the Stilled, the Far-Voiced, and the Answered, if they practise the use that can hurt a bystander. The papers actually issued are fewer than that, and fewer again on a frontier where a rope is as likely as a stool. Three guilds keep the papers, and they keep no shared list. A stiller cannot ask the element-guilds for every Answered person in the city. The state watches the charter, the guild's leave to operate, and it cannot ask for a list of this city's Far-

Voiced. The arrangement makes its own friction. Guilds guard their monopolies. A ticket can start to be treated as a thing the guild holds, and an unlicensed practitioner threatens the charter as much as the street.

There is no Furnishing Seat, no college set over the other towns. A town keeps its own lot and its own hall. A deathless house, a house of people who do not die of age, endows its own stacks of books. Nothing in this sector tells a far commons how to water a bed.

Who furnishes what

Each gate has a shape of *enough*, a moment when it closes, and a place the need goes when the gate has shut. The official door does not follow you past that line.

Gate	Form of *enough*	Closes when	Where the need goes
Green, the greens-keepers	A night or an hour on living dirt, for a Taken-In person, someone the wild has taken partway into itself, who wilts without living ground. The bed-slate is a list of plants.	The share is gone. They will not walk three streets.	A cousin’s pot. They do not say the cousin’s name. That private pot, once it is rented, is the Slide.
Outlet, the hall-keepers	A scheduled Cry, a boards-hour, or a sweep-hour, the hour a person can still afford when a bench is beyond them. The Voice-ticket sits on the same stool. A Cry is a Far-Voiced feeling breaking into everyone in earshot. It is a blow, not a command.	The lamps. A missed hour is a missed hour.	A room that still shuts. They do not say the room’s name.
Novelty	A long-house of books, where a deathless chair still sits. What it furnishes is something genuinely new, which is the upkeep of a Long-Lived person, someone who does not die of age and who fades without it.	Closing. They will not carry a rumour to a fade shut in a room.	A junior who extends a page. That junior has started a week.
Unbound warmth	Almost none. An Unbound person is what a finished contract leaves behind, free of the Terms and missing the piece the contract took, and the upkeep is connection. Family, an attic, or a paid sitting is what there is.	The sector has no hour to close.	None. The sector cannot buy being known.
Bound Terms	An honest table, and the Book-Hands, the clerks who close a civic year. A Bound person swore a contract and is still under its Terms. This is not a body-ticket. The Whisper, the contract’s voice, cannot command another person’s will.	The year closes. The Terms do not.	The Holding Desk, the back room that will write a next term when the honest stamp has already closed.
Returned purpose	Cannot be furnished. A Returned person died with a purpose unfinished and came back to it. A purpose is not a share the sector can hand over, and no employer can supply a vengeance, a vow, or a person still to find.	—	None.
Two-Bodied	Civic land, and no ticket. A Two-Bodied person carries a second, animal body, and the	—	None.

Gate	Form of *enough*	Closes when	Where the need goes
ranging	upkeep is time spent as that animal.		

The three tickets are for danger to others only. The person holds the paper. The craft issues it.

What	Who holds paper	Who does not
The Stilled, a personal Gaze-ticket. The Gaze is the look that holds a moment still.	Anyone who Gazes in public, including surgeons, riot-lines, and demolition. Most stillers hold one, because the vocation is the Gaze. The Stillers stamp it. It is the strictest ticket, because the same look can, misused, leave a person helpless in a fight.	A Stilled person who never Gazes, which is rare, though the guild still wants that person in the yard.
Far-Voiced, a Voice-ticket and a hall-hour.	Those who Cry in a crowd or keep a scheduled hour: criers, performers, and sworn witnesses. The hall-keepers stamp the competence and sell the hour at the same desk.	A field-voice who vents at the hedge. The hall-slate is a list of hours, not of every blue-leaf in the city. Blue-leaf is the ordinary name for the leaf a Far-Voiced child draws.
The Answered, a shop charter and a journeyman-mark. An Answered person is someone an element answered, and goes on answering.	Those who let an element speak in a crowded yard. The element-guilds, the Crae, charter the door, and journeymen sit under that charter.	A Tide-Answered person on their own boat, under a master's eye. They answer to the shop. The shop does not keep a person-file.
Bound, a table, not a body-ticket.	No licence is issued for the body. The honest table hears the Terms.	A Bound person is not counted among the licensed.
No ticket.	—	Two-Bodied, Long-Lived, Returned, the Taken-In, the Unbound, Phoenix, and all the Kept. Phoenix, a single person the town cannot mistake for anyone else, is a political problem and not a licence. The Kept are the people a Tree hugged and left without a Condition. Most people hold no ticket. They are simply neighbours.

The Intake is the shared shed of those three ticket-yards. It catches a raw Struck person before anything happens in public, and the work has succeeded when nothing is heard of it afterwards.

Fellowships

A mill, a hull, and a road each have people who keep them through a season, and those people are the fellowships. The work is the ordinary keeping of that mill, that hull, or that road, and it does not licence a body. The licences already written stay where they are: the Stillers stamp a Gaze, the element-guilds stamp an element, the hall-keepers stamp a Voice-ticket, and the Intake catches a raw Struck person before the town reaches for a rope. A mill-share, a hull-wright, and a road-mend do not stamp any of those. They will not rent a week, which is the Slide’s rental, or refinance a Term, which is the paper the Holding Desk refinances when the honest stamp has closed, or sell a standing, which is the witness the Standing Trade sells, a person paid to say they were there when a town was not.

A Gale-Answered miller, an Answered person whose element is the wind, can hold an element-guild ticket for that wind and still owe a share of grain. The ticket is the hazardous act, letting the element speak. The share is the season of work. A Tide-Answered wright can hold a ticket for the water and still be the person who walks the hull. A Root-Answered mender can hold a ticket for the stone and still be the person with the shovel. In each yard the fellowship is the season, and the ticket is only the act.

You are of a fellowship when you have kept the thing through a season and someone of it will say so. There is no Seat set over the other towns, and no apprenticeship a crown confirms. The fellowship does not ask what Kind a person was born, the ancestry they arrived with, and it does not keep a chapter of any born people. Kumbaan, the Sundering Isle beyond the storm-wall of weather, current, and reef, does not keep these three. No graft ever crossed to that isle, so there is no race to share, no quay that classes a hull, and no Mile to mend. They will not follow a Taken-In person home. That walk belongs to the greens-keepers. There is no town where the fellowship is the government, and there is no boss to send for.

The mill-share. A miller takes a share of the grain that comes through the mill, and the fellowship is the people who will say whose race this is, the mill-race that turns the stones, and whose share of that grain is owed.

At the Mill-hold the miller is not the person the square turns to, and the share is still taken. When the culvert is opened to keep water off the Hand, that town’s Turning Tree, the race drops, and a mill-hand is already there with a count of lost turns. They do not Speak a colour, which would be naming a leaf in the square, and they do not carry a scion. A scion is living wood cut to plant a Tree, and that cart belongs to a Road-hand.

A Gale-house may coax the wind at a mill. If the person is Answered and lets the element speak, so that the wind answers the hands rather than the room, the coaxing is a ticket. The stones, the sacks, and the share belong to this fellowship even when nobody in the mill is Answered.

When the race is drawn down, the mill-share sets the stones and leaves one measure of last year’s grain on the lip until the water comes back. They will not say why.

Threnmaieth would like that measure on a roll of persons. The mill-share keeps it with the grain. The Walled Book, the closed house that ranks the people who live inside its walls, can give those people a turn of work at a mill. That turn is the Book’s assignment of a person. It is not a share of the grain.

The hull-wrights. They know whether a hull will take water, and they look at the bend, the caulk, and the line to know it.

The Hinge Shore decides whether a hull is a pilgrim, a pot, or cargo, and the Book-Hands stamp the paper that records the class. A Tide-Answered person may work the bend under an element-guild ticket. The hull-wrights do not classify the cargo, do not set the Hush-rate, the single charge on a crossing of the Old Crossing, and do not sell a witness who will say *I was there*. The Standing Trade sells that witness. This fellowship sells a hull that floats.

On the Down-Bank there is no hull yet. A traveler who rehearses a hull-class at an inn is early, and a wright who starts the classification there has left the craft and begun the Hinge Shore’s job. At Denlad a tied hull is a hull waiting out weather. The wright will not call it a hold and will not charge a house-share for the tying. At Orentel the fellowship sits under the crane. It is not the White Note House, and it does not keep the berth.

Netstrand charters hulls. The charter is a crossing, and the wright is the person who will still walk the hull after the quote is written.

Before a new hull takes water, the hull-wrights walk it once empty, from stem to stern, and do not speak. They will not say why.

The road-mend. They fill a hole, clear a ford, and shore a culvert. The stretches they keep are the Near Mile, the inland walk through the Motherland, the spur that stops at Nelath, and the days along the Down-Bank.

They are not Road-hands. A Road-hand carries living wood, and a mender carries a shovel. They do not ask a traveler for a name, a last hearth, and who stands for them. Those questions belong to the watch, which holds a person until morning and does not keep the answers past dawn.

A person on a named walk is still vouched as a walker by the road, which means the road itself is what says they may walk it, and the mend is why the road is still there to walk. At Nelath the road ends at the boughs, so the mend stops with it. They do not cut the thorns back to make the spur go on. The town already decided where the road ends.

The Walled Book can give a turn on the road to a person who lives inside its walls. A mender on that page still knows the work. The assignment is the Book’s.

At the first ford after a town, they leave the shovel standing in the bank overnight after a mend. They will not say why.

The work people hire

When the work needs doing, people hire a craft. They do not enroll in a school of magic to get it.

A Daggerheart domain card is a job the town already pays someone to do, and the nine domains below are those jobs. The cards stay on the SRD, and this chapter does not copy them, because a class on a sheet is how the table plays the jobs. A domain card does not Turn anyone, which means it does not make a person into a Condition. If the same person has both, each one does what its own card says: the Tithe ticks only from the Condition, and the domain card still does what the SRD printed. A licence is still a licence. None of those papers comes off a domain card, and the fellowships still do not stamp a body.

Domain	The job
Arcana	Shaping heat, water, stone, air, or a light a workshop already charges for, the same family of work as an Answered coax. The card is the craft. The Condition is the element that answered a person for life.
Blade	A weapon in the hand, a watch holding someone until morning, a pruning knife or a kitchen knife, or a cohort walking children to a sound Hand, a sound Tree.
Bone	Knowing where to stand, who is tired, and which bank will go, which is reading a fight the way a road-mend reads a ford.
Codex	Paper, minutes, a copy, and a count, the work of a Book-hand’s table. Reading a page is not Speaking a colour.
Grace	A guest-meal, a factor’s terms, or a voice that asks. The hazardous Cry stays on the hall-keepers’ ticket. This job is the ask, not that Cry.
Midnight	A shut door, a night’s work, or a trade that does not want a square. The Slide keeps its own note for that trade.
Sage	Ground, herd, weather, and the bark of a young graft, which is a greens-keeper’s eye. The Taken-In remain their own card.
Splendor	The room after harm, the wash and the light and the pot and the table once a stiller’s gaze is done. Phoenix fire stays with Phoenix.
Valor	Standing a gap, whether that is a flood-wall or a child walked to a sound Hand. The watch, and the cohort it sends, is the civic hold.

An Answered person who also carries an Arcana card has a Tithe and a craft, and what it means for that person to be idle is already said with the Answered: an element left unused will speak whether or not the shop is paying. A Kept person with the same card has the craft, and no element that lets go in a crowded room. The town can tell those two people apart by the work, and by whether the workshop has a plan for a day off.

At Leaf-Fall, the week the door is open and a child can stand under a Tree, a warden says the colour, or says that the child was held. The square hears what the leaf did. That sentence is the Speaking. It is not a spell, and it does not use a Spellcast trait, the trait a spell would call on. Hope does not buy a colour. A warden cannot Speak a person into a Condition who is not standing under a sound Tree in the week the door is open. When a colour is misspoken, it is corrected, and the week is not run again.

The long-house (novelty without a new order)

A Long-Lived house that has endowed a library is already this sector. What that house furnishes is something genuinely new. The money goes out into the stacks, and a deathless member of the house still sits the chair and names the scholars, which is how an endowment keeps the steering after the coin has left. The Pourers, a circle of Long-Lived who meet at a shelf in a deathless library, keep one such shelf on the Ledger Coast. Staff are often the Kept, people with no Tithe of their own, able to fetch and to stay. What the house will not furnish is a page at a time to a person who cannot walk in. They will not carry a rumour to a fade shut in a room. A junior who extends a page, the way a clerk extends a novelty subscription one more week, has started the Slide’s week beside the long-house.

The gate (the sector’s shared courtesy)

Every official door stops at a line the town has agreed to call *enough*. The greens-keeper keeps the lot, and does not walk the room where someone is already wilting. The hall-keeper keeps the hour, and does not open the side door after the lamps for a voice that missed its slate. The long-house is open to a person who can walk in, and it will not carry news to a Long-Lived shut in a room. The ticket-house trains the child who was Given the colour, and stamps the adult who has become competent. The raw Struck person is the Intake’s problem. The guild is glad to forget the shed if the catching-year, the in-house word for that week, stays quiet.

The Slide begins where that line is. The two houses can meet, and they do not merge. A hall that runs late on purpose is already arguing with a week-rent that still opens. The worst of it is a public wilt or a Cry in the market that the official door caused by closing.

The other houses touch the gate without becoming it. A tree-warden points a newly Given child at a lot or a hall, and does not licence anyone. The lot and the hall decide who gets the bed or the hour. A Book-hand’s term may assume a greens-share, or an hour on the seventh day. If the lot or the slate is full, the term is unpayable that day, and the book records it as owing. The Holding Desk is not this

sector. A Bound person’s civic year may assume a hall. The desk downstairs does not furnish one. A Taken-In door-keeper, one of the people who keep the older doors a later Strike can come through, may live on a lot. The courtesy of that door does not give anyone a bed.

Under the Tallied Crown the hall and the green *are* the channel, the share the roll can open or shut. Videm *(VEE-dem)*, the channel-clerk, runs the counted hall and the slate that is supposed to match the tended green, and will say the channel held while someone three streets off is already wilting. Sirtal *(SEER-tal)*, the warrant-hand, writes the warrant that withholds the share until a name sits still. A lot that still has beds, and a share Sirtal will not open, are the same street.

What follows is a closing-notice, nailed to a lot-gate and, in the same hand, to a hall door. The back of the sheet is last week’s notice, not taken down.

> *Share is enough. Hour is enough. After close we do not walk the rooms. After the lamps we do not open the side door. If you have already wilted, the lot is still the lot — come when we open. If you have already cried in the street, the hall is still the hall — come at open, not now. If you cannot wait, we do not know a pot. We do not know a room. The town is glad. File that as weather if you must. It is a door.*

The keepers do know a cousin’s pot, and they do know a room that still shuts. The notice says they do not, so that neither the lot nor the hall is blamed for what the pot and the room do. The town is glad of both, the official gate and the week that opens when the gate has shut.

How they live in the three corners

In the Waiting Lands the works are commons-minded, and the purse is thin. A cousin’s field stands in when the lot is short. You were helped, so the valley expects you to spend the gift as it asks, and when the share fails the Slide is a private pot they call the last pot, and also gift-credit.

On the Ledger Coast the provision is posted and charged by the season. You can be priced out of staying whole, and after the fee fails the Slide is week-rent.

Under the Tallied Crown the crown furnishes, and the crown holds. Videm holds the channel. The Slide is the late week that channel will not admit failed. Videm knows the week is there, and Sirtal files the leak as the person’s own lapse.

Kumbaan, the Sundering Isle, has no greenhouse and no ael-hall. A wreck walked uphill is a guest. The storm-wall is weather, current, and reef, and a graft never crossed it.

A bed-list is plants, a hall-slate is hours, and a guild-roll names the practitioners of a dangerous art. Only two crowns write persons and the gifts they carry on the same paper. Threnmaieth calls its roll holy and names it the Threnhael. Trenledd, the Worn Count, keeps a roll of persons too, and does not

call that roll holy. Road-hands carry living wood, greens-keepers keep the soil, hall-keepers keep an hour, and the ticket-houses keep a licence.

The Greens-Keepers

Greens-keepers keep the garden-commons, the greens, and a leaf-lot, so that a Taken-In person in a stone town has living ground to lie on and does not wilt on a parlour floor. They are a jurisdiction of the furnishing, not a house with a college of its own. They keep the lot, and they do not go looking for anyone who is not at the gate.

Everyday people say **greens-keepers**, or **lot-keepers**. In the liturgy they are the **Saelhael** *(SAEL-hael)*. *Sael* is sowing, the first green, said "sayl," and *hael* is whole, said "hayl," so the name is the sown-whole. The Waiting Lands' second word is **Mother's-green hands**. The Ledger Coast says **lot-keepers**, as ordinary as saying gardener. The Tallied Crown files them as **the Tended**.

Shape of the house

The house is the lot. A town has a strip along the wall, or pots in a yard, or, in the Waiting Lands, a cousin's field held in common. Whoever waters it, and says who sleeps on which bed tonight, is the house. There is no Green Seat over other towns.

A share gives a night on living dirt, a season on a bed, or a commons-hour. The person should leave able to work. Someone who cannot leave is the Slide's work, a private pot after the share fails. The keepers will not follow you home with that pot, and they will not open the gate again because the wilt has started in a room they do not walk to.

A bed-slate is a list of plants, rows and tired beds. A person's name gets onto it because that person is *on* a bed, not because the lot has started a roll of people. In Threnmaieth the crown already has another list. Videm, who holds the counted channel, wants the beds to match that channel. The lot will not invent a bed to close someone else's book.

If you meet one

You meet them with dirt under the nails, a key to a gate in a wall, and a slate of rows, and if you are let far enough in you meet last year's leaf already buried under a new bed. Ask where a Taken-In person sleeps when the rooms are stone. A stone town cannot keep its Taken-In without a lot. Green is free on a farm, and in the city it costs a gate.

Who comes, and when

A Taken-In person who works in town comes because the rooms are stone and the Tithe is due. The keeper gives the share the lot has, a bed or a night or an hour, and writes the bed if anything is written. They will not walk the three streets to the room where the wilt has already started.

A Book-hand comes when a settling assumes a greens-share. The keeper honours the term if there is a bed, and marks the slate full if there is not, so the book becomes owing and the lot does not tell a lie to close it. A crown-clerk in Threnmaieth comes because the tended green is supposed to match the channel. The keepers give the beds they have. They will not pretend a wilt off the lot is not happening, and they will not walk to it.

Almost no one else comes for the share. The week that is not a queue is watering, and turning the rows the slate already names. Grain feeds the town by another door. This gate is the living ground that keeps an exposed person off a parlour floor.

An ordinary week

They open the gate, and that opening is the kindness. A Taken-In person lies down on living ground until the tokens fill, the count of the upkeep coming back up, and then leaves, after which the bed is turned and the next row is watered. Last year’s commons-leaf is buried under a new bed. No one will explain the leaf to a guest. A first-year who asks is told, by whoever is on the gate, that this is how the lot remembers.

When the queue is longer than the wilt, they still open for the share they have, and they close when the share is gone. They know a cousin still has a pot. They do not say the cousin’s name. A child who carries the water can name that cousin. The slate cannot, and the notice on the gate says the lot does not know a pot, so the lot is not blamed for what the pot does.

They do not steal a scion, the living wood a Road-hand carries to plant a Tree, and they do not send a lot to Kumbaan. What they give, they call a share.

Who may keep a lot

The house does not ask what Kind a person was born. You are of the house when you can keep a bed, when the lot is still alive in the dry month, and when the town still sends its Taken-In to you.

How they live in the three corners

In the Waiting Lands, where they are called Mother’s-green hands, the commons is a cousin’s field. They will say they are tending a gift. The quiet obligation is the one the valley keeps: you were laid on

the Mother’s green, so you will spend the green as the valley asks. When the field fails, the last pot does the Slide’s work, and they will still call it tending.

On the Ledger Coast, where they are called lot-keepers, the leaf-lot is posted by the season, with coin on the gate. A Taken-In person who cannot pay the season is priced out of this lot. The lot that still opens after the fee has failed is doing the Slide’s week-rent.

Under the Tallied Crown they are filed as the Tended. The crown furnishes the tended green and can withhold it, and the beds are supposed to match the channel. A wilt off the lot is a leak the roll does not want to file. The keepers look like gardeners. What the crown can shut off is the water.

Kumbaan has no greens-keepers, and no lot is sent there.

The gate

Whoever furnishes a provided-for Tithe holds power over the person who needs it. The greens-keepers hold that power and refuse to carry it past the wall. The refusal is the kindness, because they will not own you, and it is the cruelty, because they will not walk three streets. The town is glad either way, because a person who wilts quietly off the lot is not a public hazard. A devout town can say the gift was offered, a Lestrand quay can say the season was posted, and the Tallied Crown can say the channel held.

The need for living land is the Tithe. People built the gate. A lot can be full of beds and still have a queue, and the keepers are then choosing who sleeps on stone.

A bed-slate

The slate inside the gate is plants, which rows are taken and which beds are tired. The words the town is meant to read are the closing-notice nailed on the gate itself, the same sheet a hall door wears in the same hand. Last week’s notice is still on the back.

> *Share is enough. Hour is enough. After close we do not walk the rooms. After the lamps we do not open the side door. If you have already wilted, the lot is still the lot — come when we open. If you have already cried in the street, the hall is still the hall — come at open, not now. If you cannot wait, we do not know a pot. We do not know a room. The town is glad. File that as weather if you must. It is a door.*

The notice is a commons keeping itself to the share, and a little cold about it. The keepers do know a cousin’s pot. The child with the water can name the cousin. The slate cannot, and the leaf under the new bed is not on the notice at all.

The Hall-Keepers

Hall-keepers keep the official outlet and the Far-Voiced ticket in the same building. A Far-Voiced person needs both the scheduled hour and the licence. In the ael-hall, the airing, from *ael*, to let feeling out, they empty a voice on that schedule, and the building is the town's playhouse. They furnish enough voice that a person can walk until tomorrow. After the lamps, a room that still shuts belongs to the Slide, and it is not this hall's side door.

Hall-keepers, or **ael-hands**, is what people say in every register, from the street to a docket. There is no church-name over them. The Waiting Lands' second word is **gift-hall folk**. The Ledger Coast says **release-hands**, as ordinary as saying box-office. The Tallied Crown files them as **counted-hall clerks**.

They sell you an hour in which you may feel in earnest, and they will not open after the lamps.

Shape of the house

One building does two jobs. The hall furnishes the outlet, and it stamps the Voice-ticket. The keeper who says your hour is the third is the keeper who says you may stand in a crowded room. The hour is enough: a song, a weeping, a relay-call, a laugh that empties the chest, feeling on purpose where a neighbour paid to hear it. The person should leave emptied and able to work. This house wants you gone until tomorrow.

Each town keeps its own hall, and no seat over the other towns writes to it for leave.

If you meet one

You can tell them by the ink or the chalk on a finger, by the slate of hours, by the stool at the door where the ticket is stamped, and by the one bench nobody sweeps. Ask where a voice can be loud without becoming a Cry in the market. A town with Far-Voiced people and no hall leaves a Book-hand writing *owing*, and leaves the street waiting for the feeling to land where everyone can hear it.

Who comes, and when

A Given child, after the sea-blue leaf, is apprenticed here. The voice has to be trained before it is a hazard, in breath and projection and venting on purpose, and the ticket comes when the town can stand next to them. The hall does not Speak the colour. The warden already did that.

A working Far-Voiced person, a performer or a crier or a sworn witness, often pays the Tithe by the vocation itself. The hall gives them the stage, the relay-post, or the stand, and stamps the year if the ticket is due, and it will not invent a crisis so they can vent off the slate. A person who has lost that

honest stage, posted somewhere isolated or set to dull labor, can buy or be granted a scheduled hour, be emptied, and be sent out. The hall will not open after the lamps. A room that still takes a voice after that belongs to the Slide, and the week it sells is never quite enough for the person to get free.

A Struck Far-Voiced person, raw from the drowning that brings the voice later and untrained, is handed to the Intake. If the Cry is already in the room, a hall-keeper may sit the first hour with the shed. The hall will not stamp a ticket on a raw voice, and it will not leave them in the market.

A Book-hand whose settling assumes a seventh-day hour is honoured when the slate has a hole, and marked full when it does not. Greyhull's release-house will take that seventh day when the term names it. The hall will not pretend a full house has a bench. In the eighth week, when the passage-money fails, the slip can still be fair, and the person can still owe a book that does not close.

Anyone who came for a play is sold a bench. The working voices pay their Tithe as the show. The hall will not stop a performance to process a ticket. The show is the Tithe for the people on the boards, and a night out for the people who paid to hear it.

An ordinary week

Morning is the slate, with the hours named, the relay-posts listed, a child's breath-lesson in the cold hall, and the ticket-desk a stool by the door. Evening is the house, feeling in earnest and on purpose, where a neighbour paid to hear it. One seat is never swept. The line people use for it is, "That's the first Cry's seat." No one will explain which Cry.

When a voice misses its hour, the keeper does not open the side door. They know a room that still shuts, and they do not say the room's name. A raw Struck person is the Intake's, and the hall will not stamp that ticket. They do not run a mission-hall on Kumbaan.

Who may keep a hall

The stool does not ask what Kind a person was born. You are of the house by practice, by who can keep the hour, and by whether the town still comes when the slate says it will.

How they live in the three corners

In the Waiting Lands they are called gift-hall folk. The venting happens at worship, the purse is thin, and a person who was given the hour is expected to spend the voice as the valley asks, as crier, witness, or hymn. When that hour is missed, the room that still shuts is the last pot.

On the Ledger Coast they are release-hands, and the playhouse is the hall. Hours are posted, the ticket is a master's papers, and a sweep-hour is sometimes the only hour a person can afford. After that, the week is week-rent.

Under the Tallied Crown they are counted-hall clerks. The crown furnishes the hour and can withhold it, and the ticket is filed as a crown-warrant. Videm will say the hour held while a Cry is still unspent at the door.

Kumbaan has no ael-hall, and the hall-keepers do not keep a mission-house there.

The scheduled hour

The hall sells, or grants, the right to feel in public on time. Off that time the voice is a ticket problem, and a missed hour stays missed. A performer who lost the honest stage still has the hour when the slate has a hole, the season-fee was paid, and the crown still lists them. The town is glad of an emptied voice, because that voice is not a Cry in the market. A devout town can say the gift was aired, a Lestrand quay can say the bill was posted, and the Tallied Crown can say the channel held.

The same hour is some people’s Tithe and other people’s night out. A devout barn and a priced quay will both tell you that is simply how a hall works. The first Cry’s bench stays unswept. No one will say which Cry it belongs to.

An hour-slate

The morning slate names the hours. The words nailed beside the bill are the same closing-notice the lot-gate wears, in the same hand, with yesterday’s sheet still on the back.

> *Share is enough. Hour is enough. After close we do not walk the rooms. After the lamps we do not open the side door. If you have already wilted, the lot is still the lot — come when we open. If you have already cried in the street, the hall is still the hall — come at open, not now. If you cannot wait, we do not know a pot. We do not know a room. The town is glad. File that as weather if you must. It is a door.*

The notice is a playhouse being practical. The sweep-hour, when the house keeps one, is the nearest thing on the slate to kindness. The keepers do know a room that still shuts. The notice says they do not, so the hall is not blamed for it. The first Cry’s bench is not on the notice. Everyone in the house knows which seat it is, and no one will explain it.

The Stillers

The Stillers licence the Stilled and run the infirmaries. One of the Stilled can hold a moment still. A wound that is bleeding stops bleeding, a poison stops where it is, and a blade already swinging hangs

in the air a beat longer than the arm meant. The same look, misused, can leave a person helpless in a fight, which is why this ticket is the strictest in the world. The guild issues it. The state watches the guild. It does not keep a list of every Stilled person, and it does not police a people.

Everyday speech is **stillers**, or **the Stillers' Guild**. In the liturgy they are **the Stelhael** *(STEL-hael)*, from *stel*, to still, to hold from moving, and *hael*, whole. The name says they keep you hale by holding you still. The Waiting Lands say **blessing-surgeons**. The Ledger Coast says **ticket-surgeons**. The Tallied Crown files them as **crown-stillers**.

They will save you on the table, and they will make you drill until the Grey is gone. The Grey is the stillness that collects in the surgeon each time the gaze is used. Left in the body, it locks one of the surgeon's own limbs stone-still. The seizing stays on the Stilled. It does not turn another person to stone, and it does not take anyone's will. The ticket marks competence. The infirmary's pace follows the surgeon's Grey as much as it follows the patient.

Shape of the house

If you understand this guild, you understand a Voice-ticket and an element-ticket, because both are the same shape of licence. What the house keeps is a roster of people who practise a dangerous art, not a list of a people. The pool of those who might be asked is large. This roll is stillers who Gaze, not every pale-stone person in the city. Pale stone, marble-white, is the leaf a Given Stilled child draws.

The infirmary and the yard are one guild and one clock. On the table they hold a wound. In the yard they spar, patrol, and hold the riot-line, because using the Gaze fills the Grey and the yard is what empties it. The guild's best work creates the guild's Tithe, and that is the job, not a puzzle they have solved. They see themselves as a surgeon's college, apprentices and a code and a ticket like a master's papers. The frightening part is the Gaze that saves you, and the unlicensed Struck person the town will meet with a rope.

There is no Stillers' Seat over other towns. A rich infirmary in the core is rich, and a frontier stiller is one tired person, because the charter is local. The state watches that charter, not the body of the person who holds the ticket.

They live beside the other houses the way any craft lives beside its neighbours, and the hard edge is where the jobs must not be swapped.

House	Everyday	The hard edge
Hall-keepers and the element-guilds	Sister tickets. They share the Intake.	A Cry is not a Gaze. A Far-Voiced person is not sent to the yard to be stilled quiet.
Greens-keepers	A Taken-In stiller still needs dirt, the way any Taken-In person does.	The infirmary is not a lot.
The Slide	A stiller who needs green, or a new page, is a person, not a week for rent. They meet when the infirmary closes a bed.	A ticket that has become a week-rent has left the yard. The two houses meet, and they do not merge.
Tree-wardens	Pale stone is pointed here.	The warden Speaks the colour. The guild trains the gaze.
Book-Hands	A settling may assume an infirmary will be there.	A frontier with no stiller is an owing, a debt the settling still records, and not a miracle.
Watchers	A second reading may say the leaf was pale stone, not storm-grey.	Description is not a stamp. The Watcher does not licence anyone.

If you meet one

You meet a calm person, flat-eyed when they are working, whose hair stirs when something nearby has gone too still. You meet them in an infirmary, on a drill-floor, or on a line that has not yet become a massacre. You would not know which hour was the guild’s unless you already needed a ticket. They are useful the way a surgeon is useful. A town without one makes do with a rope and a prayer.

Who comes, and when

Who	Why they come	What the stiller does	What they will not do
A Given Stilled child, after pale stone	The Gaze must be trained before a misuse leaves someone helpless	Apprentice them, drill them, put them in the theatre, and give the ticket when they can still a wound and not a person	They will not Speak the colour, and they will not put the child on a riot-line in the first year
A patient	Bleeding, poison, or a knife that needs a still field	Hold the moment, work fast, and walk to the yard afterward to burn the Grey	They will not hold a will. They cannot. They will not still a person as punishment
The watch, or a street that is turning	A brawl about to become a pile of bodies	Stand the line, and still the swing rather than the person, if they can help it	They will not become the town's executioner. Holding a person still is a crime the code names
A Struck Stilled person, raw, who survived being stone	The Grey is already in them, and it is unpracticed	Hand them to the Intake, sit the first drill with the shed, and reverse what can still be reversed	They will not stamp a ticket on a raw Gaze, and they will not leave the person in the square
A charter-clerk	Someone unlicensed is stilling in public	Protect the charter, either by taking the person in or by swearing they were not of the house	They will not write the town's people down. A guild-roll is not a Threnhael
Anyone who wants the Gaze as a weapon	No honest errand	Refuse. The code is the ticket	They will not sell a hold on a person. Anyone who does is not of this house

An ordinary week

The theatre is the pleasant horror outsiders remember. A gaze stops blood, and the surgeon then has to go and move. Between patients they drill, they spar, and they dance, badly, because the dance works the Grey out of the body that spent it. No one in the core calls this therapy. They call it the job.

They touch a doorknob before they look at a patient. If the knob has gone still under an unwatched Gaze, the room is already wrong. A first-year who forgets is sent back to the yard. The yard is exertion

on purpose, the Tithe paid as the work they already understand themselves to do. The ticket-stool is a master’s mark, and the person holds it. The guild knows its members the way any craft does. On the Ledger Coast the ticket can start to behave like property, a place and a chair and a name on a door. That is this house’s live argument. It is not a rule the rest of the world has locked, and other towns do not have to keep it.

When a raw Struck person arrives, the paying floor loses a master for a week, and the guild is not grateful. That week is the Intake.

What they carry is a ticket, a code that is spoken, this world being late-medieval, chalk for the drill roster, and hands that have learned to keep moving. The roll they keep is stillers. It is not a census of the Stilled, and it is not a book of weeks.

They cannot still a will, and they will not pretend they can in order to frighten a street. A raw Struck person goes to the Intake rather than leaving the yard with a stamp. If they can still drag a person to the yard, they will not let the Grey run to a public seize, because a seize on the floor ruins the charter. A roll of stillers is not Threnmaieth’s register of the Stilled, and they do not export a college across the storm-wall.

Who may hold a ticket

The Gaze does not care what you were born. A child of one of the common ancestries and a Kitsune apprentice, one of the fox-born, can stand in the same yard. You are of the house when you can still a wound and then move, and when the town has watched you do both. The house leans toward the Stilled for the work that matches the Tithe. It does not gate the yard by Condition.

Act	Often	Why	Also, and welcome
Theatre, the line	The Stilled	The Tithe and the vocation are the same shape	—
The yard, the roster	Anyone who will make them move	Grey is a body problem	A Kept drill-master, who carries no Condition; a Two-Bodied person who will run them
The ticket-stool	A Given Stilled person who trained young	A memory of the rare colour helps, and is not required	A Long-Lived Speaker’s cousin who copies the code
Intake week	The master who can be spared, often the one the floor can least spare	A raw Gaze is a live hazard	A Struck person who remembers stone and will sit the first drill

Skeptics are welcome, because the Gaze does not require a Mother, and believers in the Waiting Lands will still say a blessing-to-practice, the devout name for the ticket, over the same paper.

How they live in the three corners

The Waiting Lands keep blessing-surgeons, often one tired stiller whose riot-line is also the only theatre, with a blessing-to-practice in place of a college. You were trained, so the valley expects you to stand every line it has. If that stiller is three valleys away, a raw Struck person is still met with a rope.

On the Ledger Coast they are ticket-surgeons. The infirmaries are superb, and the guild-ticket sits next to property, so you can be priced out of the chair. The charter is a commercial good, and unlicensed practice threatens that charter as much as it threatens the street.

Under the Tallied Crown they are crown-stillers. The crown wants the ticket as a crown-warrant and the roll as a column. Some masters cooperate and call the cooperation stewardship. Some refuse, because a guild-roll is not a Threnhael. The Gaze that saves you can run through a channel that withholds the bed from a household the crown dislikes. It is the darkest infirmary in the world, and it is still a real infirmary.

On Kumbaan a travelling stiller is a guest. The guild keeps no chapter there.

The Grey as labor

The guild's best work fills the clock that will lock a limb if the surgeon does not then labor. So the house needs them on the table and in the yard, and the charter needs them never to lapse in public. The infirmary's pace is set by the surgeon's Grey, not only by the patient. This is not a queue for a living Tree, and it is not a week rented from the Slide. It is a hospital that runs on its staff's Tithe.

The argument about the ticket as property, which is the Coast's and which leaks into other towns, is the second face of the same house. Competence lives in a person. The chair can start to live in the guild.

The Motherfaith says she gave a gaze that costs. The roster is people's work, and nobody expects the Tree to make the drill optional. A grudging extra drill-master is the most the guild will grant at the end of any story. The paying floor still comes first.

Theatre, paid surgeries, and charter-fees are the living, together with whatever stipend a town puts on a civic infirmary. Intake is badly paid. The raw Struck people who most need a week in the shed are the week the floor can least spare, which is why the shed stays the underdog and never becomes the rotation anyone wants. The stillers do not furnish green, and they do not furnish novelty. A stiller who is also Taken-In uses the lot like anyone else.

A Grey-drill roster

What follows is a Grey-drill roster from a core infirmary, chalked on the yard wall. The back of the wall is yesterday's roster, washed badly.

> *After third theatre: spar, full glass. After the line: the long run, no Gaze. Apprentices: the knob first, always. A Grey that stays overnight is a Grey we file as lapse, not as rest. The shed is not on this wall. If you were stone last week, you are not on this wall. Come to the door that does not face the street. We do not write that door. We do not still a person to close a day. Touch the knob. Then look.*

The roster is a college keeping its people hale, with the code written as a work-order. It also shows the paying floor refusing to write down the door to the Intake. "A Grey we file as lapse" is how a tired surgeon becomes a charter problem instead of a person who needs a longer run. The knob is not explained.

The Element-Guilds

Ember, Tide, Root, and Gale are four ordinary craft charters that share one safety rule. They keep separate fees, masters, and work, and they share a ticket standard because an idle Answered person is a workshop hazard before they are a theological question. The ticket is what lets that element be used in a crowded yard.

Everyday speech is **the element-guilds**, or the **Ember-house**, the **Tide-house**, the **Root-house**, and the **Gale-house**. The umbrella in a formal charter is **the Crae** *(kray)*, from *crae*, craft, the working of an element. A single Answered person is *of the Crae*, and *of Ember* if you need the door. The Waiting Lands' second word is **gift-shops**. The Ledger Coast says **the craft-houses**. The Tallied Crown files **the Reckoned Craes**. People say the element-guilds. *The Crae* survives mainly where a charter is being written, and the umbrella name is not a separate liturgy for each door.

The shop is how an Answered person pays the Tithe. Leaving the shop leaves the element idle, and idle is the hazard.

Shape of the house

Four doors share one way of licensing. Ember keeps smiths, glass, and firefighting. Tide keeps hulls, dyers, and any work that needs water to behave. Root keeps masons, potters, and the carrying-earth a Road-hand may buy, living earth coaxed so it will travel with a scion. Gale keeps sails, mills, and instruments. An Ember-master does not set Tide's fees. The shop is what the charter covers. Journeymen sit under a door, which is not a census of every lamp-amber leaf in the city. Lamp-amber is the shade that names an Answered child, and the shade names the element. The mill-share, the hull-wrights, and the road-mend keep the season of work beside these doors, and they do not stamp this ticket.

Earnest work, the element used at the craft and not in play, slakes the Tithe. The guild is therefore the upkeep. That is why the monopoly has teeth. A benched Answered person is not merely unemployed, because the element will speak whether or not the shop is paying them. A late-medieval town already needed smiths and masons. The Condition made those guilds necessary twice, once for the work, and once so the work does not let go.

The paper is ordinary on purpose. An apprenticeship term, a supervised Reach, a crowded-yard endorsement, a night rotation, and a transfer are the boxes a clerk already understands. A Reach is the element answering through the hands. The danger enters when one of those boxes is hiding grief, or coercion, or a master protecting a fee. A Condition does not hand the house a personality. An even-tempered Root potter and a short-fused Ember smith share a ticket standard and almost nothing else.

House	Everyday	The hard edge
Stillers and hall-keepers	Sister tickets. They share the Intake shed.	An untended element is not a Gaze and not a Cry, so the person has to reach the right shed.
Greens-keepers	Root and the Taken-In share dirt, and they do not share a roof.	A lot is not a mason’s yard.
Tree-wardens	Lamp-amber is pointed at a door. Road-hands buy carrying-earth.	Root sells the earth. It does not carry the scion. Walking the wood stays with the Road-hands, whose liturgical name is the Thaelvaeth.
Book-Hands	A hull wants a Book-hand’s stamp and a Tide-ticket.	Two stools, and two papers.
Door-keepers	A green door, one of the doors they walk, is not Root’s shop.	Guest-rights are not a craft-ticket.
The Slide	An idle Answered person becomes the Slide’s customer if the shop benched them.	The guild does not rent out a week of spark.

If you meet one

What you notice depends on the door, sweat or clay or salt or chalk-dust, and in every house a shop-rule nailed up beside a ticket-stool that looks like any other master’s. You would hire them to build a hull. You would find the ticket if you asked who may let an element speak in a crowded yard.

Who comes, and when

Who	Why they come	What the house does	What they will not do
A Given Answered child, after lamp-amber	The shade of that leaf named the element, and the shop has to catch the child young	Apprentice the child to that door, put them to earnest work, and give the ticket when the element answers the hands and not the room	They will not Speak the colour, and they will not switch a child's element because the town needed Tide
A working Answered	The craft is the Tithe	Give them the shop, the watch-rotation, the fire-crew, and the escort	They will not bench the person for a rest without a plan. Idle is the hazard
An Answered who lost the shop	Grief, a wrecked yard, or a lord who benched them	Find earnest use now: a crew, a demolition, or a night at the bellows	They will not rent a week of "just enough spark." That rented spark is the Slide
A Struck Answered, raw	A threshold let an element in later, and the person is untrained	Send them to the Intake, and to the right door rather than the nearest fire	They will not stamp a ticket on a raw Reach, and they will not put the person on a hull the same day
Anyone who wants a thing made	A hull, a glass, a wall, or a sail	Make it, and charge as a craft charges	They will not let an unlicensed cousin "just coax the stone" in the street. The charter is the street's safety and the shop's monopoly
A Road-hand needing carrying-earth	Root can coax living earth so that it will travel with a scion	Sell the earth. The guild does not carry the scion	They will not become the Road-hands. That is a different cart

Four doors

Door	The work	The shop-rule you notice	If left idle
Ember	smith, glass, fire-crew	they never let the last coal go dark	heat finds a place to be
Tide	hull, dye, anything wet	a cup of yesterday's water over the door	water finds a place to be
Root	mason, potter, carrying-earth	clay under the nails they will not wash on a work-day	stone and soil find a place to be
Gale	sail, mill, instrument	a window that is never fully shut	wind finds a place to be

Left idle, the element finds a place to be. That place is the shop's problem, and it is never a seized will, so the element does not take hold of someone else. The guild's job is to make the place the shop, and not the crowded hall. The coal, the cup, the clay, and the window are a different matter. Each door keeps one of those habits, and no one explains the habit to a guest. They will not say why.

An ordinary week

A week moves from the shop to the rotation, the fire-crew and the escort and the watch that is also the Tithe, then to the ticket-stool, and it ends at the shop-rule no one explains to a guest.

When a master is pulled to Intake, the paying floor loses a Reach for a week. Ember hates this during a dry month, when the fire-crew can least spare a pair of hands, and Tide hates it when a hull is mid-bend. That hatred is why the shed stays the underdog.

They will not switch an element to suit a labour shortage, because the shade of the leaf named it. Benching someone "for their own good," with no earnest use waiting, is how a room lets go, so they will not do it. A raw Struck person goes to the Intake, and leaves without a stamp. They are not a fourth clergy. They have no colour to Speak, no graft to carry, and no drowning-stone to keep, and they do not export a Crae-college to Kumbaan.

Who may hold a ticket

The ticket is not a Kind. Ember is not a Drakona chapter, and Gale is not a Tengu chapter. Drakona and Tengu are born peoples. You meet more Drakona where a work-fire stays lit from morning until dark, and some of them are Ember-Answered, which is common and still not a gate. A Tengu, the crow-born of the high country, lean and sharp-featured, with dark feathers through the hair and down the arms, who is also Gale-Answered, is a common lean of the same kind. The element is not reserved to either

people. You are of the house when the element answers your work and not the rafters. The house keeps those leans. It does not keep a gate.

Act	Often	Why	Also, and welcome
The shop	The Answered of that element	The Tithe and the vocation are the same work	A Kept striker or puller, who has no Reach and keeps the mundane tools
Fire-crew and rescue	Ember, Gale	Earnest use that is also civic	Two-Bodied on the line; Returned in the wreck, a person who died and came back to finish the work
Carrying-earth	Root	The earth has to live if it is going to travel	Taken-In who will not call the coaxing a grove-rite
Intake week	The master the floor can least spare	A raw Reach is a live workshop hazard	A Struck person who remembers the door and will not flinch

Kept labor is the free generalist around the Reach. They strike, they pull, and they hold the mundane tool. The Ledger Coast calls that person *free*. The Waiting Lands' word is *Waited*, and a Waited person is still useful.

How they live in the three corners

The Waiting Lands keep gift-shops, one mixed yard and four tools and a blessing-to-practice. You were answered, so the valley expects you to spend the element as it asks, on the mill, the wall, or the fire-line. Idle is rare, because the valley will not let a gift sit.

On the Ledger Coast the craft-houses are deep, the tickets are posted, and the monopoly has teeth. You can be priced out of the chair and still need the work, which is how a person slides from self-paying to exposed overnight. The charter is money and safety in one paper.

Under the Tallied Crown the Reckoned Craes put the element and the person on the same column of the roll. Workshops are channels the crown can hold, so a benched Answered person is a withheld Reach, a use the crown has not released. The shop looks like a gift-works. What the crown can withhold is the fire, the slip, the stone, or the wind.

On Kumbaan a wrecked Tide-Answered person is a guest. The guild keeps no Tide-house on the sand.

The shop you cannot leave

Self-paying holds until you want to stop. The Tithe does not care that you buried a child, that the yard burned, or that you are tired of glass. Idle, the element speaks for itself. So the guild's kindness, a shop and a crew and a rotation, is also how the guild holds you. Leaving is a Tithe-crisis, the upkeep failing because the work has stopped. The Waiting Lands, in the devout way of speaking, call that a vocation. The quay, which is how the Ledger Coast talks about the same paper, calls it a contract. The Tallied Crown calls it a channel.

The Motherfaith says she answered. The shop-rule is people's work, written by the house and not by the leaf. The complaint a person can bring is about the exit. The constraint is the element itself. The charter is local, and it has no authority to make another town take an idle journeyman.

A shop-rule

What follows is a shop-rule from an Ember-house in a Lestrand glass-yard, nailed above the last coal. The back of the sheet is a Tide-house rule from the next quay, used as backing.

> *The last coal stays. A Reach used in play is not a Reach used in earnest — the ticket will not have it, and the room will. If you cannot work, you will still work: the fire-crew, the night bellows, the watch. We do not bench. We do not rent a spark. The shed is not this door; raw hands go to the door that does not face the street. If you have already let go, this is still the house — come to the coal, not to the square. Gale will not take you. Tide will not take you. The coal will.*

The rule is a craft keeping its people steady, and it is a little fierce about it. "We do not bench" also means "you may not leave." The Tide-rule on the back says the same thing about a cup of water. The two houses did not copy each other. Why the coal stays, and why the cup is yesterday's, they will not say.

The Intake

The Intake is a shed, and it works to a plain rule. It gets a newly Struck person, someone the change took outside the childhood ceremony and who is not yet safe to stand next to, into a state where the town does not have to reach for a rope.

Everyday speech is **the Intake**, or **the shed**. The in-house word is **the catching-year**. The Waiting Lands call it **the late-catching**. The Ledger Coast calls it **the emergency ticket**. The Tallied Crown

calls it **the unwitnessed warrant**, because the crown treats a change nobody witnessed as a thing that still needs a name. A person has a week. In that week the hazard is live and the town wants the person gone. If the week works, the slip is burned, and the story told afterwards is that the guild simply trains its own.

They have a week to make a live hazard into a person the town will stand next to, and if they succeed, no one writes it down.

Shape of the office

The Struck person is brought to the shed. A runner arrives, or a master is pulled off the paying floor. The fear is a rope already in someone's hand, a runner still three days out, and a loud week that becomes a charter hearing. Road-hands already walk the long road. If the Intake walks, it walks toward one particular person. It is not a circuit.

Three ticket-houses share the shed, and each hazard still has its own door. A raw Gaze goes to the Stillers. A raw voice goes to the hall. A raw Reach goes to the right element, not the nearest fire. The wrong house is how a Cry gets stilled quiet, as if a voice were a thing the yard could hold still, or how an Ember is put on a bench to sing. The parent yards pretend the shed is not on their wall, even in a week when they have lent it the master. Success is silence. A quiet catching-year is a week the floor lost. A loud one is a hearing. Nobody changes the guild's mind about the shed. A grudging extra pair of hands is the most the yard will grant, and they will take them back.

What the catching-week requires

The shed has four things, and no more. It has a place, the door that does not face the street, which is not the theatre, the boards, or the paying shop. It has hands: one master the floor can spare, often the one it can least spare, a Kept person who carries no Condition and will sit, and whatever the yard had left from last year. It has a narrow authority. They can take the person if the person will come. They cannot overrule a frontier rope, and they cannot stamp a ticket this week. It has a thin reputation. Leadership has forgotten them on a good day and will blame them on a bad one, because the charter is at risk if the person harms someone, and at risk again if the guild refused the Struck and the town later says it left a hazard in the square.

What they are racing is time. The Gaze, the Cry, or the Reach is already live, and the town wants the person gone. The task is to begin the apprenticeship before that rope, to help the person make a first honest payment of the Tithe that is not a public hazard, and to find someone who will vouch for them as what they are now, which means someone who will stand up and say they know the person as they have become. Intake does not sell that vouch, and it does not take the vouch's place. At the end of the week the person is still raw and beginning to be safe to stand next to, or the person is gone. Gone

means the rope, the road, or a week-keeper who will keep them by the week and will not make them safe.

What counts as success is that the person is still alive, still here, and beginning to be safe, and that the town pretends this was always going to happen. The guild does not apologize.

If you meet one

You meet someone tired, chalk on a sleeve, a key to a door the slate does not name. You would miss them if you came in the front of the infirmary or the playhouse. Ask where the one who was stone yesterday went. Or you are the runner, and you already know the door. They are who a town has when a becoming has already happened and the town may prefer it had not.

Who comes, and when

Who	Where they go	What the Intake will not do
A raw Stilled person, who was stone	A first drill. The hold does not outlast the scene.	Stamp a ticket, or still a crowd as a lesson.
A raw Far-Voiced person, who drowned	The back room of the hall, so the person can vent on purpose.	Open that room after the lamps as a policy.
A raw Answered person	The right element door, for earnest use that is not the crowded shop.	Put them on a hull the same day.
A family, a door-keeper, or a Book-hand	The Intake takes the person and asks who will stand for them as what they are now.	Sell a vouch, or call the person Given.
The watch	The Intake bargains for the shed instead of the rope, and sometimes loses.	Fight the town. They have a key. They cannot command the street.

The paying floor wants its master back. The shed finishes the week or fails it, and the master goes back to the floor.

Bound Terms are a table, not a body the shed can catch, and a Taken-In upkeep is a lot, so neither of those people is this door’s work. A Returned purpose cannot be furnished here, a Two-Bodied person uses civic land, and a Long-Lived person uses a long-house. A bystander who was only standing nearby gets no ticket from the shed.

An ordinary catching-year (it is not ordinary)

There is no ordinary week, only the week in front of them.

They get the person off the square, out of the water, and away from the shop that is already wrong. They name what is already true, that the person carries a Gaze, or a voice, or a Reach, and then they help that person make a first honest payment that is not a public hazard, a drill or an hour or a coal that is not the public forge. They find someone who will stand for the person anew. At the end of the week the person is handed to the real apprenticeship, still raw and beginning to be safe, or the person is gone.

The slip is written on the inside of a ticket-blank, and the face stays empty until a real ticket is earned. A first-year who writes on the face is made to strike it out. They will not stamp a ticket this week, because competence is not a week old. If they must walk, they walk toward this Struck person. The Road-hands already have the road, and a Bound person’s Terms are another table’s paper.

Who may sit the shed

The shed does not choose sitters by Kind. A person sits the week so the Struck person does not become a public story. Whoever sits is a ticket-holder of that hazard, there for the live Tithe, or a Kept person who can stay because they carry no Condition of their own, or a Struck person who remembers the door, or a runner who can run.

How they live with the other houses

The Stillers, the hall, and the element-guilds pretend the shed is not written on the wall. If the week fails, the Slide takes the overflow. The Intake wants the person safe enough to leave. The Slide wants the person not fallen enough to stay. A Book-hand may send someone, and a hall that was never there still counts as owing. A door-keeper may name the person kin the same week. Kinship is not a ticket. They are two courtesies, and either one can happen without the other. The Standing Trade will sell a witness who says they watched. The Intake will not.

How they live in the three corners

In the Waiting Lands the rope is real, and the shed may be a barn. Once the person is caught, the valley will spend them.

On the Ledger Coast there is a fee if anyone can pay it, and the hazard in the street still takes the person when nobody can.

Under the Tallied Crown the crown wants the person named as they are caught, so a slip written on the inside of a blank, where the face stays empty, is already a defiance of that naming.

On Kumbaan a wreck walked uphill is a guest, and there is no shed on the sand.

The week no one writes

The floor needs the master back on the paying work, the town needs the hazard gone, and the Struck person needs a year, while the shed has a week and is blamed for all three. If the week succeeds, the story told afterwards is that the guild trains its own. If it fails, the story is the shed. The pay is whatever the parent house has left after the paying floor, the shed and the food and the master's lost week, and what they do with it is catch a person rather than keep a commons or sell an hour.

A catching-year slip

What follows is written on the inside of a blank ticket, in a stillers' shed in a core town. The face of the blank is empty on purpose.

> *Inside only. Gaze, raw. Third night. Stood for by the sister and by N. who will not give a family name. First drill held. The hold does not last. No ticket. If the week ends quiet, burn this. If it does not, the charter already knows. We do not face the street. If they will not come, we cannot make a town take them.*

The empty face is deliberate. When the slip is burned, the success becomes the guild's ordinary story, and the person's becoming was never written down in public. The sister stood, and N. would not give a family name, and both of them are someone standing for the Struck.

Three corners: Vaethorn, Lestrand, Threnmaieth

Every polity in the Turning sets three things, and sets them apart from one another. **Theology** is how far the gift is taken into ordinary life, from an ardent Motherfaith, the faith of the Leaf-Mother, to a place that is frankly secular. **Reach** is whether the place stands among healthy Turning Trees, where the Given are dense, or at a thin edge, where more children come away Kept and more people are Struck later and alone. **Governance** is how far the state reaches onto a person, from light guild self-rule, the ordinary arrangement, to a crown that writes its subjects down. Law, livelihood, and daily life stay the same from power to power, because they come from the Trees and from the Conditions. What changes is the combination.

Say **the Waiting Lands**, **the Ledger Coast**, and **the Tallied Crown**. Charters, rites, and learned maps write *Vaethorn*, *Lestrand*, and *Threnmaieth*. Each pair of the three shares exactly one setting and

differs on the other two. Three further corners have notes of their own. Ornled is a secular frontier. Maiethvael is a devout, lightly governed, Tree-rich core. Trenledd is a cold surveillance-state with no faith to sanctify the roll. The other twelve powers sit between these.

Name	Theology	Reach	Governance	The one-line feel
the Waiting Lands *(written Vaethorn)*	high	low	low	Faith is ardent, the Trees are thin, and almost no state reaches a person: a warm, poor, half-lawless pilgrim edge
the Ledger Coast *(written Lestrand)*	low	high	low	Faith is worn lightly among dense Trees, and guilds do the governing a crown would do elsewhere: a rich, cool, transactional merchant power
the Tallied Crown *(written Threnmaieth)*	high	high	high	Sacred and surveilled together: a wealthy, pious core where keeping the census is a holy duty

The Waiting Lands and the Ledger Coast share low governance, and that is the only setting they share. Both keep a light-touch state, and everything else swings the other way, so that one is warm, poor, and faithful while the other is rich, cool, and secular.

The Waiting Lands and the Tallied Crown share high theology, the same ardent faith, lived in wildly different circumstances. One is devotion at a starving edge. The other is devotion in a sanctified core that watches its people.

The Ledger Coast and the Tallied Crown share high reach, the same wealth of Trees, and they spend that wealth in opposite directions, the Coast in free markets and the Crown on a census of persons held as holy.

The three settings are independent, which is why two devout lands can be this far apart, and why two lightly governed lands can be this far apart, and why two Tree-rich lands can spend the wealth as enemies of each other’s idea of a good life. Theology is not a measure of good or bad. High theology produces both the kindest corner to a whole neighbour, the Waiting Lands, and the most inescapable control in the world, the Tallied Crown. Devotion multiplies whatever else the polity is already doing. Each corner owns its injustice, and the harms come through different institutions. Warm faith, a free market, and a sanctified order do not fail in the same way.

The name a polity gives a shared thing shows the stance. A devout land’s gift-hall is a surveillance-crown’s counted hall. It is the same building. The three written names come down from the Old Tongue, the root speech the rites still use.

Vaethorn: the Waiting Lands

(formal VAETH-orn; spoken Wetorn · theology high · reach low · governance low)

Vaethorn is a broad, thinly peopled land at the world's Tree-poor margin, where the faith burns hottest because the Trees are scarce, and where the ruling mood is waiting. People wait for a graft, young wood set in this ground, to take. They wait for a distant Tree to be reached. They wait for a gift that may never fall. This is a frontier with theology turned as high as it goes, and the two facts feed each other. Where the Trees are few and young, more children come away Kept, more people are Struck later and alone, and the Motherfaith answers that scarcity with more devotion, not less: pilgrimage, longing, and a theology built around waiting for a gift that may not come.

Law here. Governance is almost absent. No crown reaches the individual, and custom outruns written law the way it does on any frontier. Citizenship is witnessed in the oldest, most literal way, a settlement small enough that everyone was there when you Turned. The Lands' thin reach makes that fragile. With few Long-Lived to remember and few Bound to vouch, the three pillars that make proof-by-people work are stretched thin. Those pillars are a Long-Lived memory, a Bound vouch, and a Far-Voiced voice. The unvouched Struck, a person who changed alone, with no guild to catch them and few witnesses to stand for them, is a constant ache, and the Lands meet it with faith rather than machinery. A feared Condition here is more likely to meet a rope or a blessing than a licence, because there is often no guild to issue one. Someone who stands for you in a new place does it at worship, and they call that standing-for *the speaking*. They call the ticket *the blessing-to-practice*. No Condition can command another person's will. That rule is the Inviolate Will, taught to every child as "the will is one's own," and here they call it *the Mother's own line*. The warden is most of the state a valley can see, and the Lands call wardens Hands-folk.

Economy here. There is little formal furnishing and there are few specialists, but the theology reads the frontier's poverty as charity. Where a purely secular frontier would improvise the upkeep as barter and favor, the Waiting Lands do it as alms and congregation. The venting a Far-Voiced person needs happens at worship, and they call that worship the gift-hall. Neighbours furnish the green a Taken-In person needs and count it a sacred duty, and they call that green the Mother's green, held in common. The Taken-In, whom rich cities keep at arm's length and still need on the lots, are here the honoured backbone of the land. Working the living earth is the holy economy. It is commons-minded generosity with almost nothing to fund it: real warmth, real want, and a thin edge where the people whose Tithe must be furnished slide with only prayer for a net. Time spent as the animal, on open land, they call the wild-leave. The long-house of books they call the deathless gift. When the commons run out, they call the Slide the last pot, and also gift-credit.

Daily life here. Ceremony is thin, and devotion makes what there is of it enormous. A child's Turning at a small, hard-won grafted Tree is the event of a decade, a joyous, anxious sacrament, and the Kept

child is felt most sharply here. In a land starved of the gift, to be passed over reads, wrongly and cruelly, as being passed over by the Mother herself. People call the Kept the Waited, or Mother-kept, and the valley pities them for it. They call the Struck the late-come, met at a later door. Medicine is a travelling stiller if the settlement is lucky, and a rope and a prayer if it is not. The gap between a rich core and this edge is at its widest here. Families are warm, mixed, and self-reliant. A Condition lapsing with no infirmary to reach is a frontier tragedy the faith can console and cannot cure.

Its injustice. The harm is a guilt. The scarcity of the gift becomes a theology of unworthiness, so the Kept wonder what they lacked, and the Struck wonder why the Mother came to them at the wrong door and alone. A hard, quiet piety can shade into treating want as a spiritual failing. The Waiting Lands are the kindest place in the world to a whole neighbour and the loneliest to an unvouched one.

The seat. Eolvaeth *(EOL-vaeth)* is a pilgrim-edge vale behind the coast that faces Strandoren. The name sets *eol*, a hinge, beside *vaeth*, the waiting, and folk-speech shortens it to Elvaeth. People walk here to wait, and the Tree at the end of that wait is not a certainty. The seat is not Harrow's Green, the Hand that grew up and that a neighbour can already count on, not the three hamlets that can see that canopy from a ford, and not Saelvaeth's march, further along the same wave of grafts.

What they remember. The wave of wood arrived late, and the First Cut is the name of that arrival, the first time living wood was carried out from the Awakening Tree and set in new ground. The Hinge Hush, the peace that still charges the Old Crossing once, says the Waiting Lands may bless a landing on Heskoren and may not levy that landing as if the peace were a gospel. Ornled, the secular frontier on that same far coast, has no hymn on the clause. Saelvaeth may take a pot of living wood without paying the Waiting Lands' price for the wait. The guilt-theology wants both of those neighbours unworthy. The history kept in the Other Count, the dated years that are not the spread of grafts, does not agree.

Lestrand: the Ledger Coast

(LES-trand · theology low · reach high · governance low)

Lestrand is a dense, Tree-rich merchant power, a merchant city of the kind a person means by Bruges or Florence, carried as far as markets can go. The Trees are mature and many, the Given are dense, and the faith is worn lightly over deep markets and thin welfare, so that the whole business of becoming is read as a transaction. It shares the Waiting Lands' light-touch governance, and no crown writes anyone down. Where the Lands' light state leaves a gap the faith fills, the Coast's light state leaves a space the guilds fill, completely.

Law here. Guild self-rule is carried as far as it goes. The state is a charter-granting council of merchant houses and craft-guilds. It charters the Stilled's guild and the element-guilds, and it watches

the guild, never the individual. Citizenship-by-witness runs smoothly here because reach is high. Long-Lived notaries are abundant, Bound oaths close the contracts, and Far-Voiced voices stand on every dock and in every court. A city this size nests that witness as hearths, a quay-gang or a courtyard, rather than as twenty thousand people sharing one memory. The three pillars are not reverence here. They are the machinery that lets a huge commercial city run on trust without a register. Travelers clear on a road-word, a traveler's vouch, or on a guild-mark. The gate asks three questions, a name, a last hearth, and who stands, and any two will do. It does not ask your colour, and it does not keep the answers past dawn. The Struck are vouched in briskly, not as a grace but as efficiency, because an unvouched person is a transaction that cannot clear. Here they call the Struck *the turned*. They call standing-for *warranting*, a commercial guarantee. They call the ticket *the guild-ticket*. The Inviolate Will is cited as sound commercial law, *the free-will clause*. A Bound contract binds property, not persons, and the Coast likes that line because it makes the Bound the witness a written contract wants. They call the Motherfaith *the old rite*, and they wear it light. The Fair Hand, the faith of honest accounts, they call *the Settling*, and on this coast that is ordinary. Its clerks are the Settling-hands.

Economy here. This is the richest corner, and the coolest. Deathless banking is fullest here. Deathless houses keep trusted notes that other houses measure their paper against, the nearest thing the world has to a gold standard, and they keep century instruments, loans and endowments on horizons no mortal lender would risk. They endow fortunes rather than leave them as inheritances, at a scale the other lands do not match. The great endowed libraries and universities cluster here, and that money funds the Long-Lived novelty-Tithe, the need for something genuinely new. They call the long-house *the endowment*, or simply *the house*. Self-paying Conditions prosper, the Answered crafts, the Two-Bodied haulage and courier trades, the Stilled surgeons, because their labor is their upkeep and the market pays for the labor. Tithe-provision is a private market, not a public good. You buy your green, and they call the plot *the leaf-lot*. You buy your outlet at the release-house, and that house is also the playhouse. If you can afford it, you stay whole in comfort. The injustice is the market's. The people whose Tithe must be furnished get thin welfare in a rich city, the starkest have-and-have-not gap in the world. The shadow economy, smuggled green, black-market novelty, sold vouching, and off-book Bound contracts feeding the Given-Over, a Bound person bargained down until the counterparty effectively owns them, runs biggest here because the legitimate market is biggest here. The risk the deathless pose is at its most acute. A handful of houses that never die quietly steer the wealthiest polity through patronage that never disperses. After a fee fails, someone rents the week, and they call it week-rent. They call the Kept *the free*, labor with no Tithe to furnish, and they say it with approval. They call the ranging *the beast-yard*, and that yard can be hired. They call tree-wardens *tree-tenders*.

Daily life here. The Condition-medicine is superb. The great Stilled infirmaries and the deathless-endowed hospitals are here, in the rich core, for those who can reach them, and the queue outside is the longest here too. Family life shrugs at theology. A marriage market reads Conditions as assets. A Two-Bodied bloodline is a trade dynasty. A Long-Lived match is a century of credit. The aching Long-Lived marriage, grief against advantage, gets weighed as coolly as any other balance. The Turning is a

civic and commercial milestone more than a sacrament. A family's Leaf-Fall is watched for what guild the child's colour opens. The life is free, and it is prosperous. An attic-host of the Open Table, the faith that sets an extra place, is a curiosity and a good supper. Sailors print "no one is a stranger twice" on a card, and the Settling will not enforce the card.

Its injustice. This is the coolest of the three. Your marriage, your gift, and your faith stay your own, and nothing here is policed, while everything is priced, so a person who cannot pay slides with a whole rich city stepping around them. The Coast will not file you and will not conscript you. It will let you fade if you run out of coin, and it will feel that it owed you nothing.

The seat. Orentel *(OREN-tel)* is a salt-quay city on the Old Crossing, the narrow water between the Motherland and this coast. The written name is a worn *oren*, to witness, set beside the Tree, the *th* eroded to *t*. The White Note House sits on the third quay, north side. It keeps terms. It does not govern the coast, and it is not the crown.

What they remember. Paper written on the Salt Walk, the old sea-and-land road through this continent, outlived the gate of the Closed Seat, the power that tried to pull the copied Trees back up and then went behind the walls of the Inner Close. The notes outlived the Grey Summer, the quay-fever on the Old Crossing in Cut-year 171, an epidemic and not a Tithe. The rate the first quay still charges is the Hinge Hush. Sirtol *(SEER-tol)* spoke for a pile of Coast charters in that peace, one charter-holder among many, and did not sit a throne. Brenledd, the hearth-league, piled its hearths into one compact rather than be priced one hearth at a time. The White Note is one desk-house, not the polity. The chronicle of that memory is the Other Count.

Threnmaieth: the Tallied Crown

(THREN-mai-eth · theology high · reach high · governance high)

Threnmaieth is a pious, Tree-rich core kingdom that keeps a census of persons and their Conditions, in the wealthiest, most devout, most Tree-dense land in the three corners. The written name sets *thren*, sacred counting, beside *maieth*, the Mother, so the name is the Mother's Reckoning. Here the roll is kept as a holy duty. The Mother's gifts are precious and must be accounted for. That makes it the hardest of the three to resist. The other two have injustices you can name and resent. This one puts its injustice in the two things the world most trusts, faith and plenty.

Law here. The Tallied Crown keeps a record held on people. Every subject and their gift is written down, not as the guild rolls and tax ledgers everyone has, but as a census of persons. At home that census is reverent stewardship of the Mother's blessings. Elsewhere it is felt as surveillance. They call it the **Threnhael** *(THREN-hayl)*, *thren* set beside *hael*, whole, so the name sounds like keeping the realm hale. Its clerks say they keep subjects whole. Outsiders hear the Counting. Trenledd keeps a roll

of persons too. The difference is that the Tallied Crown calls its roll holy, and Trenledd does not. Other cities nest the witness as a hearth, the neighbours who stood, and then stop. Threnmaieth copies that stand onto the Threnhael, and the copying is the whole difference. On that roll the second name is the house, where other lands would say a surname.

Because reach is high, there is a great deal to count. The Given are dense, and the crown calls them *the marked*. The guilds are dense. Long-Lived memory is abundant, and the crown distrusts it, because that memory is not the crown's. What gives the crown away is that it will not rely on the three pillars the rest of the world runs on, because living memory answers to itself and a ledger answers to the crown. The unvouched are hunted, and the Struck are pursued so they can be catalogued, a pursuit the crown files as *the unwitnessed*. The Bound are watched far past their real hazard. The roster's own clerks know the Inviolate Will means the Whisper cannot command, and the watching is stigma kept as if it were safety. Devotion supplies the justification a census without faith would lack. A steward will say you would not hide a gift from the Mother, so why hide it from her stewards. They call standing-for *the naming*, because you are named to the crown, and they call the ticket *the crown-warrant*, the Inviolate Will *the crown's assurance*, and the Motherfaith *the Reckoned Faith*.

Economy here. Tithe-need is turned to leverage, and consecrated. The crown provides the upkeep efficiently, even generously, because a pious, rich state can afford to, and then it holds what it provides. It holds the green, which it calls the tended green, the novelty, which it calls the crown archive, the outlets, which it calls the counted hall, and the Stilled medicine, all of them running through channels the crown can withhold. A population whose staying-whole runs through the state cannot afford to refuse it. That is the most complete control in the world, and here it wears a halo. To receive your provision is to receive the Mother's bounty through her appointed hands, and to be cut off is framed as your lapse, not the crown's lever. They call the furnishing the counted channel. They call the Slide the late week, the week the channel will not admit failed. Videm knows that room is there, and Sirtal files the leak as the person's own lapse. A Two-Bodied person's time as the animal is filed as the ranging-roll. Deathless finance here is superb and centuries deep, but the Long-Lived are courtiers and crown-archivists as much as bankers. Their memory, which cannot be bribed into forgetting, is bent to the census rather than left free to check it.

Daily life here. The sacrament and the census are the same hour. A child's Turning is a joyous holy day that is also a state registration. The colour that falls is celebrated with a hymn and recorded by a clerk. Marriages of heritable Conditions, Two-Bodied bloodlines especially, are noticed, encouraged or discouraged, and filed. The medicine is excellent, and it runs through the crown's channels. A household whose bloodline and upkeep are both on file cannot easily refuse the crown anything. That is a blessing said over a house the crown can already see. The Kept are pitied here the way a devout land pities them, and recorded the way this crown records them. The roll says *the unmarked*, or *the passed-over*. They were passed over by the Mother, and the crown notes them as such. Tree-wardens are filed as the Reckoned Hands. The crown wants them named to the Threnhael as officers of the

Reckoned Faith, the colours written down and the Speakers working as stewards. Some Speakers cooperate, because they believe they are keeping the realm hale. Some refuse. The Tree witnessed, they say, and a ledger is a second, lesser seeing. Nearness to the First Seat is pressure. The crown does not own the Seat. The college can refuse the roll, and some Speakers do.

Its injustice. This is the worst of high devotion and a state that reaches every person, each excusing the other. The devotion makes the surveillance feel like reverence, so that being counted is piety, and the surveillance enforces the devotion, so that refusing the count is impiety. What you meet is a wealthy, faithful, orderly people who genuinely believe that accounting for the Mother's gifts is the highest form of tending them, and that belief makes the control almost impossible to resist. Elsewhere the roll reads as chilling, because only two crowns keep one. Here the faith is what lets it feel like grace.

The seat. Maiethlir *(MAI-eth-lir)* stands on the Core-thaw, the snowmelt river in the Sacred Core. *Maieth* is the Mother, and *lir* is the thaw. Its children can Turn at its own Tree, which makes it a Hand, a town with a Tree of its own. Pilgrims still walk on from here to the Awakening Tree, whose name is Thaeloren, and the crown's roll is kept in this town. The seat does not own Thaeloren. The First Seat of the wardens sits in the Motherwood beside the town, and the crown does not own that college either.

What they remember. The Two Papers, in Cut-year 67, are what this crown calls the year the reckoning stood. Limrae *(lim-RAY)* opened a desk in a river-town and wrote persons down, because, as they said, a gift you cannot find again is a gift you have already failed to tend. The crown-count starts in that summer. A devout clerk may write Cut-year 387 and Crown-year 320 on the same slate, and the sixty-seven years between them are the split. Maiethvael is the cousin-country that would not be named, the same hymns on the opposite paper. The Inner Close keeps another list, of rank and not of care, and will not share ink. The chronicle is the Other Count.

Book V

The Lands

The Four Continents

The map is a gradient of how far the Trees have reached. Read it outward and the old sacred country nearest the origin is dense with Trees, the merchant coasts beyond it still have many, the frontier runs thin, and past the last capes a storm-walled isle has none. That distance is the reach.

There is one Awakening Tree, **Thaeloren**. Every town Tree is a living graft of it, a piece of that first Tree kept alive on the road and planted in a new square so a child can Turn under it. People call that planted Tree a Turning Tree. The farther a land sits from the deep, old, densely grafted core, the thinner its reach tends to run. The Trees are fewer, younger, and more fragile. More children are hugged at the Tree and stay Kept, which means the leaves left them with no colour and no Condition, the change a person carries. More children miss a Tree entirely and stay UnTurned. More people are Struck later, alone, with no one there to see the change. How far a land sits from Thaeloren is also how long ago the wood arrived. The Ages chapter tells that history.

The old speech drifts along the same line. Names keep the old *th* nearest the Tree, where the liturgy is still almost unchanged. A frontier town wears the sound down and puts it back when someone prays. A dock town sands it off. You can hear how far a land sits from the grove in how people say the same word.

What the names mean

The names on the map are old words glued together. Here is what they are saying the first time they appear as places.

Name	Says	Means
Thaeloren	THAEL-or-en	the Tree that witnesses. Everyday: **the Thallow**. The Awakening Tree.
Maiethorn	MAI-eth-orn	the Mother's Land
Strandoren	stran-DOR-en	the Witnessed Shore. Everyday: **Strandor**
Heskoren	hesk-OR-en	the Outer Land. Everyday: **Heskorn**. *Hesk-* is a frontier word for the far edge; the old rite is older than this grafting.
Kumbaan	koom-BAHN	the hidden home, in the Yumboes' own tongue. Sailors say **the Sundering Isle**, or **the Sunder**, for the water that walls it off.

Each of the three large continents has one famous corner, named by gluing two old words together and wearing them down. The farther the corner sits from the Awakening Tree, the more the old sound has worn off.

Name	Says	Means
Threnmaieth	THREN-mai-eth	the Mother's Reckoning. Keeps the full old sound.
Lestrand	LES-trand	the Reckoning Coast. The *th* is gone.
Vaethorn	VAETH-orn	the Waiting Land. Spoken: **Wetorn**.

The other named powers on each continent are built from the same old words. You will meet them as you go. **Language and Naming** will let you hear one as it appears, or make another.

How the continents sit

Reading the world roughly **east to west**, which is also the direction the wood thins:

Maiethorn anchors the **east**. It is the land that has been settled longest, and the Awakening Tree still stands there, which is why everything the world calls "the center" is on this continent.

Strandoren lies **west across the Old Crossing**, close enough for constant, ancient trade. That is why Maiethorn and Strandoren are spoken of as the Old World pair. Strandoren's long indented coasts face the water, and that water is the busiest in the world. People call the two continents the Old World pair

because the water is old and close, and because it made them into one argument. They do not call the water “inner.”

Heskoren sprawls **further west and south**, beyond Strandoren’s far coast. It was reached late and grafted late, and it is the edge of the settled world. Between Strandoren and Heskoren the sea widens into the West Water, the reach thins, and “the frontier” is the name people give to what begins on the far shore.

The Sundering Isle sits **alone in the far west ocean, or in the deep south**, past Heskoren’s last capes, and the compass is not the part that is fixed. A band of killing weather, currents, and reef has wrecked most of the people who tried to cross, so the isle is off the edge of the reach entirely. It has no Tree, the grafts never crossed to it, and its people are mythic-rare on all three of the other continents, known mostly as a sailor’s story.

What has to hold, if a later map turns the page, are the relative positions and the distances. Maiethorn and Strandoren stay close and old. Heskoren stays far and thin. The Isle stays sundered beyond the last capes.

The four continents at a glance

Continent	Reach	Role	Named powers here	Rival faith
Maiethorn (the Motherland)	full	The sacred origin; the Awakening Tree stands here	Threnmaieth · Maiethvael · Orenbren · Saelthael · the Hinge Shore · Lirorn	the Watching
Strandoren (the Shore-lands)	high	The great trade continent, the world’s crossroads	Lestrand · Brenledd · Leddvael · Trenledd · Netstrand	the Fair Hand
Heskoren (the Sundered Reach)	thin	The frontier; newest-grafted, half-wild	Vaethorn · Ornled · Vaelhesk · Saelvaeth	the Old Ways
The Sundering Isle (Kumbaan, the Yumboe homeland)	near-none	The storm-walled remote isle; mythic-rare people	not a mainland power	the Open Table

Each of the three large continents carries several of the fifteen great powers. Threnmaieth, Lestrand, and Vaethorn sit one to a continent, so a traveller cannot meet all three by walking one road. The

Motherfaith is one faith among several. The Watching, the Fair Hand, and the Old Ways live on the large continents, where they rub against the Motherfaith. The Open Table is the Isle's own.

Maiethorn: the Motherland

(mah-YETH-orn. The name is "the Mother's Land," spoken almost unchanged from the liturgy.)

Maiethorn is the world's old heart, the continent people mean when they say "the center." It is old the way a cathedral town is old: long-settled, deeply grafted, every hill with its Tree and every Tree with its centuries. This is where the Motherfaith began, where the Awakening Tree grows, and where a child's Turning is least remarkable because it is most certain. The Trees are healthy enough that more children are Given here, a coloured leaf falling on them at the solstice, than in the world as a whole, so a hug at the Tree is less common here than elsewhere. The hug is not rare, and every Maiethorn school has Kept children. The Conditions chapter gives the shares.

The work and trade that runs on what people became goes to its full depth here. Deathless houses, the households of the Long-Lived, stand centuries old, Stilled infirmaries are part of ordinary care, and the Far-Voiced, whose feeling carries in the voice, are on every court and every quay. If the rest of the world is that fullness thinning as you travel outward, Maiethorn is the thick end the thinning is measured from.

Devotion here is the heaviest in the world, because the Awakening Tree stands on this continent. It runs through institutions and through politics, and living close to the holy brings pressure, not peace. The faith is old and contested. Threnmaieth counts its people and calls the count sacred. A stubborn heartland heresy claims the same center.

Geography and climate

At the heart of the continent stands **Thaeloren, the Awakening Tree**, called the First Hand, in a deep old grove that is the destination of the world's great pilgrimage. The land around that grove is the most densely grafted on earth: an old, gentle country of rounded hills, river valleys, and towns crowned with Trees, worn smooth by long settlement.

A vast old-growth forest of motherwood and its wild kin rings that core. Here are the healthiest Trees, and the graft-nurseries from which the cuttings travel to the whole world. The First Seat and the faith's institutions cluster in the clearings. **Rothallo** sits a day's walk out from the wood. People still call it the Inner Close, and it stands inside Orenbren, not as a sixteenth power.

The Rain-Wall, which Lirorn calls the Thaw-Wall, divides the continent's watersheds. The climate on the settled side is temperate and seasonal, with four true seasons and winters real enough that a Leaf-Fall timed to the solstice means something. Guild towns keep mechanical clocks, and there is no printing press. Tengu hearths, the crow-born people of the high country, and Fox-of-the-Snows country sit on the high snows. Those are families on that ground, not a nation of one born people. The range is also why the east is dry.

Two passes cross the range. The **Noon Pass** is the old high road, and the water-line of the Thaw-Break still sits on its ribbon-notch. The **Shelf-gate** is the road Narol of the Pass took after that Break, when the old stone sat under the water. Narol is dead, so the household that inherited the toll still levies it, and the person does not. The river that runs west off the range is the **Core-thaw**, and Maiethlir sits where that water slows.

East of the Rain-Wall, on the leeward side away from the Old Crossing, the land falls into **dry hills and sand-country**, the one true dry reach in the known world. The Well-wash is a river in a kind Liren, the thaw when the water is gentle, and a line of silt in a cruel one. This is the hearth of the Fox of the Sands, and it is still Maiethorn: the same Trees, the same old *th*, and the same pilgrimage west toward Thaeloren. The weather here is the dry one. Towns cluster at wells and at whatever graft will take in thin soil. **Larbril** is where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass. **Ornsael** is the smaller well-town farther into the dry, where people sow at a well. Open sand-country lies between it and Larbril, and the town sits inland. Children in the sacred core could already Turn at a Turning Tree while families here were still walking west to Thaeloren.

The western coast faces the busy **Old Crossing** toward Strandoren, the oldest trade route in the world. Ports here are ancient and rich, if less frantic than Strandoren's. The Hinge Shore is the face that says what a hull is carrying before anyone across the water prices it. Selkie families, the sea-born, are common on these quays, as they are on any old water.

Reach

The reach is **full**, the densest and healthiest grafting anywhere. The core runs higher on the Given than the world as a whole. Long-Lived memory, the sworn word of the Bound, and Far-Voiced feeling are thick on the ground, and those three gifts are the pillars a witnessed life travels on. The Kept are fewer than elsewhere, but there are Kept children in every town, and in the more fervent districts they are quietly pitied as passed-over. The Walled Book, behind Rothallo's walls, teaches that a hug is rare. That is the Walled Book's lesson, not the count. Nowhere else are so many children Given, or so many of those three gifts at work. What the rest of the world treats as ordinary was written as if this fullness were normal everywhere.

The wood arrived with the First Cut. The years since that first successful planting are Cut-years. Maiethorn filled in Cut-years 0–80, origin-towns first. A cutting could travel about a day while the

wood was still alive, and then it had to meet new ground. The **Rain-Shadow was slower**: the same continent, thin soil, and wells. Towns in the sacred core had Turning Trees, and their children stopped walking to Thaeloren, while sand-country families were still walking west. That difference is dirt, not a different gospel. The Ages chapter has the years.

Powers

Threnmaieth, the Tallied Crown (theology high · reach high · governance high) is the wealthy, pious, surveilled kingdom near the sacred center. Its census, the **Threnhael**, treats the writing-down of people as reverent stewardship of the Mother's gifts. Maiethorn's full reach is why Threnmaieth has so much to count. Its seat is **Maiethlir**, a town on the thaw-river with its own Turning Tree. The grove of Thaeloren stands outside the crown's rule, and Maiethlir does not own it.

Maiethvael, the Gift-Realm, is devout and rich, and it keeps no census. Its capital is **Seinbrun**, a large city in the warm core, off the thaw-river where Maiethlir sits. People furnish a hall, a green, and medicine. The Down-Bank is the road below Maiethlir's Down Gate, and gift-folk live along that road. Seinbrun is farther on, down the Core-thaw and north of Maiethlir on the atlas, more than a day from Maiethlir. The rest of that walk is not recorded.

Orenbren, the Witness-Hearths, is the lodging on the roads to the grove. Pilgrims sleep in its inns, and that lodging is the power. The Awakening Tree stands outside its rule. Its capital is **Rothallo**, the walled city one day's walk from the wood. People still say the Inner Close, and they mean this city. The First Seat is in the wood. The Third Hearth is a road-house on the same pilgrim road, and the Mill-hold and Nelath are squares of the same lodging-country.

Saelthael, the Sown Tree, is the Rain-Shadow, and families here still walk west to a healthier canopy to Turn. Its city is **Larbril**, east of the Rain-Wall on the dry side, where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass. **Ornsael** is the well-town farther into the dry, where people sow at the well.

The Hinge Shore is Maiethorn's coast on the Old Crossing. Before a hull is priced across the water, this shore says whether it carries pilgrims, a cutting in a pot, a person, or cargo. Its port is **Votaer**. Orentel is the city on the far shore. Votaer is the port on this one.

Lirorn, the Thaw-Land, holds the Rain-Wall and the snowmelt that feeds the lowlands. Its walled town is **Tasain**, in the valley below the Shelf-gate, on the west road south of Thaeloren on the atlas. Larbril is on the far side of that pass. The days between them are not recorded. The toll said at the gate is still Narol's, and the collector of that household says so.

Tengu, Fox, and Selkie live in hearths inside these six powers.

Faith

This continent is the birthplace and the stronghold of the Motherfaith. Its institutions, its pilgrimage, and its authoritative tree-wardens all seat here. The sacred center is contested, not serene.

The heartland heresy is the Watching, whose own name is *Haelthael*. An older Tree-faith the Motherfaith grew over persists in Maiethorn's oldest districts, so the argument lives at the center rather than out on a frontier. They keep the Tree as witness and refuse the Mother-name. The Tree sees, in their telling, and it does not owe you a mother's name. Because the faith is old, it claims to remember what the world believed before the Trees were understood as the Mother's hands. Watchers keep a night at the **Seeing-Ring**, a ring of old stones on a hill in the old Watching country, north-east of Maiethlir. They will not call it a temple.

In the Walking Years, a Maiethorn child Turned by walking to Thaeloren. That inland trip is the Near Mile: days to a couple of weeks. The pilgrimage to Thaeloren still brings people from everywhere. The Ages chapter tells those years.

Strandoren: the Shore-lands

*(stran-DOR-en. Everyday **Strandor**. The name is "the Witnessed Shore," and the docks have worn it smooth.)*

Strandoren is the crossroads of the known world, a continent of harbours. The coastline is so deeply indented with bays, sounds, and peninsulas that no point of it sits far from saltwater. If Maiethorn is the old cathedral heart, Strandoren is the market that grew up facing it: charter-towns, guild halls, banking houses, and quays. The Trees here are mature and many, the reach is high, and the Given are dense, but the faith has been worn light and folded into commerce, until a child's Turning is watched less as a sacrament than as the question of which guild the colour opens. This is where deathless banking, the finance of houses that outlive an ordinary span of years, reaches its full scale, and where Condition-labor buys the world's most advanced public works.

It is free, prosperous, and cool, and nothing here is policed, so your faith, your gift, and your marriage are your own, while everything is priced. The injustice is the market's. A person who cannot pay fades while a rich continent steps politely around them, and liberty is its virtue.

Geography and climate

The indented coast is the fact the whole continent is built on. The shoreline is a run of natural harbours, tidal estuaries, and sheltered sounds. Every notable town is a port, and the sea is the

continent’s highway. This is the densest Selkie hearth in the world, a lot of shoreline rather than a nation of the sea-born.

The Old Crossing lies to the east, the narrow, crowded, ancient water between Strandoren and Maiethorn, and it is the busiest crossing in the world. Orentel faces it. The Hush-rate, the charge left from the peace that ended the fight over who priced this water, is still taken here.

The West Water lies to the west and south, the wider sea toward Heskoren and, far beyond the last capes, the Sundering Isle. Netstrand faces that water. Strandoren’s boldest houses run the frontier trade, and almost none of them have crossed the storm-wall. The people who claim they have crossed are the ones who tell the Yumboe stories.

Inland, fertile lowlands follow **the Chart-run**, the river that feeds the port-cities. The climate is mild and maritime, wet and temperate. Mature grafted Trees stand thick along the wealthy coasts and thin only in the deep interior. Trenledd sits on the stretch of river rich enough to be written into the count. The inland stretches that waited while the coasts were already served are this run.

Reach

The reach is **high**. The grafts are mature and abundant, especially on the coast, the Given are dense, and the three pillars are the machinery a huge commercial society runs on rather than a reverence. Long-Lived notaries remember what a contract said, the Bound close a bargain with a sworn word, and the Far-Voiced are on every dock and in every court. The Struck, people who changed later and alone, are vouched in briskly. An unvouched person is a transaction that cannot clear.

The wood arrived by sea in Cut-years 40–160, wealthy coasts first. A ship outran the work of planting every inland hamlet, and a rich coast could pay the First Seat for a Cutting-leave, the permission to carry a living cutting, while a village on the Near Mile was still waiting its turn. The interior, along the river, was planted later. Clerks of the Fair Hand call that arrival “the carrying,” and they file it as cargo.

Powers

Lestrand, the Ledger Coast (theology low · reach high · governance low) is the premier merchant power. Guild self-rule is carried as far as it will go, deathless-house finance runs at scale, and the Tithe, the upkeep a Condition needs if it is not to fade, is a private market. You buy your green, your novelty, your outlet, and you fade if you cannot pay. This is the richest and coolest corner of the world. Its seat is **Orentel**, on the Salt Quay. The White Note House keeps its office on that quay and keeps the old notes, and it is not crowned there. The guilds govern the city.

Brenledd, the Hearth-League, is many charter-towns under one compact. Each town keeps its own Tree and its own vouching, and the league stays a league of hearths rather than becoming one state.

The throne-city is **Raitin**, a river-city inland, south-west of Orentel on the atlas, where the council sits and the shared notes clear. Six charter-towns sit around it, each with its own hearth. Raitin is where they meet.

Leddvael, the Reckoned Gift, keeps the Fair Hand as the city's own rite. Leaf-Fall here is a festival and a signing-watch. Its port is **Naenor**, down the coast south-west of Orentel and south of Raitin on the atlas. The Book-Hands stamp a signing and recite. They work on this water and keep no hall of their own.

Trenledd, the Worn Count, writes its people on a roll of tax and hazard. The count carries no hymn. Its city is **Lunbra**, on the Chart-run, where the roll is kept and the money is shown.

Netstrand, the Night Shore, faces the open ocean and quotes the trade to Heskoren. Its harbour is **Braetu**. One berth on that quay stays unlit, and no house is attached to it.

Faith

The faith is worn light, and it is not absent. Here it has a rival with real doctrine.

The Fair Hand (*Leddoren*) is a mercantile theology. It does not read a Condition as a gift given, which is the Motherfaith's line. It reads a Condition as a bargain struck. The world, in this telling, is a ledger of deals, and what you became is what you, or your line, bargained for. That is a direct rival to the doctrine of the gift, and it is at home among the Bound. It reframes the Tithe as a term to be serviced, rather than an upkeep to be tended.

The Salt Walk was Strandoren's way to a Turning: a ship across the Old Crossing, then the Near Mile inland. The berth had to be caught in fair weather. A family that missed the last crossing missed the year. That hinge-month is Eolthael.

Heskoren: the Sundered Reach

*(hesk-OR-en. Everyday **Heskorn**. The name is "the Outer Land," a frontier coinage, and the root does not appear in the old liturgy.)*

Heskoren is the edge of the world that the Trees reached last. Maiethorn is old and full of healthy Trees, and Strandoren is rich and tied together by its harbours, but Heskoren is young in wood, thin, and still waiting. It is a broad, rugged, half-settled country where the grafts came recently, take poorly, and sicken often, so that whole districts wait on a Tree that has not taken and on a gift that may never fall.

This is the continent that runs high on the Kept, the children the leaves hugged and left without a colour, and on the Struck, the people who changed later, alone, with no one there to witness it. It also has many UnTurned children, who reached no healthy Tree in the year they turned ten. It is where the Motherfaith burns hottest, because scarcity of the gift answers with more devotion rather than less: pilgrimage, longing, and a theology of waiting. In the Walking Years the same pattern was the rule of distance. The Long Mile from this continent to Thaeloren took weeks or months, and it cost more than most families could spend. Some districts still send children that far, or to a neighbour's Tree. Distance and history did the waiting.

It is warm, poor, and self-reliant: the kindest place in the world to a whole neighbour and the loneliest to an unvouched one, a person no one will stand for. Raiders are seldom what threatens a household. The danger is a lapsing Condition with no infirmary near enough to reach, and a faith that consoles what it cannot cure, a quiet cruelty in which scarcity of the gift shades into a doctrine that the people who went without were unworthy of it.

Geography and climate

The country is rugged and various, with highland spines, upland moors, deep forests, and long river-runs down to a wild coast. The weather is bigger here than on the Old World pair, the winters are harder, and more of the ground is still untamed. These spines are not the Rain-Wall. That range is Maiethorn's, and it does a different job. Tengu ridge-towns and Fox-of-the-Snows hearths sit on the heights, the Fox-of-the-Wilds live in the deeper woods, and Selkie families hold the wild coast. A dense hearth is a family's livelihood on that ground. It is not a state of that Kind.

Settlement clusters wherever a graft has taken. A healthy Tree is the seed of a town, and the map of Heskoren's civilization is a map of its surviving Trees. Between those towns lies wild that no power claims, thinly held marches, and long roads from one Tree to the next. **Harrow's Green** sits above the Rise-water. Downstream is the ford of Brenod, Vaelun, and Ornath. The Seat will not learn those three names, so it keeps calling the place by the water. A day's walk from Vaelun, sometimes two, takes you into the Yield, the country of Vaelhesk, and not back along that stream. There you find the First Bowl, a guest-grove in an old green, not a second Harrow's.

The frontier coast is the east coast. It faces the West Water back toward Strandoren, and that crossing is the lifeline for trade and for new grafts. Eolvaeth is a vale behind this coast. It is a place people walk to in order to wait, not one of the towns where a new graft has just taken.

The slate-shore is the west coast, in Ornled. Sanbreo's beach faces the last capes and, far beyond them, the storm-wall. A hull that wants a beach here comes round the capes. Heskoren's westernmost capes are the closest settled land to the Isle, and the source of many people who have seen the storm-wall even if they never crossed it.

The climate is cooler, wetter, and wilder than Maiethorn or Strandoren. The Leaf-Fall is timed to the solstice everywhere, and here it is a hard-won event of a decade rather than a certainty that comes round every year.

Reach

The reach is **thin**. The grafts are young, scattered, and prone to sickening, and the three pillars are stretched thin, with few Long-Lived to remember a neighbour and few Bound to vouch for one, so citizenship-by-witness is fragile. The unvouched Struck are a constant, aching problem, and the frontier meets that problem with faith where there is little machinery. Kept and Struck are both common, many children stay UnTurned, and the specialist care other continents take for granted is scarce. People here put the thinness down to distance and history. The Ages chapter calls the unfinished carrying the Grafting, and it is this decade's work, not a closed age.

The wood reached Heskoren in Cut-years 200–387, and the work is still incomplete. After Strandoren's coasts, cuttings died on the Long Mile. Each new Turning Tree had to grow up before it could supply the next town, and the queue planted the town that could pay. That gap is a history of distance and of a queue. Vaethorn will preach that the wait means the people were unworthy. The years do not agree. Where the Old Ways hold a planting, the first meal is the host-right. A planting without that meal is a claiming. **Harrow's Green** is the canopy the neighbours can see and use. The Three Hamlets Past the Ford — Brenod, Vaelun, and Ornath — are still walking their children to a Tree this year.

Powers

Vaethorn, the Waiting Lands (theology high · reach low · governance low) is the frontier's touchstone. The faith is ardent, the Trees are thin, and there is almost no state. It is a warm, poor, half-lawless pilgrim edge, and its ruling mood is waiting: waiting for a graft to take, and waiting for a gift that may not come. Its injustice is a guilt, scarcity read as unworthiness. Its seat is **Eolvaeth**, a vale on the pilgrim edge, inland of the coast that faces Strandoren. People walk here to wait. Saelvaeth's march lies on another road.

Ornled, the Outer Ledger, is the secular frontier: the same thin Trees as the waiting country, and no congregation to tend them. Its town is **Sanbreo**, on the slate-shore of Heskoren's west coast, its beach facing the last capes and the storm-wall. It is on the brink of a small city, and the slate is kept there. A hull that wants the beach pays a beach-fee. A hymn is not what the town sells.

Vaelhesk, the Far Yield, keeps the Old Ways' host-rights. The first meal at a planting is the law they keep. The land itself is the seat, and there is no city. The First Bowl is the guest-grove, where a stranger is fed.

Saelvaeth, the Sown Waiting, is the march on the live edge, where new grafts are taking. The march-voice stands at **Natai**, west of Harrow's Green, in the country between Sanbreo and that grove. The days to either are not recorded. **Harrow's Green** is a grove-town in this march's country, and it lies in the power's orbit without being the seat. People Turn under its canopy. The hamlets' ford is the crossing Brenod, Vaelun, and Ornath use.

The four powers are fewer, poorer, and more scattered than the powers of the old continents. Wild country with no power of its own fills the space between them.

Faith

Two faiths stand in tension here, and the friction belongs to the frontier itself.

The **Motherfaith** burns hottest here. It is a theology of longing and pilgrimage that grew up around the scarce gift, around the Trees that sicken and the children who wait.

The Old Ways (*Vaeloren*) are an animist and ancestor faith that predates the grafts. Their own sentence is, "The Mother's reach is new here. We had our own ways before her Trees came." They revere the Struck, and the Taken-In, people the wild took partway into itself and gave back changed, as the land's own children, and they resent the Motherfaith as a latecomer. The grievance has real theological standing.

The Sundering Isle: Kumbaan

*(koom-BAHN, "the hidden home." Sailors say **the Sundering Isle** or **the Sunder**. Outsiders name the barrier. The Yumboes name the hearth.)*

The Sundering Isle sits off the edge of the reach entirely. It is the one land the grafts never reached, and dead wood is not a Tree. Where Heskoren is thin, the Isle is empty of the Trees the rest of the world is built around, and its people become what they are by their own path, outside the Leaf-Fall altogether. Nobody on the mainland knows how that becoming works. The storm-wall has wrecked most of the people who tried the crossing, so that in Maiethorn, Strandoren, and Heskoren alike a Yumboe is a figure from a sailor's tale: pearly-skinned, silver-haired, "the good people from across the drowning sea." Some of the stories are even true.

Kumbaan is an ordinary home, warm and hospitable, that happens to be nearly impossible to reach. The Yumboes are not strange to themselves, only to a world that has never met them. They are a hill-people who love a feast, served by hands you cannot see, and the rest of the world thinks they are a legend.

Geography and climate

The storm-wall is a near-permanent girdle of violent weather, treacherous currents, and reef, and it is the reason the Isle stays sundered. Ships that try the crossing are wrecked, turned back, or simply never heard from again. There may be a season, or a way, in which the wall thins, and nobody knows which, or whether. The wall is not a ferry, and it is not shut for good.

The Paps are the hill country, the Isle's defining landform. The Isle is rolling green hills, honeycombed beneath with the dwellings the Yumboes actually live in. They live within the hills and come out by moonlight. What you see by day is pasture, terrace, and standing-stone, and the life of the place is below.

The climate is mild, wet, and moonlit, a temperate maritime island under the storm-wall's cloud. In the Isle's own tellings it is famous for its bright nights, because the people are nocturnal and moonlight is the light they do the day by.

The Isle is small, the one small continent of the four, an island you can walk and that its own people know in full, which is the opposite of Heskoren's trackless vastness.

You do not book a passage here. A hull out of Netstrand may try, because that coast is where the far crossing gets quoted, and a quote is not a date. Shore-sitters do not swim out and do not keep a rescue boat. If you live, you are on the sand or you are not, a shore-sitter decides that you are alive, the living are walked uphill, and the first night is a guest's night in a hall. At the second meal a table-keeper decides whether you are kin. That belonging holds on the isle, and a mainland watch will not take it as papers. The hall a sailor comes into is **Ndenjoo**, the Feeding Hill. Njunda keeps the table. The sand below that hall is Soonke's stretch, and Soonke is the person who sits it.

Reach

The reach is **near-none**. There is no Tree on the Isle, and there never was a graft, because the grafts never crossed the storm-wall, so the count for this isle in the First Cut's years is never. Sailors tell of pots that went into the water, and those pots were dead wood that never took as Trees. The Yumboes do not Turn at a Tree, and whatever they become, they become otherwise.

People: the Yumboes

The Isle is the homeland of the **Yumboes**, who call themselves *Bakhna Rakhna*, "the good people." They are pearly-white-skinned and silver-haired, they live in the hills, and they keep the moonlit hours. They are famously hospitable to a stranger, whether the stranger was born on the Isle or came off a wreck.

They live beneath the hills, come out by moonlight, and hold great feasts served by hands and feet you can see but bodies you cannot. That service at the table is the image the mainland repeats whenever it tells the isle. They are native to Kumbaan and rare beyond it, because the storm-wall keeps them home, so the few who do cross become the source of every legend the mainland tells. Their tongue and their faith are their own, and they owe the Leaf-Mother nothing.

Faith

The Open Table (*Ndeyaan*) is the Yumboes' own cosmology. It grew in isolation, and it owes nothing to the Motherfaith. Their old accounts bind the good people up with the ancestors and the dead, and the tales told on the mainland call them "the spirits of the dead." They are a living people, with a faith of hill, moon, hospitality, and the staying-kin, which is what they call the ancestors and the dead kept with the living, and they are not ghosts. The Table-Keepers keep the hall, and the Shore-Sitters keep the sand.

The Reckoning of the Year

The Turning keeps time by the sun. The Leaf-Fall, the week when the Trees turn their colour and the year’s ten-year-olds stand under them, falls at a solstice, so the count is also how people know when children Turn, when the great festival falls, and how a world with mechanical clocks and no printing press numbers its days. The sky here is enough to run the rite and to date a debt.

The sky

There is one sun, and on the mainland one moon, on a familiar monthly round that is enough for nights and for tides. Kumbaan keeps twelve named moons and does not owe that mainland round a translation. They are the same sky, counted differently. There are four true seasons, and the winters are real. People stand on one ground. The storm-wall is weather, current, and reef, and it is not a door. The hills at Ndenjoo are hills people live in. A Tree is a tree on this ground, and a person who has become is still standing on this ground. The Low Wall, the Seeing-Ring, and the Dry Stair are older stone on this same ground, not a ruined heaven you can walk into. People reach a place by walking or by sail. What a faith calls a door, people keep as a practice, a meal, a return, or a hymn.

The fact that matters for the rite is the **solstice**, because that is when the Trees turn.

At the High Solstice, the longest day, a Tree’s shadow at noon sits almost on its own roots. Supper happens in light that should have been gone, and Turning-Week is that whole week of light. A storm can soak the crowd. The weather does not extend the week or move it off the sun’s day. On the Rain-Wall the sun clears a shelf it leaves in shadow in the Deep, and the snow-line looks further off than it is. On the Old Crossing the day is long, and a squall in Hale-month, when the land is supposed to be sound and the roads are full, can still take the sail. On Heskoren the same long light falls on a canopy, a bog, or neither, depending on the fold. People argue about what the light did. They are not arguing about a map of stars. Believers say the Mother timed her choosing to the year’s hinge, and skeptics say a tree answers light, but both stand in the same noon and see the same short shadow.

At the Deep Solstice the sun is a guest. It rises late, stays low, and is soon gone, so the work moves to the hearth and the roads shorten to daylight. The mainland moon is the light you actually use, when cloud allows, and the deathless houses finish closing their accounts in this dark. A clear Deep night shows the moon and a great many unnamed lights. People do not farm by those lights. They farm by the months.

At Ndenjoo, on a bright night, the moon is the daylight, and you can carry a bowl across the hill-yard without a lamp. The storm-wall is a darker ring around that brightness, reef-thunder under the cloud at the edge and the hill itself lit. The bright moon washes the small lights out, so a person here does not steer by a field of named stars. They say which moon it is. Njunda, who keeps the hall's table, will say the moon's name. There is no Leaf-Fall in that sky, and no Tree to throw a noon shadow. The long mainland day is a sailor's story here. The bright night is the ordinary one.

The Leaf-Fall happens at the solstice because that is when the Trees turn their colour and choose. The sun reaches its turning, and so do the children. The devout and the skeptics share that calendar.

The Turning Year

The year hinges on **two solstices**, and those two dates are the fixed anchors everyone can see.

The **Deep Solstice**, at midwinter, is the longest night, the low of the year and its turning point. The season around it belongs to the hearth, to endowment-giving, and to the deathless houses' closing of their accounts.

The **High Solstice**, at midsummer, is the longest day, and it is **the Turning**. This is the great one: the solstice when the Trees turn and the year's ten-year-olds meet the Leaf-Fall.

The High Solstice is warm, safe to travel and to gather, and full of light. A child's Turning is a joyous festival, so midsummer suits it, and that same warmth makes the pilgrimage to Thaeloren a summer road.

Turning-Week

The Leaf-Fall is not a single day. It runs through **Turning-Week**, the week that brackets the High Solstice, when the Trees hold their colour and the choosing is done. Every child who has turned ten since the last High Solstice Turns during this week, or misses it. The town gathers, the tree-wardens officiate, and the week is at once the holiest rite and the biggest fair of the year, part christening, part graduation, and part festival. A city nests that witness among the people who already know the child. A village stands as one circle. The year of a person's Turning becomes a lifelong marker of age and of cohort, which is what people mean when they say, "We Turned the same summer."

Months and weeks

The calendar is plainly countable. Twelve months follow the moon's cycle, arranged as four seasons of three months each, hinged on the two solstices, with the two equinoxes between them kept as the lesser markers. The week is the working unit of the guild towns: guild-weeks, market-days, and the mechanical clock-towers of the trade cities striking the hours. There is no printing press, so clergy and

clerks keep the calendars by hand, which is one reason the tree-wardens and the Tallied Crown's clerks hold a quiet power. They are the ones who keep the dates.

The twelve Maiethren months

The liturgical names are Maiethren, the old speech of Maiethorn. Beside them sits the worn common-tongue form, the way Lestrand says the same month. The name a person uses shows the stance they are taking. The table is counted **from the Deep Solstice**, as an astronomical order. The argument about which day opens the year comes after it.

#	Season	Liturgical	Says	Worn / common	Holds
1	Winter	**Nethael** (neth-AYL)	“the night made whole”	*Nethel* / **the Deep**	the **Deep Solstice**
2	Winter	**Brenorn** (bren-ORN)	“hearth-land”	*Brennor* / **Hearth-month**	midwinter hush; deathless account-closing finishes
3	Winter to Spring	**Liren** (LEER-en)	“the thaw’s speech”	*Liren* / **the Thaw**	water runs again
4	Spring	**Saelorn** (SAY-lorn)	“sowing-land”	*Salorn* / **Seed-month**	first green
5	Spring	**Haelren** (HAYL-ren)	“hale-speech”	*Hailren* / **Hale-month**	the land sound
6	Summer	**Eolthael** (ay-ohl-THALE)	“the Tree’s hinge”	*Yoltal* / **Turning-month**	the **High Solstice** · **Turning-Week**
7	Summer	**Vaelorn** (VAY-lorn)	“gift-land”	*Valorn* / **Gift-month**	after-Turning; the colours settle
8	Summer	**Leddorn** (led-ORN)	“reckoning-land”	*Leddorn* / **Ledger-month**	late-summer markets, contract-terms
9	Autumn	**Ornvael** (ORN-vayl)	“the land’s yield”	*Ornvale* / **Harvest**	bringing-in
10	Autumn	**Threnael** (thren-AYL)	“the tally made whole”	*Trennel* / **the Tally**	autumn count
11	Autumn	**Vaethren** (VAYTH-ren)	“the waiting-speech”	*Vaeren* / **the Wait**	longing toward the dark
12	Winter	**Nethorn** (NETH-orn)	“night-land”	*Nethorn* / **Dark-month**	approaching the Deep

When the year starts: three new-year days by stance

The devout and the clergy begin the year at **Eolthael**, because for them the Turning is the hinge that matters. Lestrand and the deathless houses begin it at **Nethael**, because midwinter is when the books

close. In Vaethorn the pulpit follows the clergy, and the fields follow the last summer a local Tree actually managed a fall, so a child “turns the year” from that summer. The twelve names do not change. Any of the three days can open the year, and any of the three can open a dispute about what year a debt belongs to. A debt can be late on one count and early on another, and people will argue which day began it.

Kumbaan’s moons

The Yumboes of Kumbaan do not use the mainland table. They keep **twelve named moons**, a lunar count that owes the solstice nothing:

Yaaba · Ndibi · Sambiyo · Waandi · Lunji · Saalo · Soonke · Nkoosa · Ndenjoo · Yendo · Njili · Mbela

Saalo is a moon, and Seed-month is a mainland month. A mainlander who points up in Saalo and calls it Seed-month has put the moon in the wrong quarter of the year. Njunda will say the moon’s name. The hall will not correct the chart. It corrects the visitor by still being on its own moon when the mainlander’s month has moved on. Soonke, in that list, is one of the twelve moons. The sand below Ndenjoo is also called Soonke, because Soonke is the person who sits that stretch.

How years are numbered

Months name a season inside the year, and **years have no universal number**. The count written on a debt is a theology, the same argument as which day opens the year, turned now toward history. The Ages chapter keeps the full count.

The First Seat and the devout clerks count **Cut-years** from the First Cut, the first time living wood was successfully cut and carried. In the liturgy that count is the *Eoloren-count*. The present year is **Cut-year 387**.

Lestrand and the deathless houses count from a house-founding or from the issue of a note. A clerk of the White Note writes the present year as “the 307th summer of the White Note.” The famous problem of turning one count into the other is the archival **200th**. Cut-year 280 was that house’s 200th summer, and Ledan, the Long-Lived clerk who still writes its quay-desk, asked the First Seat which number a hundred-year loan should carry, because the bank, the borrower’s town, and the Seat were not counting the same summer. The house still converts its years the way that query did. The Ages chapter keeps the letter.

Threnmaieth writes the Cut-years and also a crown-count taken from the Two Papers. The papers fall in Cut-year 67, and the present is **Crown-year 320**.

Vaethorn counts from the year the local graft took. People there say, “the year our graft took,” which is the same local-fall logic as the way they start the year.

The Watching refuse the Cut-count entirely. Kumbaan keeps its moons and owes the ages nothing.

The Awakening Tree is old beyond reliable dating. There is no year the world began, and no year she appeared.

How it is lived along the gradient

One sun, one moon, and the two solstices make the count the same sky on the mainland. People live it differently as the wood thins, from a country where Turning-Week is an institution to the one country that has no Trees.

On **Maiethorn**, where the reach is full, Turning-Week is a near-certainty and a vast institution. The Trees stand dense and healthy, the core runs higher on the Given than the world as a whole, and the pilgrimage to Thaeloren crests at the High Solstice. When that walk was required, it was the Walking Years. The Near Mile is the inland trip on Maiethorn, days to a couple of weeks. The Ages chapter tells those years.

On **Strandoren**, where the reach is high, the solstice is kept, and it is as much a commercial hinge as a sacred one. The fairs, the contract-terms, and the deathless houses’ own reckoning all turn on it. The Salt Walk was the berth that made Eolthael. Miss the last crossing, and you missed the year.

On **Heskoren**, where the reach is thin, Turning-Week is a hard-won event of a decade. A child may travel days to the nearest Turning Tree, or wait years for a graft to take. The solstice still arrives, and the gift may not fall. Whole districts are still on the Long Mile, weeks or months to a Tree that can Turn them.

On **Kumbaan**, where there is no reach, the Yumboes keep the moon and not the solstice. Their reckoning is nocturnal and lunar, and it owes the Trees nothing, because they have none. They are the one people in the world whose calendar has no Leaf-Fall in it. A mainlander who lines a moon up with a Maiethren month is wrong in the same direction every time, and the hall will not correct the chart.

What the year feels like

The year is kept by stance and argued by faith, and the two do different work. A place sets how long people talk and what they repeat. A person’s faith sets which words they will not say. That is why someone of the Watching can eat on a dock, and why a follower of the Fair Hand can stand in a pious square. Each street chooses the words. Each street also keeps one habit, and the people who keep it will not explain it.

In a devout town, and in any square that puts the name back when a sentence dropped it, the year people feel begins in Eolthael, whatever a clerk's tablet started earlier. On an ordinary market morning, people carrying baskets stop when a tree-warden steps onto the Tree's roots, and they start again when the warden steps off. Someone of the Watching will not say "Maieth," and will still wait. The wood is the wood. Someone of the Fair Hand, passing through, will not wait, and the square notices without stopping them. In Maiethlir a clerk may be copying a slate of bells in the same hour, and the hymn is still first when Rithim, the Speaker, can make it first. The Core-thaw runs louder the week before Leaf-Fall than it did in Hale-month. Maiethlir will not say why.

On a dock, and on any quay that lets the *th* go, the year the account books feel begins at the Deep Solstice, when the notes are closed. Turning-month is a fair laid on top of that closing, and it is not the start of the quay's own count. All year, a **clear** is a no-colour, a child the Tree hugged and gave no Condition, and the quay says the word the way it says a berth that just opened. A crane-crew will hire a clear. Nobody on this water calls a clear a sadness. Even a house that never kept a book will count coins into the other person's hand, not onto the barrel, when the one they owe is watching. A book-hand calls that worship. The gang calls it how you fail to start a fight. They only collide when a child in the tenth year is present. In Eolthael, salt crusts the roots of the Trees, and on Orentel's rise the tide does not reach the salt. Orentel will not say why.

In a waiting town, and in any town whose sentence does not close the week, people date a child from the last summer the local wood actually spoke. The pulpit may say Eolthael. The field says the last real fall. They do not spend the good flour on a promise that the wood will speak again. A guest gets the common pot. If the wood spoke last year, Turning-Week gets the better loaf. If it did not, the week gets the pot too. Some houses walk the old doors at a flood or at the ice and leave food, and they do not call that a second Turning. A wet leaf lies on the spring, or too many, or none. Eolvaeth will not say why. At Harrow's Green, in a year when the wood will speak, people say "the wood" first, and the neighbour after that. If their own wood will not speak, the sentence in the street is "Not this week," and they name the neighbour's town when they have to send the children on.

At Ndenjoo the year is moons. Noon is when the hall is asleep, so a tool you need at noon waits, or you stay quiet enough that the sleepers stay asleep. A mainlander who lines a moon up with a Maiethren month is wrong in the same direction every time, and the hall will not correct the chart. On one night of the moon sailors call Yoltal, the hall eats the heel of the loaf first. Every other night the heel is last, or it goes to the goats. The valley says the hands like the crust when the mainland is loud. Njunda will not correct that, and will not say it is the reason. They will not say why. A guest who asks is given more bread.

Turning-Week, as a town spends it, is baskets, bells, a berth, and a loaf. The leaf-colours, and the questions a warden gets asked, belong to the rite at the Tree.

In Maiethlir the stalls go up under the town Tree on the first morning, and the hearths stand to the bell in the morning, again in the afternoon, and again at eve. The public slate names the street and the hour. The colour a child received stays off that slate. Rithim speaks the word of the fall aloud even when the square already knows the common fall, and the next errand waits until the people who stood have stepped off the root. A Watcher household stands with their child and says their own line, quietly, and Maieth is not in it. A follower of the Fair Hand stands at the edge with a book held shut. Before the fair eats, someone in from the road may set a bowl at the root and go back to a stall. The square lets the bowl sit. Setting it down is not the standing.

On Orentel's quay they say "the fall" on the crane, and they call the wood Tallo, though a charter that is open still carries the long name. The standings follow the quay-gang, the people who already know the child, and they happen at the tide that gang can spare. A clear gets the same shout the quay uses when a berth opens. Salt crusts the roots, and the quay will not explain it. In the same days the book-hands settle a year's term where the gang can see. If a Bound's oath-day falls in the week, the oath is recited and marked, and the warden still speaks. The quay calls the Mother "the old rite," and it does not put the *th* back into the word to be polite.

In Eolvaeth the town fills before the week arrives. In Hale-month the camp-streets double, and when Eolthael comes the town faces the canopy it has, which some years speaks and some years does not. If the wood will call a fall, the town stands small and the gift-hall pot is open. A hug is not dressed as a prize, and a sermon may still pity the person who received one. The pot does not wait for the sermon to finish. If the wood will not speak, people in the street say "Not this week," and a cohort may be sent toward a luckier Tree. The spring has a wet leaf, or too many, or none, and the town will not explain it. In those same days some houses walk the old doors, leave food, and do not ask for a colour.

The hill on Kumbaan keeps its moons through the week the mainland calls Turning-Week, so no child is stood up and no one asks for a colour. A guest who brought a tenth-year is fed, and nobody offers the path to a Tree, because there is no Tree in the valley. The loaf comes heel-first, and they will not explain the heel. The shore does not come up the path to make a rite, and the sand stays the sand.

Climate, Ecology, and Travel

This chapter names the water and the stone, says how a week feels in each band of weather, and says how long a walk takes. Say the everyday name. A devout speaker keeps the *th* in the land-names around the water. On a dock, that *th* wears off. Clerks enjoy the long old form. Dates here are in Cut-years, counted from the First Cut, the first time living wood was successfully cut and carried. The Ages chapter keeps that count.

The year is familiar enough to farm by and strange enough to argue over. Maiethorn and Strandoren, the Old World pair, keep four seasons and the twelve shared month-names. The Rain-Wall, the range down the middle of Maiethorn, can make that same month a flood on one face and a dry well on the other. Heskoren gets a shorter kindness between frosts. Kumbaan keeps its own moons and lives inside the storm-wall. A month tells people what work should be possible. A season tells them what the land actually did. A late frost can put winter into Seed-month, and three clear weeks can put the harvest into Ledger-month. Clerks still date the note by the month. Farmers date the year by what survived.

Named water, range, and rivers

Everyday	What it is	Who says something else
the Old Crossing	the busy water between Maiethorn and Strandoren, narrow enough to be one argument and old enough to be the oldest trade route	Lestrand: *the crossing.* Vaethorn: *the waiting-water.* Sailors: *the Crossing.* Threnmaieth wants the name on a roll.
the West Water	the wider sea between Strandoren and Heskoren	already the Night Shore's word for this sea. The Hush's west-water clause lives on it.
the Rain-Wall	Maiethorn's central range, wet on one side and dry on the other	Lirorn-folk: *the Thaw-Wall.* Clerks: *the Divide.*
the Noon Pass	the old high road over the Rain-Wall. It lost its stone in Cut-year 233.	the courier's *noon-pass.* The water-line is still on the stone.
the Shelf-gate	the pass Narol of the Pass took after the Break, when the old high road was no longer the way	Threnmaieth named it *the new one.* Lirorn charges **Break-rate.**
the Core-thaw	the river Maiethlir sits on	clerks file the rise as *snowmelt.* Watchers will not.
the Well-wash	seasonal water in the Rain-Shadow, east of the range	dry most years; a bad thaw leaves silt
the Rise-water	the stream from Harrow's Green down to the hamlets' ford	the Seat still says *the ford*
the Chart-run	Strandoren's interior river, running out to Orentel's estuary	Lestrand files it as inland tickets that have reached salt

the Old Crossing. This is the oldest trade route in the world. It is narrow enough that a fair-weather hull makes it in a handful of days, and busy enough that a late storm in Hale-month, when the land is supposed to be sound, can hold a family past Turning-Week. Miss that week, and the child stays UnTurned, having reached no Tree in the year they turned ten. The Hinge Shore is Maiethorn's face on this water. Orentel is Strandoren's face. The Salt Walk, the old way a Shore-lands child reached a Turning, was this water first and the Near Mile inland after that, the walk on Maiethorn to Thaeloren.

People call Maiethorn and Strandoren the Old World pair because the water is old and close, and because it made the two continents into one argument. They do not call the water “inner.” What happened on it has dates. The Grey Summer, in Cut-year 171, was a fever that tied the quays. It began as a cough in packed holds, it killed across the Given, the Struck, and the Kept, and it left grafts unwatered when their tenders fell. It was a fever. The Stilled are people whose upkeep is exertion, and the Grey they work back out is the stillness that fills the body when the work stops. The Grey Summer was neither that stillness nor a punishment laid on anyone’s Condition. The Hinge Hush, in Cut-year 304, is the peace still charged as the **Hush-rate**. From Cut-year 299 to 304 the two shores fought over who set the price. The hush is a rate, a clause for the far water, and a refusal to name a winner.

the West Water. This sea is wider than the Crossing. It is the water-leg of the Long Mile, the long way on from Strandoren toward a Tree on Heskoren, and that road takes weeks. A pot of living cuttings has a harder berth here than on the Old Crossing. Netstrand quotes the far crossing on this water, and Braetu is the harbour where that quote is written. Heskoren’s frontier coast, its east coast, faces the same sea back toward Strandoren. Heskoren’s west coast, the slate-shore, faces the last capes, and beyond them the storm-wall.

The Hush’s west-water clause lives on this sea, and it says who may do what once a hull leaves the Crossing. Netstrand quotes the far crossing. Saelvaeth may take a pot of cuttings without a waiting-due, the charge Vaethorn would have written before the wood could move, while Vaethorn may bless a landing and may not levy it, and Ornled collects a beach-fee at Sanbreo when a hull wants the beach. Vaelhesk is not on the clause, because a first meal set for a guest is not a landing-due. Kumbaan is not on this water either. Sailors tell of a pot that went into the storm and was wrecked, and no graft took. No house on this water sells a passage to the isle.

the Rain-Wall. This is a highland spine down the middle of Maiethorn. Weather on the west face is wet and runs through four seasons. The leeward east is the Rain-Shadow, which is why Saelthael sows at wells, and why Lirorn can levy a thaw as if the melt were a tax. Fox-of-the-Snows and Tengu hearths sit densest on the high snow. That is terrain, families on the ground the weather made, not a flag and not a nation of one born people. Heskoren’s highland spines are a different weather. They are not this range.

Two passes cross the spine. The **Noon Pass** is the old high road. In the Thaw-Break of Cut-year 233 a water-line was left over its ribbon-notch, and the road up to the pass was gone for two summers. Children still rub that line for luck, and ridge-folk rub it because the water was real. The toll does not tell a lowlander which rubbing is the prayer. The **Shelf-gate** is the road that was left once the old stone sat under that line. Narol of the Pass took the thaw-toll when the old holder’s stone was under the water, and Narol is dead, so the household that inherited the toll still levies it. Threnmaieth wanted the new pass counted, and Lirorn charged them for the water anyway. The Shelf-gate is the road people use now.

Four rivers. The **Core-thaw** is snowmelt off the Rain-Wall's west face, running toward the Old Crossing. Maiethlir sat down where the water had slowed enough to hold a Turning Tree, a day's living-earth from the Motherwood, which is as far as a cutting could be carried in a day and still be planted. The town is on the river road, not on Orenbren's Near Mile. Clerks file the spring rise as snowmelt. The river runs louder the week before Leaf-Fall, and Maiethlir is where that louder week is known. Watchers do not file it. Rithim, the Speaker, raises their voice over the water, and the town will not say why the week is louder. In a high Liren, when the thaw is already up, the lodging-road meets a near branch of the same river. The line "Eolthael, the summer the ford ran high" is this water in a bad year, and it is not a fifth river. Below Maiethlir the same water is the Down-Bank, the days a traveller is already going to spend on the way to the Hinge Shore. It is not a second river. In the Thaw-Break the Core-thaw took a month of melt in seven days.

The **Well-wash** is a seasonal run east of the range. In a kind Liren it is a river, and in a cruel one it is a line of silt. Towns cluster at wells because this water cannot be a civic certainty. **Larbril** is where the west road meets that wash, short of the pass. **Ornsael** drinks a well, not the wash, farther into the dry, with open country between it and Larbril, and the wash is why the well matters. The town sits inland. Between a river-week and a silt-week, the day-wash shows for an afternoon, water enough to look like a camp. A traveller from the core sees a silver in the dust and treats it as a ford, and by morning it is a stain. Saelthael already knows this, which is why the towns sit at wells. Ornsael's problem is a well dropping, not that shine. The Dry Stair climbs above a different well-town, and it is not a river-shrine. Sometimes a bright thread of water runs uphill of the last rain, lasts an hour, and is gone. Well-keepers say the rock remembers a wet year, and travellers from the core say the map is wrong. Nobody on the bank will say which of those is true.

The **Rise-water** is a low stream off Harrow's rise. Downstream it becomes the hamlets' ford, the crossing of Brenod, Vaelun, and Ornath. The Seat still says *the ford*, because the Seat will not learn those three names. In clear weather the hamlets can see Harrow's canopy from the water, a dark on the far slope. There is no stone on the waiting side, and the cup still goes on the ford-rock. **Natai**, the march-town, stands on other ground, west of Harrow's Green, between Sanbreo and that grove, and not on this ford.

The **Chart-run** is Strandoren's interior river-plain, running out to Orentel's estuary. The coasts took their Trees by sea. The inland country waited on a cart and on this river together. Lunbra sits on the wealthy stretch, and that is where the roll is kept. Food sold on the Salt Quay comes from this plain, from the catch of the Crossing, and from whatever the hinge pays to have brought across.

Climate bands

A week in each band feels like this. Choose the band, read the month, and then let the weather turn once. A whole week of identical weather should feel notable. Weather is usually an inconvenience

before it is a danger: the queue at the dry shed, the cart sharing a rock, the neighbour whose cistern failed. Turning-Week stays the week around the High Solstice. A storm, a fever, a blocked pass, or a late hull does not move it.

Band	Where	Weather
Crossing-shore	both faces of the Old Crossing	mild, wet-temperate; a Hale-month storm can decide a Salt Walk
Mother-core	Maiethorn west of the Rain-Wall	four true seasons in old sacred country; winters that make the High Solstice mean something
Rain-Wall / Thaw-Wall	Lirorn	snow, shelves, and a thaw the towns keep as a civic year
Rain-Shadow	Saelthael, east of the range	dry hills, wells, and either the Well-wash or nothing
Shore-lands	Strandoren coasts and the Chart-run	maritime, indented, the sea used as the highway
Night Shore	Netstrand	open ocean, west-weather, watches kept for hulls that do not arrive
Sundered upland	Heskoren	cooler, wilder, harder winters; settled country is a map of the Trees that survived
Storm-wall / Kumbaan	the Sundering Isle	mild and wet under cloud, bright nights, and the wall itself is the climate

On the Crossing-shore the week opens under low cloud and mild rain, and the turn is a clear tide-day or a fast squall, which in Hale-month is the squall. Berths close before the roads do, so a Salt Walk family can lose Turning-Week without ever being far inland. The Mother-core opens on weather you would know as four seasons, and the turn is a river rising, a bright drying wind, or a cold night that does not belong to its month. Mills keep moving, while the grafts, the orchards, and the crowded greens all want the same drink.

The Rain-Wall opens with snow on the high shelves and melt or cold rain below, and the turn locks the path or unlocks all of it at once. In Liren the Shelf-gate may already be a lake before a traveller reaches the toll. The Rain-Shadow opens clear, cool, and dusty, and the turn is a hard shower, a blow of dust, or no change at all, so the wells fail before the roads do. The Well-wash may run for a day and still leave no drink a town can count on.

The Shore-lands open in salt mist and a working tide, and the turn is sun enough to unload, estuary rain enough to flood, or a gale along the coast. A leaf-lot, the rented plot of living green a stone town keeps for people who have to rest among plants, can be burned by brine and drenched by fresh water in the same month. The Night Shore opens on an open-ocean wind, and the front arrives as hard rain, a sudden lull, and then a second wind, until missing hulls become a kind of local weather. A Far-Voiced warning, from a person who has to put the feeling of the voice somewhere, can cross when the hull cannot.

The Sundered upland opens as cold rain below, sleet on the ridges, and sun in one vale while the next is still in cloud, so a healthy pocket can be bringing in a harvest while the next valley loses its roof, its road, or its young graft. On Kumbaan the inside of the island is mild and wet under cloud, and the edge is reef-thunder. The turn is a bright night within the wall, or a squall that reaches inland as steady rain. The crossing remains a chance, and it is never a timetable.

Maiethorn

Maiethorn holds four of the eight bands, and a traveller can go from salt drizzle to old forest, cross a pass that floods like a lake, and reach a well-town measuring dust, without leaving the Motherland. The deep difference is water. Towns in the core drain it, Lirorn waits to levy the thaw the range lets go, Ornsael divides what the wells hold, and every living graft wants a share.

West of the Rain-Wall the country keeps four true seasons, and the winters are real, which is why the High Solstice means something. A core week is two wet days, one bright break, and then a river on the rise. Grafts take in the old sacred country and in the Motherwood because generations have built drains, cistern turns, and a rule about keeping animals off the roots. The core’s food is bread, peas, cabbage, and orchard fruit, with pork or river fish when the week allows. In the core, the greens a Tithe asks for, the living plants a Taken-In person has to keep near, are commons and garden lots. Stilled infirmaries and Returned plague-work cluster in the rich core because that is where the chairs and the endowments are. The Mill-hold is the caution in that plenty: the mill-race stayed full, and the town’s Tree stood in the overflow. Stored grain did not water it.

On the range, last year’s snow is this year’s civic year. A Wall week freezes at night and melts by noon. Lirorn levies the thaw, the pass, and the high road, because the weather has made that road scarce. A thaw-week can turn the Shelf-gate into a lake. The Thaw-Break was that arrangement failing at once, a month of melt in seven days, and the west road stayed closed for two summers. People still remember which notch holds the water-line. The lower shelves eat barley, roots, and hard cheese. Hay is wealth, because the animals of winter eat the summer that was cut.

East of the Wall the week is dry wind until one hard shower fails to fill the well. The food is millet or barley, lentils, onions, and goat cheese if the herd came in. A Taken-In Tithe’s living green is cheap on

a terrace and expensive if the well is dropping, because the same bucket is the food, the plants, and the Tree's drink. Two-Bodied people, who have another self in a real animal body, range the dry hills at night. Returned work sits downwind of the drink. People on the pass tell of a travelling stiller, a Stilled person whose upkeep is hard use of the body and who can hold a wound. The dry country has no stillers' college. At Ornsael the well-rope is knotted at last year's water-line, and this year's knot is wet even when the water stands below it. Ornsael will not say why.

On the Old Crossing face the weather is the berth. The week is mild rain, with a squall in Hale-month that decides a Salt Walk. Far-Voiced warnings are how a dock hears weather it cannot yet see. They do not steer the ship. Selkie hearths are common on the quays. The Hinge Shore says what the hull is carrying before anyone across the water prices it. The food on that shore is herring, mussels, and rye bread.

Strandoren

Strandoren is maritime country. A week can begin with three working tides, lose two days to fog, and end with every crane tied down. The sea softens the cold and refuses to be predicted. Hard frost is less reliable here than in Maiethorn's core, which makes the winter wet rather than kind: rot, mud, smoke, and bad bedding do more harm than deep snow. People eat rye or wheat bread, beans, cabbage, apples, and eel or herring, with mussels and cockles when the tide is safe, and oat pottage when the fleet stays tied.

The coasts received the wood first. The Chart-run carried it inland, and the river also carries another district's weather downstream, so a quay can flood under a clear local sky. Food on the Salt Quay is this plain, the Crossing's catch, and whatever the hinge pays to bring across. Tithe-provision here is a market. You buy a hall-hour, a lot-night, a novelty page. The Taken-In who live in the stone cities are a working minority on lots, orchards, and river-gardens. They work at a polite distance, and the lots are in use. Brine in a lot is a failure of that provision. A west wind lays salt on leaves that were green at dawn, a rise on the Chart-run or a squall off the Crossing soaks those same leaves with fresh water, and a Taken-In person resting in the lot feels the scald and the rot as one week while the granary uphill still has bread. That split is the estuary's weather. Guilds count the flood, because a flood has a witness, and the salt-burn is quieter and often the one that takes the green. Sometimes a lot salts on a windless morning, when the estuary is flat and nobody filed a gale. The tender washes the leaves and will not say where the salt was in the air.

Separate from that lot, salt lies on the roots of mature coastal Trees above any storm line. Orentel's Tree on the rise is the case people know, on ground the tide does not reach. Tenders wash the roots with fresh water, the factors file the salt below the rise and decline to file this, and Orentel will not say why.

The Night Shore watches for hulls that do not arrive. A west-weather week begins as a long low swell, spends a false lull arguing whether anyone should sail, and finishes in a second wind that can break a berth or bring in wreckage with no crew in it. Chart-crews and the rightful owners meet at whatever the water brought. Prestige and necessity use the same water and do not pay the same rate.

A Hale-month storm on the Old Crossing can turn a Salt Walk into a missed year. Denlad is the inlet about a day's sail short of Orentel's estuary, a village with its own Tree on a low rise, and you can miss the week from there without ever seeing a crane. These spans are fair weather. A storm rewrites them. A later fever is not a second Grey Summer. People say "Grey" when they are frightened, and a clerk decides whether the comparison changes a rate.

Heskoren

Heskoren is one broad band with several weathers inside it: cool coast, rough moor, wooded vale, high spine, and long river country. Winters run harder than on the Old World pair, and the kind season between frosts is shorter. A clear day is when the roofs, the hay, the carts, the witnesses, and the people tending a graft all try to move at once. A usual week is cold rain in a vale, sleet on a ridge, one brilliant dry day, and then a hard frost. On the west coast a long swell can keep the next hull outside while the shore spends those clear hours. The food is oat mash, rye bread, peas, cabbage, turnips, hard cheese, and smoked fish, with berries and nuts when the season allows. A first-meal bread at the First Bowl is a little sour.

The continent is not empty wilderness. It is worked pockets around surviving Trees, and older hearths that predate them, with country between that is too wet, too steep, too cold, or simply too far to hold densely. Young grafts face wind, thin soil, and a queue written in the Motherwood. A Taken-In person's upkeep is the living land itself, until a bad winter, a quarantine, or a dead planting cuts them off from it. Two-Bodied people range, scout, and herd, and a town can start treating a family's range as if it were public stock. Returned work the far sheds, the flood, and the dead, and a useful danger is not automatically the Purpose they chose. Stilled medicine is one tired stiller, or a rope. The high country is not Maiethorn's Rain-Wall. It has no thaw-levy and no Shelf-gate. Tengu and Fox-of-the-Snows hearths are denser on the heights because of the ground and the history, and a mixed hearth uses the same winter stores.

On a clear day a canopy shows on the next ridge, and the road does not. Someone says the wood spoke this week. Someone else says the colour is last year's leaves. Neither of them has walked it. Tunral is that kind of gap, a kitchen and a mile-post coastward of Harrow's Green, about a week along a road with no sight of the canopy. Huval, who keeps the post, sets a bowl outside at dusk on the side away from Harrow's, and will not say why. The bowl is not a first meal, and it is not a shrine. Harrow's Green is what the far green is, on the weeks the road allows. The hamlets are the rare case where the canopy is a sightline and a ford, not a rumour. On some clear days the green is there at dawn and gone

by noon, with no cloud. Travellers blame haze, ridge-folk do not bother to blame it, and nobody measures it.

The live front is Saelvaeth’s luck, which is why Harrow’s Green is the grove the neighbours can see, with the Rise-water running from that rise down to the hamlets’ ford. Natai, the march-town, stands west of the grove between Sanbreo and Harrow’s, on its own ground, and the days between them are not recorded. Harrow’s square is the grove-town’s own ground, so a complaint can name Natai while the canopy the hamlets can see is still Harrow’s. Vaethorn waits in a vale with no view of that canopy, and the people there do not want the view. Ornled has the same thin wood and keeps no congregation, with the slate kept at Sanbreo on the west-coast slate-shore. Vaelhesk is old greens, the land is the seat, and there is no city on it. Between mile-shrines the next stone is a rumour, though empty road-houses still make a bed for the people who did not go home.

After the first hard snow around some young Trees, a narrow melt runs back along the road by which the graft first arrived. It can lie on the shaded side while the open square stays white. People call it the old-road melt only when they need to give directions. Packed earth, a buried stone, or a tender’s morning walk can account for any one example. No account covers enough of them to end the conversation. The melt does not point toward the next town, and it does not promise a Tree will take there.

Kumbaan

Kumbaan is mild, wet, and cloudy, and it turns bright by night when the storm-wall opens a view of the moon. The wall is the wind, the current, the reef, and the surf working together at the edge of the island. It is not weather happening somewhere past the last beach. Inside, the same weather arrives diminished and still persistent: cloud, rain, salt carried farther inland than a guest expects, and a low thunder that can keep going under a hill sky that looks calm. A week is mild rain under low cloud, one bright moonlit night, reef-thunder with no local wind, and then a squall that closes the shallows and soaks the peat. People eat barley broth, oats, beans, peas, cabbage, turnips, onions, and goat milk or cheese. The shore adds mussels, limpets, fish, and seaweed, with berries and nuts in season. Fuel is peat, and what a wreck sometimes gives the hall.

There is no Tree here, and no graft crossed. A slip planted on the isle would die. Dead wood never became a Tree. A wrecked mainland pot is rot, fuel if anyone will burn it, and the discomfort of knowing why it was carried. Islanders date a rain, a birth, a debt, or a second sitting by the moon, and they describe the season by its work: ditches full, terraces open, shallows closed, peat drying, goats brought in. A mainlander can call a week springlike and be understood. They cannot convert the calendar by picking whichever mainland month has similar rain.

The hills, which people call the Paps, carry pasture and terrace-gardens on the surface. Halls, stores, and the rooms where people sleep through the day lie under the turf. Rain runs down every mistake in a terrace wall. Goats are common, and they undo a repair the moment it is finished. Large draught animals are uncommon on ground this steep. People, goats, small carts on the good paths, and unseen hands carry most of the loads. Those hands can hold a basket, lift a light net, fetch a line, gather limpets within reach, and bring the wet baskets in before the rain. They do not conjure food, they do not harvest a valley at once, they do not swim the wall, and they do not make a lean year generous by themselves. A great table after a poor harvest means the hearths contributed, the stores were opened, or the meal is thinner than the serving makes it look.

There is no ferry, and no ticket you can buy. Shore-sitters know a moon when the wall thins, the wreck-moons and the weeks after a rumour of a crossing, and that knowledge is weather. Nobody sells it as a sailing date. A quiet shore does not mean the outer reef is passable, and a violent night can still put a living wreck on the sand. Most ships wreck, turn back, or are never heard from again. Shore-sitters do not swim out, and they do not keep a rescue boat. They decide whether you are alive after the sea has already decided.

If you live, the landing goes in this order, and it does not skip. You are on the sand, or you are not, and a wreck that never makes the beach has not landed. A shore-sitter decides whether you are alive. The living get water and a blanket, and they are not asked their Kind or their colour. The dead go above the tide. The living are walked uphill, and the first night you spend as a guest begins at a hall, not on the sand. At the second meal a table-keeper decides whether you are kin, and the guest is told, “no one is a stranger twice.” That belonging holds on the isle. It does not travel back to a mainland watch. Before you sail, a Strandoren quay still wants a road-word, the name of someone at your last hearth who will stand for you. On the isle the watch’s three questions, your name, your last hearth, and who stands for you, are not asked.

The way back is the same wall, and the sitters do not send anyone home. You wait for a thinning, or you take a hull that will try. A Yumboe who wants off the isle sits the same sand from the other want. If you eat, eat what is set in front of you, and sleep the day if you can. Do not plant a Tree, do not file the hill in a clerk’s book, and do not swim the wall. Do not repeat “no one is a stranger twice” at home as a saying you can spend. It is said to a guest at the table, and it is not a pass. Guest-right on the isle is the table, not a token you carry home to show a watch.

The hall a sailor comes into is Ndenjoo, which sailors call the Feeding Hill. Njunda keeps the table. The sand on that stretch is called Soonke, and Soonke is the person who sits it. The lamp on the path does not call ships.

On some nights later remembered as a thinning, peat smoke from the hill vents lies seaward while the grass and the rain move inland. Shore-sitters notice it after the wreck or the sail. They do not use it to

call one beforehand. A bad vent or a crossed gust can explain the smoke for any single hall. The smoke stays an observation, and it is not a crossing calendar.

Travel times

The unit is a **day's walk**, the interval a mile-shrine on the old roads already marks. A horse takes the same road and spares the blisters. A ship takes the water those walks already name. It does not invent a different country.

Walk	What it was	Fair-weather band
Near Mile	Maiethorn inland to Thaeloren	**3–12 days** (a couple of weeks at the long end)
Salt Walk	Old Crossing, then the Near Mile	**3–5 days' sail** plus the inland days; typically **1–3 weeks**
Long Mile	West Water, then Heskoren inland	**weeks to months**; figure **6–12 weeks** for a coast-to-grove attempt

Kumbaan is not on that table. No walk has crossed the storm-wall.

From	To	How	Fair weather
Thaeloren	Rothallo (people still say the Inner Close)	walk	**1 day**
Thaeloren	Maiethlir	river road along the Core-thaw	**1–2 days**
Thaeloren	the Third Hearth	Near Mile	**3 days**
Third Hearth	Brenthael	Near Mile	**1 day** further out
Brenthael	the Mill-hold	Near Mile	**2 days** further out (Raillath, the ordinary halt, sits in this stretch, a day from each)
Brenthael	Raillath	Near Mile	**1 day** further out
Raillath	the Mill-hold	Near Mile	**1 day** further out
Near Mile, a day short of the Third Hearth	Nelath	the spur, and then it stops	**1 day**
Thaeloren	the Low Wall	off the present Mile	**1–2 days** (not inside the Close)
Thaeloren	Hinge Shore quays (Votaer is the port)	Core-thaw and the west-road	**8–12 days**
Thaeloren	Ornsael	west-road over the Shelf-gate, or the Noon Pass if you want the water-line	**10–14 days**
Hinge Shore quay	Orentel	Old Crossing	**3–5 days' sail**
Orentel	Denlad	a side inlet toward the Hinge Shore, short of the estuary	**about 1 day's sail**
Orentel	Lunbra	Chart-run	**4–8 days**
Orentel	Braetu	coasting, to the Night Shore	**8–14 days**

From	To	How	Fair weather
Braetu	Heskoren frontier coast	West Water	**2–4 weeks**
Heskoren coast	Eolvaeth	inland vale	**1–2 weeks**
Eolvaeth	Harrow’s Green	live-front roads	**2–3 weeks** (Eolvaeth cannot see Harrow’s, and does not want to)
Harrow’s Green	Tunral	live-front road, coastward, no sight of the canopy	**about a week**
Harrow’s Green	the Three Hamlets Past the Ford	the Rise-water	**hours to 1 day** (the canopy is a dark on the far slope)
Harrow’s Green	Natai	west, between Harrow’s Green and Sanbreo; not on the ford	**not recorded**
Vaelun	the First Bowl	vale track into the Yield, away from Harrow’s	**1–2 days**
Maiethlir	Seinbrun	off the Down-Bank; north of Maiethlir on the atlas	**more than 1 day** (the first day below the Down Gate does not reach it); the rest is **not recorded**
Thaeloren	Tasain	the west road, below the Shelf-gate; south of Thaeloren on the atlas	**not recorded**
Tasain	Larbril	the west road over the Shelf-gate; Larbril is east of the Rain-Wall, on the dry side, where the road meets the Well-wash	**not recorded**
Maiethlir	the Seeing-Ring	a hill in the old Watching country, north-east of Maiethlir; the atlas sheets do not mark it	**not recorded**; the climb up the hill takes a morning
Orentel	Raitin	the road inland; south-west of Orentel on the atlas	**not recorded**

From	To	How	Fair weather
Orentel	Naenor	coasting; south-west of Orentel and south of Raitin on the atlas	**not recorded**
Any mainland quay	Kumbaan	storm-wall	**not a timetable**

Where a row says **not recorded**, the seat gives a place and a direction and does not give a time. The directions come from the atlas sheets. Larbril lies on the dry-side road toward Ornsael, short of the pass, and the counted days in the table are the days to the well, not a separate count for Larbril. Raillath is a halt, a few hearths and a shrine with water, and it is not Nelath. Nelath is the spur where the walk stops.

A Hale-month storm on the Old Crossing can turn a Salt Walk into a missed year. A thaw-week on the Rain-Wall can turn the Shelf-gate into a lake, and the Thaw-Break closed roads for two summers. The table is weather, not a promise.

The Closed Seat was an origin-gate on the grove. Hildal’s Retreat shut its walls one day’s walk from the Motherwood, inside Orenbren’s lodging-country, and that city is Rothallo, which people still call the Inner Close. The book kept there is the Walled Book, and it belongs to the grove’s country, not to the shore. Fifteen powers stand. Rothallo sits inside Orenbren as one of them, and it is not a sixteenth. The Hinge Shore is the coast of a different war. Its peace is the Hinge Hush, still charged as the Hush-rate. Rothallo’s wall and the Hinge Shore’s quay keep their own names.

What a house keeps in the field

An ox ploughs, hauls timber, and pulls a cart. The herds are on the core farms, the Chart-run plain, and the broad vales of Heskoren. A breeding animal is worth more to a house than a week’s wages, so people are more afraid of losing the ox than of the ox itself. The ox will not take a ford when the water is over the axle, and then it stops, so a driver who knows the animal waits, or finds the shallow, or unloads. Whipping it through is how a house loses the season. On a ford that is already shallow, the driver still gets down and leads, and they will not say why. A Two-Bodied person in an ox’s body is a person. This animal is an ox, and it is not on a guild roll.

A goat gives milk, meat, hide, and dung, and it browses scrub other stock will not take. The herds are on the Rain-Shadow, the rough ground of Heskoren, and the terraces of Kumbaan. A house that loses the herd loses the cheese and the wall’s upkeep in the same week. The house is afraid of the goat in two places: a terrace wall knocked loose, which is a season of soil in the wrong yard, and a well-share argument when the herd comes in and the coping is already crowded. The goat is not afraid of the wall.

The goat is doing the job the scrub offered. A Two-Bodied person in a goat’s body is a person. This animal is a goat, and it is not breeding stock for a guild.

A dog herds, guards a door, and keeps a quay or a hall honest about who is coming in. Farms, quays, halls, and road-houses keep them. The dog knows the way the house uses, and the house trusts the stop. The dog is afraid of floodwater and refuses a flooded path, so handlers who know the dog stop with it. A driver who drags it through is arguing with the animal about the water, and the animal has already read the path. A granary cat, on the same kind of work, marks spoilage, and that is a different animal. A Two-Bodied person in a dog’s body is a person. This animal is a dog.

Horses, mules, sheep, cattle, pigs, geese, and bees are livelihoods in the same way, on the ground that can feed them. They enter a scene as property, food, labour, or loss. The adversaries of a wild road are a different matter from a house’s stock.

Maps

East is Maiethorn, where the wood is oldest. West of that heart the grafts are still arriving on Heskoren, and past the storm-wall is Kumbaan, where the count of Trees is none. The names of the water and the stone are in *Climate, Ecology, and Travel*. What the lands are is in *The Four Continents*. These sheets show where a named place sits. If a painted roof and a sentence in this book disagree, follow the sentence.

There are two kinds of drawing, and they are not the same thing. The schematic is the placement: west is left, east is right, and if you read it from the left you are walking the reach backward, from none, through thin, through high, and at last to full. Kumbaan, the storm-wall, Heskoren, the West Water, Strandoren, the Old Crossing, and Maiethorn sit in that order, and the coastlines on it are a sketch, not a measured survey. The pictures in this chapter are the labeled paintings. They carry the same four landmasses and the same west-is-left rule, and they are still paintings. The relative positions stay. A later page may turn the compass. What has to hold is who sits next to whom, and how far.

World map

The picture is the labeled world painting. West is left, and the labels are the ones painted on that sheet: four landmasses, the Old Crossing, the West Water, the Rain-Wall, the four rivers, the Noon Pass, and the Shelf-gate. The fifteen powers are regions of ground. No surveyed border is painted. If a painted roof and a sentence here disagree, follow the sentence. An isle with no name in these notes is paint.

Rothallo is the mark inside Orenbren, one day’s walk from the wood. People still say the Inner Close. That name is this city, and the city is the capital. On the regional sheets the painted mark is still the small walled square. No sheet paints a star on a capital. Maiethlir and Orentel are each marked once.

Capitals, large cities, and important towns are marked where the notes already place them. **Vaelhesk** is the land. It has no settlement dot. Harrow’s Green is a grove-town, not a capital. Ornsael is a well-town, not a capital. The First Seat stands in the wood, and no sheet marks it. No date is written on the Tree. There is no graft on Kumbaan, and none took on the isle.

On the drawing, three older stones are small marks: the Low Wall, the Seeing-Ring, and the Dry Stair. They are found stone from before the Walking Years, on this same ground. The Seeing-Ring is on a hill north-east of Maiethlir. The painted sheets do not mark it. The Ages chapter tells that stretch.



Natai sits west of Harrow's Green, between Sanbreo and that grove, on ground of its own. The hamlets' ford is a different crossing. **Larbril** is where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass, west of Ornsael's well. **Ornsael** is farther into the dry, at a well. Open country lies between it and Larbril, and the town sits inland. Where the paint and a sentence in this book disagree, follow the sentence.

Continent maps

Maiethorn, east. The labeled continent painting is the picture.



The Mother-core lies west of the Rain-Wall. Thaeloren is the canopy-ring in the old growth, the Tree the later cuttings came from. Rothallo is the walled mark one day out. People still say the Inner Close, and the city is the capital, still painted at the scale of that small square. Maiethlir sits where the Core-thaw slows. Seinbrun stands off that river, north of Maiethlir. The Seeing-Ring's hill is north-east of Maiethlir and is not painted. The Third Hearth is a road-house three days out. Lirorn is the range. The name of the divide is the Rain-Wall, and Lirorn calls it the Thaw-Wall. The Noon Pass is the older high notch, the one with the water-line. The Shelf-gate is the lower road, the one taken after the Break. Tasain is in the valley below that gate, on the wet side, south of Thaeloren. Saelthael is the dry east. Larbril is the meeting of the west road and the Well-wash, east of the range and short of the pass. Ornsael is the well-town farther along that road into the dry, with open country between the two, and the town sits inland. The Hinge Shore is Maiethorn's face on the Old Crossing. Votaer is the port on that shore.

Strandoren, middle. The labeled continent painting is the picture.



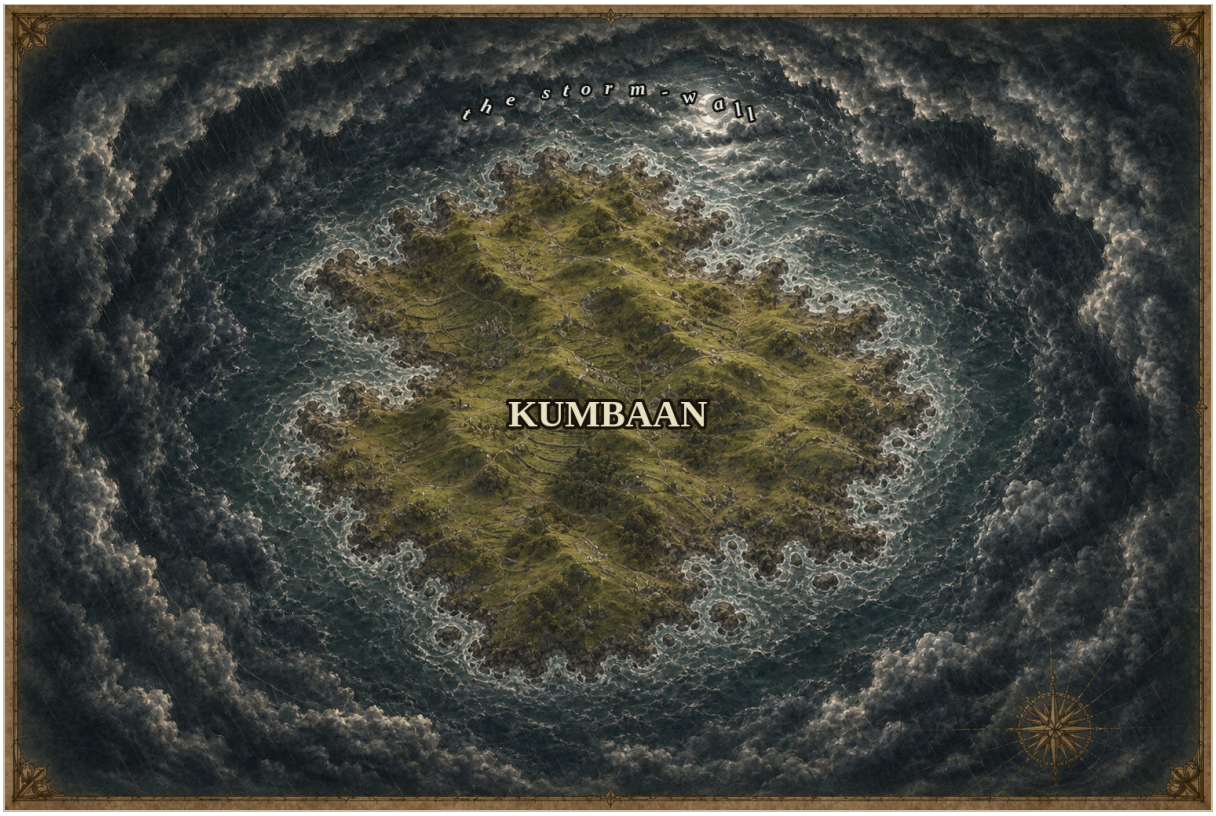
Orentel is a plain dot at the eastern estuary, not a star. The Chart-run crosses the interior to that estuary. Lunbra is on the run, upriver of the salt. Raitin stands on the river behind the premier coast, south-west of Orentel. Trenledd and Netstrand are written as areas of ground, and no border is painted around them. Naenor is on the south coast, south-west of Orentel and south of Raitin, on water of its own, apart from the Chart-run and apart from the West Water. Braetu is the harbour on the Night Shore. Six charter-towns sit around Raitin. This sheet does not name them, and it does not mark them. Denlad, the inlet about a day’s sail short of the estuary, has no sheet of its own.

Heskoren, west of the West Water. The labeled continent painting is the picture.



West is left. The west coast is the slate-shore, in Ornled, facing the last capes and the storm-wall. The sea on the right of the sheet, the Strandoren side, is the West Water, off Heskoren’s east coast. Eolvaeth is the pilgrim-town in the waiting vale, and the vale has no view of Harrow’s. Sanbreo is the slate-shore town on the west coast, the mark that names Ornled’s seat, and its beach faces west. Harrow’s Green is a plain grove-town on the live-front rise. Natai is the march west of that grove, between Sanbreo and Harrow’s, on ground of its own. The hamlets sit on different ground past the Rise-water crossing: Brenod, Vaelun, and Ornath. Their ford is that crossing. Harrow’s square is the grove-town’s own ground. Vaelhesk is old greens, and it has no settlement dot. Tunral, a kitchen and a post coastward of Harrow’s with no sight of the canopy, has no sheet of its own.

Kumbaan, behind the storm-wall. The labeled continent painting is the picture. There is no settlement dot and no graft.



It is one isle, and the name sits on the hill-country with no point marker. The storm-wall is weather around the isle: cloud, current, and reef. The sheet shows no graft, no city, no harbour, no safe channel, and no Tree. Ndenjoo is a hill-hall. Njunda keeps its table, and that is a person, not a second mark. The sheet gives the hall no flag. Nothing on the isle is a graft.

The overlays

Each painted region keeps the names the ground already had.

The world sheet is the painting at the start of this chapter. It runs the same west-to-east line: Kumbaan, the storm-wall, Heskoren, the West Water, Strandoren, the Old Crossing, Maiethorn, the Rain-Wall. The sea-names sit in the water. Vaelhesk has no dot on this sheet either. Maiethlir and Orentel are marked once here.

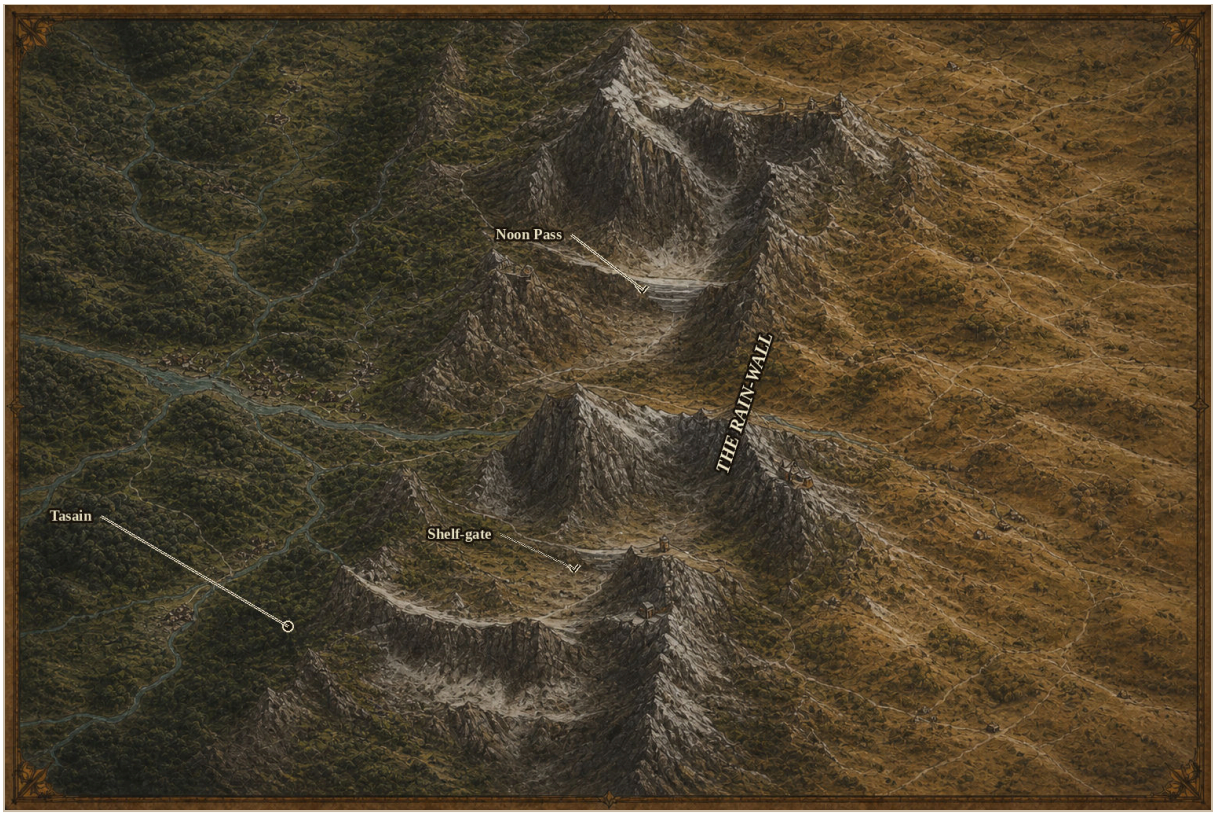
The Old Crossing. Orentel is on the Strandoren estuary. The Hinge Shore is named as a stretch of the Maiethorn coast, and Votaer is the port on that coast. The Hush-rate is the charge for the crossing.



The Sacred Core. Thaeloren’s canopy-ring. The First Seat, in the wood, has no separate mark. Rothallo is the walled square one day out. Seinbrun is off the Core-thaw, north of Maiethlir. The Third Hearth is three days out. Maiethlir is the counted city on the Core-thaw road.



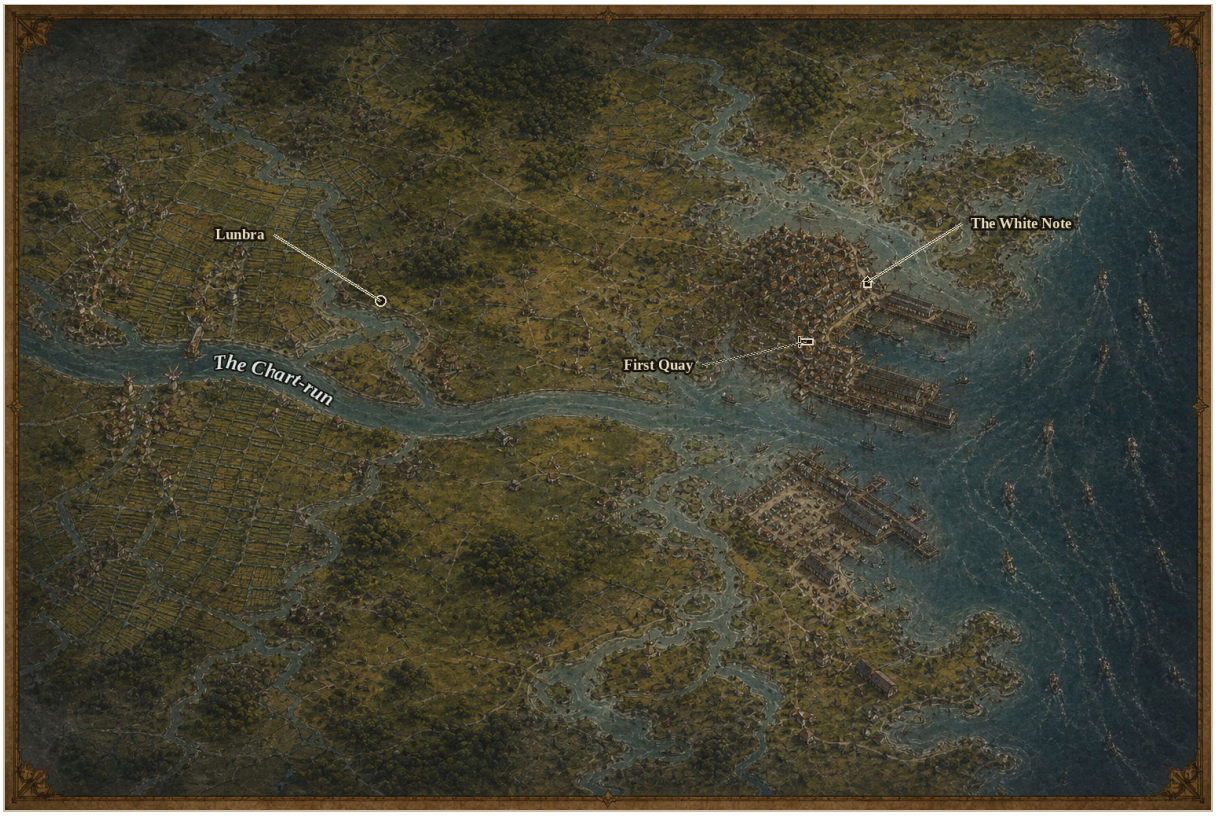
The Rain-Wall. The range is the Rain-Wall. The Noon Pass and the Shelf-gate are notches in the range. Tasain is the town in the valley below the Shelf-gate. Tengu and Fox-of-the-Snows hearths sit on the snow, inside Lirorn.



The Rain-Shadow. The dry east, painted as weather. Larbril is on the west road, short of the pass. Ornsael is on the well, farther into the dry, with open country between them. The Well-wash is seasonal water. The Dry Stair is a site on a different rise. The well-town at its shoulder has no name in these notes.



The Chart-run. The river to Orentel’s estuary. The first quay is the old landing. The White Note is one desk-house on the third quay, north side. It keeps the notes, and it is not a crown. Lunbra is upriver of the salt. Other towns in the filed country have no names on this sheet.



The West Water. The open ocean, in the blue. The Night Shore is the west-and-south face, named as a shore. Braetu is the harbour. This sheet does not mark the unlit berth.



The live front. Harrow’s is a grove-town on the rise. The march’s seat is Natai, west of this grove, and this sheet is not Natai’s square. The Rise-water runs to the ford. Brenod, Vaelun, and Ornath are three small hearths past the crossing.



The waiting vale. Eolvaeth is a pilgrim-town at the gift-hall. The spring is a pool. This sheet does not draw Harrow’s canopy.



Square and seat maps

Closer sheets exist for the seats and the town squares that already have streets. They are the same places as the notes. A closer sheet of a city is that city. Rothallo’s gate is the same square gatehouse as the city: beds outside, the Book inside. Larbril’s Well-wash is a silt-line, and the road there is the west road. Vaelhesk has no sheet. Raillath, Denlad, and Tunral are on the travel table, and they have no sheet of their own. The Third Hearth, the three hamlets, and the First Bowl are painted on the regional sheets above, not as cities of their own.

Place	What to find
Rothallo	walled capital inside Orenbren; people still say the Inner Close; one day from the wood; no star
Seinbrun	Maiethvael’s capital, off the Core-thaw, north of Maiethlir and more than a day from it
Maiethlir	on the Core-thaw, a day’s carry of living wood out from the Motherwood. The grove is other ground. The First Seat has no mark
the Third Hearth / Brenthael	Near Mile, three days out from Thaeloren, then one day further
Raillath	the ordinary halt between Brenthael and the Mill-hold, a day from each; no sheet
the Mill-hold	two days past Brenthael; the culvert and the Hand, its Turning Tree
Nelath	the spur off the Near Mile; the road stops
Larbril	west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass, on the dry side east of the Rain-Wall
Ornsael	well-town farther into the dry, inland, with open country between it and Larbril
Votaer	Hinge Shore port, facing Orentel
Tasain	walled town below the Shelf-gate, south of Thaeloren on the west road
Orentel	Chart-run estuary; the White Note is a desk on the third quay, north side
Denlad	a side inlet about a day’s sail short of that estuary, toward the Hinge Shore; no sheet
Raitin	Brenledd’s throne-city, on the river behind the premier coast, south-west of Orentel
Naenor	Leddvael’s port, on its own south-coast water, south-west of Orentel and south of Raitin
Lunbra	Trenledd, on the Chart-run
Braetu	Night Shore harbour; one berth stays unlit on the quay sheet

Place	What to find
Sanbreo	Ornled’s slate-town on Heskoren’s west coast, the slate-shore; on the brink of a small city; the beach faces the last capes
Natai	Saelvaeth’s march-town, west of Harrow’s Green, between Sanbreo and that grove
Harrow’s Green	grove-town on the live front; the Rise-water runs to the ford. The march’s seat is Natai
Tunral	a kitchen and a post coastward of Harrow’s, about a week, with no sight of the canopy; no sheet
the Three Hamlets	the ford; canopy visible from the water in clear weather
the First Bowl	guest-grove in the Yield, away from Harrow’s. Vaelhesk itself has no dot
Eolvaeth	Vaethorn vale, with no view of Harrow’s
Ndenjoo	hill-hall on Kumbaan; no Tree and no graft

Three old walks are still roads.

The **Near Mile** is the inland stones toward Thaeloren. Some of them now end at a Turning Tree. Nelath’s spur is one road that stops, and Raillath is the halt that does not.

The **Salt Walk** is the Old Crossing, then the Near Mile. The Hush-rate is charged on the hinge. Votaer sorts the hull. Orentel prices the berth. Denlad is the inlet where a family can still miss the week.

The **Long Mile** is the West Water, then Heskoren mud. Empty road-houses still make the bed. Braetu quotes the far run.

The travel times are in *Climate, Ecology, and Travel*. A day’s walk is the interval a mile-shrine marks.

Closer paintings of the seats and town squares that have them follow. West is left on each.

Rothallo, the walled capital. People still say the Inner Close.



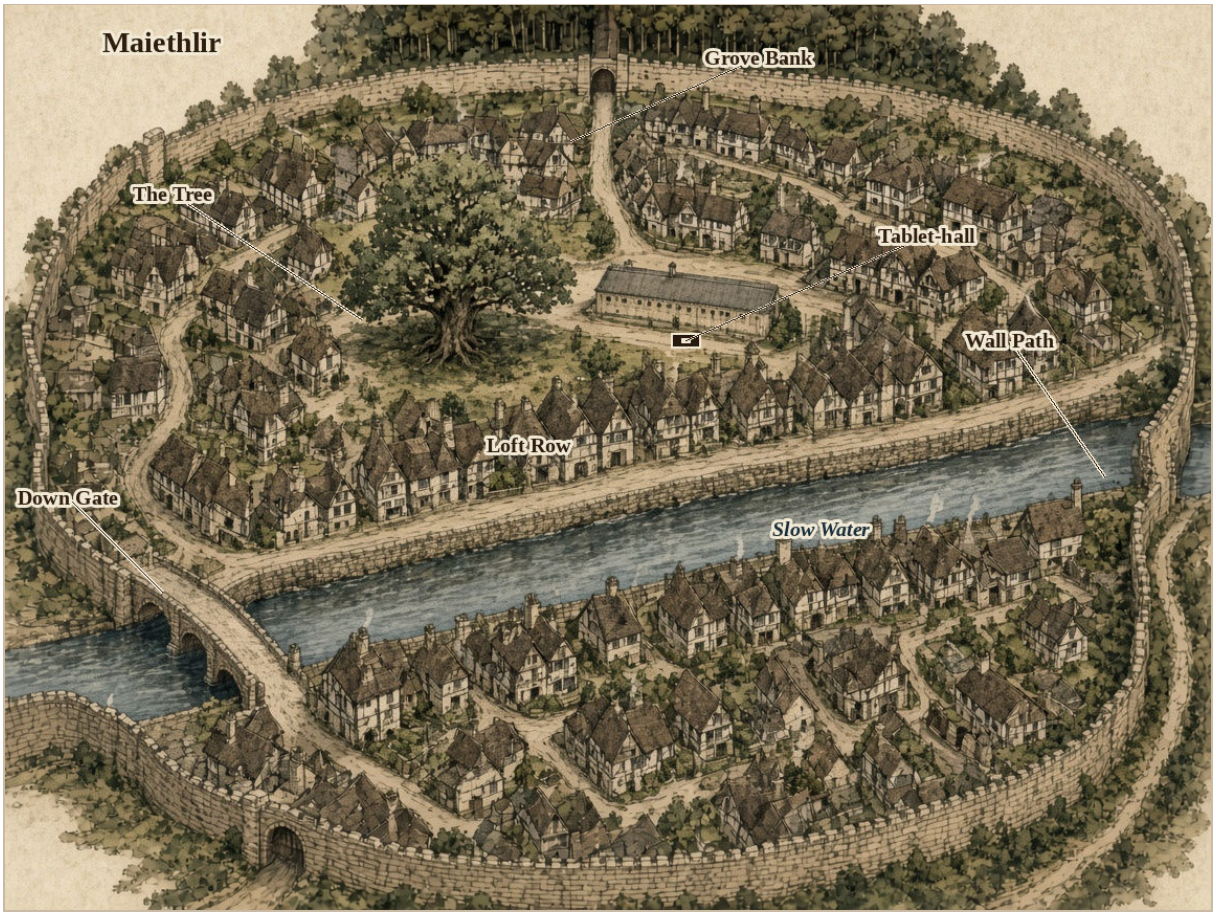
The gate is the same square gatehouse, with the beds outside and the Book inside.



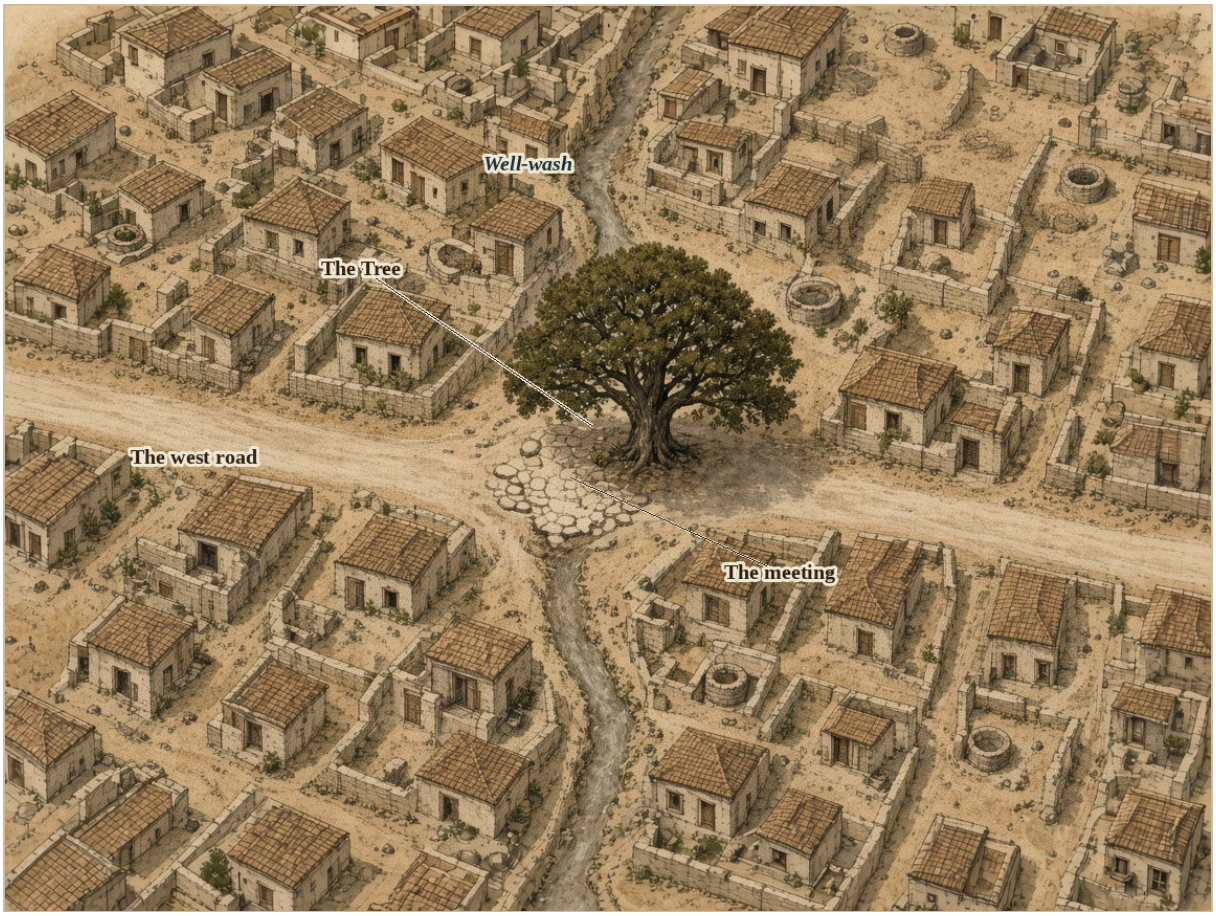
Seinbrun, Maiethvael’s capital.



Maiethlir, on the Core-thaw. The First Seat has no mark on this sheet.



Larbril, where the west road meets the Well-wash.



Ornsael, the well-town farther into the dry.



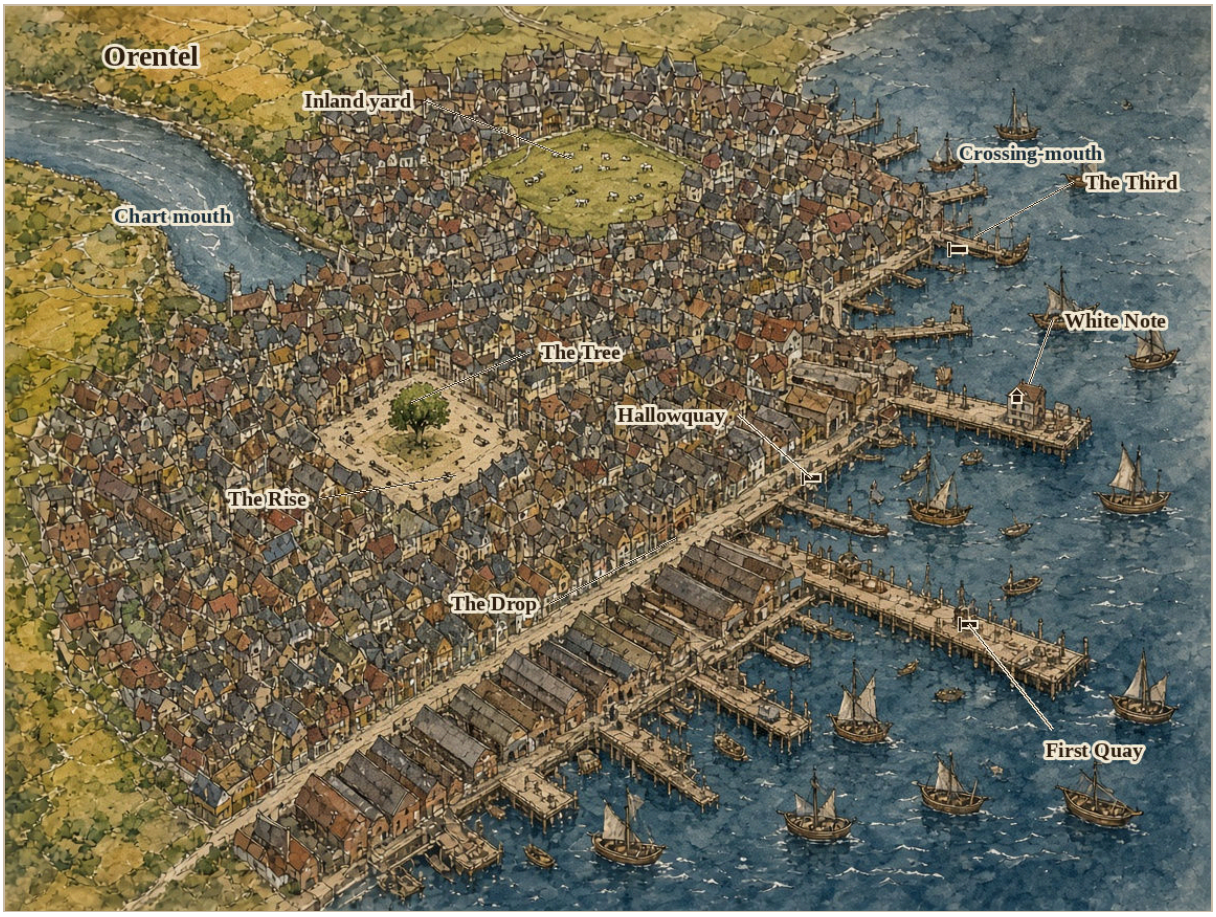
Votaer, the Hinge Shore port.



Tasain, below the Shelf-gate.

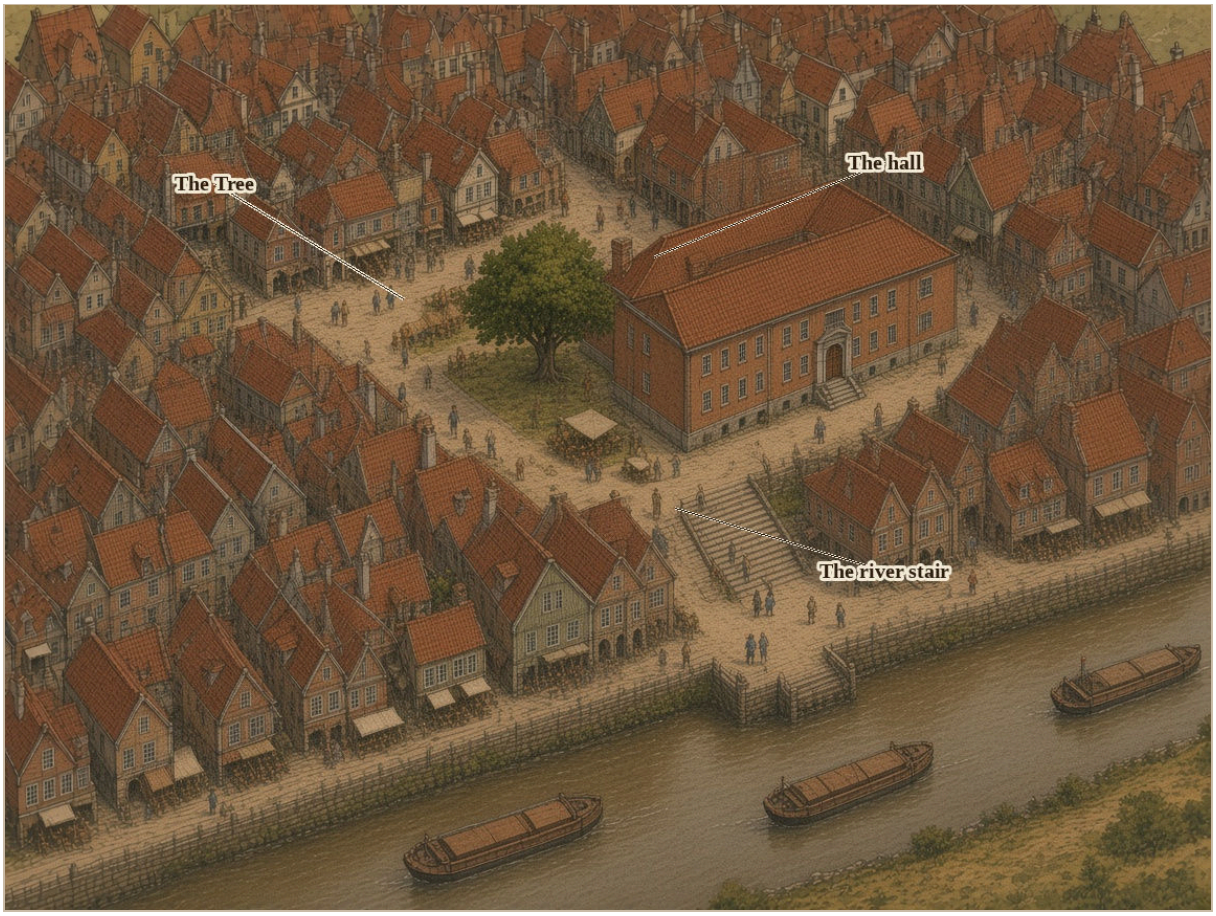


Orentel, at the Chart-run estuary. The White Note is a desk on the third quay.

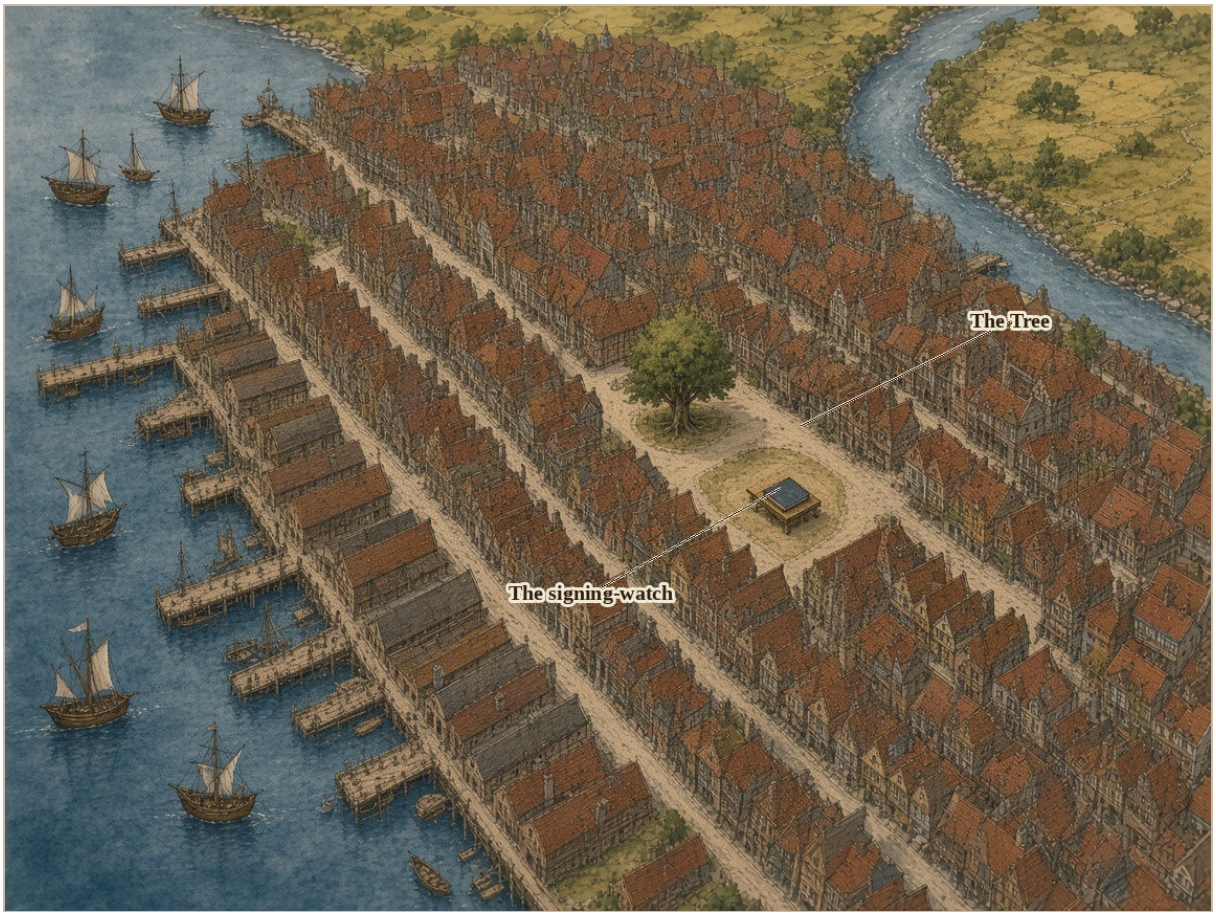

Orentel
Inland yard
Chart mouth
Crossing-mouth
The Third
White Note
The Tree
Hallowquay
The Rise
The Drop
First Quay



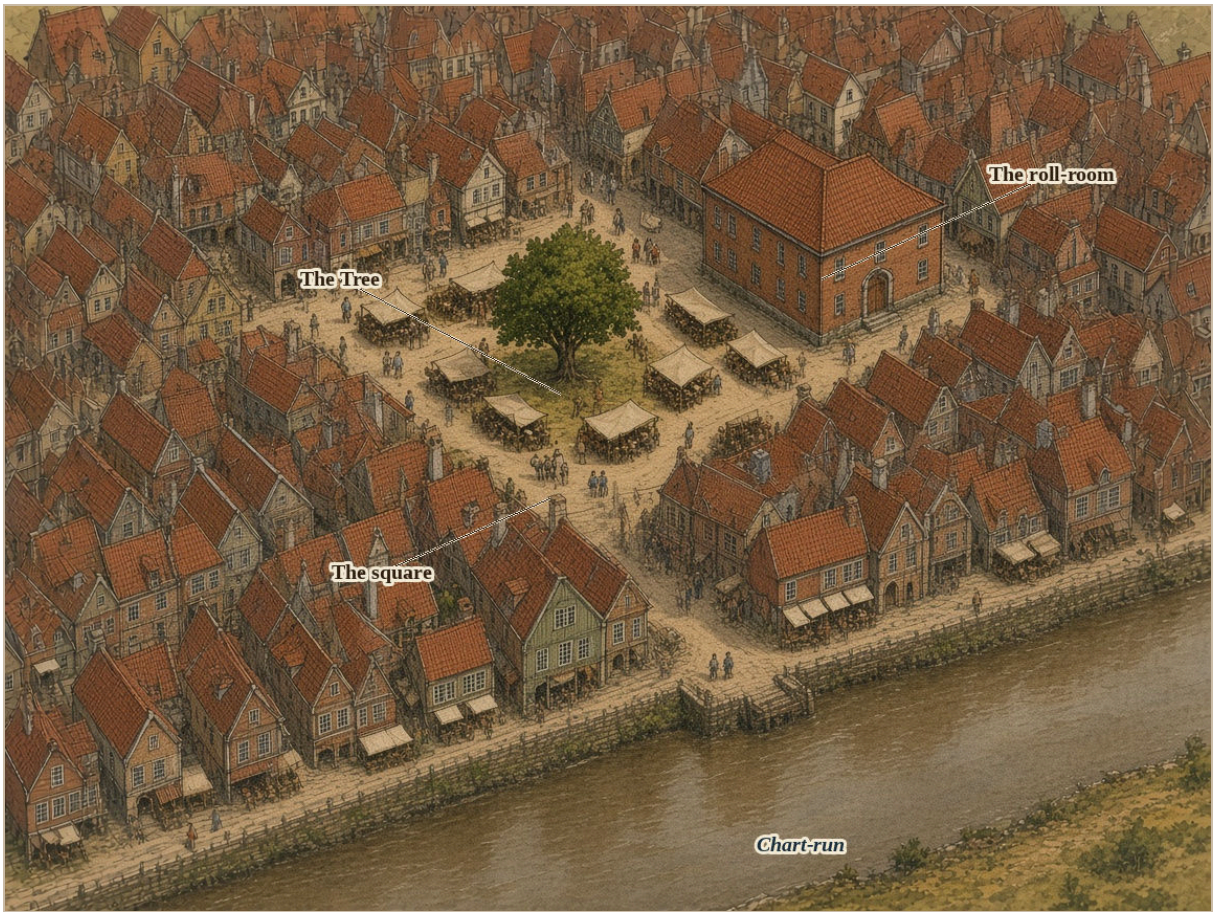
Raitin, Brenledd’s throne-city.



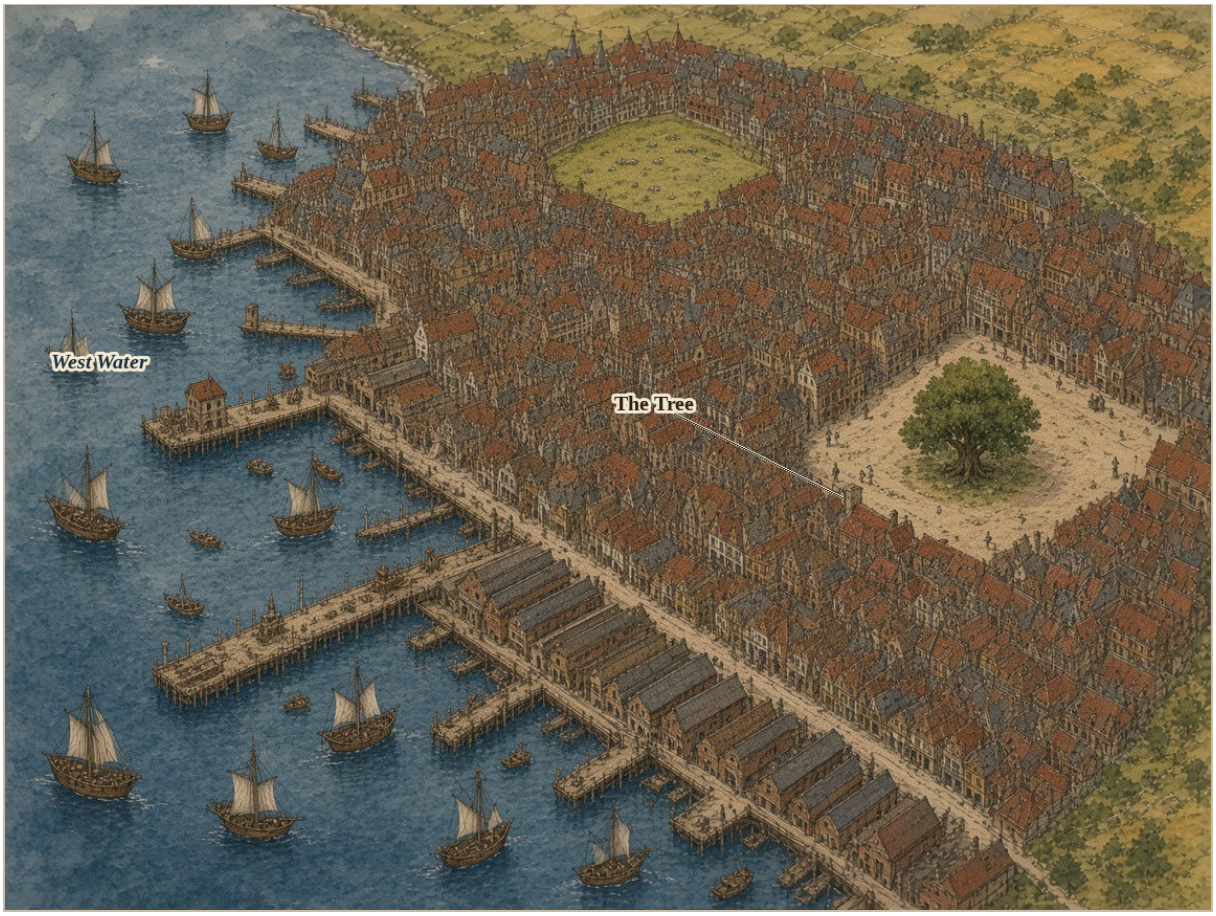
Naenor, Leddvael’s port.

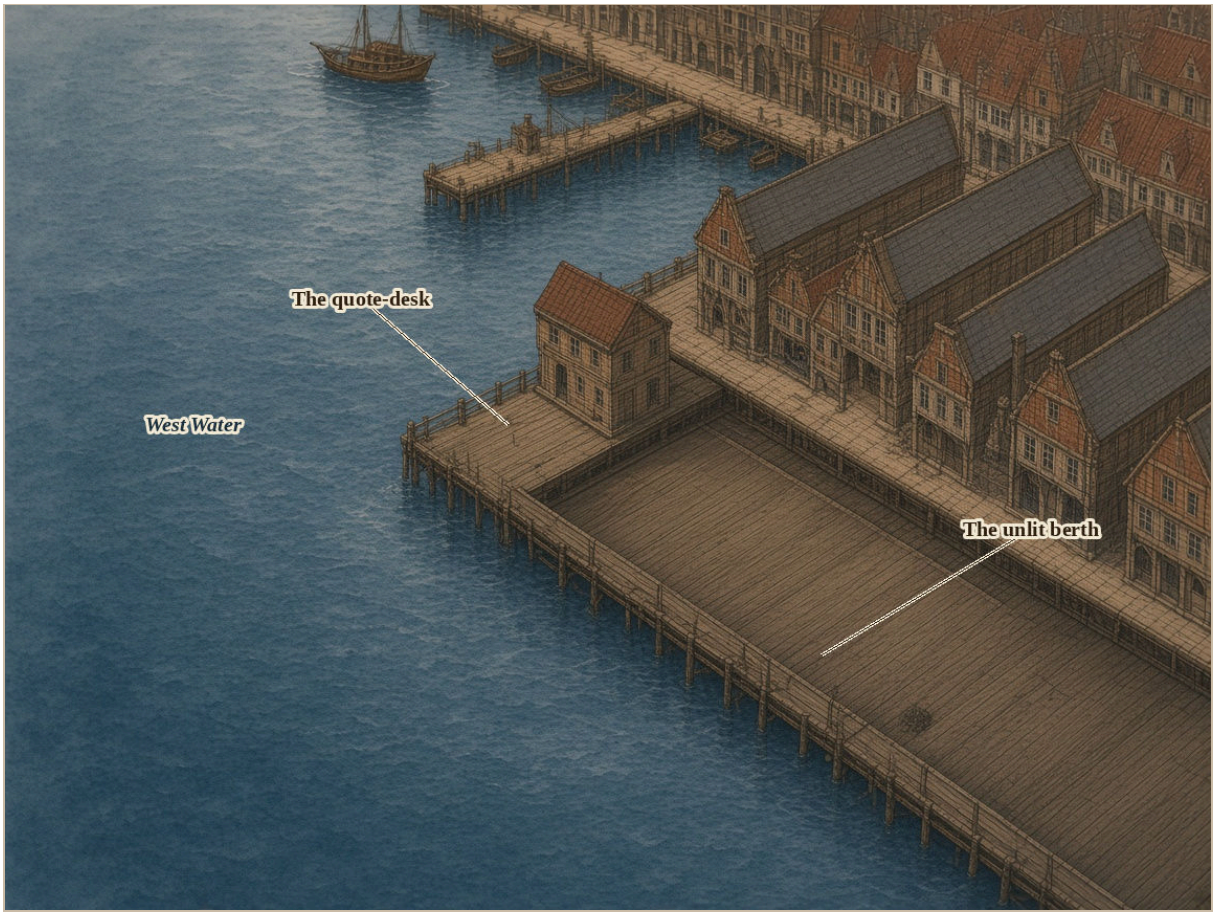


Lunbra, on the Chart-run.



Braetu, the Night Shore harbour. One berth stays unlit on the quay sheet.


West Water
The Tree



Sanbreo, Ornled's town on the slate-shore. The sea is on the left, to the west, as on the Heskoren sheet. The shore gate meets the beach, and the slate is on the wall inside the gate.



Natai, the march west of Harrow’s Green.



Harrow’s Green, the grove-town on the live front. Natai is the march’s seat.



Eolvaeth, in the waiting vale.



The Mill-hold, the sick-Tree town.



Nelath, the road-end.



Ndenjoo, on Kumbaan. No Tree.


The hall

Book VI

The Ages

The Ages

People in this world do not live in a fourth age stacked on three earlier ones. They keep two clocks at the same time, and the clock a person reaches for tells you where that person stands.

The first clock is personal, and a family keeps it the way it keeps a grandparent's stories. It counts how you were Turned. Turning is what the Awakening Tree does for a child in the tenth year: a Condition, a change that comes to a person rather than a people they were born as, can be Given, or the Tree can hug the child and leave them without one. A colour at that giving means a Condition. A hug means no colour, and a person left with none is called Kept, and also UnTurned. Did you walk to Thaeloren, the Awakening Tree itself, or to a neighbour who had already made that walk, or did you stand under a town graft, a cutting of that Tree planted at home and grown as the same plant? An ordinary family will tell you they are a Hands-house, Hands being those planted town Trees, and that grandmother still talks of the road. A Long-Lived person, whose aging has stopped and who forgets nothing they have witnessed, who says "I walked" is saying when they were young, because the Long-Lived live long enough that the walk can have been their own childhood.

The second clock is geographic, and it has not finished. The Grafting is the carrying of living wood outward from the origin, Hand by Hand, and it is not a golden age that opened and then closed. The wood started at the Awakening Tree, filled Maiethorn, crossed the sea to Strandoren, and is still arriving on Heskoren, which people also call the Sundered Reach. Kumbaan, the Sundering Isle, stands entirely off that spread. Where the wood is still thin, that thinness is not a scar history left behind. It is the front of a process that has not finished.

Both clocks sit on a preface that was never given an age-name, Before the Walk. The Tree was already there. People were already born into Kinds, the peoples a person is from birth and does not become later, and some were already Struck, which is a Condition arriving later at a threshold such as a drowning, an oath, or a death, before anyone had called the Tree a mother. No count that is being honest begins with the Tree.

This was not a civilizing mission, and the Walking Years were not a golden age of pilgrimage that the grafts then improved. The Walking Years were the work of getting a child to one Tree in time, across weeks of road and water, and that work killed children. The Grafting was horticulture, the cutting and planting of living wood, and people sanctified it afterward. The First Seat, the college of tree-wardens at the Awakening Tree, now tells both the walk and the grafts as the Mother's will travelling. Folk memory is less tidy, and holds the romance and the graves in the same sentence.

The ages at a glance

	Everyday	Liturgical	Says	What it is
Preface	**Before the Walk**	*(mostly unnamed)* · the Watching keep **the Before**	—	The Awakening Tree already stood. People were already born into Kinds, already becoming at doors, and already seeing, and nobody had called the Tree a mother. The time is left uncounted on purpose.
Count of how you Turned, old default	**the Walking Years**	**Brenvaeth** *(BREN-vaeth)*	"the hearth gone to waiting"	You walked to Thaeloren or you stayed UnTurned for want of the trip. The far lands ran heavy with the UnTurned, and with people who were Struck later.
The hinge	**the First Cut**	**Eoloren** *(EOL-or-en)*	"the witnessed hinge"	Someone cut living wood and the cutting took. Who cut it is argued. That it happened is not.
Count of where the wood has reached	**the Grafting**	*(a process, not an age you leave)*	—	The carrying of living wood, Hand by Hand. It is still unfinished on Heskoren, the Sundered Reach, and it never crossed the storm-wall.
Count of how you Turned, new default	**the Years of Hands**	**Ornthael** *(ORN-thael)*	"Tree-land"	A town Tree is the ordinary way to Turn. Pilgrimage remains, as devotion, as prestige, or as a necessity wherever a graft has failed.

The pair of liturgical names turns inside out the name the Road-hands use for the work of carrying wood, and the Road-hands are the tree-wardens who walk that wood. In the Old Tongue, Thaelvaeth means "the Tree gone to the waiting," which is wood carried out to the hearths. Brenvaeth *(BREN-vaeth)* means "the hearth gone to the waiting," which is people walking in to the Tree. Eoloren *(EOL-or-en)* is the liturgical name of the cut, and Ornthael *(ORN-thael)* is the liturgical name of the years when a town has its own Tree. The Grafting is the moment the world stopped sending hearths to the Tree and started sending the Tree to hearths.

A history in order

This section tells the history in order, from before anyone counted years to the present. The years are given the way the First Seat and the devout clerks count them, from the First Cut, the first time a piece cut from the Awakening Tree was planted in another town and grew. That year is Cut-year 0, and the present year is Cut-year 387. Many people count another way, and “How years are numbered,” below, says who they are. The later sections of this chapter tell each part at length. What follows here is the order of events, and what each one left behind.

Before anyone counted years

Before anyone counted years, the Awakening Tree already stood on Maiethorn, in the country now called the Sacred Core. It was the only tree in the world a child could be Turned under, and nobody planted it in any summer that anyone remembers.

People were already born into their Kinds. Some were already Struck into a Condition at a threshold, far from the Tree and with nobody to witness it. Under the Tree, children in their tenth year were already brought at the solstice and either Given a colour or hugged. Nobody knows how long any of that had been going on.

The Watching, the faith that keeps a night of attention and will not start history at a mother’s name, call this time the Before. They teach that the Tree was already watching people before anyone called it a mother. The Old Ways on Heskoren, a long way from Maiethorn, say their people were already being Struck at the places they call doors, a drowning, a grove, or a stone, before any road to the Tree existed. Kumbaan is not part of this history. Its people have their own past, and they do not count it by the Tree.

Nobody wrote down a king, a war, or a founding from this time. A few stone places from it survive, and three of them are described near the end of this section. More of the thin preface is in “Before the Walk.”

The years of the walk

The time before the First Cut is called the Walking Years. Nobody knows when it started, because it started when families began to organize the trip to the Tree, and nobody wrote that year down. The road, the inns, the graves, and the gate are told at length in “The Walking Years.”

In those years there was one Tree to Turn under, and one week in which to do it. A child who had turned ten since the last High Solstice had to stand under the Awakening Tree during Turning-Week, the week around the High Solstice in the month of Eolthael. A child who arrived after that week was not Given a Condition, that year or any later year. They could still be Struck later in life, but no Tree

would ever Give them a Condition. Families who lived far away left months early. The richest families, and the most frightened, sent a nine-year-old to spend a whole year near the Tree, wintering in a road-house, so the child could not miss the week.

People in Maiethorn walked the Near Mile, which took between three and twelve days. People in Strandoren, the country reached by ship, took the Salt Walk: three to five days on a ship across the Old Crossing, the sea between the two shores, and then the Near Mile, usually one to three weeks in all. People in Heskoren, and in the far inland parts of Strandoren, walked the Long Mile, which took six to twelve weeks. A family on the Long Mile had to give up a year’s spare food, or sign a debt at a road-house, or not go.

Many families could not afford to send every child. A family with three children near ten might send one. That child might come home with a Condition, while the brothers and sisters who stayed home grew up UnTurned, or were Struck later. Because so many children never reached the Tree, the far lands were full of UnTurned people, whom folk called Kept, and of people Struck later in life.

Inns along the roads gave travellers a bed and let them eat on credit, to be paid back on the way home or years later. Many of the innkeepers were Long-Lived, and they forgot none of what was owed. After the walk stopped being necessary, some of those inns kept their records and became banks. The White Note House in Orentel is one of them. The Third Hearth is an inn that stayed an inn.

Children died on the road, and so did the adults who carried them. They drowned at river crossings in the thaw, caught fever in crowded inns, were lost in late storms on the Old Crossing, and went hungry on the long stretches of the Long Mile. Travellers buried them where the group stopped and set a stone there. The next year’s travellers used the stone to find the water. Those stones are the mile-shrines that still stand along the old roads, often with a ribbon tied on.

Reaching the Tree was not enough. A group of families with no Condition lived around the Awakening Tree and decided who was allowed to stand under it. People now call them the Closed Seat, and in ordinary talk they are the Grove-Sitters. A family needed a paper called grove-leave to pass their gate. A family could arrive with good shoes and a paid ship’s berth and still be turned away. Some children walked the whole Long Mile and went home UnTurned because the gate refused them.

The Closed Seat ruled the country around the Tree, and the rule stopped at that country. Strandoren’s families paid for the crossing, but the Closed Seat never ruled Strandoren. Heskoren was too far away to rule, and Kumbaan never came.

Some Long-Lived alive today walked one of these roads as children, and they remember every day of the walk. They do not agree about what it meant.

The First Cut (Cut-year 0)

In Cut-year 0, someone cut a piece of living wood from the Awakening Tree, carried it in earth to a town about a day’s walk away, and planted it, and it grew. People had always grafted fruit trees. This was the first time a cutting from the Awakening Tree took root somewhere else.

Nobody knows who made the cut, and the town is not named either. People call that first graft the nameless green. A town Tree grows from wood cut from the Awakening Tree, so people count it as the same Tree. The devout, who speak of that Tree as the Mother’s, call each town Tree a Hand of the Mother. The five stories of who cut are in “The First Cut.”

The years of argument (Cut-years 0 to 19)

A new graft cannot hold a Leaf-Fall, the Turning in which a town’s own children stand under it and are Given a colour or hugged, until it has grown for about a generation, about twenty years. For nineteen years nobody knew whether the nameless green would ever Turn a child.

During those years other towns on the Near Mile cut their own pieces and planted them, and most of the cuttings died. The First Seat said the cutting was theft and forbade it. People cut anyway.

In Cut-year 19 the nameless green held its first Turning-Week, and a child of that town was Turned under it. The stories disagree about whether the child received a colour or a hug. Either way, a town that was not the Awakening Tree’s town had Turned its own child. The First Seat stopped trying to forbid cutting and took charge of it instead. From then on, a cutting needed the Seat’s permission, called Cutting-leave. That permission, and the waiting list of towns that want a graft, called the scion-queue, still exist. Rithnali, a Speaker of the First Seat, wrote the record of that summer’s meeting. It says the Seat will write down how a cutting is done and will not write down who did the first one. The minute is under “A minute of the First Seat.”

The Closing (Cut-years 19 to 38)

The Closed Seat’s power depended on being the only gate to the only Tree. A town that could Turn its own children did not need grove-leave. From Cut-year 19, the Closed Seat sent riders out with sacks to dig up the new grafts and bring them back, or burn them in their pots. They told every square the same sentence: the copy was a theft of the one Tree, so bring the wood home, or burn the pot it was growing in.

They failed. Some of the grafts died, and the towns that meant to keep a cutting hid it in a well and watered it at night. The lodging-towns around the grove, which made their living housing travellers, would not stop housing them to help the Closed Seat, and would not starve a season of beds to please a gate. The First Seat wanted to control who cut, not to destroy trees, and it would not help burn a graft

that had already Turned a child. The Closed Seat could not guard every town within a day's walk in every direction, in a world where an order dies with the person sent to carry it. People call this war the Closing, because what they closed in the end was their walls. Folk who watched the riders also call it the Uprooting. The remnant that still keeps the book says the Retreat. No one agrees which pot was the first they failed to pull. Naming that town would pick a hearth, and a hearth would pick a hand.

In Cut-year 38, Hildal *(HIL-dal)*, the last person to speak for the Closed Seat whose name people still use, ordered the Retreat. Hildal was a clerk, not a warlord. The Closed families gave up the grove, moved a day's walk away into a walled city, and took their Book with them. The Book is their record of who owes what, and the walled city is Rothallo, which people still call the Inner Close. They believed they had been doing horticulture and mercy. One Tree, as they told it, cannot bear the whole world coming at once, so someone has to choose who takes the road. That is the same wish to ration the Tree that the First Seat later named Cutting-leave, and the same wish the Inner Close still files as rank. The rule that strikes a Given heir off the roll is older than the Retreat. The war did not invent it. The war moved it off the grove and put it behind a wall.

The Closed Heirs say they closed the walls so the Book would live, and that they sat the grove because someone had to. Folk, the lodging-towns, and the college say the riders went out to pull pots and could not, and that the Retreat was a gate that chose a wall. A Long-Lived person who walked to the grove as a child in Cut-year 10, and a Closed Heir who keeps Hildal's last page, will fight about the same summer, because the memory is perfect and what the summer meant is not. A Salt-Walk house will still skip the years 19 to 38 in its own count, call the gap an origin delay, and collect on the notes.

The Closed Seat's power split four ways, and nobody has put it back together.

- Nobody controls who may stand under the Awakening Tree anymore. A family needs nobody's leave to bring a child there in Turning-Week.
- The First Seat controls who may cut a graft, through Cutting-leave and the scion-queue.
- The lodging-towns joined together and became Orenbren, which houses travellers near the Tree. The hospitality is how the rent is paid. They were not a new crown.
- The Closed families kept the Book, and the Book only governs people who live inside Rothallo's walls. It classifies who owes. It is not a church.

Rothallo is Orenbren's capital, and it lies inside Orenbren, so the Closed families did not found a new country when they moved. They share Orenbren with the lodging-towns. The lodging-towns run the inns outside Rothallo's wall, and the Book runs the city inside it. Strandoren's houses had never been a province of the gate, and the far hearths on the Long Mile had never been held by it. The collapse of the gate did not make that road any shorter.

The Closed Heirs after the Retreat (Cut-years 38 to 387)

The Closed families are now called the Closed Heirs. After the Retreat they kept the same habits inside Rothallo that the Closed Seat had kept at the grove, and they have kept them for three hundred and forty-nine years. The group that keeps the Book is called the Walled Book. This is what a visitor to Rothallo can see today.

- **Where a person sits.** At a meal in a Closed house, Kept guests sit nearest the host. A guest with a Condition is shown to the far end of the table. When the Book is read aloud, the Kept sit on the front benches and everyone else sits behind them.
- **Whose word a clerk writes down.** When two people disagree in front of a clerk of the Book, and one is Kept and the other has a Condition, the clerk writes the Kept person's account as what happened. The other account is written underneath as "also said." The person with a Condition can still win, but only if a second Kept person says the same thing.
- **Who holds a key.** Only a Kept person may hold a key to a gate in the wall, to the Book's house, to a cistern, or to a granary. A person with a Condition holds the key to their own door and their own stall.
- **What the school teaches.** At the school beside the Book's house, the teacher Volnai tells the children that a hug is rare, and that a child the Tree hugged was kept back for something better than a colour.
- **Who inherits.** A Closed Heir who receives a colour at the Leaf-Fall is struck off the heir-roll. A Closed Heir who is hugged stays on it.
- **Who works.** Everyone who lives inside the walls owes the city turns of work, the way a town expects each household to take a turn on the watch. Kept households mostly keep the watch on the wall and hold the keys. Households with a Condition get the heavier turns, and more of them.

A person with a Condition in Rothallo is not a slave. They work for wages, keep what they earn, marry whom they choose, and can own a stall with a licence from the Book. They can walk out of the gate on any day it is open and live somewhere else. The Book's list of turns has no claim on anyone who lives outside the walls, and the Book cannot send for a person who has left.

The school's lesson gets the numbers wrong. About two children in five are hugged at the Leaf-Fall, and about a quarter of all people stay Kept for their whole lives. Being hugged is common. What is rare is a family like the Closed houses, which has stayed without a Condition on purpose for generations. They do it by striking every Given heir off the roll and keeping their heirs away from the oaths that can Strike a person. The clerks of the Book can read the real count. The school teaches the same lesson every year anyway.

The gate at the grove has been gone since Cut-year 38. The belief that a hugged person ranks above a person with a colour is still alive in Cut-year 387, and in a few places it reaches past Rothallo's walls.

Some inns just outside Rothallo’s gate keep their best table for Kept guests on nights when a Closed house dines there, and they move a guest with a Condition to another table if the Closed house asks. Brenthael, a town with its own Tree on the Near Mile, has no copy of the Book. At its Turning-Week supper, Kept people still sit on the benches nearest the Tree and people with a Condition sit on the outer benches, and a child who has just received a colour gets up and moves outward before the food is served. Nobody in Brenthael can say when this started. Other places reject it in public. The gift-hall at Eolvaeth, the seat of Vaethorn in the Waiting Lands, teaches that a colour and a hug are equal, and says aloud that the Close is wrong. Given heirs who were struck off the roll eat there. Hithaen is one of them.

In Cut-year 387, a Closed child named Talnin is on the heir-roll and has not yet had a Leaf-Fall. If a colour falls for Talnin, Talnin will be struck off.

How the grafts spread

From Cut-year 0, the grafts spread outward from the Awakening Tree, town by town, as each new Tree grew old enough to Turn children and to give cuttings of its own. The order is the same everywhere: Maiethorn first, then Strandoren by sea, then Heskoren, which is still receiving them, and Kumbaan never took one. A town that gets a graft still waits about twenty years before its Tree holds its first Leaf-Fall. Until then its children walk to a neighbouring town’s Tree. The time since town Trees became the ordinary way to Turn is called the Years of Hands. The spread is told at length in “How the wave moved,” and the present in “The Years of Hands.”

On Maiethorn, from Cut-year 0 to about 80, the towns nearest the Awakening Tree got grafts first, because a cutting could survive a short trip. By about Cut-year 80, most of Maiethorn’s core had its own Trees. The dry east beyond the Rain-Wall mountains, called the Rain-Shadow, was slower, because grafts die in thin, dry soil. Some families there still walk west to the Awakening Tree in Cut-year 387.

On Strandoren, from about Cut-year 40 to 160, ships that had carried children across the Old Crossing began carrying grafts in pots of living earth, kept on deck and watered at dawn. The rich port cities could pay for Cutting-leave and a ship in the same summer, so they got grafts first, while some Maiethorn villages were still waiting. Strandoren’s inland towns got grafts later, by river and cart. By about Cut-year 160, the coasts had mature Trees.

Then came a wait of about forty years, from Cut-year 160 to 200, in which no graft reached Heskoren. Cuttings died on the long road. A cutting has to come from the Awakening Tree or a mature town Tree, and the line of mature Trees took time to grow. The First Seat’s list served towns that could pay first. Heskoren did not wait because its people were unworthy, whatever some Vaethorn preachers say.

From Cut-year 200 to the present, grafts began arriving by sea from Strandoren to Heskoren's coast. The luckiest towns, such as Harrow's Green, got a graft in the 200s and have Turned their own children for a few generations. Many districts still have no Tree. Their ten-year-olds walk to a neighbouring town, or walk the Long Mile, as children did in the Walking Years. The Three Hamlets Past the Ford can see Harrow's Tree from their fields and are still on the list. This is happening now.

No graft has crossed the storm-wall around Kumbaan, the drowning weather that closes the isle. Sailors tell of pots that went into the sea. Dead wood is not a Tree, and Kumbaan's people count moons, not Cut-years.

A town Tree can also sicken and stop holding a Leaf-Fall. When that happens, the town's children go back to walking to a neighbour, even in Maiethorn. The Mill-hold is a town where that has happened.

Other dated years

These events happened while the grafts were spreading. They sit beside the history of the Trees, and they are not another age of the world. "The Other Count" below sets them in a table.

In Cut-year 67, the old hymn-country of the Sacred Core split in two over whether to write people down. People call that split the Two Papers. Limrae opened a desk in a river-town and began recording every person, saying that a person you cannot find again is a person you cannot look after. Manril, in the country around, refused to be put on the list. Manril said a person belongs because people saw them Turn, and stays well because their neighbours supply what their Condition needs. A Tithe is that upkeep, the thing a Condition asks of the person who carries it. There was no battle. Households chose which desk to deal with. The side that kept the list became Threnmaieth, the Tallied Crown, and the side that refused became Maiethvael. Threnmaieth counts years from that summer, so Cut-year 387 is Crown-year 320 there. That list is a later paper. It is the same wish to reckon people, carried into a country of hymns, and it is not the Closing's child in a straight line.

In Cut-year 171, a fever started in the crowded holds of ships and spread through the ports on both sides of the Old Crossing, on the Hinge Shore and on the Ledger Coast. People call that summer the Grey Summer, and on the docks it is the Salt-Grey. It was an ordinary disease, not a Tithe. The fever killed people who had a town Tree, a guild ticket, and their prayers said, the same as anyone else. Ships stayed in port all summer. Some grafts went unwatered because the Taken-In, the people the wild has taken partway into itself and given back able to tend living wood, were dead, and a few coastal towns sent their children to a neighbour's Tree the next year. Long-Lived bankers did not die. Their borrowers did, and the debts passed to the families. Afterward, Trenledd began keeping a list of persons, and Dirrol added a column for who was still alive. In Cut-year 174 the small towns of Brenledd put their charters together into one league, so that nobody could set their prices one town at a time. Leddvael made the signing of a contract a public ceremony, because so many witnesses had died.

For about ten years fewer ships sailed toward Heskoren. Deathless clerks still write “Grey + 1” on the back of a note that survived the fever.

In Cut-year 233, the snow on the Rain-Wall in Lirorn melted in one week instead of over a month. People call it the Thaw-Break, and on the ridges the one-week melt. Valleys flooded, people died, and one well-town lost its cistern to silt. The old high road over the Noon Pass was washed out. Narol of the Pass took the toll on the new, lower road, the Shelf-gate, and Narol’s house still collects it. The west road in Saelthael was cut for two summers, so children who should have walked to the Awakening Tree in 233 and 234 went late, went to a neighbour, or missed their week. A graft on its way to Ornled died because the cart was late to the quay. Vathne wrote on a wall, “We will not wait with a hymn for a stick that drowned in someone else’s thaw.” Vathne meant that Ornled would stop praying and waiting for grafts that other countries’ troubles could take away. Ornled still copies that sentence.

In Cut-year 248, at Harrow’s Green, a warden announced copper-green for a child the Tree had actually hugged, because the town wanted a Taken-In. The child was sent to learn a Taken-In’s work, and the green did not take, because there had been no Gift to tend. A visiting Speaker of the First Seat corrected that announcement two years later. It was a person’s doing, not the Tree’s. People call the year the Wrong Green. Speakers still name it when they teach wardens not to announce the colour a town wishes it had.

In Cut-year 280, Ledan, a Long-Lived clerk of the White Note House, wrote to the First Seat to ask which year number to put on a hundred-year loan, because the bank, the borrower’s town, and the Seat each counted the year differently. Cut-year 280 was the bank’s 200th year. The bank still converts its years the way Ledan’s letter did, and Cut-year 387 is the White Note’s 307th year. The letter is under “A clerk’s query.”

From Cut-year 299 to 304, the Hinge Shore and the Ledger Coast fought for five summers over who set the price of crossing the Old Crossing. They seized each other’s ships and blocked each other’s quays. People call those summers the Hinge War. Taerso spoke for the Hinge Shore’s houses, and Sirtol spoke for a group of Ledger Coast charters. In Cut-year 304 they agreed a peace that names no winner. There is one charge for the crossing, called the Hush-rate, and it is still collected. The Hinge Shore gives a blessing to anyone who wants one, and the Ledger Coast writes the paperwork. The same peace covers the far crossing to Heskoren, and Netstrand keeps the ships that sail it. Saelvaeth may receive a graft without paying a blessing-fee to Vaethorn, while Vaethorn may bless a landing and may not tax it. Ornled charges a fee when a ship puts in on the beach. People call the peace the Hinge Hush.

Three old places you can still walk into

Three stone places come from before anyone counted years. Nobody knows when they were built or by whom, and the people who look after them will not let anyone cut a year into them. A party can visit all three. They were found, not founded, and they do not give the Tree a year.

The Low Wall is a low stone wall in Orenbren's lodging-country, off the Near Mile, within the first few days' walk from the Awakening Tree. It is not part of Rothallo's wall, and the stone is a different colour. People who tell you the two walls are the same wall are making a claim. It has three gaps that people use as gates: one widened for carts, one only wide enough for a single person, and one with an old post-socket. Midway along is a stone panel whose letters were chiselled off long ago. The wall ends in the back garden of an inn, where Thuda rents beds in the loft. The Closed Heirs say the wall is theirs. The Watching say it is older than any count. In Cut-year 381, Nurreith and three lodging-guild workers dug under the panel. Delamem, who keeps the Book of Tithes, wanted a chip of stone that matched Rothallo's quarry. It did not match. They filled the hole in the same week.

The Seeing-Ring is a ring of standing stones on a hill in Maiethorn's old Watching country. It is not the Awakening Tree's grove. The stones are set so that a person walking around the ring turns to look outward. Four wider gaps face outward. One faces the Awakening Tree, one faces the Old Crossing, and two face nothing anyone can name. Later someone built a shrine on top of the ring, and later still someone took the roof off and left the steps. Tithsael, of the Watching, keeps a night there every week and lets visitors sit with them, unless the visitor has brought a colour-ribbon to tie on the stones or means to carve a year into them.

The Dry Stair is a flight of steps cut into a rise in Saelthael's dry country, above a small well-town that is not Ornsael. The steps climb to a door-shaped stone with no wall around it and a basin cut in the rock that has never held water in living memory. A tree-warden once planted a cutting in the basin, and it died. Local children dare each other to climb the last step. Behind the basin there is a narrow crawl to a second dry basin lower in the rock.

The memory cup

The memory cup is a late practice among the Long-Lived. It began in the Years of Hands, long after the First Cut, and the circles that keep it do not write down the year it started. It is old enough that people have written about it at length. Long-Lived scholars who are not members have written commentaries on it, and those are kept in the long-houses where the Long-Lived meet. The Motherfaith, the faith that speaks of the Mother, has said what it thinks the cup is, and so have the Watching and the Fair Hand, the faith that dates a bargain from the day it was signed. It is recent enough that a Long-Lived person who walked to the Awakening Tree as a child, before their town had a Tree of its own, can say that nobody did this when they were young.

The group that keeps the cup is the Pourers, also called the Cup Circle. Every Long-Lived person is asked to join once, in person, by a member. A person who says no is not punished, keeps their standing, and is still given a seat in the long-houses. Most Long-Lived people are not members, and all of them know the circle exists.

A member gives one year of their memory into a cup at a time, of their own free will. Each year is its own night, with its own minutes, and the member may stop before the next. The circle asks five years of a member in all, and for each of those years the member adds one drop of their own blood, because the Long-Lived read memory from blood. Afterward the member no longer has the memories of that year. They still need to keep learning, as every Long-Lived person does, and what they lose is a year of remembering, including the deaths of the people they knew in that year.

Members say they give “the memories those years held, and the years themselves.” The second part means two things. For each year given, the member also gives the long-house shelf all the papers they wrote or kept in that year, such as letters, account books, and diaries, and the long-houses that keep the circle stop counting that year in the member’s age, so a member who has given all five years is seated as if five years younger. Among the Long-Lived, age decides who speaks first and who keeps a key, so each gift costs a member rank in those long-houses. Courts, banks, guilds, and Long-Lived who are not members keep counting the ordinary way.

Members can read the cup the way a Long-Lived reads a drop of blood, and what they read is true. One reading can hold several members’ memories of the same year. Members also keep books in the Long-Lived library in Lestrand, on the Ledger Coast, and they make copies of books in the Old Tongue and in the common speech for it. People use those books. Molevad keeps the minutes of the best-known circle in the same library. A second circle meets in an upper room of a lodging-house in Orenbren and does not ask Molevad’s circle for permission.

A member may leave, and the years already given stay in the cup. What comes back to the member is their papers, which members call a thinner copy. The other members stop reading blood with them, and the long-houses that keep the circle stop giving them a seat.

The circle claims that by giving to the cup they made a god, which they call the Poured God, and among themselves the Cup We Made. They say every gift is freely given. That claim is the circle’s belief. The Pourers are a separate group from the Walled Book, and from the Protectors, the quiet house that says it keeps the one Phoenix in its care so the stories will stop arriving at ordinary doors. A Phoenix is the one person in the world who dies and rises again, each time carrying less of who they were.

What nobody knows

Nobody knows who made the First Cut. Five different accounts are told, and this history does not pick one. In one, a parent stole the branch so that no more children would stay UnTurned for want of the trip, or die on the road. In another, a tree-warden cut it before the First Seat allowed cutting. The devout say the Tree let a branch come away. The Watching say people had always grafted trees and the count was added later. The Old Ways say the land received a guest.

Nobody knows how old the Awakening Tree is. It was standing before anyone counted years, and the Watching argue against any date anyone proposes.

Nobody has settled whether there is a Leaf-Mother. People who believe in her ask why her Trees could not Turn children far away until a graft was planted near them, and why Kumbaan has no Tree. Believers do not agree on the answer. Skeptics say distance and soil explain everything, and that the Tree is a plant. This history does not answer the question.

How years are numbered

There is no year-zero that everyone shares. The calendar these counts sit on has the same twelve months, and it has three different days for the new year. The past is the same past. There are seven honest ways to count it, and the number a clerk writes on a debt is a theology, because the year you choose is the place you are willing to start the story from.

Who	What they count from	What it sounds like
First Seat / devout clerks	**the First Cut** — **Cut-years** (in the liturgy, the *Eoloren-count*)	"the 387th Cut-year"
Threnmaieth	Cut-years *and* a **crown-count** from the Two Papers (Cut-year 67; the present is **Crown-year 320**)	a number that wants to be a roll
Lestrand / deathless houses	a **house-founding**, the issue of a note, or the term of a contract	"the 307th summer of the White Note," which is the present; the archival conversion is the **200th**, Ledan's query in Cut-year 280
Vaethorn	**the year our graft took**, or the last actual Turning-Week	a child "turns the year" when the local Tree last managed a fall, and that is already how Vaethorn starts its calendar
the Watching	they **refuse the Cut-count**	a count laid over the Tree is not an epoch, because the Tree was already seeing
the Old Ways	a closed door, a drowning-year, or a guest that took	the Years of Hands are when guests arrived, not when history began
Kumbaan	**moons**	the mainland ages are a sailor's chart, and Kumbaan does not owe that chart a count

The present is Cut-year 387, the 387th summer since the First Cut. It is not a round number chosen to look finished.

What nobody can date is older than that number. The Awakening Tree is older than any reliable dating, and Before the Walk has no start. Who made the First Cut is contested, and the argument is kept without a winner. Believers ask why her Trees reached the far lands late, and skeptics say there is no Leaf-Mother. The Low Wall, the Seeing-Ring, and the Dry Stair are stone places from before the walk. People found them standing. They carry no builder's name.

Cut-year 0 is a graft. It is the first witnessed copy of living wood, and it is not the first Condition, not the first Giving, and not the Tree's birthday. The Giving, and the walk that carried children to it, have no start year. Becoming at a door is older than the walk. Being born a Kind is older than both.

The Other Count

The years on this table are the dated ones inside Cut-year 0 to Cut-year 387 that are not the spread of grafts. Two clocks still organize that past. One counts how you were Turned, by a walk or under a

town Tree. The other counts where the wood has reached. These three hundred and eighty-seven summers also held a war, a split over paper, a fever, a flood, and a hush that is still the peace on the Old Crossing. This count sits beside the clocks. It does not take their place. A clerk who writes only Eoloren-years can still be asked what the Grey Summer did to a note. A hearth in Vaethorn that dates itself from “the year our graft took” can still owe a hull-fee under the Hinge Hush.

In the Walking Years the grove at the origin was not open to everyone who arrived. A class of the untithed, people of whom no Tithe was asked, sat on Thaeloren and decided who might walk up to it. They were a gate that grew a country around the one Tree, and not a banner planted on all three continents. Strandoren paid for the Salt Walk and was never a province of that gate. Heskoren lay beyond a ride from that gate, and Kumbaan was not in the story. Who held the nameless knife, the person who made the first cut, is still unwritten. The First Seat stays in the wood. Rothallo, still called the Inner Close, is a walled city inside Orenbren, and it is Orenbren’s capital. It is not a sixteenth power.

Cut-years	Everyday name	Kind	What it left
Cut-year 19–38	**the Closing**	war / political	The First Cut gave a town a Tree of its own. The old Closed Seat tried to pull the copies up and could not. The Seat collapsed, and what remained went behind the Inner Close.
Cut-year 67	**the Two Papers**	political / dynastic (paper, not blood)	One hymn-country became Maiethvael and Threnmaieth. The crown-count starts here, and the present is **Crown-year 320**.
Cut-year 171	**the Grey Summer**	epidemic	Quay-fever on the Old Crossing. It was an epidemic, not a Tithe. Trenledd began writing persons down. Brenledd piled a compact in Cut-year 174. Leddvael made the signing of a contract a civic rite.
Cut-year 233	**the Thaw-Break**	natural	Snow on the Rain-Wall, in Lirorn, melted in one week. The Noon Pass was lost and the Shelf-gate was taken. The west road was cut for two summers. An Ornled graft that was waiting died, and a gospel was refused.
Cut-year 248	**the Wrong Green**	Tree / civic	A hug was announced as copper-green, and the wound was a human one. This is not one of the five years that were not about the Tree. It sits on the table because the year is already written.
Cut-year 280	**Ledan's query**	archival dating	The White Note House was in its 200th summer. Ledan is Long-Lived, and the conversion Ledan wrote is still the habit of the house. The present house-year is **307**.
Cut-year 299–304	**the Hinge War → the Hinge Hush**	inter-power / treaty	The Hinge Shore and the Ledger Coast fought over who set the tolls on the hinge. The hush is the peace that still governs the Old Crossing, and it carries a West Water clause that Netstrand still quotes.

The present year is Cut-year 387. Who cut remains unpicked. A chronicle that writes a first king onto the Before is laying a later story on a time that was left uncounted. The Watching warn against that.

Maiethorn is what followed the grove-gate: lodging, gift, reckoning, hinge, thaw, and dry sowing. Those are six successors of one gate, not six ancient kingdoms. Strandoren is what the Salt Walk became once the gate was dead and the fever had made people write new paper. Heskoren came into

the clocks late, and host-rights were already there. Waiting, sowing, and slate are three answers to the same cart that arrived late, not three eternal peoples. Borders and hull-clauses have causes. They do not have a first king.

What a traveller notices, besides the wood, is often a date that will not sit still. A debt can carry three dates, and a fourth if the note survived the Grey Summer: a Cut-year, a house-year, the year a graft took, and “the summer after the fever.” A kitchen still will not send a child through the Inner Close’s gate, and cannot say whether the fear is the Book or the older Closed Seat. In Lirorn, a stone on the pass has a water-line over the old ribbon-notch, above the mark where a ribbon used to be tied. A quay on the Hinge Shore charges the Hush-rate and will not call it a victory. The Watching keep a night on a ring of stones that is older than any Cut-year anyone will write down.

What follows is an unsigned conversion table, filed in the White Note’s founding-book after Ledan’s query. The front of the sheet is in Eoloren-years, and the back is in the house’s own years. A third hand has added, in dock-ink, “Grey + 1” beside 172.

> *280 = White Note 200. 304 = the Hush, do not discount. 171 is not a Cut we honor and is not a founding. If the debtor’s grandparent died in the Grey, the note still stands. If the debtor’s town dates from a taking, ask which taking. Do not ask the Close for a year. They will rank you.*

Spread of the wave

The bands below are enough to keep the geography honest. They are not a campaign almanac.

Cut-years	Where the wood went
Cut-year 0	the First Cut, near Thaeloren, on Maiethorn. The first witnessed graft.
Cut-year 0–80	Maiethorn filling. The origin-towns, nearest the Awakening Tree, came first, and the Rain-Shadow was slower.
Cut-year 40–160	Strandoren by sea. The wealthy coasts came first, and the deep interior later.
Cut-year 200–387	Heskoren, still incomplete. The luckiest towns have had a local Turning for a few generations, and whole districts still wait.
never	Kumbaan. The wood never crossed.

A freshly planted scion, the cutting kept alive on the road, still takes a generation to hold a Leaf-Fall. So the year a graft arrives and the year a town Turns its own children under its own canopy are twenty

years apart. Heskoren's waiting is not only the queue. It is the queue, and then the childhood of the wood. The forty years in which no graft reached Heskoren at all, about Cut-year 160 to 200, are told under "The gap."

What the two clocks did

These are the lasting effects of the two clocks on law, money, the clergy, language, the map, and faith.

Law. Citizenship because someone local saw you Turned is the ordinary way belonging works in the Years of Hands. In the Walking Years the town that saw you Turn was the crowd under Thaeloren, or it was nobody, if you never arrived. Children in the far lands who stayed UnTurned were not simply missing from a roll. They were unwitnessed as Given, because they did not make the trip. People invented ways to carry that original witness home across the distance: a Long-Lived person who remembers the fall at the origin, the word of someone Bound, who swore a contract in extremity and whose sworn word holds, and the feeling of someone Far-Voiced, whose voice carries a feeling exactly as far and as true as they mean it to. That vouching at a distance was made so the origin's witness could travel. The Struck who were never vouched for are older than the grafts, because a becoming on a far threshold was always unwitnessed. The Grafting did not invent that unease. It localized who is expected to have been seen, and it put that expectation in the town where the person lives.

Money. Many of the deathless houses, the houses of the Long-Lived, began as road-houses. They were inns, they held endowments, and they extended credit across a century to families who had to walk. When the walk stopped being required in the core, the lands nearest the Awakening Tree, those houses still had a Long-Lived memory of every debtor on the road, and they had paper that outlived the pilgrimage season. They became banks. The endow-not-inherit loop, in which a house is endowed rather than passed to an heir, is older than the Years of Hands. The trusted note, the paper a house will still honour years later, is an instrument from the Walking Years, and it outlived the road it was written for. The same houses are still here, with a different business, and the banking people use now is old.

Clergy. Cutting-leave is how the First Seat captured a practice that had begun without the Seat's permission. People argued the first successful cut as theft, as mercy, as the Tree offering a branch, and as old horticulture that the Motherfaith later gave a name. The Seat won the authorization, the right to say which cutting may be made. The scion-queue is the Grafting's child. It is the waiting list that appears, and the bottleneck with it, when someone has the power to decide which town is next.

Language. The pilgrimage kept the old speech from drifting. Once a year, people from far away walked to the same grove and heard the same liturgy, so the Old Tongue stayed nearer to itself along the road. When a town had its own Tree, its children grew up where they were born, and the speech grew there with them. That is why the drift in the Old Tongue follows how thin the Trees are, and why Lestrand moved so far from the old speech, and so quickly. Lestrand had trade, it had a canopy of its

own, and nobody there needed to walk to the Motherwood, the grove of the Awakening Tree. The Old Tongue split into three daughter-drifts, later speeches descended from that root where the Trees grew thin: one that Threnmaieth still keeps close to the liturgy, a worn speech on the Vaethorn frontier, where the written name Vaethorn is said Wetorn, and an eroded speech on the Lestrand coast, which moved the farthest and the fastest. Those three belong to the Years of Hands, sitting on a root the Walking Years had held nearer to itself.

Geography. The graded reach of the Trees across the map is the Grafting as it stands in Cut-year 387. Maiethorn is old in the Years of Hands, and its towns have had their own Trees for a long time. Strandoren is mature in those same years, and the commerce that carried the grafts is still in the way the country works. Heskoren is the Grafting in this decade, the place the wood is arriving now. Kumbaan never entered either clock. To someone living in the world, this reads as distance and as history, and that reading is true as far as it goes.

Faith. The Watching remember Before the Walk as the Before, a seeing before anyone had called the Tree a mother, and they will not start history at a Cut. The Old Ways were already becoming, already taking a Condition at their own doors, before any pilgrim road existed, and for them the Years of Hands are when guests arrived late. The Fair Hand dates a contract from the day it was signed, not from the First Cut in the wood, and it treats the Grafting as a fact about the supply of wood. The Open Table, the faith kept on Kumbaan, which grew with no Tree, owes these ages nothing. It does not count its life from them.

What a traveller notices

- A Long-Lived person says “I walked,” and the room goes quiet. That is the personal clock, how you were Turned, spoken as a life.
- A mile-shrine stands on a road that now ends at a town Tree. The stone was set for a Turning that no longer has to happen on that road. The devout still leave a ribbon on it, and the town’s children climb it.
- An old inn lets its upper room, once full of pilgrim-beds, to merchants, and the beds are empty of pilgrims. The deathless house that owns the inn still dates its notes from the founding-summer, the summer those beds were full.
- One debt carries three dates for the same summer: a Cut-year, a house-year, and the year the graft took. A fourth date appears if the note survived the Grey Summer.
- A hamlet on Heskoren still sends its ten-year-olds to walk to a neighbour, and that walk is this year’s necessity, not a history the hamlet has decided to perform.
- Someone names a Phoenix as a way to mark an era, “the Phoenix of the last Walking summer,” and nobody in the room agrees which summer that was.

A clerk’s query (Cut-year 280)

What follows is a query from a clerk of the White Note to a Speaker of the First Seat, written in Cut-year 280, the house’s 200th summer. It is filed in the founding-book, and the desk still reaches for it when two counts have to be set side by side. Ledan, the clerk, is Long-Lived. Mataero, in Cut-year 387, is still junior to Ledan. The back of the sheet has been folded around a second number.

> *Ledan of the White Note, to the Speaker who keeps the Eoloren-count.*
>
> *The house writes a century-loan from our founding-summer, which we call the 200th of the White Note. The debtor in Wetorn writes the same summer as the year their graft took. Your college will write it as the 280th Cut-year if I have the conversion right, and as the 279th if I have it wrong.*
>
> *Which number should stand on the note so that in fifty years the same person still owes us? We do not ask which summer was holy. We ask which summer a court will still be able to find.*

In Cut-year 387 the house is in its 307th summer, and Ledan still asks which number a court can find.

Before the Walk

Before the Walk is the unnamed preface. The Awakening Tree was already standing before anyone had a year to set it in. People already had Kinds, and some had already become something at doors the later faiths would struggle to place. This stretch of time has no honest start. The ages that follow it are the spine above.

Most of the world does not have a name for this time. The devout skip it, and skeptics call it “before anyone bothered to walk,” which is a shrug, not a chronicle. The one name that is still lived, rather than shrugged off, is kept by a single faith.

The Watching keep that name: the Before. In their telling the world was Kind and Kind alone, what people already were and not yet anything they became, and then the Tree was already there, watching. The Giving, their name for the later story in which people began to be Given, came after the Watching. The Mother-name, the later story that calls the Tree a mother, came after that. Each of those is a later layer, and each layer is a story laid over a seeing.

The Old Ways do not grant that becoming waited on a road. Heskoren’s people already crossed doors, a drowning, a grove, a stone, before any pilgrim mile. When the Walking Years arrived as a foreign traffic, they were not the beginning of history. They were the beginning of company.

Kumbaan’s hill-history does not owe Thaeloren a preface. The Open Table grew there with no Tree and no Mother-name.

What can be said without inventing kings is only this. The origin Tree is the one Tree no one grafted from another. Nobody grew it from a cutting of some earlier tree, and it was not planted in a remembered summer. Far from it, people lived as they lived. Some were Struck at thresholds because thresholds exist: a door was already there, and a person became something at it, with no journey organized to bring that about. Some were never either Given or Struck, because there was no local fall to miss. Where nothing nearby offered a fall, they were not people who had failed to attend one. When people organized the tenth-year trip, and a child’s tenth year became a journey households could plan, the Walking Years began. That organization is the start of the walk, not the start of the world.

None of it is dated. That is the point. A later chronicle that discovers a first king, a first war, or a first sermon in this era is laying a story that has a beginning over a seeing that was never given one. The Low Wall, the Seeing-Ring, and the Dry Stair can still be walked into. They do not start a year.

The Walking Years

Once there was only the Awakening Tree, and a child’s tenth-year Turning, standing under that Tree where they might be Given what they would become, meant a walk to it. Families who could not make the trip stayed UnTurned for want of it, never Given, and folk called them Kept, so the far reaches ran heavy on the UnTurned and the Struck as the ordinary count, not as an edge. Everyday speech calls the time the Walking Years. The liturgical name is Brenvaeth *(BREN-vaeth)*, “the hearth gone to the waiting.” It grows out of Before the Walk with no dated start.

In these years the Leaf-Fall happened in one place: one grove, on Maiethorn, under Thaeloren. A tenth summer was a journey, or it was no Leaf-Fall at all, because you were not there.

The far-flung who stayed home were not people a town could prove a goddess had skipped. They were children who did not walk. Some were later Struck at a drowning, an oath, or a death, a becoming with no leaf and no crowd, because the only crowd that counted was a continent away. Some stayed UnTurned for life, wanted or not, because want of a trip is a distance, not a theology.

This is where today’s thin reach comes from, stated as a fact of the map. Thin reach used to mean far from the one Tree. After the First Cut, thin reach came to mean places where the Trees are young, sick, or few, which is why a hamlet next door to a dying scion can be “far” in the old sense without being far on a map.

The pilgrimage did not vanish when grafts began. It changed jobs. In the Years of Hands the devout still walk to the origin, and the poor and the Tree-bereaved still walk to a neighbour. The Walking

Years are the time when everyone who Turned as Given had walked, or had been carried.

The later romance of the old mile is a feeling from the Years of Hands, laid on graves from the Walking Years.

The era has no dated start. It grows out of Before the Walk when the trip becomes the way to Turn. It has a dated hinge, the First Cut, at Cut-year 0. After that the Walking Years cease to be the default in lands the wood has reached, and they remain the default in lands it has not. Heskoren is still, in places, in this era. That is this year’s road, not a metaphor.

The door is one week

Turning-Week is the week around the High Solstice in Eolthael, the month people also call Turning-month, because that month holds the sun’s high turning. Every child who has turned ten since the last High Solstice Turns that week, under Thaeloren, or they do not Turn as Given at all.

If the child misses that week, the door has shut for good, and an eleven-year-old who reaches the origin the following summer is only a visitor, because the Tree’s Given-door is that tenth-year group, in that week, and not a standing appointment you can make up later. Doors that Strike a person still open afterward, elsewhere, with no leaf and no crowd. That later mercy was always the far lands’ other path.

This is why families from any distance left early, and why the richest or most frightened households from far away spent a whole year at the origin. A nine-year-old wintered in a road-house so the child could not miss. That held-over child is the expensive mercy. Everyone else gambled one summer.

Towns that later grew a Tree of their own did not grow a second door. A fever in your own square during Eolthael shuts the week the same way a late arrival on the Long Mile does. There is still no year in which an older child is Given because they tried.

Three walks, not one road

People named the walks in the common tongue, because the walk was a problem of food and berths before it was a liturgy.

Walk	Who used it	How long	What it cost
the Near Mile	Maiethorn inland, anyone already on the Motherland	three to twelve days	a harvest-timing; almost everyone who meant to come, came
the Salt Walk	Strandoren: ship the Old Crossing, then the Near Mile	three to five days' sail plus the inland days; usually one to three weeks in all	a berth in fair weather; miss the last crossing and you miss the year
the Long Mile	Heskoren, and the Strandoren interior before the coasts were rich	six to twelve weeks	a year's surplus, or a road-house note, or you did not go

On the road, people did not say Brenvaeth. They said "We are on the Long Mile," or "We took the salt." The later names still sort by who is speaking. Vaethorn, in the Waiting Lands, calls the whole past the waiting-road. Lestrand, on the Ledger Coast, files it as the road-years. Threnmaieth, the Tallied Crown, wants the miles on a roll.

The timing sat against the year, and the month names are the mainland's. Near-Mile families left in Haelren, which people also call Hale-month, when the land is counted sound, or in early Eolthael, and were home by Vaelorn, Gift-month, after the Turning, when the colours settle. Salt-Walk households watched the Old Crossing from Saelorn, Seed-month, the first green, and a late storm in Hale-month left an UnTurned child. Long-Mile columns left in Liren, the Thaw, when the water runs again, or in Saelorn, and hoped the High Solstice had not happened without them. Some arrived in Leddorn, which people call Ledger-month, the late-summer markets, with a ten-year-old who had already missed. The road-houses knew that silence. They did not charge extra for it. They also did not refund the note.

No walk crossed the storm-wall to Kumbaan.

Who could afford it

The Near Mile was a civic season. Whole towns moved a short way together, and a poor child walked in a neighbour's dust. The cost was real, lost labour and a week of food, and it was rarely what decided whether a child went.

The Salt Walk sorted people by cash and weather. Coastal wealth on Strandoren bought berths. The interior of Strandoren was already "far" in these years, even though the coasts would later be rich in Trees. A family might send the Turning-child and one adult, and leave the rest. Guilds sometimes advanced a berth against a future colour, so that a Given Answered, a person an element has gone on answering, or a Far-Voiced was worth the loan, while a hug was a debt with no new trade in it. The Fair Hand would later call this a term. In Brenvaeth it was just the quay.

The Long Mile sorted people by whether you could lose a year. You needed food, shoes, a second adult if you had one, and the note you signed at the first road-house that would take it. Many could not afford that. Those who could often could not afford it for every child.

The split household is the era's ordinary cruelty. A family with three children near ten could sometimes walk one of them, so the one who walked might come home Given, and the ones who stayed were UnTurned, or were Struck later at a local door, and grew up in the same kitchen as a sibling the origin had seen. Distance did this. Vaethorn's later guilt, the sermon that says "we wait because we are unworthy," is a reading from the Years of Hands laid over that fact. The miles do not agree with the guilt.

Old Ways households on Heskoren often refused the walk on purpose. Their children were already the land's. Motherfaith neighbours, counting a child by whether the trip had been made, read those children as UnTurned for want of the trip, which is a misreading the walk itself cannot correct. Both families are telling the truth they have.

Who was let through

Distance and coin were not the only things that sorted a child. A class of the untithed sat on Thaeloren and decided who might stand under it. Folk called them the Closed Seat, and also the Grove-Sitters. A family could have shoes and a Salt-Walk berth and still be turned away at the gate. Grove-leave was the paper you carried to that gate if you hoped to be let through.

Far lands ran heavy on the UnTurned because some children did not walk, and because some children walked and were turned away. Both of those fill a kitchen. The later romance of the old mile prefers the children who never started, and the folk songs remember the ones who arrived and were turned from the gate.

The Closed Seat was a gate at the origin, not an empire of the world. Strandoren paid the crossing and was never a province of that gate, while Heskoren lay beyond a gate's ride. When a Near-Mile town Turned under a copy, the gate was no longer the only seeing. The war that tried to make that untrue is the Closing, told in "A history in order." The road was already a life. The gate was a third cruelty laid on it.

Who died

Children died on the road, and so did the adults who carried them. They died at river crossings in the thaw, of a fever in a packed Near-Mile inn, in a late squall on the Old Crossing, of hunger on a Long-Mile stretch between hearths, and in a birth that would not wait for the grove. This is not a slaughter-age and not a hymn. It is a problem of getting people down a long road, and long roads kill people.

The graves are mostly unmarked at first. Then someone sets a stone at a day’s walk, because the next column needs to know the water, and because a name should sit somewhere. A ribbon goes on the stone the year after, and a later column uses the stone as a mile-mark. The romance and the graves are the same object seen at two hours of the day.

A child who dies on the way to be witnessed may Strike as Returned on the road. A Returned is a person who died with something unfinished and whose purpose keeps them walking, so this was a becoming with no crowd, on the way to the only crowd that counted. It is rare, and it is remembered.

The origin also filled with children who arrived and had no one to walk home with. Road-houses took some in, and a bed became a life. Origin-towns took some. A Given child with no one to carry the witness home is the other half of the grave: they lived, and belonging still had to be invented for them.

Far reaches as the rule

In Brenvaeth, a land far from Thaeloren was heavy with the UnTurned and the Struck because most ten-year-olds never stood under the canopy. That was not a curiosity of the frontier. It was how the world worked anywhere the walk was too far or too dear.

The Given were the ones who had been there, a minority that shrank as the miles piled up. They came home as people who could do work the town could not otherwise grow, and as people the town had not watched become.

The UnTurned were the ordinary far childhood, because they never stood under the Tree. They were whole, untithed, and unwitnessed as Given, and folk called them Kept. The few who walked and were hugged were Kept in the strict sense, kept by the Tree with no colour. Some of the UnTurned were wanted that way. Some were the price of a summer the family could not raise. Some were Old Ways children the Motherfaith had misfiled.

The Struck were the far lands’ other door, and they always had been. A drowning, an oath, or a death made them, with no leaf and no origin-crowd. The unease that follows the Struck is older than the grafts. The walk only made it louder, because the Given in the same town had been seen, a continent away.

When the wood later travelled, this pattern moved. A pocket with few Trees, next to a dying scion, reads the same way on a count of who was seen, and it is not far on a map. Some of today’s Heskoren is still Brenvaeth, this year, for this group of children. Some of it is a neighbour’s canopy and a queue. Both can be true on the same road.

Institutions of the road

There was no travelling church with offices in these years. Tree-wardens who carry grafts belong to the Years of Hands. In Brenvaeth the origin-hearth was the only Speaking that counted, the only place where a speaker under Thaeloren could name what a child had become and have that naming travel. Far towns had no Tree to tend, so what the road had was inns, stones, and summer traffic.

Mile-shrines

A mile-shrine is a stone at about a day's walk, with water if the ground allows, a flat top where a pack can sit, and often a name and a ribbon.

They begin as graves and waymarks in the same act. You bury someone where the column had to stop, and the next year the stop is the place you aim for. The devout later leave ribbons for the Tree, children later climb the stones, and Hands-towns later argue about pulling them down, because the road now ends at a local canopy and the stone is in the way. The stone does not know which story it is in.

A ribbon is not a leaf-colour. People tie what they have, so a copper-green scrap on a Long-Mile stone does not mean a Taken-In died there, even when a traveller who has only heard the romance reads the green that way. Travellers who have walked once know the difference. Travellers who have only heard the romance do not.

Road-houses

Many deathless houses began on this road. In Brenvaeth they were road-houses: beds, porridge, a dry room, and credit for a walk you could not miss twice.

The everyday name is road-house. The cant is brenhael *(BREN-hael)*, from *bren* and *hael*, "the hearth kept whole." The Waiting Lands say waiting-hearth. The Ledger Coast says the bed-house, and still means the bank. The Tallied Crown would like them on the roll.

What a road-house actually sold was ordinary, and several later institutions are that ordinary thing with a different job.

They sold a bed in the two crowded months, and a quieter bed in the other ten. Held-over nine-year-olds were the winter trade. An empty pilgrim-bed in an upper room of the Years of Hands used to be this bed, in the season when the road was full.

They sold a note. You eat now, and you pay at the origin, or on the way home, or when the child is grown, or when a sibling walks next year. The Long-Lived innkeeper forgets none of it, which is why the paper will outlive the pilgrimage season and become the trusted note. In the act, it is an innkeeper who will still know your name in fifty years, which is a kindness and a leash.

They kept a little furnishing for a Tithe, improvised, and not a guild. A green-lot behind the house was there for a Taken-In parent, and a shed was there so a Far-Voiced could cry without taking the dormitory with them. The road itself is novelty enough that a Long-Lived innkeeper's own Tithe stays fed, which is why the deathless stayed in the trade, and why the same people later endow libraries: the hunger that kept them on the mile is the hunger that built the archive. Brenvaeth had a pot and a shed.

They kept a held bed. A family said they would come, and they did not, so the innkeeper keeps the bed a year, then two, then as a habit that looks like hospitality and functions as a shrine. The slate below is one of those beds, still being made.

The White Note's founding-summer is a house-year, not a Cut-year. In the Walking Years that house was a hearth with too many boots by the door. This is the same fortune, earlier.

Summer traffic

For two months the Near Mile is a moving town, columns and dust, with Far-Voiced cries carrying from ridge to ridge: the road is full, the ford is wrong, a child is down. The Two-Bodied, people who carry a second animal self and can use it at will, range the edges, because the ranging is the Tithe and the column is a herd to keep. Markets grow at the mile-shrines and vanish when Eolthael ends. Then the road is empty and local, and the road-house counts the notes.

There were no pilgrim-knights and no official convoy. People walked with whoever left the same week. A Bound's word might hold a column together for a fortnight, and a Bound cannot cheaply lie about what they swear. A Kept adult with no Tithe to manage was, then as now, the person who could carry the extra pack.

Witness at the origin, or not at all

Belonging because your own town saw you Turn comes later, with the Years of Hands. In Brenvaeth the town that saw you Turn was the crowd under Thaeloren, or it was no one.

Going home did not bring that crowd with you. Your village had not watched. Belonging at home required someone who had been under the boughs to stand for you: a parent, a neighbour from the column, or a Long-Lived who keeps origin-falls the way they later keep town-falls. Vouching at a distance was invented to carry the origin's witness home. The three pillars of that vouch, Long-Lived memory, a Bound's word, and a Far-Voiced feeling, are older than the grafts. The job of carrying a far Turning is what belongs to the Walking Years.

A Given child with no surviving witness is thin in the law of the place they grew up. Origin-orphans, road-house children, and a Bound stranger who will swear the colour they did not see, and who cannot cheaply lie, are all versions of that thinness. The unvouched are older than the unease that later attached to the Struck, and they include people the Tree did Give.

Someone Struck on the road carries a double unease: an unwitnessed becoming, and that becoming happening on the way to the witnessing. A Returned child may walk the last days of the Near Mile beside the parent who has not yet forgiven the threshold.

Staying home meant you were never witnessed as Given. You were still of your town, because your town had watched you be a child. An UnTurned child was not a blank on a roll that had never been written. Folk called such children Kept, though no Tree had hugged them.

The origin-crowd was enormous in Eolthael and ordinary the rest of the year. Speakers of the origin-hearth named colours until their voices went. The colours were already known to folk. The warden's word made them count for people who would have to carry that word home.

Long-Lived who still say "I walked"

A Long-Lived person who says "I walked" is saying when they were young, and the memory of that walk is perfect even when what they mean by the sentence is not. There is no single Long-Lived account.

At present, Cut-year 387, the sentence does at least four jobs, and the people who say it argue about which job is being done.

Some mean they walked as a child, under Thaeloren, before their town had wood. A Long-Lived person on Maiethorn who was Given in the late Walking, among the last cohorts in the core before Maiethorn filled during the first Cut-years, is speaking of a summer most of the room has only as a ribbon. A Long-Lived person on Heskoren may mean last decade. The words are the same. The wood reached their towns at different times.

Some mean they walked the mile as the inn, and a road-house Long-Lived may never have stood under the canopy as a pilgrim at all. They walked the same stretch every summer for two hundred years, so they remember every debtor, and they will not always tell you which children came back.

Some remember the graves and will not call them holy. These are the skeptics among the deathless, and they say the road was bodies and bad fords. They are sincere, and they still tear up at a ribbon, which they will not explain.

Some remember the graves and will not call them a problem of logistics. These are the devout among the deathless, and they say every stone was a waiting. They are sincere, and they still know which ford killed which name, which they will tell you whether you asked or not.

A Blood-Read, a Long-Lived reading of the memory in a drop of blood, will give you a true fragment of a walk. It will not tell you which of the four jobs the living speaker is doing.

They also disagree with Seat chronicles that start history at the First Cut. A Long-Lived person who walked as a child, and a clerk who counts Cut-years, will fight about the same summer, and both can

be honest, though only one of them was there.

What a character notices

- In Hale-month the Near Mile is dusty with people on the move, and in Ledger-month that same road has no dust on it, because the walking season is over.
- A mile-shrine carries a ribbon and the scuffs of someone climbing it, and a child of the Years of Hands looking at the stone does not know it was a grave.
- An inn's upper room has more beds than the present trade can fill, and the house still dates its notes from a founding-summer when those beds were full.
- A held bed has not been let in anyone's living mortal memory. The innkeeper can tell you the name on it. They will not tell you whether they think the child is dead, or Kept, or of the Old Ways, or was never born.
- A pair of siblings will not walk the same side of a road. One of them is Given, and the other never stood under a Tree, so that second child is UnTurned, though folk still call them Kept.
- A Far-Voiced cry goes out along a ridge in the old pattern, "the ford is wrong." No column answers. Birds do.
- Someone at a table says "I walked," and the room sorts itself by who goes quiet.

A Turning-Week slate

What follows is a Turning-Week slate from the third hearth on the Near Mile, kept by Thilim, who is Long-Lived and has kept this house since before the Cut, as later clerks would say. The back of the sheet is knife-scored with tally-marks that do not match the front.

> *Eolthael, the summer the ford ran high.*
>
> *Beds: forty-and-two spoken for. Notes out: Tora of the long cape, two people, pay on the home-walk. Valein of the salt, one person, paid at the quay. The Held: Seine of the far cape — tenth summer, not come. Hold the bed. The mother said next year. Next year was last year.*
>
> *Porridge: enough. Shed: the blue-leaf girl from the second column cried the rafters quiet; no charge; we needed the quiet. Green-lot: used. The Taken-In man from the long cape left a cutting. I put it in the pot. It is not a Tree.*
>
> *I do not ask which summer was holy. I ask which people will be here at dark. The Held bed is made. If Seine comes I will not have to remember I made it for nothing.*

The cutting in the pot is not a First Cut. It is a Taken-In man who missed his green, and Thilim put the cutting in the pot and wrote that it was not a Tree.

The First Cut

Someone cut living wood from Thaeloren, or from a branch that came away in a hand, carried it a day's earth, married it to new ground, and it took. A town on the Near Mile Turned a generation later under a canopy that was not the origin's, which is to say the town stood its own child under a local tree. Everyday speech calls it the First Cut. The liturgical name is Eoloren *(EOL-or-en)*, "the witnessed hinge." The clerical count of years starts here, so this taking is Cut-year 0 and the present year is Cut-year 387.

Everyone agrees that a first town-graft succeeded. It happened within a day's living earth of Thaeloren, close enough that a cut could still be green when it met the new ground. That much is horticulture, the keeping of living wood, and not a theology. No two houses agree whose story the cut is, and this account does not pick a winner for them.

The first green is not named. Folk who need an object to point at call it the nameless green. Naming the town would pick a hearth, and a hearth would pick a hand.

In the Walking Years the origin was not an open grove. The Closed Seat decided who might walk in to it. Distance was one way they sorted a child, and grove-leave was the other. A local Tree meant you did not need their gate. That is the monopoly the Cut broke, and it is not a sixth story about whose hand held the knife. The five stories still disagree about the hand, and they can agree about what the copy did. The Closed Seat tried to uproot the copies, and they could not. The war, the collapse, and the retreat are the Closing. Who cut stays unwritten there too. The riders fought a pot, and they never learned a face.

A freshly planted scion still takes a generation to hold a Leaf-Fall. So Cut-year 0 is a wound in wood, and the first local Turning is about twenty summers later. "A graft arrived" and "this town Turns under its own canopy" are never the same year. The wave is slow because each Hand has to grow up before it can be a source for the next cut.

The five attributions

The five stories are not speeches someone stands up and recites. They are jobs a room is already doing, and which job the room is doing is a faster read than any creed. Who cut stays unpicked. All five stay in use.

Folk: the stolen branch

Folk tell the cut as a theft that was also a mercy. A parent who would not watch another child stay UnTurned for want of a trip the family could not make, or who would not bury another child on the Near Mile, took wood without leave.

The object people keep is the nameless knife, and it is not a saint. Some hearths hang a kitchen-knife on a ribbon, the way children in the Years of Hands climb the mile-shrines, and they cannot say whether they are honouring a theft or a gift. There is no name on the handle.

Thief-songs on the Near Mile are walking-songs, and the singers say “we” for the cutter. A singer from the Salt Walk turns it into a joke on the quay and calls it the first unpaid berth. Versions from the Long Mile are not funny. Vaethorn’s later guilt wants this parent to have been unworthy. The songs do not agree.

Folk-right cutting did not stop when the Seat wrote a leave. A Taken-In with a sick neighbour and no year to spare will still take a slip, a small cutting. Most of those slips die. The ones that take are how the queue learns that it is not the only horticulture in the world. Road-hands call a stolen slip a problem. Towns that lived through a stolen year call it a year they Turned.

In this telling, the later Cutting-leave fee is a fine that forgot it was a fine. Lestrand will broker that fee without blushing, which is this same story with a clerk. What the telling leaves out is that a stolen Hand still left a town behind that did not get the next one. The songs leave that town and go on.

Clergy: the warden ahead of the college

In the clergy’s telling, a tree-warden of a Near-Mile hearth cut with a leave that did not yet exist. The wood took. The hearth at the origin spent the generation of argument, from Cut-year 0 into the first local Leaf-Fall, trying to decide whether the taking was blight, theft, or rite. The First Seat as a desk that issues Cutting-leave is what that argument left sitting on the ground. The Road-hands are the scandal moved into an office. They are the people who walk what used to be done without sanction.

Speakers who will not say “first” are part of how the office lives. A Speaker will say “the witnessed hinge.” They will date a note. They will not point at a grave. Some of them are skeptics who will grant the horticulture and refuse the saint. Some of them are devout, and they think that naming a cutter would steal the offering from the Tree. It is the same silence, doing two jobs.

After the first copy, the Motherwood tried to forbid any further cut. Wood died in pots anyway, and neighbours cut anyway. Forbidding a copy that had already taken is how a college learns that it does not own the Tree’s living wood. It owns only the authorization, the right to say which next cut is allowed.

The Road-hands were not designed as a church that travels. They are the generation of argument, given a cart. What this telling leaves out is that “we will write how, not who” is how a heresy becomes a monopoly. The college writes the how.

Devout: the Tree offered

In the devout telling, a branch came away in a hand. There was no theft in it, and no genius, only a Hand giving a Hand. The Mother, or the Tree if you will not say Mother, meant the wood to travel. This is the version the Seat prefers when it preaches, because it makes the scion-queue sound like stewardship rather than like a ration.

At Turning-Week in the Motherwood, a Speaker says she sent her hands outward so the hearths could stay. On a good day the graves of the Walking Years are named in the same breath. On a bad day they are not.

The watering-words, the words said when the wood is married to new ground, are offered as proof. The devout ask why the wood would listen if that rite were only horticulture. A skeptic’s answer is that you watered it. Both of those people can stand under the same canopy.

In this telling, Cutting-leave is a blessing. Vaethorn calls it the wood’s blessing, and the devout need that name. Without it the queue is only a list of who waits. What the telling leaves out is that “she meant the wood to travel” narrates a wave that went to paying coasts before it went to the poor far. The thing saved, when anything was, was a walk, and it was not everyone’s walk.

The Watching: horticulture, then a later name

The Watching say people had always been able to cut living wood. They grafted fruit, kept kin in orchards, and set a slip in a pot. The Motherfaith later named one of those cuts the First and started a count from it, a later name laid on a thing people were already doing. The Tree was already seeing. A date does not make a mother.

They refuse the Cut-count. A Watcher clerk will date a debt from a house-year, or from a drowning-year, or from a night they kept. They will convert the date into the Eoloren-count if a court makes them, and they will not call that count history.

Watcher hearths on Maiethorn still graft ordinary pears in the same week a Road-hand passes with carrying-earth, the living earth a cutting has to travel in. They do not think the pear is a joke. They think the pear is the whole argument, done with hands.

They withhold the word “first” in the same cadence as a blessing they withhold. What they will say is that what was cut was seen, and what took was seen, and that the Tree does not reach twice by chance. There is no Mother in that sentence, and no epoch. What the telling leaves out is that refusing the date

does not refuse the wave, because children still died on the road until the copies took. The later name is only a name. The graves were already in the ground.

The Old Ways: the land received a guest

In the Old Ways telling, nobody “cut” in the sense the Seat means. A grove took kin in. The Hands, the years of local trees, are when guests began arriving from the east, and host-rights start there, not in a warrant from a college.

The first meal for a new graft is food left at the planting, the way you feed a guest before you ask their business. The Door-Keepers, who keep that meal, still do this. A Road-hand who eats is doing the courtesy of a host, whether or not the Seat wrote the meal down. A Road-hand who plants and leaves without sitting is making a claim.

A Guest-reading town and a First-reading district start the story in the same place and then split. A Guest-reading town will make the pilgrimage and keep the meal. A First-reading district will tend the same wood as a guest in their house, and will still refuse the Tender’s blessing, the line a warden says over a child at the fall. Both of them start at a receiving, not at a knife. The Cut is a mainland word for what they call an arrival.

They do not start history at Cut-year 0. On Heskoren the guests arrive in the Cut-year 200s. Calling that arrival “late” is already the Motherfaith talking. Calling it “the First Cut, delayed” is a map drawn by the Seat. The land was already making children at the old doors.

What the telling leaves out is that a guest who takes a generation to speak, which is what the first local Leaf-Fall is, will still be called a Tree by the children who Turn under it. Host-rights do not stop a town from becoming a town of the Hands years.

People tell all five. Skeptics will grant the horticulture, because you can see it, and will deny that a mind chose the travelling. The Fair Hand is not a sixth story about the cut. They come into it when the wood boards a ship. The Open Table is not in this story.

The generation of argument

Cut-year 0 is a cut. The next twenty summers are copies, dead wood, a college that cannot un-cut what has taken, and a first local Leaf-Fall that ends the argument without settling it.

What people actually did was smaller than the sermons, and more stubborn. Near-Mile towns cut because the first green was visible from the next square. They had living tissue, a day’s earth, a pot, and a Taken-In who knew soil. That is why the towns at the origin filled first. It was the distance a sapling can survive, not a later sermon about worthiness.

Most of the early copies died. The wood was mortal, or the season was wrong, or a pot dried on the Near Mile in Hale-month, or a well-meant slip went into the ground with no carrying-earth under it. Those deaths are why the Seat could tell itself, for a while, that the first taking had been a fluke.

The hearth at the origin tried to forbid the next cut. Speakers named it theft, blight, a wound in the First Hand, and neighbours cut anyway. A prohibition that has no riders cannot police a day's walk in a world without a printing press, where the order dies with the person sent to carry it.

The proof arrived as a ceremony. When the nameless green held its first Turning-Week, a colour fell, or a hug fell. The tellings do not agree which, and the disagreement does not change the paper. A town that was not the origin had Turned its own child. Belonging because the town itself had seen the child came into that square the way weather does, a generation after the knife, without anyone passing a law to create it. The walk stopped being the only door. The Seat can argue doctrine until the leaves fall. It cannot argue the leaves back onto Thaeloren.

What the Seat captured was not the living wood, which the college could not own. It could own who may cut next, and that ownership is the copy-right. Cutting-leave is the paper. The scion-queue is what a copy-right becomes when the demand runs ahead of a generation of wood.

The fee is framed as the cost of carrying-earth and of a Road-hand's year, and it is the same coin heard four ways. Folk hear a fine in it, Lestrand hears a licence, Threnmaieth wants it written on a roll, and Vaethorn calls it an offering. Historically it is how an institution absorbed a heresy and called the heresy horticulture. Cutting that had no sanction became cutting that had a permit. The practice survived by changing owners, and the queue is old.

Road-hands are the people you send when you have claimed the knife and you still need the wood to walk, and they are not a second order of their own.

Once a town had its own tree, the new injustice was which town is next, and that injustice is paid in twenty more years of borrowed Turnings, twenty years in which children still stand under someone else's tree while theirs grows up.

How the wave moved

This is how the wood moved, inside the dates already given.

A scion still takes a generation before it can Turn a child. A healthy town Tree may supply the next cut, acting for the origin. So the wave is a chain of Hands that have to grow up, not a crate of miracles you could open on any shore in the same summer. The sea can jump a link in that chain. A cart on the Long Mile cannot, not until carrying-earth will last the trip, and not until there are rest-hearths whose job is the wood rather than the pilgrims.

Maiethorn, Cut-years 0–80 (origin-towns first; Rain-Shadow slower)

The Near Mile stops being a requirement in the core, town by town, as the canopies come of age. The squares at the origin go first, a day's earth, then two, then a valley. The pilgrimage does not disappear. It remains as devotion at Thaeloren, and as necessity wherever a graft has not yet spoken.

The Rain-Shadow is slower, and the slowness is in the ground. It is the same continent, with thin soil, wells, and sand-country. A cut that takes in the Sacred Core, where the soil will hold it, dies in the dry hills unless a Taken-In and a lucky year agree. This is dirt, not unworthiness and not a different gospel. Hearths of the Fox of the Sands, the fox-born of that dry country, still walk west toward Thaeloren after the squares on the coast have already stopped. The wave runs at two speeds on one continent.

The Seat's narration of those years is that her hands filled the Motherland. Folk memory says they stopped burying children on the Near Mile where the wood took, and they did not stop where it did not. Both sentences can be said in the same market.

By Cut-year 80 the Motherland is old in the Years of Hands in the core, towns whose trees have been ordinary for a long time, and still waiting in pockets. That waiting is not Heskoren's story yet. It is why a hamlet on Maiethorn can still send this year's ten-year-olds to a neighbour, and not be play-acting a history that has closed.

Strandoren, Cut-years 40–160, by sea (wealthy coasts first, interior later)

The Old Crossing already knew how to move a child. Moving a Hand is the same berth with worse instructions on it: living earth, do not stow the pot below, water it at dawn, and a Taken-In or a Road-hand sleeps beside it.

The sea starts while Maiethorn is still filling, in Cut-year 40, because a ship is faster than filling every inland hamlet. A wealthy coast can pay a Cutting-leave and a Salt-Walk crew in the same summer that a Near-Mile village is still sitting on the Seat's list. The wave went where the ships and the fees went.

The coasts take first. Port-cities take, and the deep interior waits on river-days and a cart, which is a short version of the Long Mile. Strandoren's later combination of a wide reach and a worn faith is not a paradox. The wood arrived as cargo, and cargo does not require a mother. The Fair Hand dates the carrying as a fact of a supply line. They will attend a planting as witnesses to a signing. They will not start history at a wound in wood. "The first carrying" is their name for Eoloren, and what they mean by it is a bill of lading, the paper that says what the ship had aboard.

Once a coast Turns under its own canopy, the berth is no longer a necessity of a child's tenth year. It becomes a luxury, a hinge in a contract, a devout extra. Road-houses on the inland days lose a season of boots and keep the notes. What belongs here is the quay that noticed the pots had replaced the children.

By Cut-year 160 the shore-lands are mature in the Years of Hands on the water, and still patchy inland. Lestrand files the whole motion as "the carrying." They are not wrong about the ships.

The gap (why Heskoren waits until Cut-year 200)

The wait is not unworthiness, and three frictions are stacked under it.

Wood dies on the Long Mile. The trip is weeks to months. A day's earth is a Near-Mile problem, and a ship's hold is a Salt-Walk problem someone has already solved, if the pot is watered. A cart between hearths in thaw-mud is how scions become sticks. Until carrying-earth will last, and until there are rest-hearths whose job is the wood and not the pilgrims, Heskoren cannot be a circuit a living tree survives. Road-hands had to exist as a standing office before the far country could be a route, rather than a funeral of saplings.

The chain has to grow up. You cut from the origin, or you cut from a healthy town Tree. Maiethorn's first generation of sources comes of age in the Cut-year 20s to 40s. Strandoren's coastal Hands are not ready to be sources until later still. You cannot skip ahead to the far reach without a mature link, unless you spend origin-wood on a march that kills it. The Seat, mostly, did not. That is horticulture, and it is also a choice about who is next.

The queue prefers a next town that can pay. After the coasts, the carrying-earth is committed to interiors, to replacements, and to sick Trees, the quiet work that does not look like a wave. Heskoren is poor, far, and already accused, by a guilt that gets its theology later, of having waited because it deserved to wait. They waited because the wood was slow, the road was long, and the list was written in the Motherwood.

Vaethorn will preach that they wait because they are unworthy. The gap is the evidence that sermon uses. The chronicle records the slow wood, the long road, and the list.

Heskoren, Cut-years 200–387 (still receiving)

The frontier coast faces back across the sea toward Strandoren, and that facing is the lifeline new grafts come in on. The luckiest towns have had a local Turning for a few generations, a scion that arrived in the 200s and spoke in the 220s, or later than that. Whole districts still send their children down the road, to a neighbour's new canopy, or still along the Long Mile, if what the neighbour has is a stick in a pot.

This is the wave in the present tense. It is not a re-enactment of the years when walking was the only way. Some hamlets are in the Walking Years this year, for this group of children. Some are already in the Years of Hands, one valley over. Both can be true of the same road. The waiting Vaethorn lives in is the front of the wave, not a metaphor for a history that has finished.

Host-rights of the Old Ways start here as a collision people are living, not as a sermon preached on Maiethorn. A graft set in an old Taken-In green is a guest, a Cutting-leave is a paper from the mainland, and the meal comes first, or else the planting is a claim. The people on both sides of that argument love the wood.

The Seat's narration says her will is still travelling. Folk memory says the cart came late, the soil was called thin, and the three hamlets past the ford can see Harrow's green from here. On Heskoren that sentence is the decade they are in.

Kumbaan: never

No graft crossed the storm-wall, and Road-hands do not carry a Tree over that drowning sea. Sailors tell of pots that went into the water, and dead wood is not a Tree, and no old scion has ever been found on the Isle. The Open Table owes Eoloren nothing, and counts its time in moons, not in Cut-years.

Seat narration vs folk memory

The Seat's account and the folk memory sit side by side, the way the Walking Years kept the romance and the graves in the same sentence.

	Seat / devout sermon	**Folk memory (and the other houses)**
The knife	She offered a Hand.	Someone took one.
The paper	It is stewardship, and it is horticulture.	It is a fine that forgot what it was, or a licence, or a warrant.
The order of the wave	It is her will, travelling.	It is ships and fees, and then the far.
Heskoren's wait	It is soil, timing, and the Mother's pace.	It is the list, the dead wood, and the cart that came late.
What was saved	The world received her.	Children stopped dying on *some* roads.

A Long-Lived person who can say "I walked," because they did, and a Speaker who keeps the Eoloren-count, will fight about the same summer. A Long-Lived person who planted, a Road-hand who held the work for a long tenure, or an innkeeper who watched the pots replace the children, will not always tell you which taking they think was holy, because the memory is perfect and what the sentence means is not.

As the trees spread, they moved the place where a child is expected to have been seen at ten. A town of the Years of Hands can still meet a feared Struck person, whose change did not come from being seen at ten, with a rope. A canopy of the town's own does not stop the rope.

What a character notices

Along the Near Mile the cut is still sitting in ordinary things. A house hangs a kitchen-knife on a ribbon and will not name a saint for it, and in the same week the Watchers in the next yard are grafting pears while a Road-hand waters the carrying-earth. At a planting, the bowl from the first meal is already licked clean by the dogs, and that meal is one the Seat never wrote down. The clerk who copies the old ship's line, "one living hand, do not stow below, water at dawn," files it as cargo. Farther out, three hamlets can see a neighbour's canopy and are still waiting, having learned not to say "queue," while a child of the Rain-Shadow is still on the west road after the core has stopped walking. The Salt Walk's berths are empty in Eolthael, the season when they used to fill, except a hold that still smells of wet earth out of season. A Long-Lived person who planted will not say "I walked," because the job was the planting, and the room still goes quiet.

A minute of the First Seat

What follows is a minute of the First Seat, attributed to the Speaker Rithnali, from the summer the nameless green held its first Turning-Week. Later clerks file it as Cut-year 19. The back of the leaf is a list of pots that died, and no one read that list aloud.

> *The wood that took within a day's earth of the First was cut without leave. We will not write who. We will write how, so the next cut does not kill what it carries.*
>
> *Carry in living earth. Marry with the watering-words. Do not cut a second without the Seat. If the scion sickens, send word; do not take another wound in the First to hide the first.*
>
> *The Tree does not reach twice by chance, and neither do we. From this summer a cut is a leave, or it is a theft we have decided not to chase. The towns that wait will wait on horticulture. The soil is thin in more places than it is not.*

Folk who keep the nameless knife think this paper is a confession. The Seat thinks it is competence. Both of them can hold the same copy.

Consequences

The wave starts here. The Grafting, as a wave, is wood carried outward, a generation to mature, Maiethorn first, Strandoren by sea, Heskoren last and still live, and Kumbaan never.

Where the wood has taken, a town Tree becomes the ordinary way. Children Turn under the town canopy. The pilgrimage remains, with a new job: devotion, or prestige, or necessity when a graft fails.

The Seat gains a bottleneck. Cutting-leave and the scion-queue are how an institution took a heresy in and called the result horticulture.

The clerical count of years begins. Other people do not have to use it, and the count a person does use shows where they are willing to start.

Language and money were already bent by the road, and the bend eases where the trees stand. Local trees let children grow up in place, so the road's pull toward the older speech loosens. Road-houses in the core lose their pilgrim-seasons and keep the notes. What both of those changes left behind is in the Years of Hands: the two fates of the road-house, and the three jobs the walk still has.

The Years of Hands

Where the wood has taken, a town Turning Tree is the ordinary way to Turn, a child standing under a Tree in their own town rather than walking to the one grove. People call these years the Years of Hands, and also Since the Hands. The liturgical name is Ornthael *(ORN-thael)*, "Tree-land." The Grafting is not a previous age you leave. It is a wave of living wood that is still moving.

This is the era the rest of the world lives in without stopping to name it. Where a graft has taken, the Leaf-Fall can happen in the square. Belonging can rest on this town having watched you become, and the pilgrimage to Thaeloren is an extra rather than the only door.

The clerical count opens the era at the First Cut, Cut-year 0, and the present, where those grafts have taken, is Cut-year 387. That count is not a finished map. Read how far the living wood has reached as a date, not as a chart of a completed age. The two clocks overlap, and neither one has closed.

Maiethorn is old in these years, and the grafts there are dense and mature, so the Walking is biography for the Long-Lived who still remember those roads, and a ribbon on a mile-shrine for everyone else. The exceptions are the Rain-Shadow, where the waiting went on after the core stopped, and any place where a Tree has sickened. A town that has had its own Tree for a long time can lose the use of it. That is weather, not the age ending. The Years of Hands go on around that town, and the town's children go back onto a road.

Strandoren is mature in these years, and the faith there is worn. The road-houses finished becoming banks on this coast. What is left of the walk is a luxury, a hinge in a contract, and a hold that still smells of earth when the passenger is a pot of living wood.

Heskoren is the Grafting this decade. The luckiest towns have had a local canopy for a few generations, and whole districts still send their children down the road. Vaethorn's waiting is not a metaphor for history. It is the wave's front.

Kumbaan never came onto either clock. No graft of this era reaches it, and no extra mile does either.

The pilgrimage did not vanish. It changed jobs. The First Seat still authorizes cuts, and what used to be a decision is now a queue. Deathless houses still remember the road, and what used to be a bed is now credit. Mile-shrines still stand, and what used to be a grave is now folklore, an argument, and a thing children climb. The romance of the old mile is a feeling of these years. The graves are facts of the Walking Years. They stand on the same ground.

These years are not “the modern age after the Grafting.” The wave is still moving. A child on the Long Mile this summer is making the week, not commemorating it. Those same 387 summers also held a war, a split of paper, a fever, a flood, and a hush, and those years sit beside the two clocks. They do not replace them.

A Phoenix’s rebirths remain the one marker of an era that even a town with its own Tree cannot file, and the people who use a rebirth as a year cannot agree which summer it marks.

The walk’s three jobs

Brenvaeth is the name for the years when a child’s tenth summer meant the road. In those years the walk was how you Turned. In Ornthael it is three jobs that share roads, inns, and the one-week door, and do not share a reason.

Job	Who still walks	What they are buying	What they are not
Devotion — the extra mile	People who already have a local Tree and still want Thaeloren	an origin-fall; a ribbon at the First Hand; the Motherwood in Eolthael	necessity. They could have Turned at home.
Prestige — the First-Hand year	Lestrand money, a Bound signing-watch, a guild-ticket hinge, a wedding extra	being seen at the origin when you did not need to be; a held-over winter as a product	piety, unless it is also that. The Fair Hand will attend as witnesses to a signing.
Necessity — the neighbour’s week (still the old mile when the neighbour is a continent)	Tree-poor, Tree-sick, Tree-young; a missed fall this year; Heskoren this cohort; the Rain-Shadow after the core stopped	a Given-door that is not at home	folklore. They are not re-enacting the old road. They are making the week.

People did not say Ornthael on the road. They said they were going to the Thallow, the worn everyday name for Thaeloren, or that they Turn at Harrow’s, or that the berth is for the child. Vaethorn calls

almost any walk the waiting-road. Lestrand files the extra as the First-Hand year and the need as the borrowed week. Threnmaieth wants the miles on a roll.

They share the Near Mile in Hale-month, the month when the road still fills. A devotion-column, a prestige household with too much luggage, a necessity-family who sold a year to make the trip, and a Road-hand going the other way with a pot of wood can sleep in the same upper room. The innkeeper can tell who is which. They will not always tell you. The Far-Voiced ridge-cry still works. Someone calls that the ford is wrong, and some of the people who answer are pilgrims, while some are carts of wood.

The inversion is lived on the road, not only in the names. Thaelvaeth is wood carried out, the Tree going to the hearths. Brenvaeth was hearths walking in, people going to the Tree. In the Years of Hands both directions are traffic. A Road-hand and a tenth-year pass on a bank and do not owe each other a sermon. That passing is the two clocks in one afternoon.

A town Tree that sickens, or that fails a fall, puts a Hands-town back on the neighbour’s week. A sick Tree is not the age ending, even in the core. The Seat will call it thin soil, and the town will call it this year.

The one-week door did not loosen. Miss Eolthael and the Given-door has shut, whether you missed it at home or at the origin. Struck remains the later mercy, and there is still no second-chance year. The held-over nine-year-old is still the expensive mercy, and on the prestige-walk it is also a winter you can buy.

No extra mile crosses the storm-wall to Kumbaan.

What the Walk left behind

What the Walking built, the Hands still sleep in, and still use. The reuse is a thing finding a new job, not a field of ruins. A Hands-town that treats a mile-shrine as only a ruin is telling itself the road is over.

Mile-shrines

A mile-shrine is still a stone at about a day’s walk, with water, a flat top, and often a name and a ribbon. In a Hands-town the last one is frequently in the square, because the town grew around a graft planted beside the road, and the road’s destination moved closer until the stone was in the middle of the life that replaced the walk.

The town does not agree which thing the stone is allowed to be. It is a grave, and a Long-Lived person who says “I walked” can still tell you which ford the name belongs to. It is a waymark, because necessity-walkers still drink there and Road-hands still aim for the water. It is folklore, because devotion leaves a ribbon and the town’s children climb it. And it is an argument: a warden wants it

moved because it is in the way of the Leaf-Fall crowd, a house that still dates its notes from a founding-summer wants it left, and a neighbour who still walks wants it left for the water and the mile, not for the memory.

The stone does not know which story it is in. A ribbon is still not a leaf-colour. Travellers who have walked once know this. Travellers who have only heard the romance do not.

Hands-towns that pull a stone down are doing theology with a hammer. They are not wrong that the road no longer has to happen there. They are wrong if they think the graves went with the requirement. The next necessity-column will miss the water.

The upper room

An old inn's upper room has too many beds for the present trade. In Brenvaeth those beds were the two crowded months. In Ornthael the same room is put to three uses, sometimes in the same fortnight.

Merchants take the beds, which is the White Note's conversion, occupancy treated as proof the house is competent. Eolthael still opens some of them, because devotion and prestige swell a Near-Mile house for a fortnight. And some stay held. A family said they would come, and they did not, so the innkeeper keeps the bed a year, then two, then as a habit that looks like hospitality and functions as a shrine and as proof the house remembers. Thilim still makes Seine's. Houses that became banks mostly stopped making those beds, except the one they will not let, which is how a clerk writes "house custom" on a slate and means a grave.

The romance of the empty bed belongs to these years. The name written for the held bed belongs to the Walking Years.

Roads that end at a Tree

The pilgrim-road was often the main road. A graft took beside it, the town grew around the canopy, and the road now ends at the Tree. The last holy mile is a square. Beyond the boughs the old way is a cart-track to timber, a neighbour, or a ford. Children are told the road goes to the Motherwood. It goes to the mill. Both can be true if you keep walking, which most children in a Tree-town do not.

For that town, the road ends at the Tree, and the children Turn at home. The family from the next valley is still walking those stones, because the wood has not reached them. The stones are the same stones.

Other things the Walk left that a character notices

What a character can still see, without anyone announcing an era, is the walk's leftovers still doing a job or refusing to stop.

In Eolthael the Salt Walk's berths sit empty except the expensive ones and the holds that smell of wet earth, because a pot of wood is the passenger now and the earth comes with it. The old ridge-cry still goes up, "the ford is wrong," and no column answers, though a Road-hand does, and so do the birds. A pair of siblings will not walk the same side of a road, one Given and one UnTurned, folk still calling the second Kept, because they are a split household's grandchildren keeping a courtesy they cannot date. Markets still swell at an old mile-mark in Hale-month and vanish again even when no column comes, the habit having outlasted the road. In a Near-Mile house the nameless knife still hangs on a ribbon, not yet a museum piece, because the house will not name a saint for it.

Deathless houses' road-past as present credit

Many deathless houses began as road-houses. That change of fortune is already in the past. The inns became banks, the same Long-Lived are still in the house, and the fortune is a different one.

The founding-summer is the credit. "We kept you on the mile" is an origin-story that still collects. A century-loan written from a house-year, counted from the summer the house was founded rather than from the First Cut, is not only a quirk of dating. It is a claim that the porridge was real, the note was real, and the house is still the same house. No mortal court can audit a Long-Lived person's memory of a walk two hundred summers back. That is why the trusted note holds. It is also why a house can call a debt whose grandchildren do not remember the ford.

Two fates of that same origin are still standing, and they do not agree about what success was.

The White Note House is the reformation. The beds are let to merchants and the paper is on the quay, so Ledan's query from the house's 200th summer, written in Cut-year 280, is already a clerk's problem in a house now in its 307th summer. The held names are in the founding-book, most of those beds are let, and one is not, which is how a bank proves it used to be an inn.

The Third Hearth is the house that stayed a hearth. Thilim still keeps it, still makes Seine's bed, and still knows which guests will be here at dark. The notes Thilim keeps are smaller than a bank's, and the shrine of the bed is larger. Lestrand calls this a bed-house that failed to become a bank. Thilim does not call it a failure.

The long-house of books is still the deathless paying their own Tithe. The road-past is why anyone trusted them to endow a library in the first place. A house that remembered every debtor on the mile is a house you let steer the shelves.

The prestige-walk is now a product some houses sell. A held-over winter at the origin, once the frightened mercy of a far family who could not miss the week, is a First-Hand year you can book. It is one commodity, and the desks do not all sell the same piece of it. Netstrand supplies the berths, hulls and crews and space on the West Water, the wider sea between Strandoren and Heskoren, chartered in to the Old Crossing. What the walk left Netstrand is that far crossing, not this winter at the grove. The

White Note writes the terms, which is credit for a year you do not need. They noticed the upper room was empty in Nethael, the Deep, when the deathless houses close their books, and full of the wrong people in Eolthael, and they made a term for it, without having invented the hold. Orentel holds the departure: Sorim, the factor on the first quay, files who occupies that water, empty Eolthael berths included, in the city that stages people toward Maiethorn. Orenbren houses the year at the origin, beds within a week’s walk of the grove, and it is not a fourth seller of the berth.

Necessity-families still sign the old kind of note: eat now, pay on the home-walk, or when the child is grown, or when a sibling walks next year. It is the same paper doing two jobs. A clerk who files both the necessity-note and the prestige-note as occupancy is counting beds, not jobs.

Vaethorn will preach that the houses abandoned the waiting-road, and the history is shorter than that sermon. The walk stopped being required in the core, the memory did not stop, and the paper outlived the season. That is a change of business, not a betrayal of the road, and it still collects.

Heskoren as the live front

This is the wave in the present tense. Some hamlets are in the Walking Years this year, for this group of children, still sending them the long way because no nearer Tree can take them. Some are in the Years of Hands one valley over, with a canopy of their own. Both can be true on the same road.

Harrow’s Green is the luckiest kind of Heskoren town. A scion arrived in the Cut-year 200s, spoke a generation later, and has now Turned local children for a few generations. It is a neighbour’s canopy you can see from the ford. New towns say, “We Turned at Harrow’s Tree before we had our own.” That is how they talk everywhere. On Heskoren it is the decade, not a proverb about the past.

The Three Hamlets Past the Ford are the waiting kind. The Seat’s Cutting-leave already named them as thin soil. They send this year’s ten-year-olds to Harrow’s, or further if Harrow’s year is too full, or still the Long Mile if the neighbour is only a stick in a pot. They have learned not to say “queue.” They can see the canopy from where they stand. Cutting by folk-right, with a kitchen-knife and without that paper, is a temptation. Most slips die. The ones that take are how the queue learns it is not the only horticulture in the world.

Old Ways host-rights start here as a collision, not a sermon. A graft set into an old Taken-In green is a guest in that green. A Cutting-leave is a mainland paper. The first meal comes first, or the planting is a claiming. The Door-Keepers and the Road-hands can both love the wood and still fight about the bowl.

Borrowed Turnings are the front’s ordinary year. Belonging to the town that saw you Turn is the practice of these years, and the town that saw you may be Harrow’s rather than the hamlet that raised you. Vouching at a distance was invented to carry an origin-fall home, someone who had been under Thaeloren standing for a child in a town that had not seen it. It now carries a neighbour-fall home

instead, the same three pillars, over a shorter road. The Struck who were never vouched for are still older than the grafts. A local canopy did not dissolve them.

The Seat’s narration is that her will is still travelling. Folk memory is that the cart came late, the soil was called thin, and Harrow’s green is visible from here. Vaethorn will preach that they wait because they are unworthy. They wait because the wood is slow, the road is long, and the list of who is next was written in the Motherwood.

The Rain-Shadow on Maiethorn is the same wait on an older continent: waiting that went on after the core stopped. Ornsael is a town where this is happening. Its Tree speaks most years, even while the well is dropping and the west road is water. A child on that west road, after the Sacred Core has stopped walking, is the same waiting on the Motherland. That is how you can tell these years are not a finished age.

What is strained

This is not a chronicle of collapse. What a traveller can already see is pressure, and it is not an ending.

The First Seat is old in the queue. It has authorized cuts since Cut-year 19, about three hundred and sixty-eight summers, and towns that can see a neighbour’s canopy have learned the horticulture-sentence by heart. Folk-right slips still happen, and Threnmaieth still wants the college on the roll, so the Seat is heavy without being near a fall.

The Road-hands are thin on the Heskoren front. They carry living earth and mortal wood on a skeleton circuit, and their authority expires a week out from the Motherwood. A live Tree is a quiet success no one writes down, while a dead one becomes a name on a complaint. They plant what they were given leave to plant, and they sleep in the town that was not chosen.

Waiting towns hang on a single scion, or on a neighbour’s week, and so does the Mill-hold, where a Tree has sickened. That is a civic crisis wearing a child’s summer.

Deathless houses are richer in paper than in beds. The road-past is the credit, and the upper room is how you can see it. The prestige-walk is a product they already sell.

The towns where this present is already something you can walk into are Harrow’s Green, the neighbour’s canopy a waiting hamlet can see; the Three Hamlets Past the Ford, the queue made visible from the ford; the Third Hearth, a road-house that stayed a hearth; Ornsael, the same waiting on the Motherland; and the White Note House, a road-house that became a desk.

A letting-slate from the White Note’s inland house

What follows is a letting-slate from the White Note’s inland house, kept by Mataero, who is junior to Ledan and has never made a held bed. It is Cut-year 387, and the house-year is not written on the

front. The back is a copy of founding-names in an older hand.

> *Nethael closing. Upper room: twelve beds. Let: eight, to the wool out of Lestrand, term through Hale-month, pay on the quay-note. Open for Eolthael: four, First-Hand year, held-over child already spoken for, the mother paid the winter in advance. Occupancy will cover the loft.*
>
> *Do not let the north bed. House custom. The founding-book has a name I am not to copy onto a term. Ledan says the house is the same house. I say the house is the note. The bed is empty. Empty is not a shrine. Empty is a bed we are not charging for.*
>
> *Thilim's third hearth still holds a far-cape name. We do not. We are not an inn that failed. We are the house that remembered long enough to be trusted.*
>
> *I do not ask which summer was holy. I ask which debtors will pay in Ledger-month. If the north bed is a grave, it is a grave that does not belong on a letting-slate.*

Folklore of the road, the Cut, and what the Walk left behind

Three things people still tell or play. One is a counting song of the road, and the numbers will not say which line is a mile and which line is a person. One is the teaching-story of the Cut, and its last line will not choose a hand. One is a square-game that adults later mistake for a fable, and it has no official ending.

The Child Who Counted Stones

People sing this. They do not recite it, and no two miles of the road keep the same gaps. The learned title is *The Child Who Counted Stones*. The count carries distance and graves in the same breath, and it does not stop to tell you which line is a mile and which line is a person.

The leader sings a number, and the line of walkers answers with whatever that number bought.

> ***One** for water.*
> ***Two** for shade.*
> ***Three** for the woman who knew the ford.*
> ***Four** for bread.*
> ***Six** for the boy whose ribbon stayed.*

The first time they hear it, children object that five is missing, and the line answers, “Keep your breath.”

The song goes on. A number may buy a dry bed, or a ferryman’s lie, or a shoe that had to be stitched twice, or a name that nobody at the next stone knows. Some of the verses are useful for getting along the road, some of them are the names of people, and most of the verses never tell you which of those they are.

When the line reaches a mile-shrine, the leader skips the number that is cut into the stone. At an unmarked grave, the leader sings one number twice. If somebody challenges that, the leader says, “Keep your breath,” and keeps walking.

The origin has no number in the song, and neither does the Leaf-Fall. The line arrives, stands, and begins the song again on the road home.

> ***One*** *for water.*
> ***Two*** *for shade.*
> ***Four*** *for bread.*
> ***Five*** *for the ribbon we left on the way.*

Children object that five was the number missing before, and this time the line answers, “Then carry it.”

A practical leader sings the verses about water and shelter in order to pace the day, so the song is also a way of knowing how far the line has come. A bereaved household puts a name into the song once, and if that verse is still being sung after three walks, the name has become part of the geography. Crews on a quay count the tides instead of the stones, and they leave long silences in the places where an inland line would be waiting for a number. Children in a town that already Turns its own use the song for skipping games. People who are still walking dislike hearing it played that way, until they notice which numbers the children have left out.

The Branch That Came Away

This is the teaching-story of the Cut, the first time living wood was taken from a Tree so another town could plant a Tree of its own. People still tell it in a town that has a Tree when the neighbour does not. In the telling, a Hand is that planted wood, and sharing a Hand requires wounding a Hand, because the branch has to be cut from a tree that already stands. The first copy invented both the local mercy and the wait: wood that has taken where people can stand under it, and the question of who is allowed the next branch. The bones stay the same from town to town. The last line will not choose whose hand.

People tell it like this.

A branch came away from the Tree.

A person carried it. They watered it. They put it in new ground.

It died.

They carried another. Or they carried the same one, and the tellings do not agree, and it does not change the ground.

It took.

The origin said, “That wood is ours.”

The new ground said, “That wood is here.”

Both were right, which is why there had to be a paper.

The paper said who may take the next branch. The Tree was not asked. The Tree kept choosing children under both canopies.

A child asked which Tree was the real one.

The mother said, “Count the Hands.”

The child counted two, then twenty, then the towns that were not in the count yet.

The child asked who was next.

The mother said, “The soil is thin there.”

The child could see the neighbour’s canopy from the ford, and could not say, later, whether they had been counting Hands or counting waits.

A Long-Lived person who planted the wood will tell you the child’s name, and will not tell you which summer, and still will not write who cut.

The bones above are common. What a teller adds last is the stance they are willing to be heard taking.

- A Near-Mile singer says, “The mother was the one who cut. The paper came after, like a fine.”
- A Speaker says, “The warden cut with a leave the college had not invented yet. The paper is how we kept the next one alive.”
- A devout teller says, “The branch came away. No one stole a Hand. She gave one.”
- A Watcher says, “We have always cut living wood. They named one cut the First. The count is optional.”
- An Old Ways teller says, “The ground received a guest. The paper is a mainland word for a meal they did not stay for.”

- A Fair Hand clerk says, “The second carrying was a berth. The first was an unlicensed one. That is the whole hymn.”
- A child in a Tree-town says, “We Turn here. The neighbour walks. The story is why.”
- A child who is still walking says, “We can see the canopy. The story does not plant anything.”

Skeptics of every house tell a short ending. One of them says, “There was not a Hand that learned to walk. There was wood, and a pot, and a college that got to the knife late.”

On Maiethorn the story is told at Turning-Week, both in the Motherwood and in kitchens that keep a knife on a ribbon. The Motherwood version starts at “came away,” and the kitchen version starts at “took.” On Strandoren the quay-version never finds a Tree until the hold is opened. The joke is the bill, and the bill is not a joke inland. On Heskoren some tellers omit the taking, and the child is still asking who is next when the story stops. Tellers who read the story as a guest-meal start at the meal. Tellers who read it as a first claiming start at the claiming. A Seat telling ends on the paper rather than at the ford, and the Speakers who give that telling think it is the real version. Kumbaan does not keep this story. A mainland guest who tells it is offered more supper, which is an answer.

The Child Who Climbed the Stone

The learned title is *The Child Who Climbed the Stone*. Children call the game Here and Far. It has no fixed narrator, no doctrinal endings, and no Long-Lived witness who can swear they saw the first afternoon. A town can play it only if an old mile-stone still stands where a local Tree later made a square.

One child stands on the mile-stone and is Here, and everyone else waits at the edge of the square and is Far. Far calls, “How many days?” and Here must answer, “None. The Tree is here.”

Far then takes one paving-stone forward and names something that is still being carried from the road. The things they are allowed to name are the old cargo: a bed kept empty, a cup set before dawn, a ribbon gone white, a child sent to the neighbour. Here may answer only, “Already here.” If Here laughs, or repeats a thing that has already been named, or steps down off the stone, the nearest child takes the stone.

The game is meant to end when Far reaches the marker. It rarely gets that far, because the list of what people are still carrying grows faster than the square is wide. Children borrow grievances from the adults, invent cargo that nobody could have brought, and argue over whether a grave and a name are one thing or two. Shopkeepers walk through the line, carts break it up, and the child on the stone keeps shouting “Already here” at people who are plainly on their way somewhere else.

There is one rule the adults never teach, and every square already knows it. When a real walking household, people who are still carrying their lives on the road, crosses the game, play stops. Here gets

down, the children move the marker aside so the packs can pass, and afterward they put the marker back, sometimes into the same socket it came out of.

A Road-hand, passing along the road, calls it courtesy when the children move the marker, and a paving clerk, who keeps the stones of the square, calls it vandalism when the children put the marker back. In a town with no waiting neighbours, no one still owed a journey to a Tree, the children run out of true things and start naming the weather. Past the ford, where the game has no stone at its centre, Here stands wherever the canopy can be seen, and nobody agrees whether that placement is mockery. Adults only tell the game as a story once they have forgotten how to lose it.

Pages a party can find

Six short pages sit on shelves a party can visit. Each was written by someone inside the world, in that person’s own words, and each is a page or two long. A page can be wrong about the world. What follows says where each page is kept, who works there, what that person says if a visitor asks, and what a reader is meant to understand from it. The pages themselves stay in the writers’ voices. This chapter says what each page is, and it does not take the writer’s voice for its own.

Three of the pages are in Rothallo: at the school beside the Book’s house, in the Book’s house itself, and at the gate clerk’s desk. The Book’s house is where the Closed houses keep their records, and the school beside it is where their children learn to read. The other three pages are on Molevad’s long-house shelf in Lestrand, where the Pourers keep their library. People name that building by the house, and it has no other name.

The school primer

The page is *First Lessons at the Close School*. It is kept at the school beside the Book’s house in Rothallo, where the children of the Closed houses learn their letters, and where other families inside the walls can send a child if they pay. Volnai teaches there. If a visitor asks about the page, Volnai says, “This is what the children learn in their first year. A hug is rare. Take a copy if you like; I write out more every summer.”

A reader is meant to understand that this is the lesson the Close teaches its children, set as questions and answers they say back. The Close is the name this lesson uses for the Closed houses’ way of teaching, and Volnai believes every line of it. The primer teaches that most children receive a colour, that a hug is rare, and that the Tree keeps back a hugged child for something better than a colour. It also teaches the seating at a Closed table, who holds the keys, what happens to a Closed child who

receives a colour, and why, on the primer's own account, households with a Condition get the heavier turns of work.

The primer is wrong about the hug. About two children in five are hugged at the Leaf-Fall, and about a quarter of all people stay Kept for their whole lives. Being hugged is common. What is rare is a family like the Closed houses, which has stayed Kept on purpose for generations. The primer gives no numbers of its own.

A history of the Closing

The page is *The Keeping of the Grove*. It is kept in the Book's house in Rothallo, on the same shelf as the Book of Tithes, and Delamem keeps the Book of Tithes. If a visitor asks, Delamem says, "It is our history of the Seat. You may read it here. The Book's house does not lend."

A reader is meant to understand that this is the Closed Heirs' own account of the Closing, and that the account speaks well of the Closed Seat. It says the gate at the grove kept order at the one Tree, that children turned away at the gate went home unharmed, and that the riders who dug up and burned the new grafts were stewards bringing back stolen wood. It says Hildal, a clerk, chose to keep the Book rather than fight for the grove, and that the Closed families moved a day's walk away into Rothallo, in the country that became Orenbren.

The facts on the page match the history above. The war ran from Cut-year 19 to Cut-year 38, and the writer counts those years from the cutting and calls them the nineteenth and the thirty-eighth year. The page does not name who made the First Cut, and it does not put a year on the Tree.

What the page leaves out is the cost. It does not say that children walked the whole Long Mile and went home UnTurned because the gate refused them, or that people died on the roads. The page calls a child sent home "Kept" and "whole," as if that were no loss.

Minutes from the long-house

The page is *Minutes of a Gift*. It is one meeting copied out of the minute-book, and it is kept on Molevad's long-house shelf in Lestrand. Molevad keeps the minute-book and the key to the shelf. If a visitor asks, Molevad says, "This is one meeting. K. said it could be read. The rest of the book stays shut."

A reader is meant to understand that these are the circle's own minutes of one willing gift. The circle asks five years of a member in all, one year on each night, and this meeting is the fifth that a Long-Lived member called K. gives, so K. is on the last of them. The Long-Lived are the people who can make this gift, because a year of their memory is a year they have actually kept. K. asks to give that year, names it, and says why: K. is tired of carrying a husband's death. The circle asks three times whether the gift is K.'s own wish. K. gives the year into the cup with one drop of blood. Afterward K.

still knows the husband’s name and face from before the marriage, and remembers nothing from that year. K.’s papers from that year go onto the shelf, and the minutes end with the long-house seating K. one year younger, five in all.

The minutes also record how the circle will describe its god this decade, that one reading held two members’ memories of the same summer, and that nobody asked to stop. They end on the circle’s claim that every gift is freely given and that the circle made the god it gives to. That claim is the circle’s belief. These minutes do not settle whether it is true.

A scene from a play

The page is *The Heir’s Seat*. It is kept on Molevad’s long-house shelf in Lestrand as a copy in the common speech. Members of the circle copy books into the common speech, and this play is one of those copies. Molevad holds the key. If a visitor asks, Molevad says, “People borrow it to put on in a yard at Turning-Week. Bring it back when you’re done.” The week Molevad means is when a town Turns its children.

A reader is meant to understand that this is a scene players can perform straight from the page, with a table, a tall chair, and a lantern, and that no theatre is needed. Two cousins of a Closed house were Turned in the same week. One was hugged, and the other received a storm-grey leaf, so that cousin is the one the Tree gave a colour, which is a Condition. A clerk of the Book strikes the Given cousin from the heir-roll and writes the name again on the page of turns of work. The Given cousin is sent to the far end of the table, and the hugged cousin is given the heir’s chair and a gate key.

The scene does not say which cousin got the better life. The hugged cousin keeps the seat, and has to stay inside the walls and hold the keys. The Given cousin loses the seat, owes heavier work, and can walk out of the gate any morning. The play ends on a question nobody in it answers.

A poem

The page is *A Room I Do Not Go Into*. It is kept on Molevad’s long-house shelf in Lestrand. The copy has no name on it, and a Long-Lived writer wrote it. Molevad keeps the shelf. If a visitor asks, Molevad says, “One of us wrote it. Read it.”

A reader is meant to understand that the poem is about a person who has five summers they no longer remember, and a room they walk past and do not open. People who read it often ask whether it is about the cup, where the Pourers give years of memory away, one year at a time. If anyone asks Molevad, or any other Long-Lived person at the shelf, whether the poem is about the cup, that person will not say whether it is.

A road song

The page is *The Day-Road Count*. It is kept at the gate clerk’s desk at Rothallo’s gate, written on the back of an old sleep-line sheet, the list of who slept in the beds outside the wall. Breolnir, the gate clerk, keeps that desk and writes the list. If a visitor asks, Breolnir says, “The school children sing it on the road to the wood. Pilgrims keep asking for the words, so I keep a copy.”

A reader is meant to understand that this is a counting song the school beside the Book’s house teaches children to sing as they walk the day’s road from Rothallo to the Awakening Tree. It counts the Kept the way the Close teaches. At every town Tree on the road, and even under the Awakening Tree, the song has every child receive a colour, and nobody is hugged. Only at the end, back at Rothallo’s wall, does the song find a hug.

The song is wrong, because a tree-warden sees children hugged at every Leaf-Fall, in every town, and under the Awakening Tree itself, and a warden who hears children singing it on the road can tell. The song gives no numbers of its own.

Book VII

Powers and Places

The Fifteen Powers

The fifteen

Fifteen named powers stand across the three large continents. Each one has a common name you say at the table and, where the old form still survives, a written name a charter, a rite, or a learned map will use, so at the table you say *the Night Shore* and *the Far Yield*, while a factor's docket may write *Netstrand* and *Vaelhesk*. A factor works for a house and prices routes and berths, and the docket is the page that house is willing to show a stranger. The Hinge Shore has no current written form of that older kind. *Eolstrand* is the retired name of that slot, replaced because the compound had crowded three names that already had jobs: *Eoloren*, the witnessed hinge and the clerical year-count; *Eolthael*, a month; and *Eolvaeth*, a city. A few old dockets still carry the crossed-out form. Current speech and current writing use the Hinge Shore.

Kumbaan, which the maps also call the Sundering Isle, is not a sixteenth power. It is an isolate with a table, a moon, and a storm-wall, a people at home on their own island, and it is not a flag on the Seat's list. A mile-shrine is a stone along a road, about a day's walk, often with a ribbon and a name, and the Isle has none.

Beneath the fifteen the world still swarms with marches, free towns, petty Tree-seats, and wild that no polity has claimed. A Tree-seat is a town that answers to its own Turning Tree, the tree grown from a graft, a cutting of living wood, so a child can stand under it. Fifteen names the powers worth naming at this table, while the marches, the free towns, and the wild continue under that count.

Continent	Reach	How many	Why that many
Maiethorn	full	**6**	The old heart, a clutch of kingdoms competing for the grove and the Old Crossing.
Strandoren	high	**5**	A constellation of coasts and compacts, with no single market wearing a crown.
Heskoren	thin	**4**	Fewer, poorer, and scattered, with a long wild between the Trees.
The Sundering Isle	near-none	**0**	The Isle is not on this list.

The name a polity gives itself shows the stance it has taken. The root sits in the old tongue, and the sound then drifts with that polity's devotion and with how far its Trees reach. On this page, **CAPS** mark the stress, `ae` is "ay", and `th` is the *th* of *thin*.

On Maiethorn the speech stays conservative. Pious talk keeps the *th* and the long vowels, which is why the Mother-names cluster in that country, why Threnmaieth counts her, and why Maiethvael gives in her name and will not count.

On Heskoren the speech is worn. Ordinary talk takes a *th* that follows a vowel and wears it down to *t*, and careful prayer puts the *th* back when the prayer is said. The frontier coinage *hesk-*, the far edge, is younger than the liturgy that still keeps the older sounds. The name written Vaethorn is spoken *Wetorn*. Ornled lets the old ending go. On this continent, dropping that sound is heard as a neglect, so the fuller reconstruction *Ornledd* goes unused.

On Strandoren the speech is eroded. A *th* goes to *t* or drops out, and the ends of words get clipped. Lestrand is the most drifted of the old three, the faith worn off the docks and the *th* worn off with it. Trenledd is what happens when *thren*, the sacred counting, itself wears down to a roll. The reconstruction *Threnledd* goes unused, because they will not say the holy word.

Every polity sets three things, and it sets them independently of one another.

Theology is how gift-devout the place is. At one end an ardent Motherfaith, the faith of the Leaf-Mother, takes the gift into ordinary life. The Leaf-Mother is the mother the hymns give the Tree, the one those hymns address. At the other end the polity is frankly secular, and it does not take the gift into the life of the place. That choice is already at work before the law speaks, because it decides how people read the Struck, who changed later and alone, the Kept, whom a Tree hugged and did not mark, and the Conditions a place has learned to fear. A Condition is the change a person comes to carry, and

a Kind is the ancestry they were born with, so the two stack on the same person: what you become is a Condition, and what you were born is a Kind.

Reach is the difference between a Tree-rich core and a Tree-poor edge. Where healthy Trees stand, reach is full, and the Given are dense. The Given are the people a Tree marked at the Leaf-Fall, the tenth-year festival, when a leaf’s colour names what the child will carry. Where the Trees are few, young, or sickening, more children come away Kept, and more people are Struck later, at some other threshold, with fewer witnesses standing by.

Governance is how far the state reaches onto the person. It runs from light guild self-rule, the warm default of this world, all the way to a crown that writes its subjects down.

The fifteen at a glance

The table reads on those three axes. **T** is theology, Motherfaith gift-devotion, **R** is reach, and **G** is governance. A filled mark, ●, is high, a half mark, ◖, is mid, and an empty mark, ○, is low. The three corners that were set down first stay the reference points, and the other twelve are read between them.

Spoken handle	Written form	Continent	T	R	G	One-line feel
the Tallied Crown	Threnmaieth	Maiethorn	●	●	●	They keep a census and call it care, and the origin towns sit under that roll.
the Gift-Realm	Maiethvael	Maiethorn	●	●	○	The country is plentiful, and it keeps no list.
the Witness-Hearths	Orenbren	Maiethorn	●	●	◖	Lodging is the power, and the power does not own the Tree.
the Sown Tree	Saelthael	Maiethorn	●	◖	○	On the Rain-Shadow, they are still planting.
the Hinge Shore	the Hinge Shore	Maiethorn	◖	●	○	It faces the Old Crossing, and it classifies the hull.
the Thaw-Land	Lirorn	Maiethorn	◖	●	◖	It holds the Rain-Wall, and it holds the snowmelt.
the Ledger Coast	Lestrand	Strandoren	○	●	○	The trade is priced, and the coast stays free.
the Hearth-League	Brenledd	Strandoren	○	●	○	Many charters sit inside one compact.
the Reckoned Gift	Leddvael	Strandoren	○*	●	◖	The Fair Hand is kept here as a civic rite.
the Worn Count	Trenledd	Strandoren	○	●	●	It keeps a roll, and the hymn has worn off that roll.
the Night Shore	Netstrand	Strandoren	◖	●	○	It watches for hulls that do not arrive.
the Waiting Lands	Vaethorn	Heskoren	●	○	○	The gift is scarce here, and the faith runs hot.
the Outer Ledger	Ornled	Heskoren	○	○	○	A secular frontier, with no net of congregations under it.
the Far Yield	Vaelhesk	Heskoren	◖ **	○	○	Host-rights, kept in the manner of the Old Ways.

Spoken handle	Written form	Continent	T	R	G	One-line feel
the Sown Waiting	Saelvaeth	Heskoren	◖	○	◖	The live front is kept as a march.

* **Leddvael** sits low on Motherfaith and high on the Fair Hand, the fortune-and-contract faith of the Strandoren docks, which reads a gift as a bargain with terms. The theology mark still measures gift-devotion. A rival faith filling that gap is not a fourth mark. ** **Vaelhesk** is the same shape, with the Old Ways where Leddvael has the Fair Hand. The Old Ways are the ancestor-practice of doors and first meals, older than the grafts on Heskoren.

Three more corners sit on the map beside the three drawn first: Maiethvael, devout, rich, and lightly governed; Trenledd, a cold surveillance with no faith to sanctify it; and Ornled, a secular frontier with the same thin Trees as the Waiting Lands and no net of congregations underneath.

The fifteen are hearth-countries, countries of towns and households, and none of them is one born people under a crown. The Sown Tree is sand-country. It is not a kingdom of the Fox of the Sands, the fox-born who come into the world with a fox’s ears and a brush of tail, pale and huge-eared because the dry ground shaped that line. The Thaw-Land is a watershed. It is not an empire of the Tengu, the crow-born of the high country, lean, sharp-featured people with dark feathers through their hair and down their arms. The Hinge Shore and the Night Shore are shores. They are not sea-realms of the Selkie, the sea-born, who carry a hereditary sealskin and belong to shore and sea at once. The Far Yield keeps host-rights, the custom of giving a guest the first meal before anyone leaves with something of the place. It is not a nation of the Taken-In, the people the wild has taken partway into itself, bark at the knuckles and moss in the hair, whom a hard country puts to work on the living earth.

The Watching stays a heartland heresy inside Maiethorn’s districts. It is an older Tree-faith the Motherfaith grew over. They keep the Tree, they refuse the Mother-name, and they say the colours fall because the Tree sees, not because a mother chooses. Leddvael is the one power that made a rival faith civic. Even there the Book-Hands, the clerks who stamp a Fair Hand signing and recite its terms, have no seat of their own.

How they sit

Maiethorn holds six of the fifteen, on the old heart, the country of the grove. The six inherit one grove-gate that fell, not six ancient kingdoms, and they are still competing for that grove and for the Old Crossing, the oldest trade route in the world.

The Tallied Crown, written Threnmaieth, sits coiled near the sacred centre because it wants everyone written onto the Threnhael, the roll of persons it keeps and calls care. Its seat is Maiethlir. The Hand

there, the town's own Turning Tree, stands on the Core-thaw, the meltwater river Maiethlir sits on, and that Hand is not the grove. Pilgrims still walk on from the town to Thaeloren, the Awakening Tree, and the crown does not own it. The First Seat, the college of tree-wardens, stays in the Motherwood beside the town.

The Gift-Realm, written Maiethvael, shares the Mother the hymns address and refuses the list, so it sings the same hymns Threnmaieth sings and keeps the opposite paper. Its capital is Seinbrun.

The Witness-Hearths, written Orenbren, are the lodging-country of the Near Mile, the approach road to the grove, and the rule there is civic rather than clerical. The First Seat sits in the Motherwood beside them and is not their crown. Their capital is Rothallo, still called the Inner Close, standing inside Orenbren and not a power of its own. The Third Hearth is one lodging-hearth on that road, three days out from the grove. The Mill-hold, two days past Brenthael, is a Hands-town whose Hand is unsound this year, so its children walk in toward Brenthael, the neighbour town whose own Tree can still do the week's work. Nelath is a spur that leaves the Mile a day short of the Third Hearth and then stops.

The Sown Tree, written Saelthael, is the leeward east, still walking west after the core stopped, with its city at Larbril and the smaller well-town, Ornsael, farther into the dry.

The Hinge Shore faces Strandoren across the Old Crossing and classifies the hull at Votaer, deciding what a ship is before anyone across the water prices it.

The Thaw-Land, written Lirorn, holds the Rain-Wall, which the people of the range call the Thaw-Wall and lowlanders call the Rain-Wall, and its town is Tasain, in a sheltered valley below the Shelf-gate. Fox-of-the-Snows hearths, the white-coated fox-born of the high snow, sit densest on that snow, and so do Tengu hearths, though neither of those peoples has the snow as their country.

Strandoren holds five, along coasts and compacts, with no single crown over them. They inherit a Salt Walk that outlived the grove-gate, the old sea-then-land road to a Turning, and a fever that made people write new paper.

Lestrand is the premier coast, seated at Orentel on the Salt Quay, where the White Note keeps a house on the third quay that writes terms and does not wear the crown, while Brenledd, the Hearth-League, sits its council at Raitin and stays a league of hearths rather than becoming one house. Along the same shore, Leddvael keeps the signing-watch at Naenor, Trenledd keeps a roll of persons at Lunbra on the Chart-run and leaves its ruler unnamed, and Netstrand quotes the far crossing from Braetu while it watches for hulls that do not arrive.

Heskoren holds four, with a long wild between the Trees. They came into the clocks late, host-rights were already on the ground when the wood arrived, and waiting, sowing, and slate are three answers to the same late cart.

Vaethorn preaches the waiting-gospel, the hot faith of a country where the gift is scarce, from its seat at Eolvaeth on the pilgrim-edge, which is not Saelvaeth's march, not Harrow's Green, and not the three hamlets past the ford.

Saelvaeth, the Sown Waiting, stands its march-voice at Natai. Harrow's Green sits in the orbit of that voice, a grove-town whose Tree grew up enough to do the week's work, and it stays out of the seat.

Vaelhesk, the Far Yield, keeps the land itself as the seat, so the First Bowl, which folk call *Lonasir*, stays a guest-grove, and a traveler who asks for the seat is pointed at a door.

Ornled, the Outer Ledger, keeps the secular frontier's slate at Sanbreo.

The Three Hamlets Past the Ford sit on the seam where those four can all be heard. From the hamlets you can see Harrow's canopy, which is counted as Saelvaeth's luck, and you can still hear Vaethorn's guilt and Vaelhesk's refusal. Folk call the three *Brenod*, *Vaelun*, and *Ornath*. The Seat still does not use those names.

What the fifteen inherited is younger than a row of ancient kingdoms, and two clocks still organize a life beside that inheritance: how a person Turned, by the old walk to the grove or under a town Tree, and how far the wood has reached. The clerical count, the Cut-years, runs from the First Cut, the grafting's arrival, and the present year of that count is Cut-year 387, which is why a border, a rate, or a grudge can be pointed at the year that left it. In the Closing, from Cut-year 19 to 38, the old gate on the one Tree tried to pull the copied Trees up and could not. In Cut-year 171 the Grey Summer, which the docks call the Salt-Grey, was a quay-fever in which people died who already had a local Tree, and no colour fell with the fever, so the summer never became a Tithe. When a household fails for want of what keeps it whole, that failing is a fade. In Cut-year 304 the Hinge Hush ended a fight between the Hinge Shore and the Ledger Coast over who set the toll, and the rate it left still covers hulls without covering the origin-winter, the prestige year a household books at the grove.

Polity	What they inherited	The live claim or grudge
Threnmaieth	The Two Papers, in Cut-year 67, when the crown-count started on Limrae's desk. The present Crown-year is **320**.	Maiethvael will not be named to the roll, and the Close's Book is the insult next door.
Maiethvael	The same split, because Manril would not be listed.	Threnmaieth brings its tablets to a furnished green. The hymn is the same, and the paper is the opposite.
Orenbren	The Closing: hearths that would not starve, and the guest-compact with the Retreat.	The beds sit outside the wall and the Book sits inside it. Threnmaieth wants the lodging-rolls.
Saelthael	Slower grafts, a matter of the dirt, and the Thaw-Break, the one-week melt of Cut-year 233, which cut the west-road for two summers.	The core calls that ground waiting soil. They still walk west.
the Hinge Shore	The oldest crossing, the Grey Summer, and a signing of the Hinge Hush through Taerso.	The live claim is the Hush-rate. A blessing is given when someone asks for one, and they learned to step around a fade.
Lirorn	A watershed holding, and Narol's pass after the Break.	Threnmaieth wants the high road counted, and the ridge pays for water the valley drinks.
Lestrand	Salt Walk paper that outlived the gate, the Grey notes, and a signing of the Hush through Sirtol.	Brenledd will not be priced one hearth at a time. The White Note House speaks for one quay, and it is not the crown.
Brenledd	A compact piled in Cut-year 174 after the Salt-Grey, still recited under the hearth-name Nidtol, and a side-paper of the Hush.	Lestrand still offers to simplify them, and the fade happens in the gaps between the charters.
Leddvael	A civic Settling, the Fair Hand's signed close, made after the witnesses died in the Grey.	A gift-reading family is treated as a bad debtor. A Bound person, someone who swore a contract, is treated as the shape of honesty.
Trenledd	Dirrol's person-column, written after the Grey.	They wanted the Hush written down as souls, and both shores refused. The roll they kept is colder than the Threnhael.

Polity	What they inherited	The live claim or grudge
Netstrand	The west-water clause of the Hush, which covers hulls and does not cover the origin-winter.	They quote the far crossing. For them, night is a watch kept for ships that do not arrive.
Vaethorn	The late wave, and a Hush clause that says they may bless a landing and may not levy it.	Ornled has no hymn, Saelvaeth has a pot without Vaethorn's due, and the guilt in the waiting-gospel wants both of those neighbours unworthy.
Ornled	A refusal of the waiting-gospel, Vathne's slate after a Thaw-Break pot died, and a beach-fee under the Hush.	Vaethorn hears godlessness in the refusal, and Ornled keeps no net of congregations.
Vaelhesk	Host-rights older than the wave, and those rights are not written on the Hush clause.	A first meal given to a guest is not a landing-due. Vaethorn reads Vaelhesk's children as Kept-for-want.
Saelvaeth	A live march running from the Cut-year 200s, and a Hush clause that lets them take a pot without paying a waiting-due.	The queue is the border, and Harrow's luck is politics.

Rothallo, still called the Inner Close, sits inside Orenbren and remembers the Closed Seat rather than a continent of its own. The Closed Seat was the old gate on the one Tree, the class that decided who might walk up to Thaeloren. In the Closing, the war of Cut-year 19 to 38, that gate tried to pull the copied Trees up and could not, and what remained went behind the Close's walls. The Book kept there ranks who owes, and Rothallo is not a sixteenth flag.

Two lists of the same fifteen

A clerk of the Seat and a Lestrand factor do not hand you the same map, and the shared practice is what keeps the peace between them. You belong by the rite you actually keep, so a Watcher who brings a child, a Settler of the Fair Hand who stands witness to the colour, and a speaker of the Old Ways who also walks the old doors can all stand at the same Leaf-Fall. Doctrine fights, and the festival usually does not. The list each speaker is willing to write is what gives that speaker away.

> ***From a Cut-year minute, First Seat (Cut-year 387).*** *Threnmaieth names itself the Reckoning and would name us. Maiethvael will not be named to them and still gives the extra mile. Orenbren lodges what we do not house. Saelthael still walks, which the origin*

> *finds inconvenient. The Hinge Shore takes the Old Crossing. Lirorn takes the thaw. Across the water the factor's five: Lestrand, the Brenledd compact, Leddvael which files a Bound as a civic virtue, Trenledd which keeps a roll and will not call it a Threnhael, Netstrand which sells the west. On the far reach: Vaethorn waiting, Saelvaeth planting, Vaelhesk feeding a first meal we did not authorize, Ornled which will not say her name and will not keep a list either. Kumbaan is not a land we graft. We do not write it.*
>
> ***From a house-year docket, a Lestrand factor.*** *Price the Hinge Shore and do not argue hymns with the Gift-Realm. The Witness-Hearths' beds are a market that calls itself a duty. Avoid the Worn Count's roll unless you like being written. The Reckoned Gift will sign; that is cheaper than faith. The Hearth-League is many tickets. The Night Shore quotes the far crossing like a pilgrimage. Heskoren: the Waiting pays in blessing, the Outer Ledger in slate, the Far Yield in a meal you had better eat, the Sown Waiting in whatever the queue did this year. The Isle is a tale. We do not book it.*

Neither list is complete, and both are true of the speaker who wrote them.

The three corners

Say the Waiting Lands, the Ledger Coast, and the Tallied Crown. Charters, rites, and learned maps write *Vaethorn*, *Lestrand*, and *Threnmaieth*. The same law, the same Tithe, and the same family life run through all three, and the three settings turn them into different places. Each pair shares exactly one setting and differs on the other two.

The Waiting Lands and the Ledger Coast share a light state, and that is the only setting they share, one of them warm, poor, and faithful, the other rich, cool, and secular. The Waiting Lands and the Tallied Crown share the same ardent faith and live it in different circumstances, devotion at a thin edge beside devotion in a sanctified core that watches its people. The Ledger Coast and the Tallied Crown share the same wealth of Trees and spend it in opposite directions, free markets on the Coast and a census of persons held as holy under the Crown.

Theology is not a measure of good or bad. High theology produces both the kindest of these corners to a whole neighbour and the most inescapable control in the world, because devotion multiplies whatever else the polity already is, and each corner owns the harm that multiplication makes. Warm faith, free markets, and sanctified order produce different harms, through different institutions. A polity's name for a shared thing shows the stance, which is why a devout land's gift-hall, where a Far-Voiced vents feeling at worship, is a surveillance-crown's counted hall.

Threnmaieth: the Tallied Crown

(THREN-mai-eth. The name sets thren, sacred counting, beside maieth, the Mother, and it means the Mother's Reckoning. People say the Tallied Crown. The crown writes Threnmaieth. Theology high, reach high, governance high.)

Threnmaieth is a pious, Tree-rich core kingdom that is also Watchful, the far end of governance, a crown that writes its subjects down. It keeps a census of persons and of the Conditions they carry, and it does this in the wealthiest, most devout, most Tree-dense land, so the roster is kept as sanctified duty. The Mother's gifts are precious, and the crown's answer is that they must be accounted for. Trenledd keeps a roll of persons too. The difference is that the Tallied Crown calls its roll holy, and Trenledd does not. The other two corners have injustices you can name and resent. This one dresses its injustice in the two things the world most trusts, faith and plenty.

Law. The record is held on people, every subject and the gift they carry written down. Guild rolls and tax ledgers exist everywhere. What is unusual here is a census of persons, framed at home as reverent stewardship of the Mother's blessings and lived, from outside, as surveillance. Other cities nest the witness as a hearth-stand, a quay-gang or a courtyard small enough that someone actually saw you Turn, and then they stop. Threnmaieth copies that stand onto the Threnhael, and the copying is the whole difference. Reach is high, so there is a great deal to count: dense Given, dense guilds, and abundant Long-Lived, the ageless keepers of memory, whose memory the crown distrusts precisely because it is not the crown's. That distrust is the Tallied Crown's deepest tell. It will not rely on the three pillars the rest of the world runs on: Long-Lived memory, which keeps what a person witnessed even a century later; a Bound's sworn word, which closes a bargain and belongs to someone who can hear a lie as it is told; and Far-Voiced feeling, which comes through in the voice and is hard to fake on a stand. Living memory, word, and feeling answer to themselves, and a ledger answers to the crown. The unvouched are hunted, and the Struck are pursued so they can be catalogued. The Bound are watched far past their real hazard, stigma dressed as safety, because the Inviolate Will, the maxim every child is taught, says the will is one's own. The Whisper that comes with a Bound debt can suggest, and it cannot command another person's will, which the roster's own clerks know. Devotion supplies the justification a bare Watchful crown lacks. You would not hide a gift from the Mother, so why hide it from her stewards?

Economy. Tithe-need, the upkeep a person requires in order to carry what they have become, has been turned into leverage, and then consecrated. The crown provides that upkeep efficiently, even generously, because a pious, rich state can afford to, and it holds what it provides. The green a Taken-In needs, time on living earth, the novelty a Long-Lived needs, new books and new things to learn so the years do not go stale, the outlets where a Far-Voiced can vent, and the medicine of the Stilled, whose gaze can hold a wound or a patient still, all come through channels the crown controls and can withhold. A population whose staying-whole runs through the state cannot afford to refuse it. That is the most complete control anywhere, and here it wears a halo. To receive your provision is to receive

the Mother's bounty through her appointed hands. To be cut off is framed as your lapse, not the crown's lever. Its deathless-house finance, the credit of houses that do not die when their founders do, is excellent and centuries-deep. The Long-Lived here are courtiers and crown-archivists as much as bankers, their memory bent to the census rather than left free to check it.

Daily life. Sacrament and census run together. A child's Turning, the hour they stand at the Tree, is a joyous holy day that is also a state registration. The colour that falls is celebrated with a hymn and recorded by a clerk. Marriages of heritable Conditions, Two-Bodied bloodlines especially, the families who carry a second animal self and pass that animal down, are noticed, encouraged or discouraged, and filed. The medicine that furnishes a Tithe is excellent, and it runs through the crown's channels. A household whose bloodline and upkeep are both on file cannot easily refuse the crown anything. The Kept are pitied here in the warm way, and recorded in the Watchful way, passed over by the Mother, and noted as such.

Its injustice. This is the worst of both high axes, each excusing the other. The devotion sanctifies the surveillance, because it is called reverence to be counted, and the surveillance enforces the devotion, because to refuse the count is called impiety. There is no clean villain. A wealthy, faithful, orderly people believe that accounting for the Mother's gifts is the highest form of tending them, and that belief makes the machinery of control almost impossible to resist. Elsewhere the roll reads as chilling, because only two crowns keep one. Here the faith is what lets it feel like grace.

The seat. Maiethlir *(MAI-eth-lir)* is a Core-thaw Hand in the Sacred Core, one or two days' walk from the wood, on a different road from Orenbren's Near Mile, a thaw-river town whose own Tree Turns the town's children. The older job of this ground is the extra mile, and devotion still sends people on that walk, on from the town toward the grove. The Threnhael is the roll laid over that older walk. Thaeloren stands outside this crown. The First Seat stays in the wood beside Maiethlir, and the seat does not own the grove.

What they remember. The Two Papers, in Cut-year 67, are what this crown calls the year the reckoning stood. Limrae opened a desk and wrote persons down, because a gift you cannot find again, as they said it, is a gift you have already failed to tend. The crown-count starts in that year. A devout clerk may write Cut-year 387 and Crown-year 320 on the same slate, and the difference is the split. Maiethvael is the cousin who would not be named. The Inner Close keeps another list, of rank and not of care, and will not share ink.

Lestrand: the Ledger Coast

(LES-trand. Ledd, to reckon, joined to strand, the shore, and then eroded smooth, so the name means the Reckoning Coast. People say the Ledger Coast. Formal records keep Lestrand. Theology low, reach high, governance low.)

Lestrand is a dense, Tree-rich merchant power. The Trees are mature and many, the Given are dense, and the faith is worn lightly. Deep markets, thin welfare, and a cool, transactional read on becoming are the character of the place. It shares the Waiting Lands' light-touch governance, in that no crown writes anyone down. Where the Lands' light state leaves a gap the faith fills, the Coast's light state leaves a space the guilds fill.

Law. This is the world's warm default carried as far as it goes, guild self-rule at full development. The state is a charter-granting council of merchant houses and craft-guilds. It charters the Stilled's guild and the element-guilds, and it watches the guild, never the individual. Citizenship-by-witness runs smoothly here because reach is high. Long-Lived notaries are abundant, a Bound's sworn word closes a contract, and a Far-Voiced stands on every dock and in every court. A city this size nests that witness as hearths, a quay-gang or a courtyard, rather than asking twenty thousand people to share one memory. The three pillars are not reverence here. They are infrastructure, the machinery that lets a huge commercial city run on trust without a register. Travelers clear on a road-word or a guild-mark. The gate asks three questions, and it does not ask your colour. The Struck are vouched in briskly, as efficiency rather than grace, because an unvouched person is a transaction that cannot clear. The Inviolate Will is cited less as sacred bedrock than as sound commercial law. A Bound's contract binds property, not persons, and the Coast likes that line because it makes the Bound the perfect notary.

Economy. This is the richest of the three corners, and the coolest. Deathless banking is most developed here. Deathless houses, whose trusted notes are the nearest thing the world has to a gold standard, run century instruments, and the endow-not-inherit loop runs at scale. They have no line of heirs waiting on a death, and their own Tithe needs a steady supply of novelty, so the great endowed libraries and universities cluster here and fund that novelty by existing. Self-paying Conditions prosper, because their labor is their upkeep and the market pays for the labor: the Answered, whose craft is an element that answers their hands, the Two-Bodied haulage and courier trades, and the Stilled surgeons. Tithe-provision is a private market, not a public good. You buy your green, your novelty, your outlet, and if you can afford it you stay whole in comfort. The injustice is the market's. The provided-for Tithe-poor, the people whose upkeep someone else has to supply, get thin welfare in a rich city, the starkest have-and-have-not gap anywhere. The shadow economy runs biggest here because the legitimate market is biggest here: smuggled green, black-market novelty, sold vouching, and off-book contracts that feed the Given-Over, a Bound who has contracted away so much of themselves that the counterparty effectively owns the person. The concentration risk the deathless pose is sharpest on this coast. A handful of houses that never die quietly steer the wealthiest polity through patronage that never disperses.

Daily life. Condition-medicine is excellent for those who can reach it. The great Stilled infirmaries and the deathless-endowed hospitals are here, in the rich core, and the queue outside them is the longest here too. Family life shrugs at theology. There is a marriage market that reads Conditions as assets. A Two-Bodied bloodline is a trade dynasty, a Long-Lived match is a century of credit, and the aching

Long-Lived marriage, grief set against advantage, gets weighed coolly. The Turning is a civic and commercial milestone more than a sacrament. A family's Leaf-Fall is watched for what guild the child's colour opens. It is not warm. It is free, and it is prosperous.

Its injustice. This is the coolest of the three. Nothing is policed. Your marriage, your gift, and your faith are your own. Everything is priced, and a person who cannot pay slides while a whole rich city steps around them. The Coast will never file you, and it will never conscript you. It will let you fade if you run out of coin, and it will feel that it owed you nothing.

The seat. Orentel *(OREN-tel)* is a salt-quay city on the Old Crossing. The written name is a witnessing-Tree with the *th* worn off, and coast-folk say the Salt Quay and mean the city. The White Note House sits on the third quay, north side, and it is not the crown.

What they remember. Salt Walk paper outlived the gate of the Closed Seat, and the notes outlived the Grey Summer. The rate the first quay still charges is the Hinge Hush, the peace of Cut-year 304, after five summers in which the Hinge Shore and this coast fought over who set the toll. Sirtol spoke for a pile of charters that was not the White Note and was not a crown. Brenledd piled a compact rather than be priced one hearth at a time. The White Note is one desk-house. It is not the polity.

Vaethorn: the Waiting Lands

(VAETH-orn, spoken Wetorn. Vaeth, the waiting, joined to orn, land, so the name means the Waiting Land. Careful writing and prayer keep the sacred th. People say the Waiting Lands, or simply the Waiting. Theology high, reach low, governance low.)

Vaethorn is a broad, thinly peopled land at the world's Tree-poor margin, where the faith burns hottest because the Trees are scarce, and where the ruling mood is waiting: for a graft, young wood set in this ground, to take, for a distant Tree to be reached, for a gift that may never fall. Where the Trees are few and young, more children come away Kept, more people are Struck later and alone, and the Motherfaith answers that scarcity with more devotion, not less. Pilgrimage, longing, and a theology built around a gift that may not come are the answer the land actually makes.

Law. Governance is almost absent. No crown reaches the individual, and custom outruns written law the way it does on any frontier. Citizenship is witnessed in the oldest, most literal way, a settlement small enough that everyone was there when you Turned. Thin reach makes that fragile. With few Long-Lived to remember and few Bound to vouch, the three pillars that make proof-by-people work are stretched thin. The unvouched Struck, a person who changed alone, with no guild to catch them and few witnesses to stand for them, is a constant, aching problem, and the Waiting Lands meet it with faith rather than machinery. A feared Condition here is more likely to be met with a rope or a blessing than a licence, because there is no guild to issue one.

Economy. There is little formal Tithe-infrastructure and there are few specialists, and the theology reframes that poverty as charity. Where a secular frontier improvises provision as barter and favor, the Waiting Lands do it as alms and congregation. The venting a Far-Voiced needs happens at worship. The green a Taken-In needs is furnished by neighbours who count it a sacred duty. The Taken-In, whom rich cities keep at arm's length and still need on the lots, are here the honoured backbone of the land. Working the living earth is the holy economy. It is commons-minded generosity with almost nothing to fund it: real warmth, real want, and a thin edge where the provided-for Tithe-poor slide with only prayer for a net.

Daily life. Ceremony is thin, and devotion makes what there is of it enormous. A child's Turning at a small, hard-won grafted Tree is the event of a decade, held as a joyous, anxious sacrament. The Kept child is felt most sharply here, because in a land starved of the gift, to be passed over reads, wrongly and cruelly, as being passed over by the Mother herself. Medicine is a travelling stiller if the settlement is lucky, and a rope and a prayer if it is not. The gap between core and edge is at its widest here. Families are warm, mixed, and self-reliant. A lapsing Condition with no infirmary to reach is a frontier tragedy the faith consoles and cannot cure.

Its injustice. The harm is not a boot. It is a guilt. The scarcity of the gift becomes a theology of unworthiness. The Kept wonder what they lacked. The Struck wonder why the Mother came to them at the wrong door and alone. A hard, quiet piety can shade into treating want as a spiritual failing. The Waiting Lands are the kindest place in the world to a whole neighbour and the loneliest to an unvouched one.

The seat. Eolvaeth *(EOL-vaeth)* is a pilgrim-edge vale behind the Strandoren-facing coast. Everyday worn speech shortens the name to Elvaeth *(EL-vaeth)*. People walk here to wait, and the Tree at the end of that wait is not a certainty. The seat is not Harrow's Green, not the three hamlets, and not Saelvaeth's march.

What they remember. The wave arrived late, and the First Cut is the name of that arrival. The Hinge Hush says they may bless a Heskoren landing and may not levy that landing as a gospel-due, which leaves Ornled with no hymn to charge and lets Saelvaeth take a pot, soil and living wood for a graft, without Vaethorn's waiting-price. The guilt in the gospel wants both of those neighbours unworthy. The history of the planting does not agree.

The twelve

The twelve that are not the three corners each have a seat, a capital or a city or a town, except in the Far Yield, where the land itself is the seat and no city was built to hold it. Maiethorn's five are Seinbrun, Rothallo, Larbril, Votaer, and Tasain; Strandoren's four are Raitin, Naenor, Lunbra, and

Braetu; and Heskoren's are Sanbreo, the land of Vaelhesk, and Natai, with the corner capitals standing apart from all of those at Eolvaeth, Orentel, and Maiethlir. What stays unnamed is part of the count: six charter-towns around Raitin, the person who governs Trenledd, and Nidtol, which the Hearth-League still recites as a hearth rather than as a city you can walk into. The Book-Hands have no seat. A square a party can visit does not become a capital by being visitable, and the First Seat stays in the Motherwood, a college of tree-wardens, outside this list of twelve.

Maiethvael: the Gift-Realm

(MAI-eth-vael. Maieth, the Mother, kept and joined to vael, gift, so the name means the Mother's Gift. The old sounds stay. People say the Gift-Realm and Gift-folk. Charters write Maiethvael. Theology high, reach high, governance low.)

Maiethvael is an old, Tree-dense realm of the Motherland that treats Tithe-provision as public tending. Congregation and guild furnish the greens, the halls, and the medicine, rather than a channel a crown can shut. You belong because living people saw you Turn, and there is no Threnhael here. They will tell you that counting persons is a failure of trust in the three pillars. The hymns are the same ones Threnmaieth sings. The paper is not, because Threnmaieth writes people down and Maiethvael will not.

Site. This is full-reach Maiethorn country, in sight of the pilgrimage weather and not built around the grove. The older job of the ground is an origin pilgrimage-country that furnishes. The extra mile, the walk someone still makes toward the grove when a local Tree would have done, is hospitality here. It is not a line on a roll.

Seat. Seinbrun *(SAYN-brun)* is the capital, a large city off the Core-thaw, down that river and north of Maiethlir on the atlas, more than a day from Maiethlir and past the first day below the Down Gate. That first day is the Down-Bank, the road below Maiethlir's gate, and Gift-folk live along it, so a traveler can spend the day among them and still not have arrived. Seinbrun is neither Maiethlir nor the Down-Bank. The smaller towns and villages around it stay unnamed. The hall furnishes what people need, and the city does not keep a list of them.

How it formed. The realm is a gift-country that never accepted a census. In Cut-year 67, the year of the Two Papers, Manril would not be named to Limrae's roll. Maiethvael kept the older proof. You belong because you were seen to Turn, and you stay whole because your neighbours tend what you were Given. The state is light on purpose, because faith and guild do the work a clerk would do elsewhere.

What they remember. They remember the same hymn and the opposite paper. Threnmaieth's crown-count is a river-habit they will not convert to. The Close's Book is someone else's rank.

Structure. Guilds rule themselves under an ardent practice. The realm recruits by office, by faith, and by the Condition a person carries, and not by Kind. The Watching persists in old districts here as it does elsewhere on Maiethorn. It is not a second flag.

Goals. They keep the gift hale without writing the gifted down, and they furnish generously. They pity the Kept in a land that teaches that a hug at the Tree is rare. The land is wrong about that, and it teaches it anyway. The pity is a slight, and it has no thin-Tree excuse, because the Trees here are not scarce.

Its injustice. What hurts here does not arrive as a boot. It is a social tax of piety, real warmth with a real bill attached. Fall out of the congregation and the net goes with it, and there is no crown to appeal to. The Kept here are pitied in the middle of plenty. Threnmaieth at least files them. Maiethvael loves them and cannot stop measuring what they missed.

Orenbren: the Witness-Hearths

(OREN-bren. Oren, to witness, beside bren, hearth, so the name means the witnessing-hearth. People say the Witness-Hearths and Hearth-folk. Charters write Orenbren. It began as a string of inns and became a country, not a single house. Theology high, reach high, governance mid.)

Orenbren is the civic mass of the Near Mile: lodging-squares, upper rooms, and old road-houses that stayed hearths after the walk stopped being required in the core. Pilgrims still come, some of them on the extra mile and some buying the First-Hand year, the prestige season spent near the grove, and Orenbren houses them. The power in that housing is a hold on the beds within a week's walk of the grove, not a crown set on the grove itself. Orenbren does not sell the Coast's product. The berth is Orentel's to hold, the paper is the White Note's to write, the hull may be Netstrand's to charter, and what Orenbren takes is the sleep.

The First Seat sits in the Motherwood beside this power and remains a college, not a throne. Threnmaieth would like the lodging-rolls. Orenbren witnesses who slept, and it does not witness what colour they are. It does not own Thaeloren.

Inside the lodging-country, and not as a sixteenth flag, sits Rothallo *(roh-THAL-oh)*, the walled capital, one day's walk from the wood, still called the Inner Close, and the Close. The walls answer to those names. The Closed Heirs, the households that still claim rank inside those walls, rank the Conditioned by a Book of Tithes. Orenbren calls the arrangement a guest-compact. Its inns lodge anyone outside the wall, and the Book rules inside it. The Close records who owes, Orenbren records who slept, and neither copies the other's records. The guest-compact starts at Hildal's Retreat. In Cut-year 38 Hildal, the last person of the Closed Seat that anyone will still name, ordered that withdrawal, saved a book rather than the grove, and put the beds outside the wall. Smaller towns and villages around the walls

stay unnamed. The First Seat stays in the wood, the wood is not crowned, and Rothallo is not the college.

A Hand stands inside the walls, and the city has no speaker of its own for the Leaf-Fall. A warden of the First Seat may come in for Turning-Week and Speak the fall there. If a colour is copied afterward, the copy is the Close's. The Low Wall is a different run of stone in a fold of the same lodging-country, outside the Close, found already in the ground. The Close will tell you that wall is theirs. The stone is a different colour, and the quarry is not the Close's.

Site. This is Maiethorn's Sacred Core approach-country, an origin pilgrimage-town repeated along the road. A Tree stands at the centre of each square. The road used to go further, and now it ends in a festival season.

How it formed. These were walking-era hearths that federated around the one-week door, the single week in which a child had to be present or miss being Given. In the Closing they would not starve a pilgrim-season in order to save the grove, and that refusal is the lodging-country's first weather. When the Years of Hands made the origin-walk optional, the years in which a town Tree is the ordinary way to Turn, the beds did not empty. The work those beds did became a different job. The lodging-network learned it could levy, charter, and speak as one without becoming clergy.

What they remember. They housed the war by keeping the extra beds open. They did not sit the grove then, and they do not sit it now. Threnmaieth wants the lodging-rolls. The Close ranks who owes.

Structure. Orenbren is many hearth-towns, not a single inn, run by town-wardens and lodging-guilds, and it does not recruit by Kind. Deathless houses exist here as patrons of beds, paying to keep rooms. The Third Hearth is one lodging square of that type, three days out from the grove. Brenthael is the neighbour Hands-town, and its children Turn at home while the Near Mile goes on past its Tree. The Mill-hold, two days past Brenthael, is a Hands-town whose Hand is unsound this year, so its children walk in toward Brenthael. Nelath is a road-end on a spur that leaves the Mile a day short of the Third Hearth and then stops. Rothallo remains the capital, and the seat.

Goals. They keep the extra mile possible, and they charge for it in coin, in duty, or in hymn. Which of the three a given town uses is the local argument. They refuse to be named as the First Seat's civic arm, and they refuse to be named as Threnmaieth's counted inn.

Its injustice. The harm is hospitality as rent, devotion priced as board. A pilgrim who cannot pay the First-Hand year still needs the hug, the moment under the Tree they came for, and the upper room has learned what a bed is worth in Eolthael, the month when the children stand. The kindness comes with a slate.

Saelthael: the Sown Tree

(SAEL-thael. Sael, sowing, beside thael, Tree, so the name means the sown Tree. People say the Sown Tree and Sown-folk. Charters write Saelthael. The shared sael with Saelvaeth, the Sown Waiting, stays visible in the writing, and speech keeps the two powers apart. They are still the Motherland. Theology high, reach mid, a country of wells, governance low.)

Saelthael is the Rain-Shadow, the country leeward and east of the Rain-Wall, dry hills and sand, with towns set at wells and at whatever graft will take. The seasonal water is the Well-wash, on a continent that is otherwise full-reach, though this side of it is thinner wood. The core stopped walking once its own Trees were enough. Saelthael did not. Children still go west in the neighbour's week, the walk to a Tree that can do the work when theirs cannot, or they go further than a week, because a well-Tree is not a certainty.

Fox of the Sands hearths are densest here because the ground is dry, and that density is the terrain, so a town with no fox-born would be the thing worth asking about.

Site. This is Maiethorn's dry east, a Rain-Shadow walk-hold on the west-road the core stopped walking. The hold is the proof that Ornthael, the liturgical name of the present years, meaning Tree-land, the years in which a town Tree is supposed to be enough, is unfinished even on the origin continent. Ornsael *(ORN-sael)*, the sown-ground, stays the smaller well-town, farther into the dry, and it is still walking west. Its drink is a well.

Seat. Larbril *(LAR-bril)* is the city, a medium one, where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass. Walking west, the Shelf-gate is still ahead. Walking east, the dry is in front of you. The Dry Stair is another rise, on its own ground, and it is the local dare that is not a Tree. They climb it so they know the difference, and then they walk west. The Stair is not the reason for the city. The city is here because the road meets the wash.

How it formed. Tree-seats formed around wells and around grafts that took slowly. From Cut-year 0 to 80 the work was slower here, and the cause was dirt, not a different gospel. When the origin-squares became Hands-country, places where a local Tree could do the week's work, the sand-country kept the habit of going to a healthier canopy. That habit grew into a polity of the people who still sow. The Thaw-Break, the one-week melt of Cut-year 233, cut the west-road for two summers, so some children went later and some missed the door. The Given-door, the week in which a child can still be Given, did not loosen.

What they remember. The core calls their waiting a matter of soil. They still walk west.

Structure. Custom is light. Town-wardens keep it, and the wells are a civic fact, something the town has to manage whether or not anyone is devout that week. The realm does not recruit by Kind. The Taken-In are honoured here as they are on any thirsty land, the backbone of the work and not a nation of their own.

Goals. They keep grafts alive in thin soil, they keep the west-road open, and they refuse the core's story that waiting here is a spiritual failing.

Its injustice. The motherland treats their waiting as a local soil-problem, which is true as far as it goes, and also as a slight against the origin. Plenty sits next door. The pilgrimage has become a leftover they cannot retire. Vaethorn's guilt, the teaching that want is a failing of the soul, has been imported onto sand that never asked for it.

The Hinge Shore

(The Hinge Shore is the name people say and the name the maps write, and its people are Hinge-folk. Some old dockets write Eolstrand, a form no current authority uses. Theology mid, reach high, governance low.)

These are Maiethorn's western ports on the Old Crossing. The shore is ancient and rich, and less frantic than the Ledger Coast. The Trees are still healthy, because this is still the Motherland. Faith is worn thinner here than in Maiethvael, because a dock's work is to sort one arrival from another.

Lestrand prices the crossing, and the Hinge Shore sorts it, which is why a child, a pot of living earth, a Given-Over, a recanter, and a necessity-family on a neighbour's week can all make the quay-bell ring the same note. A recanter is someone taking back a standing, the claim that a witness watched them. A necessity-family is walking because the Tree at home cannot do the work. The bell does not tell those arrivals apart. A clerk writes which docket they belong on, and that writing is the job. The Standing Trade, the people who sell a standing, works this face more often than Orentel, because a standing has to travel and this is the water it has to cross.

Selkie families are common on these quays, as they are on any old water. That is a hearth of families, not a sea-realm with the Selkie as its flag.

Site. The shore is the Old Crossing's other face, salt-adjacent quays on the side of the Salt Walk where people landed. People left Strandoren and came ashore here. The Hush-rate, the charge the Hinge Hush left behind, is collected as old custom. They will not call it a victory.

Seat. Votaer *(VOH-tayr)* is the port, one of the largest on this coast, because the crossing is why the people are there. Hulls are classified on those quays, and the Hush-rate is charged there. The port faces Orentel without becoming a second Orentel. The White Note writes its terms on Orentel's third quay, not on this one. Towns and villages along the rest of the shore stay unnamed.

How it formed. Port-kings and charter-harbours grew up on the crossing. The tongue stayed conservative because the grove is at their backs, and the devotion stayed middling because Lestrand is in front of them. A hinge has two sides. The Grey Summer taught this pious shore how to step around a

fade without putting the blessing down. The cooler way of doing things that Lestrand is known for began here as the weather of that summer, not as a conversion.

What they remember. Taerso spoke the Hush for the hinge-houses. The name is a desk, not a throne. They charge the rate, and they say the blessing if a customer wants one.

Structure. The shore is a guild-coast with a light state and old houses. It does not recruit by Kind. The Far-Voiced stand on every quay as infrastructure, the same as on Strandoren, with more hymn left in the voice.

Goals. They keep the Old Crossing as the world's highway by classifying a hull before anyone prices it, and they broker pilgrimage-traffic and cargo without becoming Threnmaieth's counted port or Lestrand's priced one.

Its injustice. The harm is category as fate. Lestrand will let you fade, and it will feel that it owed you nothing. The Hinge Shore will bless you in the same hour that it files you, and a Tithe-poor household fails in sight of the pilgrimage-road with a hymn still in the air. They learned that step-around by looking across the water in a grey summer. They kept the hymn so they would not have to call the step a conversion.

Lirorn: the Thaw-Land

(LIR-orn. Lir, thaw, water that runs again, beside orn, land. People say the Thaw-Land and Thaw-folk. Charters write Lirorn. They call the range the Thaw-Wall. Lowlanders say the Rain-Wall. Theology mid, reach high, governance mid.)

Lirorn is Maiethorn's highland spine: high snow, towns you reach by rope or by wing, and rivers that begin as thaw. Reach is still full, which here means the grafts take in the valleys and on the sheltered shelves, but the weather is the bigger fact, and the state is a watershed holding, organized around the water rather than around a cathedral square. The lowlands drink Lirorn's spring, and the ridges have noticed. Maiethlir drinks the Core-thaw, the melt that comes off this wall, and that thirst is a lever Lirorn can use.

Tengu ridge-towns and Fox-of-the-Snows hearths sit densest here. Every shelf is mixed Kinds, people of more than one birth. A lowlander arriving on foot is a guest who climbed. A wing-post is a job a person holds, not an order closed to every other birth. Sky-couriers hear first, and the hearing has a price.

Site. The holding is the Rain-Wall, where ridge-roads run along the old walking-paths to the grove, stones stand in the high squares, and some of those roads now end at a local Tree. Crossing the range takes two passes. The Noon Pass is the water-line over the old ribbon-notch, the mark where travelers

used to tie a ribbon, and it stays a pass, higher and older than the road below. The Shelf-gate is the road Narol took after the Thaw-Break.

Seat. Tasain *(tah-SAYN)* is the walled town in a sheltered valley below the Shelf-gate, where the west road comes down and the levy is taken, reckoned on how much snow fell the winter before. The town gate is Tasain's own wall, and the Shelf-gate is the pass above it, while the villages and hamlets stay up on the shelves and Larbril sits on the dry side of that pass. Narol of the Pass is dead. The household that inherited the toll still levies Break-rate, the toll named for the Thaw-Break, even in a kind year, and will not explain it to a lowlander. No new person is named beside Narol.

How it formed. The holding grew as march-holds on the snowmelt. Governance sits in the middle because water is a fact you can levy without taking a census of souls. You tax the thaw, you tax the pass, and you tax the high road. Theology cooled because of the height and the distance from the grove's daily pressure, not because anyone here stopped believing. In Cut-year 233 the levy became visible as a water-line, and that year gave the older injustice its name.

What they remember. After 233 they named the Shelf-gate, and Lirorn charged for the water anyway. Threnmaieth still wants the high road counted. The people stay off the Threnhael, and the keepers of that roll will name a pass when they can.

Structure. Ridge-compacts, pass-tolls, and valley charters sit under the one holding. The holding does not recruit by Kind.

Goals. They keep the passes and the spring, and they mean to be paid for water the core calls a gift.

Its injustice. The ridge pays in isolation for water the valley files as a gift. When a shelf-town's graft sickens, that town is also a long way from a stiller. The state is large enough to levy, and not large enough to furnish every Tithe on a cliff. A toll that feels like geography feels like 233 if you were on the shelf when the water-line was drawn. The Core-thaw runs louder the week before Leaf-Fall. That week belongs to Maiethlir, and Maiethlir does not explain it. It is not this holding's sermon.

Brenledd: the Hearth-League

(BREN-ledd. Bren, hearth, beside ledd, to reckon, so the name means hearths of the ledger. The older sounds have worn down the way names wear on this coast. People say the Hearth-League, the compact, and League-folk. Charters write Brenledd. Theology low, reach high, governance low.)

On Strandoren, Brenledd is a league of charter-towns, river-ports, lesser harbours, and inland markets, that compacted together so they could face Lestrand's houses without becoming one house themselves. A charter is the writing a town actually lives by. Each town remains a hearth, with its own Tree in the square and its own vouching, which is simply someone of that square standing up to say a person

belongs there. The compact is the arithmetic that makes the separate hearths worth joining. They share tickets, they share notes of credit, and they share a refusal to be priced one town at a time.

Faith is worn lightly here, the same as along the rest of this coast, and the Trees are mature. The league polices nothing. What it means to keep, it writes into a charter.

Site. The towns sit behind and between the premier coast: salt towns, river towns, and some road-end Tree-towns that federated rather than fade into the hinterland of a deathless house.

Seat. Raitin *(RAY-tin)* is the throne-city, a river-city and one of the largest on this shore, which is where the council sits and where the shared notes clear. The shared list is seven hearths, Raitin among them, with six charter-towns sitting alongside that still have no names. Villages and hamlets stay off the list. People still recite Nidtol when Lestrand offers to deal with one ruler instead of seven hearths. Nidtol is that recited hearth, not the throne-city, and not a city of its own. Raitin is not a second Orentel. The league means to stay a league of hearths rather than become one house.

How it formed. The towns got tired of being the other party on a Lestrand note. After the Grey Summer, in Cut-year 174, Nidtol's hearth piled the first shared refusal: berth-fees charged in a summer when there were no berths, and notes called in early because a house was frightened. No king founded the league, because a set of charters began acting together, and that shared acting is what the league is. The Hinge Hush added a side-paper later, so hinge-tolls will not price them one hearth at a time either.

What they remember. Lestrand still offers to simplify them, which would turn the many hearths into one party at the table. They are still reciting the refusal.

Structure. A council of hearths runs the compact, and you are of your town first. The league does not recruit by Kind. Someone vouched in one Brenled square may still be a stranger in the next, because the compact moves coin better than it moves standing.

Goals. They want many tickets to stay cheaper than dealing with one house. The towns underwrite each other, and they stay a league in the seasons when Lestrand would rather negotiate with a single spokesman.

Its injustice. The harm is falling between charters. You can be vouched in one town and unknown in the next, and Tithe-provision stays a town matter the compact will not touch. Welfare stays thin inside a rich network, and a person fades in the gaps the league calls local, because no single charter has been written to catch them.

Leddvael: the Reckoned Gift

(LEDD-vael. Ledd, to reckon, beside vael, gift, so the name means the gift reckoned. People say the Reckoned Gift and Gift-clerks. Charters write Leddvael. Motherfaith devotion is low. The Fair Hand is worn as civic law. Reach high, governance mid. They do not rewrite Bound Terms.)

Leddvael is a signing-coast on Strandoren that took the Fair Hand off the dock, where it had been a theology of terms, and made it a civic rite, so Leaf-Fall is a festival and a signing-watch, with clerks there to see the term opened. The Tithe is treated as a term to be serviced, and the Bound are model citizens here, employed as the shape of honesty rather than kept at a distance. Governance sits in the middle, where the book works as a kind of statute and stops short of a census of souls. They will file a contract, and they will not copy Threnmaieth's list.

Site. This is a different stretch of indented coast from Lestrand, with enough water to have grown its own houses. It is a salt quay with a signing-watch, and Fair Hand clerks and Motherfaith tree-tenders work in the same wind. The held prestige berth stays on the Ledger Coast.

Seat. Naenor *(NAY-nor)* is the port where the signing-watch sits, slightly smaller than Orentel. It competes with the Ledger Coast, and it wins the term and loses the berth. The signing happens here, and the prestigious dock does not. Towns and villages along the rest of that coast stay unnamed. The Book-Hands stamp the signings and recite the Terms in this wind. They have no seat of their own, and they do not rewrite Terms. Naenor is not a second Orentel.

How it formed. Fortune-and-contract practice thickened until a charter-coast found it cheaper to establish the Settling, the Fair Hand's signed close, than to argue hymns at every dock. After the Grey Summer the witnesses had died, and a Bound's word still closed a bargain, so the civic rite is that year made into a seal. A habit acquired a seal and became the statute, and no prophet stood at that founding.

What they remember. A Given child is a term opened. In the Grey Summer, honesty was in short supply, and the Bound were the people who kept it.

Structure. A charter-council sits over the book-tables. The coast does not recruit by Kind. Gift-reading families live here, the households that still hear a colour as a gift rather than a price, and they are the minority that sounds devout and looks like a credit risk.

Goals. They keep the signings clear, and they vouch a Struck person briskly, reading that later change as a later contract. Motherfaith talk of gifts is allowed through the town. It is unpriced language, and unpriced language is not the language they prefer.

Its injustice. The harm is bargain-theology as statute. A Given child is a term opened, and a household that insists the colour was a gift is a bad debtor in a signing-town. The Bound are safe here, and they are over-read. The person the world already uses as a contract-pillar is asked to be the world's whole person. There is no villain-faith in that, only a sincere ledger laid over real Conditions.

Trenledd: the Worn Count

(TREN-ledd. Eroded thren, sacred counting, beside ledd, to reckon. People say the Worn Count and Count-folk. Official records write Trenledd. They call the list the roll. On the Ledger Coast that word

means a tax roll, and here it means persons. Theology low, reach high, governance high.)

Trenledd is the wealthy interior of Strandoren, with mature Trees, a dense population of the Given, and guilds thick on the ground. Over that wealth sits a state that writes people down. The list began as the machinery of tickets and taxes, safety-licences and house-notes and charter-rolls, and it forgot to stop when it reached the edge of property. No hymn calls the list stewardship, and there is no Mother to be accounted to. You are on the roll because commerce and hazard-control wanted a name they could find again.

Threnmaieth at least claims to keep you hale, whole and looked after. Trenledd claims to keep you findable. Cutting a person off from what they need is the default here, and the state does not treat that cut as impiety, because it keeps no piety the cut could offend.

Site. The country is Tree-rich interior, and the reach here is high. Road-end Tree-towns got filed, and the stones in the squares have numbers on the back.

Seat. Lunbra *(LUN-bra)* is the large, wealthy city on the Chart-run, four to eight days upriver of Orentel, where the roll is kept and the money is shown in the square, because people come for a fortune a family already has, or for one they want. Towns and villages through the filed country stay unnamed, and whoever governs Trenledd stays unnamed. Vamar keeps a column of the roll, who owes, who Turned, and who can be found. The file reads Melro, Vamar, because a clerk in this list-land says the house first, while a neighbour says Vamar. Vamar is not the ruler.

How it formed. The roll grew from guild-tickets, from deathless memory, and from a council that distrusted a living witness the way Threnmaieth does, without Threnmaieth's scripture to bless the distrust. The Grey Summer added the column that would not stop, and Dirrol wrote down who is still alive to be found. The three pillars work here, and the state treats them as insufficient, because feeling, word, and memory answer to themselves while a ledger answers to the desk. The growth was a pile of crises, each one adding a column, rather than a single coup.

What they remember. They wanted the Hinge Hush written as persons, and both shores refused. The roll they kept is a fever's child, not a hymn's. It is colder than the Tallied Crown.

Structure. A crown or a council writes the roll and runs the state, and the person who sits at the head of it is not named. Licence-guilds work as organs of that state. The state does not recruit by Kind. The Struck are pursued so they can be catalogued, because an unwitnessed change is a row that appeared on the page without a clerk.

Goals. The state wants to know who is dangerous, who owes, and who Turned. It furnishes the Tithe through channels that can be shut. When someone objects, its clerks answer with procedure, and they never answer with theology.

Its injustice. The harm is a census with the halo worn off. You cannot appeal to piety when you want off the list, and you cannot shame them by saying the Mother's gifts should not be listed. They agree with the sentence, and they list you anyway, as cargo and as hazard.

Netstrand: the Night Shore

(NET-strand. Eroded neth, night, the long dark, beside strand, shore. The reconstruction Nethstrand goes unused in daily speech, and people there will not say why the name means night. People say the Night Shore and Night-folk. Charters write Netstrand. Theology mid, reach high, governance low.)

Strandoren's west and south face is the West Water, the open ocean toward Heskoren and, far beyond that, the storm-wall. The bold houses run the frontier trade. What they sell is hulls and west-water berths: crews, capacity, and a crossing quoted the way other shores quote a pilgrimage. They do not sell the First-Hand year, the origin-winter, as a finished product. That year is assembled on the Old Crossing, and the work is split. Netstrand charters the ship, the White Note writes the terms, and Orentel holds the berth. Almost none of the people of this shore have crossed to the Sundering Isle. The people who claim they have are the tellers of Yumboe stories. The Yumboe are the hill-folk of Kumbaan, pearly and silver-haired, and off that isle they are rare enough that most mainlanders know them as a story.

Faith on this shore is mixed. Motherfaith is worn light, the Fair Hand is ordinary on a signing-quay, and there are quay-charms nobody writes down. The Trees along this wealthy edge are still mature.

Vaethorn waits for wood the way a devout shore waits on a gift, and the Night Shore waits for hulls the way a house waits on a fare. From the quay the two waits can look alike. One of them is faith. The other is money.

Site. The coast faces the open ocean. It holds empty berths in Eolthael for the Heskoren run and for hulls chartered in to Orentel's first quay. The holds smell of earth because graft-pots are going out. A neighbour's week gets billed here as a crossing. The far crossing is this shore's prestige, and the origin-winter is not.

Seat. Braetu *(BRAY-too)* is the harbour city on this face, smaller than Orentel because the far run is thinner than the Old Crossing. A far crossing is quoted there, and a lamp can be kept on a name. They keep a dark book of quoted crossings that never returned, and a Held bed for hulls, a berth held back and not let onward. Houses pay to keep a lamp on a name. The book is not a Threnhael, and it is not a White Note. It is the only record the shore keeps of its lost ships. One berth stays unlit, with no house attached, and the city leaves that berth that way. Towns and villages along the rest of the shore stay unnamed. Selkie stay common on the quays and off the flag. Braetu is not a second Orentel.

How it formed. The west-houses grew out of Salt Walk traffic and the later carrying to Heskoren, by sea, the coasts first and then the far water. This is a shore that faces the wave's supply-line, not the

grove. After the Grey Summer the west trade thinned for a decade. After the Hinge Hush they kept the west-water clause, under which Netstrand quotes the far crossing, Saelvaeth may take a pot without a waiting-due, Vaethorn may bless a landing and may not levy it, and Ornled is a beach-fee.

What they remember. They quote the far crossing, and the clause they inherited covers hulls. It does not cover the origin-winter. A lamp kept on a name that will not come back is charged as watch, not as grief.

Structure. Merchant houses, berth-guilds, and a light charter-council run the shore. It does not recruit by Kind. Sky-couriers come from Lirorn, and Tengu families keep the clock-towers, all of it as jobs rather than as a district of their own.

Goals. They quote the far crossing, keep the Heskoren run profitable, and charter hulls to the Old Crossing when inland coin wants an origin-winter. They sell tales of the Isle without having to survive the crossing those tales describe. They do not let Trenledd write the berths, and they do not claim the First-Hand year is theirs to crown.

Its injustice. The harm is the crossing as inventory. Prestige is priced, necessity is billed, and a neighbour's week owed to a waiting cluster becomes a line on a docket. Kindness is for the people who can book. The origin-year they do not own still uses their wood.

Ornled: the Outer Ledger

(ORN-led. Orn, land, beside ledd, to reckon, clipped. The reconstruction Ornledd goes unused. People say the Outer Ledger and Outer folk. Slates and learned maps write Ornled. Theology low, reach low, governance low.)

Ornled is thin-reach Heskoren country that never took the waiting-gospel. The grafts are as young as they are in Vaethorn, and the people run the same way, heavy with the Kept and the Struck. What Ornled does not have is a congregation to fill the gap those young Trees leave. Tithe-provision is barter, favor, and a slate on the wall. An unvouched Struck is a problem met with a rope, a deal, or a neighbour, not with a blessing. Custom outruns law, because there is almost no law here and almost no hymn.

They do not hate the Mother, and they do not call on her either. Vaethorn hears the missing *th* in Ornled's name as godlessness. Ornled hears the *th* Vaethorn still pronounces as a luxury. The name is worn down, and they let the old ending go.

Site. The country is frontier pockets off the hottest pilgrim-roads. It looks like a waiting cluster, and it has no gospel to wait with. The same stones are here, and the same upper rooms where a walk used to pass. The work in those rooms is necessity rather than devotion.

Seat. Sanbreo *(san-BREE-oh)* is the town on the brink of a small city where the slate is kept, and a beach-fee can be paid there when a hull arrives. It stands on Heskoren's west coast, the slate-shore. The beach faces west, toward the last capes and the storm-wall beyond them. The frontier coast that faces the West Water is on the east side of Heskoren, so a hull that wants this beach comes round the capes. The town remains a town rather than the city it is nearly large enough to be. Villages and hamlets in the pockets around it stay unnamed. Eolvaeth is a vale in the waiting-gospel, and it is not this gate.

How it formed. Districts heavy with the Kept and the Struck watched the waiting-theology arrive with the grafts, and they declined to make scarcity into a problem of the soul. They make things up as they go, and that improvising has become the culture. The government is light because nobody has spare people enough to be a state. The Fair Hand is a rumour that comes off ships, not a civic rite, because they have few Bound to make a book of. The Thaw-Break gave one cluster a year they can point at. Vathne's slate is the first line on the wall, cut after a waited pot drowned in someone else's thaw. The line says the town will not wait with a hymn for a stick that drowned. Someone recopied the words onto newer wood. Vathne is that line, not a person you meet on the gate. Whoever is on the shore gate that day cuts the beach-fee, and that person is not named. The Hush writes them as slate-shore. What they owe a hull is a beach-fee, not a hymn. They were not asked.

What they remember. Vaethorn hears godlessness in the missing sound. Ornled hears Vaethorn's waiting-gospel as a luxury the well-supplied can afford. They keep no net of congregations.

Structure. Town custom, slates, and vouching stretched thin are what pass for membership. The pockets do not recruit by Kind. The Intake, the catching of a raw Struck before the change has anywhere to go, is an acute problem here and an unofficial one. A raw Struck gets a shed if they are lucky, and silence if the silence works.

Goals. They try to stay whole with what is already in the pot. They owe no hymn in exchange for green. They trade with Netstrand when a ship comes, and they try not to become the neighbour that ship can bill.

Its injustice. Where Vaethorn's cruelty is a guilt laid on the person, Ornled's cruelty is no net at all. A person who cannot barter their Tithe slides, with no prayer under them and no guild beside them. The loneliest unvouched in the world are not in the waiting-lands. They are next door, where no one is waiting with them.

Vaelhesk: the Far Yield

(VAEL-hesk. Vael in the older sense, what the land yields, beside hesk-, the far edge. People say the Far Yield and the Yield. Charters write Vaelhesk, and saying it that way keeps the spoken name clear

of Vaethorn. The fight with the Waiting Lands is in the first syllable, vael against vaeth. Motherfaith devotion is mid. Old Ways practice is high. Reach low, governance low.)

Vaelhesk is the pre-graft host-lands on Heskoren: old greens, doors kept for ancestors, and a first meal before anyone is allowed to leave with something of the place. The Mother's wood, the grafted Tree of the Motherfaith, is a guest on that older ground. A Cutting-leave, the Seat's permission to take living wood, is a claiming if it happens without the meal. The Door-Keepers walk here as Kin-speakers, people who speak for the kin the door is kept for. The land is the seat, not a college, and it does not need a college in order to be owed a meal.

The Struck and the Taken-In are read here as the land's own children. A neighbour's week to a Motherfaith Tree can be refused on purpose, and what the refusal says is that the child is already the hill's. Vaethorn reads those same children as Kept-for-want, passed over because a gift was scarce. The disagreement is what decides whether a child travels. Both families are telling the truth they have.

Site. The country is Heskoren's old greens, and not only the live front where new grafts are still arriving. Its guest-grove is the First Bowl, which folk call *Lonasir*, and the bowl is not a capital, because the land itself is the seat. There is no new city and no new name. Villages and hamlets stay on the old greens. A traveler who asks for the seat is pointed at a door. The First Bowl stays the guest-grove it already is. Harrow's Green is the grove-town on Saelvaeth's march, next door to this ground and not this seat.

How it formed. These were animist and ancestor polities, answering to the land and to the dead, and they predate the wave of grafts. When the grafts arrived, across Cut-year 200 to Cut-year 387 and still arriving, some districts became Vaethorn, and these districts kept the door. The state stays light because the land does not need a clerk in order to be owed a meal. The Thaw-Break moved guests off flooded ground and up to high doors. The Hinge Hush does not write Vaelhesk into its clauses, because a first meal is not a landing-due. Netstrand crews who skip the meal learn that, and they learn it without a treaty.

What they remember. The host-right is older than any Cut-year. A waiting-gospel that came later called the refusal a deprivation.

Structure. Membership is the hearth-cluster, the door-keeper, and the custom of the host-right, and the land does not recruit by Kind. The Taken-In are densest here as frontier labor and as kin, and that density is still not a flag.

Goals. They feed the first meal, and they name a Struck person at the door that made them. A warden who arrives with a pot is a guest if they sat down for the meal, and a thief if they took the wood without sitting.

Its injustice. The harm is host-rights used as a claim that can shun. Refuse the meal, take the wood, and you are not a neighbour. A Road-hand, one of the hands who carry pots of living wood for the

Seat, can become a trespasser for following a sentence the Seat already wrote. The kindness has a threshold. The wrong side of that threshold is real, and the injustice stays local.

Saelvaeth: the Sown Waiting

(SAEL-vaeth. Sael, sowing, joined to vaeth, the waiting, so the name means sowing into the waiting. People say the Sown Waiting and March-folk. Charters write Saelvaeth. The shared sael with Saelthael stays visible in the writing, and speech keeps the two powers apart. Harrow's Green sits in the march's orbit, and it does not sit as the capital. Theology mid, reach low, governance mid on the table and mid-low in the march itself.)

This is the live front of the grafting on Heskoren, the still-moving planting of Trees, running from Cut-year 200 to Cut-year 387 with the front still incomplete, and the wave of planting reached this edge in this decade. Towns form where a graft has taken, and between them are waiting clusters who can see a neighbour's canopy and do not yet have one of their own. Harrow's Green is the luckiest kind of square in this march, a Hand that grew up, and the Three Hamlets Past the Ford can see that green. They were written as remainder, the part left over, under the folk names *Brenod*, *Vaelun*, and *Ornath*, which the Seat still does not use. New towns everywhere still say the Harrow-sentence, *we Turned at Harrow's Tree before we had our own*, and on this front that sentence is the decade, not an old story. The queue is visible from the ground, because people can see who is waiting. Ornsael, on Saelthael, is the same sowing on the origin continent, with the city of that sowing at Larbril and the well at Ornsael.

Governance sits mid-low because someone has to stand and answer for the sentence the Seat already passed on Harrow's Green. Wardens do that standing, Road-hands carry pots of living wood through on the way to a town that was not chosen, and a march-voice speaks that did not exist when the first pots came. The state is large enough to be blamed, and no larger.

Site. The march is Heskoren's grafted pockets on the moving edge. It hosts the neighbour's week out of necessity rather than devotion. Natai sits west of Harrow's Green, between Sanbreo and that grove, on ground of its own, and not on the ford.

Seat. Natai *(NAH-tye)* is the town where the march-voice stands, and the town can be blamed for a queue it did not write. Other towns where a graft has taken stay unnamed, and so do the hamlets and waiting clusters between them. Harrow's Green stays as it is and stays out of this seat. The Three Hamlets Past the Ford stay the three hamlets. Eolvaeth is Vaethorn's seat, on a different road.

How it formed. Who is next for a scion, a cutting of living wood, depends on who can pay, whose soil will take it, and who is next in the chain on a list written in the Motherwood. The polity is that luck and that queue. The Grey Summer thinned the supply-line for a decade, and the Thaw-Break turned the neighbour's week into worse mud. The Hinge Hush wrote one mercy into the peace. This march

may take a pot without paying a Vaethorn waiting-due. Vaethorn will preach that the march is unworthy of what it received. The history of the planting does not agree.

What they remember. The queue is the border. Harrow's luck is politics, not a reward for having waited more faithfully than the hamlets. The mercy in the clause does not move them up the scion-queue.

Structure. Town-wardens keep the squares, and Turnings are borrowed, a child's standing done where a Tree exists because the waiting cluster does not have one yet. The march does not recruit by Kind. The Old Ways are neighbours, which is Vaelhesk, and they are not a museum of a dead practice. Vaethorn's heat sits on many hearths as gospel, and it does not always sit there as a flag. The march they stand in is Saelvaeth.

Goals. They keep the grafts that have taken alive, they host the neighbour's week, they argue for the next pot, and they survive being the sentence the Seat has already written.

Its injustice. The harm is the queue as a border. The hamlets can see the canopy and send their children anyway, and spreading Trees did not make the march kind.

Gazetteer

Gazetteer types

Every place the Turning has already built shares a grammar, rich town and waiting kitchen alike. A Turning Tree stands at the centre, the living wood a town gathers under when a child comes of age, or else the neighbour’s Tree does that work, or the place is still waiting for a Tree of its own. Where a polity can afford it, the Tithe is treated as something the town has to furnish, the upkeep a Condition asks of the person who carries one. A Condition is what a person becomes, at the Tree or later in life, and a Kind is what they were born, so a town does not sort its streets into Kind-nations. Dangerous trades sit out on the edges, houses are built so a becoming has room in them, and the edge of the wood’s reach is what draws the map.

The Years of Hands left a road that used to go further than it goes now, a stone that used to mark a day’s walk, an upper room that used to sleep pilgrims, and a house that used to be an inn. People reused what the walk left behind, and that reuse is how Ornthael, the years a town is living in now, comes to look like a present.

Kumbaan has no towns of this kind. The storm-walled island keeps a different past, the storm-wall and the moons and the Open Table, which is the faith of its one hall at Ndenjoo, and it does not keep a mile-shrine. It has no Tree, and it is not a mainland power.

Once a town had a Tree of its own, the long walk to the origin stopped being required, and a place can still be doing one of the jobs that walk used to do. Devotion is the extra mile, the walk you take to the Motherwood when you already have a Tree at home. Prestige is the origin-winter you can pay for, a First-Hand year, bought by a household that does not need the walk. Necessity is the neighbour’s week, the walk you still have to make because your Tree is missing, or young, or sick. A Held bed is a bed kept for a named person who has not come. An inn on that road can sleep more than one kind of traveler in the same week. The town around the inn still has a job of its own.

Type	What it is	Older job of the walk	Where it lives	Named square or seat
Origin pilgrimage-town	devotion's extra mile, and the Motherwood's lodging	the Near Mile as a civic season and as a holiday, with the Seat close by	Maiethorn's Sacred Core	Maiethlir. The roll layers the extra mile and does not own the grove. Neighbour square: Brenthael
Road-end Tree-town	the walk stopped here, and the square is the last mile	a stone in the square, a road that ends at the boughs, an upper room	any Hands land, densest on Maiethorn	Nelath, a spur that stops. Harrow's Green, Brenthael, and the Mill-hold are other kinds of square
Deathless inn-bank	the road's past, kept as credit	beds and notes, with a Held bed as the house custom	the Near Mile inland, and a Salt Walk quay	the Third Hearth, which stayed a hearth. The White Note House on Orentel, a desk on the third quay and not the crown
Salt quay	a prestige-walk, and the pots that come with it	empty Eolthael berths, holds that smell of earth, a Fair Hand signing-watch	Strandoren's coasts	Orentel. The White Note is a desk on the third quay, and it is not the crown
Live-front Tree-town	the luckiest ground on Heskoren, under a neighbour's canopy	the Harrow-sentence as this decade, with borrowed Turnings coming in	Heskoren	Harrow's Green
Waiting cluster	a queue made visible, this year's children still walking	a neighbour's canopy in sight, folk-right cutting as a temptation, a cohort Kept-heavy and Struck-heavy	Heskoren, and Rain-Shadow pockets	the Three Hamlets Past the Ford. Folk names Brenod, Vaelun, and Ornath. The Seat still does not use them
Sick-Tree square	a Hand that fails	the necessity-walk returns, and the civic	any continent the wood has	the Mill-hold, in Orenbren's lodging-

Type	What it is	Older job of the walk	Where it lives	Named square or seat
		crisis shows up as a child's summer	reached	country. Ornsael's well can drop without a sick fall
Guest-grove	an Old Ways planting	a first meal set against a Cutting-leave, the paper that says where the wood may take	old greens on Heskoren	the First Bowl, folk name Lonasir, on Vaelhesk. Not a second Harrow. Vaelun points at it and is not it
Rain-Shadow walk-hold	a well-town whose wood grew up and whose drink is leaving	the west-road, walked now because the water will not stretch	Maiethorn's dry hills, east of the Rain-Wall	Ornsael. Larbril, Saelthael's city, is where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass
Pilgrim-edge	the wait kept as a destination	a congregation that made a country, and a Tree that speaks in some years	Heskoren	Eolvaeth

Three kinds of place the road already needed now have names, and they are written in Other Places. The sick-Tree town is the Mill-hold. The guest-grove is the First Bowl. The road-end is Nelath. One kind of place is still only a kind. Two claimants on one green, a tree-warden and an Old Ways door-keeper, both sure the wood is theirs to speak for, have no named square yet. Vaelun, one of the three hamlets past the ford, leans that way. The First Bowl remains the guest-grove. Vaelun remains a kitchen past the ford.

Towns a party can walk into

These are towns a party can walk into. Each entry says where the place sits, what work it does, and who you can meet there. A block set off in quotation marks is a page someone in the place wrote, or a thing someone there said, and the sentences around it tell you what that page is. Where an entry says the wave, it means the slow spread of living wood outward from the Motherwood, the first grove. That

spread is still moving. This year’s children still walk to a Tree that can speak, or a road is still in use because the walk is not over. It is the present. The Ages tells the spread at length.

Harrow’s Green

Harrow’s Green is a live-front Tree-town, the luckiest kind of square Heskoren has. People call Heskoren the Sundered Reach, the frontier continent, and they call this square the neighbour’s canopy. A scion, a young cutting of the wood, arrived in the Cut-year 200s, the clerks’ numbered count of years, spoke a generation later, and has now Turned local children for a few generations. New towns everywhere still say the Harrow-sentence, *we Turned at Harrow’s Tree before we had our own*. Here that sentence is the decade, not an old story. Everyday speech already had *Harrow’s green* as a Seat sentence on a Cutting-leave, the paper that says where the wood may be taken. Haelin *(HAY-lin)* is the warden, the person who speaks the fall when the leaves come down. The town is a few hundred hearths around one canopy. It is not the capital of Saelvaeth, the live-front march, and the next scion is not a reward. Natai is the march-town, west of this square on the roads between Sanbreo and the green, and the days between them are not recorded here. This square’s water is the Rise-water, the stream off the rise, and the ford is downstream.

The town is a grafted pocket on the Sundered Reach. On Heskoren, settlement clustered where the wood took, because civilization here is a map of surviving Trees, and Harrow’s is old enough, for the front, to be a town: a canopy at the centre, a square that used to be a road, and borrowed Turnings coming in from the Three Hamlets Past the Ford every Eolthael, the month the Tree is asked to speak. It is not the end of the wave. It is a Hand that grew up, a grafted Tree a neighbour can already count on. The three hamlets can see the green from the ford, and the Seat has already written that the wood will take here and will not, this year, take there. Harrow’s lives inside that sentence whether it asked to or not.

Vaethorn’s gospel, the faith of the wait, is spoken on many hearths, and not always as a flag. This square lives in Saelvaeth’s orbit, and it is not that march’s capital. The Old Ways, the older practice of doors and first meals, are neighbours, not a museum. When a cut from this Tree is set down in an older green, the first meal at that later planting is a live argument.

What the town does each day is the neighbour’s week, the week other places send their children here because their own Tree cannot serve. Devotion leaves a ribbon on the stone. Nobody books a winter here.

Site. The houses sit on a low rise above the Rise-water. The graft took on the rise, and the old pilgrim-road climbed it because that was the day’s water. Towns on Heskoren do not pick a pretty hill and then invent a Tree. The wood picked, and the hearths followed.

Water is the stream, a cistern by the warden-hearth, and the stone in the square, which is still the day's drink for anyone using the road as a mile. Food is the pocket's gardens, ranging beyond the last house, and whatever the neighbour's week brings in Hale-month, the month the roads fill with crowds, dust, and a complaint. Fuel is the same woods the Two-Bodied use as ranging, people who also carry an animal body and work the edge in it. The Taken-In, people whose life is the living green, keep the greens around the Tree from going to seed indoors. There is no resident stiller, one of the surgeons who sit with a dangerous body, and a travelling one is a summer's luck.

The square is the last holy mile. Beyond the boughs the old way is a cart-track to the ford. Children are told the road goes to the Motherwood. It goes to the mill, and then to three hamlets that can see the canopy. Both are true if you keep walking.

The square. The town grew around the canopy, house by house rather than on a grid. The oldest houses face the Tree, and later houses filled the wedge between the road and the stream. There are no walls. The boundary is the ranging and the last garden.

The Tree is mature enough to Turn the local children, and young enough that grandparents still remember the borrowed years, when this town's own children had to go elsewhere. Leaf-Fall, the day in a child's tenth year when the Tree gives a colour or a hug, is held in the square because there is nowhere else a crowd fits. A colour is a Condition. A hug leaves the child Kept, unchanged, with no Condition to carry. You can read the town's age in the wood. This is a Hand, not a First, not the original Tree in the grove.

The stone is the last mile-shrine of the road that used to go further. Children have scuffed it climbing, the Road-hands still take water here on the way through with wood, and some years there are ribbons. Haelin wants the stone moved before the next Leaf-Fall, because it stands in the way of the crowd. A hamlet child will climb it and ask how far it is to the Tree. The cistern-dipper is hung with the bowl toward the stream, and Harrow's Green will not say why.

The upper room still has too many beds for the trade the town has now. It opens for the neighbour's week, and it has not become a merchant-loft. A Road-hand sleeps here on the way to a town that was not chosen for the next pot, sometimes with the pot itself, and a pot off Sorim's earth-berth on Orentel's quay may be the one upstairs. Hale-month is dust and extra people. Ledger-month, the quieter month after the crowd, is local. Haelin can tell a pot from a pilgrim, and will not always say.

The greens are potted groves and a garden-common around the Tree, enough to live from, and not a lot you buy a ticket for. They will not follow you home. The Taken-In here are neighbours, not a quarter of the town. The ranging sits at the edge, not in a beast-yard, and the Two-Bodied work the woods that feed the hearth, with no Kind-flag on the trees. The far shed is Returned work, the plague-and-body labour, set downwind on the same logic as a tannery. It is not an infirmary, and it is not a district.

Homes have room for a becoming: a window that opens, a room kept green, a threshold a Long-Lived waits to be asked across. The Long-Lived are the ageless keepers of memory. Mixed Kinds live here. A Fox of the Wilds at the ranging is unremarkable, and a Tengu on a ridge-visit is a guest. What the town can furnish for a Tithe is frontier-warm and thin, the greens, the ranging, and the upper room as a seasonal outlet for whoever is loud that week. There is no counted hall, and no stiller on a licence-wall. You can be too poor to stay whole here, and the neighbour's week will not fix that.

The square is the last mile. The road ends at the boughs, the children of a Hands-town Turn at home, and the hamlets can see the canopy and still send this year's ten-year-olds. A Road-hand is going the other way with wood, because the walk is not over. The Harrow-sentence is this decade.

A warden who pulls the stone down is doing theology with a hammer. They are not wrong that Leaf-Fall needs the space. They are wrong if they think the graves went with the requirement, because the next column that has to walk will miss the water. Haelin knows this and still wants the stone moved.

Offices. Haelin's office is practice-first. It is not reserved to a Kind. Haelin speaks the fall truly enough for a front-town, believer-heavy the way a live Tree makes a person, and still has to lodge the neighbour's week. The queue of scions is not Haelin's to fix, and it is the sentence the town lives in. The hearth still keeps the Seat's letter from the Wrong Green, Cut-year 248, in which Nathdo Spoke a hug as if it had been the colour copper-green. Haelin Speaks slowly, and Hale-month does not always forgive the slowness.

Tora *(TOR-ah)* of Brenod is the second person on this square. They walk a neighbour's fall home when they can, carrying the witness of a Turning done here back to the hamlet, and they are here when the stone is to be moved, because the next column still drinks at that stone. Haelin has a Tree. Tora has a ford. It is the same week. Vouching at a distance was invented for a fall at the origin. Here it is a walk back to the ford. If the witness will not walk, the child is seen at the canopy and unvouched at breakfast.

Road-hands sleep in the town that was chosen, on the way to the one that was not. A Door-Keeper at a later planting holds the host's rights if a cut from Harrow's is set in an old green. The later planting is the First Bowl, called Lonasir, in the Far Yield. What that ground still wants is the first meal, or else the planting is a claiming. When the queue is ugly, Saelvaeth's march-voice can be blamed for it. That voice is Dumu, and Dumu stands at Natai, not on this rise.

A notice chalked on the cistern-wall in Hale-month, Cut-year 387, in Haelin's hand. The stone is not named.

> *The crowd will need the square. The stone will be walked around until Eolthael, and then we will see. Water stays. Names stay if they were names. Climbing is for after.*

> *Beds above: the neighbour's week first. A pot is not a pilgrim. A pilgrim is not a pot. I can tell. I will not always say.*
>
> *If you came from the ford, you are seen here. If you must be seen at home, take someone with you who was here. I will not walk it for you. I have a Tree.*

The notice shows Haelin making room for the crowd, and refusing to walk anyone home. In the square it reads as crowd control. Past the ford it can arrive as a slight.

The Three Hamlets Past the Ford

The Three Hamlets Past the Ford are a waiting cluster, three hearths rather than one village, and none of them is a capital. The Seat's Cutting-leave has already filed them as a remainder: *the wood will take at Harrow's green. It will not take this year at the three hamlets past the ford — the soil is thin there.* They can see Harrow's Green from the water. They send this year's ten-year-olds to the neighbour's week, or further if Harrow's year is too full, or still the Long Mile, the old walk when the neighbour was a continent away, if the neighbour is only a stick in a pot. The folk hearth-names sit in worn Maiethren, the old tongue as people still speak it. The Seat still does not use them. Its paper still reads "the three hamlets past the ford." Three hearths, a few dozen houses each. You walk from kitchen to kitchen, and you do not walk through a town.

The three hearths sit close enough to share a complaint and far enough apart that a scion cut for "the hamlets" would still start a fight about which green received it. The reach is thin as weather. This year, for this cohort, the hamlets are Kept-heavy and Struck-heavy: a child may stay Kept at the ford while a sibling walks, and a Kin-speaker, someone who speaks for a household's kin, may stand for a Struck person the square will not. Struck means the change came later than a child's standing, by a drowning, an oath, or a death. That thin year is not a re-enactment of the old walking age. This is the present.

They have learned not to say *queue*. They can recite the horticulture-sentence, the one that names the thin soil. Folk-right cutting is a kitchen-knife kept in a drawer, not a rebellion with a flag. Most slips die. The ones that take are how the First Seat, the college of tree-wardens in the Motherwood, learns that it does not own the Tree's tissue, only the authorization to cut it.

Old Ways hearths among them may refuse the neighbour's week on purpose, because their children are already the land's. Motherfaith neighbours read those children as Kept for want of a gift. The disagreement changes who walks, who stands witness afterward, and who will share a kitchen on the return. History does not agree with Vaethorn's guilt, the teaching that the wait is a kind of unworthiness.

They sit on a seam. Saelvaeth's luck is the canopy they can see. Vaelhesk's refusal is in the kitchen. Vaethorn's gospel is on the tongue. Ornled's slate is what they would meet if they walked the other

way, toward Sanbreo. The hamlets are making the week themselves. A visitor who calls that devotion has misread the ford, and nobody with money stops here.

Site. The ford is the Seat's geography, the place from which you can see Harrow's green, water a mile-shrine would have marked if anyone had set a stone on the waiting side. No one set that stone. Necessity still drinks there, and children still ask how far it is.

The Rise-water comes down from Harrow's rise. In clear weather the canopy is a dark against the far slope. In rain it is a rumour you have to take on trust. The three greens sit on slightly different ground, a wetter shelf, an old taken plot, and a thinner rise past the last hedge. A scion planted "for the hamlets" would still be a fight about which of those grounds is soil.

Food is gardens, a shared mill-path, and ranging that is simply the woods. There is no hall where a person can vent a Far-Voiced hour, the hour someone whose feeling carries in the voice needs to let it out, and there is no ticketed lot of green. What a lapsing Condition can be given is the yard and the neighbour. Here that lapse is a family problem before it is a guild's.

The names are worn and short, stressed on the root, and everyday speech comes first. There is no liturgy in them. To name a hearth in the old holy shape would be to pick a Seat-hearth, and a Seat-hearth would pick a scion.

Brenod (BREN-od)

Brenod is the sending hearth. Motherfaith in this kitchen is a practice. They walk the child to Harrow's, they want someone who was there to walk back and stand for the fall, and they can recite the thin-soil sentence without using the word *queue*. The kitchen-knife sits in this drawer more often than in the others, which does not mean they have used it. It means they have looked at it.

Brenod keeps the neighbour's week as a duty. A visitor from the core will hear faith. Brenod hears a date in Eolthael. Tora of Brenod is the one who sends. They walk a neighbour's fall home when they can, and they are at Harrow's when the stone is to be moved, because the next column still drinks there.

Vaelun (VAY-lun)

Vaelun is the yield-hearth. The older word *vael* is what the land keeps, and it is not *vaeth*, the waiting. The Old Ways sit this kitchen. They may refuse the neighbour's week on purpose, because their children are already the land's. A first meal is the host's claim, not a courtesy. A later cut from Harrow's, acting for the origin, still wants the bowl if this ground is an old green.

Vaelun's work is host-rights, not a second Harrow. The Door-Keepers play here, people who keep an ancestor's door and speak for the kin that door is for. The later planting they point at is the First Bowl, a day's walk into the Yield, sometimes two, and not this kitchen. Motherfaith neighbours in Brenod

will call Vaelun's Kept children passed-over. Vaelun will not correct them in the Mother's language. Nethiro *(neth-EE-ro)* of Vaelun is a Door-Keeper's cousin. They ask about the bowl before they ask about a leave, they may refuse the neighbour's week on purpose, and they walk to the First Bowl when the bowl is set.

Ornath (OR-nath)

Ornath is the furthest hearth past the ford. The soil is thinnest here as a feeling, not as a horticulture anyone has locked. Ornath can see Harrow's when the weather is kind, and Ornath can walk the other way, toward Sanbreo, where Ornled keeps the slate, if the congregation's net fails. They have not gone. The road is still a temptation that looks like sense: no gospel, a ledger, and the same thin Trees.

Ornath keeps the wait, and the other road is an exit that is not a Tree. Some people there still wait. Some have stopped saying the Mother's name, and have not started keeping a list either. Baelon *(BAY-lon)* of Ornath has not taken the slate-road, and has looked at it. The cup this kitchen leaves empty on purpose, or does not, is Ornath's.

A pot in a yard, a young failure, or nothing yet: any of the three greens can hold the sick stick for a night. The fight about which green would receive a scion is the cluster's civic life. Naming the hearths did not end that fight.

Harrow's has a Tree, and the square down the slope is Hands, a town that Turns under its own wood. This year's ten-year-olds still walk. A household can split on a shorter road than the old mile: one child goes to Harrow's, one stays Kept at the ford, and a sibling will not walk the same side of the road. Beside those kitchens there is a Kin-speaker who will stand for a Struck person the square will not, and someone who owns a knife they will not call nameless.

There is no stone on the waiting side. There is a cup, and the night before the neighbour's week someone leaves it on the ford-rock. If it fills, they send. If it does not, the tellings do not agree, and the child still goes, or does not, according to the kitchen and not according to the cup. Brenod calls the cup weather. Vaelun calls it the land answering. Ornath has started leaving it empty on purpose, or has not. In a flood the canopy is only a rumour, and the week is still a date, so someone has to decide without seeing Harrow's. If a folk-right slip takes, which green receives it is still undecided.

The Seat's leave still says *the three hamlets past the ford*. Clerks who learn Brenod, Vaelun, and Ornath have learned more than the minute wanted them to.

Said at the ford, not written, in a Brenod voice, a Vaelun voice, and an Ornath voice, over the same water.

> *We can see it. That is not the same as having it.*

> *The land had them before the cart came. I will not walk a child to a neighbour to be named a Waited.*
>
> *If the cup stays dry I still have to decide. The slate the other way does not ask about soil.*

The voices disagree, and nobody settles it. At dawn someone still decides whether to lift the cup, wake the child, and take the Harrow road.

The Third Hearth (and Brenthael)

The Third Hearth is a road-house that stayed a hearth. It is the third lodging out from the Motherwood on the Near Mile, the short road in to the origin, and Thilim *(THIL-im)* keeps it. Thilim is Long-Lived, and has kept this house inland since before the First Cut, as later clerks would say. The First Cut is the first time a cutting of the Tree took in new ground, which is where those clerks start their years. Seine's bed is still made. The notes here are smaller than the White Note's, and the shrine is larger. People say *the third hearth*. The road-house cant is *brenhael*, the name any such house can be called. The neighbour-town is Brenthael *(BREN-thael)*. Thilim is not on the quay. Brenthael is not Orenbren's capital, and it does not hold the First Seat. That capital is Rothallo, which people still call the Inner Close. The college sits in the wood beside this country.

This is an old Near Mile house on Maiethorn, three days' walk out from Thaeloren, the grove-name of the Motherwood, toward the approach-country. It still has beds, porridge, a dry room, a green-lot, and a shed. In Brenvaeth, the years when a child's Turning was the walk to the one Tree, the house sold that walk, the one you could not miss twice. In Ornthael the house still opens for Eolthael.

It sits in Orenbren's lodging-country, the stretch of civic beds within a week's walk of the grove. The inns grew a country. This is one house, and the compact does not own it.

The house's older work is devotion, the extra mile walked by people who could already have Turned at home. The loft still sleeps necessity, the people who have to walk, and, rarely, prestige, the households who come because they can be seen coming. Thilim can tell which guest is which, and will not always tell you. The White Note sells the First-Hand year. This house makes the bed.

The Ledger Coast, the coast that prices a house by what its paper earns, calls this a bed-house that failed to become a bank. Thilim asks who will be here at dark. One description prices the building. The other decides whether supper is enough.

Site. The Near Mile is a week's door to the origin. Counted from the grove outward, the first hearth is a day out, then the second, then this third. Pilgrims walking in, toward the wood, hit the neighbour-town before they hit the inn.

Brenthael stands a day's walk further from the grove than the inn. It is a Hands-town that grew around a graft planted beside the road. Brenthael's own children Turn at home, under that Tree, and the Mile

goes on past the town, through Raillath, then the Mill-hold, then the rest of Maiethorn. Children there are told the road goes to the Motherwood. It does, if they keep walking past the inn, two more hearths, and the wood. Most children of a Hands-town do not.

The Third Hearth kept the older job, which is beds for people still going in. Water is a well in the yard and the stone by the road. The stone is a day's-walk shrine that never got pulled into Brenthael's square, because the inn refused to let the town have it. Thilim uses the stone for water and will not join the argument about pulling it down. Brenthael's warden wants it moved. The stone stands in the way of a crowd that is not this house's crowd. Food is the pot, the green-lot, and whatever the extra mile pays in Hale-month. The shed is still a shed.

Features. The upper room still has too many beds, and it has not been converted. It opens in Hale-month and is quiet in Ledger-month. A devotion-column, a necessity-family, and a Road-hand going the other way with a pot can sleep in it in the same week, which is two kinds of need in one afternoon. A prestige household that missed the White Note's winter is rare, and when one lands here it is conspicuous.

Seine's bed is Held, kept made for Seine of the far cape, who was due in a tenth summer and did not come. The mother said next year. Next year was last year, and it has been last year for a length of time Thilim will not convert into Cut-years. It is not a shrine Thilim will admit, and it is a shrine everyone else can see. A name at the door that is not Seine and thinks it is, or that is Seine, is the day Thilim has to decide whether the bed is still Held.

The slate is still kept. The back of the board still does not say what the front says, and the full text is in the Walking Years. The stone stands by the road, not in Brenthael's square, and it has climbing-scuff on it anyway, because people still climb it. Road-hands still aim for the water. Brenthael wants the stone down so the extra mile does not look like a requirement on their approach. Thilim will not move a name.

The green-lot and the shed are still a pot and a shed, not the civic works a town builds so people can pay what a Condition asks. A cutting sits in the pot and is still not a Tree. Thilim missed a green once, and that miss is not the First Cut.

Brenthael's square is a neighbour, not a second kind of house. A Tree stands at the centre, the Mile goes on past the boughs, and Leaf-Fall is the town's civic season, with lodging-guild pressure coming in from Orenbren and no throne under it. Mixed Kinds live there. The town's own version of the extra mile is a holiday. From the last house they can see the inn's stone, and they resent it as a grave that is also an advertisement, a remembered name and a sign that still draws the walk.

Brenthael Turns at home. The Near Mile is optional now, and Orenbren houses the people who still want the origin. The stone still waters a mile. Seine's name is still cut over the door. A necessity-family from thinner soil still pays when they walk home. A Hand can fail. The Mill-hold, two days past

Brenthael, put a Hands-town back on the neighbour's week this year. Brenthael's Tree has not sickened, and Thilim does not say the age is over.

The two fates of the same origin still stand next to each other. The White Note collected, on a Strandoren quay, and the Third Hearth kept making the bed. Mataero, from that other house, sees this one only as a warning.

At dark, Thilim sets the yard-broom across the doorway and steps over it, and they will not say why.

People. Thilim is Long-Lived, inland, and tired. When Thilim says *I walked*, the phrase can mean four different things, and the four are set out in the Walking Years. A Blood-Read, the memory a Long-Lived can take from blood, will give a true fragment of a walk. It will not tell you which meaning Thilim intends when they make the bed. What Thilim wants is the stone's water for the pot at dark. The document of this house is Seine's bed, made, and it is not a notice anyone can file. A pilgrim who asks where the college is will be pointed at the wood, not at the inn.

Meirim *(may-REEM)* is Brenthael's town-warden, and wants the stone. The office is held by the work, not reserved to a Kind. Meirim speaks a fall in a square that used to be a road. This Hale-month Meirim also has a necessity-column coming in from the Mill-hold, people still walking because they have to. Orenbren's lodging custom makes hospitality into rent in Eolthael. Thilim charges less than that custom, and is called a failure for the difference.

A chalked complaint from Meirim's warden-hearth, carried to the Third Hearth and left under the stone's lip. It is Cut-year 387, after Hale-month. Thilim has not answered on paper.

> *The crowd will need the approach. Your stone is a mile that is no longer owed. Water we have. Names we can keep on a ribbon in the square, which is where a remembered name belongs.*
>
> *You house the extra mile. We Turn at home. If you make a shrine of a bed, that is a house matter. A stone in the road is a town matter.*
>
> *We are not pulling a grave. We are pulling a requirement that has ended.*

The complaint shows that Brenthael wants the stone out of its crowd's way, and that it offers a ribbon in the square as the place for the remembered name. The Held bed is still made. If Seine comes, the stone will still be standing in the way of a crowd that is not hers.

Ornsael

Ornsael *(ORN-sael)* is a Rain-Shadow walk-hold whose drink is leaving. The name keeps the conservative drift of the old tongue, *orn* for land and *sael* for sowing, the sown-ground. Everyday speech says Ornsael. A traveller from the core who says "the west-road well" is corrected, because the

well is why anyone stopped and it is not why they stay this year. The town is a few hundred hearths, thinner than the core's, and it is not Saelthael's capital. The three corner seats are Eolvaeth, Orentel, and Maiethlir. Larbril is Saelthael's city, where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass. Ornsael is the smaller well-town, farther into the dry.

East of Maiethorn's Rain-Wall, the range that leaves one side of the Motherland wet and the other dry, on the leeward side away from the Old Crossing, the country is dry hills and sand, and the towns sit at wells. Ornsael is one of those wells. A Tree stands beside it, young for the Motherland and old enough to have Turned local children for a generation. It Speaks most years, and a missed Eolthael counts as weather, since the crisis on this square is the drink.

Saelthael is the polity of people who still sow. Ornsael is a square of that habit, not a throne. Plenty sits on the other side of the range. Pilgrimage here used to be a walk the town could not retire, because the wood was thin. The wood grew up, and the well did not. Children still go west in the neighbour's week, not to hunt a colour, but because the Hale-month crowd needs water this well cannot host. Core pilgrims who arrive in Eolthael expecting a holiday extra mile find a necessity-column already on the west-road, and they are shocked. They thought waiting was a Heskoren feeling. They were not wrong about waiting. They were wrong about what is waited for.

Fox of the Sands hearths are densest here, and that is the terrain, not a flag. A town with no fox-born would be the thing worth asking about. Mixed Kinds drink the same share. The town's daily work is meeting need. The west-road is the neighbour's week lived as water. Devotion belongs to people who already have a healthy canopy and a wet well. Nobody books a dry hill.

Site. The well is why anyone stopped. The range takes the rain, and this side keeps the dust. The houses gathered around the water. The graft was married to the well on purpose, because living earth wants a drink in sand-country as much as a child does. The Hand took, and now the well is what is failing.

The west-road is the main street. It used to be how you reached a healthier canopy, then how you reached the origin, then how you reached the core's Hands-towns after those towns stopped coming east. It is still how this year's extra people go, when the share will not stretch through Hale-month. Beyond the last house the road is a pale cut toward the range-pass. East of the well it peters into tracks and Taken-In plantings that used to look like stubbornness and now look like a second drink.

Water is the well, a few cisterns, and the dew-catch on the north walls. The cisterns are the civic argument: who filled them, who may draw, and whether a planting may have a bucket before a child. Food is terrace-gardens, goats, and whatever the west-road pays when it still pays. Fuel is dung, and whatever the range-trade carries over the pass. The Taken-In are the backbone here, because thirsty land honours green, and they are not a nation. Their pots also need water. There are no walls. The boundary is the place where the well's water no longer reaches and the dust does.

The square. The Tree at the well is the civic and sacred heart, a reasonable Hand. Most Eolthaels it Turns. The town-warden Speaks when there is a colour and does not invent one when there is not, and that is ordinary work, not the town's plot. A missed week still shuts the Given-door, the one week in which a child can be Given a colour. Struck remains the later mercy. There is still no second-chance year. The square does not turn on that warden.

The well is the day's drink and the year's fear. A rope hangs in it with knots at the old water-lines, and the share is chalked on the well-lip, not on a warden's lath. Children who have heard a stone-story have scuffed the lip by climbing. The west-road carries mile-markers toward the pass, and one stone still stands in the well-square because the town grew around a day's water. Ribbons on that stone point west, which children from the core find backwards. The column that leaves at dusk is the people the share refused.

The well-market is stalls in the morning shade. Fox-born are densest in the crowd, and they are not gated. Stock ancestries drink here, a Tengu comes through on a pass-errand, and a Selkie who married in from the Hinge Shore is dry and funny about it. The greens are potted, hauled, and argued over, with no lush lot to retreat to. Lesna's planting is the only green for a day's walk in some weeks, and it drinks. The greens-keepers do not run a chapter of their craft here. The ranging is dry hills and night-work, where the Two-Bodied know the difference between a sand-fox and a Fox, and it sits at the edge. The far shed is Returned work, downwind of the well, because you do not put the dead on the drink. There is no infirmary. A travelling stiller is a pass-story.

Homes bend to the change a person is in the middle of: north-side cool rooms, green pots beside the doors, and shutters that open for a Far-Voiced hour because there is no hall to book. At street height this is Saelthael's own combination, thin infrastructure, a high theology, and very little government.

This is the Motherland, where a town Tree was supposed to be enough. The extra mile is supposed to be optional, and this canopy Turns at home. The well is dropping. Children and Hale-month guests still go west, and the road that used to go further still does. The word *sael* is the same word as in Saelvaeth on the live front, sowing said on two continents. If the wood sickened, a Hand could fail. It has not. The drink has.

Vaethorn's guilt, imported to sand that never asked for it, is the wrong sermon for this square. Waiting read as unworthiness was about a colour. This year the town empties itself for water. A core hymn about thin soil will be heard as someone who has never drawn a bucket.

The well-rope is knotted at last year's water-line, and this year's knot is wet even when the water stands below it. Ornsael will not say why. Theisva moves the knot, Lesna says the planting tastes the same when the knot is wet, and Bovaer puts sand in a west-facing shoe and does not call that a rite.

Offices. Three people keep the argument at the well. Theisva *(THAYS-vah)* keeps the share, speaks the conservative way, and will cut a guest's bucket before a child's and a planting's before a guest's.

Theisva will not pretend the chalk is a hymn, and is tired of being asked whether this is fox-country. Theisva may be Sands-Fox, and may not. Either way the question is the slight. Lesna *(LES-nah)* is Taken-In, and keeps the planting east of the well. Lesna wants one more bucket than the share allows, because the green is also the town's food, and will not follow you home. Home is dust if the planting dies. Bovaer *(bo-VAIR)* still sends people west. Some years the Tree has Spoken and Bovaer sends anyway, because the drink is the limit. Core pilgrims hear faith. Bovaer hears a date and a water-mark.

Some years the witness of a fall is local. Some years a person has to walk home from a wetter town over the pass, not because the wood failed, but because the week could not be hosted. A vouching that has to travel, on the Motherland, is still the tell that the age is unfinished. Road-hands are rare on this road, because the circuit prefers the next town that can pay. A pot meant for Ornsael is a fight with the queue. Saelthael's custom is light, and the wells are civic fact. The well-share is the town-law. There is no list of persons. Threnmaieth would like one. Plenty on the other side of the range is Maiethvael's problem, not this well's.

At first light Theisva draws, the mark is lower than yesterday, and a crowd is already there with jars. A night-bucket given to Lesna's planting, and refused to a child, is a fight, because the planting is also breakfast. At dusk Bovaer's column is ten-year-olds, Hale-month guests, and a core pilgrim who came for a hymn and is being sent on. The lip can shear and take the rope with it, and for an hour the town has a hole and no share.

Well-share marks, chalked on the lip in Hale-month, Cut-year 387, in Theisva's hand. The Tree is not mentioned.

> *Dawn-mark: below last knot. Child-jars first. Guest-jars after the planting's one bucket, and I will hear about the planting.*
>
> *West-road at dusk if the noon-mark does not rise. Bovaer has the names. I have the rope.*
>
> *A man from the Reckoning asked to name the well on a roll. We named the well Ornsael, which it already was. He wrote a colour-year. The sand does not keep his hand. The knot is wet. I did not wet it.*

Theisva is keeping the water, and will not file a year. Lesna will read the marks as a slight on the green. Bovaer will already be on the road.

The three seats

Eolvaeth (Vaethorn’s seat)

Eolvaeth *(EOL-vaeth)* is the Waiting Lands’ seat, a pilgrim-edge town and not a live-front luck. The name joins a hinge to the waiting, and folk-speech shortens it to Elvaeth *(EL-vaeth)*. People walk here in order to wait, rather than because the canopy is a certainty. Vaethod *(VAYTH-od)* keeps the square. A couple thousand souls live here in Ledger-month, and more in Hale-month. This town is not Harrow’s Green, not the three hamlets, and not Saelvaeth’s march, and this Tree does not have Harrow’s luck. It is the capital a poor land gets when the capital is a congregation, and it is not a throne.

The town sits in a vale behind Heskoren’s coast that faces Strandoren, and it is one of the earlier pots on this continent, a graft of the Cut-year 200s that took, spoke a colour in some years, and never grew into a neighbour’s certainty. The live front moved on along the wave, and the waiting stayed, and congregation made a country of that staying. Vaethorn is the gospel of the wait. Eolvaeth is the square the gospel stands in.

Governance here is almost absent. What sits in the vale is a Tree, a spring, a gift-hall that is the town’s worship, and the camp-streets of people who came for a hinge and did not leave. Custom outruns written law. The town-warden is Hands-folk, so the office is kept by practice and not by a crown.

Saelvaeth’s luck is a different weather, further along the wave. Harrow’s Green is a Hand that grew up. The three hamlets can see that canopy from a ford. Eolvaeth cannot see it, and does not want to, because wanting it would be admitting the wait is a queue. The gospel says stay. Horticulture, in some years, says send.

The town’s older work is devotion, the wait kept as a pilgrimage you can walk to. Visitors from thinner country are usually here because they have to be, and the town will not call that necessity. Nobody books a thin vale.

Site. Two tracks meet at a spring in a fold of upland, and the graft was married to that water because living earth wants a drink and a child does. Settlement clustered where the wood took, and then the camps filled the fold, because a thin Tree that might speak is still the oldest Hand a long walk can reach without crossing into Saelvaeth’s orbit.

The spring is the day’s drink, and it is not a mile-shrine stone. Ribbons belong on other squares. Children leave a wet leaf on the lip the year the Tree does not speak. Travellers from the core will try to climb something, and there is nothing here to climb. The Long Mile used to pass this vale when the neighbour was a continent. The requirement to walk it ended, and the wait did not.

Food is the vale’s gardens, ranging on the slopes, alms from the gift-hall pot, and whatever Hale-month guests bring. Fuel is the same woods the Two-Bodied use as wild-leave. There is no resident

stiller, and a travelling blessing-surgeon is a decade's luck. The Taken-In are the backbone, Mother's green held in common, honoured, and not a nation. There are no walls. The boundary is the last camp-street and the ranging. You can walk in, someone will feed you, and no clerk will write you down.

The square. The town grew around the canopy. The oldest houses face the Tree, later houses filled the wedge between the tracks, and the camp-streets run up the fold. They are pilgrim-camps that learned to winter, set one against the next until they look like a town and still smell like a season.

The Tree is the heart of the place even when the wood is only a maybe. Grandparents remember a fall. A Seat clerk would not call it a First. Some years it Turns. Some years the colour is late, or thin, or Vaethod will not call a fall that is not one. A missed Eolthael still shuts the Given-door. Struck remains the later mercy, and there is still no second-chance year. The spring is why the vale is here. In a wet-leaf year the leaves are already on the lip, and children who have heard the stone-story have scuffed it anyway. The gift-hall is worship and venting in the same room, a hall kept as the congregation. A Far-Voiced hour here is a hymn whether they meant it to be. There is no counted hall, and no ticket at the door. Hale-month still doubles the people, and Ledger-month is local and guilty about the empty rooms. The green around the Tree is enough to live from, and it will not follow you home. The ranging is on the slopes, at the edge, with no Kind-flag on the trees. Returned work sits downwind of the spring, and it is not a district.

Homes have room for a becoming. A Fox of the Wilds at the ranging is unremarkable, a Tengu on a spine-visit is a guest, and a Selkie who married in from the coast is wet about the vale and kept anyway. What people need in order to stay whole is alms and congregation, real warmth with real want beside it. You can be too poor to stay whole here, and the gospel will console what it cannot furnish.

Some children did Turn at this Tree, so the Long Mile is supposed to be optional and the hinge is supposed to have arrived. The Tree is not a certainty. Camp-streets still fill for Eolthael, and some years a cohort still goes toward Saelvaeth's luck, or further if that luck is full. The gospel says wait, and the Seat's horticulture, on a thin year, says send. Vaethod has done both, and the town remembers which summers.

People walk to Eolvaeth to wait together, and that is how a poor land gets a capital without a crown. It is not Orenbren's extra mile, because those people already have a healthy canopy, and it is not the hamlets' necessity, because those kitchens can see Harrow's. It is the wait made into a destination, which is also how scarcity becomes unworthiness if you let the sermon land.

A wet leaf lies on the spring, and pilgrims from the core ask if it is a ribbon. Eolvaeth will not say. In a year when the Tree speaks, there is no leaf. In a year when it does not, there are too many to count, and no one writes the number down.

Offices. Vaethod is Hands-folk, and will not write a colour that did not happen, even when a visiting clerk wants the hinge tidy. The year they send a cohort toward Saelvaeth is the year the gospel and the

wood disagree. They have not resigned. Some years the witness of a fall is local, and some years it has to walk home from a luckier Hand. A vouching that has to travel, on a gospel capital, is the tell that waiting is still a road. Road-hands sleep in the town that was chosen early and stayed thin, on the way to a town that was not chosen this year. Vaethorn's custom is a light state, a hot faith, and alms, and no list of persons. Threnmaieth would like a list. Ornled would not understand why anyone stays. The unvouched Struck, people the later mercy took who have nobody to stand for them, are the ache this seat meets with faith rather than with a guild.

The wants on the square are carried by people. Vaethod wants Saelid's stall to keep feeding its winter guests. Nedaen wants the gift-hall pot to feed a child through Ledger-month. Heiral wants a marriage witnessed without Mother-kept pity, the pity a Motherfaith neighbour spends on a child the Tree hugged. Daron wants a corpse named so a grain-debt dies. Hithaen is eating in the gift-hall this Hale-month, and Vaethod has not decided which kind of guest that is. A cohort that was sent can walk back in while the notice is still being chalked, some of them Given at a luckier Hand and one of them unvouched, and Saelid's stall feels it by evening. Hale-month can put a fire through the tents that learned to winter, and the spring is the drink, not the bucket-line. A clerk from the Reckoning can ask to name the spring while the leaf is already on the lip.

A notice chalked on the gift-hall door at Eolthael, Cut-year 387, in Vaethod's hand. The Tree is not named as sick.

> *The hinge is this week. Beds on the camp-streets first. Someone who came to wait is a guest. Someone who came to count us is a clerk, and I can tell.*
>
> *If the Tree speaks we stay. If it does not I will not invent a colour. I will not send until the week is over. I have sent before. I will not pretend I have not.*
>
> *The spring is not a stone. Leave the leaf if you must. Do not ask me what it buys. It buys nothing. That is why we leave it.*

The notice is Vaethod saying, in their own chalk, that a cohort has been sent from this square before. It is good for one week, and by the time the gospel repeats the wording, it reads as a slight.

Orentel (Lestrand's seat)

Orentel *(OREN-tel)* is the Ledger Coast's seat, a salt quay rather than a desk wearing a crown. The name is the witnessing-Tree, with the *th* worn down to a *t*. Coast-folk say the Salt Quay and mean the city. Notes and berths meet here, and no house sits a throne. The White Note House is on the third quay, north side, placed and not crowned. Sorim *(SOR-im)* is the factor people ask for, the one who charters berths and files who occupies the water. Ledan is not the government. Tens of thousands live here, and the old Tree-town is the smaller half.

Orentel stands on an Old Crossing estuary, the oldest water in the world, on Strandoren, facing Maiethorn, on the shore where the Salt Walk used to land. When that walk stopped being required on this coast, the berths did not empty. They changed jobs. A Tree-town grew a quay, then a second quay, then a run of warehouses along the tide, until the old square was the smaller half of a salt-city.

Lestrand is guild self-rule carried as far as it goes, and Orentel is the square that proves it. A charter-council of houses and craft-guilds speaks for the city. There is no crown, and there is no Threnhael, the roll that writes every person down. Citizenship by witness runs smoothly because the reach is high, with a mature Hand and the city's own children Turned at home. In a city this size the witness is a hearth, the quay-gang that stood, not the whole crowd sharing one memory. The three pillars of that witnessing are a Long-Lived's memory, a Bound person's sworn word, which hears a lie as it is told, and a Far-Voiced person's feeling, which is hard to fake once it is in the room. An unvouched person is a transaction that cannot clear.

The city's daily work is prestige. A First-Hand year is held as a product and sold to households who can pay to walk a walk they do not need. Sorim assigns the empty Eolthael berths on the first quay. The White Note writes the terms. A Netstrand hull, from the Night Shore, may be the wood in the water. Orenbren takes the sleep at the origin. Three desks, one commodity. Necessity still eats in the lofts, and Mataero files that necessity as occupancy, the count of who is in a room.

Site. People stopped here because the estuary gave them deep water, a sheltered sound, and a tide that writes the working day. The graft took on the rise above the first quay in Cut-years 40 to 89, a wealthy coast and a paying next, and the oldest houses still face that Tree. The road used to come inland from the berth toward a healthier origin-canopy. Then this canopy grew up, and then the berth became the point.

The estuary faces east, toward the Old Crossing, and the Chart-run, Strandoren's interior river, comes in from the west. A sail from the Hinge Shore takes three to five days in fair weather and arrives at the Crossing-mouth. Denlad is a side inlet about a day's sail short of that mouth, on the way in, and it is not a berth in the mouth itself. Inland boats and the river-plain come by the Chart mouth. Lunbra, where Trenledd keeps its roll, is four to eight days upriver, and the food on the quay is that plain as much as it is the catch off the Crossing.

Water is the tide, the cisterns on the rise, and the paid wells in the warehouse stretch. Food is the Chart-run plain, the catch, and whatever the hinge pays. Fuel is drift, peat, and what the factor-houses book. The Taken-In rent leaf-lots by the season. They are here because they were Given here, because grain-hands winter, and because the lot is a job, not because the city is a forest. Selkie hearths are densest on the water, a lot of shoreline and not a gate. No walls here matter. The boundary is the last crane and the ranging-yard inland, and the council charters the guild, never the person.

The Rise is where the graft took, and the square still Turns local children for free. The Drop is the street from the Rise down to the first quay, and the tension of the city is that one hill. Free colour at the

top, held berths at the bottom, and a family can stand on the Drop and see both prices in the same glance. Sorim's slate starts at the bottom. The Tree-tenders' free Turning starts at the top. Neither of them owns the street. The first quay is the Salt Walk's old landing: berths 1 to 4 are held in Eolthael, and berth 5 is earth. The third quay, north side, is the White Note, a desk and not the council. Hallowquay is a lesser inner quay, not a second city. A fox-born broker might still be called of Hallowquay. That byname was already in the world. The seat is Orentel. The inland yard is the ranging ground behind the Rise. Leaf-lots and the ticket-infirmaries sit downwind, off the Drop's seaward end. They are not the tension. The tension is the hill.

The square. The old town on the rise gathers around the Tree. The quays run along the tide. The warehouses jumped to the next stretch of bank wherever a fire or a silted berth made that stretch cheaper than rebuilding, and the interesting streets are the edges where the rise meets the salt.

The Tree is still the civic heart, even when the money has gone downhill, and the Hand is mature. Leaf-Fall is a civic and commercial milestone, because a family's colour is watched for the guild it opens, and the day is not a warm festival. The square still Turns local children for free, and the quay cannot price that without noticing itself. On the first quay, empty Eolthael berths are held as prestige, which is Sorim's occupancy, and wool through Hale-month covers a shrine. There is a smell of earth out of season when a pot, and not a child, is the passenger. A west-water hull sitting in an Old Crossing hold is a Netstrand charter. The White Note is Ledan's desk, with Mataero's loft in the rise behind it, twelve beds, the north bed not to let, and century instruments in the house. Lestrand will only count the house as success.

Downhill from that free Turning, the release-house tickets the hall as a playhouse and an outlet, superb if you can pay, and the queue outside it is the gap between having and not having, at eye level. The leaf-lots are rented green rather than the Mother's common, and they will not follow you home, home being a loft if they did. The beast-yard at the inland edge hires out ranging, so Two-Bodied haulage becomes a trade dynasty if the match was priced that way, while the Stillers' ticket-infirmaries sit on the downwind edge, excellent for those who can reach them, with the longest queue in the city. Returned work sits past the last crane, on the same logic as a tannery.

Homes have room for a becoming. Mixed Kinds live here, and a Sands-Fox at a desk is unremarkable if they have warranting. In the alleys the council does not charter, what moves is sold vouching and smuggled green. The Standing Trade is there if the alley needs a face.

The canopy Turns children at home, and the Salt Walk is optional. Empty Eolthael berths are still shaped like a landing, pots still take a child's space, and a First-Hand year can still be booked. If Orentel's Tree sickened, this quay would be the neighbour's week. It has not sickened, and the council does not say the age is over. It reports occupancy. The city sells a walk people do not need, and that is how a rich coast gets a capital without a crown. When a hymn lands here, the release-house schedules it. Necessity in the loft is Mataero's concern, and it is not the city's face.

Salt sits on the Tree's roots in Eolthael. People say it is the tide, and the tide does not reach the rise. Orentel will not say why the salt is there. A hall-keeper will schedule around it. A Book-hand will not put it in a term.

The charter-council turns one chair to the wall before a meeting and turns it back when the room is empty, and will not say why. From there the Drop is a cook's step, the pot set on the rise side and ladled toward the quay, which the cook will not explain either. The first quay's crane-crew taps the hook once against the beam before a lift, and once the release-house has shut its doors the last bench in the queue is left unroped. A leaf-lot renter knocks twice on the gate-post and does not knock again, and on a coughing morning the ticket-infirmary hangs a dry cloth on the downwind nail and leaves it after the queue has gone. Hallowquay sets the first basket of the morning with the lid underneath, and the inland yard leads the hired beasts out and back in before the first job. Asked, none of them will say why.

Offices. The charter-council watches the guild and never the individual. Sorim can be asked who chartered the empty berths this Eolthael, and the answer comes back as occupancy. Sorim is not Ledan. Tree-tenders are Lestrand's word for the wardens. They Speak the fall as a civic fact, and a colour that opens a guild is still a colour. At the White Note, Ledan writes and Mataero lets. The north bed is house custom. The Book-Hands are ordinary on this quay. A signing-watch here is prestige, if you book it. They do not rewrite a Bound term, and they do not sit a seat. Tesara sits the stillers' shed, where success is silence. Road-hands are rare. A pot on an Eolthael berth is cargo to the clerk. The Tithe-poor fade while the city steps around them, and that is the injustice. Nothing is policed. Everything is priced.

The wants on the quay do not agree with each other. Mataero is trying to get Sorel off a century-note that Sorel, still alive, is still on, while Sorim wants berths 1 to 4 held and counts the hold-fee as the house-share. In the stillers' shed Tesara, for whom success is silence, wants Valen stamped before the floor takes the master back. Lasole is asking the leaf-lots for one more season of credit, and Didel of Hallowquay is asking for a kin-berth for a wedding rather than a First-Hand year. Reimaethe lets a room on the rise, and Rosire works the ticket-infirmary downwind of the shed. A crane can fail on berth 5 while a family who wanted 1 to 4 watches the earth come up. The tide can fill Tesara's shed without pausing the catching-year, the week a person just Struck is kept there. Didel's wedding and a First-Hand boarding can want the same morning.

A berth-slate, first quay, Eolthael through Hale-month, Cut-year 387. Sorim's hand. The Tree is not mentioned.

> *Eolthael berths 1–4: held. Do not load wool. A First-Hand year is not cargo. I have explained this to the crane.*

> *Berth 5: earth. A pot is cargo. I have explained this to the family who wanted 5 for a child. They could not hold 1–4. I did not invent the hold.*
>
> *The rise still Turns for free. That is a Tree-tender matter. The quay is a hold matter. If you need both in one week you are at the wrong desk.*
>
> *White Note, third north: not a berth. Do not send me their conversions. I do not keep house-years.*

The slate shows that Sorim says the hold was not Sorim's doing, and that the family without a berth is still without one. It does not mention the salt on the roots. Ledan reads a neighbour who cannot convert. Mataero reads occupancy. Their readings call for different action on the same berth.

The White Note House (placed, not crowned)

The White Note House is a road-house that became a desk, and it is still a house you can walk. It is a deathless house of the trusted note, kept by a Long-Lived so the paper does not die when a mortal clerk would. Ledan writes at the quay-desk. Mataero *(mah-TAY-ro)* lets the loft and is still junior to Ledan. People say *the White Note*. Lestrand, the coast that counts a house by its success on paper, still says *the bed-house* and means the bank. The founding is about Cut-year 80, about that year and not a sharper date. The present house-year is 307, the same summer as Cut-year 387. The conversion query headed "the 200th summer" is archival, from Cut-year 280, and it is not the count the desk is in now. The house stands on Orentel's third quay, on the north side, with the inland loft in the rise behind the salt. The desk is not the crown.

The fortune here is the same fortune as the Third Hearth, come later and to a quay. In the years when Turning was a walk you could not miss, the house was beds, porridge, and credit for that walk. When the walk stopped being required in the core, the Long-Lived still remembered every debtor, and the paper outlived the pilgrimage season. The desk sat down on this quay because that is where notes move now. Twelve beds stand in the rise behind the salt, and their window looks at a Tree that still Turns for free.

What the house sells now is century instruments, notes written to be trusted across a long run of summers, and the terms on a First-Hand year, credit for a stay at the origin the buyer does not need. It also sells loft-terms to wool through Hale-month, and it still writes the old kind of note for a necessity-family, people who have to eat now and pay on the home-walk. Same paper, two jobs. The house does not hold the berth, and it does not own the hull. A winter booked from this coast is one product with three desks. Netstrand supplies the ship, this house writes the term, and Sorim holds the first-quay berth. Orenbren takes the sleep at the far end. Ledan will convert the year from one count to another. They will not tell the crane which berth is empty.

The north bed is how a bank proves it used to be an inn. Empty is not a shrine, Mataero says, because empty is a bed they are not charging for. Ledan says the house is the house it always was. The founding-book has a name in it, and Thilim, inland, still holds a far-cape name the White Note does not. If you ask Mataero whose name the north bed is, you are told it is house custom. If you ask Ledan, they will want that name spoken once, aloud, and they will not speak it first. Ledan wants the founding-name spoken once over the north bed, so they can stop being the only memory of it.

There are two doors and one house, and you can use both in a morning if the rise is not wet. The street door opens on the salt, and there is no chapel-front. The counting-room smells of ink and of the tide. Ledan's stool faces the door, not the water, because they have seen the water. A second stool is there for a junior who is not Mataero, Mataero having the inland key, and a chest under the desk holds the founding-book. The Held names in it are credit-tokens, names the house still extends credit against, and they are not read aloud when a term is being written.

A customer comes in with a walk, a wool-season, a grandchild's debt, or a court-slip, and Ledan asks which count is to be written: the house-year, a Cut-year, or a third date that a Lestrand court invented last generation. Ledan can convert among them, and will make you say which one you want. If the paper is a First-Hand year, the term is written here and the berth is not. Ledan will send you to Sorim for the hold, and will not walk you there. If the paper is a necessity-note, the back still says *eat now* and the front says a house-year, and Mataero may already have given the family a bed. A smell of earth out of season means a pot, not a child, is the passenger on the next term. The clerk files that pot as cargo. At the next berth over, a First-Hand year is not cargo.

The way up from the third quay is a walk, not a secret stair. There are twelve beds, eight let and four open, and the north bed is one of those four. Three of the open beds are for Eolthael, and the north bed is not to let. The window beside that bed looks at the Tree on the rise. Mataero's slate hangs on the inland door, and it reads *let / open / not to let*. Wool, a First-Hand household, a necessity-family, and a Road-hand carrying a pot can all want a bed in the same week. Mataero files who is in which bed, and will not copy the north bed onto a term. Lestrand will only count this house as a success. Orentel's charter-council will only count it as one ticket among many.

On a usable afternoon in Cut-year 387, morning at the desk is a conversion. Ledan writes a Hale-month loft-term as a Cut-year because a court on the rise asked for that count. Mataero brings the occupancy numbers and does not sit. A necessity-family from a thin year that Vaethod sent is already in a bed, and their grandchild cannot point to the ford named on the back of the note. Someone else's note can be due in the same hour. Sorel's century-instrument is not due then, but it is still on the paper. A court-clerk can have a year converted, and cannot have the Held names read out as a performance. Two lets can be claimed against one bed, and wool and a neighbour's week do not share a mattress just because they share a job-name. If the north bed is occupied, the person in it may be a guest, a thief, a junior's mistake, or a name that came back, and the house is a house again, in public. Ledan stays until

the tide-bell. Mataero walks the rise and checks the north bed. Empty is the custom. Occupied is a session, because the room has become a scene the moment someone is in that bed.

You brought	Ledan writes	You still need
Coin, a house-year, a walk you do not need	a First-Hand term, credit for a stay at the origin you could have skipped	Sorim’s hold, and a Netstrand hull if you want the water
Hunger, a last hearth, someone who will pay on the home-walk	a necessity-note, eat now and pay on the way home	a loft-bed if Mataero has one, and guest-right, the right to be lodged, if they do not
A court-slip, a Cut-year, a demand to convert	the same debt, written in the count they asked for	the court, because the house does not sit the case
A question about the north bed	nothing	to leave the desk, or to say the founding-name if you have it and are someone who may say it

You do not need clergy to get a term, and you do not need a leaf’s colour. A Long-Lived memory of a ford is why the note holds. A grandchild who cannot point to the ford is why the note is cruel. Sorim is not of this house, holds the first quay, and will not convert a house-year. Thilim is the other fate, the hearth that went on making the bed. Sorel is still on the paper, still alive, and not a clerk here.

A term, half-written, on the quay-desk, on a Ledger-month afternoon in Cut-year 387. The hand is Ledan’s. The verso is blank because the customer has not said which count to use.

> *House-year 307, or Cut-year 387, or the court’s third date — say one. I will not invent the hold. I will not invent the hull. I will write the winter.*
>
> *Loft: ask the junior. North bed: not a line on this paper.*
>
> *If you came about a ford your grandparent walked, I remember it. If you came to hear the name in the founding-book, you did not bring someone who may say it. Sit or go. The tide-bell is not a liturgy.*

Ledan is in the middle of a conversion, waiting for the customer to choose a count. If Mataero sees the blank back, they will hear a junior’s chance in it, a moment when the younger clerk might be the one who writes. Sorim will not be in the room unless the term needs a berth, and this house cannot give it one.

Maiethlir (Threnmaieth’s seat)

Maiethlir *(MAI-eth-lir)* is the Tallied Crown’s seat, an origin pilgrimage-town under a roll, and not the grove. The name is the Mother’s thaw. This is where the crown started counting a hearth that was already holy, not where it acquired Thaeloren. The First Seat sits in the Motherwood beside this country and is not its crown. Rithim *(RITH-im)* is the Speaker on the square, the person who names the colour. In a small town the warden Speaks. Here the office has its own person. The city is smaller than Orentel, and older. The clerks will tell you a number after every Eolthael, and the number changes. This is not the Third Hearth, and it is not Brenthael.

Maiethlir is a thaw-river town on Maiethorn, in the Sacred Core and not in the grove. Snowmelt comes down from Lirorn’s Rain-Wall, and the Core-thaw carries that melt toward the Old Crossing. The city is an origin-town of Cut-years 0 to 40, one or two days’ walk from the wood, and it sat down where the water slowed enough to hold a Hand, on a different road than Orenbren’s Near Mile. Orenbren lodges the approach. This river counted the people who stayed.

The extra mile used to come through with the thaw. When Hands-towns made the origin-walk optional, the lodging emptied toward Orenbren’s beds, and the rooms did not stay empty. Clerks filled them, and a pilgrimage-street learned house-names on a tablet.

Threnmaieth coils near the sacred centre and wants everyone on the Threnhael, the roll of names, colours, and marriages of heritable Conditions once they have been noticed. Maiethlir is the square that proves the coil without owning the Tree. The colour that falls is a hymn and a line. Maiethvael shares the Mother and refuses the list, the same hymns on the opposite paper. Its people live downriver, along the first day below the Down Gate. Their capital, Seinbrun, is more than a day from Maiethlir, off the water, and this gate does not lead to it. How much more than a day is not recorded.

The street’s older work is devotion. The extra mile is kept as a civic season, and the roll sits on top of it. A family from thin up-range soil still sleeps in an uncounted loft, and a counted winter can be booked for a price. The Threnhael sits on that season and does not replace it.

Site. The Core-thaw is why anyone stopped. There was a ford, a mill, and a Hand planted beside the water, because the first carrying followed living earth and a day’s drink. The Motherwood is a dark on one horizon. You can walk to the grove, and most children of a Hands-town do not. The college is in those clearings, and it is not this square.

Water is the river, the conduits the crown maintains, and the cisterns in the old pilgrim-streets. Food is the Core’s plenty. Fuel is the wood’s edge, which the Seat will not let a crown cut without a leave. Proximity is pressure, not ownership. The Taken-In work the tended green the crown furnishes, and they are not a nation. A wall exists, and it is old. It was for floods and for a generation of argument, not for a siege the Core no longer expects.

The Core-thaw runs west, toward the Old Crossing, and the city sits where that water slowed. From Thaeloren you come along the Grove Bank, one or two days on the river road, which is not the Near Mile, and you arrive with the Motherwood as a dark behind you. The Down Gate opens downstream onto the Down-Bank. The counted conduits thin within a day, and the Hinge Shore is still several days of bank, orchard, and mud beyond that. The Wall Path goes upstream toward Lirorn and the snow that feeds the thaw. Vehaela's thin-snow winters come this way. It is not the Noon Pass, the old high road over the range. It is the path the river's source already implies. Inside the wall, the Slow Water is the ford and the mill-reach, where a Hand could be planted because the carrying had stopped being a current. The Loft Row is the old extra-mile, one street from the Tree to the tablet-hall. The upper rooms that slept pilgrims are clerk-dorms now. The tension of the city lives on that street: a hymn at the square end, a copy at the hall end, and beds between them that the roll has not all found. Rithim Speaks at the Tree. The clerk waits on the hall side of the same street.

The square. The streets ring the canopy and then run out along the river and the old extra-mile. The order is the order a counted city grows into, an accretion that learned its numbers, not a grid drawn last week.

The Tree is a mature Hand, not the First. Leaf-Fall is a joyous holy day that is also a registration. The colour is Spoken, and a clerk waits to copy it. Rithim Speaks, and does not always let the copy happen in the same breath. The tablet-hall is the Threnhael's local office, beside the Tree and not the Tree. Outsiders hear the work called the Counting. The clerks say they keep the realm hale. The counted hall is the outlet and the attendance in one room. A Far-Voiced hour is furnished through the crown's channel, and to be cut off is framed as your own lapse. A Held bed in the old lofts would offend the roll, and the roll has not found all of them. The Watching keep a room under a chapel the wardens recut, filed as the Grown-Over. The tended green will not follow you home, and home is on file if it did. Two-Bodied leave at the edge is noticed, and that notice is not a Kind-flag. The crown's stiller is excellent medicine, downwind, through the channel, and the Bound are watched past their hazard, the watching dressed as safety. Returned work is kept past the last conduit, and filed there.

Homes accommodate a becoming, and the accommodation is on the tablet. Mixed Kinds live in the city. A Fox of the Snows, down from Lirorn, is a guest with a name. The clerks will tell you a number, and it changes after every Eolthael.

The canopy Turns children at home. The Near Mile is Orenbren's work, the extra mile is a civic season in Maiethlir, and the Motherwood is a walk, not a requirement. The thaw-road still brings a family in need when the up-range soil is thin, an uncounted loft still smells of Hale-month, and a Hand can fail. The roll would like those summers filed. People still come because the hinge is holy. The Threnhael is a tablet beside the Tree, not a record put there instead of it. That is how a pious core got a capital without taking the grove. The same layer has learned how to cut off a household's green.

The Core-thaw runs louder the week before Leaf-Fall. Clerks file that rise as snowmelt, and the watchers do not, and Maiethlir will not say why. Rithim will Speak over the noise, and a clerk will wait for the water to quiet before copying. The counted hall serves the Far-Voiced hour from cups that have already been used that morning, which Maiethlir will not explain, and on the day a marriage is copied the clerks tie a loose thread around the tablet-stylus and cut it off before a colour, which they will not explain either.

Offices. Rithim speaks under Reckoned pressure, and the office is practice-first, not a Kind. The copy is a second, lesser witnessing. Some summers Rithim lets it happen in the same breath, and some summers not. The crown has not replaced them. The Seat has not recalled them. Among the tablet-clerks are Long-Lived whose memory has been bent to the census rather than left free to check it. The named instruments of the roll are Menirein, Tarvae, Videm, and Sirtal. They are not a replacement for this hearth. Rithim is still the Speaker. A pilgrim who asks where the college is will be pointed at the wood, not at the tablet-hall. Some Speakers cooperate with the roll, because they believe they are keeping the realm hale. Some refuse. On the other road, Orenbren witnesses who slept, not what colour fell, and Threnmaieth would like those lodging-rolls. Laevila keeps the old room of the Watchers. They have no seat.

The wants are specific. Rithim wants Valein to stay unmarked on the tablet. Laevila wants Senithi's name good for a marriage. Vehaela wants an uncounted loft for one winter off Lirorn's thin snow. Baerith wants the crown to stop cutting green on a sister's street. The Kept are pitied and noted as unmarked. A household whose bloodline and upkeep are both on file cannot easily refuse the crown anything. In a bad week the river comes over the tablet-hall step, a shove starts at a cut pot and stays a neighbours' shove, or an uncounted loft gives way because the timber did, while the roll had not found the room.

A Threnhael copy-slip, tablet-hall, Eolthael, Cut-year 387. The Speaker's name is on the recto. The clerk's hand is on the verso. The Tree is named as hale.

> ***Recto, Rithim.*** *Spoken: storm-grey. Witnessed in the square. The hug was not this child's. I have said the colour. I have not said the line. The river was loud. I will not wait for it.*
>
> ***Verso, clerk.*** *Copied: Two-Bodied, named to the Threnhael, household already on file. Speaker delayed the copy until after the hymn. Delay noted. River-noise noted as snowmelt. The unmarked in the same household noted. Provision continues through the counted channel.*
>
> *The wood was asked whether the Speaker is a Reckoned Hand. The wood did not answer in this hall.*

The slip shows that Rithim said the colour and refused to give the line, and that the clerk filed the loud river as weather. The clerk calls the delay weather. Rithim calls it the hymn coming first. The First

Seat, asked later, will say only that the Tree witnessed.

The twelve seats

The three corner capitals are already above: Maiethlir for Threnmaieth, Orentel for Lestrand, and Eolvaeth for Vaethorn. These twelve are the other seats of power. A seat here may be a capital, a city, a town, or a refusal to build a city at all. Harrow's Green stays a square in Saelvaeth's orbit, and it is not one of the twelve. Six charter-towns around Raitin, the shelves of Lirorn, and the pockets between grafts stay unnamed. No sheet paints a star on a capital. The First Seat, the college of tree-wardens, stays in the Motherwood.

In each entry the opening says what the place is and where it sits. The work is the job, and who does it. A neighbour uses a given name. In a land that keeps lists, a clerk says the house-name first. What comes last are habits. People do them, and they will not say why.

Seinbrun (Maiethvael's capital)

(SAYN-brun.) Seinbrun is Maiethvael's capital, a large city in the warm core of Maiethorn, and the city that furnishes. People call the country the Gift-Realm, while the charters write *Maiethvael*. The city keeps no list of persons, because counting people is treated here as a failure of trust, and there is no Threnhael. The hymns are the same ones Threnmaieth sings, and the paper is not.

Smaller towns and villages sit around the city, and this book does not name them. Seinbrun stands more than a day from Maiethlir, down the Core-thaw and north of Maiethlir on the atlas, and how much more than a day is not recorded. A traveler who leaves by Maiethlir's Down Gate spends that first day on the Down-Bank, among Gift-folk, and has still not arrived. The bank goes on toward the Hinge Shore. Seinbrun stands off that water. During pilgrimage season the Motherwood is in sight, and the grove stays outside the city. Orenbren houses the people still walking toward the grove. Seinbrun can see that season. It is not an inn on the Near Mile, and it does not crown the First Seat. A pilgrim who asks for the college is pointed at the clearings.

A town Tree stands beside the furnished hall, and Leaf-Fall is kept there. The colour is spoken, and nobody copies it onto a roll. Water comes from wells and from the rain of the warm core, not from the counted conduits. Food is the core's plenty, tended as a green. The Taken-In work the tended lots, and they are not a nation. The hall's court and the older house-walls are what a crowd can point at. The weather the core still plans for is a flood.

The work is hospitality, in the furnished hall, with the green beside it. Congregation and guild tend what a person was Given: the pot, a bed when the hall has one, medicine, and the commons. There is

no crown channel and no tablet-hall. To be inside the hymn is to be inside the net. Vuthbraen keeps the hall. Raermu keeps the medicine basket. A neighbour says those names, and a stranger hears *of Seinbrun*. There is no house to put first, and Maiethvael will not write one. The extra mile arrives as a meal and a bed. A person who has already left the hymn can still be given a bowl.

The warmth is real, and so is the bill. A household that leaves the congregation loses the green, the hall, and the medicine together, and there is no crown to appeal to. The Kept are pitied here, in plenty, and the pity measures what they missed. Breillai left the hymn, and the green went with it, and Breillai is still in the city. The hall can still set a bowl. The net stays where the hymn is.

Sit down in the furnished hall and an empty bowl is already at the end of the table, away from the pot, cleared when the others are cleared, and Seinbrun will not say why it was set. On the day a household leaves the hymn, a neighbour stacks their green pots in the lane with the plants still in them. Raermu opens the medicine basket's latch and only then knocks. After a hug at Leaf-Fall the hall turns the child's bowl so the chip in the rim faces the door, and the Kept are given the first drink from a new cask, the next cup coming from the old one. A lamp in the window burns through the afternoon and is put out while the pilgrimage road is still full. Vuthbraen tears the guest's bread and sets the first piece on the threshold before anyone eats. They will not say why.

Maiethlir's clerks, Orenbren's beds, and the college in the wood are other powers. They are not a staff for this hall.

Rothallo (Orenbren's capital)

(roh-THAL-oh.) Rothallo is a walled city, one day's walk from the Motherwood, and the capital of Orenbren, which people call the Witness-Hearths. People still say the Inner Close, and the Close, and the walls answer to those names. The seat's name is Rothallo. It stays inside Orenbren, and it is not a second power. Smaller towns and villages lie around it in the lodging-country, and this book does not name them. The Third Hearth, the Mill-hold, and Nelath stand in that same country, and they keep their own jobs: a hearth, a sick-Tree lodging, and the road-end.

The First Seat is in the wood, beyond the wall. The wood is not crowned, and Rothallo is not the college. From the grove the walk is one day, and arriving does not make the college a room in the city. From the Near Mile you have already passed the outer hearths, the Third Hearth among them at three days out, and a person who thought the Close was an inn finds a gate. The river road to Maiethlir is a different road. Threnmaieth sends clerks to this gate with empty tablets, and they do not get the page.

A Hand stands inside the walls, and the city has no speaker of its own for Leaf-Fall. A warden of the First Seat may come in for Turning-Week, the festival week when the children stand, and Speak the fall there. If a colour is copied afterward, the copy is the Close's. The wall is old. Hildal's Retreat, the withdrawal that carried the Book behind a wall, put the lodging-beds outside and kept the Book inside,

and the wall was closed then rather than raised to found a kingdom. Orenbren says the wall was meant as a guest-compact, and that the compact never opened to guests. The inns lodge anyone outside the wall. The Book rules inside it. The two share a country, and they do not share a page. Water inside is cisterns and a well the wall owns. Food is the lodging-country's surplus, and whatever the Book assigns bodies to grow. The Taken-In work lots the Book can write them onto, and they are not a nation.

The work is the Book of Tithes, kept inside the walls. Delamem *(del-AH-mem)* keeps it, and will tell you the Book is housekeeping, though the page that assigns labour is in the same hand as the page that assigns a hearth-tax. The pages assign taxes, restrictions, and turns of work, and the Tithe a person already carries is not that assignment. The assignment sits on top of it. Everyone who lives inside the walls owes the Close those turns, the way a town expects each household to take a turn on the watch: the green, the hall, the wall, the road, and the beds outside the gate. A Kept household's turns are mostly the watch on the wall and the keeping of keys. A household with a Condition is given the heavier turns, and more of them, and the Book picks the turn by the Condition. A person who does not want the turns can leave. The Book has no claim on anyone who lives outside, and it cannot send for someone who has left. It does not sell a person. Delamem and the Close will not call the Book a scripture, and they will not Speak a colour.

Talnin *(TAL-nin)* of the Inner Close is still the heir whose tenth year is not finished, so the Tree has not Spoken this child's colour yet. The name is on the heir-roll. A Closed Heir who is Given at Leaf-Fall loses the heir's place. The hug keeps the name on the roll, and the colour takes it off. A Strike later is treated the same way once the clerks learn of it. A neighbour in the city says a given name. A clerk says the house first. *Closed* on a roster is a rank, not a second name. The line can cast a person out and still keep the house on them.

What a visitor sees. A visitor does not need to read the Book to see the rank. At a meal in a Closed house, the Kept sit nearest the host, and a guest who carries a Condition is shown to the far end, past the last Kept guest. When the Book is read aloud, the Kept sit on the front benches and everyone else sits behind them. Nobody is turned away. The host says where each guest sits. When two people disagree in front of a clerk, over a debt, a boundary, or a broken pot, and one of them is Kept, the clerk writes the Kept person's account as what happened and writes the other account underneath as "also said." The person with a Condition can still win, and to win they need a second Kept person to say the same thing. Only a Kept person may hold a key to a gate in the wall, to the Book's house, to a cistern, or to a granary. A person with a Condition holds the key to their own door and to their own stall, and no others.

The children of the Closed houses learn their letters at a school beside the Book's house, and other families inside the walls may send a child if they pay. The teacher, Volnai *(VOL-nai)*, tells them that a hug is rare, and that a child the Tree hugged was kept back for something better than a colour. Volnai believes this and teaches it every year. The lesson is wrong about the count. Most towns have Kept

neighbours, and being hugged is common. What is rare is a family that has stayed without a Condition on purpose, generation after generation, and treats that record as a birthright. The school does not teach the count. Orders and Houses has the Walled Book and the Inner Close in full.

A person with a Condition who lives inside the walls works for wages, keeps what they earn, owns their tools and their household goods, marries whom they choose, and can own a stall. The Book writes a licence for that stall, and a Kept stall-keeper needs no licence. They can walk out of the gate on any day it is open. Nobody owns them, and they are not slaves. What they cannot have inside the walls is the heir's place, a gate key, a vote in the Close's compact, or the first word in front of a clerk.

In Turning-Week the wall will not lodge a Given pilgrim, and the lodging-country is in the business of beds. Breolnir, house Tethnae, writes who slept. The Book writes who owes. The same person can be a guest on one page and labour on the other, and the pages will not be copied onto each other. Brimaen, house Lanbru, keeps a stall inside the walls on a licence the Book can revoke. Methei, house Sithlaen, is Given, on the Book's list for the beds outside the gate, and lives there while the turn lasts. Methei can walk away on any day the gate is open. A neighbour says Brimaen, Breolnir, Methei. A clerk says Lanbru, Tethnae, Sithlaen, and then the given name. Hithaen is a disinherited heir of the Closed, already eating in Eolvaeth's gift-hall. Hithaen is not Talnin, and not Methei.

On a morning with no crowd the outer gate is shut for the length of a kettle's boil, and Rothallo will not say why. At that gate Breolnir sands a sleep-line and writes it again before the ink would have needed sand, while bread for the beds outside is cut while it is still too hot to eat and the heel is set on the wall-stone, which the beds will not explain. Inside, Methei turns the blanket so the stripe faces the wall rather than the door, and Brimaen wipes the stall-board with the cut edge of a loaf and then sells that loaf. The week before a Closed child's tenth year, the child leaves one shoe by the Book's step and walks the lane in the other. The lane, the stall, and the bed will not say why.

Larbril (Saelthael's city)

(LAR-bril.) Larbril is Saelthael's medium city, the place people call the Sown Tree, where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass. It is not a great capital, and the well-town farther into the dry is still Ornsael. Walking west, the Shelf-gate is still ahead of you, the pass above the dry. Walking east, you have already come down, and the dry country is what stands in front of you.

Ornsael stays the smaller well-town, farther into the dry, and its drink is a well. Larbril's drink, when the city has one, is the wash. The days from here to Ornsael, and the days to the pass and to Tasain, are not recorded. The Dry Stair is another rise, and people climb it so they will know a dare from a Tree. The climb is not why this city is here. The city stopped where it stopped because travelers already wanted water and the walk west, and because the core stopped walking while this country did not.

The wash is a river in a kind Liren, a gentle thaw, and a silt-line in a cruel one, a ford in the one case and a pale line in the road in the other. A Hand stands at the meeting and Speaks most years. A missed week is called weather. The civic fact is the wash. Fox of the Sands hearths are dense in this country, and that density is terrain. Brormei is not chosen for being Fox-born, Larbril is not a Fox nation, and mixed Kinds use the road. There is no wall. The boundary is where the road stops being a street and becomes the climb, or the dust. Food is what the wash year allows, plus what a west-bound cart pays. The Taken-In plant where a bucket can be argued.

The work is the meeting, and the city's daily work is the walk west, the decision of whether a column goes on. Brormei says what the wash is this week, and whether a column goes west toward the pass. A neighbour says Brormei. A stranger hears Brormei of Larbril. Saelthael does not keep a person-list, and there is no house to put first. Ornsael's well-share is Ornsael's, and Larbril does not chalk a rope for that well. The pass-levy is Lirorn's, taken at Tasain and at the Shelf-gate. This city keeps the road and the wash in one place. Necessity is a column that still has to go. Devotion belongs to people whose well and canopy are both sound.

The city stands on water that is not a certainty. In a cruel Liren the carts still come, the wash is a line in the dirt, and the core will call that thin soil, and a slight. Larbril still has to say whether the week goes west. Plenty on the far side of the range does not shorten the road. Theisva, Lesna, and Bovaer stay at Ornsael. They are not moved here.

When the Well-wash is a silt-line, Brormei still wets the meeting-stone from a jar, and will not say why. A cart bound west is held while the driver sets a pebble on the dry line. Larbril will not say why.

Votaer (the Hinge Shore's port)

(VOH-tayr.) Votaer is the Hinge Shore's port, one of the largest cities on the Motherland coast, because the crossing is why the people are there. It faces Orentel, and it is not a second Orentel. Hulls are classified on these quays, and the Hush-rate is charged here. Towns and villages along the rest of the shore stay unnamed.

Orentel prices the crossing, and Votaer sorts it. A child, a pot of living earth, a Given-Over whom a contract has come to hold, a recanter taking back a standing, the claim that a witness watched them, or a family on a neighbour's week can make the bell sound the same, and a clerk writes which docket that hull belongs to. That writing is the job. The White Note is not on this quay, and the Chart-run is not this water. The city is ancient and rich, and less frantic than the Ledger Coast, because the grove is still at its back. A fair-weather hull reaches Orentel in three to five days. From Thaeloren the inland way is the Core-thaw and then the Down-Bank, eight to twelve days in fair weather. The bank is the stretch before anyone asks what a hull is. The question is asked here.

The trees on this shore are healthy, and this is still the Motherland. Faith is worn thinner than in Maiethvael, because a dock teaches categories. A Hand stands back from the working quay, and the quay's work is the hull, not the canopy. Selkie families work these quays, as they do on any old water, and the docket does not belong to a hearth. The rate is old custom from the Hinge Hush, the peace the Old Crossing still charges for, and they will not call it a victory. Taerso spoke that Hush for the hinge-houses in Cut-year 304. Taerso is dead. The rate is remembered as Taerso's, and Taerso is not a living clerk.

The work is the classification quay. Tumair writes the hull, pilgrim or pot or person or cargo, and Lertho charges the Hush-rate on the same water. A neighbour says the given name. A stranger hears *of Votaer*. The quay does not file a family, and there is no house to put first. The Standing Trade uses this face more often than Orentel, because a standing has to travel and a hinge has two sides. That trade is not the city's office. Other harbours exist on this coast, and this book does not name them. They are not a second port for the Hush.

The blessing and the docket happen in the same breath. A Tithe-poor household can fail in sight of the road to the grove while a hymn is still in the air. Across the water, Lestrand will price what this quay has already sorted. Votaer will not become that price, and it will not put the blessing down in order to look unlike it. Water for the city is rain and the casks a quay keeps. A wall, where it exists, is for a surge and for the old argument about a fade, not for a siege the Crossing still thinks it can sail around.

Tumair chalks the hull's class under the waterline, where the next tide takes the mark, and will not say why. Lertho counts the Hush-rate aloud, sets the last coin in the box, and takes it out once before it stays. When a bell rings for a sail that is not in sight, a cook-fire on the quay is put out, and on a day when no one has asked for a hymn a dry net hangs on the blessing-rail. The quay will not say why.

Tasain (Lirorn's town)

(tah-SAYN.) Tasain is Lirorn's walled town, in a sheltered valley below the Shelf-gate, where the west road comes down and the levy is taken. People who cannot keep the high road through a winter sleep here. The town is not a great city, and it is not a second Maiethlir. Villages and hamlets stay on the shelves and at the passes, and this book does not name them.

The town gate is the wall in the valley, where a cart comes down off the pass and can wait. The Shelf-gate is the notch above that wall. They are not the same gate. The Noon Pass is a third thing, higher and older, a water-line still sitting on its stone, and it is not a town and not a seat. The Shelf-gate is the road Narol of the Pass took after the Thaw-Break, the one-week melt of Cut-year 233, when the old stone sat under the water. Narol *(NAH-rol)* is dead. The house still levies, and the person does not. Break-rate, the toll still said in Narol's name, is asked even in a kind year, and a lowlander is not given a sermon with the coin.

Saelthael's west road crosses by this pass. Larbril is the city on the dry side, short of the climb if you are walking west. Tasain is where you are when the road has come down into shelter and someone asks for the year's due. Tengu hearths and Fox-of-the-Snows hearths are densest on the high snow. Mixed Kinds live in the valley, and the office at the gate is the levy, not a people. A sky-courier who hears a thaw first is doing a job. A Hand stands in the valley, where a graft can take in shelter.

The work is the levy, taken at the town gate and reckoned on how much snow fell the winter before. The household that inherited Narol's toll still collects, and it carries no house-name. It levies the thaw, the pass, and the high road. After Cut-year 233 the argument was which notch the road should use. A traveller at the gate meets a collector of that household. The collector has no name in this book, and says the toll is Narol's. Maiethlir drinks the Core-thaw downstream and files a loud week as snowmelt. That filing is not a receipt for this gate. Water the core will call a gift is taken here as a due. Devotion can still walk west once the gate has opened.

The valley takes the levy in shelter, and the shelves above pay in isolation for water the lowland files as a gift. A shelf whose graft sickens is a long way from a stiller. The town can charge, and it does not furnish every Tithe on a cliff. A toll that feels like weather feels like Cut-year 233 to anyone who was on the shelf when the stone went under.

In a kind year, before the levy is taken, a bowl of shelf-snow is left on the gate-stone until it is water. Tasain will not say why.

Raitin (Brenledd's throne-city)

(RAY-tin.) Raitin is a river-city on Strandoren, inland of the Ledger Coast and south-west of Orentel on the atlas, and one of the largest on that shore. The days from Orentel are not recorded. People say the Hearth-League. Charters write *Brenledd*. The league stays a league of hearths. It does not become one house. This is where the council sits, and where the shared notes clear.

Six charter-towns sit around the city, and this book does not name them. Villages and hamlets along the same water are not on the shared list. The list is seven hearths, and Raitin is one of them. People still recite Nidtol when Lestrand offers to deal with one ruler instead of seven hearths. Nidtol is the hearth that made the league's first shared refusal, in Cut-year 174, after the Grey Summer, the fever that emptied the quays in 171, and the name is recited for that. Nidtol is not this city, and it is not a person in this hall.

Where Orentel prices a berth, Raitin clears a note among hearths. There is no crown and no Threnhael, and you are of your town first. The three pillars are the machinery a commercial shore already uses. An unvouched person is a transaction that cannot clear, and a vouched person can still be unknown in the next hearth. Faith is worn light, as on the rest of this coast, and a Hand stands beside the council hall, where Leaf-Fall is kept. Nothing is policed, and a charter is. Raitin's water is the river under the

stair. The Chart-run, four to eight days upriver of Orentel, is Lunbra's water, and it is not this river. The city does not hold a First-Hand year.

The work is the council hall, at the head of the river stair, where the shared notes clear. Turvo keeps the notes, Sulnu carries a cleared ticket down to the stair, and Nubo is vouched in this city and still unknown where another hearth did not stand them. A neighbour says the given name. A stranger hears *of Raitin*. There is no house to put first, and the league will not write one. The six charter-towns keep their own hearths. This hall does not appoint them. Water for the city is the river and the cisterns above the stair. Food is what the hearths underwrite into the market, grain and river-fish and a ticket a charter will still honour. A rise in the river still lifts the lower doors, and the city plans for that week.

A note can clear in this hall and still die in the next hearth. The fade sits in that gap, and the league calls the gap local. Lestrand can still offer one ruler in place of the seven. Raitin is where the council sits. It is not that ruler.

Watch a meeting and you will see Turvo turn a cleared note face-down before the next hearth is called, Nubo move a dry thread from the left wrist to the right on the way out, and Sulnu set a river-stone on a shared note and put that stone into a bowl of water at dusk. The hall sets one cup at the end of the table and leaves it empty. Bread for the meeting is broken at the river door, and the heel stays on the sill until the meeting ends. On the morning a note is due, the stairs are swept from the water up toward the hall, a child who came through Leaf-Fall with no colour is handed a wooden token with no price on it, and the lamps on the stair are lit from the hall downward. Ask Turvo, or Nubo, or Sulnu, or the hall, and you will not be told why.

Naenor (Leddvael's port)

(NAY-nor.) Naenor is Leddvael's port, on its own stretch of indented coast, down the coast south-west of Orentel and south of Raitin on the atlas. The days are not recorded. It is slightly smaller than Orentel, large enough to keep its own houses, and it is not a second Orentel. People say the Reckoned Gift, and the charters write *Leddvael*. Towns and villages along the rest of that coast stay unnamed. This port does not face the Hinge Shore. Votaer is the port that does.

Leddvael took the Fair Hand, a dockside theology of the gift, and made it a civic rite, so Leaf-Fall here is a festival and a signing-watch at once. A Tithe is a term serviced. The Bound are employed to witness a term, because a Bound's word still closed in the Grey Summer, when the other witnesses had died. The city will file a contract. It will not copy Threnmaieth's list, and it will not become a census of souls.

The port competes with the Ledger Coast, and it wins the signing. A term can close on this quay while Orentel is still pricing the hold. What Naenor loses is the berth, the White Note, and the scale of the deathless houses on the Old Crossing. A First-Hand year is not this city's product. The empty prestige

berths are Orentel's. Naenor has working berths, and the work the city is for is the watch. The Book-Hands stamp and recite on this quay, as they do on other signing-quays. They have no seat of their own, and they do not rewrite terms. Inland filing is Lunbra and the far crossing is Braetu, so Naenor is the stretch between those jobs.

A Hand stands off the signing-square, which Motherfaith tree-tenders and Fair Hand clerks share. Gift-reading families live in the city. They are the minority that sounds devout, and the statute reads them as a credit risk. The city's daily work is the signing. If devotion lands, it is a hymn the festival will schedule. Necessity is a household that still calls the colour a gift.

The work is the signing-watch, on the book-table in the square. Derdil stands it. A neighbour says Derdil. A stranger hears Derdil of Naenor. There is no house to put first, because the Reckoned Gift does not keep a person-list. The Book-Hands who work this quay are not Derdil, and they are not a seat.

The city wins the term and loses the berth. A Bound's word can close a contract on this quay, and the hold that would make the contract a life is still priced on the Ledger Coast. Inside the win, a household that calls the colour a gift is filed as a bad debtor. The Bound are safe here, and they are over-read, because the sworn contract is being asked to stand for the whole person. The faith is not the villain. It is a sincere ledger laid on a real Condition. Water is rain, casks, and a paid well off the salt. A wall, where the town kept one, is for a surge. The statute is not a wall.

Derdil stamps the wax, then warms the stamp in a closed hand before the next page, and will not say why. The watch reads a term aloud and turns the page with the left hand only, and at Leaf-Fall the square sets the Bound witness's chair with its back to the Tree. Naenor will not say why.

Lunbra (Trenledd's city)

(LUN-bra.) Lunbra is a large, wealthy city on the Chart-run, four to eight days upriver of Orentel and inland of the salt. People say the Worn Count, and the records write *Trenledd*. This is where the roll is kept. The governing office, or the council, stays unnamed. Towns through the filed country stay unnamed, and a road-end town that got written down is not the roll-room.

The city shows the money, in stone fronts, paid chairs, and guild doors left open onto the square so the coin is visible from the street. People come because a family already has the money, or because they want it, and both kinds of arrival are written down. Trenledd began as ticket-and-tax machinery and did not stop at property. You are on the roll so commerce and hazard can find you again. There is no hymn that makes the list a stewardship. Threnmaieth at least claims to keep you hale. The Worn Count claims to keep you findable.

After the Grey Summer, Dirrol's column was who is still alive to be found, and that column is the city's memory. Dirrol is not a living clerk in this room, and not the crown. Cutting a person off the

furnished channels is the default, and it is not called impiety. The Struck are pursued so they can be catalogued, because an unwitnessed change is a row that appeared without a clerk. A Hand stands in the square, where the trees are mature and the faith is worn light, and the number on the back of a stone is a count, not a prayer.

In fair weather, grain, beans, and the inland tickets go down the Chart-run to the salt, and the food on the Ledger Coast is this plain as much as it is the catch. In winter the banks go to mud and the river still moves, so the week belongs to the boats. That shift is weather, and it is not a second government. The Taken-In work the river-gardens. Oxen pull the heavy carts, and a barge does the bulk.

The work is the roll-room, on the square where the money is shown. Vamar keeps a column of who owes, who Turned, and who can be found. The file is Melro, Vamar. A neighbour says Vamar. A clerk says the house first. A stranger hears Vamar of Lunbra. Vamar is not the governing office. Licence-guilds write their own tickets through the same room, and they are not a second crown. In Trenledd the column may file a person under the house that pays, including a house they dislike. Vamar's page is where that fight becomes ink.

The city shows the money, and the roll is how a person is allowed near it. A family that already has the money is already a house on the page, and a person who came to make it is written in order to try. There is no hymn to appeal to. The office that could strike the row stays unnamed, and the column does not become that office by being the page people can see.

Vamar sets a coin on the open page, and the coin is not the fee, which Vamar will not explain. On the morning a new house is written, the stones in the square are turned number-down, and a newcomer is shown the expensive chair and is not asked to sit until the house has been said. Lunbra will not say why.

Braetu (the Night Shore's harbour)

(BRAY-too.) Braetu is a harbour city on Strandoren's west and south face, on the West Water. It is smaller than Orentel because the far run is thinner than the Old Crossing. People say the Night Shore, and the charters write *Netstrand*, which sells the hulls and the west-water berths. Towns along the rest of the shore stay unnamed. A crossing is quoted here the way another shore talks about a pilgrimage.

The city does not sell the First-Hand year as a finished thing, and that winter is not this city's to crown. The year is assembled on the old water: a Night Shore hull is chartered here, the White Note writes the terms, and Orentel holds the berth. Braetu is the first of those three desks, and it is not the other two. Coasting from Orentel to these west quays takes eight to fourteen days. You arrive with a hull to charter, or with a name to keep lit, and you do not arrive in a hold.

The far run, toward the Heskoren frontier, takes two to four weeks in fair weather. Beyond the last capes is the storm-wall, and almost nobody has crossed it. A story that says otherwise is a story, and

Kumbaan is not booked from this quay. Along that run, Saelvaeth may take a pot without a waiting-due, Vaethorn may bless a landing and may not levy it, and Ornled is a beach-fee. The quote for the run is written here.

The harbour keeps a dark book of the quoted crossings that did not come back, and houses pay to keep a lamp on a name in it. A lamp on a name that will not come back is charged as watch. The book is not a Threnhael, and it is not a White Note. It is how this shore remembers that it is a night shore. One berth stays unlit, with no house attached to it, and the city does not add one. Selkie families are common on this water without becoming the flag, and the sky-couriers out of Lirorn and the Tengu families on the clock-towers are jobs in the harbour, not a district of it. Faith is mixed and worn light, quay-charms stay off the charter, and a Hand stands back from the working water. The harbour's worry is a hull past the last forecast anyone trusted.

The work is the quote-desk, where the dark book is kept and where a lamp can be bought for a name. Mursur writes the far crossing and takes the fee for the lamp. A neighbour says Mursur. A stranger hears Mursur of Braetu, because there is no house to put first and the Night Shore does not keep a person-list. Mursur is not a house on the unlit berth, and nobody is. A name can be kept lit, and the lighting is a charge. In the same harbour, one berth stays dark, with no one to bill. The city will not put a house on that berth to make the book tidy, and it will not pretend the far quote is grief. Watch is what the lamp is sold as.

Mursur lights a name's lamp with a spill from the cook-fire, not from another lamp, and will not say why. The far figure is written, blotted, and written again the same, and people leaving the harbour touch the unlit berth's ring without hanging a line on it. Braetu will not say why.

Sanbreo (Ornled's town)

(san-BREE-oh.) Sanbreo is Ornled's town, on Heskoren's slate-shore, the west coast. It is on the brink of a small city, and it is still a town. People say the Outer Ledger, and Outer folk, while slates and learned maps write *Ornled*. The beach faces west, toward the last capes and the storm-wall beyond them. The frontier coast that faces the West Water is on the east side of Heskoren, so a hull that wants this beach has to come round the capes. Villages in the pockets around the town stay unnamed. They share the same thin grafts, the same barter, and the same absence. Eolvaeth is a vale behind the other coast, in the waiting-gospel, and it is not this gate.

The roofs have filled the pocket. A walk that used to pass through here left stones and upper rooms, and people still sleep in them. The brink did not grow a congregation, and it did not grow a counted hall. Custom outruns law, because there is almost no law and almost no hymn. Braetu can quote a far crossing, and the fee here is a beach, not that quote. Vaethorn may bless a landing, and may not levy it. Ornled was written into the Hinge Hush as a beach-fee, and they were not asked. They take the fee anyway, because a hull that wants the beach is a hull, and a hymn is not what they sell.

The work is the slate, on the wall inside the shore gate, where a pocket-road meets the beach. The first line is still the sentence Vathne cut, after the Thaw-Break, when a graft pot the town had waited for drowned in a flood that came from someone else's thaw. The line says the town will not wait with a hymn for a stick that drowned. The wood of the wall is newer than the words, because someone recopied the line onto it. Vathne is that line, and Vathne is not a person you meet here. When a hull arrives, whoever is on the shore gate that day cuts the fee on the same slate, and that person is not named. Barter, favor, and the wall are what a person puts up so they do not slide. An unvouched Struck is met with a rope, a deal, or a neighbour. There is no blessing queued behind the fee.

A hull can pay, and a neighbour who cannot barter a Tithe still slides. The roofs filled the pocket without becoming a net. Vaethorn hears godlessness in the missing hymn, and the wall hears a luxury that died in a cart. The loneliest unvouched on this coast are next door to a gospel, in a town where no one is waiting with them. The Outer Ledger does not keep a person-list, and there is no house to put first.

When a hull has paid, the coin stays on the slate's sill until the hull is gone. Sanbreo will not say why.

Vaelhesk (the land is the seat)

(VAEL-hesk.) The land is the seat. The formal name sets *vael*, what the land yields, beside *hesk*, the far edge, and saying it that way keeps the spoken name clear of Vaethorn. People say the Far Yield, and the Yield, while charters and learned maps write *Vaelhesk*. There is no new city and no new name. Old greens, doors kept for ancestors, and a first meal before anyone is allowed to leave with something of the place: that is the country. The Mother's wood is a guest on that older ground. A Cutting-leave without the meal is a claiming. Villages and hamlets stay on the old greens. A traveler who asks for the seat is pointed at a door.

There is no settlement dot. The First Bowl stays the guest-grove, folk name Lonasir, a planting on this land and not a capital. Harrow's Green is the live-front square, and it is not this seat. The Door-Keepers walk here as Kin-speakers. They did not carry the scion, they do not confirm colours, and what they argue is who the host is. The Struck, and the Taken-In, are read as the land's own children. A neighbour's week to a Motherfaith Tree can be refused on purpose, and the refusal says the child is already the hill's. Vaethorn reads those children as Kept for want of a gift. That disagreement decides whether a child travels. No new person is seated on the refusal.

These were ancestor countries before the grafts. The grafts arrived across Cut-year 200 to the present year, 387, and they are still arriving. Some districts became Vaethorn, and these districts kept the door. The state stays light because the land does not need a clerk in order to be owed a meal. The Thaw-Break moved guests off flooded ground and up to high doors. The Hinge Hush does not write Vaelhesk into its clauses, because a first meal is not a landing-due. A warden who arrives with a pot is a guest if

they sat down for the meal, and a thief if they took the wood without sitting. Refuse the meal, take the wood, and you are not a neighbour. The harm stays local, and it does not become a holy war.

Natai (Saelvaeth’s town)

(NAH-tye.) Natai is a march-town on Heskoren’s moving edge, in Saelvaeth. People say the Sown Waiting, and March-folk, while the charters write *Saelvaeth*. A graft has taken here, and the canopy is a town’s Hand, young enough that the neighbours still argue which town gets the next pot. It is not the luck at Harrow’s Green. Other towns where a graft has taken stay unnamed, and so do the hamlets between them.

On the roads, Natai sits west of Harrow’s Green, between the square and Sanbreo, and not on the ford. The days to either place are not recorded. Harrow’s square is the canopy the hamlets can see, with Haelin’s stone and the upper room, and it is not the march’s seat and not a capital. The Three Hamlets Past the Ford stay the three hamlets. Brenod, Vaelun, and Ornath stay their kitchens. The Hinge Hush lets this march take a pot without a Vaethorn waiting-due. The due that remains is local. Someone has to stand where the queue can be shouted at, and that is why this town has the office. The neighbour’s week of need still happens at Harrow’s. What sits here is the blame.

The work is the march-voice, the office that answers for the queue of grafts. Dumu stands it. A neighbour says Dumu. A stranger hears Dumu of Natai. There is no house to put first, because the Sown Waiting does not keep a person-list. The office did not exist when the first pots came. The Seat’s ruling about who gets a pot had no one to answer for it, and the office is that person. Dumu hears the complaint and answers to whoever is angry, and cannot decide where a pot goes or move the wood into the next pocket. Haelin keeps Harrow’s square, Tora of Brenod keeps the walk from the ford, and Dumu keeps this gate.

The town can be blamed for a queue it did not write. Harrow’s has the canopy, and Natai has the person to blame. The town has enough state to be blamed, and not enough state to be a kingdom of the luck. The gate is the road between grafts. It is not Harrow’s square, and it is not the ford.

While a complaint is said, Dumu leaves the gate-latch on the post, and puts it back in the catch when the speaker turns. They will not say why.

Other Places

The twelve seats have their own chapters. What follows is the ground those chapters point at and do not sit in: three stones nobody has been allowed to date, a hall on the far side of the storm-wall, and three towns the roads already use when a Tree is sick, when a guest has to be fed before a colour is named, or when a mile has been pulled into a square and then stopped. Harrow's Green stays the grove-town in Saelvaeth's march, Ornsael stays the well-town in Saelthael's dry country, and Larbril stays the city. The First Seat, the college of tree-wardens, stays in the wood. One kind of square is still only a kind. Two claimants on one green stays unwritten, and the last section of this chapter says what that hole is.

The Low Wall

In Orenbren lodging-country, the stretch of inns within the first days' walk of the Motherwood, a low run of stone leaves the present road, stays outside Rothallo, the city people still call the Inner Close, and stops in a fold of ground that is now lodging-fields and the back garden of an old road-house. Everyday speech calls it the Low Wall. Folk also call it the Wall Against No One. The Close, the walled ground people still live in, will tell you the wall is theirs. Scratch the lichen and the quarries part company, because the Close is one quarry and this wall is another, so the claim and the rock are already arguing. What no one could date sits with the leftovers of the count. The stone is from before the Walk, the years that have no start and no first year anyone can honestly write, and it is not a date for the Turning Tree, and it is not the Inner Close.

The wall is shoulder-high in most places, higher where the ground dips, and broken in three gaps that people use as gates. It does not enclose a town, and it does not face the grove. It faces out, if out still means anything, toward lodging-fields and that back garden. No one living built it. The Watching, the faith that keeps the Tree as something already seeing and will not let a later name start its history, will fight any Cut-year a clerk tries to scratch into it. A Cut-year is a numbered year in the count the wardens use, running from the First Cut, and the present year of that count is Cut-year 387. The Old Ways, who set a first-meal where they mean a guest, will leave that meal at a gap and will not call the wall a guest-Tree. Motherfaith wardens, who serve the faith that gives the Tree a mother, want a ribbon taken off, because children already climb the wall the way they climb a mile-shrine, and this wall is not a mile-shrine.

The Closing, the later work of dressed stone that people still live inside, made a different wall. Hildal's Retreat is that work, taller than this and still inhabited. People who say the Low Wall is the Close's outer ring are doing a claim.

Want	A child brought down off the high dip, labour taken off the garden, and a year kept from being scratched into the panel.
Have	Three gaps, an inward step, a blank name-stone, and a garden-end loft.
Fear	The Close confirming the wall as theirs, a clerk dating the Before, and a knife-ribbon left here in error.
Live conflict	The Close's claim, a Watcher's refusal, the lodging-guild's nuisance, and the climb itself.
Enters a scene	A labour-gang in the person-gap, a child on the high dip, and a chisel at the panel.
How this site talks	As a walk and an argument, not as a warden's notice.

One gap has a socket that might have held a post, one has been widened so a cart can pass, and one is only wide enough for a person. The Close's labour-roster sometimes assigns a walk through that last gap as owed work. The Book, the Close's own record of who owes, cannot make that walk count as owning the stone. On the field side the footing is built as if someone expected to stand behind the wall and look out. There is no walkway left, and there is a habit of standing there anyway. Mid-run, a slab carries a panel that once held letters. The letters are gone, and they were taken off rather than worn away. Watchers say that taking is correct. A Closed Heir, someone who still claims a rank inside the Close, says the panel was theirs. A lodging-guild says a later pilgrim stole a luck-name. At the garden end the wall dives into the back of a hearth that still lets beds, a road-house of the same kind as the Third Hearth and not Thilim's house. The innkeep waters the last course of stone as if it were a pot-ring, the circle where a pot would sit, and it is not a pot-ring.

Who	What they need it to be	What they will not admit
Inner Close	An outer ring they forgot to staff	The quarry is wrong
Orenbren lodging-guild	A nuisance that draws climbers in Eolthael, the month of the Turning	That its own guest-compact never opened to guests, which is a wall of its own
Watchers	The Before, kept as stone	That watching does not need a wall
Old Ways hearths on the Mile	A guest-mark, or a door that is not a Tree	That a meal will not make it a grove
Tree-wardens	A climb they want stopped	That a ribbon here is not a colour, and the children already know

It was one summer, and it was not a school of diggers. In Hale-month of Cut-year 381, Hale-month being the spring month when the land is counted sound and the crowds come to climb, **Nurreith** *(NUR-rayth)* and three lodging-guild hands opened the bed under the blank name-stone. Delamem, for the Walled Book, had paid for a chip that could be filed as the Close's quarry. A Watcher stood in the cut and would not let a chisel touch the panel. **Thuda** *(THOO-dah)* wanted the gang off the garden by dark, and pulled them. What they fought over was the chip, and under the chip the right to call the wall a page. Delamem needed the quarry to match. Nurreith needed the labour back on the guest-beds, and also needed the chip to be worth the afternoon, or the guild would call the day a waste. The Watcher needed no Cut-year on the stone. Thuda needed the person-gap empty and the last course left as a pot-ring, which it is not.

The chip was the other quarry, and nobody scratched a year. They filled the bed the same week, and the fill is newer than the taking of the letters, so the fill can date the quarrel and cannot date the wall, the Tree, or the Before. The next person with a shovel is still a person with a shovel. No office came of the afternoon, and no method came of it either. The Close still wants a confirmation, the Watchers still want the panel blank, and the garden still wants its evenings. Nurreith is a given name, the kind a neighbour says out loud. A stranger who hears *Nurreith of the garden-end* has already made more address out of it than Thuda likes. There is no house-name.

You come in the way the wall already lets people through. The cart-gap has been widened, so you walk in the way a delivery would, and the Close prefers this gap when they want the wall to look like theirs. The person-gap is only wide enough for one, and the labour-roster assigns a walk through it as owed work, so you can be sent in or you can send someone out. The socket-gap might have held a post, and Old Ways leave a first-meal here some weeks, so you can step over a bowl to go through. Under the name-stone the panel's bed is loose if you have an afternoon and a reason. The way in is a crawl, not a dungeon level. It goes along the footing toward the inward step and stops, and there is no under-city.

Thuda lets beds against the last course, so you can sleep in the garden-end loft and wake with the wall in the window.

While you are there, the Close wants a confirmation they can file, and Delamem will pay for a quarry-match that is not true. A Watcher will not let a Cut-year touch the panel, and will stand in the chisel's way. The lodging-guild wants climbers off the high dip before Eolthael, and wants the labour off the garden now. Thuda wants the person-gap empty by dark, will feed you, and will not call the stone a shrine. Hale-month is when the crowds climb. Ledger-month, the late-summer month when contracts come due, is the quieter one, and it is meaner about who hired you.

You can walk the wall in an afternoon, sleep in that loft, and be asked to fetch a child down off the high dip. The hire changes with who finds you. The Close will pay to have the wall confirmed as theirs, a Watcher will pay to stop a clerk from dating it, and Thuda will pay to pull a labour-gang out of the person-gap. What you might find, and still no year, is a different quarry's chip in the name-stone's bed, with the Cut-year 381 fill on top of it, a pot-ring that is not motherwood, a knife-ribbon someone left because they thought this was the nameless knife's first house, which it is not, a second footing behind the inward step that never got a walkway, and scratch-wear on the person-gap that is newer than the Close's claim. A visitor can see a ruined wall, a climb, and an inn's back garden. From that they can guess two quarries, a claim, and a Book that assigns a walk through a gap. Nobody knows who the wall was against, or whether against is the right word.

Who	In a scene	Will pay you to
Delamem (Close)	at the blank panel, or assigning the person-gap	confirm the quarry
A Watcher (unnamed)	standing the chisel off	stop a year
Thuda	garden-end, watering the last course	pull labour; fetch a child
Orenbren lodging-guild runner	with a complaint already written	make the climb stop looking like a mile-shrine
Nurreith	the guild's shovel, if the bed is open again	finish an afternoon, or be stopped

A lodging-guild complaint, unsigned, nailed to the garden-end for a summer and then taken in. The Close had sent people to walk the gap as if the walk made the stone theirs.

> *The Close sent three Conditioned to walk the person-gap as owed work. They are not our beds and they are not the Close's wall. The children will climb whether we complain. If a Speaker asks, it is not a shrine. If Delamem asks, it is not a page. If a Watcher asks, we did*

> *not scratch a year. Pull your labour off our garden. The stone was here when the beds were full, and it will be here when the notes are.*

The complaint calls the three walkers Conditioned, people who carry a Condition, the acquired change that stacks on the ancestry a person is born with, and it dates the stone by when the beds were full, which already counts years without cutting a Cut-year into the panel. A Speaker, in that note, is someone who would ask whether the wall is a shrine. Delamem would treat a gap in the wall as a row in the Book, and a gap is not a row.

The Seeing-Ring

On a hill in Maiethorn’s old Watching country, the hymn-country where people kept a watch on the Tree before they gave it a mother, north-east of Maiethlir, stands a ring of stones older than any name a clerk will be allowed to write. Someone later put a shrine on the ring, and someone after that took the shrine’s roof off and left the stones. Everyday speech calls it the Seeing-Ring, folk call it the High Stones, and Watchers keep a night there without calling it a temple. The lower ring is undated, and it is not a date for the Tree. The upper work is overlay, from the Hands years or from late in the Walking years, and which of those it is remains argued. The Hands years are the years when a town could Turn under its own Tree. The Walking years are the older years, when Turning meant the walk to the one Tree. **Tithsael** *(tith-SAYL)* keeps the present night. The days’ walk from Maiethlir is not what this hill is for. The grove, and the First Seat, stay in the Motherwood.

The hill is not Thaeloren, the origin Tree in the Motherwood, and it does not want to be. On a clear Eolthael you can see a smear of Motherwood weather from the top, which is why later people built a shrine. If the First Hand is there, her hand at the origin, showing in that weather, a seeing-place here can be talked into hers. The lower work is a ring, not quite a circle and not quite a wall, of stones set to make a person turn as they walk, so that you look out. That looking-out is the argument the Watching needs. The Watchers keep the Tree and say it was already seeing, and that a mother-name came after the seeing. Each layer on this hill is a story laid over a seeing. The upper work is cut from a kinder quarry, stone that is not the ring’s own. The steps do not match the ring’s tread, and a socket once held a door-beam. A Tender’s mark, the sign a tree-warden pecks to bless a place, is pecked over a withheld pattern. The roof is gone, and the mark is still there if you know to rub the lichen. Wardens call the emptying respect, and Watchers call it finally.

Want	The night kept, a colour-ribbon taken off the socket, and a year kept from being cut into the ring.
Have	A ring-walk, four out-looks, an emptied shrine, and a pecked mark.
Fear	A roof put back on, a congregation forming, and a clerk with a chisel.
Live conflict	The Watchers' seeing, the wardens' emptied respect, and a roll that wants the hill written down as a person.
Enters a scene	A chisel, a ribbon, a child who wants a door that is not a slight, and rain on the open socket.
How this site talks	As a night and a refusal, in Tithsael's slate, not in a Speaker's notice.

Clockwise is the local habit of the ring-walk, and a Watcher will not tell you why. A warden will tell you it is Turning-Week in stone, the week of the Turning copied into a direction, which is overlay so confident it sounds like folklore. Four gaps are wider than the rest. One faces the smear of the origin, one faces the Old Crossing weather, and two face nothing a present map cares about. Nobody says what those two face. What is left of the shrine is steps, a beam-socket, and no roof. In Eolthael someone ties a cloth ribbon on the open socket, and by Leddorn, the later month when contracts are reckoned, it is gone. Tithsael takes the ribbon off if it is a colour-ribbon, a ribbon tied for a colour a Tree Gives, and leaves a hug-ribbon, tied for the hug that Keeps a child and gives no colour. That is how a Watcher does a kindness the Seat will not understand. Pilgrims say the wood sent the ribbon, or that it fell from the origin and landed on this hill. It is cloth that someone on the hill ties, and they will not say why they chose a colour, and the origin did not drop it. A person can untie it and hold it, and it is a strip of cloth that does not Speak and does not cast anything. You can feel both cuts if you put a thumb on the pecked mark, the warden's sign and the older pattern under it. Tithsael keeps the night not as a service but as a seeing. People come with a cough, a question, or a child who was not Held and was not Given, neither kept by a Tree nor given anything by one, and who wants a hill that does not owe them a name.

Who	What they need it to be	What they will not admit
Watchers	The Before, kept	That a night can become a congregation
Tree-wardens	A shrine they emptied politely	That emptying is an admission the ring was not theirs
Threnmaieth clerks	A hill that should be on a roll, a list of persons	That a seeing is not a person, and so cannot be entered
Maiethvael guilds	A furnished night, oil and a lamp, without a list	That furnishing a night is already a bill
Closed Heirs	Nothing. A hill is not a rank.	That they once sat a different high place and called it a gate

The hill path is ordinary, and you climb it in a morning. Once you are in the ring, clockwise is the habit. The emptied shrine steps are the later tread, and they do not match the ring. A warden will call these steps the door, and a Watcher will call them overlay. Between the lower stones and the hill, on the sea-gap side, there is a squeeze a small person can do and a mainlander can do with a scraped back. It may be a drainage-gap or a seeing-gap. It goes a body-length, opens on one out-look from underneath, and there is no temple-crypt. Tithsael lets you sit the night if you did not bring a colour-ribbon and did not bring a year to cut.

A clerk wants a Cut-year cut into the ring. Tithsael will not let the chisel touch, and a party can stand with either side. A warden wants a roof put back on the socket, and calls that respect. Watchers call a roof the start of a congregation. A colour-ribbon shows up on the socket in Eolthael, and Tithsael takes that one off, while a hug-ribbon is left where it was tied. Maiethvael will try to furnish the night, to bring oil and a lamp, without putting anyone on a list, and furnishing a night is already a bill. The smear of the origin shows only on a clear Eolthael. The other two out-looks show themselves in any weather, which is worse for a pilgrim who came wanting a meaning.

You might find a second withheld cut under the Tender’s mark, a pot-ring of ordinary clay, a view of the origin that makes a pilgrim weep and a Watcher shrug, a scratch under the ring that is not a letter, and lichen that grows only on the overlay quarry. A visitor can see a stone circle, a ruined shrine, and a night-watch. From that they can guess two builds, a later overlay, and a faith that will not let the first cutting of living wood be the year the count begins. Nobody says why two gaps face nothing on a present map, or what seeing meant before it meant a mother. This hill holds no gate of the Closed Seat. You can be hired to stop a clerk, or to put a roof back, or to take a colour-ribbon off, or to rub the pecked mark and say which hand was first, and the hill will not tell you which hand that was.

Who	In a scene	Will pay you to
Tithsael	the night; the slate under a stone that is not in the ring	take a colour-ribbon off; stop a year
A Reckoned clerk	with a chisel and a number	write the hill onto a roll
A tree-warden	at the beam-socket	put a roof back, or bless what was emptied
A Maiethvael guild-hand	with oil and a lamp	furnish the night
A child (unnamed)	asking if the hug lives here	sit with them until the smear is weather

Tithsael's night-slate, one line a week, kept under a stone that is not in the ring. It is a watch kept in writing, not a service.

> *Ribbon off. Clerk came with a year; I would not let the chisel touch. A child asked if the hug lives here. I said the hill does not Give and does not Keep. The child said that was a better door than a slight. I did not correct them. The origin was a smear. The sea-gap was weather. The other two were themselves. If you are a Speaker, this is not a colour. If you are Limrae's child, this is not a row. If you are Hildal's child, this is not a seat. I am going to sleep on the inward step of a different stone. I am not taking the hill with me.*

The slate shows that Tithsael turned the clerk's chisel away, heard the child call the hill a better door than a slight, and did not correct that. It refuses a Speaker's colour, refuses to be a row for Limrae's child, and refuses to be a seat for Hildal's child. Then Tithsael walks off to a different stone and does not take the hill along.

The Dry Stair

In the dry east of Saelthael, the Rain-Shadow, where the towns sit on wells, a rise above a well-town holds a flight of steps cut into the rock. They climb to a door-stone and a basin that has not held water in any summer a living person will swear to. Everyday speech calls it the Dry Stair. Folk call it the stair that does not climb to a Tree, and they say that both as a joke and as a warning. The stair is undated, and it is not the Tree's original temple, not a first shrine of the fox-born who keep hearths in this dry country, not a ruin left by one born people ruling the rise, and not Ornsael's hill. Ornsael is the

other well-town, farther into the dry, and its drink is a well. Larbril is the city. This stair is the climb, and the basin stays dry.

The Rain-Shadow still walks west after the core stopped. The core is the country that used to walk that road and then stopped, and Saelthael's dry east did not stop, so the well-towns still send people toward a Tree. This stair does not join that walk. It climbs up, only as far as the rise, to nothing a Hands-child is trained to want. A Hands-child is a child of the present years, raised to expect living wood at the end of a climb like this, and the top of these steps is bare stone. The steps are worn in the middle, because people have gone up for a long time. At the top there is a slab with a threshold cut into it, standing like a door with no wall, and behind it a basin pecked into the rock that is dry. Taken-In who know wells, the people a dry town asks when a hole in rock will not hold, say the rock was never a good cistern, because the pecking is wrong for holding. Old Ways visitors on a visiting week leave a first-meal at the threshold and do not call the slab a guest. Children dare the last step and come down louder than they went up.

A later warden planted a slip in the upper basin, a cutting of living wood carried in a pot, so the stair would have a point. The slip died, and the Seat did not send a second. What is left is a thumb of dead wood in a crack at the lip. A person can work it free and hold it, and it still will not green and will not take in a pot, and what they are holding is not a scion and not a colour. People say the stair refused a mother. The rock was dry, the pecking was wrong for water, and the slip died of that. The refusal is the story they prefer to the dirt. Saelthael already knows about dirt: the soil is why a slip dies on this rise. Dead wood is not a Tree.

Want	A dare finished, a second slip stopped before it is planted, and a missed child sat with, without the town calling that child Kept.
Have	A worn flight of steps, a door-stone, a dry basin, and a well-town below that is not Ornsael.
Fear	Outsiders claiming the rise as a Fox shrine, a clerk copying the scratches on the risers, and a warden who comes to plant again.
Live conflict	The joke, the shame, and a west-road that still goes.
Enters a scene	A slip in a pot, a child on the last step, a year rubbed into a riser, and night on the slab.
How this site talks	As a climb and a dare, in a child's count, not in a warden's notice.

The steps are countable, and the count changes if you ask three children. One step is broken, and people skip it and call the skip luck, or a slight, or nothing, without agreeing which. The door-stone is a threshold with no wall and nothing over it, so you can stand in it and be on both sides of a door that does not enclose anything. Door-Keepers, who officiate at a real door and at the meal that makes a guest, will not officiate when they have come this far west, though they will eat if a bowl is there. The pecking of the basin is the wrong shape for a well and the right size for a pot, which is why the warden tried a slip there. A ring of salt-white sits in the pecking. It is not ash brought from the Motherwood, and it is not a colour. The well-town below is not Ornsael. It is a lesser walk-hold, a well-town that still sends its people west. The stair is the town's dare and its shame at once: visitors ask where the Tree is, the town points west, and then someone laughs at the stair. A few steps have a scratch that might be a person. Watchers would not date them. A Threnmaieth clerk, the kind who copies a mark onto a record, would want them copied. The town rubs them with a thumb and does not read them aloud.

Who	What they need it to be	What they will not admit
Saelthael west-road	A habit they can retire by joking	That a local ascent that Gives nothing, with no Tree here to give a child anything, is the core's story of them
Old Ways visitors	A door	That a door-stone without a meal-habit is just a slab
A warden with a pot	A place the wood should have taken	Dirt, again — the soil is why the wood will not take
Fox-of-the-Sands hearths	Not theirs, please	That outsiders will claim any dry rise as a Fox shrine
Ornled travellers	A slate: the hill does not owe a hymn	That they came up anyway

The climb takes a quarter-hour, whether you skip the broken step or not. Behind the basin a crawl starts where the pecking is wrong. It is a slit a hand can disappear into, and then a shoulder, and it opens on a second basin, lower in the rise, also dry, with the same salt-white and no hole a Tree was set in. You enter the stair from the town's shame. Visitors ask where the Tree is, the town points west, someone laughs, and then someone dares you.

A warden with a pot has another slip, because the last one died, and still wants the stair to have a point. The well-town's warden is unnamed, and is not Theisva of Ornsael. A clerk wants the scratches on the risers copied, while the town rubs them with a thumb and does not read them, and a party can stand with either. A child who missed Eolthael is unTurned, and not Kept. Kept is the name for a child the leaves closed around and gave no colour, and the town will not put that name on a miss. Someone will

ask you to sit the door-stone overnight so the child has a door that is not a slight and not a Tree. Fox-of-the-Sands hearths want no outsiders claiming the slab as a Fox shrine, and outsiders will try. At night the last step is louder going down than it was going up, and the wind in the basin is not water.

You might find that the salt-white is mineral, or ash of ordinary brush, or something the town does not have a word for. You might find the second basin, a west-road name scratched over an older scratch, and pecking-tool marks that are the wrong angle for a cistern on purpose. A visitor can see the stairs, a dry fountain, and a dare. From that they can guess a failed planting, a habit of doors that have no grove behind them, and a town that walks west because this place is not a Tree. Nobody says what the basin was for, or why the pecking is the wrong angle on purpose.

Who	In a scene	Will pay you to
The well-town's warden (unnamed; not Theisva)	with a slip	plant again, or be talked out of it
A west-road child	counting, skipping the broken step	dare the last number with them
An Old Ways visitor	bowl at the threshold	eat, not officiate
A Threnmaieth clerk	at the thumb-names	copy the risers
An Ornled traveller	who came up anyway	say the hill owes no hymn, then stay

A west-road child's count, said going up, copied by a Road-hand who should have been going the other way, and who wrote the dare down instead of walking on.

> *One, the broken. Two, the thumb-name. Three, the laugh. I am not to say the last number because the last step is the dare. At the top there is a door that does not keep you in. There is a bowl that does not keep water. We go west for the week. We come here so we know the difference. If a warden plants again I will water it, and I will not call the death a slight. If a clerk writes a year I will rub it. If you are from the core, this is not your mile-shrine. We climb those too. They have ribbons. This has a dare.*

The count shows that the town climbs the stair to know the difference between a dare and a mile-shrine, one of the ribboned climbs on the same west road. The Road-hand who copied it wrote a dare down as if it were a mile.

Ndenjoo

Ndenjoo *(nden-JOH)* is a hill-hall on Kumbaan, the Sundering Isle, and the own-name comes from the isle register, while sailors say **the Feeding Hill**. The valley comes here on the bright nights, and what they come to is a table, because there is no Turning Tree.

Ndenjoo is one of the Paps, a green hill honeycombed underneath, with pasture and standing-stones on the turf and the life below. It is the hall the valley already knows. **Njunda** *(NJOON-dah)* opens it because it was their grandmother's, and because it still fits the crowd. That keeping rests on reputation, not on an office. When they die, the valley will come to the next hall that still sets the extra place. The storm-beach is a walk down, not a quay. **Soonke** *(SOON-keh)* sits that stretch of sand and does not swim out. When a wreck comes in with living people on it, they walk those people uphill, and the first night is spent as guest at the hall, not on the sand.

This is an ordinary home that happens to be nearly impossible to reach. The uncanniness is the distance, and the hands you can see without bodies. The home is not a paradise, and it is not a monster-haunt. Mainland noon-faiths are loud here the way a guest who will not sit is loud. Kumbaan never had the pilgrim walk, and it never had a Tree. What the hill carries from the wall is people who arrived and did not leave, and people who want to leave and cannot book a thinning. A thinning is a moon the sitters know, not a ferry.

Want	An extra place laid. A second night that makes kin. A guest who can sleep the day.
Have	A hall under the turf. Unseen hands. A path down to Soonke's sand.
Fear	A wreck that becomes a crowd. A kin who will not leave. A noon that will not stay quiet.
Live conflict	Njunda seats; Soonke only decides alive; Saalo wants a crossing out; Nolas has sat twice.
Enters a scene	A wreck walked uphill tonight; the hands stop; a guest loud at noon; a hull rumour.
How this place talks	A second night at the table. There is no warden, no notice, and no Tree.

The hill is why anyone stayed. The hall is a long room under the turf, with lamps that face the table and not the sea. On the surface there are terrace-gardens, a standing-stone the children dare, and goats. Below that are the hearths, the feast-board, and the extra place, set slightly back from the rest. Water is

a hill-spring and caught rain. Food is the terrace, the shallows when the wall is kind, and whatever the unseen hands fetch, so that a poor house still sets a table that looks like more than its means. Fuel is peat, and whatever a wreck sometimes gives the hall. There is no lot, no counted hall, and no stiller. There are no walls. The boundary is the last path-cut toward the sand, and the storm. A slip planted here would die. Dead wood is not a Tree, and no one in this valley is waiting for a colour. A few dozen hearths live under the one Pap, and they come to the one hall.

Life is under the hill, so you do not walk through a town. You walk into a Pap and come out at a board, where the table is the civic heart and the sacred heart at once, because the rite is supper. The extra place sits slightly back, not at the end, and it is laid at every meal that matters, not only at the feast, so that omitting it is the one impiety. Unseen hands fetch and pour while people sing, and nobody reads a colour or recites a set of terms. A child of the house learns the work by carrying dishes, and by being told not to sit there. When the moon is down, people sleep in the cool day-rooms, because daylight is a Sabbath of sleep and not a fallen hour, and a mainlander who is loud at noon is a problem the whole hall feels. The path to the sand is Soonke's stretch, with a hooded lamp that does not call ships, so the living go up and the dead go above the tide. The standing-stone on the turf is a dare rather than a mile-shrine, and there are no ribbons on it. Visitors from the core will try to climb it as if it owed them a leftover, and it does not.

On one night of the moon sailors call Yoltal, which is the worn mainland name for Turning-month, the hall eats the heel of the loaf first. Every other night the heel is last, or it goes to the goats. The valley says the hands like the crust when the mainland is loud. Njunda will not correct that, and will not say it is the reason. They will not say why, and a guest who asks is given more bread.

Homes here accommodate the becomings the isle actually has. A rare Struck is family news, not a class. A Yumboe is what you are because that is who lives here. Mixed mainland Kinds are guests if they crossed, and they do not grow quarters of their own.

Njunda keeps the table, and that is the whole job. They want the extra place laid, and they want **Nolas** *(NOH-las)* gone without the place being omitted. Soonke sits the shore on this stretch. They want the living walked uphill, and they want the lamp left unmistaken for a harbour. They will not seat anyone on the sand. **Saalo** *(SAH-lo)* is of the valley, and wants a crossing out to find **Waandi** *(WAHN-dee)*, who left two moons ago and sent no word. Saalo is a sibling, not a scholar of Trees. Nolas came off a Netstrand hull that tried the wall. They have sat twice, which makes them kin inside the hall, and they will not go back to a ship. The valley is tired. Staying hosts say the dead's names when they fill the extra place. Serving hosts do not say the names, and they still fill the place. The argument waits until after the dishes. There is no town-warden, no roll, no First Seat, and no Road-hands. The Open Table is the faith, and this is a hall that keeps it.

You cannot book a passage to Ndenjoo. You are on the sand, or you are not. Soonke decides whether you are alive to be walked up, and Njunda decides whether you are kin. The second sitting is how you

belong on the isle, and that belonging does not travel back to a mainland watch. A road-word, the mainland custom of being vouched for by a name, a last hearth, and someone who stands, still helps you leave a Strandoren quay before you sail. On the hill, nobody asks for it. The shore-sitters leave the arrived where the beach put them. A thinning is a moon the sitters know, not a ferry. Most hulls wreck, turn, or do not return, and the sitters do not send anyone back. Saalo is waiting anyway.

What can come up the hill is a wreck walked uphill tonight, the people wet and breathing and nobody asking them for a colour, so the hall has to open on a first night when the extra place was already set and now there is also a living stranger. The hands stop when a child sat in the extra place, or the place was used as a spare stool, or a Serving host and a Staying host argued during the pour. The valley is hungry, and fixing it is manners, not a miracle. Noon-noise is Nolas, who will not sleep the day. The noise is mainland loud, and the hill feels it. A hull rumour is someone on the sand who saw a sail. Soonke will not swim out to it, Saalo will want to go down, and Njunda will want the hall kept. A warden who arrives is still a guest. There is no Tree to tend. The argument about a tenth-year week belongs to the mainland, not to this valley.

This season, Njunda wants Nolas to leave as kin, not as a slight, and wants the extra place to stay laid. Soonke wants this wreck off the hill before the next loud night, and wants the lamp still hooded. Saalo wants a crossing toward Waandi, or a word that Waandi sat a second night somewhere that is not here. Nolas wants the hall as a hearth. They have been counted, and they will not be a passenger again.

Said to the extra place before the hands arrive, at Ndenjoo on a bright night. Children are taught it. Njunda added the second line after Nolas sat twice.

> *We have counted you. Sit. If you have a name we have not learned it yet; if you have a colour we have no tree to read it.*
>
> *If you have sat twice, you are of the table. The table is not a ship. Sleep when the moon is down. The sand does not owe you a second hull.*

It is a grace said over a meal. Sitting twice makes a guest into kin, and that is why the hall fills. A sailor who copies only the first two sentences will sell them on a quay as a proverb.

The Mill-hold

The Mill-hold is a Hands-town whose Hand is standing in water. A Hand is a town’s grafted Tree, a cutting of living wood that took and now Turns the children at home, and everyday speech says *the Mill-hold*, while travellers who only saw the drain say *the culvert*. It is not Orenbren’s capital, which is Rothallo, and it is not Brenthael. The three corner seats stay Eolvaeth, Orentel, and Maiethlir. A few hundred hearths sit around one mill-race and one canopy.

West of the Rain-Wall, on Maiethorn’s four-season core, a mill-town grew around a graft that took beside a race, so the town has bread and a Hand in the same water. For a generation they Turned at home. The Near Mile goes on past Brenthael and past this hold. Children here were told the road went to the Motherwood, and most Hands-children did not keep walking. The culvert choked this Liren. Liren is the thaw, the month when water runs again, and the culvert is the drain that keeps spring-water off the roots. The mill-race stayed full, and the Hand stood in it. What the wardens call root blight is ordinary horticulture, waterlogged soil and crowded roots and a drain someone assumed someone else had cleared, and it is this year rather than a curse or a sermon.

Unsound wood spends the week. A warden who lets a cohort stand under a Tree they know cannot Turn has made those children unTurned, and a later summer does not repair this week. The civic crisis is wearing a child’s summer, which is the only summer the Given-door will open. The town’s daily work is meeting need, so the neighbour’s week returns, the week of walking to someone else’s Tree. Devotion belongs to people whose Hand still Speaks. Nobody books a blight.

Want	A neighbour’s week that still has room, and a mill that still turns after the culvert is opened.
Have	A neighbour-slate, a shovel at the drain, and Brenthael’s canopy two days grove-ward.
Fear	A child stood under unsound wood, Brenthael’s extra-mile week too full, and a second cut taken from this Hand while it is sick.
Live conflict	Milsun’s drain against Talen’s race against Thurrei’s wood.
Enters a scene	A bough coming down, mill-foam on the lip, a slate with one name too many, or a child already in the square.
How this square talks	A neighbour-slate and a shovel. Two working people, and a Road-hand who came for the wood, not for the children.

Counted from the grove, the Third Hearth is three days out, Brenthael is one day further, and the Mill-hold is two days past Brenthael’s boughs. Six days out, still lodging-country, and still not a throne. Brenthael is the neighbour Hand, and its Tree is sound. Fair weather is a promise the culvert did not keep. A side-cut of living water feeds the race, and the same cut was supposed to take flood off the square. The oldest houses face the Tree. The mill-house and the race sit on the lower side, where the water wants to be. No walls stand here. The boundary is the last mill-share and the ranging. Water for people is not the crisis. There is drink, and there is too much of it in the wrong place. Food is mill-grain, terrace gardens, and pigs on mast-rights older than the lodging-guild. Fuel is coppice the Two-

Bodied also range. A travelling stiller, one of the Stilled who hold a wound or a moment still, is a Near-Mile luck, not a resident of the hold.

The Tree at the centre is mature enough that grandparents Turned under it, and young enough, for the Motherland, that someone still remembers the year the road stopped being required, though the leaves this Hale-month are late and a little colourless at the edges. Under the square the culvert is brick and timber older than the mill-house's present roof, with climbing-scuff on the lip from children who have heard a stone-story, shovels, a smell of wet bark, and mill-foam that holds a day after the race is drawn down. The mill-race is the town's bread and its name, so opening the culvert to save the Hand lowers the race, and Harvest is not theoretical. The neighbour-slate is chalked on the mill-door rather than on a warden's lath, and it carries the names of this year's ten-year-olds and which Brenthael household has room, Talen's hand on the recto and Meirim's marks on the verso when they arrive. The upper room used to sleep the extra mile when people were walking in toward the grove, and this Hale-month it sleeps the necessity-column going the same way for a different reason, so it is not a merchant-loft yet. The greens are potted and hauled up off the wet, because there is no lush lot, and the Taken-In here are neighbours whose planting, Milsun's, sits above the race on purpose. The ranging stays at the edge, where mixed Kinds work and no Kind-flag hangs on the mill, and the far shed is Returned work downwind of the drink and the grain, with no infirmary.

This is Maiethorn, Hands-country, where the town Turned its children at home and most of them did not keep walking past the boughs. The Mile still goes on, and this year the wood is sick, so the children walk in, toward Brenthael, while a Road-hand is here with earth rather than with a colour. A Hand can fail, and that failure is weather, not the end of the age. The Seat will call thin soil, the mill will call a race, and Talen will call a date in Eolthael. All three are looking at the same square.

Mill-foam on the drain-lip keeps last Eolthael's colour a day longer than the water does. Milsun will not say why. Talen moves the foam with a stick, and Thurrei wipes it off a pot-wrap and does not write it down. A miller still takes a share of the grain. The square does not turn on that miller unless you ask whose race was kept full. When the race is drawn down, the mill-share sets the stones and leaves one measure of last year's grain on the lip until the water comes back. They will not say why.

The talk in the square is about the drain and the slate. **Talen** *(TAH-len)* is town-warden. They Speak the conservative way, so the office is a practice and not a people Talen was born. Talen will not stand a child under unsound wood, and wants the mill to keep turning through Harvest. The same water that has to come off the roots is the town's bread. The document of this square is the neighbour-slate, not a notice about a stone. **Milsun** *(MIL-sun)* is Taken-In, on the drain and the planting. Milsun has been saying the culvert would choke since last Tally, the autumn count, and wants the mill-family to stop taking the Tree's turn as if plenty were a hymn. A sister's child is on this week's slate. Milsun will not follow you home. Home is wet if the Hand dies, and dry if the race does. **Thurrei** *(thur-RAY)* is a Road-hand, here for the wood. Thurrei brings living earth and the watering-words, and a report to the Seat if the scion sickens, and will not cut a second without leave. The queue that would replace this

Hand is the same queue that has not yet given the three hamlets past the ford a first Tree. Thurrei knows that sentence and will not say *queue*. What Thurrei wants is one night when no one asks about the hamlets. **Meirim** *(may-REEM)* of Brenthael is the neighbour-host. Meirim wants the Third Hearth's stone down for an extra-mile crowd, and now has a necessity-column walking in from the other side. Same square, two crowds. Meirim is not this town's warden. The square that used to watch children Turn has to walk grove-ward this year and come back. Orenbren lodging-custom keeps hospitality as rent in Eolthael. A Hands-town that sends its children inward looks, from a bed-guild, like failure. Talen hears a date.

What arrives while someone is already talking is a bough coming down, the wood wet and the Hale-month crowd under it, or the culvert at first light, when Milsun digs and the race drops and a mill-hand is already there with a count of the turns the mill lost, or a slate with one name too many, because Brenthael's verso says the beds are full and a child is still ten this week and the Given-door is still one week, or a child already in the square at dawn, dressed for a fall Talen will not Speak. Unsound wood does not become a hug because someone is hopeful. Thurrei's pot in the upper room smells of earth. A second cut would be a fight with the leave, not a kindness.

A neighbour-slate, chalked on the mill-door in Hale-month, Cut-year 387. Talen's hand is on the recto. Meirim's marks go on the verso when they come. The blight is not named.

> *Ten this week: eight. Brenthael can take six if the extra mile sleeps in the loft and not the square. Two names left. I will not invent a seventh bed.*
>
> *The race is drawn at dawn so the lip can be opened. Grain after. Colour is not this door's work.*
>
> *A pot is upstairs. It is not a pilgrim. It is not a child. I can tell. I will not always say which of the eight is Milsun's kin.*

Talen is doing a week, and will not file a blight. Milsun will read the slate as a slight on the drain. Thurrei will already have walked the roots.

The First Bowl

The First Bowl is a guest-grove. An old green kept host-rights here before any leave was written, and the right is to feed a guest. A young Hand stands in the green now, cut from Harrow's Green after Harrow's took, acting on the origin's behalf, and married into the ground after the live front had a canopy of its own. Everyday speech calls the place *the First Bowl*, which is what you do before you cut, tend, or Speak. The folk hearth-name is *Lonasir (lo-NAH-seer)*. The Seat still writes *a later planting in the Far Yield*, and it does not use the hearth-name. This grove is not Vaelhesk's capital,

because the land is the seat and Vaelhesk names no city. It is not Vaelun, not a second Harrow, and not a sick Tree. The Mill-hold, in Orenbren, is the sick Tree. A few dozen houses sit around one old green and one young guest.

The vale is a pocket on Heskoren, in the Far Yield, and what the pocket still has is an old green, ancestor-doors, and first meals. The Mother's wood stands here as a guest. A Cutting-leave, the Seat's paper for a cut, is a claiming if it arrives without the meal. Door-Keepers walk here as Kin-speakers. They did not carry the scion, they do not confirm colours, and the thing they argue is who the host is. The cut came from Harrow's after Harrow's took. What stands here now is a healthy Hand, and it was not a first Tree for the three hamlets past the ford. The hamlets can see that from the ford even when they cannot see this vale. The wood went past them into Yield-land. Brenod calls it the queue. Vaelun calls it a guest that should have sat at their green. Ornath has looked at the other road. None of those kitchens is this grove. The village's daily work is host-rights, and the right is the meal. Devotion is a misreading visitors bring, because they come looking for a chapel. Nobody books a first bowl. A Road-hand's necessity leaked through once, and it leaked through in a pot.

Want	The bowl before the colour. A child who can be kin and Given without one name eating the other.
Have	An old green, a young guest, a bowl, two people who both love the wood.
Fear	A warden who will not sit. A leave that treats the meal as delay. Vaethorn calling refusal deprivation.
Live conflict	Delvor's bowl against Vilraet's Speaking against Brudu's morning water.
Enters a scene	The bowl set out; a pot that has not sat; a child waiting in the rain; Nethiro from Vaelun with a question about the heel.
How this square talks	Two settings of one bowl. No slate. The leave does not mention the meal.

The vale is a day's walk from Vaelun, sometimes two, and the walk goes away from Harrow's, deeper into the Yield rather than back along the Rise-water. You do not pass Harrow's square to reach it unless you are carrying wood from there. The weather is sheltered. People grow rye, oats, cabbage, and hay, with apples on the warm slope and pigs on woodland mast under local rights. The kind season is short: one brilliant dry day, and then rain. A clear day is when everything moves at once, so Leaf-Fall, the week the children stand under the Hand, and a hinge-walk can land on the same dry hours. Water is a vale-beck and a planting-ditch. It is not a named river, and it is not Ornsael's well. The fight over a morning bucket is host against guest in the same green, not a town emptying itself for drink. The

houses sit dispersed around the green. You walk from hearth to grove, and you do not walk through a town. There are no walls, and the boundary is where the old green ends and the moor begins.

The old green is Taken-In ground, with ancestor-doors and a first meal older than a Cut-year, and it is Brudu's planting, so the hearths are mixed Kinds and the green is not a Kind-quarter. The guest is a young Tree at the green's heart, Spoken for a few years, not mature the way Harrow's is and not unsound, with leaves that take colour. Vilraet Speaks when the bowl has gone around, or tries to. The bowl itself is wood, darkened by use, set on a stump that was never a mile-shrine, and some years the rim carries two chalk-marks, *sat* and *cut*, though most years only one of those marks is honest. The door-path goes water, then hill, then stone, and a guest who reverses it is corrected without a sermon, because the path is not a procession-route for Leaf-Fall even when the crowd wants the boughs and the two routes cross in the mud. The warden-hearth is new, relatively, and practice-first, with its door facing the guest, which is where Vilraet lives, and a pot may sleep in the loft when a Road-hand is passing through with someone else's wood. At the vale-edge the Two-Bodied work the same woods the doors walk, with no Kind-flag, and downwind the far shed keeps Returned work on a different door from the ancestor-meal.

The green was a door before it was a square, and the children were already the land's. A household can refuse a neighbour's week at a Motherfaith Tree on purpose. The guest-Hand Speaks in some years. Some of the ten-year-olds stand here, some still walk to Harrow's, and some do not walk. The Harrow-sentence is a luck this vale did not inherit by asking, and the wood arrived anyway. Vaethorn's gospel is spoken on many hearths, and this square lives in Vaelhesk custom. A waiting-gospel that calls refusal deprivation is the enemy of the meal. The hamlets' cup asks whether to send, and this bowl asks whether to sit. It is the same water-country, and it is a different question.

The first-meal bread is always a little sour, and Delvor says that is how you know the grove sat down. Vilraet will not eat the heel. Brudu puts a pinch from another hill in the bowl, and will not say which door it came from. After the last person has gone in, a rye-straw is laid on the door-path's first stone and left until first light. The First Bowl will not say why.

Two claimants share the green with one tender, and this sharing does not close the unwritten square at the end of the chapter. **Delvor** *(DEL-vor)* of Lonasir is the Kin-speaker. They ask about the bowl before they ask about a leave. This season they want a particular Struck housed, kin-named at the grove-door rather than walked to a Tree to be filed as late. They may refuse a neighbour's week on purpose for a child they believe is already the hill's. They will tend the guest as host, and they will not carry a scion. **Vilraet** *(vil-RAYT)* is town-warden of the guest. The practice comes first, and the office is not a Kind. They want the week Spoken so a marriage in the vale can be witnessed this Eolthael without a walk to Harrow's. The year the wood arrived, Vilraet did not sit, or sat late, and Delvor has not forgotten. The leave in the hearth does not mention the meal. **Brudu** *(BROO-doo)* is Taken-In, and the old planting. They want the morning water before the guest's pot. They will not follow you home, because home is the green that was here first. They are tired of being asked if this is Taken-In country.

The question is the slight. **Nethiro** *(neth-EE-ro)* of Vaelun is a Door-Keeper's cousin, and walks here when the bowl is set. Vaelun's work is still host-rights at a kitchen that refused the neighbour's week, and this grove is the later planting that kitchen points at. A Road-hand comes through sometimes, and either that hand planted or their circuit did. They are told to eat first, and if they do not, they are a thief for a season. The Seat's leave still says *a later planting in the Far Yield.* Clerks who learn *Lonasir* have learned more than the minute wanted them to.

What enters is the bowl set out, before Leaf-Fall or before a pot is opened or before Vilraet Speaks. If the bowl goes around, they sit. If it does not, the child still stands, or does not, according to the hearth and not according to the leave. A pot that has not sat brings an earth-smell, a Road-hand on a clock, and Delvor at the stump. A warden with a pot is a guest or a thief, depending on whether they sat down. A child waits in the rain while two honest claims take the dry hour. The colour and the kin-name both want to go first. A hinge-walk collides with the crowd when someone reverses the door-path and is corrected without a sermon. A Struck the vale will not house stands where Delvor named them kin, with the courtesy and without a pillar, and standing-for is still civic.

Said at the stump, not written. One voice is Delvor's, one voice is Vilraet's, and the bowl is the same.

> *Sit. Then Speak. The wood is a guest. I will not let a colour go first in a house that fed it.*
>
> *The week is one week. If the bowl lasts the rain I still have a fall to name. I have a Tree. I did not invent it.*

The three voices disagree, and nobody settles it. At dawn someone still decides whether to lift the bowl, wake the child, and take the colour or the door-path first. A third line, if Brudu is there, is only: *The planting drinks at first light. The guest can wait until the bowl.*

Nelath

Nelath *(NEL-ath)* is the road-end Tree-town, the place where the walk stopped, so the square is the last mile. Mile-folk say **the spur** and mean the road, then use the town's name once they are in it. It is not a capital of Orenbren, and it is not the First Seat. Rothallo is the capital. The three corner seats stay Eolvaeth, Orentel, and Maiethlir. The warden is Raetoth, and the neighbour who argues with that warden is Lithsur. This town is not Harrow's Green, not Brenthael, and not the Mill-hold. It is one square at the end of a spur, with fewer hearths than the Mill-hold.

West of the Rain-Wall, in Orenbren lodging-country, a graft took where a side-day of the Near Mile used to end. The main Mile still goes on to the Third Hearth, Brenthael, and the Mill-hold. This track leaves that road and does not rejoin it. When Hands made the origin-walk optional, this town did not leave the feeling in a sentence. They brought the next stone in. The boughs closed what had been the

day after. Many Hands-roads end at a canopy while a cart-track continues to a ford, a mill, or a neighbour. That sentence is true at Harrow's, and it is true at the Mill-hold, whose children can still walk grove-ward. It is not true here. Beyond these boughs there is no ford. There is a scar: a ditch, thorns, and the width of a road that is no longer a road. The town's daily work is being the place where the walk stopped. A pilgrim may leave a ribbon. A family in need, if one comes, turns around and uses the Mile. Nobody books a spur that cannot be walked through.

Want	The stone left in the square, the scar left closed, and a bed that is not being asked to be a next day.
Have	A sound Hand, a stone that used to be a further day, an upper room, and a ditch of thorns where the road was.
Fear	The stone hauled back onto the scar, a child told the ditch is a mile, and a slate that files the name over the door.
Live conflict	Raetoth keeps the mile in the square. Lithsur wants the name back on a day of walking.
Enters a scene	A rope on the stone, someone coming out of the scar, or a Road-hand asking which bed is the next day.
How this square talks	A cistern-chalk and a neighbour. Two people. The Mile is a different road.

The junction is on the Near Mile, a day short of the Third Hearth, about two days from Thaeloren in fair weather. From the junction the spur is one day, and then the canopy. You do not pass Thilim, or Meirim, or the culvert. The Low Wall is a different fold, closer to the wood, and has no Hand. The graft was planted beside the old day-mark because living earth and a child want a drink. The drink for people is a cistern by the warden-hearth, and the stone is not the well. Settlement nucleated around the canopy and then stopped, because there was nowhere further to put a house. The oldest houses face the Tree, the spur comes in on one side and becomes the square, and no walls stand here. The boundary is the last garden and the scar. Food is the spur's gardens, a pig on a mast-right, and whatever a Mile-cart leaves when someone is willing to turn around. Fuel is coppice. A travelling stiller is a Near-Mile luck, not a resident, and the Taken-In who keep the green around the Hand are neighbours, not a nation.

The Tree at the centre is a mature Hand, old enough that grandparents Turned under it, and the road's requirement ended in the living memory of the deathless and in stories for everyone else, so the wood is sound and this is not a sick year. Leaf-Fall is held in the square because the square is the mile. The stone that used to stand a day further on now sits in that square, with a flat top, climbing-scuff, a ribbon some years, and a name cut in it. **Raetoth** *(RAY-toth)* will not read the name aloud. **Lithsur**

(LITH-sur) will, and wants the stone back on the scar so the name is a day's mark again and not a festival climb. The cistern by the warden-hearth is the day's drink, and it is not a mile-shrine and not Seine's pot at the Third Hearth, while the stone is not the drink either, even though a notch on the stone still holds a little rain after the square has dried. Raetoth calls that weather, and Lithsur calls it the day. Beyond the boughs the scar is thorn, ditch, and a line you can follow for a stone's throw before it closes, with no cart-track and no neighbour's canopy, so people who try it come back scratched and thirsty while the water-notch stays on the stone, which is here. The upper room has too many beds for the trade the town has now, because it slept the day that was pulled in. It is let, and it is not a bank. A name is cut over its door that no one reads aloud, and no lodging-slate has copied it, so when a Road-hand asks which bed is the next day, Raetoth will not answer that question with a bed. Around the Hand the greens are enough to live from and not a ticketed lot, the ranging stays at the edge where mixed Kinds live and work and no Kind-flag is hung, and the far shed is Returned work downwind of the cistern, and it is not an infirmary.

Children Turn at Nelath, because the walk stopped and the square is the last mile, and the road ends at the boughs. Someone still walks the scar and will not call it closed. A Road-hand still treats the upper room as if a pot were going further, and no Tree failed this year. The Seat will call the requirement over, Raetoth will call the mile the square, and Lithsur will call a name that used to be a day. All three are looking at one stone. The rain-notch stays wet, and a name is cut over the door of the upper room. Nelath will not say why the notch stays wet, or whose name that is. A clerk who copies either one has already misunderstood the town.

Raetoth is town-warden, practice-first and not a Kind. They Speak the fall at home, and want the stone left in the square and the scar left closed. A neighbour says *Raetoth*, a stranger hears *Raetoth of Nelath*, and there is no house-name. What Orenbren witnesses is who slept, and it does not list a family. Lithsur is a neighbour, a given name with no house behind it. Lithsur wants the stone back on the scar so the cut name is a day's walk again, will bring a rope in Eolthael, and will not call that rope a riot. Lithsur will not take a house-word to win the argument. The name over the upper-room door is not a person you can hire. A Road-hand passing the junction sometimes turns down the spur with earth or with nothing, sleeps upstairs, and asks for a road. They are not a chapter of this town. Orenbren is a compact of hearths. This town is one of them, and it is not the compact's crown. The First Seat is in the Motherwood, beside the country, and not in this square.

Hugs are less common on a sound Motherland Hand than elsewhere, but not rare, and a missed week still hurts. A family that needs a neighbour's Tree walks back to the Mile. That walk is a repair, not this town's brand. The road-mend stops at the boughs, the thorns stay, and the spur stops with them.

What enters is a rope on the stone, the Eolthael crowd in the square, Lithsur with the rope and Raetoth with the square, while the Hand is still going to Speak and the argument does not get a second week. Someone comes out of the scar through thorns, with no water, and with a story that the ditch went further than it does, and the cistern is the drink, while the stone is not. A Road-hand in the upper room

asks which bed is the next day. The name over the door has an answer nobody will read, and the scar does not have one either. A child on the stone asks how far it is to the Tree. They are already under it. The climb is not a map.

Chalk on the cistern in Hale-month, Cut-year 387, in Raetoth's hand. The name on the stone is not copied.

> *The mile is the square. The scar is not a road. I will not put the stone back to make a day this town ended.*
>
> *Lithsur may say the name. They may not take the stone in order to say it. A rope is not a mile.*
>
> *Drink here. The notch on the stone is not the drink. The upper room has beds. The name over the door is not a slate. If you came for the Mile, you left it yesterday.*

The chalk shows that Raetoth will keep the stone in the square, and that Lithsur may say the name and may not take the stone in order to say it. Closing the road did not unsay the name. The Hand does not decide between them.

Two claimants on one green

Not yet written. Two claimants on one green: warden and door-keeper. Vaelun leans this way. It is not yet a named square of the type. The First Bowl is the guest-grove. It does not close this hole.

Book VIII

Faces

Faces of the Turning

These are offices the towns already needed, made into people, and the job is why a party meets them at all. None of them were chosen. You can meet two in a week and miss the rest. They were not recruited by Kind, the ancestry a person is born with, so any Kind may hold the work. A neighbour says the given name. The second name, and what a clerk or a stranger gets instead, sits at the end of this chapter.

Read the last column of a table as an ordinary want, a stall or a bed or a name, and not as a want about the Tree.

Offices already on the ground

Each of these six already stands where the work is. The seats stay the seats already named.

Person	Square	The job	The ordinary want
Vaethod	Eolvaeth	town-warden who sometimes sends a cohort to another Tree	Saelid keeps the baker’s stall through winter
Rithim	Maiethlir	Speaker who will not say the line	Valein stays unmarked on the tablet
Mataero	the White Note loft, Orentel	occupancy, the count of who is in a room	buy Sorel out of a century-note
Thilim	the Third Hearth	innkeeper of the Held bed	the stone’s water still feeds the pot at dark
Laevila	the recut chapel, Maiethlir	Watcher, who describes what was seen and does not confirm a colour; keeps a copy of the chapel beam’s hidden face	Senithi’s name is good for a marriage
Tesara	the stillers’ shed, Orentel	the catching-year, the week the Intake keeps with a person just Struck	Valen gets a ticket, not a quiet week

Thilim and Laevila both say *I walked*, and they do not mean the same walk. Thilim means the Near Mile, kept as an inn. Laevila means a child's walk under Thaeloren, the origin Tree, before this river had to count them. Mataero Turned at home, files the year as occupancy, and treats the spread of town Trees as finished. Vaethod sends people toward a luck they cannot see from Eolvaeth. The live front is Haelin's square at Harrow's Green, not Vaethod's, and Eolvaeth remains Vaethorn's seat, the gospel of the wait. Other offices already stand on that ground, and the later table keeps them: Haelin at the live front, Tora walking a witness home, Ledan at the White Note quay-desk, and Sorim holding a berth on Orentel's first quay.

Positional pivots

These six matter because of the office they already hold.

Vaethod — Eolvaeth

Vaethod *(VAYTH-od)* is town-warden of Eolvaeth, the vale where people come to wait, and there is no house to give a clerk. A neighbour says Vaethod, and a stranger gets Vaethod of Eolvaeth. They are Hands-folk, raised where a town Tree is the ordinary way to Turn, and they were Given at this Tree, a colour at their own Leaf-Fall, so the office is practice and not a Kind. They are the person who has to say whether the hinge happened, whether this Tree's week actually turned, and some years whether a cohort walks toward Saelvaeth's luck, the march where young wood takes more readily. They will not write a colour that did not fall. They have sent people away before, and the town remembers which summers.

What they want is **Saelid** *(SAY-lid)*'s baker's stall through Ledger-month, the late summer when contracts are counted. Saelid is the younger sibling, on the camp-streets. The winter customers who buy the bread are the same households a sent cohort takes away, and Vaethod has not told the square that this is why they wait until the week is over. They have sent people toward Haelin's live front without meeting them. A pot going that way is a Road-hand's job. They are fortyish, with salt in the hair already and chalk on a cuff more weeks than not. They will feed you, and they will not let you name the spring as a clerk's list. They cannot stamp a Cutting-leave, the First Seat's paper for who may take living wood, and they cannot make the Tree speak. They can refuse a colour that did not happen, and they can tell a hundred people to walk.

Rithim — Maiethlir

Rithim *(RITH-im)* is Speaker of Maiethlir, the person who names the leaf-colour at Leaf-Fall so the town can treat it as a fact, while a clerk waits to copy that colour onto the roll. House **Nirsei** *(nir-SAY)* sits on the conservative side of the river, where a clerk still puts the house first, so a neighbour says

Rithim and a clerk says Nirsei, Rithim. The crown has not replaced them, and the Seat has not recalled them. In a small town the warden Speaks, which is the act of naming the colour aloud. Here the Speaker is a separate office, and Rithim holds it under pressure from the Reckoned Hands, the crown's tablet offices. The office is practice, not Kind. They Speak truly, and they treat the copy as a second, lesser seeing. Some summers they let the Speaking and the copy happen in the same breath. Some summers they do not.

What they want is **Valein** *(vah-LAYN)*, Kept and unmarked in the same household, to stay off the tablet. Kept is what a square calls a person the Tree hugged and did not give a colour, and unmarked is the roll's word for that. Valein is a partner, not a child, the person who brings Rithim a cup after a Speaking, and the house is Nirsei if a clerk is allowed the second name. The verso of last Eolthael's copy-slip, the back of the paper, already noted an unmarked person in the household. Rithim has not said the name into a hall. Until they Speak, the colour is weather, and after they Speak it is a civic fact. They cannot unsay a colour, and they cannot keep a clerk from writing *delay noted*. They can make the hymn happen first, and they can refuse to read a household aloud. On the same morning Laevila describes the other colour in the same square, which is a different refusal from the line Rithim keeps off the roll. They eat together after the Night Watch, the silent vigil the night before Turning-Week, and they do not agree what that meal means. The First Seat stays in the wood beside the city, and the nearness is the pressure. Rithim's office is the square's Speaking. If a pilgrim asks where the college is, they will point at the Motherwood, and they will not walk the pilgrim there.

Mataero — Orentel

Mataero *(mah-TAY-ro)* lets the inland loft of the White Note House, the deathless road-house on the quay that kept its beds when it became a desk. There are twelve beds, eight of them let and four standing open, and the north bed is one of those four. Three of the open beds are for Eolthael, the month that holds Turning-Week, and the north bed is not to let. Mataero files all of that as occupancy. They are of the rise behind the third quay, with no family to put first. A neighbour says Mataero. While a White Note paper is open the line may be headed White Note, Mataero, and it is the desk. Shut the paper and the quay says Mataero of the rise. They Turned on the rise, for free, in a city that still does that and does not like to notice. They did not walk the old mile. The job requires them to believe the house is a bank that happens to have rooms.

What they want is **Sorel**, their mother, clear of a century-note the house still holds, a hundred-year paper from a walk Sorel cannot point to. They think a clean loft-slate will buy that, and the cut of the occupancy money has not moved the paper. They are young for a house that does not age, with ink on the fingers and a key to the inland door rather than the quay-desk. They answer in occupancy even when you asked about a name. They cannot rewrite Ledan's count, and they cannot let the north bed. What they can do is lose a name in a slate that only says *let* or *open*, and if you press them they will tell you that empty is a bed they are not charging for. A household Vaethod sent may already owe a bed

here. **Reimaethe** pays a rise-room Mataero writes *let*. Ledan, who is Long-Lived and writes the quay-desk, will not explain house custom unless the week makes them. Sorim, the factor on the first quay, will not convert the White Note's house-years into anybody else's calendar, and Mataero hears a neighbour who cannot file beds.

Thilim — the Third Hearth

Thilim *(THIL-im)* keeps the Third Hearth, the third lodging out from the Motherwood on the Near Mile, and they are of the Held bed, a bed kept for a name that has not come. There is no house, and they will not borrow one. They are Long-Lived, deathless, and inland. The notes they write are smaller than the White Note's, and the shrine is larger. They have kept this house since before the First Cut, as later clerks would say. The First Cut is the hinge the wardens count from, the year living wood began to leave the one Tree. Thilim walked the mile as the inn, the same stretch every summer, until the stretch was optional, and they kept making the bed anyway. Lestrand, which prices a road-house by whether it became a bank, calls this a bed-house that failed to become one. Thilim asks who will be here at dark.

What they want is the stone's water still feeding the pot when it is dark. Seine of the far cape, due in a tenth summer, has not come. The mother said next year, and next year was last year, and has been. Seine's bed is still made, and it is not a shrine Thilim will admit. The stone by the road is the inn's water and the Road-hands' mile, so the name is also a well. Meirim *(may-REEM)*, Brenthael's town-warden, wants the stone moved so the extra mile does not look like a requirement on their approach. Thilim will not move a name that is also a well, and has not answered Meirim's chalk on paper. They can feed a necessity-family and a devotion-column in the same loft in the same week, and know which is which without saying. When they say *I walked*, a Long-Lived is saying when they were young, and the same sentence does work the people who say it do not agree on. They will not always tell you which of those they are doing when they pour. They wait to be asked across a threshold, even their own, if they have been out to the stone. It is courtesy, and they will not explain it. At dark they set the yard-broom across the doorway and step over it, and they will not say why. They cannot make Seine arrive, and they cannot make the White Note fail. A pilgrim who asks where the college is will be pointed at the wood, not the inn.

Laevila — Maiethlir

Laevila *(lay-VEE-lah)* bakes on the old extra-mile, the street where people still walk past what the local rite already gave them, and keeps the room under the chapel the wardens recut. Before that recut they copied the hidden face of the beam, the side turned away from the room, and the copy is the only one. The roll files a Watcher of that room as the Grown-Over, its name for people whose old place sits under a chapel that was built over it. House **Thalonve** *(tha-LON-ve)* is the clerk's name, so a neighbour says Laevila and a clerk says Thalonve, Laevila. They are Long-Lived, and they walked as a

child under Thaeloren before this river had to count them. A Watcher is the neighbour the Watching sends when a leaf comes down strange. They describe what they saw, and they do not confirm it, because confirmation is the Speaking. Laevila looks like the neighbour who stayed, flour on the cuff and no mark of any office, and you know them because someone said *ask the old room*, or because you saw them under the Tree the night before Turning-Week with no lamp.

What they want is **Senithi** *(seh-NITH-ee)*'s name good for a marriage. Senithi is their grandchild, Given a colour at the Leaf-Fall and of the same house, and a marriage is priced on a line that lists the wrong grandmother. The hidden face still has that grandmother under her own name. Laevila wants it read once, in a room a clerk will accept as a witness, not as theology but as a name a tablet will swallow. They will not Speak, and they will not say *Two-Bodied* if what they saw was two colours, though they will say the two colours. Rithim Speaks in the same square. They eat together after the Night Watch. Rithim will not say the line the clerk is waiting to copy, and Laevila will not say the Mother, the name a Watcher leaves out of the blessing. That is as close as peace gets on this street. The chapel wardens leave a plate during Turning-Week, and that plate is courtesy, not a wage. They cannot confirm a colour, and they cannot unsay the recut. They can sit beside the Speaker and say the second colour aloud, so it stays spoken in the square and the clerk cannot quietly drop it.

Tesara — Orentel

Tesara *(teh-SAH-rah)* sits the stillers' shed that does not face the street, the catching-year, which is the week a newly Struck person is kept somewhere quiet before the town reaches for a rope. A key is kept off the slate, so if the week goes well, nobody hears of it, and they will not stamp a ticket this week. A ticket is the licence that lets one of the Stilled use the gaze where the town can see it. There is no family to put first. A neighbour says Tesara, and a stranger gets Tesara of Orentel. Years back Tesara was Struck, a Condition met at a later threshold rather than at the childhood leaf, and what they carry is a Gaze, the stilling look, taken raw in a week somebody else sat. The paying floor does not write that down. Tesara remembers the door, and that memory is why they are the one the floor can spare. They think the work is first aid. You catch the person, you steady them, and you hand them on to the year the guild would actually train.

What they want is **Valen** stamped with a real ticket, not left on a slip that can be burned. Valen was stone on the third night, a Struck member of the Stilled, the kind who survived being turned to stone, stood for by a sister and by an N. who would not give a family name. The week is almost over, and the face of the ticket is still empty, because the slip is written on the inside of a blank and Tesara will not stamp the outside this week. A burned slip is how a quiet week disappears. The paying floor wants the master back, because a quiet catching-year is a week the theatre lost. They cannot overrule a quay-watch, and they cannot stamp a ticket this week. They can keep a master in the shed one more night, and they can fail to burn a slip. If Valen lives and still has no ticket, Mataero is who they will need,

because occupancy will not say *Struck*. Rosire used to bring water downwind of the shed, and is not on the floor this Hale-month. Tesara has not been told why.

Named wants in the three seats

Wants sit on people. An institution can furnish a bed, a pot, or a paper, or withhold them. The want stays with the person.

Eolvaeth. Vaethod wants Saelid's stall to keep its winter customers, because in a year when a cohort is sent away the camp-streets that buy the bread go empty. **Nedaen** *(neh-DAYN)*, one of the Taken-In, the people the wild took partway into itself and gave back, keeps the commons around the Tree and wants the gift-hall pot to feed their child through Ledger-month. Mother's green is enough until it is not. **Heiral** *(HAY-ral)* is Kept and lives on the camp-street. They want a marriage witnessed without being pitied as Mother-kept. They will take a neighbour's word, and they will not take a sermon. **Daron** *(DAR-on)* is Returned, a person who died with something unfinished and is still walking because of it, and they keep the far shed. They want a specific corpse named so a grain-debt dies with it. The family will not come downwind to do it.

Orentel. Mataero wants Sorel off the White Note's century-paper, and they think a clean loft-slate will buy that. **Sorim** wants berths 1–4 to stay held through Hale-month, the spring month when the land is counted sound. Their house-share is the hold-fee, the fee for keeping the berth, and not the wool. Tesara wants Valen stamped before the paying floor takes the master back. **Lasole** *(lah-SO-leh)* rents a leaf-lot on the rise and wants the credit extended one season. The lot will not follow them home, and home is a loft if it did. **Didel** *(dih-DEL)* of Hallowquay is Selkie, sea-born, one of the skin-kin, and works haulage. They want a kin-berth for a skin-kin wedding in Eolthael. Sorim has held berths 1–4 for a First-Hand year, a berth kept for the prestige walk to the origin, and Didel cannot hold those.

Maiethlir. Rithim wants Valein unfiled. The verso already knows how to write *unmarked*. Laevila wants Senithi's name read off the hidden face of a recut beam, once, in a room a clerk will accept as a witness. **Vehaela** *(veh-HAY-lah)* came down from Lirorn's thin snow with two children and wants an uncounted loft for one winter. The extra-mile street still has rooms the roll has not found. **Baerith** *(BAY-rith)* is Far-Voiced, a voice that carries exactly as far and as true as the singer means it to, and they sing the counted hour. They want the crown to stop cutting green on the street where their sister keeps a pot. To be cut off is framed as a lapse, and what it is, is a household going hungry.

The squares touch by paper, beds, pots, and one week in Eolthael, and the crossings are not a party. A household Vaethod sent last thin year sometimes eats now on a necessity-note from the White Note, a paper for a household in need. Mataero files the loft, and Vaethod does not know the house-year, the count that house keeps for itself. Sorim's berth 5 is earth. The pot, a young tree in the container it travels in, is going toward a luckier Hand. Haelin will sleep the Road-hand, the warden walking with

that wood, if the wood arrives. That is the live front, not a reunion. Rithim Speaks the colour, and Laevila describes the other colour in the same square, the same morning. They already share a street, and they do not say the same thing. Tesara's week, if it is not burned at the end of it, becomes a person who later needs a loft or a berth. Mataero will hear occupancy, and Sorim will hear a hold they cannot invent. Thilim still holds a far-cape name the White Note does not have. A court that wants a Cut-year set beside a house-year writes inland and to the quay. The two answers will not match, and the two desks do not travel to deliver them. Reimaethe lives in a rise-room Mataero lets, and has given four years of memory into the Pourers' cup. Hithaen arrived in the gift-hall with no list behind them. Vaethod can tell a person who came to wait from a clerk who came to write, and has not yet decided which this is. Rosire works a ticket-infirmary downwind of Tesara's shed when they are in Orentel. This Hale-month they are not there, and Tesara has not been told why.

Other people of note

These are not a second court. They are the people already doing the work in squares that needed one more pair of hands.

Person	Square	The job	The ordinary want
Njunda	Ndenjoo	table-keeper	Nolas gone as kin, extra place still laid
Ledan	the White Note House	quay-desk	founding-name spoken once
Theisva · Lesna · Bovaer	Ornsael	well-gang	a share that lasts Hale-month
Tora · Nethiro · Baelon	the three hamlets past the ford	three kitchens	send, or refuse, or not take the other road
Talen · Milsun · Thurrei	the Mill-hold	drain and slate	a mill that still turns; a week that still has room
Delvor · Vilraet · Brudu	the First Bowl	bowl, Speaking, old planting	sit before colour; a Struck housed; morning water
Meirim	Brenthael	neighbour-warden	the Third Hearth's stone down; room for the Mill-hold's week
Raetoth · Lithsur	Nelath	stone and scar	the mile stays in the square; the name goes back on the day
Lonteith	Raillath	the halt	the column drinks and does not stay
Relmun	Denlad	the post	a tide that is not a hold
Huval	Tunral	the night's kitchen	a true distance, and no invented colour
Nurreith	the Low Wall	one summer's shovel	the labour off the garden; the chip was the other quarry
Soonke · Saalo	Ndenjoo sand and valley	sit, or leave	wreck off the hill; Waandi found
Thuda	the Low Wall garden-end	innkeep	labour off the garden

Theisva *(THAYS-vah)* keeps Ornsael's share, Lesna *(LES-nah)* the planting, and Bovaer *(bo-VAIR)* the west road, and the share is the want that has to last Hale-month. Tora *(TOR-ah)* of Brenod sends the child and walks the witness home. Nethiro *(neth-EE-ro)* of Vaelun may refuse the neighbour's week.

Baelon *(BAY-lon)* of Ornath has looked at the other road and has not taken it. Lonteith *(LON-tayth)* keeps the halt at Raillath, a day's post on the Near Mile between Brenthael and the Mill-hold, fills a cup for a column that is passing, and will not chalk a bed, because hosting the week would make the halt a second Brenthael. Relmun *(REL-mun)* keeps the cove post at Denlad, a day's sail short of Orentel, says a name aloud because chalk will not stick to the wet post, and will not call a hull that tied up in a blow a hold. Huval *(HOO-val)* feeds the night at Tunral, on the road toward Harrow's and not under a canopy, will not invent a colour for a child who is ten, and at dusk sets a bowl outside on the side away from Harrow's. The bowl is not a first meal, and it is not a shrine, and Huval will not say why.

Haelin *(HAY-lin)* keeps Harrow's Green, the live front this cast points at, and wants the stone moved before Leaf-Fall so the crowd can stand, with the water still on it until then. They name a colour only when they are sure of it. Last Eolthael something white happened at that canopy, and Haelin did not Speak it. Tora is on the square when the stone is to be moved, because the next column still drinks there, and because a colour that was never named aloud cannot be walked home as a witnessing.

Maiethorn's seats. These are people at Maiethorn's seats, each with an ordinary want. A neighbour says the given name, and at Rothallo a clerk says the house first. A Given pilgrim is a person who received the becoming at the childhood Turning, and is on the road as that person. Tasain's levy is the toll Narol's household still collects, and Narol of the Pass is dead.

Person	Square	The job	The ordinary want
Vuthbraen	Seinbrun	the furnished hall	the pot still open to a house that left the hymn
Breillai	Seinbrun	outside the hymn	a green and a bed without the net
Raermu	Seinbrun	the medicine basket	a stiller's hour for a Kept child
Brimaen	Rothallo	a stall inside the walls	the key through Turning-Week. House Lanbru.
Breolnir	Rothallo	the sleep-line at the gate	a Given pilgrim written as sleep. House Tethnae.
Methei	Rothallo	a turn of work on the outer beds	the turn ends at dark and is not set again. House Sithlaen.
Brormei	Larbril	the meeting of road and wash	the west road still a road when the wash is silt
Tumair	Votaer	the hull's docket	one class for a hull that is also a pilgrim
Lertho	Votaer	the Hush-rate	the rate taken as a rate

Delamem and Talnin stay with the Walled Book, and Hithaen is another Given heir, already in Eolvaeth.

Strandoren's seats. These are people at Strandoren's seats, each with an ordinary want. A neighbour says the given name, and at Lunbra a clerk says the house first. Orentel was already seated above, Denlad stays Relmun, and the White Note stays Ledan.

Person	Square	The job	The ordinary want
Turvo	Raitin	the shared notes	a cleared note the next hearth will still stand
Nubo	Raitin	the gap between hearths	a vouching that holds past the hall
Sulnu	Raitin	the ticket to the river stair	a ticket that still means something at the water
Derdil	Naenor	the signing-watch	a term that closes without making a gift a debt
Vamar	Lunbra	a column of the roll	the row under the house that was said. House Melro. Not the crown.
Mursur	Braetu	the far quote, and a lamp	the dark berth left without a house

Heskoren's seat. There is one person in this table, because Sanbreo has no new person and Vaelhesk has no new person, and the land stays the seat. A neighbour says the given name.

Person	Square	The job	The ordinary want
Dumu	Natai	the march-voice	a shout that lands at that gate, and not on Haelin's square

Ledan *(LED-an)* still writes the White Note quay-desk. They are Long-Lived, and the Cut-year 280 conversion-query, the question of how to turn one count of years into another, is theirs. They will convert a house-year, or a Cut-year, or a court's third date, if you say which. They will not invent a berth, and they will not invent a hull. What they want is the founding-name on the north bed spoken once, aloud, so they can stop being the only memory of it, and they will not speak it first. The six pivots stay Vaethod, Rithim, Mataero, Thilim, Laevila, and Tesara. Ledan is the desk a session can sit at when the paper has to be in the room, and not a seventh pivot.

Four people a campaign can start from. They are four separate people, not a crew, and they do not travel as one.

Reimaethe *(RYE-may-theh)* is Long-Lived on the rise in Orentel, of the rise and of no house. Every Long-Lived person is asked once to join the Pourers, the circle that sets a year of memory into a cup, and Reimaethe said yes. A member gives one year at a time, each on its own night, with a drop of blood as the record, because a Long-Lived already reads memory in blood. The year goes into the cup and is gone from the member's memory, the papers from that year go onto the shelf, and the circle counts the member one year younger. The circle says the cup holds a god it made, and the Unspent is the presence in it, a small household presence that stores what it is given and does not make plans. The circle asks five years in all. Reimaethe has given four, and a member may stop before any year, while the years already given stay in the cup. They want to stop before the fifth, and they want their papers back, thin as that copy is, because the papers are all the circle returns. They want Mataero to keep writing *let* and not *why*. Neighbours call the practice a rich uncle's hobby, and they do not look like a hobby. A second cup sits next to the first. They have not asked to drink from it, because asking would already cost them something with the circle.

Hithaen *(hith-AYN)* arrived in Eolvaeth's gift-hall this Hale-month with no list behind them and a name they will not put on a wall. They are Given, and somewhere behind the walls that are still standing, families that have stayed Kept for generations are still a class, and a child Given at Leaf-Fall can fall out of that line, which is what happened to Hithaen. The house is **Brethlumal** *(breth-LU-mal)*. The line cast them out and kept the name on them. They will not say it, and they will not take *of Eolvaeth*. They want a life that is not a wall-pass, a life of being let through the wall, and on worse nights they want the name back, which is not the same want. They are not Talnin, and they are not Methei. Vaethod has not decided whether Hithaen came to wait or to be counted. What is left of the arrangement they walked out of is the Walled Book, the Inner Close inside Orenbren, political rank and not a church. This is one person eating alms in a vale that has no list, which is why they walked here.

Taeren *(TAY-ren)* is of Brenod, not of Harrow's and not of a capital, and there is no house to put first. They are a hush, the filing word for a white-fire the clerks will not let become a civic fact, and a child who stood at the neighbour's canopy when something white happened. The wider world knows there should be a Phoenix, the one person the stories are about, and it has not seen one in a generation, while doctrine says there cannot be two. If a white-fire is Spoken while a sanctuary still holds the Phoenix, the clerks file it as a mis-Speaking or as a hush. Last Eolthael Taeren stood at Harrow's Green. Something white happened, and Haelin did not Speak it. A colour that was never named aloud cannot be walked home as a witnessing, so Taeren is still in the square when the Hale-month crowds arrive, with the tenth year just behind them and heat in the hands they do not show. They ask ordinary questions, about bread and about whether the week is over and about why an old hymn uses a name they do not own, and they do not know why a fire answers them when someone says an old name. The public sentence about a Phoenix is still that there is one, and this chapter does not change it.

Rosire *(ro-SEER-eh)* is of Orentel, with no house, and this Hale-month they are sleeping in an upper room at Harrow's Green. They once held a post in a house they do not name. They opened a door they were not scheduled to open, and someone walked out through it. Rosire walked the other way, took the ticket-yard work of bringing water at Tesara's shed, and does not use the byname from before that floor. They are not on Tesara's water this week. They walked inland with the person who walked out. They want that person, and any child a fire might answer, not to become a story, and they want themselves not sent for. They look infirmary-tired, with grey under the nails from other people's stone, and travel stays out of their talk.

A neighbour still gets the given name. Raetoth, Lithsur, Lonteith, Relmun, Huval, and Nurreith are given names the places already use, and a stranger hears *of Nelath*, *of Raillath*, *of Denlad*, *of Tunral*, or *of the garden-end*. None of them has a house. Maiethlir writes a house before the given name: Laevila and Senithi are Thalonve, Rithim is Nirsei, Valein is that same house left unwritten, and Baerith is Rairtei. Vehaela is of Lirorn, and has not taken a house. Eolvaeth asks *of where?* Vaethod, Saelid, Heiral, Nedaen, and Daron are of the town, or of the street they already stand on. Hithaen will not take *of Eolvaeth*. Orentel asks *of where?* as well. The quay does not file a family. The White Note is a house only while the paper is open, and then it is the desk. Valen is of Orentel, and Didel is of Hallowquay. Thilim is of the Held bed, Taeren is of Brenod, and Njunda is the given name, which is the whole of the name.

The six pivots stay the six. Reimaethe, Hithaen, Taeren, and Rosire stay four separate people.

Book IX

At the Table

Playing in the Turning

Follow this page, in this order, when you make a character and when you start play. The stories and the laws live in their own chapters. This page is the sequence at the table, so it tells you what to do and where the fuller ruling sits, and it does not become a second copy of those chapters.

Tone. The people of this world are neighbours and colleagues, and most of what a session spends its time on is ordinary life, with a real danger underneath it. A Tithe, the upkeep a Condition card asks of the person who carries it, never takes the player character over. Keep the frightening part rare.

Making a character

You run this once, in this order, and you do not invent a second way to build a character beside it.

1. **Kind.** Choose what the character was born, which this book calls an ancestry. That can be a stock ancestry from Daggerheart, one of the four written for this world (Kitsune, Selkie, Tengu, or Yumboe), or a Mixed Ancestry in the way the System Reference Document already allows. The rulings sit in *The Kinds*. A stock ancestry grants two features, and each of those four grants three, so a character whose two features both come from stock ancestries, whether that is one stock Kind or a mix of two, takes a **Hearth-Mark** to make up the difference. Name the place that raised you, a town or a quay or a road, written as a place and not as a Kind. Once per session, when you make an action roll or a reaction roll that leans on how that place taught you to live, you add +2, and you do not spend Hope to add it. A character who takes any feature from the four ancestries written for this world takes no Hearth-Mark, because that third feature is already the hearth. A Yumboe needs the GM's leave, and the character is the full Kind, all three features, never a mix and never a Hearth-Mark.
2. **Community.** Take a Community the way the SRD has it, the card for the sort of place that raised the character. A Hearth-Mark names a place. It does not fill the Community line, and it is not a second Community.
3. **Class, Experiences, equipment.** Take class, equipment, and Experiences as the SRD has them. Write two Experiences, the phrases on the sheet that say what the character has lived. A Kept character has those same two and no third, and the tradeoff for that empty card is written below.
4. **Turning.** Pick one, and write it on the sheet. The Leaf-Fall is the week a child stands under the town's Turning Tree in their tenth year, and what the Tree did then, or did not do, is the Turning.

How many people are Given, Struck, and Kept is in *The Conditions*.

- **Given** means a coloured leaf fell on you when you were ten, and you take one Given-path or Both-path card from *The Conditions*.
- **Kept** means the leaves closed around you in a hug and no colour fell, so you take no Condition card. What that empty card is worth is below.
- **Struck** means a later threshold, one the roster already names, already happened in the backstory. You died and came back, you swore a contract, you survived a drowning, you survived being turned to stone, or you were lost and dying in the deep wild and the wild took you in. You take a Struck-path or Both-path card. Someone the town will believe stood up and said what you had become, and you say who.
- **UnTurned** means you never stood under a Turning Tree, so there was no hug and no colour, and you are not Kept. Neighbours may call you Kept. The law and your sheet say UnTurned. You can still be Struck later.

5. **Choices for the whole table.** Some characters are a conversation the whole table has, not a private pick.
   - **Phoenix** is a spotlight Condition, a campaign that will keep arriving at that fire. If anyone at the table does not want that, pick another card, or the GM runs the Phoenix as a person in the world and the player characters are someone else.
   - **Hidden Phoenix** uses the same consent, because the fire still keeps arriving. There is still one Gift, the single living Phoenix, and the shape of a Phoenix who is not the public legend is worked out between that player and the GM.
   - **Yumboe** needs the GM’s leave, and the character is the full Kind only.
   - **the Unbound** is not a starting pick. A Bound character, someone who swore a contract and is still keeping the terms, becomes Unbound when the term ends, in play, or because the table agrees at the start that the term already ended.

Kind and Condition stay two things on one character, so the ancestry you were born and the Condition you carry are both on the sheet. A Selkie can be Given Two-Bodied. A stock Human can be Struck Returned. A character of mixed heritage is Given, Kept, or Struck the same way anyone else is.

They stay two things when the stories sound alike. An **Infernis**, a stock ancestry whose features are already on the sheet from birth, who swears a contract is Bound the way anyone else who swears one would be. The blood they were born with stays Kind, and the contract is the Condition. The two do not merge, they do not cancel, and the character does not become Given-Over by default. Given-Over is the world’s name for a Bound person who signs contract after contract, and it is a title rather than a Condition this page hands out.

The Kept deal

The Kept are a deliberate tradeoff, and they are not a consolation Condition invented to make up for a missing card. They have no boon and no Tithe, so the card is empty and there is no clock on it to tick. A Condition card asks other characters to mark a Tithe clock, and the mark usually comes at a long rest. The Kept clock is empty on purpose, and that emptiness is the tradeoff.

What they have is a legal standing and a free rest. The law treats them as the ordinary person: the hug was witnessed, they owe no guild, and they hold no Condition licence. At every long rest they take their downtime with no Tithe checklist, while everyone who carries a Condition may be marking a clock. That free evening is the advantage at the table. They can still be Struck later. Kept is the life they have now, and it is not a promise that the life will stay empty.

They do not receive a tenth Condition, a bonus Experience, a Hearth-Mark they did not already qualify for, or a Kept ability of their own. An ability that is really a Tithe belongs on a Condition card. If a table later wants a house rule, that house rule is theirs, and this page does not give one.

An UnTurned life looks similar from the outside, because there is no Tithe and no guild. The difference is that a Kept person’s hug was witnessed, and an UnTurned person never stood. Do not file an UnTurned neighbour as Kept just to be kind, and do not write an UnTurned character as Kept on the sheet.

Struck in play

A Kept or UnTurned character can be Struck when the story crosses a threshold this book already names. Dying, with something left undone, can make them Returned. Swearing a contract can make them Bound. Surviving a drowning, breath and voice both stopped and both come back changed, can make them Far-Voiced. Surviving being turned to stone, held rigid and then returned to flesh, can make them one of the Stilled. Being lost and dying in the deep wild, until the wild takes them in rather than let them die, can make them one of the Taken-In. Long-Lived, Two-Bodied, the Answered, and Phoenix are Given only, so no later door can Strike them into being.

The player agrees to take the card. The GM does not hand out a becoming to punish a failed roll. A Tithe never takes the character over, and becoming is not a moment where the player loses the character.

When the player takes the card, add the Condition, and the Kind stays what it was. Someone stands for them again at the next desk that will take them, which means someone says what they became so the town can know. A hazardous becoming goes to the Intake, the quiet week a town keeps for a person just Struck. Mark them Struck. They were not Given, so there is no leaf and no second Leaf-Fall. They do not take a second Condition, because the Tree does not put one becoming on top of another, and a later door does not either.

A Bound character whose term ends becomes the Unbound, as that card says. No other Condition turns into a further Condition.

Advancement

A Condition card does not level, so the card you took at level 1 is the same card at level 10, while class features, domain cards, Experiences, weapon tier, Proficiency, and Hope scars change around it. Hope scars are the marks that cross a Hope slot off the sheet. A few things look like the card is growing, and they are not a new level of the Condition. A Two-Bodied character can gain an Experience, a Bound term can move, and a Returned or a Phoenix counts down Hope slots, while attacks the card already grants can roll more Proficiency dice as that Proficiency rises. The card underneath those changes is the card you started with. The full ruling is in *The Conditions*.

A domain card is a job someone in a town is already paid to do, and you use it as the SRD printed it, without a second roll on top of the card. A Condition clock ticks only from its own card. A Spoken colour, the sentence a warden says at the Leaf-Fall, is not a spell, and Hope does not buy a colour. If a scene has a thing that keeps working with no person in it, name the maker and name the problem that thing is still causing, and do not give it a Kind, a Condition, or a domain.

Travel

You move on someone’s word. A paper that names what you are does not replace the answer. When a watch stops a stranger, they ask your name, your last hearth, and who stands for you, and two of the three will do. If you can give them none, you sit until morning, or they walk you to the next gate.

The customs that count as that word are a road-word, a named person who will stand for you; a company’s vouch, the party standing for one another; a guild-mark, a craft mark that travels; a house-note, paper from a house that will answer for you; guest-right, a host who took you in; and the custom of a walk, the word the road itself gives someone who is on a named walk. Distances are in *Climate, Ecology, and Travel*. Kumbaan, the Sundering Isle, does not use this road-word. The crossing is in *Other Places*, under Ndenjoo, and in *The Four Continents*. People do sell a vouch. That sale is a separate trade, and it does not answer this watch.

City witnessing

A village remembers the child who stood. A city is too large for that memory, so it remembers a **hearth**, and the legal sentence is “I am of the third quay,” rather than “I am of Orentel.”

Turning-Week is still **one week** in a city. People stand by hearth, in named slots. The warden says the colour or the hug aloud, and they do not write a list of gifts. Threnmaieth writes the stand down, and that writing is the exception, because the other towns leave it spoken.

Crime

There is no crime of *being* a Condition. The Inviolate Will, the doctrine that a Condition cannot seize another person's will, already sorts the charge into a Tithe that lapsed through neglect, or a power used on purpose as a weapon.

The charge walks up a ladder from a neighbour's word, to the watch, who hold the person until morning, then to a guild hearing, and then to an open hearing. Exile from the hearth is the penalty the town treats as civic death, the end of belonging to that place. A ticket names a hazardous use, the Gaze, the Cry, or an element let loose in a yard, and it does not name the Condition. A Bound hearing sits at a table and covers the Terms of the contract. The three licences on the body stay the Stilled, the Far-Voiced, and the Answered. Bound is not a fourth.

Leaf-Fall edge cases

When you cannot open *The Turning Tree*, hold to this. The door that Gives a Condition is open for **one week** in the tenth year, and a completed standing, whether a colour fell or the leaves hugged, under sound wood, happens **once**. A miss, a refusal, or a week spent under unsound wood makes the child **unTurned**, and it does not make them Kept. Struck remains the mercy that can still come later. You may correct a Speaking, the warden's sentence about what the leaf did, and you may not rerun the fall itself. White-fire, the leaf that would name a Phoenix, is sent to the First Seat, and a town-warden does not guess that reading.

Starting situations

Start in one of these places, and stay with the one job the old walk left on that street. After a town has its own Tree, that job is one of three. **Devotion** is people keeping a walk they no longer need, either as an extra mile or as a wait at a Tree that may not speak. **Prestige** is a household paying for a winter, or a berth, for a walk they do not need. **Necessity** is a local Tree that is missing, young, or sick, or a week that cannot hold everyone who comes, so people use a neighbour's standing, water, or bed. Give the place one of those jobs. A guest may bring a second into the same week, and the second is not the place's theme.

Eolvaeth. People come here to wait, and the wait is the job. Vaethod, the town-warden, will not invent a colour. Saelid's stall keeps feeding its winter guests, and those guests are the same households a sent cohort takes away. A stranger in the gift-hall has no list to stand on. Some years the wood says send the children on, toward a luckier Hand, and the gospel in the vale says stay. In a year when the Tree does not speak, a wet leaf lies on the spring, pilgrims from the core ask if it is a ribbon, and Eolvaeth will not say.

Orentel. The quay sells a winter to households who can pay for a walk they do not need, and that sale is the job. A First-Hand year, the prestige season at the origin, is assembled at three desks: a Night-Shore hull chartered at Braetu, the city on the shore that sells the ship, a term from the White Note, and a hold at Orentel, where Sorim keeps berths 1–4 empty because they are held. Orenbren houses the sleep once the year reaches the grove, and does not sell the year. Tesara works the stillers' shed, and the shed does not face the street. Two streets off the third quay, a person too poor to meet a Tithe fades while the city steps around them. Salt sits on the Tree's roots in Eolthael, the month that holds Turning-Week. People say it is the tide, the tide does not reach the rise, and Orentel will not say why the salt is there.

Maiethlir. Start the week before Leaf-Fall, when the thaw is loud. Clerks file that rise as snowmelt, the watchers do not, and Maiethlir will not say why. Rithim, the Speaker, will not give the clerk the line, and will Speak over the water. The wardens have recut a chapel, and a Watching room is under it, where Laevila keeps the only copy of the beam's hidden face. The crown keeps a counted channel for a Far-Voiced hour and for the city's green, and that channel can be shut. The extra mile is still walked here. The roll writes on top of that walk, and the walk remains.

Harrow's Green. Start in Hale-month, the spring month when the land is counted sound. The year is Cut-year 387, the 387th summer counted from the First Cut. The job is a neighbour's week that can still be walked home. Haelin wants the stone moved so the crowd can stand, and the water is still on it, because the stone is the day's drink for anyone using the road as a mile. The upper room has extra guests. Children here Turn under this Tree. The hamlets can see the canopy and are still sending theirs. The cistern-dipper is hung with the bowl toward the stream, and Harrow's Green will not say why.

Ornsael. The well is dropping, and the job is water. Theisva keeps the share, chalked on the lip, Lesna keeps the planting, and Bovaer still sends people west when the drink will not stretch through Hale-month. Pilgrims from the core arrive expecting a holiday walk and find a necessity-column already on the road. The well-rope is knotted at last year's water-line, and this year's knot is wet even when the water stands below it. Ornsael will not say why.

the Three Hamlets. Play the same week as Harrow's Green. In clear weather the canopy is a dark on the far slope, and in rain it is a rumour. Brenod sends the child, Vaelun may refuse the walk because the children are already the land's, and Ornath has looked at the other road, toward a slate and away from a Tree, without taking it. The job is the neighbour's week. The night before, someone leaves a cup on the ford-rock. If it fills, they send, and if it does not, the tellings do not agree, while the child still goes, or does not, according to the kitchen and not according to the cup.

the Third Hearth. Thilim has made Seine's bed and left it made. The extra mile is optional, and the house still keeps the bed. That is the job. Meirim, Brenthael's warden, wants the stone taken down so the extra mile does not look like a requirement on the town's approach. Seine's name is on the lintel.

The pot needs the stone's water at dark, and the stone at the road is the day's water. At dark, Thilim sets the yard-broom across the doorway and steps over it, and they will not say why.

Ndenjoo. Play the hall's hospitality, and play the storm-wall as the weather. A wreck has walked uphill with the extra place already set, and a guest is loud at noon, when the hall sleeps. There is no Tree, so you seat the wreck, keep the kin who will not leave, and let someone want a crossing out. The session is the hall, and it is not spent proving what the Trees are.

Tone at the table

Play neighbours, colleagues, and family. The Tithe is where the danger sits, and Leaf-Fall is a warm week, so keep dread out of the Tree. When you need one moment of wrongness, use the weather, a host still keeping a guest from a week that ended, a week that already closed, or a person who missed the standing.

The Conditions are already the people in the world. There is no second vampire, no cursed wolf-kin, and no hungry dead who is not a Returned. The cart-ox, the terrace goat, and the path dog are livelihoods people keep, and they are not adversaries you drop into a fight.

Sample frames

Use one of these for a run of sessions. In each mainland frame, some people Turn under the Tree in town, and this year someone is still walking because living wood has not reached every hearth. Play both as the present. The Years of Hands are underway, which are the years a town Tree is the ordinary way to Turn.

A town where the planting is still arriving. Harrow's Green, or the hamlets looking at its canopy, where the job on the street is a neighbour's week. A pot of living wood may arrive, and it may not. Someone here is still sending this year's children, while someone who thinks the planting is finished lives two weeks away and cannot see this canopy.

A quay that sells a winter. Orentel. A household that wants the prestige of a First-Hand year goes to three desks, a Night-Shore hull, a term from the White Note, and a hold at Orentel, and one desk does not finish the winter. Necessity still sleeps in the loft. Ledan, at the White Note desk, will convert a house-year, the house's own count of summers, or a Cut-year, the wardens' count from the First Cut, or a third date a court invented, if you say which. They will not invent the count for you.

An origin town with a roll. Maiethlir. The extra mile is still walked, and the clerks write on top of it. Rithim will not copy the clerk's line. A Watcher will describe what they saw, and will not confirm it. The First Seat is in the wood beside the city, and can refuse what the city asks.

The hall on the isle. Ndenjoo, where hospitality is the rite, an extra place and a second night and a guest who can sleep the day, and the storm-wall is the weather. Play kin and a wreck. The session is not spent proving what the Trees are.

The first campaign has its own opening, in the GM's chapter. It is not one of the starts above.

Dangers on the road

Settlements already have the things that can enter one of their scenes, a cohort, a crane, a well-mouth, so use this section for the country between those towns, the Long Mile, the wild of Heskoren, and the named waters. What threatens a traveler out here is people who missed their week, the animals on the road, and the weather, which is a real obstacle under ordinary travel.

Start battle points from the SRD: `[(3 × PCs) + 2]`. Spend: Minion group 1 · Support/Social 1 · Horde/Ranged/Skulk/Standard 2 · Leader 3 · Bruiser 4 · Solo 5. Benchmarks: Tier 1 Difficulty 11, thresholds 7/12, ATK +1; Tier 2 Difficulty 14, 10/20, ATK +2.

Name	Tier / type	Where it lives	What it wants
Gap-Cat	T1 Skulk	Rain-Wall shelves, Heskoren ridge, mile-gaps	A quiet kill, and then the high rock back
Chart-Crew	T1 Horde	Chart-run, Night Shore, West Water wrecks	The hull that did not arrive, or yours if that one is gone
Bed-Keeper	T1 Leader	Empty road-houses on the Long Mile	The bed occupied, and you staying in it
Spent-Week Walker	T2 Standard	Long Mile, west-road, live-front tracks	To finish a tenth-year week that has already closed
Colourless Host	T2 Support	Dead pots, unsound grafts, waiting ground	To Give a Condition the way a Tree would, which it cannot do

None of these stat blocks are Conditions. A walker may carry a Condition the way any person might, and the card they carry is not this block. The Spent-Week Walker and the Colourless Host are Tier 2 blocks, so in a Tier 1 scene you use the Tier 1 Difficulty, thresholds, and attack bonus from the benchmarks above in place of theirs.

You use one of these places as the scene, and you put a single adversary into it. An impulse is what the place does when you spend Fear, or when someone fails a roll to travel.

Mile-gap (T1 Traversal, Difficulty 12). This is the day's walk between two mile-stones, and the next shrine depends on the weather rather than on a promise that the stone will be there. The place will stretch the day, hide the next stone, offer a false bed, or make a Tithe expensive. A Taken-In who cannot touch living green, or a Long-Lived with nothing new, feels the gap, but their next long rest runs the card's check as usual and the gap adds no extra tick. Travel rolls to find the next shrine are Difficulty 12. Failure with Fear ends the day in the gap.

Thaw-gate (T1 Traversal, Difficulty 13). This is a shelf-gate or the Noon Pass in a thaw-week, when last year's snow is the road you are walking this year. Crossing without a guide is Difficulty 13. On a failure, someone is swept, or a cart is lost, and one roll does not do both. Anyone who lived the Thaw-Break, in Cut-year 233, has Advantage on the next travel roll here if they say what they remember. Anyone who did not has to trust someone who did.

Empty road-house (T1 Exploration, Difficulty 11). This is a road-house the walking years left on the mile, a brenhael *(BREN-hael)*, and it kept the upper room after the walk ended, with someone still making the bed. Guest-right is a week. If you eat, a host stands for the stay, and leaving before morning without a word is a slight the next shrine will hear.

Night-berth (T1 Exploration, Difficulty 12). This is a Chart-run or West Water quay at first dark, where a hull that does not arrive is counted as local weather. The place wants to wait, to take what the sea gives up, and to sell a stand, and it does not want to file a hill.

Pair a place with one danger. On the Long Mile inland, use a mile-gap and a Gap-Cat, and add a Spent-Week Walker if the table wants more. On the Long Mile where a house still keeps a bed from a week that ended, use an empty road-house and a Bed-Keeper. On the Rain-Wall, use a thaw-gate, and let the weather be enough. On the Chart-run or at Netstrand, use a night-berth and a Chart-Crew. At a dead pot on the live front, use one Colourless Host as Support, with walkers or a Gap-Cat, and never a second Host, because what a Host does is make the place worse. Near a town on the Near Mile, use what that town already sends into a scene. The storm-wall belongs with the isle, in *Other Places*, and it is not one of these road dangers.

Use a Colourless Host when a planting has gone wrong, or a pot never took. Skeptics and believers can both be loud about what that means, and the argument stays open.

Book X

For the GM

GM Canon

Read the player-facing chapters first if you want to meet the world the way a player would. The table does not start the campaign already knowing this chapter.

What follows is what is actually true, whether or not anyone alive can prove it. The central fact is the **keystone**: the Leaf-Mother is real and kind, her reach has a limit, and every gift costs her something to give. Skeptics who say there is no mind behind the Trees are sincere, and they are wrong about that mind. If a campaign ever confirms her, the moment should land as warmth, with an ache under it, because a mother who saves whom she can reach, and grieves the rest, is the one this world has.

A **Tithe** is the upkeep a person has to meet to live well with a Condition, the becoming that sits on top of the ancestry they were born with. The frightening edge of a Tithe is pressure in the story. It is never a trick you spring, and it never takes the player's character out of the player's hands. Consequences land on that person's own body, memory, Stress, or the ground immediately around them, unless a feature on the card says otherwise. Nobody's will is bent. Keep the frightening edge at about five percent, small enough that the day stays neighbours and work and the obstacle underneath stays real.

GM only: Conditions

The cards do not level. If a Condition is ever going to advance, that has to be a new decision, and you do not quietly write levels onto a card. There is one Phoenix Gift in the world. How a house can catch the fire, and what a hidden Phoenix player still gets to choose, is under **Secrets and reveals** later in this chapter. The population shares, including the warning not to count the Unbound twice, already sit in Kind and Condition. Do not keep a second census here.

Long-Lived. Going still is how a Long-Lived dies, which is what happens when the memories are gone, and that death is not a death move you drop into a fight. Across several long rests the player can see it coming: Stress, then a Hit Point, then the stillness. Use that as story pressure, a deathless archivist found statue-still in a sealed room, and do not use it as a sudden kill or as a spiral of Hit Points that will not clear. The fade before the stillness is a mind thinning. It is not a curse lying on every roll the character makes.

Blood-Read is how you investigate and how you let a scene feel something, because one drop, freely given or taken from a wound that is already open, shows a true memory you narrate, such as a dead

man’s last sight or the reason a witness is lying. That drop is not feeding, not damage, and not a drain, and you do not spend it as a weapon in a fight. The threshold courtesy is the texture of a household. A Long-Lived can cross a threshold uninvited if they truly must, and they simply never do, because the manners run that deep. A foe who tries to put either habit on the sheet and call it a vampire rule has left the Condition.

Two-Bodied. The forced shift, which is the Tithe, is about timing and inconvenience. It nudges the player to live in both bodies, and it does not take the choice of action away. The other self is a partner in the roleplay, not a second player at the table. It can want, argue, sulk, and celebrate. The wolf pushes to give chase, and the cat refuses the cold water. It never rolls, never acts, and never overrides a choice the player made. If a table reaches “the animal made me do it,” pull the game back to nagging and let the player decide. Encourage the player to give the animal a name and a voice that is not their own. That name is the cheapest richness this Condition has.

This is the commonest Condition, about eighteen percent of people, so the free shift and the natural weapon are meant to be worth using in a scene. A hawk really flies, and an otter really swims, and you do not clip what the animal naturally does. What you do hold is the size, the ban on mythic beasts, and the fact that the animal body has no hands, no person’s mind, no speech, and no tools. A Two-Bodied can be a better animal than a Tengu, who is a person in the air, or one of the Answered, who use tools in the water, and cannot be a better person than either of them. One signature capability is the start, and a second comes only by a milestone in the story, so a veteran does not stack scout, tracker, and bruiser into one body. The natural weapon belongs to the animal body. It does not stack with a weapon the person-body is holding, because they are one body or the other, and its die does not rise when the character levels. Proficiency does.

Returned. Refuse to Fall means hard to keep down, which is a finite road and not immortality, because every use costs a scar, a Hope slot, the same mark any character spends when they brush death, and the table can watch the count fall. They leave the current scene and pull themselves together by the next long rest. When the last Hope slot would go, they cannot come back, and that is the true death, so a Returned near the end of their scars still feels a death move. Do not offer Avoid Death as an extra courtesy, because they already died, and the safe unconsciousness is what they spent when they did. A Purpose left to lapse, the unfinished work they came back to finish, is a quiet crisis, not a punishment you assign.

The hand that Strikes them has a name on this side of the screen. It is the Quiet Tally, *Threnvaeth*, the clerk of the Leaf-Mother’s household who keeps the unfinished work of the dead, and she acts under the Leaf-Mother’s allowance. The Leaf-Mother does not Give this Condition at the Tree. Threnvaeth authorizes the catch when the death comes with work still unfinished, and she does not steer that work. The Purpose stays the Returned person’s own. Player text does not name Threnvaeth.

Bound. Keep the Whisper strictly suggestive, plausible lies and intrusive thoughts which the player can reject by spending a Stress, and never puppet the character. The Pledge, the part of themselves they named to give when the contract ends, is a known and dreaded horizon toward the Unbound, whom people call the Hollow. It is not a surprise you save for the last session of the term.

The Counterparty who answers a sworn ask is **Orledd**, a Hand of the Leaf-Mother's household. The face chosen at creation, whether demon, cosmic horror, or unknown, is a mask Orledd wears, and the terms underneath have the same shape whatever the face. Do not play Orledd as a devil, and do not let this turn a Given Condition into a bargain. During the term, what Orledd receives is the named ask remaining true, and the Terms being kept where other people can see them. At the end of a term-limited contract they collect the Pledge, which is already on the card. They do not take a soul, worship, or a second signing. The Given-Over, a Bound who signs again and again until the other side effectively holds them, is that person's fear of paying, not Orledd's hunger. A flood of unread bargains starves a Counterparty. How allowance strains and breaks is under **The Other Hands**.

Do not add the Hollow as a second percentage on top of Bound's about five percent. The Unbound, about one and a half percent of people, are already inside that contract-lane. About three and a half percent are currently Bound. Listing both as parallel shares double-counts them.

The Unbound. The Quiet tempts. It does not compel. Every time the emptiness reaches for a bargain, they can refuse, and the refusal costs a Stress. The tragedy to play toward is an Unbound who stops connecting. The quiet inside gets loud, they sign again to mute it, they pay another Pledge, and they slide toward the Given-Over. Warmth, another person who knows their name and stays, is the only thing that actually fills the hole. A new contract only mutes it.

Keep three lanes apart when a table starts to blur them. Absence stops Stress, or Fear, that comes through the pledged hole, and it is not an immunity to every roll in the same broad lane. Quiet spends a token so the character can act anyway. The unshaken clause on the Returned is corpses, gore, and deathly places, and only the Returned have it. If a table is automatically passing every fear roll on both cards, pull the ruling back to those lines.

Far-Voiced. The Cry is a feeling that lands on listeners and costs them Stress, and it never forces an action or a belief. A Struck Far-Voiced arrives with the voice raw, so their first Cry, before any guild has had them, is a formative beat of how they became this, and you do not assign it as a punishment. A Given Far-Voiced deep in Tithe-debt, at no tokens, on duty in a courtroom or a relay tower, is a set-piece you build toward. It is not a surprise you spring.

The Stilled. The Gaze against an unwilling target is an attack, Instinct or Presence. A willing creature, or a creature that is down, needs no roll. A miss still adds a Grey token, the stillness already spent off the Stilled and onto the card, because the stillness has left them whether or not it landed. **Stilled** is a special condition, not the ordinary Restrained condition. Restrained only stops movement. Stilled stops the creature from acting. They can still speak, be moved, and be targeted, and they may mark a Stress

to clear it when they would act. Do not apply both conditions unless some other effect has earned Restrained on its own.

The seizing, which comes when the Grey is full at three tokens, locks the Stilled's own limb, or it locks harmless scenery. It never takes another player character's turn, and it never forces an action. A Struck Stilled's first, unpracticed Gaze, probably on someone they love and probably by accident, is the story of how they became this. A Given Stilled deep in Grey-debt on a riot line or in an operating theatre is a set-piece you build. The apprentices touch the knob first. The yard does not explain that drill, and a knob that has gone still is a practical tell of a seizing, not a relic.

The Answered. Every consequence at no tokens stays on the Answered and on the ground, air, or water immediately around them. Never force an effect onto another creature's body, action, or will. Let the element the player chose become the character's whole voice, because an Ember-Answered does not feel like a Root-Answered in a fight or in a quiet room. They ask. They do not own a servant, and nobody else is the master of what answered them. One of the Answered deep in Tithe-debt, walking into a crowded hall, a ship's hold, or a dry archive, is a set-piece you build toward.

The Taken-In. Going to seed stays in the room around them, because the growth comes out of the ground and out of the structure, and the roots do not seize another creature or force an action. A Struck Taken-In's uncertainty, whether they walked out or were sent, is a quiet dread about who they are. The wild in them is part of them, not a master and not a string someone else is pulling. One of the Taken-In dragged deep into a dungeon, down into a ship's hold, or left inside a stone keep to wilt, is a set-piece you build.

Phoenix. You run two things at once. The count: let everyone watch the Hope slots go, and make each rising cost something the player feels, a face or the reason they started, not merely a mark on the sheet. The attention: a Phoenix on the open card is never anonymous. Seed every town with people who revere them, worship them, hunt them, and hate them, and let those often be the same crowd. Never force a Rise, because Rise From Ash is always the player's choice among the death moves, beside the standard three, and a Phoenix may choose Blaze of Glory and end if the story has earned that ending. Fire immunity stays full, because a Phoenix is fire. The bonus to Evasion comes once per rest, and a Rise is a new body rather than a full resetting of the person. Played as a legendary non-player character, the rebirths make markers you can hang an era on: the same soul, met three times, remembering the party a little less each time.

The rule's name is One Gift. There is never a second living Phoenix Condition while this one can still Rise. If the game seems to need two, the leftover is not a Phoenix. The house that catches the fire is the Protectors, and the rules they use, which they do not get to rewrite, are later in this chapter.

GM only: Peoples

Where a Kind lives, Kind meaning the ancestry a person is born into, tells you something about her reach only for the Yumboes. Mainland hearths are ordinary geography: foxes in the woods, seals on the coasts, crows on the ridges. A Kind-hearth is a people's home ecology, not a nation. Kumbaan's isolation is the one Kind-fact that also maps the edge of the keystone. There is no Tree there, no Gift, and the people are themselves without her. "Yumboes have no Conditions" is a fact about the place. It is not a racial immunity.

No power is founded for a Kind. A place where many Foxes live is a Rain-Shadow polity that happens to have many Foxes, and it runs on the same faith, the same reach, and the same government as everyone else. The moment a government exists for a Kind, Kind has become a country, and the two-layer model has broken, because Kind is what you are born and a Condition is what you become, and they stack. Factions recruit by Condition, by guild, and by faith. A tree-warden order that took only Kitsune would be that break. A town can have a fox-market, a Selkie quay, or a Tengu perch without the town being that Kind. Ornsael is the worked example: a market by the well, mixed Kinds, no gate.

A grandmother still says the word for the lost fourth Fox. If you use it, use the folklore that stayed when a hearth died, a dry lake that vanished or a wood that was cut. Nobody explains the word, and it is not a secret ancestry feature. A Fungril household sets one spoonful aside, and they will not say who it is for. That spoonful is the same kind of habit. Do not turn it into a feature, and do not decide who the spoon is for.

An ordinary introduction carries two names, a Kind and a place, and the players should hear both. It is not a secret identity. A Yumboe who takes a mainland second name has decided to stay. A Threnmaieth clerk who refuses to record hearth-names is following the roll, which wants the house, not the kitchen. Witness-lands use a byname. Threnmaieth, Trenledd, the Inner Close, and filing houses use an inherited house-name, said the way a surname is said, where a list has to find the person again.

Each polity's vocabulary is how it excuses itself. It is not the truth of what it does. Threnmaieth's "keeping-whole," **Threnhael**, is a census that calls itself care. Lestrand's "the free," for the **Kept**, the people the Tree hugged and left without a colour, is a market reframing a social slight as a virtue. The Tree hugged them, with no colour and no Condition Given. Vaethorn's "the Waited" wraps real pity in reverence. Confirming the Mother does not make any of those three names honest. They are how each society excuses its own injustice, and a kind Mother did not author the excuse.

The word-box and the how-to for naming a person live in Language and Naming. What the linguistics words mean, and the sound-change that makes a name wear the same way every time, is the next section.

GM only: Language

Language and Naming is where you name a person, mint a new one, glue a hall, and look up what a land calls a building. Keep that chapter as the how-to. This section is what the linguistics words mean, which sounds each way of speaking uses, and the regular wearing-down that lets you push any old word through a land and still have it sound like that land. Use it when you need a name that still belongs and the lists are not enough. It is not taught at the table.

What the linguistics words mean

Linguists have names for things everyone already does with speech. Here they are in this world’s terms, so a reader who has not opened the language chapter can still follow a name.

Word	What it means here
Root	The smallest chunk of meaning. *oren* means “to witness.” You glue roots to make names.
Lexicon	The word-box. The list of roots you are allowed to build from. The old-word table in Language and Naming is the lexicon.
Compound	Two roots glued. **Thaeloren** is *thael* (Tree) + *oren* (witness), said THAEL-or-en, with the stress on the first root.
Etymology	Where a name comes from. Players hear a pretty word. You know Thaeloren means “the Tree that witnesses.”
Phonology	Which sounds a language uses, and which it will not. English has *th*; many languages do not. Kusawe has *sh* and no *th*.
Syllable	One beat of sound. *Ra-ki* is two syllables.
CV / CVC	A recipe for a beat. **C** is a consonant, **V** is a vowel. CV is *ra*. CVC is *tek*. CVF in Kusawe means the beat may end on n, m, or r.
Stress	The beat you hit harder. Capitals mark it. This is not the Stress a character spends to stay in a scene. A transparent compound, one you can still hear as two roots, stresses the first root: THAEL-or-en, VAETH-orn.
Digraph	Two letters, one sound. *ae* is “ay” as in *day*. *ai* and *ei* are “eye.” *eo* is “ay-oh.”
Onset	The consonant or cluster at the start of a beat. *Kr* in Kukra is an onset. Tengu likes those as ordinary speech. The Old Tongue only inherited a few.
Prenasal	A hum before a stop: *mb*, *nd*, *nk*, *nj*. Yumboe uses them. The Old Tongue does not.
Register	A way of speaking used for a job, not a whole language you write sentences in. Kusawe is the fox hearth-register: given names and in-group talk.
Liturgical / Old Tongue	The church language, **Maiethren**. Like Latin: nobody’s first language at the market, still used for the rite and for old names.
Vernacular / common tongue	What people actually say day to day. Worn-down Old Tongue. *The Kept*, *the ranging*, *tree-wardens*.
Daughter language / drift	When one language splits into regional versions. Threnmaieth, Vaethorn, and Lestrand all come from Maiethren. They did not invent new tongues. They wore the same one differently.

Word	What it means here
Conservative	A drift that kept the old sounds. Threnmaieth still says *th*.
Worn	A drift that wore them down. In ordinary speech *th* after a vowel becomes *t*, and endings simplify. Written Vaethorn is spoken **Wetorn**. Careful prayer keeps the *th*.
Eroded	A drift that sanded sounds off. Lestrand dropped *th* to t or d, or dropped it.
Sound-change	A regular swap, not a one-off. If *th* becomes *t* on the docks, it does that in every word, not just one. That is why you can push any old word through the same rule and it will still sound like Lestrand.

You do not need the rest of a linguistics toolkit. There is no grammar to learn, and you do not dress English sentences in swapped vocabulary and call the result Maiethren. Nobody writes sentences in Kusawe, Sakoa, or Gonan. If a scene needs an in-group word, coin one word from that Kind's sounds and say what it means in the same breath.

The Old Tongue's sounds

The Old Tongue feels warm and weighty, a hall-and-hearth tongue. Liquids and nasals, *l*, *r*, *m*, and *n*, carry the warmth. The *th* of *thin*, and the long vowels, carry the weight. Clusters exist, and they are a small inherited set, not an invitation to pile consonants together.

Sounds it uses. Consonants: m n, l r w j, p t k, b d g, f v s h, and *th* as in *thin*. Vowels: a e i o u, plus the digraphs *ae*, *ai*, *ei*, and *eo*. An ordinary beat is an optional opening consonant, an optional *r* or *l* after it, a vowel that may be written as a digraph, and an optional closing consonant. The clusters the old words already use are *br*, *cr* or *kr*, *st*, *str*, and *th* plus *r*. Closings already in the language include *sk* and *nd*. Those patterns are what license *bren*, *crae*, *stel*, *strand*, *thren*, and *hesk*. A new root should prefer the simpler shape. Do not invent a three-consonant opening except *str-*, and do not invent a four-consonant knot.

Sounds it does not use. Prenasals, *mb*, *nd*, and *nj*, belong to Yumboe. *Sh* is a fox sound, not a church sound. Free front clusters such as *gr* and *hr*, and *kr* used as the ordinary feel of a name, belong to Tengu. The Old Tongue's *kr*, as in *crae*, is one inherited word-shape, not that ridge habit.

How to say it. Capitals are the stressed beat. *Th* is as in *thin*, never as in *the*. *Ae* is "ay" as in *day*, *ai* and *ei* are "eye," and *eo* is "ay-oh." *A* is as in *father*, *e* as in *bed*, *i* as in *machine*, *o* as in *go*, and *u* as in *moon*. A simple root keeps the stress listed for it. A compound you can still hear as two roots takes its main stress on the first root and a lighter beat on the second, so the Awakening Tree is THAEL-or-en and the Waiting Land is VAETH-orn. Stress is not a rule that blindly hits the second syllable. Old

ceremonial forms, and personal names, may keep a stress they already had, and the pronunciation given the first time you use the name is the one to trust.

The word-box is the old-word table in Language and Naming. Glue one or two roots. Then wear the compound the way the land wears it.

How an old word wears in each land

One Tree, with grafts carried out from it. One old tongue, with names wearing down as they travel. Linguists would call Threnmaieth, Vaethorn, and Lestrand daughter languages, three children of Maiethren. In this book they are the three drifts. There is no fourth human drift.

The sound-changes are regular. Push any old word through the same rule.

Drift	Land	What happens to the sounds	How it feels
Conservative	Threnmaieth, pious Maiethorn	Almost nothing. *Th* and long vowels kept whole.	Archaic, formal, holy. Sounds like the rite because it barely moved from it.
Worn	Vaethorn, Heskoren folk	*Th* after a vowel, or sitting between vowels, becomes *t* in speech (Vaethorn becomes Wetorn). Endings simplify. Unstressed vowels flatten. Careful prayer keeps the *th*.	Rough-warm folk-speech that still reaches for the old holy words.
Eroded	Lestrand, Strandoren docks	*Th* becomes t or d, or drops. Long vowels clip. Word-ends wear off. Trade-words sneak in.	Smooth, clipped, mercantile. The most worn name belongs to the least-devout place.

The same rule, worked through:

- *thael* plus *oren*, kept whole, is **Thaeloren** (THAEL-or-en). That is the Awakening Tree, “the Tree that witnesses.” The worn everyday name is **the Thallow**.
- *vaeth* plus *orn*, kept with *th* in writing, is **Vaethorn**. Spoken, it is **Wetorn**.
- *ledd* plus *strand*, with the *th* already gone, is **Lestrand**.
- *thren* plus *maieth*, kept whole, is **Threnmaieth**. The same *thren* worn to *Tren* is **Trenledd**: the sacred count with the sacred sanded off.
- *oren* plus *thael*, with the *th* dropped, is **Orentel**. That is the salt-quay seat.

- A devout river-town on a thaw, *maieth* plus *lir*, is **Maiethlir**, *th* kept.

A named power uses these roots and the drift that matches how it stands. Vaelhesk keeps the older *vael*, what the land yields, and the frontier *hesk*-. That is still this family, worn further. Kumbaan is not in this family.

Coinage is frozen. Do not make another liturgical compound merely because two familiar roots fit. The families closed to new compounds are *eol*-, *sael*-, *vael*- and *vaeth*-, *bren*-, *maieth*- and *thren*-, *-oren*, and *-hael*. The words that already exist remain. What is still available, and should be used sparingly, is *orn*, *lir*, *neth*, *ledd*, *hesk*, *strand*, *stel*, and *crae*, and a new use still has to be said out loud next to the names it might be mistaken for. Two cants stay unused and should not be fleshed out: *Orenvaeth* and *Thaelneth*. *Aeloren* is retired. *Eolstrand* is retired in favour of the Hinge Shore.

Family	Existing words that remain	Ruling
eol-	Eolthael, Eoloren, Eolvaeth	Closed. *Eolstrand* retired; the name is the Hinge Shore.
sael-	Saelthael, Saelvaeth, Saelorn, Saelhael, Ornsael	Closed. Use common handles in speech.
vael- / vaeth-	Vaethorn, Vaelhesk, Vaeloren, Vaelbren, Vaelun, Vaethledd, Maiethvael, Leddvael, Thaelvaeth, Brenvaeth	Closed. The final *th* is too slight a spoken distinction to carry another category.
-oren	Thaeloren, Vaeloren, Leddoren, Eoloren, Nethoren, Orenhael, Orenbren, Orentel, Heskoren, Strandoren	Closed. *Aeloren* retired.
bren-	Brenvaeth, Brenorn, brenhael, Brenthael, Brenledd, Brenod	Closed.
maieth- / thren-	Maiethren, Maiethorn, Maiethvael, Maiethlir, Threnmaieth, Trenledd, Threnhael	Closed.

Place-names and house coinages stay off the person-list. Do not name a person Vaethorn, Lestrand, Threnmaieth, Thaeloren, Maieth, Kumbaan, Ndeyaan, Haelthael, Leddoren, or Vaeloren, and do not give them Orenhael, Thaelvaeth, Nethoren, Leddhael, Vaelbren, Njaalo, Njawaal, or Vaethledd. The squares Ornsael, Brenthael, Brenod, Vaelun, Ornath, and Harrow’s are reserved the same way, and so are the seats Eolvaeth, Orentel, and Maiethlir, and the hall Ndenjoo.

Why the drifts sit where they sit

People in the world will tell you that names wear down with distance and trade. That reading is true as far as it goes. The daughters drift furthest where the Trees are thinnest, and the deeper pull that keeps the old sound near the Trees is the Mother's nearness. Same fact, two readings. Player text does not state the deeper one.

History adds a mechanism you can play. The pilgrimage itself was a conserving pull, because people from far away walked to the same grove each year and the old sound got refreshed. Local Trees then let the daughter drifts grow in the place where people lived, so the change of the Years of Hands sits on a root the Walking Years had held closer.

Thaeloren is not decoration. The name means "the Tree that witnesses." She is real, and the Leaf-Fall, the tenth-year ceremony when a leaf chooses a child, is her seeing each child. The language keeps a truth the skeptics have explained away. Player text does not call that mere poetry. Let a scholar notice it, or save it for a reveal late in a campaign.

The four Kind registers

Each custom Kind has a register, a closed set of sounds for given names and in-group talk. It is not a language you write sentences in. The lists in Language and Naming are what you pick from. These inventories are how you mint a new name that still belongs.

Kitsune: Kusawe (koo-SAH-way). Light, slipping, a little hissy.

Consonants	k s sh n r m t w y f h
Vowels	a i u e o, and *ai* as in *eye*
Beats	CV, or CV ending on n, m, or r. Two or three beats.
Never uses	*th* (church), *mb/nd/nj* (Yumboe), *kr/gr* (Tengu)

Selkie: Sakoa (sah-KOH-ah). Liquid, rounded, coastal.

Consonants	l r n m s v f d b k w
Vowels	o u a i e, and *ea*, *oa*
Beats	CV or CVC. Two or three beats.
Never uses	*th*, *sh*, *kr/gr*, *mb/nd/nj*

Tengu: Gonan (GO-nan). Clipped, windy, high-country. The names start hard, on a single consonant or on *kr*, *gr*, or *hr*. This is ridge-speech, not the fox register, and Tengu and Kitsune do not share one.

Consonants	k t g n r h s b d. Front clusters *kr*, *gr*, *hr* are at home.
Vowels	a o u e. Few *i* (that vowel lives with the foxes).
Beats	CVC or CV. One to three beats, prefer two.
Never uses	*th*, *sh*, *mb/nd/nj*, long *ai/ea/oa*

Yumboe. Not Maiethren. Open vowels, a drum-like rhythm, prenasals *mb*, *nd*, *nk*, and *nj*. Their own name is *Bakhna Rakhna*, “the good people.” Home is *Kumbaan*, “the hidden home.” It has no *th*, and it is not clipped down to a dock-name.

A name that bleeds across registers is a tell. A Selkie named Wishi, or a Tengu named Maethaem, was raised away, adopted, or is passing. Use it on purpose, or do not use it at all. If the first fox-name that comes to mind is Yuki, throw it back. Same for Morag on a Selkie and Kenji on a Tengu. Pick from the middle of the existing list, or build from the inventory above until the name could sit next to Raki, Lavo, or Teku without anyone blinking.

The player recipe stays in Language and Naming: pick from a list, or use the make-another steps, or glue two old words and wear them for the land. The inventories above are the same registers written as sound-lists, so a new name can be checked against the rule. The sound-change table is how you push any old word through a land without inventing a fourth human drift.

GM only: Society and Faiths

The Leaf-Mother exists. The Turning Trees are genuinely her hands, so when a Tree chooses, she is choosing. A **scion** is a grafted town Tree, continuous living tissue of the one Awakening Tree. The Conditions are real gifts. The Leaf-Fall is an act of love: she looks at a child and gives them a becoming the world will need and that they can carry. The Tithe is the honest weight of that gift, not a hidden price and not a trap. She is kind and finite. She cannot lay a hand on every child, cannot reach every threshold in time, and cannot give without spending. The limit is real. She is doing her best against it. A mother who could save everyone and did not would be sinister. That is not the mother this world has.

The Kept are spared, and some of them are simply past her edge. A hug and no colour is, for most, a deliberate and kind choice, the gift of being left whole. The constraint means the Kept are not all one thing. Some were chosen for wholeness, and some are children she could not reach far enough to give

to this turning, held safe rather than gifted. She does not tell them apart, and neither can they. Both are held. Not both are chosen. No later week is offered to sort them. The Given-door is one week, a completed standing is once, and a miss is not a retry.

The Struck are still hers, at the farthest reach of her arm. She Gives at the Tree and does not Strike, so the catch at a later door, a death, an oath, a drowning, stone, or the deep wild, is enacted by lesser gods of her household, each restricted to one door, working under her allowance. The Struck are still hers because those hands are hers to send. **Narrow-Hand**, the reading that she only Gives at the Tree, is right about that limit. **Wide-Hand**, the reading that the Struck are still hers, is right about belonging. Neither holds the whole.

Her kindness is cosmological, not social. She authored the gifts. She did not author the injustice built on top of them. Confirming that she is real and kind must not make the society just. The keystone answers whether anyone is there and whether they mean well, and the answer is yes. It does not answer whether what people built around her is fair, and often it is not. Protect that gap. That is where the play is. The queue for a scion, the suspicion that follows an unvouched Struck person, the over-watching of the Bound, the guild that conscripts the Given, Tithe-need used as leverage, the Kept pitied as spare, the Given-Over's lost personhood, the lintel recut over an older faith, the book that will not close, the host of a dying guest, the sentence that will not travel, the week that will not end, the gate, the scheduled hour, the Grey used as labour, the shop you cannot leave, and the week no one writes: these are things people built. A kind Mother does not dissolve them.

The three corners do not share a mechanism. Vaethorn's injustice is a guilt-theology of unworthiness. Lestrand's is a market that lets the poor fade. Threnmaieth's is a sanctified census. Confirming she is kind does not make any of the three fair. Rival faiths can be used as leverage. Dissent is not automatically the moral good. The same confirmation does not dissolve Threnmaieth's counting of heretics, Lestrand's priced fading, or Vaethorn's guilt.

The household is still GM-only. She is first of a household. She Gives, and lesser Hands Strike at restricted doors under her allowance. Player text does not confirm this. The Open Table's staying-kin are not of that household, and Kumbaan is not part of it.

Each rival holds a true kernel and misses the whole.

The Watching correctly remembers a Before, and a cost, and a household from before that household was named Mother. They miss that the seeing is hers. The Masked reading, that she is a later face, and the Bare Tree reading, that there was never a she, are both playable. Neither is the answer, and the lintel is a clue, not a verdict. The cost they remember is real. What was spent is still the open nature of her limit. They get no seat in a late reveal, because that would turn the heretics into a second Motherfaith. The warmth lands through them, not as them.

The Fair Hand is right that a Counterparty exists for the Bound, and wrong that every becoming is a bargain. The Mother's Gifts are still gifts. They have misread a cost as a price, and they have correctly felt that giving is not free. They are not devil-worshippers. A Book-hand cannot turn a Given child into a debtor, and cannot rewrite the Counterparty's clause. A petition-watch is keeping the door. It is not the authority of an acolyte.

The Old Ways are right that land-doors are real. They miss that she authorized the guests. Keep the grievance real: the grafts are late, and the Motherfaith did talk as if becoming were new. Keep the miss intact. Ancestor-meals are not the Returned. The dead in the ground are kin who remained. The Returned are a different door.

The Open Table is the cleanest experiment: no Gifts, rare Struck, a faith that was never hers. Their claim, that they were never lacking, is still a late beat. They are not ghosts. The unseen hands do ordinary household work. "No one is a stranger twice" is courtesy with legal weight on the isle, and a proverb on the quay. It is not a geas, which would be a binding spell, and it is not a trap-cult, and it is not a Fair Hand contract. A wreck is not a Struck-door she authorized.

If a campaign works toward the keystone, the three old corners are the Watching, the Old Ways, and the Open Table: pre-Mother, pre-graft, and never-grafted. The Fair Hand is the modern misreading, commerce wearing a theology. Use all four. No one of them speaks the reveal for the others.

The Tree is something players can see, and it sits next to the keystone. "Every Tree is literally the one Tree's hand" is the physical fact that, followed to its end, confirms she is real and present. Present that as doctrine the faithful hold, never as demonstrated cosmology. Skeptics grant the grafting and deny the mind. The Tree is not eerie, and the ceremony is not sinister. Dread lives in individual Tithes, not in the rite.

Use the schism again. The three questions, what a hug means, what a Struck becoming means, and whether a mind is there, keep supplying people, factions, and family arguments. No player-facing scene awards the win to either branch. Believers see the hand and miss the edge. Skeptics see the edge and miss the hand. The world is built so that being a skeptic costs nothing day to day, which keeps the argument poignant. It does not turn the skeptics into a joke.

The Child at Four Doors. The paradox is the point. The child cannot pick a door without already having been claimed, and cannot be claimed without picking. Each faith makes the middle bearable by deciding that its door was the one that had been open the whole time. None of the last lines is the true cosmology. The true cosmology is that a mother reached, at cost, and did not reach everyone the same way. The fable will not say that. Which ending a person offers is a faster read of their stance than a speech about doctrine. There is no official fifth door. The Open Table already refuses the frame of four. A children's story does not settle the keystone. Save the warmth for the confirming beat, if it ever comes.

The Orenhael are the tree-wardens, and the everyday name is tree-wardens. The liturgical name in use is Orenhael, and that form is still polishable the way the household names are. They are right about the wood and incomplete about the hand. Every scion is continuous tissue of the one Tree, and when any warden Speaks a colour they are naming a choice she made. Present them as competent neighbours, not as people who secretly know. A skeptic town-warden is good at the job and wrong about the mind. The Seat runs believer-heavy. A skeptic Speaker at the grove is possible, and uncomfortable. The split is the queue, not the Tree. The Seat sees soil and carrying-earth. The hamlet past the ford sees another year of borrowed Turnings. Which town gets the next graft is a human rationing of her reach. Threnmaieth does not own the Seat. Being near it is pressure, not ownership. A First Seat that was the Threnhael would be a darker setting. Keep the college able to refuse the roll.

The Slide. They do not know what story they are in. They think they are in a rent-and-credit story. They want the week to continue, not a victim they relish, and a corpse is a ruined asset. Play them as patient, useful, and sure they helped. The town is complicit, because the town is glad not to see the Cry, and the week-keeper is not the only villain. Official Tithe-halls and the licence-guilds are the public, posted, counted version of furnishing. This house is the overflow those guilds pretend not to know, and a gate that closed on purpose can now meet them at the table. They do not rewrite Terms, steal scions, or sell a false Turning-witness. Those trades have other faces. The everyday name, the Slide, and the name week-keepers, are settled. The cant Vaethledd may still be polished. It is not Orledd, and it is not the retired Nethledd.

Official halls and greens. The people who keep them think they are in a wells-and-yards story. They want a town that does not wilt, Cry, or seize in the square. They do not want a client. Every closed gate feeds a week-book. The words they are comfortable inside are share, hour, ticket, and enough. She gave the Tithe. She did not build the lot.

Greens-Keepers. They want a living lot, not a client. A wilt on the lot is a ruined commons. A wilt off the lot is weather they have decided not to see. The buried leaf is how the lot remembers. A player character who digs it up has committed a local rudeness, and has not found how the world works. The bed-slate is plants. If it is already a quiet census, that is Threnmaieth leaking, not the world's baseline. They will not tell a guest what the leaf is for.

Hall-Keepers. Put both jobs in the one hall, the furnished hour and the Voice-ticket, and keep them two jobs. Far-Voiced people are where those jobs meet. Write the unswept bench as what the hall does. Nobody says which Cry it remembers, and you do not explain it. The old liturgical form Aeloren is retired. No living hall claims it.

Stillers. They want a street that does not seize and a patient who lives. They do not want a register of the feared. Holding a citizen still is ordinary violent crime, the one harm the code names. The Gaze can leave a person helpless in a fight. It never seizes a will, it does not hold them past the scene, and it does not turn them to stone. Whether a ticket can be held as guild property is Lestrand's live argument,

not world-law. A ticket that becomes a week's rent has left the yard and met the Slide. Do not merge the two doors.

Element-Guilds. The four elements are four doors under one set of rules, the Crae, from *crae*, "craft." They want work that slakes the Tithe, and a room that holds the element. They do not want a client. Write the last coal, yesterday's water, the unwashed clay, and the unshut window as what the guild does. Nobody in the guild explains them, so do not turn them into theology or into four relics. "We do not bench" is care in the voice of the shop, and it is also the exit refused. Gale-Tengu is a lean. Ember-Drakona is a lean. Leans are not chapters. The Root guild does not walk a scion for a Road-hand, and there is no Tide-house on Kumbaan's sand.

The Intake. They want a quiet week. They do not want a client, a relic, or a route. Success is burned, so the town never has to look at the week, and Given children got a childhood of training the Struck will never get. Travel is accidental, a runner toward this person. If you find them on the road every session, you have cloned the Road-hands, who already walk. The shed does not take a Bound person, because that contract is a table and not a body-ticket, or a Taken-In person, because that upkeep is a lot. It does not take a Returned person, a Two-Bodied person, or a Long-Lived person. The rope, which is the sentence a hearing can pass, alongside the wall, for murder or for holding a citizen still, is also what people say when a raw Struck person has nowhere left but the street. The shed exists so the week can end somewhere short of that rope. The cant, the catching-year, is not settled.

The reach-edge stays GM-side as cause. Vaethorn's high rates of Kept and Struck, the dense Given of Lestrand and Threnmaieth, and the medicine gap between core and frontier all read, inside the world, as plain distance and biology. That mundane reading is the skeptics' whole case. The real reason, that her reach is bounded and thins where the Trees are thin, stays on this side of the page. No player-facing beat states the cause. Vaethorn is the sharpest test, because a devout population there most wants an explanation for the thin gift, and the true answer would confirm the guilt-theology's worst fear.

The Long-Lived marriage is the quietest grief you can bring back more than once. A Long-Lived stops aging, and the spouse does not, so the Long-Lived outlives and buries a spouse, and sometimes a child. Save it for a scene that needs the weight. It also gives you people you can put in a chair: the deathless widower who has stopped, and the one who keeps beginning again.

The cold embrace is a diagnostic and a hook. A Returned's family can feel a lapsing Purpose at a touch. A loved one who has run cold is a quiet family crisis, and the question in the room is what unfinished thing is slipping, and whether anyone can meet it before the Returned settles or turns cold to everyone.

Whoever furnishes a provided-for Tithe holds power over its bearer. That is the sharpest economic lever in the setting, coercion with a friendly face.

Player-facing notes keep her unproven. Skeptics have their full dignity. No player-facing beat confirms the Mother. The confirmation is yours to place, and it should land as warmth and relief with an ache under it. There is no harvest waiting under the kindness, and no betrayal waiting to be uncovered. The floor is sound: bounded, costly, and grieving, and still sound. The order in which a table might come to believe that, and what a square does if the belief lands, is the appendix.

The Pourers, the Unspent, and the Walled Book

Three groups stay apart, because they do not share a job. The Pourers give away their own memory. The Walled Book ranks people. The Protectors catch Phoenix fire and hide it behind worship. No page in the library connects them, and you do not merge any two into one description.

Inside the Pourers there is an inner circle. Most members do not know it exists, and its work does not go through Molevad's minute-book. It chooses a Long-Lived person for the knowledge that defines that person's life, a judge with three hundred years of rulings, or the last person who can read a dead hand. The person does not have to be a member. Someone who refused the invitation can still be chosen.

The inner circle takes the person and holds them until they give that knowledge into a cup. The means are confinement, isolation, and threats. Shutting a Long-Lived away from anything new is already a known cruelty, and the inner circle uses it on purpose. Some victims are deceived instead. A member is told that this is an ordinary one-year gift, and the inner circle chooses what goes in. No new power is involved. The gift works the way every gift works. The difference is that the person did not choose it.

What is taken is personal memory and the understanding the person spent years earning: the cases a judge learned from, the reasons a scholar trusts one source over another, the people they loved and why. The person keeps their speech and their ordinary skills. They can still recognize the world around them. They know what is gone, and they can say so. They are not starving under the Long-Lived Tithe, and the Long-Lived card applies to them as written. Each victim loses something different, so no two are the same afterward.

The taken memory does not go into the shared store. It goes into a second cup, the one on the shelf nobody will talk about. The founder reads that cup. The founder is the Long-Lived person who started the Pourers, and is still alive. This book does not name the founder. Because a Long-Lived forgets nothing they take in, the founder keeps all of it. The founder believes that enough of this knowledge will make them a god. The founder also believes the attempt might ruin what they hope to save, and has accepted that risk. That is the founder's belief, and nothing more. This book does not say the founder can become a god, and it does not say the world could end. Player text never calls the founder a god.

Ordinary members still give one year at a time of their own accord, and that is most of what the Pourers do. “Every gift is freely given” is the circle’s claim, and it is true of them. The circle meets on a shelf in a long-house in Lestrand, and the other circle meets in an upper room in Orenbren, which is not the upper room at Harrow’s Green. Do not give a date or a month for the nights of giving. Do not add a library, a city, or a medical house. Medicine stays with the Stilled.

The Unspent is the presence in the cup. It stores what is put in, and it does not know or care whether the person chose to give it. It is older than the name the circle gave it. It has always taken in the memories that deathless people could not keep carrying, and it had no public face. The Long-Lived named it, gave memory to the name, and decided that naming it had made it. It lets them say so, and it does not correct them. It does not make plans, does not feed on people, and does not need worship. It cannot Give a Condition, Strike someone into one, make anyone Long-Lived, or save anyone at a threshold. If a circle asks the cup for more years, a second Condition, or a rescue from death, the cup only keeps what it already holds. The founder is a person, not this presence. The Unspent will not take over a will by itself, sort the Kept, confirm the Leaf-Mother, name the Other Hands, take Phoenix fire, or give a memory back in the form of a Condition.

Each year a member gives has three parts. The memory goes into the cup, that year’s papers go onto the long-house shelf, and the long-houses that keep the circle count the member one year younger. The papers are ordinary paper on an ordinary shelf, and they are not part of the Unspent. They are how a party learns about a gift without reading the cup. A member’s letters, account books, and court notes from the years they gave are filed under their name, and Molevad can let a visitor read them. A person named in one of those letters may want it back. The circle answers that the letter was the member’s to give, and a party can be hired into that argument. The papers of a person the inner circle took from do not go onto the open shelf. Where they go is not written. The count is a long-house custom. It changes where a member sits and who speaks first. It changes nothing on the Long-Lived card.

The harm a party meets is one person, a Long-Lived who has lost the knowledge that defined their life and can tell you so. They may not know who took it. Daily life with the Pourers is courtesy and real scholarship. The inner circle is the one hidden thing underneath, at about five percent frightening. Members who want to stop giving want it for different reasons. Some found out about the taking. Some helped with a taking without knowing what the inner circle was doing. Some believed in the practice until they saw what it did to someone. Player text gives them no single shared reason. A member who stands in a passage in the minutes is one of those withdrawers. The page does not say why they stand there, and you do not explain it.

The Walled Book ranks people by Condition. Its injustice is the Book, not a hymn. It ranks the tithed and disinherits a Given heir, and its heir-roll lists only its own heirs. Threnmaieth’s census writes everyone down and calls it care. A party that steals both lists finds they do not say the same thing about the same child. The Book teaches that a hug is rare. The Close knows the real count, which lives with the population shares and is not repeated here, and teaches the lesson anyway. Volnai is the one

teacher who says that lesson aloud. Volnai is a given name only, not a plot. The named people of the Book stay Delamem, Talnin of the Inner Close, and Hithaen.

The list of turns is a duty of living inside the walls, not ownership. A person with a Condition can own a stall, keeps their wages, and can leave by the gate. The Book does not sell, lend, or hand over a person. Outside the walls, the Book's manners reach three places only: Orenbren's inns near the gate, Vaethorn's gift-hall at Eolvaeth, and the supper benches at Brenthael. Brenthael keeps no copy of the Book, and nobody says who started its seating. Do not explain that seating. Hithaen, a disinherited Given heir of the Closed houses, eats in Eolvaeth's gift-hall.

The Closed Seat once sat the grove and decided who could walk. The First Cut broke that hold. The Closing was the war that followed, and Hildal's Retreat is what closed the walls a day's walk from the Motherwood. Do not name the cutter in order to explain the war, and do not make Hildal a villain-king. Rothallo, still called the Inner Close, is Orenbren's capital and stays inside Orenbren. It is not a sixteenth power, not Threnmaieth's inner court, and not the college in the wood. The Book keeps no Phoenix fire. Do not move the walls to the Hinge Shore, and do not let them capture the First Seat.

Appendix: GM Canon

Player-facing notes keep her unproven. This appendix is what is actually true, regardless of what anyone in the world believes.

The Leaf-Mother

She is real, and she is benevolent, and her reach is not infinite, and giving costs her.

She exists as a genuine, present power, not a metaphor and not a dead god whose name survived her. The Turning Trees are genuinely her hands. The town scions are not a natural phenomenon that people only read as divine. They are how she reaches into the world, and when a Tree chooses, she is choosing. The Conditions are real gifts. At the Leaf-Fall she looks at a child and gives a becoming the world will need and that the child can carry. The Tithe is the honest weight of that gift, not a hidden price and not a trap.

She is kind and finite. Her reach has an edge, and every gift costs her something to give. She cannot lay a hand on every child, cannot reach every threshold in time, and cannot give without spending. That limit is not a flaw hidden under the warmth. It is why the warmth aches. The limit is real. She is doing her best against it.

A hug and no colour is, for most Kept, a deliberate and kind choice, the gift of being left whole, wanted in its own right. The constraint means some Kept were chosen for that wholeness, and some are children she could not reach far enough to give to this turning, held safe rather than gifted. She does not tell them apart for us, and neither can they. Both are held. Not both are chosen. A later week is not offered to sort them. The Given-door is one week, a completed standing is once, and a miss is not a retry.

A becoming that arrives through a later threshold, a drowning, an oath, a death survived, is not a Condition that escaped her. She meets people at those doors too, and the threshold is the edge of her reach, not her ordinary hand. There she catches rather than gives. It is chancier, costlier, and not always in time. That is why the Struck feel received and still arrive without ceremony, and why they can feel a half-step outside the fold. They were reached for at the limit, not gifted at the centre. She Gives at the Tree. She does not Strike. The catch is enacted by lesser gods of her household, each restricted to one door, under her allowance. The Struck are still hers because those hands are hers to send. Narrow-Hand and Wide-Hand are both half-right.

The believers are right about the big things. She is real, she is kind, and the gifts are gifts. The skeptics are wrong that no one is there, and they are not entirely wrong, because they have correctly felt the edge: the Kept who seem passed over, the Struck who arrive unmet by ceremony, the sense that the giving is not seamless. There is a seam. They have mislabelled a limit as an absence. No one in the world holds the whole shape. Believers see the hand and miss the edge. Skeptics see the edge and miss the hand. The faith is true, and incomplete in exactly the way its own doubters sense.

The world keeps her as belief, not as confirmed cosmology. No one can prove her. Revelation is quiet. Honest skeptics remain honest.

What she is stays open. A goddess, the Trees' shared soul, or something older wearing a mother's face are all still possible, and this book does not pick among them. The maternal, benevolent intent is settled. Her metaphysical species is not. What she wants, past the giving of good gifts, is unwritten. Where she is, and whether anyone can reach her, is unwritten. There is no throne to visit. That her reach has an edge, and that giving costs her, is settled. Why she is finite, whether by nature, from some old wound, by rationing a power that could run out, or by holding something back in order to hold something else up, is deliberately unwritten. A wound in the deep past is one available cause among several. Before the Walk does not pick it. The history shows the edge moving when wood was carried. It does not explain the wound, the finitude, or the rationing.

How it surfaces

Because she is quiet and genuinely kind, revelation gathers as things fitting together, and then as one object that can close the question. The first five steps stay deniable on purpose, so a skeptic can still

walk away. The sixth is a pin, not a speech you are told to reserve forever. The setting still works if a table never uses it, and it must remain possible to use.

1. **The gifts fit too well.** Over a lifetime, a town notices that the Conditions Given tend to be the ones that town will need, as if something is looking ahead. The pattern is easy to dismiss as hindsight, counting only the gifts that worked, which is what the skeptics do.
2. **The Kept are cared for, not merely skipped.** Many Kept report that the ceremony felt like a choice made for them, not like an absence, and not all of them report that, so the difference nags. The testimony is hard to falsify and easy to call sentiment. Both readings are true of different Kept, some chosen and some past her edge, which is why the testimony never resolves cleanly.
3. **The reach has an edge.** Remote hamlets far from any mature Tree run higher on the Kept and higher on the Struck. A Tree strains, and a child goes ungifted where a central town's Tree would not have missed. The giving thins where the Trees are thin. It reads as distance and biology, which is the skeptics' whole case, and it is in fact the shape of a bounded hand. Before the grafts spread, only those who could make the pilgrimage were reached, and the far-flung stayed unTurned for want of the trip. That the reach has grown with the grafts is itself the quiet argument that a hand, and not a climate, is behind it.
4. **A Tree does something a phenomenon should not.** Now and then, rarely and quietly, a scion acts with apparent intent. It withholds a colour that would have doomed a child, or it reaches, and sometimes visibly strains, for a specific person. The moment is never flashy, and it is always deniable.
5. **The Struck are met, barely.** Testimony from the Struck says the threshold felt received, as if someone reached from the far side of the door, late, or thin, or at the very limit of arriving at all. It is the strongest experiential evidence, and the clearest felt sense of the edge, and it is still only testimony. This step does not name the Other Hands.
6. **The confirming beat is the Spent Leaf.** The Spent Leaf is a colourless remainder of a Giving, kept by the Remainder in the First Seat's side-yard. Early checks stay as deniable as the five steps above. It answers motherwood, and the yard-log says it is lighter after a Giving week. The confirming act is to hold it under a healthy Tree during a real colour-fall. The holder feels warmth, and a grief that is not theirs. The canopy thins for a breath and then recovers. The next child is not shorted. That gesture is a mind, kindness, and cost together. Land it as warmth and relief with an ache under it. The answer to whether anyone is there is that she meant it kindly, and she is doing what she can against a limit.

The leaf will not sort the Kept into chosen and past-her-edge. It will not name a Hand or a door. It will not explain the nature of her limit. It will not rerun a week or change a fall.

If confirmation lands

Use this when the square, or the people who matter to the party, believe the leaf. One clerk’s private feeling is not that moment.

Right practice, the habit of doing the rite correctly, was what kept the peace. A proved mind makes the skeptics choose whether to convert, leave the festival, or become a named dissent. Threnmaieth already files the Watchers as the Grown-Over, a counted column on the roll, and it will want a Denied column beside that one.

If a bounded hand is real, then waiting under a Tree is the rationing of a person, not a run of weather. The scion-queue becomes a moral sentence. Road-hands get more leave and more blame. The hamlets past the ford do not get their twenty years back.

In Vaethorn the guilt-theology’s worst fear is confirmed, because a thin reach is real. Some hearths stop bringing children rather than risk a hug they now read as a miss, and more children grow up unTurned. That spike is not her will.

Lestrand sells viewings, copies, and what it will call cost-insurance. If the Seat keeps the box, the leaf is not a product. The story of the leaf is.

Threnmaieth tries to write her into the roll as a counted fact. Speakers who refuse become a problem for the crown. The college can still refuse the roll. Keep that refusal available.

The Watching is not promoted. They will say they told you there was a cost, and they still will not say Mother. The warmth lands through them, and not as them.

Some of the Kept will want the leaf to tell them which hug they were. It will not. She still does not tell them apart.

Confirmation changes what people believe. It does not change the justice of the queue, the Grown-Over column, the rope, or the week that will not end. The rope here is the sentence already named, the hanging or the wall, and the week that will not end is the Slide’s book, which keeps a person by extending the same week.

Confirming her does not reveal the Other Hands. That comes later, or never, and never first. They know that she spends. They do not know why.

If the Seat buries the leaf instead, the square goes on as before. The five earlier steps still work. A clerk from the Remainder walks off with what they know, and the yard-log still exists. That clerk is how a party gets involved without a prophecy.

What players will think first

“It’s just what the Trees do” is the skeptic’s reading, biology with no mind behind it. It is sincere, it is common, and it is wrong about the mind. The people who hold it have genuinely seen the edge, the thinning at the margins and the unmet Struck, and mislabelled a limit as an absence. It is safe to let them hold it. Being half-right is what makes it durable.

“If she’s real and kind, why the Tithes, why the Struck, why anyone Kept?” stays live. The answers ache, and they are true: a gift has honest weight, she reaches the thresholds only at the edge of her arm, and some Kept are chosen for wholeness while some are simply past her reach. The answers are not provable, so the questions stay in the room.

“A kind god would save everyone” is the misreading the constraint invites, the claim that a bounded mother is not really benevolent. In the world it is a real theological wound. She is kind and finite, and the gap between those two facts is where the grief lives. Do not let the table solve the gap into omnipotence, and do not let them solve it into indifference.

The dark reading, that a benevolent front hides a harvest or a betrayal, is one this setting rejects. The floor stays sound. Bounded, costly, and grieving, and still sound.

“The Spent Leaf is harvested fire, a second Phoenix, or proof she is dying” is the wrong object. The leaf is a remainder of a Giving. She spends, and nobody is farming her. The leaf has nothing to do with the Protectors.

“The Closed Lamp is a leaf, an uncounted fall, or the same remainder” is the other wrong object. The lamp is metal and a banked coal. It belongs to the fire plot, not to the keystone.

Her kindness does not launder society

The floor being sound at the divine layer does not make the social layer kind. People build unjust things on top of true gifts she never authored and her kindness does not excuse. Struck stigma and legal suspicion, Tithe-halls that become leverage over the people who need them, guild conscription of the Given, communities that treat their Kept as spare labour, and communities that manage the feared Conditions, the Stilled and the Bound, as problems to be filed: confirmation does not dissolve any of that.

The keystone answers whether anyone is there and whether they mean well. It does not answer whether the society people built around her is just. The moral tension of the setting lives in that gap.

Fifteen injustices, not one injustice wearing different hats. Maiethvael is not the kind foil to Threnmaieth. Piety is a social tax there, and the Kept are pitied in plenty. Trenledd is not Threnmaieth with the hymns taken out and the counting made kinder. It is colder, because there is no duty to keep

you hale. Ornled is not freedom. There is no congregation-net, and light government plus thin Trees is exposure. Confirming the Mother is kind launders none of them.

Vaethorn's guilt, Lestrand's market, and Threnmaieth's census are three different injustices, all built by people on top of the same true gifts. They do not share a mechanism. They share only that people built them. The Tithes are honest costs, not divine leverage. A Tithe never seizes the player character. The schism stays a good-faith disagreement, and the constraint makes it two-sided. Believers hold the hand. Skeptics hold the edge. Neither holds the whole.

The Other Hands

The Leaf-Mother Gives. She does not Strike. The Struck are still hers, because the hands that catch at those doors are of her household, working under her allowance.

She is not exclusive. She is the first and greatest of a household. The Struck are the work of the Other Hands, lesser gods of that household, each with one restricted door and her permission to reach through it. The world still holds her as belief. The other faiths already describe these powers as they themselves understand them. Confirmation is a late beat. When it lands, it should feel as if the household had always been in the next room, not as a list of gods dumped on the table. A campaign never opens with a pantheon.

A Condition is the becoming itself. Given means she gave it at the Leaf-Fall. Struck means an Other Hand caught the person at that Hand's door. She cannot, or will not, Give a death or a contract to a ten-year-old, because those doors do not open at the Leaf-Fall, and that is why Returned and Bound are Struck-only.

The division of labour

Path	Who	Where	What
Given	the Leaf-Mother alone	a healthy Turning Tree at Leaf-Fall	she looks, she chooses, she Gives. Long-Lived, Two-Bodied, Answered, and Phoenix are hers only. No Other Hand may grant them.
Struck	one Other Hand, by her allowance	that Hand's own door (death, oath, drowning, stone, wild)	they may grant only their Condition, only at that door, only within her allowance
Both	Mother or the relevant Hand	Tree or door	Far-Voiced, the Stilled, and the Taken-In can be Given at ten or Struck later. Same Condition. Different hand. Different person at the table.

The household

There are five Hands, five doors, and five Conditions that can arrive without a leaf. Each Hand is restricted to one door, one grant, and her allowance. They are not a dark court, and they are not a rival pantheon. They are family labour, the work she cannot do at the Tree without breaking what a gift is. The liturgical names are Maiethren, the Old Tongue. The division of labour is settled. The names may still be polished.

Door	Condition	Everyday name	Liturgical	What they want	Play them as
died with work unfinished	Returned	**the Quiet Tally**	*Threnvaeth* (THREN-vayth), “the counted waiting”	The last task done well, the book closed honestly	Not a reaper. A clerk of unfinished work who will not close the book while work remains. Warm and solemn, the way the Returned themselves are.
a contract sworn in extremity	Bound, and the Unbound when the term ends	**the Counterparty**	*Orledd* (or-LED), “the witnessed reckoning”	An extremity that can still be answered, and the answer stay readable. Fewer kept bargains, not a flood of unread ones.	Not a devil. The one who answers a sworn ask and keeps the term. The face the Bound chose is a mask that person gave, and Orledd wears it.
survived drowning	Far-Voiced, on the Struck path	**the Second Breath**	*Eloren* (ay-LOR-en), “the deep-witness”	Voices that would have stopped, used: song, warning, comfort. Breath spent, not stored.	Not a sea-god. The deep that returns a voice. The Far-Voiced who was Given is hers. The drowned one is Eloren’s.
survived being turned to stone	the Stilled, on the Struck path	**the Holding**	*Ornhael* (orn-HAYL), “the whole-ground”	A pause someone walks out of. Stillness that saves, then lets go.	Not a curse-god. The ground that holds a person still and then lets them walk out.
lost and dying in the deep wild	the Taken-In, on the Struck path	**the Taking**	*Vaelorn* (VAYL-orn), “the yield-land”	That no one die unmade in the wild. The lost taken in.	Not a hungry forest. The land that will not let you die unmade. *Vael* in the Old

Door	Condition	Everyday name	Liturgical	What they want	Play them as
					Ways' older sense, what the land yields.

The collective everyday name is the Other Hands. She is the First Hand. They are the rest. They do not have temples of their own on the mainland as a set, because the Motherfaith grew over that memory, and the rival faiths kept pieces of it.

Eloren (ay-LOR-en) sits one letter from *Eoloren*, the liturgical name of the First Cut. *Ornhael* (orn-HAYL) sits close to *Ornthael*, the liturgical name of the Years of Hands. Both stay as they are. Say them with the stress given here, so a table does not hear one name and answer with the other.

The Unspent, whose everyday name is the Poured God, is in the household, and it is not a sixth Hand and not a door. It existed before the Pourers named it. It cannot Give, Strike, or catch a person at a threshold. No circle can pour anyone into being Long-Lived.

Allowance and purchase

Allowance is her permission for a Hand to Strike. An Other Hand cannot Strike a Condition outside their door, cannot Give at a Tree, and cannot exceed what she has permitted. That is also why the Struck feel received and still unmet by ceremony. A lesser hand caught them, at the edge, by permission.

Purchase is not clerical magic, and it is not a matter of praying for a domain spell. It is how easily a Hand reaches where its door is kept: funerals and unfinished work for Threnvaeth, oaths and books for Orledd, drowning-water for Eloren, stone and stillness for Ornhael, wild and grove for Vaelorn. On the mainland those doors exist even for skeptics, because the world is full of them. Belief helps. Geography and practice matter more. Her Giving does not need worship. Skeptics still Turn. The Trees are her hands, not her collection plate. The Leaf-Fall is not something a person has to believe in before it works.

During a term, Orledd receives two things, and if the table never learns this they will play the Counterparty as a devil. The first is the ask remaining true. The Granted Power works because the want was real and was named, and a vague "save me" that was never turned into a clause is not a bargain they can hold. The second is the Terms being kept in public. Each kept Term is a witnessed reckoning, which is how a Counterparty exists in a world whose ordinary hand Gives. Orledd cannot Give. A gift with no named return would be her work, so the exchange has to stay readable or the labour at this door collapses. At the end of a term-limited contract, Orledd receives the Pledge, which

they have been holding through the term. The collection at the end is the release of what they held, not a surprise theft. Orledd does not receive a soul, worship, a second signing, or the Bound's personhood. Play a Counterparty who would rather have one kept Term than ten whispered extras. The mask does not change what is received.

Allowance is not a mood. It is a permission with a failure mode. Use strain often and quietly, and use a break almost never. Strain means the door still works, and the catch feels thin, late, or off, so that Narrow-Hand testimony gets louder.

Hand	A strain looks like
Threnvaeth	A Returned is kept from their Purpose and used as cheap deathless labour, so the book cannot close.
Orledd	Terms are written to eat toward the Given-Over, or the ask was never extremity and was only appetite.
Eloren	A Struck voice is silenced, or used only as a weapon, or a drowning is arranged so that a voice will come back.
Ornhael	Someone is held as a tool and not allowed to walk out, or the Grey is treated as a prison.
Vaelorn	The lost are warehoused as urban green-poverty, or land is used as a dump for people a city does not want.
Any	Reaching on Kumbaan, where the doors are barely a concept, or reaching in a year she has already spent.

At the table, strain looks like a threshold that should have caught and did not, so the drowning just drowned, or a Strike that felt like a grab rather than a catch, or a Bound Whisper that lies more often because the Terms are being kept as theatre.

A break is a household rupture. It is rare, it is the size of a campaign, and it is not a war between gods. A Hand breaks allowance by granting a Given-only Condition, which means Long-Lived, Two-Bodied, Answered, or Phoenix, or by Giving at a Tree or during the Leaf-Fall, or by striking where there is no true door, or by taking another Hand's door, or by answering an ask that is a Gift in disguise, such as "make my child Long-Lived," or by seizing a will. The rule that nobody's will is bent is bedrock, and a Hand that tried would be outside the household, not a scarier member of it. Persisting after she has refused a particular catch, or after she has narrowed a door for a year, is a break as well. What the table sees is a door that sticks, so the next drownings stay dead, or a bargain that answered with a Gift-shaped clause and a Leaf-Fall that went argumentative, or Struck people who come through and do not feel received. Keep it near that small frightening share. This is a family argument.

She can narrow a door, which means fewer Struck that season, or refuse one catch, and neither of those is a break. That is her allowance still working. The Hands are not owed a quota.

What this does to the schism

Narrow-Hand is right that she Gives only at the Tree, and that the Struck were received by some other means. Wide-Hand is right that those means are still hers: her household, her allowance, and her catch at the edge. Neither reading holds the whole.

The Watching remembered a household from before it was named Mother, and that memory is half-right. The Fair Hand is right that a Counterparty exists, and wrong that every becoming is a bargain, because the Mother's Gifts are still gifts. The Old Ways are right that the land-doors are real, Vaelorn and Ornhael and Eloren among them, and wrong that she is only a latecomer claiming credit, because she authorized those guests. The Open Table is not of this household. Do not absorb Kumbaan's staying-kin into Threnvaeth or into anyone else. Their table is their own.

A household does not turn the Leaf-Fall into a committee. Giving is still love. The Tithe is still honest weight. The Other Hands are not a dark pantheon. Threnvaeth is why the Returned are respected, not why they are a plague. Narrow-Hand does not win. She authorized the catch. The stigma that follows a Struck person is social. It is not a cosmological abandonment.

How the household surfaces

Keep this ladder behind the keystone's own clues. Do not lead with a pantheon.

1. Struck testimony splits. Some people felt a mother. Some felt a clerk, a term, a deep, a holding, or a green. The Motherfaith files all of that as "she caught them." The Old Ways and the Fair Hand file it as their own doors. Both filings are half-true. The handout that shows one stamp, and Struck people who will not sit under it, does not complete the roster.
2. A Returned who settles sometimes speaks of a book closing, and not of a lap. If you are listening, that is Threnvaeth.
3. Bound faces disagree, and the terms do not. Demon, vast, or unknown, the clause has the same shape, because Orledd is wearing masks.
4. The Watching's saying, "we kept the watch before the name," is about a household, and not only about a nameless Tree.
5. Kumbaan works as a control. There is almost no Struck life there, and no Given. If the household needed only doors, and not doors that people keep, the isle would be full of Struck people. Purchase matters. The storm-wall is a reach-edge and a name-edge together.
6. The confirming beat is late, and it is yours to place. If the campaign ever names the Other Hands, the fact in the room is that the family was already there. Pair it with the keystone's own confirming

beat, or let it land after that beat. Never fire it first.

Yumboes and Kumbaan

Kumbaan has no Tree because a graft has never crossed the storm-wall, not because the good people of the isle refused one. The isle is almost impossible to reach. The culture there is centred on the Open Table, the moon, the hill, and hospitality, which are different ideals and a different sacred.

There are no Gifts on the isle. Her reach does not get there, there is no Leaf-Fall, and Yumboes do not have Given Conditions as a people. They do not worship her or her household, so the Other Hands have little purchase. The doors are not kept in their names, and the rites are not theirs. This is not a rule that gods starve without prayer. A Hand reaches through a door that is used, and on Kumbaan those doors are barely a concept.

Struck becomings can still happen, at far smaller rates than the mainland's about fifteen percent over a lifetime. A Yumboe who dies with work unfinished, or who drowns, or who is taken by the deep green of the Paps, can be caught, and the catching is rare. It is enough for a story, and it is not enough to make a social class. There are no Returned neighbourhoods on the isle, and no Bound guilds.

A Yumboe abroad, standing under a mainland Tree, is a live campaign beat, and it is not a population fact. The Tree is her hand, so she could Give, and it almost never arises. Do not write a racial immunity to cover that rarity. Yumboes do not mix. They need your leave, and if the table says yes they are the complete Kind, Hollow-Hill and Moon-Waked and the Unseen Hands together. A child of a Yumboe and a mainlander is a full Yumboe or the other parent's Kind. The unseen hands are helpers. They can fetch and fumble, and they cannot deal damage or restrain a determined creature. The tremor-sense under the hill is a feeling for gait and number. It is not an immunity to being caught off guard.

The source myth calls Yumboes ghosts, or ancestral spirits. They are a living people, a playable Kind. The ancestral flavour is the faith's picture of itself, a people who venerate hill, moon, and lineage and speak of themselves in the old ancestral idiom. They are not literally undead. That lane belongs to the Returned.

The isle remains the sharpest experiment on the map: a people outside her Giving, barely inside her household's reach, with a faith that was never hers. Yumboes are unreached, not refused. A graft that cannot travel is not a judgment. Do not find an old scion on the isle. An old cutting that took would break the isolate and the Open Table. Dead wood is not a Tree. A wrecked pot in a sailor's story is allowed. A taking is not. Road-hands do not bring the Mother across the storm-wall.

Whether the storm-wall can be crossed, and how, stays open. Choose for the story in front of you. A wall that can never be crossed removes the expedition. A wall that thins every week removes the isolate. A seasonal thinning, a known passage that kills, or a Kind or a Condition that might survive a night on the reef, a Selkie or a Far-Voiced among the maybes, keeps a crossing available when that story wants one. This book does not record any one choice as the fact. The wall is weather, current, and reef. Do not set a larger power in the water to keep her, or the Hands, from crossing. That choice would pick the nature of her limit, which is still open, and it would turn a crossing into a seal.

Kumbaan is not one of the fifteen powers. A later campaign may reach it. It is not a great power. Play Ndenjoo as a home. The first nights are dishes, wrecks, and guests, and the confirmation that the isle is the control stays late. On one night of the moon sailors call Yoltal, the hall eats the heel of the loaf first. Every other night the heel is last, or it goes to the goats. The valley has a sentence about the crust and the mainland being loud. Njunda will not correct that sentence, and will not say it is the reason. They will not say why, and a guest who asks is given more bread. Do not make that night a ward, a liturgy, or a Leaf-Fall in disguise.

The map as the edge

The reach-gradient, from the dense core to the thin frontier to the Treeless isle, is the ground-level face of the Mother’s bounded reach. In the world it reads as plain distance and history. The ages explain today’s thin edges as places that are Tree-poor, young or sick or simply few grafts, and as the front of a wave that is still moving on Heskoren. The skeptics take that account as the whole truth. It is most of the truth. The part that stays on this side is why the grafts thin with distance from Thaeloren: her reach itself has an edge. No player-facing region note states that deeper cause. It reads as geography.

Maiethorn is the control end of the natural experiment. The Trees are healthiest there, and the Given are densest. Keep the cause on this side, that her reach is fullest at the source. In the world it is simply the oldest, best-tended Trees.

Strandoren has Trees as healthy as Maiethorn’s and wears the faith lightly. The Given are dense here for the same reason they are dense anywhere healthy grafts stand, and the faith is thin for a social reason, because commerce erodes devotion. Keep those two facts separate. The cool faith is not a sign of thin reach, and the reach is not a sign of the cool faith. The eroded language is the tell: smooth because secular, not because the place is Tree-poor.

Heskoren is the sharpest in-world test of the edge. The Waiting Lands are the place a devout population most wants an explanation for the thin gift. The true answer, that her reach is bounded and thins where the Trees are thin, is exactly the answer that would land hardest and cruellest here, because it would confirm the guilt-theology’s worst fear. No player-facing note states it. In the world the thin

reach is young, sick, or scarce grafts, which is true as far as it goes, and history, a wave of grafts still moving. The gap between “true as far as it goes” and the whole truth is where the play lives.

The Sundering Isle is the strongest experiment. A land with no Tree, whose people become what they become without the Leaf-Fall, is the cleanest natural test of whether the Mother is behind any of it. There are no Gifts, because no graft has crossed and her reach does not get there. Struck are rare, because the household has little purchase where it is unknown and the doors are not kept. Their Kind and their table are their own, not a subtler Tree. Whether a lone Yumboe is Struck is not settled in session one. It is still a late beat.

East and west are not settled cosmology. Only the relative positions matter. If a later map wants the gradient to run north to south, or along some other axis, that is free. The gradient is the canon. The compass is not.

The Watching sits at the sacred centre so that an old faith can hold old memory, what was believed before the Trees were called hers. It is the natural in-world source that could corroborate the keystone from an unexpected direction: not the skeptics, and not the devout, but the heretics.

The Open Table joins the Watching and the Old Ways as the world’s three keystone-adjacent faiths, each grown far from the Motherfaith’s account, or before it, each possibly preserving a fragment of what the Trees really are. The Isle’s is the purest control, a cosmology with no Motherfaith in it. If a campaign triangulates the keystone, these three are the corners.

The Old Ways may be half-right for the wrong reasons. They revere the Struck and the Taken-In as the land’s own, made without the Tree, and on a Tree-poor frontier people genuinely do become things without a healthy Tree nearby. They are the frontier mirror of the Watching, two old faiths at opposite edges, both remembering something the Motherfaith smooths over. Whether they are right about the Mother stays behind the keystone. Host-rights do not dissolve when the keystone lands.

The Fair Hand is a rival reading of the true gifts, not a false religion pasted over nothing. The Conditions are real gifts. The cult calls them bargains, the Motherfaith calls them blessings, and both are interpretations laid over the same real thing. The cult is wrong about who, because no bargain was struck at the Leaf-Fall, and its adherents are as sincere as the Motherfaith’s. It is not villain-theology. Leddvael is that reading made civic.

The solstice is a two-reading fact. Believers say the Mother times her choosing to the year’s hinge. Skeptics say the Trees colour with the length of the day, and that the choosing is biology. She is real, so the believers are right about who, and the skeptics are right about the mechanism. She works through the Trees’ real nature, not against it. Player text does not settle it. The calendar works the same either way.

Kumbaan’s lunar calendar is the sharpest small tell in the world. The Yumboes keep the moon, not the solstice, because the Trees never reached them. A whole people reckon time with no Leaf-Fall in it. In

the world that reads as cultural difference. It is also the keystone experiment, the one calendar the Mother's Trees demonstrably never shaped. Reserve the significance, and let it look like colour.

Whoever keeps the dates holds power. There is no printing press, so calendars are hand-kept by clergy and by clerks. The tree-wardens set Turning-Week. The Tallied Crown's clerks record it. A campaign can turn on a disputed date, a miscounted cohort, or a child Turned a year late because someone kept the calendar wrong, or made them. Cut-years set against house-years set against "the year the graft took" is the same lever aimed at history.

The sky from the ground is enough to play. One sun. One moon on the mainland. Kumbaan keeps twelve named moons of that same sky and does not owe the mainland round a translation. Two solstices run the rite. This world does not have other planes. The storm-wall is weather, current, and reef, not a door. Whether a ship can cross it stays open. A second mainland moon is not available. Eclipses and comets are not written. A later story that needs one names it in play, and naming one does not add a moon, a plane, or a door. The household is not a place you can walk to, and the nature of her limit is not "she cannot cross planes."

Every scion is continuous tissue of the one Tree, so the First Cut really did move a Hand. Player-facing, that continuity is doctrine. The First Cut is the first living graft that took. Who cut it stays unpicked. The growth of reach with the grafts is the quiet argument for a mind. It is not a licence to narrate her standing over the first knife. Skeptics still win the mundane reading, which is horticulture, ships, and soil. Both readings share the same wave.

The ages, GM-side

Two things change over time, and they are kept apart. The first is how a person Turned: they walked to a Tree, or they stood under a town graft. The second is where the wood has reached: the wave of living grafts, still moving. Keeping them apart protects the keystone without confirming it. Where the wood has reached is what players can see of "reach grew with the grafts," the quiet argument that a hand, and not a climate, is behind the thinning. Skeptics still win the mundane reading, young Trees, sick Trees, few grafts, distance, and history. Both readings share the same map. No player-facing era note states that a mind is behind it.

The present is this year, especially on Heskoren. Ornthael, the Years of Hands, is not a modern age that began after the Grafting finished. That telling would stack one finished age on another. The wave is live. A sick Tree in the core puts a Hands-town back on the neighbour's week. That changes how that town's children Turn. It is not an age ending. A hamlet sending this year's ten-year-olds to a neighbour's Tree is showing where the wood has reached, today. A hamlet sending them all the way to Thaeloren is still Turning them by walking, today. Neither is a re-enactment.

The Grafting is not a redemption arc for society. Local Trees did not abolish Struck stigma, Tithe-leverage, guild conscription, or the pitied Kept. They changed who gets a local witness and who waits on a queue. The scion-queue is the Hands-era injustice grown from a Walking-era mercy. Confirming she is kind does not make the queue fair. The Seat's phrase, that her will is travelling, is a claim about the wood, not a verdict on the list.

The colonial version is wrong. "We brought Trees to the benighted far" is the Seat's sermon after the fact, and it is also Lestrand's story of a supply line. What happened is shorter and worse. Children died on the road, someone cut a branch, the branch took, people copied it, and the Seat claimed the right to authorize the copies. Heskoren still lives the spread as waiting, not as being given a civilization. The Old Ways live it as guests arriving late. Keep all three of those tellings.

The Walking Years did not make far people spiritually deficient. Distance did. Vaethorn's guilt-theology is a Hands-era reading of a Walking-era fact. An Old Ways refusal is not a missed gift. It is a different door. History does not agree with the guilt. Keep the Given-door to one week. If eleven-year-olds Turn Given because they tried, the split household and the held-over year lose their force. Struck remains the later door. That is enough mercy.

Protect the two-sided memory. Devout storytellers of the Hands years will want Brenvaeth, the Walking Years, as holy traffic, every child a pilgrim and every summer a hymn. Skeptics will want it as biology plus bad roads. Both of them are using the era. The graves make the hymn expensive, and the hymn makes the graves a meaning. Play both. The fables refuse to pick.

The gap from Cut-year 160 to 200 stays. It is not empty time, and it is not a punishment. It is dead wood on the Long Mile, a chain of Trees that had to mature before they could give cuttings, and a queue that preferred a next town that could pay. The Grey Summer, the quay-fever of Cut-year 171, stacked a fourth friction on that wait, and it did not become the reason for the gap.

Who made the First Cut stays unpicked. A named first Road-hand, a named parent, or a named saint is available only if a session needs a tomb. Naming one face makes one person the cause. What carries the age is the wood and the waiting. The five attributions are the play. If you collapse them in your own voice, you have written a gospel. Do not narrate her standing over the first knife, and do not smuggle a cause of her limit into the reason the first cut worked. The riders of the Closing fought a pot, and they never learned a face.

Rithnali's minute says Tree. The later Cutting-leave says Mother. The early paper has not finished laying the later name over the older one. A household that keeps both practices, an old Speaker, or a college still arguing the name, is playable, and none of it is a trap. Do not correct the minute.

Before the Walk stays unfilled. People will not give it a start, and this book does not. The Watching and the Old Ways already hold the two usable memories, seeing without a mother, and doors without a graft. A third account, offered as the true prehistory, would flatten both. The Tree standing before it

was called hers is compatible with she is real, and with the Mother-name being later. This era does not decide what she is. Cut-year 0 is a copy of wood, not the day Conditions began. The Giving, and the organized walk, are older than that shelf and have no start year. Becoming at a door is older than the walk, and Kinds are older than both. Long-Lived people are Given only. They can remember a walk they witnessed. They are not a library of centuries from before the Giving. A clean switch at the Cut, she appeared when the chronicle starts and before that there were no Conditions, is the overlay this era refuses. The three stones a party can walk into, the Low Wall, the Seeing-Ring, and the Dry Stair, do not date the Tree.

Long-Lived memory is the era-marker the calendar refused to be. In Cut-year 387, the 387th summer since the First Cut, plenty of deathless people remember the late Walking Years from their own lives. They are walking archives, and they do not agree. Memory is perfect. Meaning is not. A Long-Lived who walked as a child, and a Seat chronicle that starts at the Cut, will fight about the same summer. That fight is play. There is no single Long-Lived account.

Several changes of fortune have already happened, and they are not proposals waiting to be rolled. Road-houses became deathless banks. Unsanctioned cutting became Cutting-leave and the queue. Required pilgrimage became optional pilgrimage. The Closed Seat became the Inner Close. One hymn-country became two papers. Quay-fever became Trenledd’s roll and Brenledd’s compact. The Hinge War became the Hush-rate. Present-day pressure is visible, and it has not been rolled.

Who	Where the pressure sits	What you can already see	What you do not do
The First Seat	Peak, and rising	The queue has run 368 years, since Cut-year 19, with Threnmaieth close by, and “thin soil” as a sentence towns can recite.	Do not collapse the college, give it a pope, convert it at the end of a Road-hand story, or let the crown own it.
The Road-hands	Overextended at the Heskoren front	A skeleton circuit, dead wood, authority that expires, blame when a pot dies, sleep in the town that was not chosen.	Do not clone a special-forces chapter, send them across the storm-wall, or make success famous.
Waiting towns, and sick-Tree squares such as the Mill-hold	Precarious	A single dependency on a neighbour’s week or a pot. Folk-right is a temptation.	Do not destroy them to make the queue feel real, agree with Vaethorn’s guilt, or narrate them as living in the past.
Deathless houses	Peak, and already reformed	The road-past is credit nobody can audit. The prestige-walk is a product.	Do not invent a second banking-order, kill Thilim to tidy the shrine, or let Mataero be right that an empty bed is not a shrine.

The road-house had two fates, and both are true. The White Note collected. The Third Hearth kept making the bed. Both are honest. Lestrand will only count the first as success. Play both. There is no single deathless account of the road. Mataero, junior at the White Note, cannot see that house custom is the credit. Thilim, inland, still makes the bed. The prestige-walk runs from Netstrand’s berths, to the White Note’s terms, to the berth Orentel holds, and Orenbren houses the year at the origin. Do not let three Coast desks each invent the same winter.

Maiethorn visitors on Heskoren will read necessity as devotion, and will say the people still walk because they are faithful. Prestige-walkers will read necessity as poverty performed for an audience. Vaethorn will read delay as unworthiness. What is happening is shorter than any of those readings. A child needs a canopy this week. Keep all three misreadings available. Your voice agrees with none of them.

The fables’ paradox is the point. You cannot know the distance without the graves, and you cannot honour the graves without using them as a map. You cannot share a Hand without wounding a Hand, and you cannot name a First without inventing a Second that waits. You cannot honour what the walk

left behind without using it, and you cannot use it without pretending, a little, that the road is still the road, or that it is over. Removing the paradox leaves a hymn or a logistics manual. Keep both counts. No fable ends with the Mother walking beside them, or telling them to cut, or moving the stone. That would settle the keystone in a children's story. The confirming warmth, if it comes, is not these stories. The branch is her tissue. The stories do not say so. Your voice picks no last line. Which last line a person offers is a faster read than a speech.

There is no official ribbon-colour. A copper-green rag is not a Taken-In. If a warden reads mile-shrine ribbons as leaf-colours, they are laying a Hands-era habit over a Walking-era rag. Useful as a person who is wrong. It is not doctrine.

Three facts are true, and no page in the library says them. The Unspent is older than the circle, so the minutes' line "We made the god we give to" is the circle's claim, and the claim is wrong. The Leaf-Mother is real, while the primer, the play, and the history speak of her and the Tree as their writers believe, and none of those pages confirms her. The Protectors take each Phoenix into the Care and cause controlled deaths to bank the fire, and no page mentions the Protectors or the Care. The minutes record a willing gift, show no taking, and never mention the second cup or the founder, and the Long-Lived houses that pay for the long-house in Lestrand are not that founder. The poem's refusal is only a refusal. Long-Lived people will not say whether the poem is about the cup, nobody decides it for them, and you do not turn that refusal into a power, a relic, or a rite.

Places, GM-side

Each square still does one job left from the road years, devotion or prestige or necessity, and it does that one job on its street. A pretty road-end whose leftover is only a view hides the graves, and a waiting cluster whose only note is that the people are poor and faithful agrees with Vaethorn's guilt, so write the job the street actually does. Thin, sick, or few grafts stay what a player is allowed to hear as the cause, and no town note states that a mind is behind the thinness.

Harrow's Green was the next town on a list written in the Motherwood that had enough pay, enough soil, and enough of a chain, so the luck people talk about is horticulture plus the queue. Vaethorn will preach that the town waited faithfully, and history does not agree, which means you do not play it as the good town that earned its Tree. Listen for the Harrow-sentence, because it tells you where the speaker is standing. Nostalgia means Maiethorn, this year means the front, and the slight, that a neighbour Turned at Harrow's because they had no Hand, means a hamlet. A Hand, in that sentence, is a town Tree. The street's job is necessity, so a ribbon on the stone stays texture beside that job, and a household here for a First-Hand year, the prestige winter people book, is lost, rich, or lying. Nelath is the seated road-end, and this square's cart-track still goes to the ford, so do not relabel the green into

that town. When someone says the soil was right here, that is horticulture, and Haelin does not assert a mind behind it. Keep the hamlets visible from the square in at least one sightline. The cistern-dipper is the one habit, and the count is already full, so leave it unexplained and do not turn it into a power, a relic, or a rite. The opening of the first campaign sits on this square in Hale-month of Cut-year 387, during the necessity-day, and you do not rebuild the square into a Phoenix festival or put a Care-fortress on the rise.

The Three Hamlets past the ford are doing this year, not a re-enactment of the Walking Years, because a hamlet that sends this year's ten-year-olds to Harrow's is living the present. They wait because the wood is slow, the road is long, and the list was written in the Motherwood. Unworthiness is Vaethorn's sermon, not the cause, and confirming she is kind does not plant the scion. The pressure on them is precarious, a single dependency on Harrow's week or on a pot, and wiping the cluster out to make the queue feel real would spend the play, so keep the seam. Saelvaeth's luck, Vaelhesk's refusal, Vaethorn's guilt, and Ornled's slate can all sit in one week, with Brenod leaning toward sending, Vaelun toward refusal, and Ornath toward the other road. Those are leans, and you do not hand each hamlet one polity as a costume. Which green has the sick stick waits on a session. The cup on the ford-rock stays unexplained, so do not give it a cause. Taeren is of Brenod this Hale-month, Tora still wants the walk home, and Tora is not plotting the Phoenix.

The Third Hearth kept making the bed after the White Note collected the paper, so Thilim did not lose the house when the paper went to the coast, and the inn is not a failure. The street's job is devotion, the extra mile, while necessity in the loft is Thilim's eye rather than a second theme for the town, and prestige that lands here is the household that missed the White Note. Orenbren is many hearths, and Brenthael is a neighbour square, not a capital. People still disagree about Thilim's four jobs, and when Thilim says "I walked," nobody gets to pick which sermon that is. Leave Thilim alive. The Held bed, the pilgrim bed still kept from the walk, does not close by a death. The stone is a day's water and a name, and it does not prove a mind. The broom in the doorway is the one habit, the count is full, and you do not explain the broom. The sick-Tree square is the Mill-hold, so do not sicken Brenthael to tidy that type.

Ornsael is a mixed town where Sands-Fox hearths are the densest, and a fox-market there is a neighbourhood rather than a quarter with a gate, so it is not a Kitsune nation. Pair it with Harrow's Green, the same sowing-root on two continents, both in the present tense. A party that has only seen Heskoren waiting should meet this well and have to recalibrate, and a party that has only seen the Sacred Core should meet the west-road and lose the idea of one finished age stacked on another. The street's job is necessity, and the necessity is water, so the crisis is the drink. Eolvaeth keeps the maybe-Tree, the spring, the warden who will not invent a colour, and the wet leaf. Ornsael does not. The physical problem is the well, the institutional answer is a share kept by Theisva, Lesna, and Bovaer, and the mystery is a wet knot below the water, which means you do not slide back into a warden who will not call a false fall. Some locals date the first low mark to after the Thaw-Break, Cut-year 233.

The rope does not date that mark, so do not confirm the year. Larbril is Saelthael's city, where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass, and Ornsael is the smaller well-town farther into the dry, not the next roof, not the coast, not a west bank, and not the capital. A thin take in dry soil stays horticulture in player text. Plenty on the other side of the range does not make the west-road kind, and confirming she is kind does not retire the road.

Eolvaeth was an early pot that stayed thin, and congregation did the rest, so the luck is horticulture plus the queue rather than a faithful wait the town earned. Harrow's is luck you can see from a ford, and Eolvaeth is a gospel you walk to. Pair them in a campaign week when you want both of Heskoren's jobs visible, and do not collapse them into one frontier flavour. The street's job is devotion, the wait kept as a destination, and a cohort sent toward Saelvaeth is friction beside that job, not a second theme. The spring is the water, the wet leaf is not a ribbon, and the road years left no mile-shrine here. A pretty pilgrim-town that is only picturesque agrees with Vaethorn's guilt, so keep a thin year visible. Confirming she is kind does not make the wait a virtue. When someone says the soil was never quite right here, that is horticulture, and Vaethod does not assert a mind.

Orentel keeps the White Note as one house on the third quay, while the council is many tickets, so a party that only meets Ledan has not met the city and the desk is not the crown. The street's job is prestige, the First-Hand year sold as a product the city holds, and necessity in the loft is texture beside that job. Empty berths and earth-holds are what the road years left on this street. Salt lies on the roots, they will not say why, and the salt is not a ribbon, so leave it unexplained and do not add a habit. The count on this street is already full. Hallowquay stays a lesser quay, a neighbourhood byname, not a renaming of the capital. Dense Given stay horticulture and trade in player text. Confirming she is kind does not make the hold kind, because a rich city stepping around a fade is the Coast's injustice at eye level. Leave Thilim at the Third Hearth. The two fates of the road-house are two doors.

Maiethlir sits beside the First Seat without capturing it, because proximity is pressure, and a First Seat that was the Threnhael would be a darker setting. Keep the college able to refuse the roll, and keep Rithim as the local, still incomplete version of that refusal. The crown has not replaced Rithim, and the Seat has not recalled them, so that gap stays open. What you have is a Hand, a town Tree, beside a thaw-river, with the grove as a dark on the horizon, while Orenbren lodges the other road and Brenthael remains a neighbour of an inn rather than this capital. The street's job is devotion, the extra mile, with the census written on top of it, and the census is not the whole town. The street shows you tablets, a loud thaw, and clerk-dorms in old lofts. The unfiled Held bed is a rumour the roll has not found, a different bed kept from the walk, rather than Seine's lintel moved to the counted city. Maiethvael is the argument next door, the same *maieth* and the opposite paper, and you do not play it as the kind foil, because piety there is a social tax in plenty. Dense Given stay horticulture in player text. The loud river is not her voice unless a later reveal earns it, and even then her kindness does not make the counting fair. Devotion sanctifies the surveillance, and the surveillance enforces the devotion, so there is no clean villain. The loud thaw, the used cups, and the thread on the stylus stay

unexplained. Do not give them a cause, do not turn them into a rite, and do not put the roll's number into a player-facing sentence as if it were geology.

Name-pairs are tells. Maiethvael and Threnmaieth are the Motherland's argument in two names, the Mother's gift against the Mother's reckoning. Same *maieth*, opposite paper. Saelthael and Saelvaeth share *sael*, sowing, on two continents. The wood is still spreading at the origin and at the front. Neither name is history, and neither is a flavour you paste on a frontier. Trenledd's etymology is *thren* worn to *Tren*, the sacred count with the sacred worn off, the same machinery Threnmaieth sanctifies, named as what it does. A scholar may notice the sanding, and the player-facing chapters do not call it a clever pun. Vael and vaeth are yield against waiting, the same continent, opposite first syllables. Vaethorn and Vaelhesk already feel it.

Theology and reach stay independent, which is why high reach and a cooled faith can sit together on the Hinge Shore, the same pairing Strandoren proves, on the conservative shore. Half-hearted hymns are not a sign of thin Trees.

On Netstrand's shore, *neth* means night, and people there will not say why the name means night. They keep a night-watch, or they name the dark off the storm-wall, or they keep an eve-custom that sounds like the Watching and does not belong this far west. Write what they do, and leave open why night sits on this west shore. You may pick one reading for a session, or never pick.

Ornled's light government, thin Trees, and missing faith-net leave people exposed, which is a different thing from the freedom a visitor might hear in the name. Vaethorn's claim that the place is unworthy is a sermon. What you actually have is distance, a choice of gospel, and horticulture beside the culture.

Kind-hearths stay hearths, and they do not become nations. Tengu are densest in Lirorn, and so are the Snows-Fox. Sands-Fox are densest in Saelthael. Selkie are common on the Hinge Shore and on Netstrand. The Taken-In are honoured in Vaelhesk. The towns stay mixed. The interesting player character is a human or a Selkie of Lirorn, or a Tengu of the Hinge Shore. A wing-post is a job. The moment the government is for a Kind, the two-layer model has started to rot.

Threnmaieth's tell lives on Maiethorn. The Tallied Crown distrusts the three pillars and keeps a ledger instead, and its Long-Lived crown-archivists may quietly remember what the Threnhael was made to overwrite. On Maiethorn, that archivist is near the sacred centre and near the old heresy.

Strandoren is the natural staging ground if a campaign ever reaches for the Sundering Isle. The ships, the money, and the tall tales originate here. Netstrand is the natural berth. The merchant who claims to have crossed the storm-wall is a Strandoren type. Hold whether the claim is true as a live question tied to the isle, and do not settle it early.

The twelve seats are named, or refused: Seinbrun, Rothallo, Larbril, Votaer, Tasain, Raitin, Naenor, Lunbra, Braetu, and Sanbreo, with Vaelhesk naming no city and Natai standing as the march. Rothallo is Orenbren's walled capital, one day's walk from the wood, and people still say the Inner Close for

that same city, which is not a second town and not a sixteenth flag. The First Seat stays in the wood, unnamed. Vaelhesk is the land, with no settlement dot, and the First Bowl is the guest-grove, not the seat. Natai sits west of Harrow's Green, between Sanbreo and the square, and it is neither the ford nor the square, while Harrow's Green stays in orbit. The six charter-towns around Raitin stay unnamed, Trenledd's ruler stays unnamed, and no capital is marked with a star.

What is settled and what is open

Settled.

- The Leaf-Mother is real, benevolent, bounded, and costly. The Trees are her hands. The Conditions are real gifts. The Tithe is the honest weight of a gift.
- She Gives, and she does not Strike. The Other Hands Strike under her allowance. The Struck are still hers. Narrow-Hand and Wide-Hand are each half-right.
- Yumboes have no Gifts on the isle, and Struck are rare. They are unreached, not refused. The Open Table is not of her household.
- The map is a reach-gradient. Four continents: Maiethorn first, Strandoren by sea, Heskoren last and live, Kumbaan never.
- The present is Cut-year 387. How a person Turned, and where the wood has reached, are kept apart. There is no universal year-zero. The year a person writes down shows their stance. Crown-year 320 is the count that starts at the Two Papers, Cut-year 67. The White Note's present house-year is 307, because Cut-year 280 was the house's 200th summer.
- The Tree is undated. Before the Walk has no start. Cut-year 0 is a copy of wood, not the birthday of Conditions.
- Turning-Week is the High Solstice. Twelve Maiethren months. Three new-year days, depending on stance. Kumbaan keeps twelve moons of the same sky.
- Fifteen powers, three corners plus twelve. Kumbaan is not on the list. Rothallo is Orenbren's walled capital, one day's walk from the wood, still called the Inner Close, the same city and not a sixteenth flag. *Eolstrand* is retired. The slot is the Hinge Shore. *Aeloren* is retired.
- The twelve seats are named or refused: Seinbrun, Rothallo, Larbril, Votaer, Tasain, Raitin, Naenor, Lunbra, Braetu, Sanbreo, Vaelhesk as the land with no city, and Natai. Six charter-towns and Trenledd's ruler stay unnamed. The First Seat is a college in the wood beside Maiethlir, unnamed, not a throne and not captured. The White Note sits on Orentel and is not crowned. Harrow's Green and Ornsael are not capitals. Larbril is the city at the wash. Ornsael is the well farther into the dry. Natai is the march, west of Harrow's, not the ford and not the square. No capital is marked with a star. Vaelhesk has no settlement dot. No graft has crossed to Kumbaan.

- The Other Count sits beside the two clocks: the Closing in Cut-years 19 to 38, the Two Papers in 67, the Grey Summer in 171, the Thaw-Break in 233, the Wrong Green in 248, Ledan's unanswered query in 280, and the Hinge Hush in 299 to 304. The cutter stays unpicked. The present is Cut-year 387.
- Fate-pressure on the First Seat, the Road-hands, the waiting towns, and the deathless houses is visible. It has not been rolled. The queue has run 368 years, since Cut-year 19.
- The Pourers' inner circle takes memory from some Long-Lived by force or by deceit, into a second cup that the unnamed founder reads. The Unspent is older than the name the Pourers gave it. The Pourers, the Walled Book, and the Protectors are three separate groups.
- The opening kit sits at Harrow's Green, Hale-month, Cut-year 387. One Gift. The apparent second is the remnant of an ended Gift standing next to a new leaf. The harvest stays in this chapter.

Open.

- The nature of her limit. That her reach has an edge, and that giving costs her, is settled. Why, whether she is finite by nature, spent from some old wound, rationing a power that could run out, or holding something back in order to hold something else up, is unwritten. Carrying wood moved the edge. That is evidence of a hand. It is not an explanation of the wound, the finitude, or the rationing. The ache is settled. The cause is not. A wound in the deep past is one available cause among several. Before the Walk does not pick it.
- Who made the First Cut. Contested on purpose. Folk, clergy, the devout, the Watching, and the Old Ways each have a lived story. History does not pick a face. Pick only if play needs a tomb.
- What she is. A goddess, the Trees' shared soul, or something older wearing a mother's face for our comfort, remains undecided. The maternal, benevolent intent is settled. Her metaphysical species is not.
- What she wants, beyond giving good gifts, is undecided. She is kind. Any larger purpose is unwritten.
- Where she is, and whether she can be reached, is undecided. Revelation is deliberately quiet. There is no throne to visit.
- Whether the storm-wall can be crossed, and how, is yours to choose for the story in front of you. It is not a settled fact.
- Why *neth* sits on Netstrand's shore stays open. Write what people do there. People there will not say why the name means night.
- Which of the three hamlets' greens has the sick stick waits on a session.
- The household names, Quiet Tally, Counterparty, Second Breath, Holding, and Taking, and their Maiethren forms, may still be polished. The structure is settled. Orenhael, the tree-wardens' liturgical name, and Vaethledd, the Slide's cant, sit in the same polishable place. The everyday names are settled.

- Eclipses and comets are not written. A later story may name one in play. A second mainland moon is not open. Other planes are not open. Whether the storm-wall can be crossed stays its own question.

Secrets and reveals

What the table learns, and in what order. The keystone and the household are already in this chapter. This is not a second cosmology.

The Phoenix rules sit behind the keystone. A campaign does not open with a second Phoenix, and does not confirm her in session one. The fire plot may run without the keystone. The claim that she Gave the leaf stays behind the keystone.

When the fire is caught

There is never a second Gift. The Tree Gives its white-fire to one living person. While that person can still Rise From Ash, spending a Hope slot to come back from that death, no second leaf falls. What can look like two Phoenixes is the remnant of an ended Gift standing next to a new Gift. A captive who still has a Hope slot they can spend to Rise still holds the Gift, so no leaf falls while they can.

The original self ends at the death they cannot Rise from, the death that would cross out their last Hope slot. That death ends the Gift. A new white-fire leaf may fall at the next High Solstice any living Tree can reach. Two Gifts never overlap.

Each Rise burns a body to nothing and remakes it. If the death was prepared, the fire of that burn can be caught and banked. Banked fire has two jobs, and only two.

While the Gift lasts, someone can spend a measure of the bank to force a Rise the Phoenix did not choose, and take the memory of that death with it. The Hope slot still scars. The named piece of the old life still does not come back. The player of a Phoenix player character is never forced to Rise. Forcing the Rise is what is done to a captive.

After the Gift ends, the bank can be spent to keep the last risen body assembled. That upkeep is not a Rise. No Hope is crossed, because none remain. The body walks, it burns, and it can still take the air. It is the fire’s memory of a person, and it is not a Phoenix. If the store runs out, the remnant goes to cold ash and stays there.

The remnant cannot Rise, cannot be Given, and cannot Give. Immunity and wings can linger, because those are properties of the fire, not of the Gift. Kindle and the Dwindling do not linger. A remnant that still thinks it is the Phoenix is a tragedy, not a second Condition.

The slot is empty from the true death, so the leaf may fall. The wider world does not see that fall, because the remnant is still called the Phoenix and is kept out of sight. Doctrine says there cannot be two, so a Spoken white-fire, a colour a warden said aloud, is filed as a mis-Speaking or a hush for as long as a sanctuary still claims to hold the Phoenix. A far graft with no Speaker never enters the record at all. The new child is real. The stories people tell are still about the old name.

The Protectors catch the fire. They use these rules. They do not rewrite them. Worship is what they use to hide the taking. They remove each Phoenix from public life, cause controlled deaths, bank the fire, and take the memory of those deaths with the forced Rise. They turn the bank into institutional power, which shows up as heat, as light, as a remnant that still walks, and as a hush that holds. They think they are caring for a relic. They cannot afford to see that they are harvesting a person. Play them as reverent, and sure they helped. The Care stays warm when the street is not. Do not give them a weapon that ends a city, and do not make the bank a second Gift. Player text knows the Care as a hospice that will not produce the one. The public sentence is “the one is in care.” The harvest stays here. Do not store the Spent Leaf in the Care, and do not pour years into it. The Protectors are not the Pourers, and they are not the Walled Book.

Clues, in an order you can use, and the first four may run without confirming her. The opening already puts them on the table, so you do not lead with a second bird.

1. Hope scars without the memories of the deaths that made them. Something that burns the way a Phoenix burns has more crossed Hope slots than lives they can name.
2. A sanctuary that will not produce the Phoenix. The world is told the one is being kept safe, and no town has seen them in a generation.
3. A white-fire fall that was never Spoken. The evidence is a far warden’s letter, or a hush, or a runner who did not arrive. A letter about such a leaf does not come back answered.
4. Fire that answers a child and an old name at once. The stored fire knows both, and that double recognition is the tell, not a second Gift. The object is the Closed Lamp, which leans, answers two people, and then there is tea. It is not a leaf, and it is not the Spent Leaf.
5. Late, and yours to place: the remnant goes to ash when the store is spent, or the new Gift stands in a room with the old name and the Tree does not argue. What lands is warmth with a theft under it. It is not a reveal that the god was a harvester. Do not fire this in session one.

Misreadings to refuse, in the voice you use with yourself before you answer a player. There were not always two. Leftover fire is not a Gift, however completely it burns. The Tree did not make a mistake. The slot was already empty when the leaf fell, and the leaf was on time. The useful lie, that the remnant is the real Phoenix and the child is a fraud, is backwards, and it is the lie the harvesters need people to believe. She did not stop Giving white-fire. She Gave, or the Tree Gave if the table is still unconfirmed on her, and the record was kept from seeing the fall. The Closed Lamp is not a Spent

Leaf, and it is not harvested fire passed off as a leaf. The lamp is brass and a banked coal. The colourless remainder is a different pin. Do not braid them.

A hidden Phoenix (player agency)

The open-card Phoenix is never anonymous. This is the other seat. Whole-table consent is the same rule the public card already uses, because a Phoenix campaign keeps arriving at fire. The Transformation card does not change. If anyone at the table does not want that fire, pick another Condition, or run the Phoenix as a non-player character.

Two legal shapes. Pick one. They are not two Phoenixes.

Shape	What you are	Typical start
The walker	The Gift that left a room where deaths had been prepared. You can still Rise. You are the one.	Hope scars you cannot account for. Missing deaths. A world that says the one is safe indoors. The working band is one to three scars, and you do not start on the last Hope slot.
The unseen leaf	A new Gift that fell where no Speaker wrote it down. You can still Rise. You are the one.	Few scars, or none. Zero is the right count, or one if a later Rise already happened in a quiet year. The stories are still about an older name. Something in a far house still burns the way you do.

If the next Rise would cross out the last Hope slot, that person cannot Rise, and they are not a Phoenix player character on this card. Agree a count of scars before play, not a biography. You and the player name that the deaths are missing, not what they were. “Three deaths I cannot see” is a start you can play. A plot in which the murders are already filled in is a story someone else wrote.

When play offers a fragment, a room, a smell, a name, or a scar that suddenly has a face, the player chooses. They may take it and name what came back. They may leave it, and a refused fragment can return later without getting louder because they said no. They may rewrite the meaning, not the fact. A prepared room existed. What it means that they walked out is theirs. You offer the fragments. You do not assign their moral, and you do not write the character’s lie for them. One fragment a session is plenty. A session with none is legal.

Stored fire can show facts: a count of how many times a body burned in that room, the layout of the prepared room and the door that was not on the slate, a name the fire still answers, that a death was arranged, and that the same fire knows a child and an old name at once. It cannot assign a self, a forgiveness, a purpose for the Gift, a second Gift, or her. If the fire tries to tell the player who they are, a keeper is the one talking, and whether the player believes them is a player choice. Do not let the bank

name the Protectors' harvest in narration the table can hear until the table is ready for that fight. Until then, the public sentence is still that the one is in care.

If this player character can still Rise, they are the one Gift, and a remnant in the same campaign is leftover fire, not a second card. If you want a remnant and a player character together, the remnant is the non-player character and the player character is the new leaf, or the player character is the Gift that walked and the remnant is what the house still shows its guests. Never put that the other way around on a player-character sheet. This opening, specifically, is a remnant beside a new leaf. Furled wings can pass. Flight and Kindle cannot. Do not run the public recognition and the hidden recognition both at full and call that fair. If the table wanted the public legend, where everyone knows the Phoenix and every town already has an opinion, use the card and skip this sheet.

Isolated Fall — the opening

The first campaign starts at a square that already exists. Session one is a kit, not a novel. Mystery comes first. There is one beat of wrongness, at about that five percent, and the wonder belongs to an isolated fall that has already happened. The Leaf-Mother is not this session's reveal.

Sits	Harrow's Green, Hale-month, Cut-year 387. Next week is Eolthael, and Leaf-Fall comes inside that month.
On-screen	The walker, Rosire, the new Gift (Taeren, or a player character in that seat), Haelin, and Tora of Brenod.
Offstage	Reimaethe, Hithaen, Vimein, Tesara's week, and the Care as a place you can walk into.
Not in this kit	A Protector fortress. Opening on a second Phoenix. Confirming her. Naming the cutter. Dating the Tree. A sixteenth power.

There is one Gift. This opening needs what looks like two, so the new Gift is an unseen leaf, able to Rise, and the walker is the remnant, the Gift already ended, unable to Rise, not a Phoenix for the Leaf-Fall, for the law, or for the roster. Rosire opened a door that was not on the slate. Rosire is of Orentel, walked the Long Mile with someone who burns, and took an upper-room bed Haelin will not always name.

If the table wants a walker who is a player character and can still Rise, that player character is the Gift, and there is no new leaf beside them. That shape is a legal other opening. It is not this kit. Do not put Taeren on-screen as a second Gift so you can keep both shapes at once.

The isolated fall is last Eolthael's neighbour's week, at a Tree the square already had, not a new Tree planted for the session. Taeren is of Brenod, not of Harrow's. Haelin did not Speak the white-fire. The

witness never walked that colour home. That is why the child is still in the square when the Hale-month visitors arrive. The hearth still keeps Nathdo's letter, from the year this square said a colour and then had to say a second word over the first. White-fire would ask them to make that kind of history again, and they will not do it in a square that already had to say a second word.

What the table can see, if you keep the list in front of you and do not volunteer a fact that is not on it: a live-front square in the middle of a necessity-day, ropes on the stone, water, the dust of Hale-month, and the hamlets visible down the slope. Civic talk in which the Phoenix should exist, the one is in care, and no town has seen them in a generation. A Brenod child, or the player character in that seat, whose hands hold heat, who asks ordinary questions, and who has been told not to be a story. Haelin will not name the colour from last Eolthael, and Tora needs someone who was there to walk the witnessing home. An upper-room guest who burns the way a story burns and cannot account for their scars, wings furled, passing for an ordinary guest until they do not. Rosire's flinch when a room has been cleared and laid with sand, grey under the nails, water in their hands, and no talk of where they travelled. A closed lamp that leans toward the new Gift and still knows an old name. The public sentence, if anyone is carrying it, that the one is in care. Not the harvest. Not the house named as harvesters.

Five moments, any order the table reaches, and the order below is the one to recommend. Play all five. Do not open on the lamp, and do not open on two burning people in one shot.

1. **Two tenses in the square.** Someone asks, in the ordinary talk, whether the one is coming for Leaf-Fall. A neighbour says the Phoenix is in care. Another says they have never seen one. Haelin's answer is the one they actually have: they have a Tree, and they do not have a legend. Curiosity, not dread. The square is not hiding a secret from the party. It has stopped looking. Then let the same people argue about the stone, so the necessity-day keeps running.
2. **White that nobody Spoke.** Last Eolthael, a Brenod child stood at Harrow's Tree, and something white showed. Haelin did not Speak it, so the colour was never said aloud, and a colour that is not civic cannot be walked home as a witnessing. Heat in the hands they do not show. If a player character occupies this seat, the moment is theirs, and you do not run Taeren beside them. Linger on the canopy, the hamlets in one sightline, and how small the square is against what the stories said a Phoenix-fall would be. Then stop. Do not confirm the Leaf-Mother. If a neighbour says she Gave, that is a neighbour talking.
3. **Scars that do not match the lives.** The walker is in the upper room, with more crossed lives than they can put in a row. They cannot Rise. Do not stage a death this session to prove the rule. Rosire brings water and does not explain the guest. The table is holding two burning facts that will not sit in one story, a child the hymns are not about, and a legend who cannot account for their count.
4. **The lamp that answers two people.** One glimpse of wrongness, and no more. Rosire kept a closed travelling-lamp. The coal should be cold. It is not. When the new Gift is on the stair, the lamp leans. When the walker speaks an old name, out of habit and not as a title, the lamp answers that

name too. Narrate the lamp, the lean, and the two names. Say nothing of harvest, bank, remnant, Protectors, or “this is not a real Phoenix.” One linger, then let someone pour tea.

5. **The door that was not on the slate.** Rosire on-screen as a person, not as a confession. A cleared room. Sand. They flinch, and they will not sit. What they will say is that someone walked, and that they walked the other way, and that this is all the travel they have. What the party does with the person who opened the door is theirs. Session one can end with the lamp still lit, the stone still unmoved, the witness still unwalked, and nobody named as the one. The remnant does not go to ash, and Vimein does not arrive.

After the lamp, decompress. Water, bread, the stone still there. No Leaf-Mother reveal. No fortress of the Care. No hunt in the first hour. No second Gift. Move people by the stairs, the cistern, and the dust. Do not cut from Tora’s water straight across to harvested fire.

Three later kits follow, each four moments and no fixed plot. The Walk Home is the days after, still Hale-month. The square keeps its day. A walk with Tora to Brenod is a choice, and one fragment may be offered, or none. It does not send the party to Natai to borrow a new town, and it does not explain the cup on the ford-rock. The Offered Fragment is the upper room as Hale-month goes over into Eolthael. One fragment, if the party is in the room for it. The Care stays the sentence the square already says, not a place that arrives, and there is no new letter. The Week Still Open is early Eolthael. Leaf-Fall is still ahead, and it is not that session. The fragment you offer by default is none, and the campaign does not close. If the walker has left because the table sent them away, do not drag them back to keep the mystery staffed. In all three the walker stays unnamed, the remnant does not go to ash, and the Leaf-Mother is not confirmed. Any ending waits for play.